# Unwanted Animal

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/56802229.

**Rating:**
Explicit

**Archive Warning:**
Graphic Depictions Of Violence

**Category:**
Multi

**Fandom:**
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

**Relationship:**
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

**Characters:**
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Angella (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Double Trouble (She-Ra), Hordak (She-Ra), Horde Prime (She-Ra), Tung Lashor, Huntara (She-Ra), Mara (She-Ra), Light Hope (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Starla (She-Ra), Serenia (She-Ra), Original Characters

**Additional Tags:**
Slasher AU, Murder Mystery AU, serial killer au, Alternate Universe - Modern: No Powers, Angst, Fluff and Angst, The most difficult story I have ever written, Why Did I Write This?, Angst and Hurt/Comfort, Angst and Tragedy, warning tags, descriptions of death, Attempted Murder, Brutal Murder, mentions of wounds, Wounds, Blood and Violence, Implied/Referenced Domestic Violence, Child Neglect, Car Accidents, PTSD, Psychological Trauma, Childhood Trauma, Depression, Suicidal Thoughts, Hallucinations, Drinking, religious trauma, Religious Fanaticism, I must mark very clear that there is NO sexual violence on this story of any kind, nor past or present or future, no insinuation or metaphors neither none, Minor Character Death, Now for the spicy tags, Sex, strap on, Cunnilingus, Fingering, Dry Humping, Penetration, all very loving healthy and consensual, Catra is a pillow princess, Adora is a stone top, And they are happy and joyful with it, Adora is in Love with Catra (She-Ra), Catra is in Love with Adora (She-Ra), Other Additional Tags to Be Added, All characters are major characters, Major character death - Freeform, suicide ideation, Open Ending

**Language:**
English

**Stats:**
Published: 2024-06-21 Completed: 2024-07-16 Words: 272,412 Chapters: 10/10

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# Unwanted Animal

by StarryNap

Summary

"She can't keep them all safe, they will die and be afraid. Mother, tell me so I say" - Yaelokre

Or

A serial killer is on the loose on the town of Etheria, leaving blood, violence and animal masks at its trail, targeting all that Adora has ever loved. As the clock runs out of time, she and her friends will have to take a look to her past and a step to her future if she wants to finish what started long ago before they'll all suffocate under the sins that weight over the quiet but dangerous town

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

# The Head of Ichabod Crane

Chapter Summary

Catra had a really bad night

Chapter Notes

Happy Summer and welcome finally to the premier of this absolute monster of a story!

It took months but we are finally here! Today we take a look to the prologue of our little story and the start of the horror. From now own I advice you to keep your notes, make your theories and bets and remember, it's easy, little ducklings, it's easy but not that much.

Keep those warning tags on check and remember, we start strong so if you are not on the mental space to read this, take your time, take a breath and I'll see you later or in another story.

Without much more to say for now, I'll leave you under the watch of the Unwanted Animal

Love, the wolf

See the end of the chapter for more notes

## Part I. Ribcage

## [The Head of Ichabod Crane]

*'Cause you, you touch, my skin peels off like paint*

*But beneath all of our panting, there's this noise I cannot shake*

*Well, can't you hear that scratching? There's something at the door*

---

♞

## October 22th, a quarter to midnight

Hordak´s breathing is elaborate, making his way blindly through the darkness of his apartment. He tries as best as he can to not make a single noise, not a creak of the expensive wooden floor or a drip of his sweat falling down his forehead. But his soles are slippery, coated with his own blood dripping down his leg, making him trip and stumble on the floor. Loudly.

The metal chair next to him falls into its side alongside Hordak, clanking like the bell of a church inside the increasing darkness. There is a storm outside, the wind lashing against the trees, making them bend in unnatural angles and crack around their branches and middles. It crashes against the building with all the strength of a god's fury, blue and purple lightning illuminating everything inside from where the curtains are open for barely enough seconds for Hordak to see beyond his nose.

His mouth tastes like salt, blood spilling on the back of his throat where he bit himself earlier. There is a gushing wound on the side of his thigh and a deeper one on his ankle, breaking the Achilles tendon, gaping like the sick mockery of a puppet’s mouth. There isn't a way Hordak is getting out of this by running and he knows that. He knows it as well as the person that walks calmly behind him knows it.

The steps of the second person are collected, heavy but well sure of where to step and what to do. They contrast the frantic cadence of Hordak’s panting into an almost sick kind of twisted dance, filled with despair. Hordak fights with the chair next to his elbow and yanks it backwards, hoping it will manage to hit the person chasing his tail. But it only manages to knock down one of the expensive bases from Hordak’s collection, clashing in the ground into dozens of sharp pieces, broken beyond repair.

Hordak curses under his breath, spitting an insult as he turns around over the mosaic of the floor, facing fully at the person

hovering above him. It caught Hordak completely out of guard, bursting through the door easily, slashing at his skin with the deadly sharp end of the knife, wordless as Hordak´s attacker chased him inside his own home like a beast seeking blood. Another lightning breaks the sky in two, illuminating for the split of a second the person's face into reds and blues, flashing the irises in green.

“I didn't know. I didn't know, alright?” Hordak chokes on his own breath and spit, raising his hands in front of his face. The person stops walking right in front of him, head tilted to the side, listening to Hordak's increasing babbles with an arched eyebrow. When no sounds come from the mouth, Hordak snarls, desperation tainting his chest like the blood soaking on the sole of his foot.

Hordak doesn't even see the flash of the knife until it is already moving, digging past the skin of his palm, across tendons and ligaments and barely avoiding the delicate bones until it comes sprouting on the back, splitting it open like a flower on the church's altar. Hordak screams, a howlering that goes unnoticed by the rich neighborhood around him, drowned by the storm lashing against the earth.

He snatches his hand away, bile pooling on the base of his throat at the sight of dark blood spilling out of the wound fast and unstoppable, staining his once perfectly tailored shirt into crimson. He turns around over the floor again, crawling his way across the living room and towards the back door, a floor to ceiling thing made out of glass alone, expensive in all its glory. Hordak can see his own reflection across it, dragging himself over the blood soaked carpets like a miserable bug, and then up at the person still creeping behind him, face completely still, unfazed by the screams and the smell of blood. This is not the first time those eyes have seen death, after all.

The killer is humming a song very low as it allows Hordak to try and reach the back door, taking pleasure on the sight of his broken body, almost chuckling when Hordak extends his arm and

grabs the platinum doorknob with a desperate yank only to find it tightly closed. All the lights in the neighborhood and the house have gone out, the camera´s placed on the corners of Hordak´s Town Mayor  house gone dead and blind to the horrors that are about to happen tonight.

Hordak feels a hand grabbing his shoulder, harshly yanking him backwards and into his back, splayed open at the flash of the blood coated knife dangling from the killer's hands and then down again, towards his body. He doesn't even notice the blade has ripped its way into his lung until it is already out again, compressing his chest as the air collapses his lungs inside his ribcage and he coughs, choking on his own breathing. Terror makes its way inside Hordaks throat, past the blood quickly rising from his trachea and staining teeth and lips in red, kicking and lashing blindly as he tries to shake away the presence looming above him.

“You can´t– You can't kill me.” Hordak gasps, spitting towards the person's face, staining skin with his blood. This face he knows well, a torment chasing him and finally reaching him. “You need me, just think what I can give you. Money, connections, an easy way out, a new life. I can give all of that to you!”

The killer stops for a second, considering, weighing the true meaning of Hordak´s words for a second so long that Hordak thinks he might just make it, coughing around his own blood still but still prideful, the bloom of hope spreading on his wounded chest.

*Squelch.*

Hordak´s eyes widen and the killer's eyes go cold again, the flash of a smirk clear on the edge of the mouth. Arms are moving, rhythmic motions accompanied by the wet sound of fabric and flesh being ripped, slow and easy, without remorse and without stopping, making shreds out of muscles and skin. Hordak doesn´t even have time to react again, to whine or scream or to realize he is actually about to die before the knife is running down again

inside his chest, reaching the remaining of his guts and veins and very bones, being carved out alive like one of the pumpkin lamps on the streets outside.

If he screams, nobody hears him. If he bleeds out nobody cares, leaving handprints and pools of his blood on the floor and the glass door, crimson testimonies of butchery and terror. He is still somehow alive when the killer kneels beside his shredded body, soaking dark pants with crimson red, pressing the edge of the dripping blade against Hordak´s throat. The killer rests a cold mouth against the side of his butchered ear. Hordak can't see it, eyes fogged and blind by pain and suffering, but he knows there is a smile on that mouth. It smells like incense, it smells like blood.

“You can die now” it's the last thing Hordak hears, gurgling blood and boiling hot skin.

Then the knife paints a gaping smile on his throat and then he is dead.

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## October 23th

Adora is having a peaceful dream, which is an accomplishment of its own, all things considered. By all means, Adora has not known the meaning of sleep without night terror in years, almost four to precise, always chasing her when she closes her eyes except for the counted times where the weight of her girlfriend´s sleeping body next to her have managed to keep the horror away. All the other nights, however, always go the same. So yes, Adora is proud to say that, for once since she was sixteen, she has been able to close her eyes and sleep in one piece through the night.

In fact, she would very much like to keep sleeping, snuggled on the warm beds, if it weren't for two things. One, the increasing daylight slipping through the cheap material of her curtains,

hitting her annoyingly directly in the face. And two, the soft pad of a fingertip poking her in the forehead with insistence, traveling from Adora´s dark eyebrows to the middle and back again, tickling her in the skin scattered with moles there and teasing her with the sharp end of a nail until Adora wrinkles her nose, batting away blindly at the hand over her face.

“Adora,” a voice call for her, whispered but still sultry, almost a treacherous song in the form of Adora´s name coated with barely contained mirth. “Adora, wake up.”

“No,” Adora whines, pouting and still half asleep. She manages to grasp the delicate hand above her face with her eyes still closed, bringing it towards her chest and snuggling into it in a weak attempt to convince its owner to join her in bed. The laughter above her repeats, soft strands of hair brushing Adora´s sun warmed cheeks.

“Wake up, horse girl. We are late for class. I don´t mind it but you're insufferable when you are late to things.” Adora groans, closing her eyes so tight that she sees stars for a second and then finally daring to open them completely.

The morning sun blinds her for a moment but she is rewarded by meeting face to face with the most beautiful person she has ever known, staring right back at her. Catra´s eyes shimmer crystal blue and liquid gold under the rays of the sun, she still has seventy one freckles in her face and there is a faint flush on her cheekbones and the faint shadow of perspiration on her collarbones. She is wearing a plain sports shirt , a jacket and her black underwear only, her leggings discharged somewhere on Adora´s floor before she climbed up the bed.

All her hair is loose, loops of deep brown bouncing over her shoulder, leaving exposed the delicate skin of Catra´s throat, raised in a soft pink scar long ago healed but still painful. It is a rare sight, Catra leaving her neck exposed like this, without her characteristic high neck top tanks or the velvet chokers protecting her from curious eyes.

But then again, this is Adora and they are in Adora´s room, where the golden light is warm and illuminates the scarring only Adora ever gets to see. From the crooked start in the hollow of Catra´s throat and then up, across her neck, over the jugular that barely protected her carotid and all the way towards the nape. A wide scar over her dark skin faint enough to be part of a dream, pink enough for Catra to curl around herself every time she stares at herself in the bathroom´s mirror.

This morning though, her expression is relaxed, as if something had changed and shifted through the night. She is splayed over Adora´s body, her hands pressed at both sides of Adora´s pillow and her entire body is soft and relaxed, staring down at Adora´s sleepy face with a kind of unreadable expression nestled in her eyes. Catra must realize that Adora is staring at her kind of intensely because her soft smile grows into a lopsided grin, the tip of her canines catching on her bottom lip.

"Welcome back to the world of the living," Catra greets her, her voice squeaky even though she tries to keep it in a whisper.

"Hey. Good morning," Adora smiles back at her, eyes hooded, resting her palms on the sides of Catra's waist, as she runs careful circles on the skin that lives there. Adora runs her eyes over her girlfriend´s form one more time before roaming her eyes across her usually impeccable room, catching sight of Catra´s backpack thrown carelessly in the carpet and her shoes next to the bed, still spotted in some kind of mud. "How did you get in?"

"I climbed the pinetree and jumped through your window," Catra shrugs, playing with a strand of Adora´s blonde hair, bringing it to her nose into a fake mustache. Her legs are tangled with Adora´s, bare soles pressing together. "Nothing new. I saw Hope-zilla´s car on the entryway so I thought using my spare key wasn't a good idea."

"Ugh, Light Hope is back?" Adora wrinkles her nose, taking one hand away from Catra´s waist just to press it against her own

forehead, groaning when a sharp stab of pain crosses her temples from side to side, a tale tell of last night's antics.

“Uh, yeah. You didn´t notice? She must have made you put it in your calendar or something,” Catra´s voice is low and soft but it is not kind, layered with shades of irritation and hidden resentment.

She has never been particularly kind to Light Hope´s existence in Adora´s life, and Hope has never been kind to Catra in return, always sneering down at her and prohibiting her to step foot on the house so as to not distract Adora from her murderous studying schedule. She is always trying to pull them apart, always with the excuse of Adora´s preparation for college. It´s a miracle, thank the goddess, that Catra hasn´t punched her in the face, content on breaking Light Hope´s rules right under her nose by sneaking into the house all the time.

“Nu-uh, didn't even check when I got back home. Glimmer dropped me off.” Adora grunts, pressing her fingertips strongly against the tender skin of her temples. Another sharp stab of pain rings on her head, making even her teeth clench with pain. “My head is killing me”

“Yeah, that's what happens when you overdo it, dummy,” Catra lets her head roll over Adora´s collarbones, pressing a kiss on the skin where her sleep shirt is folded. “You know you have no alcohol tolerance, Adora, yet you took five shots in one row.”

Adora eyes her sideways, running her fingers almost as a second thought through the curls of Catra´s nape. “How´d you know that?”

“Glimmer texted me,” Catra answers with a huge grin, stretching deviously when Adora´s eyes widen. “Photos too.”

“Great,” Adora let's her head fall back on the pillow, rolling her eyes. She can feel Catra´s grin in her collarbones and even though Glimmer snitching on her annoys her she cannot stop the smile plastering in her face. “It was not the alcohol” Catra hums,

obviously incredulous, staring at each other with wordless comprehension. “It was not. Everyone was drunk but I was not.”

“Uh-hu,” Catra lingers an open mouthed kiss over Adora´s collarbones, rising goosebumps on the pale skin there. “I figured you would need me after your adventure last night, that's why I came. I brought you Tylenol too.”

“You are a saint,” Adora groans, sighing deeply. “I was sad you weren't there, though.” Adora nuzzles her cheek over Catra´s hair. She smells nice, like the forest that surrounds their town, sandalwood and rosemary. Kind of like petrichor too, in the very roots, rain stitched to her freckled skin.

“You are the volleyball team captain and the most popular person on the entire fucking campus, Adora. I'm sure you were just fine.”

Banter is normal between them, after knowing each other for the good part of twenty years, they are used to each other´s inner jokes and quirks, Adora´s shit eating humor and Catra´s sour sarcasm. It's an Adora and Catra´s thing; something they know, that they learnt even before neither could spell or begin to understand how much they would need and love each other in the future. Something that was already there when Adora´s parents became best friends with Catra´s dad and Catra and Adora ended up glued to the hip. Friends, partners in crime, a team, best friends. Lovers, eventually.

This, however, this small hint of bitterness in Catra´s voice Adora knows is not banter or joke, something real and rotten boiling under the surface that went unspoken between them for so long that almost tore them apart and that Adora hoped to never hear it again. She is still fighting to never hear it again, sheltering Catra from the things that happened last year, from memories and scars in her neck. But even with all the love in the world and inside Adora´s heart, Catra has never been the same since then. Something completely shifted from its axis after what happened, shaking her soul to the very core, cracking her, tainting her. And it makes Adora sad.

“Also, I don't like parties, you know that. And I don't like your friends,” Catra´s tone is more lighthearted than before, tethering more towards a joke, lifting just a little the weight inside Adora´s chest. Maybe Catra caught the sad glint inside Adora´s eyes at her bitter words, maybe she realized it herself. Maybe she is trying with her entire strength to be better, do better, fight the demons and memories eating their way inside her chest. Whatever it is, it's enough to make Adora grin again, still sad in the edges, bumping her nose against Catra's cheek.

“You like Glimmer and Bow.”

“I like Bow, it's not like I have a choice with him. And I tolerate Glimmer because Angella lets me crash at their house until you and me fuck off to college,” Catra thumbs the collar of Adora's shirt, wiggling her hips closer. There is a flash of something on her colorful eyes, for a moment, something heavy. “The rest of your friends, though? Ew”

“Don´t be a brat.” Adora rests her fingertips right over the end of the scar, drinking in the shiver of Catra´s body against hers at the touch. “They are fine, just– difficult. You learn how to deal with them with time.”

“Sure.” Catra snaps her eyes away from Adora´s profile, clicking her teeth together sharply. She leans away from where she is resting atop Adora´s body, scrambling back over the wrinkled sheets until she is sitting on the middle of the bed with her back towards Adora, all of her hair falling around her neck and hiding her face. Adora´s heart gives a painful jolt inside her chest. She narrows her eyes, a wave of worry and also sharp protectiveness cursing through her entire body.

When they were younger, Catra was loud. About everything in her life, she was loud. Loud like a firecracker exploding in the sky, loud as a lightning against the night, loud as laughter inside a crowded room, loud like the color red. She was loud and happy, chasing life like a hunter, like thunder, seeking for freedom on every single corner and crevice of the world. Even after her father

´s death, she was loud and strong, a force of nature incapable to be tamed or controlled, a hurricane out of control. Even when she was drowned by the presence of her mother, scolded by her hand and words and tossed around like a leaf to a storm, she never managed to weather Catra down, to make her dim. Until last year.

Now Catra is quiet. Quiet in a way that makes Adora afraid. She is quiet like the forest outside the bedroom window. Quiet like rain falling sadly over the grass. Quiet like a graveyard, broken marble and defiled earth. Quiet like a volcano, boiling under the surface but stone cold below the soles of feet, nurturing the ground but ready to break free and explode, a ticking time bomb that Adora does not know what it will do to Catra once it's set free. Because, instead of being nurtured and protected by the person that was supposed to cherish her the most in the entire world, by her *mother,* Catra was broken. And Adora sometimes doesn't know what she is going to do if she fails to hold the pieces of Catra's bruised heart together.

"Come here," Adora sits up too, kicking the sheets until she is wrapped around Catra's warm body. Adora's arms snake their way over Catra's chest, holding her flushed against Adora's as she nuzzles her nose against Catra's pulse point, peppering soft kisses in the skin there. This is Adora's favorite place to exist, this single point between Catra's neck and her shoulder where her blood drums alive and her skin is scattered in copper freckles. Adora doesn't know how it took her so long to realize how deep her devotion for Catra ran, nor knows what would have been of herself if she had lost her that night.

"Where were you last night then, uh? I texted you a million times and you didn't answer."

Catra tenses imperceptible underneath Adora's palms, still avoiding her eyes when she answers between clenched teeth. "I was taking a walk"

“In the middle of the storm?” Adora wonders with a nervous laugh, unable to hide the surprised hint in her voice.

She had seen last night the turmoils of clouds approaching Etheria from the windows of Mermista’s house and knew that they meant trouble the second the first lightning lashed against the ground outside. It was actually kind of fun, a storm lashing over the school party before everyone passed out by exhaustion or near alcohol poisoning.

Catra, however, does not answer, shifting uncomfortably in Adora's hold. She is pressing her mouth closed so tightly that the metal tips of her piercings dig painfully over her bottom lip, coloring the skin deep red, threatening to break.

“I needed some fresh air, I didn't think it would storm so bad,” she says but her voice is strained, obviously annoyed to have to give an explanation to begging with. Adora frowns, twisting her torso to stare at Catra´s face fully.

“Cat,” Adora´s voice drops, searching for Catra´s bright eyes. “The truth?”

“That's the truth,” Catra snaps, wrinkling her nose. Her eyes harden suddenly and her shoulders tense, returning Adora´s gaze sharply. There are spots of red on her cheeks, popping up all of her freckles. Even her breath is elaborate, voice sore and with that squeaky edge that never really wore away after the incident and that made Catra stop singing completely. “Nothing is going to happen to me for taking a walk down the fucking block while it rains, Adora”

Adora shrinks on herself, eyebrows knitting together. Her chest gives a painful tug, so similar to the stab of pain that had been chasing her for a while now. They hold each other's eyes for a painfully long minute, silver against blue and amber until Adora´s shoulders drop forward, her face falling.

“I´m sorry, I didn't mean to overwhelm you.” Adora thumbs gently the angel-bites nestled below Catra's upper lip, careful of not tugging from the piercings. “I just, after that night–”

“I know, Dora,” Catra´s eyes relax too, anger melting off her body like boiling lava. But her body remains locked into a shiver, tension pouring off her very skin. Adora blinks against the tears stinging in the corner of her eyes, moving softly as to not tense Catra further. She cradles Catra´s face between her palms, bringing her closer to her, Adora´s warm breathe caressing the delicate skin of Catra ´s neck.

“You were bleeding so much,” Adora whispers, and it's around a sob, broken in the edges. All the apprehension drops off Catra´s body, weaving herself inside Adora´s touch. She closes her eyes, exhaling between Adora´s palms, resting her own hands over Adora´s red knuckles.

“It's alright now.” Catra is trembling softly, suddenly overwhelmed by memories. The sound of screams, the smell of her own blood pooling around her chest, Adora´s cries against her cheeks as life failed her. She doesn't want to remember them, she rejects them but they are a part of her now, as much as Adora´s lips on her mouth or the smell of sandalwood on her clothes. A part of her that will always make her afraid. “It's going to be alright.”

“Right,” Adora agrees, nodding softly but sure, always seeking to give Catra the fragile reassurance she needs. “Nothing bad is going to happen as long as we are together. I´m not going to let anything bad happen to you ever again.”

“No matter what?”

“No matter what,” Adora grins, pressing their foreheads together. “I promise.”

“Okay”

Silence falls back between them, comforting in the small space that lives between their bodies. Thoughts are still fighting their

wait inside Adora´s head, though, whispering scary things in her ears.

“Can I ask you something?” Adora waits until Catra is looking at her again, nodding with a confused frown between her thick eyebrows. “Are you afraid? Of us leaving town?”

Catra´s eyes widen with surprise and she chuckles, shaking her head softly still between Adora´s palms. There are faint lilac lines below her pretty eyes and she looks exhausted.

“No, Adora. There is nothing I want more in this world than being with you,” Catra presses a kiss inside Adora´s hand, staring back at her with a new found kind of fire burning inside her irises. “I'd do *anything* to be with you. Anything at all, there is not me without you” Her voice hitches in the middle, drowned out by a kind of passion that Adora can feel, traveling down her skin like a fever unknown by Adora but welcomed on this warm October morning. Something dooming that she doesn't even know yet. “I just want to be done with this fucking propaedeutic year and leave this town forever with you. We are already a full school year late for my fault.”

“Hey, it was not your fault,” Adora disagrees softly. “And we will,” Adora promises, resting a tender kiss over Catra´s cheekbone. This is the only thing sometimes holding them from crashing down, the flutter of their dreams and their want to be together above anything else. “We already graduated high school. We just need to survive this year and then we’ll go to Horde College together and have perfectly normal and tiring jobs and a perfectly normal boring life. We are almost there, finally.”

“Almost there,” Catra repeats, voice heavy. “I promise too. No matter what.”

A shiver runs down Adora´s spine but she ignores it, too weak and too in love to dare to put a name to it. Instead she runs her fingers over the red sleeves of Catra´s jacket, frowning softly when recognition falls over her. Red sleeves, white flaps, golden

lettering with Adora´s last name in the back and the captain´s logo in the front. The varsity jacket that was given to Adora as a reward after years of effort on the team and that now hangs from Catra´s slender shoulders like a second skin.

"You are wearing my team´s jacket," Adora marvels, grinning like an idiot when she catches sight of the shirt below, pristine white with Ethernia´s Campus logo in the chest. " *And* my captain´s shirt"

All apprehension forgotten now, Catra smiles, running the tip of her tongue over her piercings. "I am"

"I´ve been looking for it for two weeks, you know?" Adora drops her fingers on the hollow of Catra´s throat, drawing invisible lines down her chest, brushing her sternum and the soft curve of her breasts beneath the warm fabric.

Catra´s breath hitches in her throat but she makes an effort of keeping her voice in control, grinning sultry and without regrets at her. "Tough luck, hot stuff"

Adora hums, glancing at Catra´s pretty and flushed face before diving forwards, nuzzling her face against the column of Catra´s neck completely. So close, she can hear the way Catra´s heart jumps inside her chest under the touch, caught off guard by Adora´s sudden boiling desire between them. She opens her mouth to say something but is cut short when Adora sinks her teeth over the tender flesh of her jaw, ripping a silent whine from deep inside Catra´s chest.

"Adora," Catra gasps, holding herself to Adora´s broad shoulders. Adora nips the smooth side of her neck, blooming soft flowers on the opposite side from the scar. Catra´s breath stops then, her pulse skyrocketing below Adora´s lips but Adora just presses a tender kiss over the jarred skin, tender and careful.

She knows everything about Catra, all of it from the inside out, and she knows damn well that hands around Catra´s neck or

biting over the long ago healed skin are a hard no. Instead, Adora moves upwards, running the tip of her tongue under the angle of Catra´s jaw until she reaches her ear. Adora hands sneak underneath Catra´s – *her own* – shirt, running her blunt nails against the soft bumps of Catra´s spine.

Catra dissolves into a whine again, rolling her head to the side. "Gosh. Adora, we are already late"

"So?" Adora shrugs, lavishing the corner of Catra´s mouth without getting to kiss her completely, leaving her panting and squirming inside her hands when Adora drops her face to the other side, too occupied to bloom hickeys on the line between Catra´s collarbone and the shirt.

"Don´t you, *oh,* don´t you have volleyball practice?"

Adora smiles around Catra´s barely hidden moan, running her palms from Catra´s feverish back to the front, cupping the small teardrop of her breasts between her fingers. She isn't even wearing a bra, which is not weird for Catra but that this morning turns on Adora infinitely more. "So?"

"And an exam? And an essay about First One´s linguistics that took you the entire weekend to write and you were pestering me about so much that we didn't have sex just so you could finish it?"

"Yes." Adora raises her head at Catra´s eyesight again just so she can wiggle her eyebrows at her, grinning when Catra pokes her tongue out at her. "And?"

Catra rolls her eyes so hard they almost strain inside their pockets. She shoves Adora´s shoulder, hard. "You are a piece of shit"

"Just a little bit. Can you blame me, though? A girl can do so much while having her beautiful girlfriend in her bed in the early hours of the morning, wearing *my* clothes."

Adora leans down against, cradling Catra´s face back into her hands and peppering sweet kisses over her nose and lips. Catra is still grumbling under her breath but she is relaxed, loose when Adora brings her closer over her lap and grabs her arms and rests them around her neck, tangling them together into an embrace. Adora rests her mouth over the shell of Catra´s ear, petting her curls with reverent hands.

“Only if you want”

Catra sighs around Adora´s whisper, dropping her weight over Adora´s hold. When she speaks, she sounds completely at ease, open and trusting Adora completely.

“I do”

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Adora smiles against Catra's skin, running her mouth over her cheek until she reaches her lips. They kiss dearly for a long while, sweet minutes that they know by heart now. Adora rests her lips against Catra´s and licks the end of the piercings with the tip of her tongue, cooing her mouth open and she smiles at the light pinch of the sharp metal against her tongue. Adora has said it to Catra before, but since the day Catra got them Adora has not been able to tear her eyes away from them, too enchanted by the way they rest over Catra´s always rose lips.

Catra sighs against Adora´s open mouth, cradling Adora´s cheek as she licks a faint line over the roof of her damp mouth, tasting Adora on the back of her throat. There is a rumble deep in her chest, almost like a purr that Adora has come to understand is deep content. The sound makes Adora smile inside the kiss and she opens her eyes a little bit just so she can stare at Catra´s face.

Catra´s cheeks are of a deep shade of crimson, traveling from the tip of her nose, across her cheeks and reaching her temples and the shell of her ears. Her eyes are closed, long eyelashes painting

shadows on her cheekbones scattered with freckles. She also looks sleepy, sloppy kisses and loose hold around Adora´s shoulders. She is always drowsy when they have sex, breathing slow and with her body loose. The first time, when they finally decided to step together into an intimate life, Adora was unsure of what it meant. As they grew up on their relationship and their knowledge of each other´s most vulnerable forms, Adora came to understand it meant that Catra was relaxed, completely open and trusting Adora and the space between their bodies. Happy.

Adora grins now at the sight, leaning her mouth away from Catra ´s just so she can drag her lips up her temples, peppering tiny caresses in there as her hands start to move too. She cradles Catra closer, making sure she is well wrapped and held against Adora´s body before allowing her right hand to travel down. Adora dips her fingers past the front edge of Catra´s underwear, running her fingers down the curled hair there until she reaches what she is craving for, the fabric of the boxers already soaked through completely by their shared kisses alone.

Sinking her fingers inside Catra's heat is easy, something familiar to Adora now, after so much time together. She is so wet too, soaked sounds rising in the bedroom as Adora caresses gently at Catra´s folds and then presses inside, past firm muscle and into the warm space inside Catra´s body.

Catra's voice hitches on her throat, the tiniest of whimpers falling off her mouth, hiccuped moans that only Adora gets to hear. Adora kisses her deeper, the high pitched noises traveling down Adora´s very spine.

Catra´s arms spasm over Adora´s shoulders, tangling her fingers on the blonde strands, her sharp nails digging against Adora´s scalp in a way that the latter consider delicious. Adora has always had a side of her that just wants to drown in Catra´s fire, to feel her sharp nails against her skin and her red mouth on her tongue, something that for many years was confusing and acid on the base of her throat that brought them both nothing but sorrow

until she realized Catra loved her and that Adora was allowed to adore her in return.

Adora thrusts into her repeatedly, drinking all of Catra's little noises on her tongue. She has two fingers in already, Adora knows she can take more, she has made love to Catra enough times, loving her tender and heated with all the goodness inside her heart.

Catra shivers from head to toe with each sweet trust, chasing the movement of Adora´s wrist with her hips and moaning everytime she sinks inside of her again. She tears her mouth off Adora´s when the tingling feeling crippling down her belly becomes too much, resting her open lips against Adora´s cheek. She is panting already, the careful control she has placed over herself to remain quiet breaking in the seams as a soft chant of moans and whimpers drip off her mouth and against Adora´s face, dangerously close to being too loud.

" *Ah, ah* ." Catra holds her breath and whimpers, holding Adora like a lifeline, her nape damp with sweat that only makes the sandalwood smell of her skin deepen. "Adora, *AH* !

Adora glances at her tenderly out of the corner of her eye, smiling softly at her flushed face. She nudges Catra´s temple gently, running the back of her knuckles against the base of Catra´s spine.

"Shh." Adora´s hand stills suddenly, ripping the incoming orgasm out of Catra´s bones. Her thumb runs gentle circles over Catra´s clit instead, a silent apology as she takes her fingers away from the slick folds. Catra gasps at the feeling, her panting falling into an annoyed rumble of displeasure. Even her fingers twitch, digging against Adora´s back painfully.

"Oh, I´m sorry, my love." Adora grins, shit eating, knowing everything about Catra´s body, pressing a kiss against Catra´s forehead. "Were you going to cum, sweetheart?

“Fuck you.” Catra wheezes, her mouth slick and hot against Adora´s neck when she lets her head fall forward, cradling herself inside Adora´s touch. Adora´s hand has raised now, pressing it flush against Catra´s belly, fingers still coated in release.

“I'd rather stay like this, thank you.” Adora allows Catra of a second, just a single one to catch her breath again before calling for her attention with her mouth again. “Rest on your back.”

Catra´s eyebrows knit together, barely managing to make sense of Adora´s whispers among the pleasure swirling inside her head.

“What–? Hey!” Adora wraps her hands around Catra´s tights and pulls forwards, tilting them body backwards in one swift swing until Catra is pressed flat against Adora´s mattress, Adora herself hovering over her. Catra gasps, surprise melting into clear delight as a smile spreads on her face. “My, oh my. Color me impressed, princess.”

Catra starts to wiggle out of Adora´s jacket without standing up, mind focused on getting naked as quickly as possible. That is until Adora´s hands stop her, wrapping softly around Catra´s wrists and bringing them up towards her head.

“No,” Adora shakes her head, staring at Catra heavily. Catra´s eyebrows shoot up on her forehead, tilting her head to the side.

“No?”

“No.” Adora moves, pushing the rest of the sheets of the bed and gathering all of her pillows, placing them thoughtfully around Catra´s head and underneath her waist and back until Catra´s hips are slightly elevated over the plush pillows and her back is resting comfortable over the bed sheet.

With the wiggling around, the shirt Catra has stolen from Adora has wrinkled up over her torso, letting Adora see the tender curve of her breasts and the cheeky glimpse of her raised nipples barely hidden under the white fabric, tempting Adora with their trembling every time Catra breaths. Her chest rises and falls quickly,

elaborated and excited, and the jacket falls open at either side of her body, Like this Adora can see her fully, from her tousled dark hair to the deep red of her cheeks and the goosebumps of her freckled skin all the way towards her parted legs. A sight only for Adora, open like a flower and dripping, smells that make Adora dizzy and enchanted like a human to a siren´s song.

Adora grins sideways, resting all of her weight over her hands as she leans towards Catra´s face, kissing the tip of her red nose before whispering again. The display of strength makes Catra whimper with crave.

"Here is how it's going to go. You are going to lay there, in my clothes and be very quiet so that Light Hope doesn´t hear you." Adora teases the side of Catra´s head, biting softly the shell of her ear. Catra´s gasp tangles on her vocal cords, doing a monumental effort to keep quiet. "And because you've been so good this morning, I'm going to eat you out and you are going to come in my tongue until all you can feel the rest of the day is me in you, alright?"

Catra stares at Adora without saying a word, baffled. She erupts into a quiet, nervous giggle, narrowing her eyes softly at her girlfriend.

"Jeez. What kind of kinky novels have you been reading–? *Oh"* Adora has used the distraction to lower down again across Catra´s body, diving in without waiting for a second more inside Catra´s parted legs, grasping her aching clit between her front teeth and giving the softest of tugs. It´s a silent warning, to behave. And Catra loves it. "Alright, got it. Absolutely."

Adora smiles at her from her place, moving until she is resting more comfortably over the bed.

"I want you to relax and have a good day. I'm here with you" She rests her palms against Catra´s trembling knees, placing a kiss over them. "Quiet, baby"

“Okay”

Adora runs her mouth across Catra´s legs, just as tenderly as she had done before across her face. From the knees, all the way down her thighs, resting her mouth over the stretch lines traveling towards her hips and pressing tender kisses on each patch of clustered freckles that live there. She takes her time, lavishing every inch of Catra´s legs, her hips and the start of her navel in loving caresses, always a breath away from the place calling for her so insistently.

Catra is wiggling almost desperate above her now, kicking and digging her ankles over the mattress, holding her breath every time a gasp robs her of her breath and she tries to quiet it down as Adora asked her. She is blushing again and her mouth glistens with her saliva where she runs her tongue over the delicate skin, staring at Adora with misted eyes full of unspeakable desire and love.

She knows everything about Adora too, all that there is to be about her, Catra knows and loves. She knows everything, *everything,* and accepts and wraps it around her heart like a second one, carrying it and beating inside her chest too. There is nothing in the world that could ever sway Catra´s heart away from Adora, or Adora´s heart from Catra and Adora knows that too, flourishing joy inside of her.

“Dora…” Catra hiccups, biting her knuckles to keep her voice low, desperation clear on her limbs. “Please”

“I know, love.” Adora murmurs against her skin, lingering another kiss against her leg before reaching for Catra´s bitten hand, pulling it away from Catra´s mouth gently to keep her from hurting herself.

Adora then wraps her hands around Catra´s legs, closing them gently and raising them with ease. Adora rests both of Catra´s folded legs over her own left shoulder, cooing Catra sideways until her torso is slightly tilted towards the side, opening the most

intimate part of Catra in a different way to Adora´s eyes and mouth.

“Hold them up, one arm.” Adora instructs Catra kindly. Catra nods, wrapping her right arm underneath her bent knees, keeping her legs from opening suddenly and hitting against Adora´s temple. “Be quiet, alright? You can hold my hair.” Catra nods again, still blushing and still quiet. “Are you okay?” Nod. “Can you tell me your words, my love?”

“Green to go, yellow to slow down, orange for a break,” Catra gasps, licking her bottom lip. Her heart is beating so fast inside her body that she feels like it's about to fly inside Adora´s room. “So very green right now”

“And to stop?”

“Apples.” Catra manages a tiny smile, caressing the corner of Adora´s eye with her fingertips. “I'm alright. Can you please…?”

“Of course,” Adora presses one last kiss over the small of Catra´s back and returns to the place where she is needed the most

She relaxes her jaw, lets her mouth fall completely open, rolls her tongue out and presses it without a second thought against the warm and pink space of Catra´s slit. She can feel the speeding of Catra´s heart pulsing on her lips and it only manages to fuel her further, licking her way past soft folds and into the heat inside, teasing firm muscle with the tip in a way that makes Catra whimper below her palm, tightly pressed against her mouth.

Adora hums, almost like a song, the vibrations falling over Catra´s puffed clit in a way that makes her spiral down. Adora smiles at the way both of Catra´s legs twitch over her shoulder, shaking with the effort of keeping them up and remaining silent.

Catra's folds are soaked through, dripping already around Adora's lips and down her chin. And she is warm, as is everything about her, the heavy smell filling Adora's nose to the brim. Adora risks a quick glance from her favorite place to Catra´s face, catching the

expression in her factions. Her mouth is open, glistening with saliva over the kiss bitten lips; her eyes are hooded, lost in pleasure, and there are tears gathering on the corners, brought out by the overwhelming sensation of letting herself lose in Adora ´s mouth. There is nothing on earth Adora would want more right now than to be able to have Catra in a safe space where she can whimper or moan or gasp without fear of being caught, but they do the best of what they can.

Adora stretches her arms towards Catra's chest, cradling her small breast inside her palm, gently fondling in a way she knows makes Catra's mind go numb with pleasure. Adora is terribly fond of Catra´s breasts, she was enamored of them since the first time she saw them, small enough to fit inside Adora´s palm, with freckles on the base and the brown nipples Adora has spent hours alone kissing.

The sex had not changed between them, not even after last year, it was still charged with fire and desire layered with rooted love. But Adora did become gentler on some spots, the urge of their shared youth washed down by the need to worship Catra´s body and sensations every time they were intimate, giving her the kindness and gentleness Catra so much deserved.

Adora breathes deep and drives out her tongue just so she can cradle Catra's folds between her lips instead, lavishing them in the same kind of kisses she would give to Catra's mouth if her girlfriend weren't too busy trying not to whimper. Adora loves these lips too, they are a little longer than the inner ones, of a pinkish brown and puffed like a plumb  every time they are like this. Adora´s tongue and lips are damp already with Catra´s release so the feeling of her mouth meeting the soft folds is even more intense, sliding together perfectly.

It must fire up something deep inside of Catra because she loses the silence battle and moans loudly, her mouth falling open and her cheek nuzzling deeper into the pillows around her head. Adora’s heart skyrockets for a very different reason than being

caught up having sex with her girlfriend in Hope's house, staring at Catra's precious red face as she enjoys herself completely.

Adora wraps her left arm securely around Catra´s waist, holding her in place, and then with great sorrow lets go off her breast, reaching up towards Catra´s face. She slips her fingers inside Catra´s mouth, quieting her whimpering with her fingertips pressing softly against the flat of her tongue. The end of the piercings brush against Adora´s knuckles every time Catra sucks on them.

Catra is close, dangerously so, Adora knows this already. It´s impressive by all means that she has been able to hold on for so long now. But her body is growing restless. The hand that is not holding her own legs in place has found its way on Adora´s head, holding herself to the strands of golden hair like a lifeline. Her back is arching off the pillow and her hips are pushing down into Adora´s face with sweet rolls of her waist, chasing the previously denied orgasm with edged desperation.

The tears stuck on her eyelids have begun to fall down, warm and painting paths over her flushed skin. She manages to open her eyes just a slit, looking down at Adora with a silent plea in her eyes, a language only Adora has ever known how to understand. She knows what Catra needs and she will give it to her no matter what.

Adora takes her fingers away from Catra´s mouth and lowers them down, circling the pulsing and aching edge of her slit before dipping them inside again with deep thrusts, three of them all at the same time, curling the tips in a way that brushes the firm point inside of Catra that makes her come undone every single time.. Adora presses her tongue flat against the damp folds and then closes her mouth softly, grazing Catra´s clit between her front teeth with a soft suck.

Catra comes so hard that it almost takes Adora by surprise. She presses her face against Adora´s pillow, scrunches her eyes closed and gasps around a silent scream, ripping the sheet with

her nails and spasming inside Adora´s arms softly. The warm touch of her release filling against Adora´s mouth and falling over her chin starts dripping down immediately and Adora has to lean back to be able to take a breath, only to dive back again so she can lick tiny and gently at the release still dripping off Catra´s slit, drinking it in like a goddess to a immortality pile.

She does so reverently until the shaking on her love´s limbs starts to lower down and she regains sense of her body again, softly squirming away from Adora´s mouth in a quiet sign of overstimulation. Adora stops immediately, untangling herself from their hold so she can travel over her body. She glances down at her deep blue sheets and raises her eyebrows, lingering a gentle kiss above Catra´s hip.

"Wow. You came a *lot."* Adora marvels, obviously delighted. " You squirted all over my sheet, baby."

"Shut up." Catra opens one of her eyes, glancing at Adora with a sharp stare as she whispers with a sore voice. "Don´t *wow* me."

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The permanent blush on her cheeks and the exhaustion in her bones gives her away though. Adora smiles lovingly at her, making her way on her palms until she is draped gently over Catra´s body. Adora rests her chin over Catra´s shoulder, nuzzling her cheek in the jacket she is still wearing. She looks down at Catra adoringly, trailing tiny kisses over her feverish neck. Like this, the scar is almost invisible under Adora´s lips.

"I love you," Adora whispers, cooing Catra with her nose until her girlfriend looks at her again. Adora´s eyes are gentle and her voice is calm yet she tries to maintain it firm, filling it with all the reassurance that she possibly can as she pronounces the words. "I love you so much, you know that?"

The corner of Catra´s eyes soften in the corners immediately, another kind of tears gathering in her eyelids. She stretches her

arm and rests her open palm against Adora´s flushed face, caressing a soft line over the curve of her cheekbone.

“I do,” Catra says back, in the thread of a voice, brushing the fine white eyelashes underneath Adora´s eye. “I really do”

Adora leans in, kissing Catra´s mouth sweetly. She still tastes heavily of Catra and they both sigh around the lingering scent hanging in the room. Catra wraps her arms around Adora´s neck and pulls her closer, wrapping herself around Adora´s body without stopping from kissing for a single second. They are so enthralled with each other that don´t even notice the steps approaching Adora´s door until the locked knob turns around suddenly, shaking the wood when the door doesn´t open.

“Adora,” Light Hope´s unnervingly calm voice slips inside the bedroom, ripping Adora and Catra from their daydream.

Adora snaps her head towards the closed door, blue eyes widening when she realizes Light Hope is waiting for her to open it and lets her through like she always does when Hope inspects the state of her room.

“Shit. Shit shit.” Adora mutters, scrambling away from Catra´s arms and down the bed in a rush. She grabs the bundle of blankets on the floor and tosses them messily over Catra´s form, hiding her from sight under the plush fabric. “Don't move.”

“Roger that.” Catra whispers, snuggling further on the blankets. She peaks from underneath the blanket suddenly, grasping Adora ´s wrist before she can rush to open the door. “Adora”

“What is it?” Adora whispers back, unable to not answer Catra´s call. Catra blushes deeply, pointing at Adora´s face with her fingers.

“You have, um,” she stutters, turning in a shade of red so deep that it rivals the red of the jacket. “Your mouth.”

Adora stares at her without understanding until she realizes her chin and bottom lip are completely sticky still, already drying in the corners.

“Oh,” Adora exclaims, almost throwing herself to the bedside table where she keeps makeup remover wipes. She grabs a handful and runs them harshly over her entire face. She grabs her sleeping shirt and takes it out too, tossing it towards the basket so she is only on her sports binder.

“Adora. Open the door,” Light Hope calls again, clear frustration starting to slip on the cracks of her usual perfect facade.

“Coming!” Adora yells back, tucking the blankets around Catra´s body so it is not completely obvious that there is someone hiding beneath them. Adora grumbles under her breath, muttering just loud enough that only Catra can hear her. “I can't even have breakfast in peace”

Catra snorts under the blankets and kicks her blindly. Adora catches her bare foot and tickles her gently in the sole, shushing her softly when Catra giggles and reminding her to be very still right after.

Adora joggers the few steps between the bed and the door and yanks it open, standing tall and straight in front of Light Hope.

“Good morning, Light Hope.” Adora greets her, running her eyes towards the woman in front of her. As always, Light Hope is very still, perfectly dressed in her two piece navy suit. Her skull-short dark hair is impeccable and her face clean and emotionless, staring at Adora slightly panting in front of her with an unimpressed look.

“Adora.” Hope greets back, tilting her head to the side barely a millimeter. “Why are you blushing?”

“I uh– I was doing warm ups, for the training class,” Adora lies, horribly because she has always been a terrible liar and an even worse actor, stretching her arms to the sides and flexing her

sweaty muscles. It´s not a complete lie, actually, but she knows Catra is rolling her eyes hard below the blankets.

Hope doesn´t seem to notice Adora´s evident nervousness, inspecting instead the state of Adora´s room from her place next to the frame of the door. As always, it is spotless. The closet is perfectly organized by clothes colors and uses; the desk is clean and free of papers; the floor is clean and the carpet without dust; dirty clothes on the basket and away from sight no posters on the wall or nothing at all except the white of the walls. Everything is perfect and soulless, *except* for Catra´s bag and shoes next to the window and the messed up bed hiding her inside. In a way, Adora thinks it's a perfect metaphor of what Catra is in Adora´s perfect existence. Chaos and true life.

"Your room is a mess," Light Hope spats, still perfectly calm, overlooking all the good things and focusing on the ones she disapproves of. At least she doesn´t seem to notice that there is a third person with them. Hope snaps her eyes back to Adora, regarding her with a scolding stare. Up close Adora can actually see that she looks kind of exhausted, some kind of heaviness hanging from her shoulders. "I was surprised that you didn´t receive me this morning."

"I didn´t hear you arrive," Adora explains weakly, fidgeting on her bare soles over the cold floor of her room. Hope, on the other side, only looks at her as if Adora had said something incredibly stupid,

"I´ve been here since three thirty, Adora." She says it as if it were something obvious not only to arrive from the so-called work at such godforsaken hour but also that Adora was supposed to be ready to greet her back. Homewer Adora has to admit that she was supposed to stay home and study the entire night for the finals, not to slip out of her window and to the town to have a good night. "You are late"

"I was studying and lost the sense of time," Adora answers immediately, voice falling into the same controlled and almost

robotic tone she always uses when she is around Light Hope. Hope´s mouth twists and then straightens again, finally a pleased stare falling on her dark eyes.

“Well, in that case I guess it's worth it, it shows dedication to your training” She leans  in all her height towards Adora, locking their gazes together. “The First One´s Academy will not take anything but the best, Adora. And your parents have always wanted the best for you. They´d be happy to know that you are following the path that they marked for you”

Adora closes her hands tightly at her sides, her nails digging halfmoon marks over the skin of her palms. “I know, Light Hope”

“Good,” Light Hope laces her hands together and starts turning around in the corridor, not even looking at Adora anymore. “I want you out of the house in fifteen minutes. I have to return to work and you are late for class. Valedictorians are not late. Ever”

“Yes,” Adora watches her go with her heart seized in her chest, a sudden sprout of bravery for things to change for the better blooming in her chest. “Light Hope?” she calls for her caretaker again, waiting until she is looking at her again.“Did any mail come for me? From other schools?”

“Why would you be waiting for any mail that wasn't from the Academy?” Light Hope inquiries, cold. The answer falls like a bucket of freezing water over Adora, tilting her on her axis.

“I– I don´t but–”

“Exactly. Focus on your duty, Adora,” Hope presses her mouth into a tight line, eyes darkening dangerously from one second to the next. “Or you'll end up like Mara.”

The feelings swirling inside Adora´s chest have no words. Despair, maybe. Fear. Disappointment, creeping its way beneath Adora´s skin and wrapping itself on her bones.

“Yes, Light Hope”

“Fifteen minutes.”

“Yes, Light Hope”

Hope is already walking down the stairs when Adora closes the door again, the lock clicking into place once more. Adora rests her forehead against the white surface of the door, breathing deeply several times through her nose. She has to physically fight the nausea down her throat, pushing back crippling dizziness and tears back and inside her soul. She cannot break down and cry right now, she doesn´t want to. She just wants to go back to bed inside Catra´s arms and ignore the rest of the world.

When Adora turns around Catra is already out of the blankets, staring at Adora´s back in silence. She opens her arms when she catches Adora looking and Adora gravitates like a planet to a sun inside her embrace, Adora wiggles them both into a more sitting position, her back against the headboard and Catra splayed tenderly over her chest. Catra lets her be in silence, instead kissing Adora´s collarbones and the base of her neck. She knows Adora needs it.

Adora stares at the ceiling, eyes locked somewhere else. It's kind of unnerving, when Adora is quiet like this because Catra, who is always able to read her from the inside out, cannot make out what she is thinking. She can imagine though, and it makes Catra terribly sad.

Adora holds Catra tightly against her but her left hand is hovering over her own thigh, scratching herself absently until the butter skin turns red and angry, a clear giveaway of her emotions boiling underneath the surface. Catra sighs and says nothing, slowly lacing her fingers with Adora´s restless hand, keeping it softly in place to stop Adora from hurting herself.

There is also anger, inside of Catra, anger and frustrations towards Light Hope somewhere in the house, uncaring of the way her words make Adora spiral. Anger that she dares to use Adora´s

parents as a way to manipulate her. Angry that she never allows Adora to choose. But she decides not to speak about it. For now

At some point Adora closes her eyes and lets her head roll back against the wood of the bed, tension slipping out of her bit by bit, her heart calming down and stilling in her chest. Catra must feel the change in Adora´s demeanor too because she relaxes and starts running her pointy nails back and forth Adora´s wide bicep and down her ribs, tickling her in the side cheekily.

“Do you think she knows we are fucking?”

“Cat,” Adora sputters, taken by surprise. She rolls her head to the side and giggles nervously, narrowing her eyes to her girlfriend. “Don't call it that”

Catra narrows her eyes too, arching her eyebrow. “You had your tongue on my pu–”

“I know, but I'm in love with you.” Adora corrects her softly, brushing an errand curl behind Catra´s ear. “We are a couple.”

She says it softly, so gently that it is obvious the amount of love those words carry and Catra, as always, comes undone under Adora´s devotion. Catra hums, nuzzling her cheek against Adora ´s reassuringly.

“Okay, baby. Let me phrase it differently,” she whispers, smiling. “Do you think your tight up ass caretaker knows you make love to me every single day until I can't breathe? In your room? In *her* house?”

Adora grabs Catra´s chin between her fingertips, tilting her head up to lock their eyes together and locking her in place. Catra straight up purrs at the motion, melting into Adora´s hands. She adores this part of Adora, the one that is not controlled by other people's expectations of her, the one that is wild and strong and that demands what she wants. And as it turns out, all Adora wants is Catra.

“Brat,” Adora says and kisses her, open mouthed and hot, raising silver sparkles beneath Catra´s closed eyelids.

“Light Hope has the romance awareness of a rock, she probably thinks I sleep too much.” Adora reassures her, ghosting her open lips softly up and down Catra´s neck. She rests her lips against the base of Catra´s ears and grins, nuzzling her as her knee comes up and makes it´s way between Catra´s legs tearing a soft moan out of her. She cannot go again for now but she is sensitive and Adora knows it. “Which is surprising with the noises you make”

Adora wraps both of her arms around Catra´s waist before she can start complaining and spins her from side to side on the bed, smiling at the sound of Catra´s laughter against her cheeks. All lust and desire tames down, replaced this time by tenderness and the simple desire of cuddling in bed with the woman Adora loves for as little minutes more as she can. They are young adults, yes, and they have an active and healthy intimate life as a couple too, but Adora would give up all of that for a single second more where she can kiss Catra´s mouth softly and adore her under the light of the morning sun.

“I love you,” Adora whispers, nuzzling their foreheads together into a touch they both know better than anything. Catra smiles tiny and sincere at her, her cheeks blooming again into red. She always looks so tender when Adora speaks those words to her, as if she could barely believe that, after everything, she has Adora and Adora has her in return.

“I love you too,” Catra whispers back, hiding a smile against Adora ´s bare bicep. Adora plays with a curl of Catra´s hair, bouncing it between her fingers.

“Was it good? Did you have fun?”

“Yes and yes,” Catra answers, rolling her eyes with fond exasperation at Adora´s persistent need to always make sure that Catra enjoys herself when they are together. As if she still couldn

´t understand how happy and desired she makes Catra feel. It's endearing. “I need new underwear though”

“I bought you new pairs,” Adora points loosely at her white dresser, “They are clean on my wardrobe”

Catra blinks dumbfounded at Adora, staring at the mole nestled in her jaw as she makes sense of the words. Adora doesn´t even seem to notice it because she keeps kissing Catra´s cheekbone like it was her final deed on earth.

“Wait, you bought me– Did you foresee something like this might happen one day? Me ruining my underwear?”

Adora eyes her cheekily, rolling her eyes. “It's not the first time, starlight. And I love you but I was running out of boxers because you kept taking them.”

“Oh, I see,” Catra´s voice is sultry now too, falling into their lighthearted banter easily. “So you *don´t* want to hand me your underwear after it's *your* fault I always ruin mine? Unbelievable”

“I want you to wear anything you want but I can´t go out butt naked”

“Beg to differ”

“Uh-uh, not chance Cat. The only one that I want staring at my naked butt is you.” Adora lingers a kiss on Catra´s cheekbone but her eyes are deeply dark, pupils blown out as she points blindly with her thumb at the floor to ceiling mirror at the opposite side of the bed. “Which I know you can do perfectly well already in my mirror when I´m strapping you down.”

Catra laughs so hard that she snorts, barely hidden away by Adora ´s palm quickly covering her mouth. Catra is still giggling softly beneath Adora´s palm as they strain their ears towards the corridor but Light Hope gives no sign of having heard them at all. Perks of living in such a, frankly, disgustingly big mansion.

“Wow. So filthy and romantic, Adora,” Catra jokes, wrapping her hand around Adora´s wrist. Adora wiggles her eyebrows at her, grinning from ear to ear. She loves to be able to be like this with Catra, to be who she really is, kind of an asshole and cocky and confident and in love.

“Always am. You can take a shower with me too if you want to feel clean for the day.” Adora thanks the stars every day that at least she has the privacy of her own bathroom with no other door but the one inside her room. It would have been too much for Light Hope to even lecture her on her shower habits. Adora grasps the flaps of her jacket, still safely wrapped around Catra´s limbs and thumbs the fabric softly, smiling at Catra with a glint in her eye. “I´m going to need my jacket back though. I do have practice.”

“You just fucked me on it”

“Exactly”

Catra erupts into giggles, hiding her face on Adora´s pillow. Her face has turned into that shade of pink that Adora knows by heart it means that Catra is completely happy and it makes the weight that had been hovering inside her chest dissolve into nothing but adoration for her girlfriend.

“You are such a little shit and I love you so much. You know that, right?” Catra says, voice muted and she is still tucked in the pillow. She glances at Adora sideways with a bright amber eye, a smile spreading in her mouth.

Adora answers the smile in kind, the corners of her eyes soft when she stares at Catra. She really does love Catra so much.

“I know,.” Adora leans to place another kiss over Catra´s eyelid, unable to stay away from her for long. “We really need to get going, though. There is a lot to do today.”

“Don´t remind me,” Catra groans, sinking further into the hard mattress below them. There is a clear edge of sneakiness in her

voice when she speaks next. “If you want me to move you´re going to need to do something about it, Dora”

Adora doesn´t bite back the dumb grin of her face, fondness spreading on her chest and covering everything else. She bends down, runs her good arm below Catra´s waist, the other around her chest and picks her up easily, not even wobbling as she throws Catra swiftly over her shoulder and climbs down the bed at the same time.

Catra smacks Adora´s butt and laughs upside down the entire walk towards the bathroom.

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Adora and Catra are not in highschool anymore. This is an important point to make, considering they are still being forced to come to Brightmoon´s campus every single week for their propaedeutic studies.

As every single young adult living in Etheria, Brightmoon´s students are always required to fulfill two years of preparation studies prior to their jump towards college life. This in order to prepare them further into the subject they are seeking to study or sometimes even to help them make the decision before rushing into something they won´t either like or enjoy.

It´s a good deal, it helps the youngs to stay home a little longer, enjoy the little free time they still have, and be a little older the moment they have to adventure towards the adult life. If you are eighteen finishing high school, you´ll be twenty shipped towards the college that has accepted you. Less wasted youth, as the Mayor  of the town would put it reluctantly.

Still, when you are a so-called new and fresh adult, it sucks massive ass to still have to share the campus with the rest of the high schoolers. Wins and loses. Wins and loses.

Adora is twenty one, freshly turned last January, much to Catra´s annoyance who is still a week away to reach the drinking age too. Not like she hasn´t gotten drunk plenty of times already, not like she is planning on doing it anymore, never again. Not ever.

Adora and Catra are a year older than their group of friends and even if they all started high school at the same time which was Mara's idea when Catra and Adora to avoid the teens from being isolated from others.

Catra and Adora are both so fucking smart they were placed a year ahead from everyone else in eight grade, which means that on insight they should have gotten out of propaedeutics a year earlier. Adora and Catra should have been in college already, this year actually, but life doesn´t always go as you plan it. Life sucks, actually, so now they are stuck here finishing finally with the rest of their friends.

It would be nice, if Catra could stand them. It's very obvious on her face. Or maybe Glimmer can read her very well after living an entire year with her grumpy ass under the same roof. At least she is always soft when Adora is there and Adora is always by her side.

Love birds.

Today, they are all sitting around their usual table in the cafeteria, the one that is perfectly separated from the high schoolers but just at the right angle for the light of the huge windows to pour nicely over their seats and table. Most of the group is here; Mermista, Perfuma, Glimmer and Bow on one side; Entrapta, Adora and Catra on the other. Sea Hawk and Scorpia are still in class and the rest are using their free time to decide the movie theme for their monthly sleepover at the Bright Manor.

"A horror movie!" Glimmer announces loudly, stepping over the bench of their lunch table. She is holding an ancient device on her hand, a triangle disk that reflects the colors when the sun touches it that was used long ago to play old fashioned movies. Before

smarter things were created, Entrapta would say if they had a mean bone on their body or at least a bone not completely focused on technology.

Doesn´t matter, Catra can say it for them.

“Yuck,” Catra mutters, poking her tongue out at Glimmer from her place, chin over the table and sitting next to Adora´s cheerful side.

This time though, Adora´s everlasting kind smile falls in the corners, her eyebrows twitching with concern. “I don't like horror movies, Glimm, you know that. Can´t we watch Spirit on the sleepover?”

“Ugh, Adora, we watch that movie every single time. I'm sick of it.” Mermista complains on the other side of the table, filing her navy blue nails.

“Spirit is a great movie,” Adora deflates for a second but shakes herself again immediately, looking at Glimmer again. Her hand is gently placed over Catra´s nape, caressing circles below the velvet choker. “Anyway, I don't want to watch blood, Glimmer. Or guts or anything.”

“As far as I have recorded, Adora fainted earlier this year in science class when we had to dissect the experiment frog. It was quite disturbing for her” Entrapta chimes in, still tinkering with some kind of invention. Adora stares at them slightly accusatory to be put in the spotlight but nods, pointing at them urgently.

“See? Last time I trusted you with a horror movie I couldn´t sleep at all in the *sleepover,* Glimmer. No, thank you.” Adora finishes punctually, a little bit too loud actually, shaking her head, her hand still protectively placed over Catra who hasn't said a single word more but stares at the ketchup of her untouched chips.

Glimmer knows Adora´s weak stomach is not really the entire culprit of Adora´s argument, something much more important hidden underneath it all, but Glimmer is not going to put her in

the spot. Or Catra. It´s not Glimmer´s place to announce to everyone the real reasons Adora refuses watching anything violent related and Glimmer learned her lesson in the last best friends sleepover, months ago.

Besides, Adora is a sweetheart, and has always been one. Brave and with a heart of gold, as kind hearted as pretty, the most beautiful of all girls Glimmer had ever known. It was no surprise Glimmer was in love with her for so long in high school, fawning over this strange new teen with two left feet and silver eyes.

Not that it ever got to anything which for a long time festered sourness and grudge inside Glimmer´s soul. After all, Adora has always had eyes just for Catra and only for her. All her attention has always been for Catra, her evenings after school all spent by her side, all her hours during school, all of her mornings sleeping next to her body on the same bed on the same sheets even before they were together as girlfriends.. Adora has never heard anything else but Catra´s voice or seen anything but her face or smile for anything that wasn't hers. Adora´s heart has always beaten for her and for her only, even when they were fighting, even when she didn´t speak of it outloud.

No matter how much Glimmer tried to call for her attention during those first years of high school, to win her affections, to tear Adora´s silver-blue eyes in her direction instead of away, the sound of Catra´s laughter would always sway Adora away like a moth to a forest fire. For a while, it made Glimmer resent Catra, blindly jealous. Confused about what was in Catra, spiteful and rude and brittle like cut glass, that had held such a grip in Adora´s soul.

They were like two pieces from different puzzles, so different from each other yet falling perfectly in place besides the other. Adora was always all smiles; jeans and white t-shirts and sneakers; golden hair falling in loops down her back or held in high ponytails to keep away from her face. The embodiment of sunshine walking down the corridors of the school. Catra almost never smiled, not when Adora was not there. She was all ripped black jeans or

leather skirt with fishnets, boots stained in mud over the tables of the school and piercings, sharp and cutting, unapproachable in the exterior, curls of dark hair framing her face like a lioness mane. A dark knight, always standing next to Adora´s light like a shadow.

Things are different now though. Now Glimmer has Bow and she knows what it is to be loved in return. Now Glimmer actually knows Catra, or at least she thinks she does. Now Glimmer understands the reason behind the sharpness in Catra´s soul and the tension in her shoulders. After many months sleeping on the same roof, Catra on the couch and Glimmer at her feet when nightmares were too bad and Adora was not there to keep Catra from digging her nails on her own flesh, Glimmer finally gets it.

In a way, she now understands Adora´s devotion for her. Glimmer will always love Adora, deep and hidden inside her heart, but now she cares about Catra too. Almost as much as Glimmer adores Adora.

"I already watched it, there is nothing like that I promise," Glimmer says softly, only for Adora, *only for Catra,* eyeing them both on the lunch table with a small nod of reassurance.

Adora relaxes visibly, nodding back. She drops her weight over Catra´s back into a barely hidden embrace and stretches her arm to steal a potato chip from her girlfriend´s plate. Catra bats her hand away with an elbow in the ribs, curling over her chips protectively when Adora laughs.

Bow offers his hand to Glimmer and helps her jump down quickly off the table before any director can see her there, sitting right back next to him with a victorious glint. She is always excellent at picking up the movies for the group's sleepovers, especially if they are horror themed ones. She is a huge fan of them and if her room weren´t already covered in lilac sparkle it would probably be filled floor to ceiling in horror movies props, a not so hidden passion that contrasts wildly with her usually bubbling self. Her

mother would have suffered an aneurysm though, but at least Bow found it endearing.

However, she is not the only one that is a huge fan of the occult and the morbid. Mermista clears her throat loudly, closing the bottle of nail polish she had gotten from goddess knows where with almost too much force.

“Well, I already gave my opinion on what we should watch”

Glimmer rolls her eyes, popping a perfect bubblegum. “We know, Mermista. But Mer-Mysteries is a series of movies”

“They are excellent”

“They all are like three hours long!”

“And they are fucking predictable” Catra adds suddenly, chewing in one of the potato chips.

Everyone in the table holds their breath, staring between both of them with weary eyes. It's never a good omen when someone talks slightly badly of Mermista´s favorite movies. It's an even worse omen that Catra is the one doing so.

Mermista drags eyes like daggers towards her, her face turning a deep shade of red with indignation. “They are not”

“They are. Always using the same boring formula.” Catra straightens on her seat and runs her tongue over her piercing, counting with her fingers as she speaks.

“The jock idiot that has more muscles than brains. The fool that serves as comedic relief that most of the time either says the title of the movie or gives the solution before dying. The bad-seed love interest that looks like a villain and, surprise surprise, is fifty fifty either the villain or was good all along in the end. The empty headed beauty that is absolutely either the jock´s girlfriend, a cheerleader, blonde or all three of them at the same time. The smart one that ends up dead for being too observant, And of

course, the same stupid final girl with big round eyes whose past has come to chase her back and that spends eighty percent of the movie bawling her eyes out until she finds her true magical courage and somehow solves everything and manages to get away alive. Yay”

Catra says the last word with a sarcastic cheer and a weak punch of victory towards the air, scowling at Mermista when the latter flips at her fully from across the table. Adora is looking between her friend and her girlfriend with her eyes narrowed in worry, sensing the storm clouds of a fight approaching the table quickly.

“Are you projecting, Capellan?” Mermista spats, calling Catra by her first last name. Catra snarls at her in return, curling her lip over her gums.

“Aren´t you tired of the same old shit? All the answers are there!”

“Hey, guys, what if we talk about the pizza choice this time?” Bow, bless his heart, tries to distract everyone with a nervous smile but is majestically ignored by everyone at the table, even Glimmer.

“Big talk for the girlfriend of the doe eyed jock. I would keep an eye on her in case a serial killer wants to snatch her from you.” Mermista says with a roll of her thick hair, smiling broadly. Catra closes her mouth so fast and hard that her teeth clash together painfully, the end of her piercings scratching her bottom lip with the pull, all the blood draining from her face suddenly. Nobody notices it but Glimmer does, watching in silence from her seat.

Adora is already in motion too, eyeing Bow sideways as they all share the same look. The conversation is edging very close into triggering and that is not going to end well for anyone. Adora rests her palms over Catra´s imperceptible shivering shoulders and presses her mouth against her ear, whispering something to her softly. Glimmer cannot hear her but whatever she says rips a giggle off Catra´s mouth, tension slipping out of her like water. It's like a kind of magic only Adora can do for her. By the time Mermista speaks again, Catra is already eating her chips again.

“Besides, in a horror story the love birds who can´t stop eye fucking each other die first” Mermista blows her own piece of blue bubblegum, smiling with a devilish glint in her eye.

“Eye fucking is not the only fucking we do,” Catra snaps back, much for Adora´s mortification who goes beet red in the face.

“Oh, rest in peace Catra and Adora.” Perfuma says, obviously uncomfortable but trying to make a joke. Catra snaps her eyes towards hers but instead of snarling she pokes her tongue out at her and grins, for Perfuma´s huge relief. Perks on being the girlfriend of Catra´s best friend.

“You can just say you are jealous, fish girl,” Catra shrugs, staring at Mermista´s sour face. She squeezes Adora´s wrist gently, running her fingers up and down the veins in the back of Adora´s forearm with her other hand, too purposely slow to be anything else but a clear claim over her girlfriend. Catra is very well aware that half of the school drools over her girlfriend, and she knows very well about Mermista´s little crush on Adora years ago.

“Fuck off, Capellan,” Mermista takes her phone violently, tapping an angry message on it, probably to Sea Hawk, to distract herself from the whole thing. Catra laughs but Mermista ignores her. She starts mocking the up right tone of the sex education professor, Octavia, instead, shaking her shoulder side by side like her as she imitates her. “Don´t have sex, young cadets. It´ll kill you.”

“Well, if that's the case, I´ll die guilty but without regrets,” Adora adds up with a tiny smile, kissing the back of Catra´s ear.

“Don't enable her, Adora.” Catra slaps her in the arm sharply, face red, but Adora doesn´t even flinch, throwing her head back to laugh.

“Um? We are eating? We don't need to know about your sex life”

“You started it, Mermista!”

“That is factually incorrect, actually,” Entrapta says out of nowhere, kicking their feet under the table. “Most killers in movies prefer their victims to be alone instead of in pairs to avoid being overpowered and to make for a better tension for the watcher. Unless it's a team or a group of killers, like cults and such. Sex related scenes previous to the kills are only added for morbid purposes. Real life serial killers could easily overpower a couple, if they have a proper plan and strategy, though the help of a partner always makes for an easier job” Entrapta explains, not even looking up from her experiment.

The entire table stares at them without saying a word, eyebrows raised and mouths slack. Entrapta doesn´t even seem to notice that they have said something slightly concerning, mumbling under their breath to record on their small tape the progress of their invention.

Glimmer clears her throat loudly, shrugging. “Catra is right, though, as much as it costs me to admit it. Adora might be a jock but she can´t even hold her alcohol for five minutes.”

“Again, I wasn't that drunk”

“Oh. You totally were.” Glimmer smiles devilish at her, resting her chin over her folded hands. “You passed out on the couch at eleven and nobody could wake you up, you were snoring so loud too. And I already told Catra you did karaoke in her name”

“Glimmer!”

“She sent them to me too,” adds Bow, grinning broadly. Adora gapes at him, betrayal written all over her face.

“Not you too, Bow!”

“It was cute!”

“Ugh”

Catra is laughing in her seat, resting her back against Adora´s front, her legs thrown carelessly over Adora´s lap. Adora keeps protesting at Glimmer´s insistence, her hand placed firmly over Catra´s knees, caressing tight circles through the fishnets.

"Maybe we should watch Spirit," Perfuma whispers under her breath, carefully placing a pot of flowers inside her crochet bag. Adora hears her even in the middle of her argument because she points at her triumphantly.

"Ha! Told you so!"

"Class Seventeen," The voice of Professor Octavia comes from right behind their table, startling the entire group violently. They turn to look at her disapproving face, staring down at them as if she were personally offended for their existence inside the cafeteria. "Your lunch was over fifteen minutes ago. The bus is already waiting for you. I will not stand for my generation of students arriving late and making a fool out of me in front of the Mayor"

"Yes, Professor Octavia," most of the table exclaims immediately, scrambling quickly for their bags and gathering the last of their food for the trip.

Everyone except for Glimmer and Catra, who don´t share the same Class as the rest of their friends. While everyone else is either going to financial, engineering or even medical studies, Catra and Glimmer are enrolled into arts and history and politics so both are most of the time sharing the same propaedeutics. Today, it means that they get to stay on campus while everyone else is driven to the Town Square for the Mayor ´s event.

While everyone rushes to stand up, Adora extracts herself gently from Catra´s legs and grabs her backpack, throwing it over her shoulders as she turns around to face her girlfriend again. Catra has flopped back into the table, her cheek against her folded arm, digging her nails in the faux wood with obvious annoyance. Her

mood has drastically flipped upside down from one second to the other.

“I´ll see you in two hours,” Adora whispers at her, pressing a sweet kiss over Catra´s cheekbone. Catra´s face turns a soft shade of pink but she shrugs, not looking at Adora when she answers.

“Yeah, whatever,” Catra´s nail draws a sharp nail over the table, small chips of plastic digging in her finger painfully. She doesn´t even flinch. “Don´t be late. Don´t drink”

Adora wraps her hand gently over Catra´s fingers and pulls them away from the table and towards her chest, rubbing them with her thumb to calm the soreness. Adora lowers down and rests her cheek against the table too, looking for Catra´s gaze who turns around finally when she feels Adora breathing closer to her. Adora holds Catra´s colorful eyes on hers, smiling reassuringly. “I´ll bring you a stuffed unicorn from the carnival”

“Don´t you dare,” Catra wrinkles her nose, poking Adora in the middle of the forehead. She smiles finally after a beat, apprehension lifting from her shoulders, slightly. “Bring me a cotton candy”

“Purple?”

“Purple”

“Alright,” Adora lingers a second kiss over Catra´s mouth, smiling at the familiar taste of the tangerine gummies they shared between classes in her lips. Catra´s hair still smells like Adora´s lavender shampoo.

Adora stands up from the table with a sprint in her step, hopping excitedly towards Bow´s side, already waiting for her as everyone else is rushed towards the door by Professor Octavia. Adora throws her arm over her best friend´s shoulder, grinning from ear to ear.

“Come on Bow. The Halloween fair´s candy is always the best kind. We can even have cake!.”

Bow laughs with her, wrapping his own arm across Adora´s back. “You just ate, Dora”

“And?”

“You are in a very good mood today, you know?” Bow says, eyeing her suspiciously. Adora smiles back, her pupils huge as plates and soft, sighing dreamingly.

“I had a *very* good morning. Amazing actually” The chip Catra throws at Adora from her seat bounces in her head with perfect aim and falls down in her varsity jacket, ripping a dumb giggle from Adora´s mouth.

Her laughter catches Professor Octavia´s attention, eyeing Catra and Glimmer as she realizes both of them are still lingering on the table. Octavia´s blue eyebrows knit into a deep frown, approaching them with a heavy click of her shoes.

“You too Miss Capellan, Miss Bright, up and going.”

Bow stops midtrack, eyeing Octavia and then back at his friends. Adora´s face shifts, still cheerful but her eyebrows scrunch in confusion. Glimmer and Catra both stare at Octavia as if she had grown a second head, Glimmer stuttering, quiet for a second as if she hoped the professor would correct herself any second now. Catra´s entire face falls, cursing violently very low under her breath, digging her sharp nails against her forearms.

“Uh, no. Our class is staying, Professor. We have an art history test,” Glimmer tries to correct when Octavia says nothing else. “Right, Catra?” Glimmer turns her head towards Catra but the latter is already looking away, chewing on the inside of her cheek.

“Not anymore.” Octavia interrupts before Catra can say anything. “Class Eighteen has also been listed to assist the Mayor ´s

speech. We need to show the school´s support and you are propaedeutics students, it's part of your duties"

“Is it now?” Catra spats, glaring at Octavia´s good eye.

“It is,” Octavia gives a step closer towards Catra´s direction, glaring at her from head to toe. “Is there a problem Miss Capellan?”

Catra frowns and opens her mouth, venom already pooling in the back of her throat. Adora leans forward a little, whispering softly at her girlfriend´s direction. “Cat. Please.”

It's a small plea, to not answer back. Catra has already had enough attitude problems since last year, mostly caused because school personnel know no boundaries and Catra is not the same as she was before New Year.. Catra looks at Adora from the corner of her eye, following the same train of thought, reading each other even from feet away.

Catra sighs and drops her shoulders, staring right into Octavia´s eyes when she answers. “No”

It's obvious it's not what Octavia wanted to hear but she has no excuse to get Catra into trouble either. She points at the door of the cafeteria and stops into the ground loudly, pointing her words very slowly. “Bus. Now”

Octavia turns around and marches right outside with her nose towards the air, fuming. Bow and Glimmer share a look and shrug, linking hands and following her steps too. Adora lingers behind though, bending down to also pick up Catra´s bag, carrying it too on her back.

Catra kicks at the floor, deeply annoyed, her eyes dark as new moons. “Ugh, I don't want to go to a mandatory stupidity. That's your class thing not mine.”

“Come on, pretty,” Adora reassures her, lacing their fingers together and pulling her back on her feet. “Don´t you want to see

the new terrible statue in the park that took so much income that we can't have free lunch at school?”

Catra frowns, something swirling in her eyes. “No”

Adora huffs with a shake of her head, wrapping her arm around Catra´s waist, drawing circles on the skin over the hem of her black skirt.

“Let's go, grinch. At least we can have that cotton candy together,” Adora presses an obnoxiously loud kiss against Catra´s temple, calling most of the cafeteria´s attention when Catra shrieks. “If you are nice I´ll even buy you that handmade ice cream you like”

“That´s manipulation”

“Yep!” Adora smiles, stepping into the grass of the campus. “You love me like that”

“Yes, I do.” Catra squints her eyes at the sudden sunlight, a shiver running down her spine at the sight of the buses waiting for them. “Just stay with me, please.”

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There is a good thing from the Mayor ´s constant need to prove himself and insistence on doing event after event and that is the carnival that always arrives in Etheria to celebrate. It's not something he planned but the merchants are smart and the people are always hungry for some kind of distraction, so it worked for everyone involved.

It´s a huge thing, rows and rows of stalls filled to the brim with food, candies and other trinkets to buy, and most of the time it is the only reason why people even bother to get out of their houses or jobs and listen to the Mayor ´s speeches, As long as everybody can ride one or ten fair attractions and eat so much sugar that it makes their molars ache, then it´s worth it.

By the time the school buses make it to the square the sun is already halfway down the sky and the place is filled with people, neighbors and friends all that know each other from years and years ago. A small town is always a small town after all but you would be surprised to realize just how many people can live in the same space without barely talking to each other.

It is not strange for BrightMoon´s School to send one class to official events of the town, especially if they are preceded by Mayor  Hordak himself. It fills the seats of whatever soulless and unnecessary project the Mayor  has managed to get approved by the council and it helps him have some sense of power and control over the public interest. The amount of money he pays to the school precisely for those endeavors plays an important role in it too, of course.

At least the lucky professors that accompany them allow the students to roam around freely until the speeches begin. Most of those students are young adults anyway, so there is not much they can do to keep them contained once they have all set foot inside the carnival.

Adora is skipping happily over the stones on the group, already in her third purple candy, lips tinted slightly in the corners by the colored sugar. Her other hand is held tightly inside Catra´s, who is flushed impossible close against Adora´s side, her colorful eyes hooded and staring at the increasingly bigger and bigger crowd with a heavy expression. She has also eaten cotton candy but her mind has long ago drifted away the more the people around them gathered tighter and tighter, all of them trying to catch the next fair game or getting in line for some greasy junk food.

Catra is very aware that some people are turning around when they walk by, staring at them, *at her,* and then leaning against each other to gossip about it. It's rude and it´s uncomfortable but Catra does her best to ignore it. Tries to lie to herself that maybe just maybe they are looking at Adora´s pretty eyes and pretty hair. Talking about her valedictorian title and the win of the volleyball team last week. Maybe people are not talking about

how different Adora is from Catra, and how strange it is that Adora Montenegro  has decided this is the girl she is going to love.

The red of Adora´s varsity jacket is a striking contrast against Catra´s leather jacket, as if someone has pulled them from some lesbian version of Grease. It is October but the breeze is strangely warm, slipping through the rips of Catra´s fishnets and below the pleated miniskirt she had stolen from Adora´s wardrobe this morning, much to Adora´s amusement. Where Adora´s shirt is clean white, Catra´s is deep wine; Adora is wearing sneakers and ankle bracelets, Catra´s feet are cradled on her favorite combat boots, the ones that make her at least closer to Adora´s height so she doesn´t have to be on her tippy toes to kiss her. Adora is wearing the thin golden necklace Catra gave her on her eighteenth birthday, Catra has piercings in her mouth and fine silver chains around her always present choker.

Catra is aware of how different they are from each other, ever since they were children. People were never shy to express their opinion outloud. No matter how much they tried to do it behind the Montenegro ´s and Catra´s dad´s back, Catra heard them always and Adora heard them too. It got bad with time, it got terrible after Catra´s dad passed away, it got worse the first time Adora kissed her in the middle of the campus yard, there in front of everyone to see. With time she learned how to live with their stares. For a while, Catra thought she would survive.

The touch of Adora´s warm lips against her cheek brings Catra back to the present with a shudder, her breath tangling in her scarred vocal cords. She turns her head towards Adora, who is already staring back at her with a tender expression in her face. Catra hadn´t even noticed they had stopped walking, standing still below the shade of one of the small trees scattered through the square, between the merry go round and the churro stall.

“Hey, welcome back baby” Adora greets her as if they hadn't seen each other for a while and not like they have been walking through the fair for the good part of the last hour. Catra wrinkles

her nose, annoyed with herself after losing track of the now. Adora´s pretty eyes narrow in the corners, concern swirling clear inside her blue irises. “Cat? What is it?”

“Nothing,” Catra snaps, way too quickly to hide her true feelings.

Adora notices it immediately because why wouldn´t she? She knows Catra better than she knows herself. Adora wraps her arm around Catra´s waist and guides her gently towards an empty corner of the square, tucking behind the dark metal of a street lamp. There are still several people walking by but at least it gives them the fake sense of privacy in the open air.

Adora roams her eyes through every single corner and fraction of Catra´s face, drinking her in before staring at the multitude around. Catra observes her in silence, already knowing what is going on inside that big head of hers. Besides so many things, this is the first time since last year that Catra goes into a place so crowded. It's driving Catra crazy and it makes Adora madly worried.

“I´m sorry, Cat, I didn't know Octavia was going to force you to come. Do you want to leave?”

“No,” Catra bites into her own tongue so  hard that she starts feeling the first drops of blood filling her gums, pushing back the wave of rage suddenly overtaking her ribcage, *It´s not Adora´s fault, it´s not Adora´s fault …*

“Catra” Adora´s voice rips between the darkness, concern dripping from every word. Adora cradles Catra´s jaw between her palms, caressing gentle circles over her skin. “You are trembling”

“There are so many people,” Catra says between clenched teeth, hugging herself.

Catra opens her mouth to say something else but is interrupted by a bunch of highschoolers that had probably snuck on the buses too, running right past them. The teens are so distracted trying to take photographs of a weird looking scarecrow with an obvious

hay head and a too heavy and mushy body impaled to the metal spears of the square´s gate that they don´t even notice them dare, crashing painfully against Catra´s side and then scrambling away without even looking back.

Catra gasps, surprised by the sudden proximity and with her shoulder pulsing with the crash. She loses her balance, tilting dangerously towards the ground. Adora catches her in a heartbeat, wrapping her hands around Catra´s upper arms, steading her back into her feet at the same time she snaps her head towards the teen´s direction, blue eyes cracking with sudden anger. Adora´s lip retracts over her gums and she frowns, yelling at them without letting go from Catra´s shoulders.

"Hey!" Adora barks, her voice cracking in the edges with the force of it. Several people turn to look at her, surprised. "Watch where you are fucking going!"

"Adora. It's okay," Catra holds Adora´s wrists between her fingers, rubbing calming circles on the inside of her palms. She is also looking back, staring as the teenagers snicker at them, flip them off and then scramble right away again, not bothering to apologize.

"Fucking brats." Catra mutters under her breath, returning her eyes towards Adora´s beautiful but deeply annoyed face. Adora´s pupils are blown out and her cheeks dusted in red with anger, small baby hairs escaping her ponytail. Catra sucks on her bottom lip, pulling from a strand of Adora´s hair gently to call for her attention. "I´m sorry, I don't want to ruin it for you"

"You aren't," Adora reassures her in a breath, clearing her throat. "If you want we can go to the library. It's quiet there"

"Octavia would rip our heads off"

"I don´t give a fuck what Octavia thinks," Adora leans down and presses her lips against the corner of Catra´s eye, tangling her

hands on Catra´s curls. Catra smiles sweetly, still unbelievably tense but softer when Adora is next to her like this.

“It's alright, Dora. I can handle it.” Catra sighs at Adora´s unsure face, slight apprehension knotting in her throat. She pokes the middle of Adora´s big forehead, managing a weak smile. “I have to. I can't live like this forever”

Adora stares at her in silence, breathing deeply through her nose. She looks like she has thousands of things more that she wants to say but she keeps them guarded for Catra´s sake, trusting her blindly. Instead of insisting on the item, Adora slips her hands under Catra´s tight shirt, caressing the edges of her ribs with her thumbs, a familiar motion that always helps Catra´s heart to calm down. Skin against skin.

“Can I kiss you?” Adora asks in an almost shy whisper, a smile already tucked in the edge of her mouth.

Catra smiles back at her, nodding. She never knew how tender love could be until she allowed herself to be loved, loved by Adora who adores her with her entire heart. That's the only thing on this world Catra is sure of. “Yes.”

The first time they kissed, Adora confessed to Catra that she had kissed before, cheerleaders that caught her off guard on the seats of the gymnasium. But she never felt anything on her chest, not excitement, no tenderness, only surprise and disappointment, annoyance even, too in love with Catra to even pay attention to the floods of girls that could have made a perfect lovely partner for her.

It hadn't been the first time Catra had kissed someone either. She had been kissed by someone else, all sharp teeth and sore throats. Inside the car of Catra´s mother, pressed on the back of dark alleys. Yellow dyed hair against her cheeks and sharp nails around her neck, trying to replace inside Catra´s heart who she really loved. And it hurted every single time, the wrong kind of kisses with the wrong person until it doesn't even feel like a kiss

anymore but a fake sense of escape. Or a self inflicted punishment.

But then, when it was over, when Adora finally laced their lips together below the lilac lights of the ice cream place after fleeing prom night together, it felt like the first time in all the ways that truly mattered. Something sweet from someone sweeter. And though Adora didn´t exactly know what she was doing, she knew everything about Catra and, somehow, she knew how to kiss her perfectly too. How to slot their lips together, how to press her tongue against the roof of her mouth, how to cherish her with her mouth. Adora knew, knew *her* , loved her, and it was everything Catra ever needed, her last first kiss with the woman she had loved her entire life.

Adora kisses her like that today, below the streetlamp and surrounded by curious people until it's only them in this shared space. Hands around Catra´s face, cupping her jaw and supporting her nape. Her own hands tangled in the flaps of the same jacket she was wearing this morning and the memory alone makes her shudder and gasp around Adora´s pink tongue, tasting the cotton candy from her throat.

Her mind is foggy and her body drowsy when Adora pulls back, sighing against the trail of kisses that Adora paints on the column of her neck, always respectful of the only place Catra will never tolerate to be touched again.

Catra lets her head roll back on Adora´s hands, boneless, staring at some empty point without really seeing anything at all. Adora blows a soft exhale against her ear and straightens up again, resting a smooch over Catra´s temple to warn her.

“Octavia is coming this way”

Catra has barely time to roll her eyes and smooth the hair she had messed up in Adora´s ponytail before Professor Octavia falls over them like a falcon, her face so worked up that she looks almost blue with the effort.

“Montenegro ! Capellan! You should have been with the rest of your group half an hour ago! Move!”

“Yes, Miss Octavia,” Catra chants, perfectly on edge to be mocking but not enough to reach the sanction zone.

Octavia huffs loudly and grasps them both from the sleeves of their jackets, grumbling the whole way and dragging them across the entire square and towards the huge fountain in the middle of the park where the Mayor ´s statue is covered by a thick black sheet. The school group is already there too, standing on the first to third row, not even seats displayed for them to seat comfortably while the whole show ends.

Octavia pushes them into the very first row, squished between their classes, barely a few feet from the pedestal with the microphone where the Mayor is to give his speech and the covered statue. Someone must have forgotten to clean the fountain's water because instead of clear liquid it is slightly brown and it smells if you lean close, flies buzzing in and around the park.

Adora catches sight of their friends right in the middle and wiggles their way next to them, still under the hawk stare of Octavia making sure they are not going to scramble away. Bow sees them coming and smiles, scratching his forearm without letting go from Glimmer´s hands, placing a kiss on the back of her knuckles gently when she giggles, enamored.

“Front row?” Bow asks, tilting his head to the side. Adora rolls her eyes, wrapping her arms around Catra´s middle and resting her chin over the top of her head, swinging them both from side to side gently.

“The professor´s idea”

“Oh, I see,” Bow rolls his eyes too, petting Adora on the shoulder with a smile. He looks towards Catra inside Adora´s arms and smiles reassuringly, giving her an encouraging thumbs up before

returning to speak excitedly to Glimmer about tonight´s sleepover.

“Wildcat! Adora!”

Catra turns towards the call, grinning when she sees Scorpia changing places awkwardly with the rest of the class so she can stand right next to them too. Perfuma is walking beside her, her cheek rosy and hair decorated in pretty flowers. For a second Catra wonders why she is blushing so hard until she notices the pink lipstick marks left over Scorpia´s nose and cheeks, bright against the paleness of her skin.

“Hey, you,” Catra greets Scorpia softly, grinning, letting her weight rest inside Adora´s arms easily. “Your girlfriend also caught you?”

“Uh?” Scorpia tilts her head to the side, confusion falling over her dark eyes. Perfuma blush deepens, clearing her throat but with her shoulders thrown back proudly. It makes Catra smile wider.

“Nothing.” Catra shakes her head, observing them both.

For a long time she couldn´t understand Scorpia, or the reasons why she tried so hard to be her friend. Then her friendship got into thin ice until it was completely strained, broken in pieces when Scorpia confessed to her and Catra pushed her away in ways she still regrets, too poisoned by certain people in her life, too filled with pain when her body craved Adora and all she had was the acid of someone else's mouth on hers.

It broke Scorpia´s heart, it broke Catra´s heart, it broke their relationship and for many months Catra thought she would never see her again, not like before. Last year at the hospital was the first time Catra saw Scorpia in a long time, surrounded by tubes and bandages, a sight so frightful she thought nobody but Adora would want to be near her again. But Scorpia was there and then Scorpia had Perfuma and Catra had Adora and things changed again, and got better.

Catra loves Scorpia in all the ways a friend loves another and Scorpia loves her back, and Catra will always be grateful for that. She loves things simple as that, milkshakes with Scorpia, sleepovers in Glimmer´s house, study nights with Bow, Adora´s laughter next to her ears. No estranged stare or disapproving murmurs when she walks by. Catra would give and do anything for that.

"Why is Octavia being an even bigger of a bitch?" Catra asks, not even bothering to lower her voice. Bow is chewing on a popsicle, voice sticky when he explains.

"The Mayor  hasn´t arrived yet," he points at the platform with his chin, giving the rest of his candy to Glimmer.

Acid starts boiling inside Catra´s stomach, burning her esophagus and past her larynx, filling her mouth with rotten taste. "So?"

"I don't know." Glimmer, cleans her hands over the fabric of her pants, frowning, "Someone went to his house but it is locked or something and he hasn't answered the phone in hours. He also didn´t show up at the office this morning." Glimmer looks up only to find the rest of her friends staring at her with raised eyebrows. Glimmer blushes, clicking her tongue against her teeth. "I heard an assistant say it at the popcorn stall. Also my mom mentioned it during our lunch face call. She says the whole office has managed without him, as always, but it's just weird he hasn't shown up to be a peacock about the inauguration of his own statue."

"Besides, it means they are all like half an hour late," Perfuma chimes in, nuzzling her cheek against Scorpia´s bicep. "You know how Hordak forbade everyone from riding the games before his speech after what happened on the last fair? When nobody showed up and he was talking to nothing? Well, now he is late and people are getting restless."

It's perfectly timed because in that exact second a nervous looking assistant with a funny swirl of gray hair on his head walks into the platform, fidgeting with his hands over and over again.

He looks at the multited crowded around the fountain and him and grimaces, searching urgently for his boss without success.

The crowd is murmuring now, some tapping on the floor, annoyed; others slowly making their way back towards the fair that is going on with full strength behind them; some others chatting about their plans for Halloween. Sweat starts gathering on the man and he starts clearing his throat loudly for several seconds, gathering bravery and trying to extend the time a little longer just in case Mayor  Hordak is going to magically appear on the stage with him.

“The Mayor's Office apologizes for the long wait. We, um, Mayor Hordak seems to have gotten into a little predicament and is— stuck in traffic. He will be here soon enough to make his speech for you, lovely people of Etheria.”

“Which traffic?” someone asks behind the rows of students. The assistant puts out a couple of wrinkled pages from the laps of his coat, reading them with rushed breaths.

“Mayor Hordak´s statue in commemoration of his birthday represents the achievements managed during this administration. The everlasting peace under his leadership and the rise of the Etherian people into greatest goals. Soon enough, once Thaymor ´s bridge is effectively repaired and the new transportation technology is introduced, we will no longer be known as a simple town but as the city of Eternia, a plan long in the making by the Mayor  himself.”

Disgruntled murmurs are clear among the people. Not many people are happy with this new plan of the mayor, nor for their peaceful town to be transformed into a city. Catra hears them echoing the sentiment behind her but she is stuck inside Adora´s arms, shivers running down her spine. Catra´s eyes are focused on the space between the covered statue and the nervous man, following the go and around of thick and dark flies hovering around them.

“And, um, well look at the time,  I guess we´ll uncover the statue while our dear Mayor makes it here,” the assistant stutters finally, holding the microphone between his hands and approaching the statue´s sheet behind him.

Out of the corner of her eye Catra catches sight of Angella arriving at the crowd, standing so tall and pink in the side of the park as she supervises for the event. She must feel eyes on her because she tilts her elegant head to the side, catching sight of Catra looking at her. She looks tired, Catra hadn´t seen her since lunch yesterday at the Bright Manor. Angella returns her gaze with lilac eyes, acknowledging Catra and the rest of the students' presence with blank eyes before turning her eyes back to the podium.

It's so crowded in the park, so many people are pressed against each other. There are so many sounds rising in the air, the carnival games, the fair, the stalls, people singing, cheering, laughing, screaming when someone dressed in early Halloween costumes jumps out of nothing and scares the sit out of them.

The bells of the chapel beyond the clock tower chimes strongly with the fifth hour, scaring the bird out of their trees. Out of the corner of her eye, Catra thinks she can make sense of a priest's robe, swirling white and green before losing itself among the crowd. And when Catra blinks, she can see the hem of a dress, there among the crowd, garnet dress and black hair and green eyes staring back at her with a closed mouth.

Teens, families and kids make a line to take pictures with the lonely and twisted scarecrow in the gate. The crowd of flies is thicker now, a black cloud hovering in the middle of the lilac sky.

Perfuma is kissing Scorpia´s cheek, braiding her hair tenderly, and Scorpia is blushing in return, staring at the statue eagerly. Bow is smiling broadly, pupils wide, and Glimmer is chewing on a piece of candy, tipping on her phone and ignoring the entire thing.

Adora is quiet but sweet, pressing kisses behind Catra's ear. She is distracted thinking about the next volleyball match and Catra´s birthday next week. She is also humming, like a second nature, a gentle lullaby under her breath that only Catra can hear, meant to calm her, to soothe her from the noise, to promise her ice cream after having to endure the crowd and the heat.

Catra had a bad night. She digs her fingers around Adora´s forearms until her skin turns red and holds her closer, returning her eyes towards the statue too.

"Very well, let's count everyone!" The assistant cheers, egging everyone else to do the same. The crowd follows half-heartedly, clapping alongside the rhythm of the chant and the music beyond the trees and bushes. The assistant tangles his fingers around the black sheet and starts to pull from it very slowly.

"Alright! For Mayor Hordak! Three!" The bells of the church go again, drowning the sound of the music. "Two!" A firecracker goes somewhere near the park, echoing painfully in Catra´s ears. "One!"

Catra´s ears are ringing. Sounds are drowned for her, her eyelids hooded, her eyes fogged. For a second she is back on that house now nailed shut at the end of her street. For a second Catra cannot move, cannot think, cannot feel Adora´s soft arms around her. For a second the world burns in firecracker´s sparkles and chapel bells. For a second, below her eyelids, there is only the image of blood. Catra really did have a terrible night.

Someone is screaming. Several people, actually. Some are even running away.

Catra is quiet, staring at the image in front of her without even breathing. She can hear Adora´s gasp above her head, can feel the way Adora´s body shivers from head to toe but Catra can´t move. And she cannot look away.

Adora wraps her arms around Catra's rib cage and yanks her away, turning her in her ankles, ripping her colorful eyes from the butchery and the blood. Adora presses Catra´s freckled face against her chest, between the varsity jacket and the white shirt, hiding her from the gruesome view in front of them. She rests her mouth over Catra´s forehead and shushes her gently, wrapping all of her body around Catra´s cold limbs. Adora can feel Catra´s tears soaking the fabric, she can feel Catra´s hands digging painfully on her back with how hard she holds her back, she can feel her own chest straining with a shuddering breath.

On the statue, pinned to his own copper features in a careful way, crafted, well thought through and done, Mayor Hordak´s head hangs without a body. His blue hair is dark, tinted in a red so deep that it looks black, dripping down his forehead and nose and staining the very metal in dry drops of crimson. His eyes and tongue are not on his body anymore, placed carefully on the hands of the statue whose metal arms are extended side to side, like a sacrifice paid to a pagan deity or the image of a corrupt saint punished by his sins. Flies are feasting on his rotting flesh.

Among the screaming crowd, someone smirks. A killer moves a piece in the checkers game and the ground is soaked in red.

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*End of Chapter I*

Chapter End Notes

Oh no! Who could have for seen that?

Chapter 2 this Monday, June 24th. See you there!

# Thorns for Briar Rose

Chapter Summary

"I'll leave you a pretty gift, pretty hare"

Chapter Notes

Hello again! Thank you so much for being here again and thank you so much to everyone that commented and left kudos, you guys really keep me going because writing a story like this is always nerve wracking

Today I bring you chapter two, where things are going to start moving on very very fast. Please be aware of the next Trigger Warnings:
- Detailed descriptions of death
- Detailed descriptions of wounds
- A Major Character from the group will die

Also, I threw a very clear FallOut Easter egg somewhere around there. I swear it is important to the story so keep your mind on that

I've started to see some very interesting theories and I love it :) Hope you enjoy this chapter!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

## [Thorns for Briar Rose]

*'Cause if we join our hands in prayer enough to God,*

*I imagine it all starts to sound like applause*

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**October 24th**

The floor of Mayor Hordak´s apartment is sticky with barely dried blood, sticking to the thick sole of Huntara´s combat boots as she makes her way through the main scene of the crime. She is aware that she should be more careful where to stand, but truthfully, there is not a place on this floor where blood has not been smeared like a spilled container of paint, long brushes on every corner where to see, from the expensive rug to the resin floor, even dry on the ceiling past the crystal chandelier. The testimony of a brutal crime that nobody even cared to clean or to even try to hide, exposed to everyone to see freely.

The forensics team from the Etherian Office are also walking in and around, placing small triangles of unsure evidence on the furniture and the floor, with their pristine white suits and masks, barely avoiding to gag at the stench, the smell of rotten blood forever stitched to every single crevice of this house.

Most of them are pretty younger, barely toddlers on the field in Huntara´s eyes, and this is the first time that any of them have seen real brutality, cruelty without holding back, blood and guts and flesh on their evidence bags and gloves. Huntara can see their face twisting below the plastic and the facemasks, their eyes watering with the acrid air that has swirled like a bomb inside the house, too new to this still.

Huntara  however is a well seasoned detective. She has been in this kind of world for a long time, she has seen many things. Things that many Mayors before Hordak hid, below dozens and dozens of paperworks until they were buried and forgotten completely by the entire town. Things that happened much before she became a detective for the Crimson Waste Department, when she was still in high school and there was terror and fear running rampant across every street and corner of this small town. Murders that were hidden and never cleared, blood too in the floor and fear. Huntara has seen all of this before, she knew damn well that horror like that would always come back. In one way or another.

*"... I just want to start, a flame in your heart …"*

There is music playing inside the living room of the apartment, coming from an old radio that is basically falling apart in pieces, with the old wood and even older speakers to match it. It is playing soft melodies, a single one actually, repeating over and over again with that characteristically cracking in the seams that makes it sound like an old radio station stuck in a single moment of time.

*" … In my heart, I have but one desire …"*

Repeating, cracking in the end, repeating again until it is barely a sound in the back of everyone's mind, some kind of twisted soundtrack for this one moment in time. Absently, Huntara wonders why nobody has bothered to turn it off. Absently too, she realizes she doesn´t give a fuck so nobody must care either.

" … *And that one is you, no other will do …* "

As expected, there are no more remains of the body here, besides the blood. It comes as no surprise, considering the head, eyes and tongue were collected first and the rest of the body was carefully lowered down and off the scarecrow costume it had been hidden into, at plain sight in the carnival´s gate, stuffed with hay instead of guts and sewn closed again with careful stitches and fish net.

It´s artistic, for certain points of view. Sadistic clearly. Sick for others. Purposefully, for Huntara´s eye, carefully planned and carefully executed, almost too magical. Done in a way nobody noticed until it was time to make the big reveal in front of most of the town. To raise chaos maybe, but to show off something, that is definitely. Huntara is still not sure what is supposed to be shown off here, but she´ll get there sooner or later. It is not as if Mayor Hordak lacked people wanting him dead.

Detective Lashor is hovering near the back door of the apartment, the one that leads towards the backyard and that, as per a few hours ago, was tightly shut. Now it lay halfway open, swinging

from side to side with the warm breeze that only helps to make the smell even worse.

The crystal door is also stained, marks of bloodshed overpowered by the unsettling smiling face painted with the same crimson substance and a firm finger, not even trembling or doubting of it´s masterpiece. Funny. Whoever did this did it with mirth, with fun, enjoying every second.

It will be interesting to test it, to see if there is a fingertip that might make their job easy to finish, to pack and forget about all in the same weekend. It would be sonic actually, because Huntara wants to have the Halloween off to visit some pub with hot women and not chase ghosts.

Huntara sighs heavily, approaching Lashor with heavy steps. He is a fucking prick, this she knows. She has known it since they were in the same high school class and he formed a stupid kind of band, scaring smaller students and dominating the rest. Is not as if Huntara hadn´t done the same but at least she had some decency that Lashor lacked. And Huntara is very well aware that not only Lashor was an asshole and grew up to be an even bigger of an asshole, but that he also fucking sucks at this job.

"Is staring at the blood doing something for you or should I be concerned, Lashor?" Huntara questions loudly, chewing on the toothpick in her mouth. Lashor turns towards her sharply, staring at her full of anger.

"Our Mayor is dead, Huntara"

"Oh, I see. So you are sad that you are not going to get your monthly money juice to cover all of Hordak´s stupidities anymore. How will you be able to pay that Rolls Royce now, uh?" The apartment goes cold with silence, people working almost too slowly as they both try to make themselves invisible and stay to hear the rest of the conversation.

Lashor does notice, however, because he turns around with his lips retracted over his gums, spatting at everyone inside the room. “All of you, fuck off”

“But sir– “ a poor idiot intern tries only for Lashor to turn around violently towards him, screaming at his face full of rage.

“Out!”

The entire team scrambles away like a bunch of cockroaches chasing their own butts, smearing more blood on places where it wasn´t even before. Huntara flinches a little at the defile of the murder scene but let´s it pass with a shrug of shoulders, too busy smirking at Lashor´s face.

“Wow, alright then”

“Fuck off. You know what you've accepted to cover too.”

“Yes. But at least I do it is much quieter and better than you.”

“Fuck you, Huntara.” Lashor flips her off, lighting a cigarette and giving it a huge blow of air, smoke raising inside the red living room immediately. “It was done here.”

“I can see that, Lashor.” Huntara narrows her eyes at the smiling face, tilting her head to the side. “Looks like whoever did it left us a greeting too”

“That stupid assistant said he came to check Hordak´s house when he didn´t show up to the square and he didn´t notice all of this?”

“Doors and windows were closed and the curtains shut thanks to Hordak´s expensive obsession for the latest security technology,” Huntara points with her chin towards the heavy metal binds halfway covering the windows and remaining doors, hiding any kind of view from the exterior world. It is not unknown, about the Mayor´s obsession for protection, for armored cars and strongly secured houses. It has always been a talk around the town, like

many other things, wondering about the real reasons why he was so scared to be murdered one day. “Look how well it worked for him.”

Lashor does not answer, taking puff after puff from his cigar until it is almost over, ash falling dark over the drying blood on the floor. “Where is the girl?”

Huntara looks at him with narrowed eyes, already knowing who he is talking about. There is nothing else Lashor had said the entire evening and morning at the office, no other person he had pointed his finger towards. In a way he almost seemed obsessed with the whole thing, demanding for the girl to be brought to him as soon as possible.

“Angella is bringing her to the interrogation room,” Huntara chews on the words, frowning deeply. “Lashor, seriously. You really cannot think that a tiny girl like her might have done *this?* And the stuff at the carnival?”

“She is smart.” Lashor narrows his eyes at Huntara, so fine and large that he almost looks like a lizard, running his sharp tongue over his lips. “You know who she is. What she is.”

“Lashor, Hordak got decapitated. Alright? Someone sew a knife through his neck so many times that it separated his head off his body and then impaled it and the rest of his body on the park in the middle of the night after a fucking storm.” Huntara says every word slowly, trying to get the full weight of it inside his big bald head. “And that girl weighs like ten pounds soaking wet. Please be serious.”

Lashor tosses the stub of his cigar into the floor, tampering it off with the point of his shoe stained in blood. There is a certain kind of anger weighing in his eyes, an humiliation done to him festering inside for an entire year that now is trying to find a way to finally be paid back. It's pathetic, actually, that a full grown man is quivering on his boots and trying to seek retribution under the thought of a twenty year old girl.

“Once a killer always a killer, Huntara.” He spats the words, gathering his jacket closer to his body.

Huntara opens her mouth to protest but her stomach falls onto her feet, a nasty filling coiling on the bottom of her belly. She cannot protest that, she cannot say anything else because after all Lashor is saying the truth. What a fucked up situation indeed.

Lashor stares at Huntara´s conflicted face and smirks like the cat that has gotten the mouse, knowing he has won the argument for now. He throws his bald head back, chewing on his own sharp teeth as she speaks, “Get me Catrina Capellan or get out of my way. This time I am going to make her pay.”

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†

**A || Where are you?**

*Sent. Not seen*

**A || Cat please just tell me you are okay. I´m really worried**

*Sent. Not seen*

**A || I love you**

*Sent. Not seen*

Adora sighs, bringing her phone towards her chest with a deep exhale.

Adora Montenegro  loves her life. If you ask her on a good day, she might tell you she is the happiest person in the entire world. Shit has happened, bad shit, terrible shit, yet she is happy.

She is different too, different to what she was when she was fourteen. There are scars like thunderbolts and star shaped marks forever stitched to her back and waist from when she was in the

wrong place in the wrong moment as a teen, testimonies of pain and sorrow that she endured and survived. She wears her hair loose, gone the tight ponytails that hurt her scalp and make her eyes tingle, replaced by loops of gold. She is different to the person she was last year. She is taller, she is older, she is stronger. She is sure of herself.

She still goes to places with a skip in her feet and a cheerful hum on the base of her throat. She still plays volleyball with so much passion that her teammates call her She-Ra, like the 80s cartoon she was obsessed with when she was a child. She still eats ice cream after college courses and still listens to music way too loud inside Catra´s car, singing out of tune with her entire chest. She still twirls in front of the mirror when she wears her mother's dress and Catra helps her fix her hair, she still gathers Catra in her arms and dances with her barefoot on the kitchen floor. She can still kiss her, hold her, embrace her, feel her grin against her neck.

Things would have gone to absolutely hell but Adora is alive, she has made it. She has friends, she has college acceptances, she has a future. She has Catra, Catra who Adora trusts with her entire heart, who Adora loves with every single inch and cell and crevice of her soul. Catra who is her best friend, her person, half of her soul, the only one left in this world that Adora truly trusts, the only one she would place her life to and trust her to make with it what her heart wants. Catra is Adora´s heart and after so much confusion, after so much fear and pain of not knowing what she felt, Adora is here now, she can kiss her now, she can be with her in all the ways a woman that loves another can be. Adora is *hers* and hers only.

She is in love and she is happy because she is in love. Love saved her.

Today sucks, though, today is not a very good day. Today Adora is not happy and Catra is not here.

In a way it was expected. Catra cannot be in the cemetery and she refuses to set foot in the chapel. She told Adora that she

wouldn't be able to do it. It would be too much, too many stares directed at her back, too much barely hidden judgment hanging over Catra´s shadow and in consequence over Adora´s back. Catra can´t even visit her father's grave without people talking about her behind her back.

Adora knew Catra would not come, but still she hoped. For a single moment of selfishness, she hoped Catra would be here so Adora would not have to do this on her own.

Adora hates the chapel. She hates all about it, she hates the tall ceiling clustered in vibrant images; she hates the thick smell of incense lingering in the air; she hates the rows and rows of benches in the ground and the people sitting on them. She hates the music, harps and choir and echo. She hates the coldness of the floor digging below her knees and the chill air. She hates the gold in every corner and the stench of lilies on the altars. She hates the memory of it all, Adora hates it.

But she is here because she is *expected* to be here. She is here because she is Adora Montenegro , valedictorian, sweetheart of the community, a living miracle after a tragic accident that almost drove her crazy but that she survived. She is here because Light Hope basically dragged her out of the house by the hair, talking about duty with the community and her presence at the First One ´s Chapel. Because Adora is supposed to be *grateful* after everything and for everything and that involves being in the front row of Mayor Hordak´s funeral, praying for him.

And Adora? Adora cannot say not because she is good and because she is kind of an idiot too, with the sense of responsibility and duty hanging heavy in her neck. She will do it because she doesn't want to fail anyone, she couldn't bear it, and Light Hope knows that.

Adora also promised she would talk with her parents soon so, in a way, it was a tale long pushed back.

Adora taps on the floor outside the chapel with her shoe and stares at the screen of her phone nervously, waiting for the chime of Catra´s ringtone to appear any second now without success. She hasn't seen her since last night at Glimmer´s house, picked up by LIght Hope before curfew was even close to begin.

After all the chaos in the square, the students had been pushed in and around from side to side of the park, unorganized and lost even. Some had separated, some others ran back to the buses or to one of the local stores where everyone else was running too, seeking to get as far away from the butchery scene as possible.

Adora had felt like she was going to throw up, grasping Catra´s cold hand inside hers and dragging her to wherever the flow of people had taken them. Adora would have lied if she said she wasn´t trembling, from head to toe violently, shaking her entire body like a tornado or a hurricane. Her teeth clashed with each other violently, hurting her jaw and the back of her tongue by how hard she bit herself down, tasting her own blood as adrenaline cursed through every single capillary, vein and artery inside her body.

All she could hear were the sounds of screams ringing in her ears, the stomping of feet rushing away all around her, the flow of her own bloodstream inside her eardrums. All she could smell was blood. Blood, blood, blood, sticking to her nose and the base of her throat. Iron and salt and something else she could never place. She still can hear it now, can smell, can see it below her eyelids, all of it forever stuck inside her mind. As present as other sets of memories, blood in Catra´s neck and a car spinning out of control, never leaving Adora´s mind again.

And yet in that moment, in those long seconds where everyone was running and the *drip drip* of sticky blood was louder than anything else, all Adora could think was Catra and not letting go of her hand. The feeling of her palm, cold and sweaty inside of hers, the touch of her fingers, smaller and slim. A hand Adora has held a thousand times before, that she held before she even knew how to spell, that Adora could recognize in hell itself. A hand that

wasn´t trembling, or shaking from head to toe, and when Adora looked back she saw Catra´s face was blank, her eyes looking without really seeing and her pupils fogged, far away from Adora ´s reach even standing next to her.

Adora doesn't remember much between the chaos and the moments they arrived at Glimmer´s house. She is partially aware that professor Octavia was barking something and that Bow found them among the crowds. Of his hand wrapping around Adora´s bicep and not even flinching when Adora yelled at him, dragging her and Catra towards the parking lot where Angella´s slick and expensive truck was already waiting for them, ready to take them all to the Bright Manor immediately.

Sleepover was canceled, as one does when the Mayor is brutally murdered, but that didn't stop the influx of messages ringing in everybody's phones violently. From quick notes from the local news to images in social media to text after text, all of them talking about the same thing until shock gave away to gossip in a matter of hours, filling the need of knowing every single morbid detail and theory until Adora´s head was pounding and she almost threw her phone against the pink wall of Glimmer´s room.

Catra was quiet through it all. She had curled around herself and against Adora´s side, looked through an empty point past the window and remained quiet the entire evening, biting at her nails until she bled herself and Adora had to lace her fingers to stop her from hurting herself more, cooing her inside her arms.

Adora held her close in silence, afraid of whatever was going on inside Catra's mind. Worried sick about her and her ghostly pale face, all her freckles dimmed down and her eyes blank. Adora hadn't seen her like this in such a long time, a year to be precise, face to face with death itself, so lost in a place inside herself that Adora didn´t know how to reach her. So Adora held her, she held her and kissed her temples and eyelids and talked about anything else. Until Light Hope arrived, driving like a fucking soul pulled out of hell and Adora barely had time to kiss Catra goodbye before

she was dragged outside, cursing every single second she was not allowed to be by her side.

Adora´s chest squeezes and hurts, making her wince. She can still remember the look of Catra´s face through the window of Glimmer´s room, watching Adora go. She can remember it, it was the same expression Catra had in the hospital that time, when she could not speak a single word, staring at some point in that wall, unresponsive to Adora´s frantic pleas and warm tears against her neck. And after too, all the words exchanged between them, secrets Catra has spilled next to Adora´s ears, her voice ragged and sore and never the same.

*Adora …*

Sometimes, just sometimes, people say so many things about Catra that Adora can't help but wonder too, especially now outside of this chapel painted black with a funeral … and the mere thought makes her sick with herself, but Adora cannot help but to wonder.

*Adora …*

*Adora …*

*ADORA …*

"Adora!"

Adora jolts out of her skin at the sound of a real voice speaking next to her, her hand firmly pressing against her chest, turning sharply towards the sound. Glimmer is standing right next to her, frowning at Adora. As everyone else here, she is wearing black from head to toe, all of her pink hair held short against the back of her head. There is a quickly printed paper sheet in her hand with the choir's pieces and she is chewing pink bubble gum loudly, staring at Adora with an arched eyebrow.

Bow is standing close behind her, studying Adora with patient eyes. He is also dressed in black from head to toe and there is a

small reassuring smile on his lips, his eyes tired where he probably stayed awake the entire night talking to Glimmer.

“Jeez,” Adora wheezes, clenching her phone close to her chest. “Sorry, Glimm, what did you say?”

“Any luck?” Glimmer repeats herself, pointing at Adora´s phone with her chin. It takes Adora a second to understand what she is talking about.

Adora sighs, shaking her head sadly. “No”

Glimmer hums, kicking a loose stone in the ground with her foot. “She hates coming to the cemetery, Dora. Give her time”

“I know. I just– I just don't want her wandering alone with all of this,” Adora laments, her heart slamming inside her chest as she lets her head fall against the wall of the chapel, closing her eyes under the golden light of the evening. Her head is pounding painfully, pulsations slamming mercilessly against the sides of her temples, making her dizzy with nausea. She could barely sleep last night and today she is feeling the consequences of it.

Bow approaches her softly, resting his warm palm over Adora´s shoulder. He squeezes down once, nodding gently at her when Adora opens her eyes a slit and stares back at him, tears nesting in the corners of her blue eyes.

“Hey,” Bow reassures her, nuzzling their foreheads together. He is always like this, caring and tender like a brother with everyone, mostly with Catra lately which Adora will forever be grateful for. “We are the best friends squad, right?”

“Right,” Adora rubs her nose with the back of her hand, scratching down her neck nervously.

“And Catra is one of us which means none of us is going to let anything happen to her. And if she doesn´t want to come to the Mayor´s funeral because it triggers her, then we will give her space.” Bow wraps his arms around Adora´s shoulders and brings

her into a kind hug, melting Adora´s rising thoughts and sorrows away, even if for just a second. Glimmer approaches them too, squirming between them and into the hug, her arms tightly wrapped around Adora´s waist.

Adora sniffs and hugs them back, nuzzling her cheek over their shoulders in a way that always manages to calm her down. Adora loves her friends so much, she adores them with her entire heart.

“Thank you guys”

They part from each other softly, fixing their clothes quickly before turning around to the rows and rows of people already walking inside the chapel. It almost seems as if the entire town was here, a sea wave of black clothes and lowered heads chatting among each other even inside the unnerving silence inside.

Glimmer clicks her tongue against the roof of her mouth, shaking her head. “I don't get why everyone is making such a fuss, it is not like the people actually liked the guy.” An older woman walking by hears Glimmer and gasps, scandalized. Glimmer only rolls her eyes at her and shrugs, crossing her arms over her chest,

“He did get murdered, Glimm,” Bow says between clenched teeth, managing a quick smile as damage control towards the woman and pulling Glimmer closer.

“Everybody knows his corrupt ass was going to get into a bigger trouble than he could handle one day.” Glimmer continues, stomping in the ground obviously annoyed. Adora raises her eyebrows at her, surprise and mild unsteadiness running down her spine. Glimmer catches her stares and flushes red in the face, getting defensive pretty quickly. “What? You know I'm right, Adora.”

“I mean, yes I guess.” Adora scratches the tip of her nose, tilting her head. “Why are you so worked up?”

Glimmer stays silent for a few seconds, her breath heavy inside her chest. Finally she sighs, surrendering with a groan. She rubs her eyes with her closed fist, smudging pink eyeliner over her skin.

“My mom is driving me crazy. She was on the phone the entire night with the Mayor´s Office and then ran in and back again until three in the freaking morning. They are naming her Mayor in the meantime too, which I wasn't supposed to say but whatever. And she keeps pestering me on not going out of the house until everything about this shit show is cleared.`` Glimmer takes out her bubblegum and tosses it carelessly into the chapel´s bushes, her nose scrunched with displeasure. “Honestly? I miss the person she was when my dad was still alive. At least she wasn't hovering over me like a falcon, I can barely breathe without her approving it.”

Bow wraps his arm around his girlfriend´s shoulders, holding her into a reassuring embrace. Glimmer is still tense, staring at the people walking besides them and then back at Adora. Her lilac eyes are apologetic but there is still an obvious snarl in her mouth, the red tip of her ears giving away just how clearly upset she is.

“What's with this?” Glimmer asks before neither Adora nor Bow can say anything else. She holds the hem of Adora´s black lace veils between her fingers, pulling from it softly. It doesn't fall from Adora´s head, held painfully tight with pins to the diadem over her head, black like ink against the gold strands.“You look like a nun.”

“It´s Light Hope´s doing,” Adora explains, digging her nails frustrated into the frail fabric, tugging uncomfortably from the sleeves of her dress, annoyed by the itch of the tights against her legs. “She wanted me on my best dress for the chapel”

“It´s–” Glimmer starts and gets stuck in the middle, mind blank. “It looks very funeral appropriate, yes”

“Please, don't try to make it better.” Adora groans. She looks at her empty phone screen once more with a heavy heart and guards it safely in the pocket of her dress, cracking her knuckles. Music has started to sound inside the chapel, the organ ripping itself to pieces with the try of a piece. “Let's just get this over, okay? My parents and Adam are waiting for me and I want to get out of this dress right now.”

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**A || I love you**

Catra stares at the message notification for a long second and swipes it left without even opening the message, shutting her phone off completely.

The air inside Angella´s car is heavy, stuffed with warmth and the cherry of Angella´s perfume, making Catra´s eyes itch and water. Maybe it is not completely the perfume´s fault but she wouldn´t admit that out loud or ever.

Angella is sitting in the pilot's seat without saying a word, not even looking back at Catra. They have parked right outside the tall and white building, the sun blasting over the roof of the car heavily, making the heat even more unbearable than it already is. Catra stares at the world outside the windscreen and, when Angella remains silent, she turns to look at her.

Catra tries, she really does, but her lips are already curling over her gums and venom is pooling in her tongue, the sharp sting of betrayal filling the back of her throat like a bad shot of alcohol.

“I get we are not going to the store, are we?” Catra asks, unable to hide the sarcasm in her tone.

Angella flinches softly but her back is straight and her shoulders pulled back, not once bending in shame for what she is doing right now. “They just want to ask a few things”

Catra bites down on her tongue so hard that she bleeds herself, the blood tampering down the need to cackle and scream at the same time. Instead, she digs her colorful eyes against Angellás sharp profile. She hopes at least that the weight of her eyes will make Angella embarrassed or uncomfortable. It should.

“You lied to me Angella”

That makes it. Angella finally turns to look at Catra´s face, regarding her in silence. She is so different from her own daughter, so different to Adora or to Bow or to Angella herself. Angella has tried to love her and she is ashamed, not for bringing her here, but for being unable to.

“I'm on your side, Catra”

Catra smiles at her without a trace of joy in her face. Tears start to gather in the corners of her pretty eyes, clinging to her eyelashes until they cannot be contained anymore, spilling quiet over her freckles and the fabric of her red clothes. Angella´s words feel like nails against chalk, cutting like broken glass. The portrayal of a betrayal before Catra even had a word to defend herself.

“No, you are not.”

It hurts Angella, it makes her heart squeeze and her forehead to gather with cold sweat. She doesn't say anything else though. What could she say after all? She knows Catra is right and Catra knows it too.

Catra huffs at Angella´s silence, shaking her head with cutting incredulity.

“I'm an adult, I know when bullshit is happening,” she digs her nails against the back of her neck, digging into the soft fabric that covers her neck completely. “Who asked you?”

“Lashor,” Angella says immediately. There is no point in lying anyway. “Huntara will be there”

“Big fucking win,” Catra kicks against the bottom of the car with so much force it shakes.

Her breath is speeding up, from forceful to almost panting, fighting with herself to remain in control even as the first tentacles of anger and panic start to eat their way inside her heart and her brain. Angella stretches her hand towards her, unknowing if to reassure her or to hold her, but she stops herself in the middle, lowering it back down. Catra doesn´t even notice, scratching up and down over her forearm until the skin is pulsing red and angry.

“I don't want to speak to them. I don't want to answer their questions. I don't want to talk about my father and I don't want to look at my mother's face,” Catra´s voice chokes with her own words, strangling her down for a moment. Her eyes are drowned in red and hooded when she looks back at Angella again,skin raw and painful. There is betrayal written in every tiny freckle of her pretty face. “You promised I wouldn't have to do this again.”

“I know, but–”

“You promised, Angella.”

Micah would have loved Catra.

He would have adored her like a second daughter, nurture her and cherish her. If Angella tries hard enough she could be able to see it inside her mind. He would have taken her to soccer practice and taught her how to swim so she wouldn't be afraid of drowning ever again. He would have helped her, hold her like the frightened child she was. He would have sewn her prom dress and try to be chaperone on her dates with Adora because he would have been a good father and he would have loved her. He would have seen past it all and would've loved her no matter what.

Maybe that way Angella would have been able to love her too.

“Just tell them the truth Catra,” Angella begs, grasping the wheel so hard that her knuckles turn white, blue veins striking against

her knuckles.

Catra chuckles, sore, throwing the door open with a kick. She doesn't look at Angella again, jumping into the hot asphalt. “What do you know about the truth?”

She slams the car door open violently, stomping across the street and towards the white building, not glancing back once. Angella stares at her back until she gets lost behind the heavy door of the Detective´s building, from the unrelenting heat of October and into the freezing cold.

Angella remains seated for a moment and then turns the car back again, driving down the street and towards the Mayor´s Office at full speed. Angella is a Mayor now and she has duties she cannot forsake. Catra can take care of herself.

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The sweet tones of the chapel´s choir mingle with the voices of the town below them, singing softly as they follow the lyrics of the chants. Adora is not a very good singer but she can manage, fighting back the need to sigh every time the page turns around and, for some reason, the chant still keeps going.

They have all been here for around two hours, maybe even more, sitting and then standing again as the First One Acolytes go in and about the funeral rituals. They are all young looking, dressed in white and gray robes from head to toes, barefoot as they step over the rich carpets of the Velvet Glove Chapel. And they are all so similar to each other, with clear eyes like crystals and golden hairs, quiet as they walk with lit candles on their hands and pristine faces casted down towards the floor.

Adora looks at them wandering around the chapel like lost souls and she sees herself on them. She would have been one of them, a soulless puppet in pristine white and pearl gray, used as another golden decoration for the chapel´s walls. She would have lived her

years here if her mother and her cousin Mara had not absolutely refused to even let her near.

Adora is so distracted by her thoughts that she doesn´t even realize the priest is looking at her until she accidentally roams her eyes towards the altar where he is chanting too, the thick book filled with First One writing heavy on his hands. As everything inside these chapel, he is cradled in silk, white gold and silver, robes of thick and rich material falling from his shoulders to the floor. His hair has gone white too, with time, dusted in silver strands across his face and down his back, perfectly groomed and without a single hair out of place, a striking contrast to the dark of his skin, also completely flawless, pristine as one of the statues of the First One´s deities hanging from the walls and the ceilings. So similar in a way to the Deity´s bones hanging from the chapel´s ceiling.

Priest Prime continues the funeral ceremony without taking his eyes away from Adora for a single second, green irises stitched in Adora´s loose hair and the side of her profile, his expression blank except for the tiniest hint of displeasure on the corner of his lips. Adora can physically feel his irises hovering above her, a strangled scream of anger tangling in her vocal cords.

There has always been something deeply unsettling about the Priest of the chapel, something dark, something strange, at least for Adora´s eyes, but it seemed that nobody else in the town seemed to notice it. They all fawned over him like moths towards burning gasoline, fluttering around his sickly sweet sermons and prophecies of Etheria´s greatness. Starved all of them for some kind of rendition they thought only the Priest could be able to grant them.

Adora has never been one for prophecies or destinies, There has already been so much expectation placed on her shoulders to be drowned under false pretense of mightiness, or some kind of godly trace in her that everyone seemed to think she carried. And she never liked the chapel, nor the hanging deities placed as martyrs or the saints or the angels. Adora Montenegro  is not a

saint or an angel, she has always known this, but the duty of people's hopes can choke down anyone.

Glimmer slides her arm suddenly around Adora´s, embracing her close against her side. She must have noticed how tense Adora had gotten suddenly, seeking to comfort her without words. Adora exhales very softly through her mouth, stepping imperceptibly closer to Glimmer´s side. She finds reassurance in the warmth of her friend's body next to her, tampering down the increasing emotions bottled up inside Adora´s chest.

Bow is standing next to her, focused on the chant, Angella´s absence visible by the empty spot in the bench. At Adora´s left, Light Hope is also chanting, following the prose easily, already knowing the words from memory. She is a devotee of the First Ones after all, her entire life. She knows these rituals and this place better than she knows anything else.

Adora risks a look towards her, staring at her from the corner of her eye. Light Hope is already looking back at her, Her face is blank, unreadable as always, but there is a pleased expression on the corners of her mouth as she watches Glimmer embracing Adora, silent words swirling in her dark eyes.

Adora knows already what she is thinking, Light Hope has not been quiet about her expectations to Adora. Glimmer is of a good family, an excellent one, the little princess of the town giving the Brights are not only one of the oldest families living here but also probably the richest. The Bright Manor does not go unnoticed by anyone that passes it by. Glimmer has been accepted into the First One Academy too, much to Light Hope´s delight. She is smart, rich and beautiful, and Adora knows what Hope is thinking. By all means, she knows what everyone thinks when they see her next to her friend, every time.

Adora presses her mouth into a tight line and looks away, wandering her gaze towards the walls at the sides, swirls of gold in every column and heavy golden and white doors in the sides. It's only then that Adora finally sees her. Adora would recognize

her anywhere, by the smell of her skin or by the way her chest moves when she breathes.

Catra is standing without moving behind one of the thick dark columns, staring back at Adora with sea glass eyes. Her hair is loose again, framing her temples and cheeks in dark loops, almost losing themselves against the granite of the column she is leaning into. The gold of the wall and metal door behind her frame her head in a halo, shimmering multi colors over her forehead from the stained glass where the sun is pouring inside.

She is wearing a dress, out of all things a crimson dress of a red so deep that it looks like pressed roses against ink. Tight around her legs, long sleeved and cradling her neck with fabric embroidered in black roses. In her chest there is a diamond shaped window that has no rights to frame her chest like that, tempting Adora´s blue eyes with the glint of freckled skin like the wine sitting on the golden cup on the chapel's altar. The skirt has been ripped on the side of the leg sharply, a frankly scandalous opening that barely stops at the top of her thigh, dark skin peeking above the hem of her tall black boots.

It´s the kind of dress that you would least imagine to see inside a chapel, during a funeral, in front of the entire fucking town. It's the only kind of dress Catra would ever wear in this life which is why Adora gave it to her as a present on her last birthday, half way as a lighthearted joke, halfway because it made her mouth water and Catra´s eyes sparkle with amusement. Adora had not seen her in these clothes in such a long time and here in the middle of a ceremony was the last place she thought would see her with them.

Nobody has seen Catra yet besides Adora, which is frankly miraculous, considering that, like this, Catra looks like one of the paintings hanging in the wall, a piece of art brought to life that is waiting patiently for Adora to finally notice her presence. Devotion spreads like a tidal wave inside Adora´s entire body at the sight of her, her cheeks flaring pink and her heartbeat speeding inside her

ribcage, the desire to run towards her making her limbs twitch with need.

Catra´s eyes flash when their gazes meet, her lips twitching in the corners. Adora thinks she might smile but Catra´s bright eyes are hooded, obscured by the shadows of something, her lips retracting over her gums with displeasure, a snarl fighting its way below the sharp points of her piercings. Adora´s eyebrows twitch with confusion until she realizes Catra is staring directly at the point where Glimmer´s arms are woven tightly around Adora´s.

Apprehension falls over Adora´s shoulders, coiling cold in the bottom of her belly. Catra´s eyes are back on hers, her arms crossed over her chest. She blinks once towards Adora, slow and deliberate, and then turns around, walking past the golden gates and into the dark corridor past it, losing herself from Adora´s sight.

Adora has long ago stopped singing. She shakes herself from head to toe, slipping out of Glimmer´s hold as quickly as she can, almost tethering her towards the back of the bench with the rush. Glimmer shoots daggers at her with her eyes, her eyes full of questions. Adora shakes her head softly and folds the ceremony papers into her hands, giving one step forward to start squirming out of the cramped space.

Light Hope´s hand wraps around Adora´s wrist and yanks her back harshly, locking her in place with her touch. She is still holding the pamphlet in her hands but she has also stopped singing, staring at Adora´s face with an expression so cold and disapproving that it makes Adora shiver violently.

“Where are you going?” Light Hope whispers, her tongue sharp and voice high pitched with alarm. People in the benches around them have started to look now, throwing glances at the sudden commotion. Bow and Glimmer are looking too, still singing but ready to jump into action if Adora asks them to.

Adora breathes deeply through her nose, controlling herself as much as she can. The last thing she wants right now is a scene in front of everyone.

“I want some space,” Adora whispers to Light Hope, proud of how her voice remains calm and soft. Light Hope blinks at her, still staring at Adora like she couldn't phantom why on earth she would like to leave in the middle of mass. Adora wets her lips with the tip of her tongue, wrinkling her nose as she scrambles to think on something more. “To pray for the Mayor”

*There. Good job.* Adora congratulates herself, nodding proudly though Light Hope doesn´t notice that. Instead Hope´s face relaxes, an expression of delight painting in all of her factions. She lets go of Adora´s wrist and nods once, stepping aside so Adora can keep walking.

“Very well”

Adora tiptoes past the benches and towards the golden gates, covering her face with Light Hope´s godforsaken veil when heads turn around to look at her walk past by. The heels of her low shoes click way too loudly against the ivory in the floor, louder than the harps and organ and singing voices gathering around her. Adora keeps her eyes glued to the space where Catra went through and tries to ignore the heavy green eyes that look at her walk away.

The corridor is frightfully cold and empty, dark where the oil lamps weren´t lit at all to begin with. Drips of humidity gather on the wooden ceiling and fall every once in a while towards the floor, making Adora hiss when they make it past her clothes and down her bare spine, raising chills on her back. She follows the long corridor almost blindly, dragging her fingertips over the wall to avoid tripping or crashing against something accidentally. There aren´t even windows here, nor paintings, just a plain corridor empty of everything else that Adora follows without a second thought.

She feels like it goes for forever until she catches sight of light at the end, pouring golden where the corridor opens to a small room. It is back to being covered in the same richness as the rest of the chapel, with the entire north wall covered in so much gold, purple, crystal blue and sharp emerald from the gems and First One´s materials that Adora has to squint when the light reflects on her eyes.

There is nothing else here besides the bright wall twinkling with colors and a huge confessional on the side. It is shaped like a small castle all of its own inside the room, made of pure amethyst and thulite crystals that shimmer with their erratic shimmer and sharp forms. It divides itself in the middle by a wall of geodes, carved by First Ones hands and polished until there were sculpted circular forms and complicated filigree with the very same stone. It's covered in cherry wood on the inside, two seats separated by the wall and the carefully carved doors to close the space framing it all. A true display of art and richness in this solitaire corner of the chapel.

The sounds outside are tampered here, drowning the echo of music and the voices of the people too. Here Adora can only hear her own thoughts and the slow cadent breathing of a second person, sitting behind one of the closed doors of the confessional.

Adora´s eyes scrunch with worry, walking swiftly towards the place. She stretches her arm towards the door where the breathing is coming from but stops in the middle. No voice comes out, even though Adora knows that she can see her through the spaces of the wood. Adora sighs deeply and lowers her hand, climbing instead inside the second part of the confessional without closing the door behind her.

Like this, below the shadows of the wood and through the smooth and thin wall that separates them, Adora can finally glance at Catra´s face up close. The filigrees obstruct Adora´s vision in place but she still can make out the shape of Catra´s profile

beyond the geodes, casting tiny specks of light over her cheekbones. Catra is quiet, looking up front and not at Adora,

“Catra, what are you doing here?” Adora whispers, as gently as she can, digging her fingers through the circles of the wall. “I thought you´d be at home?”

“I know.” Catra answers in a beat. The sound of her voice makes Adora cringe, sour and tired. Catra exhales and lets her head fall back into the wall, still not looking at Adora at all. “ I feel like I'm going to get sick.”

“Cat–”

“I want to be here.” Catra rushes to say, finally looking back at Adora´s eyes. Her breath rattles inside the reduced space, echoing softly. She looks at Adora through the wall with charged eyes, holding her eyes in hers. “I know it makes you sick too.”

They stare at each other in silence until Adora cannot bear it anymore. She steps out of her side and grabs the knob on Catra´s side, throwing the delicate door open with so much force that it crashes against the crystal.

Catra is sitting on the hard wood-seat, staring at Adora without surprise in her eyes.Her hair is tousled on the side where she has been running her nails across her scalp, showing the bare side of her face completely. Adora did not see it before because the curls were hiding them, but there are tear marks on her cheekbones, scattering over her skin like spiders. They color the delicate skin below her eyes in red and the start of lilac, pulling down the corners of her sweet eyes sadly.

She has been crying. The sight of it makes Adora´s belly knot into pieces and her throat to close, despair showering over her.

Catra is holding a precarious bundle of flowers in her hands, pulling from the tender leaves softly to control the trembling of her hands. They are mostly weeds and field flowers, yellows and purples and small buds of wheat. There is still dry mud under her

nails and fingers, she must have collected them on her way to the chapel, walking from wherever she was before and all the way there.

Catra offers the bundle of flowers to Adora in silence, petals sauntering towards the floor between them.

“I went to Perfuma´s for tulips but it was closed. I know they are your mom's favorites"

The corner of Adora´s eyes sting with tears, looking at the tiny flowers with a flutter inside her chest. She exhales, ignoring them for a second just so she can cradle Catra´s cold jaw between her palms, caressing the skin of her eyelids with her thumbs.

“What happened?”

Catra shrugs inside Adora´s arms, chewing on the inside of her cheek. “Lashor and Huntara had questions,” she explains, robotic, almost as if she were repeating the words from a script.

Adora´s eyebrows knit in confusion, shifting on the floor where she has kneeled to embrace Catra closer. “Questions? About what?”

“Hordak”

“But why would the detectives have questions for you?”

“You know why Adora,” Catra spits, looking away. She doesn´t pull away from Adora´s touch though, instead wrapping her free hand around Adora´s wrist and nuzzling against her palm. “I already told them the truth but they obviously didn´t believe me.”

Adora´s breathing is elaborated, anxiety raising in her throat. Catra notices it because her shoulders flop forward, eyes hooded. Catra hates when Adora worries about her too much. She cannot blame her though, she hates the reasons why she worries too. It always seems that no matter what they do, no matter what Catra

does, the shadow of what happened, of her mother and of the town's judgment will always chase her wherever she goes.

For a long time, Catra thought that eventually it would make her lose Adora too. That Adora would realize that the town´s chattering was right, that Catra was beyond salvation, that she wasn´t worthy of good and kind things, and that Adora would move on, leave and make the life she deserved to have. It almost tore them apart. It still might.

Adora opens her mouth to say something else but Catra stops her, dragging her fingers from Adora´s wrist to her mouth, pressing over Adora´s pink lips gently. Catra´s eyes linger over Adora´s mouth, her freckled cheeks dusting in pink with a gentle blush. She grasps an errand strand of Adora´s golden hair and places it gently behind her ear, caressing the angle of her jaw. Her eyes travel to the bridge of Adora´s nose, the moles scattered like suns in her face, the silver blue of her eyes, marveling in all that Adora is.

She loves everything about Adora; she adores every single crevice and spot of her soul. She loves and loves and loves her. It is all reflected in her eyes and when she looks back at Adora´s she can see it all reflected right back to her, something Catra was made to believe she would never deserve, much less have from the girl she had loved her entire life. Adoration and love and tenderness, all given to Catra completely. Adora´s entire heart.

Maybe Catra is not so broken, after all. Maybe she still has salvation. If Adora, who is good and kind and gentle, can love her this way, maybe Catra is not so rotten inside.

Adora kisses her inside the confessionary. She cradles Catra in her arms and coos her mouth with hers, kissing her deep and sweetly. The field flowers crush softly between their bodies, petals falling colorful around their feet. She licks Catra´s upper lip and past her front teeth and presses her tongue against Catra´s, lapping at the roof of her mouth damp and sweet.

Catra whimpers inside the kiss, resting her palms over Adora´s neck, tangling her hands in Adora´s golden hair. Her fingers dig on her scalp and grasp the edges of the ridiculous black veil, pulling off it until the pins give away, coiling in the ground behind her back, releasing her hair of its confinement so Catra can pull from it softly, embracing Adora tighter against her chest.

Adora gasps against Catra´s mouth, relishing in the feeling of her nails against her nape and the taste of her breath on the back of her throat. She runs her hands over the outer side of Catra´s thighs, past the edge of the high boots, ghosting tenderly against her dark skin. Her palms travel up and up until they run underneath the skirt of Catra´s dress, making their home against her waist.

The touch of Adora´s palms against the small of her back makes Catra´s entire body shiver almost violently in Adora´s hold, biting accidentally over her bottom lip. Her fangs and the edge of the angel-bites grasp the tender skin of Adora´s mouth, The smallest drop of blood twinkles solitaire on Adora´s lip, making Catra´s breath to hitch of her throat at the taste of it on her tongue.

Something boils inside her body at the sensation, something hot and sticky that goes beyond love or desire. Catra tries to keep her breathing in place and runs her tongue over Adora´s bruised lip, apologetic, tampering the sting with her mouth. She relaxes her arms around Adora´s neck, expecting her to pull away. Adora is already pulling her arm away from her waist.

Instead, Adora wraps her long hand around Catra´s neck and tilts her head backwards, gentle but also firm. She surges forward with a grunt, reclaiming Catra´s mouth back around hers with a searing kiss, open mouthed and bruising.

Catra exhales against Adora´s lips and and kisses her back with all her heart, diving her own hands past the neck of Adora´s dress, resting flat over her bare shoulder blades. Skin against skin has always been such an intimate thing for both of them, even beyond sex itself. By all means, right now this is not about that

and they are not about to desecrate the confessionary more than they are already doing.

They have laid countless nights bare from head to toe in each other's arms, without doing anything else but to rest their mouths together and hold each other under the covers, breathing in each other's air until they were both asleep. They have held below the warm spray of the shower, undressed the other carefully and wrapped their limbs together in calm and quiet seconds where neither of them wanted to feel anything but the other. Their skins brushing together is about something so much more important and deeper. And Catra could live like this forever, with her mouth nestled against Adora´s and her mind calm for once. She would burn the world down just to be able to keep Adora like this forever.

The confessionary is cramped but just wide enough for them to embrace each other without bumping into the other painfully. Adora gets a good grip of Catra´s hips, moving her around easily until Catra´s legs rest at either side of Adora´s waist and Adora is cradled between her legs, still kneeling on the floor like a devotee praying to her own kind of deity. Her hands slip out of Catra´s dress and wrap them around Catra´s waist, holding her close.

Catra parts from Adora´s mouth with a sore gasp, leaning her forehead against Adora´s gently. Her body feels looser, more tender now after being kissed and held. She stares at Adora´s eyes from below her eyelashes, taking in the tender blush in her face and the glimmer in her pretty eyes.

“Adora,” Catra whispers, her voice raspy by the kissing and the past tears. Adora looks at her with so much tenderness that she feels like crying all over again. “My beautiful, beautiful Adora”

Adora is also calmer , her heart steady inside her chest even though it feels like it could run like a wild horse set loose just by the sensation of Catra´s own heart so close to it. The rising thoughts, worries and doubts festering inside Adora´s mind have quieted now completely, And mentally Adora beats herself raw for

even daring to wonder, to doubt about Catra. About Catra´s love and her heart.

How could she ever doubt, to listen to others worries? How when Catra is the only good thing left in Adora´s life? How when she is Adora´s angel, a tender spirit brought to earth so Adora could adore her. How when Adora knows her, better than she knows herself, Adora *knows* her. Adora loves her and she trusts her, no matter what shit the universe throws at them again.

Catra runs her closed lips with feather touch across Adora´s forehead and temples, lingering on the frail skin of her eyelids. Adora smiles at the gentle touch, nuzzling her cheek over Catra´s jaw. "I'm here, angel. I´ve got you."

Catra hums, nuzzling her face against the angle of Adora´s neck. Adora peppers tiny kisses over Catra´s ears, worshiping every single freckle, mole and patch on her skin, slowly approaching Catra´s mouth to kiss her again. This time the kiss is more tender, sweeter like honey on their tongues. Their lips meet and separate softly before they lean apart from each other again, just so they can wrap their arms tightly around the other into a strong hug, so strong that they might as well melt into one soul, embracing on this dark corner of the quiet church.

They are so enthralled with each other that they don't even hear the quiet steps approaching the outside of the confessionary, the tiny ring of tinier bells stitches handmade to a heavy tunic, nor the crack of black candles being lit into green fire until it is are right in front of them, past the thin closed door. surrounding them like a viper about to bite.

"It is a beautiful display of the First One´s mightiness, isn't it?" Priest Prime´s voice echoes inside the room, loud enough to be a thunderbolt.

Catra and Adora freeze on each other's arms, eyes wide with alarm. Adora looks back at Catra frantically, her mouth closing so fast that her teeth click together painfully. Catra goes sickly pale

above her, all the blood draining from her face. Adora does not let go from Catra but she can feel the shiver coursing through her body and then across her own, shaking them both to the bone.

“These crystals were brought here all the way from Krytis,” Priest Prime continues, unmoving. Adora can see him from the cracks of the door, standing facing the golden wall. Adora cannot see his face very well but she can make out the corners of his mouth and she knows he is smiling, all knowing and dangerous.

Dread falls down Adora´s chest, unconsciously holding Catra tighter against her chest. Catra´s fingers dig over her shoulders, her mouth resting against the shell of Adora´s ear. Adora cannot see her well under this mild darkness but she knows how they both look; tousled hairs, red cheeks, pupils wide; their lips kiss bitten and their clothes slightly ruffled from where hands have seeked the other´s tenderness in the middle of their devotion.

Adora moves quickly, blindly smoothing Catra´s dress back in place and her curls back framing softly around her face. A pang of anger stabs across Adora´s chest, the same feeling from yesterday's morning, annoyance and frustration of not being able to hold Catra freely. That and bitterness, acid, burning on the back of Adora´s throat.

Adora does not want anyone looking at the way Catra´s face softness when they kiss like this; she doesn´t want anyone looking at Catra´s cheeks and eyes when Catra allows herself to be vulnerable and frail in the edges, when she drops the barriers she painfully had raised around herself and lets Adora adore her. Adora does not want anyone looking at what Catra has tried to protect so fiercely of herself, things she only trusts Adora with and that the town refuses to acknowledge, her tenderness and her fear and her love. She doesn´t want anyone to gossip and dig their nose into it, much less Priest Prime.

Adora cradles Catra´s face and kisses her swiftly on the lips, pressing her thumb over her mouth, grazing her front softly as she shushes Catra´s panic. She lowers down and picks up Light

Hope´s veil, resting it over Catra´s head instead of hers, obscuring her face with the lace fabric. It is impossible for them to pretend they weren´t together inside the confessionary, but that doesn´t mean Adora cannot still try to protect Catra´s privacy.

Catra would have beaten her if she knew what Adora was thinking, but Adora doesn´t care right now. She presses her hand against the confessionary´ s door and pushes softly from it, allowing the multicolored light of the small room to wash over her.

Adora steps out first, coming face to face with Priest Prime´s green eyes. Adora´s back bends forward a little and her shoulder flop but she tries to remain as straight as possible, swallowing down a rush of nausea at the expression in Prime´s eyes. Knowing, waiting patiently for them yet somehow irate below the bright green of his irises.

“Ah, there you are, Adora,” the Priest greets her, calm like a storm about to slash the earth, sweet like poison. He opens his mouth to say something else but he catches sight of Catra too, stepping off the confessionary and standing behind Adora. His eyes only seem to flash more at the sight, a sly smile making its way on his lips. “Little sister. We've missed you in the choir.”

Catra takes a sharp breath behind Adora but says nothing, wandering her fingers around Adora´s wrist and holding it down so hard it might just bruise. It´s a grounding motion, both for her and for Adora.

Adora inhales, twisting her hand to lace their fingers together, gathering courage on their touch. She knows the motions doesn´t go missed by Prime´s eyes.

“Priest Prime, is everything alright?” Adora asks, slightly proud of the way her voice doesn´t break. Prime tilts his head to the side, regarding her with a small smile, his arms crossed behind his back.

“Light Hope sent me looking for you, Adora. She was concerned you had lost your way,” Adora cringes a little at the words, swallowing back acid. Prime´s eyes slip from her and towards Catra again, humming under his breath when he sees her face, “Is there something afflicting you, little sister?”

Adora bites down on her tongue until it hurts, absently giving a step forward. Catra´s hold in her hand grows, pulling back from Adora in a silent negative. She doesn´t want to be perceived as weak or defenseless, she is anything but that, much less in front of this man.

“We just needed somewhere quieter.” Catra adds, her voice so steady and blank of emotions that it throws Adora off for a second.

Catra's face is completely collected when Adora glances at her, blank and void of any kind of emotion. Adora gulps heavily, squeezing Catra's fingers once inside hers. Priest Prime is looking at her too, still grinning but with heavy eyes.

“I know all of this is very difficult for everyone.” He says, giving a step towards the girls’ direction. “But our Deity has a plan for everyone and that includes Hordak. He had to die … if it was the Deity's will.” His eyes travel from Catra's face back to Adora's, regarding her like he does to his faux deity paintings in the walls. “We all have to die, sooner or later. It's the natural course of things, it is the only way this world can remain pure from human's sins. Death, oh, death is the purest form of purity.”

He says it almost tenderly, savoring every single word, his arms stretched to his sides. Adora and Catra share a nervous stare, eyebrows raised. Catra wrinkles her nose and Adora had to force herself not to laugh, or scream by all matters. She cleans her throat, stepping back slowly and towards the corridor again.

“We are sorry, Priest Prime, we didn't mean to disturb the confessional room”

“I´m sure there is nothing you can do to displease the Deity, Adora.” His voice sounds lower, a mixture between a grin and a hum echoing on the rich walls. “He sees it all, Prime sees it all.”

It's not the first time that it occurs to Adora how weird it is that all the Priests are named Prime after their raise to the Chapel's Chair. But it is the first time she realizes how fucking creepy it is that they are all named after the Prime Deity, every single one of them like clones of the other.

“Yes, sure.” Adora clears her throat, pressing her back against Catra's side. She doesn't know if Prime has put two and two together and realized they were making out inside the confessionary and she doesn't really want to stay and find out. “We'll be going now.”

“So soon? The ceremonies are still going.”

Prime gives another step towards them, the rosary on his hands clicking together every time the bone beans move. However, his eyes lock on the weathered flowers still in Catra's hands, and his face falls and brightens all over again like a fire, red emotions flashing on the green of his irises.

“Ah, I see. Yes of course, I should have imagined.” He smiles at Adora from ear to ear, sterling back until he is back against the rich wall and away from them. “Go with my blessing, child.”

Adora releases the breath she didn't realize she was holding, shaking her shoulders lightly. She grabs Catra's hand tighter inside hers and pulls from her towards the dark corridor, alarm and urgency clear in her eyes when they look at each other.

*He is so fucking creepy,* Adora says silently with her eyes.

Catra pupils shrink with a small nod, nibbling on her own lip nervously. *I know.*

“Adora.” Prime calls for her again before they can blend back into the shadows. Adora turns to look at him, weary, every single cell

inside her body already rising into goosebumps. Prime's eyes look so dark from here that they don't even look like eyes anymore, instead pools of darkness with green orbs in the middle staring at Adora's very soul. "Every day you look more and more like your mother."

Every single thought inside Adora's mind comes to a stop, locking her in place like a deer against the lights, a hare in front of a predator about to attack. Her breath tangles inside her throat and leaves in a pained wheeze, curling her entire body inwards, with the blunt hit.

This time, it is Catra the one that steps between the priest and Adora, her back held very straight. She is a flame in the middle of gold and crystal cut gems. Red and black and defiant, her eyes charged with hatred when she stares back at the priest, an expression on her burning eyes that Adora cannot see from her position but that she can almost feel in her very bones, racking the foundations of the chapel to their chore.

*Mine,* those eyes seem to say, but Adora cannot see it at all, blinded by the love spreading inside her chest at the sight of her.

Catra wraps her arm around the small of Adora´s waist and pulls her closer to her side, still holding Prime´s eyes like a lionells against a snake, silently fighting each other for a dove.

"Let 's go, Adora," Catra says, lingering a kiss over her shoulder and guiding them both back to the dark corridor. Prime´s green eyes follow them behind but none of them turn back.

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" *Just tell me where were you"*

*"I already told you. In Angella Bright´s house." Catra groans, throwing her head back over the uncomfortable metal chair. "I live*

*there now, you know that Lashor. Even you should be able to hold down that information."*

*´Watch your mouth, Catrina.´*

*Catra cringes, repelling the third voice like poison against her skin. She stares at the window of the Detective's Office, fighting back the tears of humiliation gathering on the corners of her eyes. Lashor rests his palms over the table in front of Catra, leaning towards her until his rancid breath is right in front of her face, messing the curls falling over her face.*

*´Look at you. You are a mess, Catrina´*

*"Is there anyone that can corroborate what you are saying? Or coincidentally there was nobody at home?" Lashor asks after a beat, smiling sideways as if torturing Catra was satisfying him deeply. Catra bites down onto her tongue until it hurts, feelling the edge of her piercing dig into her skin.*

*"I had dinner with Glimmer and Angella at seven, then they both left. Glimmer went to Mermista´s Halloween Party and Angella did whatever Mayor´s right hands do."*

*"Ah, how convenient isn´t it?" Lashor leans back, resting his palms this time over his waist. He looks ridiculous with that vest. "Why not go to the party? I would think it's right up your alley."*

*Catra clenches her teeth until her jaw hurts, digging the sharp end of her nails over her legs. She can feel her back shivering with a cold sweat and she tries with all her strength not to look towards the left corner of the room, the one that is wrapped in shadows where the light on the midday sun doesn´t reach.*

*Catra keeps her eyes glued to either Lashor or the door of the office, holding her breath until she feels her lungs strain. Huntara is here too, walking past the corner without turning around, displeasure written in her face but still without saying anything.*

*“I don't like parties,” Catra manages finally, spitting the words as if it burnt her. Lashor smiles, pleased at the way Catra seems to be breaking in the seams.*

*“I wouldn't have guessed that. Weren´t you the same blind drunk idiot that crashed against the tree line four years ago?” He places the words between them as if they were compliments, with a skip on his step and a happy ring in his voice.*

*Bile starts to gather in the back of her throat, acid burning her entire esophagus and tongue as she remembers exactly what Lashor is talking about. He was there after all, and so was Huntara, dragging Catra´s bruised ass back to her house without caring what would it be of her after he left.*

*She can still see it all behind her eyelids, the sound of the creaking convertible car completely destroyed, the three fallen over the roof, the smell of gas soaking the ground and the pang of blinding pain in her head where she crashed against her forehead so hard that the entire side of her face was covered in sticky blood. She can still remember herself that night, seventeen and sick for how drunk she was, crying silently on the freezing car seat, trying with her entire force to reach her broken phone on the floor to call for someone she had pushed away months ago. Catra remembers all of her mistakes, every single one of them.*

*´You are a disgrace´*

*“Careful,” Huntara warns with a bark, staring directly at Lashor´s back. Lashor hums, digging his hands inside the pockets of his worn leather vest with a hint of victory already in his eyes. He knows he has managed to upset Catra.*

*Catra rests her hands over the table and pushes away the myriad of photographs that had been placed in front of her, running her tongue over her teeth. There is blood already in her mouth, from her own bitten tongue, smearing on her fangs and gums in red.*

*“I wasn't the one driving.” Catra spits back, breathing hot and angry through her nose. She regards Lashor back with a boring stare, taking on how tense his body really is below all that pride and self confidence. The Mayor's Office must already be biting his ass for answers, pressing him into foil. Catra grins this time, tilting her head to the side. “Aww, what is it, Lashor? Already missing Hordak´s dick to suck onto?”*

*Lashor slaps her across the face. It's so hard that it shackles her teeth painfully, tearing tears off her eyes burning hot and embarrassed.*

*“Lashor!” Huntara yells, wrapping her huge hand around his shoulder and pulling him back so hard that he trips, dragging his exalted ass towards the opposite corner.*

*Catra can barely hear them discussing above the rush of blood inside her own ears and the ringing in her head, the first tentacles of a migraine crawling their way inside her head. She feels movement out of the corner of her eye, blurred by the tears.*

*´Such a disappointment,´ Catra hears her mother say, staring at her with her black eyes. Catra cannot see it well but she knows her eyebrows are pulled into a frown, looking at Catra as if she was nothing less than a nuisance. ´Unreliable, stupid, volatile. You are a ticking bomb´*

*“Alright, I think we all need to calm down,” Huntara says between her teeth, digging her finger against Lashor´s chest with a warning stare. But Catra can barely pay attention to her, her cheek pulsing and her voice stuck on her throat.*

*“Then she needs to tell the truth,” Lashor pushes and pushes again.*

*“I already told you”*

*“You are not going to make an idiot out of me. You weren´t at the party, nobody can say you were at the Bright House. Not even*

*Adora Montenegro  can have your back now like the day of the car accident. Tell me where you were!"*

*"At the house," Catra repeats, strained.*

*"Liar!" Lashor huffs at Catra´s face, baring his teeth. Catra´s heart slams into her chest, about to burst open and bleed her alive, her voice higher and higher the more the corner becomes closer and Lashor hovers over her.*

*"I didn´t do anything wrong"*

*´You are going to ruin Adora´*

*"Shut up!" Catra slams her hand against the table and stands up, spitting at the floor with a furious stare.*

*The room falls quiet, charged with electric energy. Catra is panting, looking at the checkerboard tiles of the floor, She is aware that she trembling visible and that there are several pair of eyes looking at her but she cannot bring herself to look up, frozen in the place where her hand hit the table so hard that she absently wonders if she didn't sprain it.*

*Huntara clears her throat, approaching the office´s door with heavy steps. She doesn't turn to look at Catra or search for her face but she doesn't need to and Catra does not want her looking either. "I think we are done here."*

*Lashor snaps back to reality then. His jaw falls open, the protest already falling off his  tongue. "But–"*

*"We are done here," Huntara repeats this time louder, giving him a pointed look. Then she turns towards Catra, nodding at the open door with her chin. "Get out, Capellan."*

*Catra crashes her shoulder against Huntara´spainfully, shoving her out of her way as she crosses the threshold and rushes out of the white building. She can hear Huntara´s angry voice discussing*

*inside the interrogation room but Catra doesn't dare to look back inside again.*

*When she walked out of the front door, Angella wasn't there anymore.*

—

Catra leans against the trunk of the lonely pinetree and stares at Adora´s back as she walks over the grass of the cemetery. Catra ´s eyes are hooded and tired, her arms crossed over her chest, holding Adora´s shoes in her hand, her other hand gripping to her own torso so hard that it digs her nails into her own flesh.

Adora´s bare soles bounce lightly with the cold damp grass, pale soles red by the cold, but Catra lets her go, waiting for her on this spot where the cemetery has not yet started but death still lingers in the air. Catra stares at Adora´s golden hair and the fall of her shoulders, her palms holding the frankly pathetic bundle of flowers Catra had brought for her and the hem of her black dress against the golden light of the evening. She kind of looks like a candle walking among pure white tombstones and grass so pale it looks blue.

Catra wrinkles her nose, digging the sharp heels of her boots against the moss of the tree trunk and doesn´t look down, still looking at Adora travel among the cemetery corridors as she starts to speak.

“Hey, dad,” Catra says, loud enough to not be a whisper, still so low that it gets lost among the cutting wind around her. “Is the earth comfortable?”

As always, neither the pinetree, the soil or the black granite tombstone placed solitaire against the root answers her back. Catra nibbles on the inside of her cheek until it hurts, rising sparks of pain from the point where Lashor slapped her to her temple.

“I didn't bring you flowers, you hate those things,” Catra huffs and straightens her back, running her free hand loosely over the curls

of her hair. She laughs without real joy behind it, whipping treacherous tears with the heel of her palm. “I'm not even talking to you. I'm talking to a piece of rock with your name on it because you died instead of staying”

Catra doesn't like the cemetery. She used to wander here when she was a child, chasing mice and hares with Adora among the tall grass when their parents were having some picnic around the woods or before Catra was dragged by her mother to choir every single Sunday. The only reason she is here now is because Adora hates coming alone.

Catra finally sits down, the first sparks of a headache lashing against her head. She ignores the damp grass and the uncomfortable position, curling herself into a tight ball against the even colder surface of her father's tombstone. She cuddles against the stone as if she was still nine years old and these were her father's arms cradling her to sleep.

It's been such a long time since then, though. So long since the accident. And Catra has been embracing this cold stone for a decade now. She knows nobody is going to embrace her back now.

At the other side of the cemetery Adora stops in front of the huge mausoleum, her mouth pressed into a tight line. The white stone and stained glass looks back at her in equal silence, the golden lights of the Montenegro  Family winking at her when the evening sun touches them.

Unlike Catra, yards behind her, Adora is calmer, much more peaceful as she approaches the stone vases placed at each side of the marble pillars. She places Catra´s flowers inside them, caressing the frail petals with tender fingers before turning back towards the closed doors of the mausoleum.

She presses her open palm against the door, narrowing her eyes sadly. She is calm, yes, but despair and sadness still manage to eat their way inside her very bones, eating her marrow from the

inside out. If she were to peek inside through the colorful windows she might be able to catch sight of the coffins placed mindfully inside, forever closed for seven years now, gathering dust in the top.

Adora exhales softly through her nose and finally allows herself to cry, tender tears dripping off her face in rivers.

“Hi mom. Hi dad,” she greets her family, her bottom lip wobbling so hard it makes her speech slurred and her chest to squeeze painfully. “Hi Adam”

The mausoleum remains quiet but Adora can feel the warm breeze caressing her cheeks and temples like her parents used to do when they kissed her forehead; ruffling her hair in the top in the same way Adam played roughly with her when they were just fourteen and chasing each other among the mud. In a way, Adora feels them there with her and it makes her smile, the only grasp of hope and peace she has that she holds so dear to her chest since the moment they left.

“Catra got you flowers,” Adora says, smiling at the sight of the colorful blooms. Then her face falls, the shadow of worry clouding her blue eyes. “I’m worried about Catra. I'm worried about all of us”

She would lie if she didn´t admit this whole thing is making her sick, her nerves on fire and her mind running wild like the rush of her blood inside her ears. She would lie if she didn't say she is afraid, more afraid than she has been in such a long time. That she feels as if time and the universe were closing around her, around this time, around the people she loves. Like a dark cloud hovering over her sunny sky, about to tear everything apart in thunderbolts and broken pieces of glass.

Adora has fought so hard for this life, this quiet life of sunshine and college acceptances and carnivals. Adora has fought tooth and nail for Catra; they have already lost each other, in so many ways, they have been pulled apart and torn into pieces and

separated for so long. Adora is so afraid to lose her, so afraid to make a mistake again, so afraid to let go of Catra´s hand and find out she could not help her broken heart in the end.

Adora feels like something is about to happen, something worse than the Mayor getting mauled. Something so much worse, crawling inside the soil of this town for so long that it is about to boil, exploding into pieces like a curse. And Adora, who could never admit it about herself but that everyone, specially Catra, knows is good and just and so terribly sad too, can't help but to fight the need to grab Catra´s palm in hers and run away as far as their feet can take them and then some more. So fucking afraid that this town will swallow them whole too.

Out of the corner of her eye, Adora catches sight of Light Hope´s car circling the limits of the cemetery, catching sight of Adora on her familiy´s mausoleum with her eagle sight. Adora exhales against a strangle breath, an uneasy shiver running down her back cold and sticky like a bad omen as she looks at Light Hope lose herself among the tree line and then appear again on the other side, never taking her eyes away from Adora.

Adora wipes the tears off her eyes and turns around to gaze towards Catra´s direction back on the pinetree where her own father is buried. Light Hope is not going to like it but Adora will try to make the most of the time she still has with Catra before Light Hope drags her back to the house. Even if it means curling on the cold grass of the cemetery for a couple of hours, wrapping her arms around Catra´s chest and holding her close in silence.

Adora lingers her palm over the closed door of the mausoleum and presses her forehead against the polished surface, whispering a small prayer to her family, wherever they might be.

“Please, look after us,” Adora rests a kiss towards them and turns into her steps, eyes focused on Catra´s red figure cutting against the evening sky.

Adora tries too but she can barely ignore the feeling of eyes following them wherever they go.

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"I do not agree with this," Light Hope mutters, still not turning off the car´s engine.

The light rumble of the vehicle makes Adora´s teeth shiver a little. The night is warm but inside the car is freezing cold by the air, chilling Adora to the bone.

"It's the Brights, Light Hope. I´ll be alright."

"I don´t care if you´ll be alright. I care that you should be studying not loosing your time"

Adora cringes visible at the words, closing her eyes to try and fight the tears off her eyes. She knows what Light Hope´s expectations and hopes are. What she expects for Adora. But it always comes as a hit every time Adora hears it outloud.

"I´ll study with Glimmer and Bow, we are taking the same finals. And they invited me to dinner too." Adora tries, as soft as she can, worrying her bottom lip with her teeth. Light Hope remains quiet for a long second, so long that Adora starts to wrongly feel relief, thinking Light Hope might just give up without pulling up a fight this time.

As always, Adora is wrong.

"You´ve come to see that girl," Light Hope says between clenched teeth. Her face is still blank like a hologram, but Adora can see her squeeze the wheel so tight between her fingers that the skin of her knuckles strains over her bones.

Adora breathes very slowly, shaking her shoulders. She is not good at lying anyway and trying it might only make Light Hope step on the pedal and drive them back to the manor again. And at least tonight Adora wants to cradle Catra in her arms and have the try of a nice night with her friends.

"Please Hope. I went to the chapel, I had the last online interview with the First One Academy after you took me home. I got straight A´s on yesterday´s tests." Adora begs, holding her backpack like a lifeline. "Just tonight."

Light Hope presses her lips into a fine line. For a second Adora thinks she might actually drive again until she hears the characteristic click of the passenger door getting open. Adora exhales, relieved, already pushing the door open and hopping out of the car as Light Hope calls for her again.

"I´ll be here at six in the morning tomorrow, Adora." Light Hope turns to look at her fully, her blue eyes so bright and displeased that they throw Adora off terribly. "Be punctual."

"Yes, Light Hope." Adora says in a rush, jumping all the way out and closing the door swiftly behind.

She steps into the precious garden of the Bright Manor and turns around on the stone steps, waving Light Hope goodbye with an almost stiff smile on her lips. She cannot see Light Hope properly from this angle but Adora definitely knows that she is not waving back.

Adora sighs in relief when the white car finally rolls away, resting her back against the perfectly cut bush next to her. She takes a few seconds for herself, taking several deep breaths as the adrenaline starts to wear off her bones.

She did have an interview today, which went excellent and absolutely sucked to do all at the same time. Even with Mayor´s dead and the close of the campus for the rest of the week, Light Hope hadn´t left her take a single break the entire evening. She

wasn´t happy that Adora had lingered for so long in the cemetery either, and it was pretty obvious.

It´s a miracle of its own that Adora is allowed to be here to begging with. And it was probably only done because Light Hope had spent a good amount of time praying inside the Chapel before driving Adora to Glimmer´s house, and her mood was lighter always after it.

Adora blows a breath to her own hair and undoes the tight ponytail from her hair, letting her hair fall in locks and massaging her sore scalp with her fingertips. She starts to make her way towards the huge door of Glimmer´s mansion when her phone starts vibrating violently inside the pocket of her jacket, making Adora hesitate in her steps.

She pulls out the thin device with a swirl and barely looks at the screen and the unknown number shimmering in it before she is already pressing the green button to answer, bringing it to her ear. Catra has always said that Adora has a horrible habit of answering every single call she gets no matter what or when, but Adora cannot help it. Not when practically the entire town has her number anyway and sometimes they call for her help on something. And Adora is not one to let a call slip now that the town is in need of some sense of normality.

"Hello?" Adora answers cheerfully, holding her phone between her ear and shoulder as she roams inside her backpack for the bag of gummies she had snuck from the store earlier.

Nobody answers back to her greeting, which in a town so small like hers it´s a huge red flag. Adora frowns, dropping her try to fish the snacks and grabbing her phone properly, standing still on the front porch.

"Hello?" Adora repeats only to be met with silence again. She takes the phone away from her ear and looks at it again, frowning at the *Unknown* words blinking on the dark of her screen. "Hello?"

Glimmer´s neighborhood is very beautiful, filled with expensive and huge houses and pretty gardens filled with bushes and trees everywhere you look. Bow lives in the same neighborhood and Adora used to live in one similar to this, before her family died. She is not a stranger to the sounds of crickets or at the street lamps illuminating the asphalt. Today, however, the place looks almost weirdly dark, the lights either too dim or completely blown out, probably caused by the storm of two days ago.

Adora nibbles on her bottom teeth, looking around her with a weary expression. Her heartbeat has suddenly picked up inside her chest, closing her throat as dread and uneasiness starts to fall over her like rain.

"Who is this?" Adora asks, more strained, louder than before. She cannot see past the trees of Glimmer´s gardens, the night is too dense and her eyes too tired after wearing contacts the entire day to see past the branches and bushes. Adora sneaks her fingers below her golden rimmed glasses and rubs her eyes with the heel of her hand, chasing a little of the exhaustion away.

A movement in the left catches Adora´s attention and she turns her head shapely towards it, her heart on her throat. She thinks she sees a shadow but she cannot make sense of it, or if it is a simple tree, a palm tree or definitely a cryptic monster about to jump over her and eat her. Everything could be possible in this town.

Adora gulps, huffing at the quiet phone call with newfound annoyance. "Alright, I´m going to hang up"

" *Adora."*

The voice creeps off the phone and into Adora´s ears, making every single cell of her skin crawl and retract in dread. It's an unreal voice, done by some machine or mechanism that makes it sound robotic and inhuman. It's not uncommon to receive pre-recorded calls from some store or bank, even for kids to go around pranking people, especially now that Halloween is almost

at the next corner. If Adora would have heard it anywhere else she probably would have just thrown her phone into the bushes. Catra and Glimmer would've definitely cursed like a sailor to whoever was doing this dumb prank on them and Bow would have politely hung up, turned off the phone and never turned it back up.

But Adora is stuck, frozen with her wide eyes staring at the darkness and the phone glued to her ear, absently counting the beating of her heart. Because, however this is, it is calling *Adora´s* name, saying it in a way that makes Adora want to yell. A strange voice on Adora´s phone in the middle of the night when she is standing alone on the dark street after the Mayor was brutally murder.

That is the thought that makes her shake back into her body. She clenches her teeth, snarling at the phone even though it can see her back. As far as she knows.

"Who is this?" Adora barks, eyes glued into the dark. The light of Glimmer´s porch illuminates her poorly, the only source of light several feet away from the rest of the working lamps.

" *Adora"*

"This is not fucking funny. Go get a fucking life." There, Catra would be proud of her, if Adora actually got her shit together, hung up and walked the small steps towards the door that separates her from her.

Adora is just about to do that when the bushes next to her creak loudly under another weight, echoing in the middle of the silence like war horns. Adora jumps taken aback at the exact second where the voice returns, louder than before, still completely strange, a bad omen finally reaching her.

" *Adora,"* the voice says and somehow it almost seems to smile. *"I´ll leave you a pretty gift, pretty hare"*

Adora´s jaw falls open, her breath tangling inside her lungs. Fear falls down her spine, the inexplicable sense of loss filling her to the brim. Before she can even begin to speak again the call cuts off completely, leaving Adora alone with the creaking darkness and the buzzing of the phone.

Adora lowers down the phone and stares at the screen in silence for several seconds, curling her lips over her gums, heart raising and mind blank. She is so out of it for a second that she doesn´t even notice the door opening behind her and the rushed steps until they are right above her.

“Adora!"

“AH!” Adora jumps and does the first thing her instincts tell her to do, grab the phone and swing towards the person behind her with all her strength into a good old punch.

If Glimmer had been just a few inches taller and she hadn´t scrunched down in time, Adora would have most definitely knocked her in the face with her fist. Glimmer´s disheveled and her eyes wide with alarm as she raises her hands in front of her, calming Adora down.

“Whoa! It´s me!” She exclaims, laughing nervously.

Adora exhales, making sense of her friend in front of her as she tries to calm her heart back down. “Fucking hell, Glimmer.”

“Sorry! You should have seen your face.” Glimmer laughs, straightening back up. She searches Adora´s face with raised eyebrows, taking in her trembling hand and fighting posture. “What's going on with you, you´ve been standing here for hours!”

Adora turns to look at her with a confused stare, frowning lightly. She is still deeply freaked out. “You saw me?”

Glimmer shrugs, pointing at the small white camera above their heads, well hidden among post of petunias. “Security system. My mom´s doing after the whole Mayor thing.” Glimmer crosses her

arms over her chest, tapping on the floor with her shoes. “What´s up with you, seriously?”

Adora huffs, saving her phone back into her jacket. “A weird call”

“Uh? The slasher maybe?” Glimmer laughs, wiggling her fingers at Adora. Adora stares at her disapprovingly, shaking her head, a pang of weariness still rooting inside her chest as she studies Glimmer´s face. Maybe Glimmer likes horror movies too much after all.

“Glimmer please”

“What? I'm noisy, you know that.” Glimmer laughs, good natured and bright. All dread falls off Adora´s shoulders at the sound, chuckling too.

“It´s a hazard.” Adora peaks towards the open door of the manor, raising the plastic bag from the farmacy she had brought from the house. “I have the gummies. And I brought Cat some cold patches for her headache too.”

“How do you know she has– nevermind.” Glimmer rolls her eyes, barely hiding her annoyance. “She is not here.”

Adora stops, glancing from the open door to Glimmer once again, her pupils shrinking like pin points in her face. “She is not home?”

“No.” Glimmer shrugs, biting on her cuticles. “She said she needed air.”

“And you let her go?” Adora´s voice raises a full note, high even for her own ears. Glimmer raises her eyebrows, surprised, and she opens her mouth to answer when a third voice joins the conversation, calming as always.

“Have you ever tried to stop her?” Bow smiles, stepping on the porch too with his night crop top and bunny slippers. He smiles at Adora reassuringly, the mirth clear on his eyes. “She bites.”

“Bow,” Adora says in a pleading voice, fidgeting with her hands nervously.

“She is alright,” he assures her, nodding towards the side of the house. “She looked in better spirits, she even took some of the cookies I baked with her and told me she would be back soon. I saw her sitting in the park on the other side of the house.”

Adora worries her lip into her teeth, dropping the backpack and plastic bag into Glimmer´s hands and turning around, ignoring her protests monumentally. She is still incredible on edge by the godforsaken call. “I´ll go for her.”

“Nonsense,” Glimmer says, dropping the bags this time on Bow´s arms and wrapping her hand around Adora´s bicep, pulling from her with way more strength than expected. “She´ll come when she wants and feels like it. You come inside. My mom is not home so I made us popcorn and an unhealthy amount of chips.”

“But–”

“Inside, Adora. If she doesn´t come in the next ten minutes we´ll all go for her.”

Adora stares at her friends, unsure, and finally gives up with a sigh, nodding. It was a hard day and if Catra needs space Adora will give it to her. As much as she needs.

“Okay then.”

“See? Let´s go then, Catra has keys”

The three friends make their way inside, closing the door behind them without looking back. They don't even see the bushes moving next to the house or the person gazing at them from the shadows that walks away when they are gone.

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Perfuma gathers the last bundle of roses and places them inside their vases on the fridge, making sure she closes the door safely behind her. She loves the night shift because it means she gets to organize all the flowers inside the shop in complete calm, not a soul in sight besides her and the quiet music from her relaxation lessons echoing on the speakers of the flower shop. She always loved plants, after all, everybody knows that. The midterm job came as a gift from the heavens when the owner of the shop asked her to help her out.

It is very dark outside, several minutes after her shift ended and she was supposed to close for the day, but she doesn´t mind. She took a little longer organizing everything and cleaning it all up; it was incredibly messy after the Mayor´s funeral, with how many flower arrangements were asked from one moment to the other, mostly from the chapel and the Mayor's Office. She is also waiting for Scorpia to come pick her up to go on a night tea date together.

Perfuma sighs dreamily, whipping the last of dry leaves and flower water from the counter and saving all the cleaning products back into their place, her pink apron stained with soil in the edges. She is facing the shelves when she hears the bell of the door ding softly, so she doesn´t see immediately who walks inside.

“Scorpia, darling you arrived early!” Perfuma chimes, turning around with a sweet smile. She narrows her eyes towards the dark corner of the front door, where the closed sign is already placed and the lamps turned off, trying to make sense of the shape standing quiet in front of it. This, however, is definitely not Scorpia, who always walks inside the shop with a loud bang and a laugh. “Oh, I'm sorry! I thought you were Scorpia!

The person says nothing, instead looking at Perfuma and then at the rows of flowers placed carefully on the shelves, running glove-clothed fingers over their petals.

“Hello?” Perfuma calls again, shifting nervously behind the counter. “I´m sorry, I can't see you well”

The person stops caressing the flowers and turns back towards Perfuma, giving several steps forward until it is right below the only lamp still turned on, illuminating the face fully. Perfuma´s eyebrows rise and her chest relaxes, recognizing the person now that is up close.

"Oh! Hi! I didn´t recognize you with those clothes." Perfuma turns around, whipping her damp hands over her apron as she circles the counter, pointing towards one of the shelves in the back where several bundles of pink and white blossoms are resting, peacefully waiting to open. "Are you looking for more flowers? I have those tulips you asked me about!"

Perfuma approaches the other side of the shop, humming under her breath as she picks up a few of the flowers. It is closed but she will make an exception tonight, it takes her nothing. She feels the person walking behind her, getting nearer and nearer until is basically right at her back, hovering over her shoulder.

"Your hair is really beautiful blonde," the person says, voice curling around the compliment sweetly.

Perfuma, bless her heart, smiles broadly, taking the compliment to heart. She holds the flowers with one hand and curls a strand of hair with the other, staring at the fine corn like hairs there with a proud stare.

"Thank you!" She says, honestly, running her fingers along the strands. "Well, I'm not really a blonde. But this is a new type of dye and Adora is teaching me how to set my bangs–"

Perfuma´s voice dies in her throat, mouth opening into a perfect ´o´as the surprise takes over her. She feels a pang on the side of the abdomen, boiling hot like a burn, numbing her skin and muscle and past it all until the soreness and acid washes out and pain takes it´s place, so overwhelming and sudden that Perfuma is left without breath.

Perfuma looks down, towards the source of the feelings, still confused, still completely taken aback. She gazes at the pink apron, her favorite one actually because it is the one Scorpia embroidered for her on their tenth date. The tender baby pink is stained now, not by mud or grass but by red, a crimson flower blooming on the fabric and spreading like a sickness, born from the place where the hunting knife is dug so deeply inside her body it almost goes missing between her flesh and the hand of the person holding it.

“What–?” Perfuma stutters, giving an involuntary step behind. The flowers come sauntering down, falling all over the floor and her white sandals, spotted in red where her own blood has started to drip.

The person leans towards her, delighted on that single second between confusion and terror that seems to be freezing Perfuma in her place. Still holding the knife, the person rest the mouth over Perfuma´s ear and whispers to her ear, clear above the sound of the music.

“You should run now.”

The knife comes out of Perfuma´s body with a swift swing and Perfuma trips against the flower shelves, comprehension finally falling down her at the sheer pain.

Perfuma gasps, pain and horror gathering in the entire body and throat, choking her with a scream that doesn't fully come out but as a terrified whine. She looks up at the person, a plea already falling off her lips but the killer is already swinging the knife at her again, catching the skin of her upper arm.

It doesn´t stab her fully but it cuts a gaping line across her skin, blood dribbling down the sleeve of her dress and into her wrist. The pain shakes Perfuma awake, finally putting her back into motion. She crunches down at the next swing of the knife and scrambles away from the killer, slipping on her own blood on the floor.

Her shoes leave imprints of her rushed steps wherever she goes, painting a trail of red as she throws herself back the counter and through the backdoor, the one that leads towards the cramped warehouse where the rest of the soil and gardening products are stored. She jumps over several sacks of dirt, crying in pain when the pain makes the stab wound on her abdomen to pull and tear itself more, blood now completely soaking her apron.

She looks behind her enough to see the killer walking calmly behind her, regarding the warehouse with an almost bored stare. Perfuma screams, grabbing several heavy pots and throwing them towards the killer´s direction with as much strength as she can. The killer evades them easily, sighing when Perfuma starts throwing plants, flowers and even cactus, desperate to get the killer away from her.

Perfuma doesn´t realize how close the killer is from her until is basically above her again, cornering against the shelves of white roses. Perfuma stretches her good arms, seeking to push the killer away, but the killer just chuckles, grabbing her wrist so hard that she cries in pain. The killer twists her arm and pushes her, slamming her against the concrete door so hard that the world goes dark for a second. Blood sprays against the white roses where Perfuma´s nose breaks and starts gushing blood, dribbling down her mouth and chin.

Perfuma cries, not knowing if to press her palm against her stab wound or against her face. Her sight goes blurry with red stains and tears, obstructing her path as she stands up and falls again several times, making her crawl on her wounded belly over the earth to try and reach the emergency door in the back.

The killer follows her slowly, not once rushing the steps or the killing, waiting patiently as Perfuma puts on a show of trying to survive. Somewhere inside Perfuma´s mind, as she stretches her arms towards the doorknob and pulls it open, make her realize that the killer is *allowing* her to do this, allowing her to try and runaway, so sure of what is about to happen that doesn´t even try to go and stop her.

Perfuma sobs, holding herself from the railing of the emergency stairs of the building and standing up in weary feet, giving the treacherous steps up. There is a connection between the next building, a coffee shop, and the flower shop on the roof, a small bridge of concrete made in case of fires, given how close the buildings of this street were to each other. She knows there must still be people in there, tending to the late night costumers. If Perfuma could make it all the way there and inside the next shop, she might have a chance to scare the killer away.

She makes it to the roof miraculously still in her feet, her legs numb and cold from where the blood has started to slip down her thigh and knee. She trips with the small stone of the floor but doesn´t fall, instead rushing across the entire roof. She can hear the crack of the metal staircase behind her with another weight and the calm breathing of the killer following close behind, but she can also see the door of the next building, so close to her that she can almost brush it with her fingertips.

Perfuma crashes against the door and pulls from the handle with all the strengths she has left, shaking the door on its hinges. But the door doesn´t open, doesn´t even move from its spot or shakes loudly to call the neighbors attention. Perfuma looks down and catches sight of the chain wrapped around the door and the heavy lock holding it all together, tightly robbing Perfuma of her last try to run away from her own death.

Perfuma sobs, she cannot stop it, all of her breathing exercises and calming methods going straight to hell as she slams her entire body against the door, banging over the surface with her palms.

“Help me! Help!” Perfuma screams, leaving blood stains behind.

She knows the neighbors, she has spoken to them plenty of times when the shifts are slow, and they are good people always ready to lend a hand; but they also always have a night of live music and after the endeavors of Mayor Hordak´s dead, the need of loud distraction was so needed that no other sound could be heard above the scandal.

Perfuma whimpers, slamming her forehead against the metal door until it hurts, too scared to look back and face the reality that the killer might already be hovering over her, too afraid to die to stop trying to do anything she needs in order  to survive.

She fishes on the pockets of her soaked apron until she finds what she is looking for, her also pink phone with the hand painted flowers in the cover. Perfuma can see herself through the dark skin, all of her blonde hair dyed in red into a sick mock of copper by the blood dripping from her nose and temple; her pale skin and freckles rimmed by red patches; stains of her own blood over her cheeks and neck.

Perfuma runs her fingertip over the screen but it wont recognize her fingerprint among all the blood, soaking the very screen in the red substance. Perfuma whimpers, desperate as she presses the buttons on the side and almost drops the phone twice trying to get her password in. Finally the phone lights alive, the picture of Scorpia smiling while holding a pot full of cactus looking back at her.

Perfuma presses the buttons of the screen until what she is looking for comes into place, dialing the phone number she knows by heart quickly.

“Hi, darling! I´m on my way!” Scorpia answers at the first try, happy as always. Perfuma is aware in some part inside her heart that she should be calling 911 or any other fucking emergency service she can think off, but the way Perfuma can almost see the smile in Scorpia´s mouth makes her laugh among tears, nuzzling her bleeding cheek against the screen.

“Scorpia!” Perfuma cries out for her, scared and weak as she feels her forces leaving with each heavy drop of blood coming from her body.

“I'm bringing the roses you asked me! I didn´t forget this time!” Scorpia announces proudly, the rumbling sound of her car clear in

the background. She must be heading this way from the flower field, all the way at the other side of the town.

Perfuma laughs between a sob, shaking her head softly. “Darling, please”

“Oh, and I confirmed our reservation! Netossa will see us there, I have a surprise for you!”

Perfuma is about to answer when a shadow falls over her, hovering right behind her. Perfuma can see it reflected over the door, and she can feel the soft breathing right behind her ear, ruffling the soft hairs that live there. Perfuma opens her mouth to scream but the killer beats her to it, grabbing the back of her dress and pulling her back, smalling her against the floor with so much force that all of Perfuma´s ribs scream in agony.

“Fuma? What was that?” Perfuma´s phone has been knocked down, fallen on the ground and several inches away from Perfuma. Scorpia has finally caught up that something is happening because her voice, even as far away as it sounds right now, becomes frantic. “Perfuma? What´s going on?”

“Help me!” Perfuma screams at the top of her lungs, digging her nails in the floor. “Scorpia, help me!”

“Darling? Perfuma!” The killer steps slowly on the phone and breaks it clean under the weight of the boot, the call disconnecting immediately.

Perfuma tries to crawl away again but she can´t, already too quick by her wounds to keep running. The killer bends down and grabs Perfuma´s ankle, dragging her back no effort and getting a hold away from the back of her clothes, lifting her up into her feet.

Perfuma struggles inside the hold, kicking and lashing blindly and as violently as she can. The killer huffs and lifts the knife again, digging it hard and deep inside Perfuma´s lung before she can even beg. The pain is so deeply shearing and brutal that all the

forces to scream leave Perfuma´s body immediately, so drowned in pain that she can´t even cry anymore.

"No," Perfuma pleads, the only thing she can do right now as the killer guides her towards the edge of the building. The cold autumn breeze and the void hit Perfuma in the face, freezing her tears on her eyelids. "No, please"

But she is not listened to. The killer slams her against the trail so hard that she black out, stabs her in the back of the neck one more time and throws her off the roof, staring at her flying body until it connects brutally with the floor below. She is no longer alive when the killer leans over the edge to look at the new masterpiece, her skull open and bleeding on the floor, body still twitching with the remaining shocks of her nerve system shutting down forever.

But it is not done yet, the killer knows with a hum as it makes its way back down, past the warehouse, the counter, the shop and the front door, calmly stepping on the street soaked in blood. The coffee shop next door is filled to the brim with people inside but nobody has even noticed it, too busy with their daily lives to care. And there are no security cameras here, the killer knows well, a pity in a way, after so much work.

The killer grabs Perfuma by the arms and pulls her back inside, ignoring the red river she leaves behind her as the killer closes back the door and turns towards the flowers with a big smile.

Tulips are indeed such beautiful flowers.

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Adora is so focused, ignoring the movie playing on the screen and swirling inside her own thoughts that she doesn't even hear the footsteps approaching the back of the couch until a pair of cold hands cradle her jaw upside down, holding her softly in place.

Adora lets her head fall back on the couch, staring at Catra's precious eyes hovering over hers where she leans against the back of the seat, smiling down at Adora all sharp canines and pink lips.

“Hey, Adora,” Catra greets her, drawing soft circles from Adora's chin to her cheekbones.

Her face is calmer than the last time Adora saw her back at the cemetery, expression softer. Her sea glass eyes glimmer under the lights of Glimmer’s living room even though they still look tired and rimmed in sore red on the corners. Her hands are freezing cold though, raising shivers on Adora's skin where Catra caresses her face gently.

“Hey, there,” Adora greets her back in a whisper, wrapping Catra's hands inside hers. “You're cold.”

Catra shrugs, running her nails below Adora's chin softly, just enough to make Adora hum pleasantly. Glimmer fakes gags on her spot on the second couch, cuddling next to Bow who only smiles at his two friends before digging back again into his bowl of popcorn.

“Are you feeling better?” Adora questions because she has too, her heart on her sleeve. Catra nods against her face, shoulders and body relaxed under Adora's relieved hold.

Glimmer rolls her eyes with muted *‘I told you she’d be back soon’.* Adora flips her off blindly but Catra ignores her, resting her lips against Adora's forehead instead, right above the bridge of her glasses.

“Where were you?” Adora asks under her breath, breathing on the petrichor smell lingering in Catra's hair.

Catra hums, nuzzling against Adora's clean face. “Nowhere important”

“Okay,” Adora squeezes Catra’s wrists, moving them so she can place a tender kiss over the inner side of each one. “Don´t leave anymore”

Catra smiles, moving until her lips are hovering right above Adora's, cooing her golden head further back with her fingertips so she can kiss her properly, deep and sweet.

“I won´t”

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*End of chapter II*

*End of Part I*

Chapter End Notes

Thank you so much for reading! And to all Perfuma fans, I'm sorry! It was horrible writing that I'm not going to lie. Writing this story has been mentally exhausting but I'm really happy I get to share it with all of you now.

See you on Wednesday for our first Interlude, until then Be good!

# Interlude I

Chapter Summary

"Call, Adora"

Chapter Notes

Heeellooo! (◕ᴗ◕✿)
Welcome to the first Interlude of this story, a look to the past four years ago. Look carefully

I've been absolutely LOVING the theories y'all have been coming up. It's so fun to read them! Some of you are grasping the starts of truth some of you are taking the right path and then going south. We'll see. There is still a LOT of information to come up.

Hope you enjoy this little chapter! See you downstairs!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

**[Interlude I]**

**The Quarry, 4 years ago**

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*The car has stopped moving. Catra exhales, resting her hands over the car's dashboard, blinking back the tears quickly gathering in her eyes.*

*Everything burns. Every single limb, every single patch of skin, every single tissue and soft patch and cell in her body burns and aches and screams with pain. She remains very still, so still as to not move a single millimeter, but her body still yells in agony.*

*Her ears are ringing so badly that for a second she thinks she might pass out completely, until the sounds around start to*

*overcome the rush of blood inside her eardrums, crossing the thick fog in her brain.*

*The stereo has gone quiet, the loud music bumping from the speakers no longer playing after the entire windscreen came crashing down inside the car, exploding sharp pieces of glass everywhere. The dashboard is still blinking with the warning signs on the pilot's seat but Catra cannot see them when she turns her eyes towards it, face to face with the wrinkled roof of the car that has sunk between her seat and the next.*

*The car has crashed against a tree, a thin tree in all luck but a tree after all, the trunk just wide enough to have inserted completely against the car´s engine, barely stopping in front of the broken windscreen. With the impact, the tree has broken in the middle, wood splinters everywhere as the top fell against the roof, sinking it almost completely right in the middle. There are branches and leaves inside the car, tangling in Catra´s hair and scratching her cheeks in shallow lines.*

*Catra sobs, closing her eyes tightly for a moment, wishing this way when she opens them again all of it will be gone. But when she does it all seems worse than before, with the dark night hovering over the accident and nothing else around her but tree lines and the black smoke coming from the engine.*

*Catra coughs, she can´t help it, crying in pain when the movement stabs her in the side of the head, right across her temple and across all of her nerve endings. She raises a trembling hand, shivering so violently that she can barely control it, and grazes softly at the side of her head, cringing when it raises sparks of pain. The skin there is damp and sticky, something liquid dripping down and across her cheek. And when Catra looks back at her fingers she can make out the sight of her own blood, crimson and fresh from the where the impact made her bounce and hit her head against the front of the car.*

*Another rush of tears falls on her face, pooling on her cheeks and dripping miserable on the fabric of her torn shirt. She looks*

*around her on the shackled seat, running her scratched palms over her legs and seat and looking frantically between her feet, searching for her phone. She is not even wearing shoes, her mouth still lingers with the taste of cheap alcohol she took before climbing inside the car. She is a mess and she hates herself.*

*She finally catches sight of her phone, face down near the gear lever and her knee, bloody where her dark jeans ripped. She whimpers, stretching her arm until she manages to catch it between freezing cold fingers. The screen is completely destroyed, broken and dark, causing Catra´s heartbeat to speed up violently. She presses into the buttons in the side frantically, pleading under her breath until it miraculously turns on for her,*

*The light blinds her for a second, burning in her already hemorrhaging scleras, and she has to make a real effort to not throw up. Catra runs her fingers over the touch screen quickly only to find out that the sensor has probably died with the crash, her fingers slippery too, leaving blood tracks over the crashed device.*

*"No, no," Catra whispers voice completely broken and sore. "Fuck, please."*

*She tries and tries and tries again until finally the voice command appears in the middle of the screen, waiting for Catra to say anything to it. Catra´s teeth clash against each other by how badly she is shivering but she bites back her own terror, pronouncing the words as clear as she can for the phone to understand her.*

*"Call–" Catra starts, choking on her own breath. "Call– call, Adora." The name comes as a sob, a cry around a name that she has not pronounced in such a long time, not like this after all, softer, pleading. "Call, Adora, please"*

*The phone hesitates for a second where Catra thinks the call might not go through at all and then finally connects, Adora´s*

*pretty face looking back at her from her contact photo. She is still Catra´s emergency contact on her phone.*

*"Please answer, please, please … "*

*Fear starts to gather on the center of her chest for a very different reason than being in a car crash. She hasn´t spoken to Adora in such a long time, not without fighting, not without hurting each other. She hasn´t seen her without being bitter and spitting poison, without turning her back to her pleading and then also angry eyes. Catra has chosen just as Adora chose too, to change Catra for prettier friends, smarter, richer ones, friends that as Light Hope loves to say will bring wonderful things for Adora´s future. Catra is just Adora´s past now because that´s what Adora choose and so Catra has also chosen, to beat Adora in classes and get physical in gym times and slip among dark corridors to be kissed by lips that hurt her.*

*Catra has chosen, all of this is Catra´s choice and Adora might just not answer at all after everything. She has the right to, after the things Catra has yelled to her, after all the recriminations and the push backs and the angry words poisoning all good that ever lived between them.*

*But Catra is also only seventeen. She is seventeen running the hundred and seventy mile and she is afraid, she is scared out of her mind. And she needs the person she loves the most right now.*

*The call rings once, twice, four times, six times and Catra starts crying again, letting her tears drop and choke her down until finally the call gets picked up and a voice travels from Catra´s phone to the metal smelling space she is confined in.*

*"What?"*

*It´s not Adora. Catra cannot place the voice but it is not Adora. Is not Light Hope either. Catra doesn´t know this person and even if she did, the fact that somebody else is answering Adora´s phone*

*is enough for Catra´s already bruised heart to come crashing down into pieces.*

*"Who–" Catra tries without really finishing her questions, her words dying on her throat. The person at the other side of the phone sighs, exasperated, clicking her tongue against her teeth when she answers.*

*"It's Glimmer" Ah. The Bright girl, all cherry pop and pink socks and shimmering hair. Everything Catra is not, answering Adora´s phone. "Catra, you seriously need to stop, you are hurting Adora with all this"*

*Catra cries even harder now. The tears blurr her vision and make her blind, mercilessly cold against her skin. She never meant to cause Adora pain, she only wanted Adora to want her back, for as little as she wished, just that.*

*"I–" Catra doesn´t know what to say, her words slurring one over the other every time she tries to say something coherent or even to apologize. "I– "*

*"You are drunk, aren't you?" Glimmer chuckles on the phone, and Catra can´t see her but she knows she is rolling her eyes. "Unbelievable. Don 't call again, I beg of you, okay? Do one good thing in your life and let Adora live her own"*

*The call cuts before Catra can say anything else, leaving her on her own in this destroyed sports car in the middle of the freezing night.*

*Catra slams her head against the back of the seat, again and again until she feels like either passing out or truly throwing up, regret and desperation eating the marrow of her bones. Maybe it is too late after all, maybe she managed what she so much affirmed she wanted, maybe she really did lose Adora for good, Catra didn´t even get to hear her voice on the phone. Even if she doesn´t die here, what is going to happen to her back at the*

*house might as well kill her and she didn 't get to hear Adora´s voice.*

*A movement at the other side of the sunken roof calls Catra´s splintered attention. The sound of branches breaking, metal and the characteristic creak of the pilot's seat under a weight that makes Catra´s heartbeat to speed back inside her chest, hope raising vile and treacherous once again.*

*"Hey, are you okay?" Catra asks, whining when it makes her jaw throb and protest painfully.*

*No answer comes back. For a moment, Catra thinks that her companion might have passed out, worry swirling in her belly, until she hears the pilot´s door being forcefully open from side to side and the weight lifting from the seat, falling instead against the grass and dirt around them. Catra wiggles in her seat, glancing quickly to her own door where the lock has bent so much that it would be impossible for her to open it from the inside out.*

*She waits and waits with her heart on her throat, fighting the pain of her head and her side, waiting for her companion to help her out. But it never comes.*

*Catra hears grunting, groaning, the sound of feet digging in the soft earth to stand up and then the slam of the pilot´s door closing harshly, shaking the already destroyed car into its very foundations. Catra´s eyes widen, pupils shrinking in her eyes as the realizations start to wash out over her the same second she hears tumbling steps rushing away from her.*

*"Where are you going?" Catra asks, shivering in fear. No answer. The already silent car becomes overwhelmingly more quiet, drawing sheer desperation out of Catra´s ribcage. "Don´t leave me here"*

*No answer. She has been left alone, the realization slamming on her chest like a war hammer.*

*“Don´t fucking leave me here!” Catra screams at the top of her lungs, until it hurts, slamming her feet on the wrecked car, pieces of glass cutting on the bare soles of her feet. Nobody answers and nobody comes back. “Fuck! Fuck you! You are going to pay for this, fuck you! Motherfucker!”*

*Again, Catra has been left all on her own on destroyed pieces of her life, left to fend for herself. She has been betrayed and left here and Catra has nowhere to go.*

*Catra dissolves into cries, burying her face between her scratches up palms, letting herself break in the seams and cry and cry. She will find her way out, as she always does. She will find the exit, the way to survive this too, she will come on top in the end, but for now she allows herself to cry until she cannot breathe anymore.*

*Her phone starts vibrating violently next to her thigh, the screen blinking with the ID photograph of the incoming call. Catra stares with red eyes at Adora´s picture, waiting just for a beat to confirm it is actually real and not a product of her already wrecked head. Catra scrambles to grab the phone with numb fingers, managing to press the answer button by some kind of miracle.*

*“Catra?” Adora´s sweet voice slips inside the quiet space, ringing as a bell for Catra´s ears. She sounds a little bit out of breath but steady even though there is an edge of nervousness in the edges of her voice, as if she didn´t know exactly what to wait for.*

*Catra giggles sadly, pressing her fist against her closed eyelid until she sees sparks. “Adora”*

*Adora exhales at the other sight of the phone, heavy as if she had been holding her breath for a long time. She is still on edge but tries to maintain her voice sweet as she speaks to Catra, resilient as always as she falls into explanations. Typical Adora. Catra has missed her so much.*

*“I´m sorry, Glimmer answered and wouldn't give me my phone back. She is being–” Adora´s voice drifts off, grunting under her breath. There is an echo behind Adora´s voice, like other voices overlapping and Catra supposes Adora is not alone right now, still accompanied by Glimmer and maybe even some of her other stupid new friends. Still, when Adora talks, it's focused, all of her attention in her conversation with Catra. “Did you– um, did you want to talk with me?”*

*She sounds so unsure, so unknown of Catra´s intentions or where to step around her. It's horrible, it makes Catra sick. They have never danced around each other before, always up front and honest with each other ever since they were little children. They have always known each other so deeply but right now Adora speaks to Catra as if she was somehow a stranger and it makes Catra sick.*

*Catra is not able to hold back her sob now, her quivering voice clear among the silence, making her words clumsy and her questions even more pathetic than she already feels.*

*“Please come,” Catra begs in a thread of a voice, shaking her to the very bone. “Please come for me”*

*“What's happening?” Adora´s voice changes immediately, switching like a lightened firecracker. From unsure and hopeful to completely on edge, alert and sharp as a sword. She is already in motion, Catra knows she is because she still knows this part of Adora, the one that is incredibly kind and selfless and caring, that she gives to everyone and that Catra has always wanted to selfishly keep only for herself. “Where are you?”*

*“Please,” Catra can´t help but feel sick with herself, humiliated and hurt on her mother´s fucking car, begging to the person she has hurt most in the world to come pick up the pieces of her. Adora´s breathing is elaborated on the phone, heavy as the sounds of rushed movement start to rise too.*

*“Cat,” Adora calls for her name, carefully, still soft above everything and Catra knows she is trying to calm her down like she did when they were much younger and Catra didn´t know how to control the hurricane in her chest.*

*Catra can hear Glimmer´s voice whispering ´She is drunk, Adora´ somewhere near the speaker but Adora walks away from her, urgency in her voice as she repeats the question again. “Where are you?”*

*“I´m sorry for everything,” Catra spills out and she hears Adora gasp too, shaken.*

*Catra has never apologized for anything to anyone in her life. It just seems fitting that Adora gets to be the sole owner of that too. As if Catra hadn´t already given everything to her before.*

*“I was wrong. I made a mistake. I–” she pauses, trying to make sense of the sudden urgency in her heart and the sticky mess inside her mouth, bittersweet like rotten molasses. She is still drunk, the hit didn´t help with that, too many drinks trying to bury what is twisted inside of her. “You were right about everything. I´m sorry, please forgive me, please”*

*“I wasn´t. I was wrong too, Cat, so wrong.” A door opens and closes and hurried steps walk down stairs, the clicking of a jacket thrown into shoulders and sneakers at the same time. “When they accepted me on the team– I– I did like the attention for a while, I liked the opportunities for my future and the people I met. But I never thought it would cost me so much.” Adora takes a shuddering breath, gathering herself.*

*Catra closes her eyes, her tears itching on her cheeks, mascara and eyeliner a mess on her face. “What did it cost you?”*

*“You. It cost me you, Catra,” Catra whimpers, feeling the words like a physical blow to the chest. “I never meant to make you feel like you were less, I never wanted to push you away. I´m so sorry. I wish I could do it all over again.”*

*Adora whispers and, honestly, fuck her. Fuck her because she is good and so loving and Catra loves her so much. Glimmer was right, Catra doesn´t deserve Adora´s forgiveness and she doesn´t deserve for Adora to twist her entire life just to let Catra´s poison in again.*

*"I said horrible things to you." Catra laments, sniffing. "I called you an idiot"*

*Adora chuckles, wet and kind of hysterical. It cuts a little by the phone´s signal but it sounds like bells for Catra´s ears. She hasn´t made Adora laugh in months. "I am kind of dumb"*

*"No you aren't," Catra rushes to say, so quickly that she accidentally bites her tongue. Adora remains quiet, breathing trembling through the phone and Catra knows she has to say this. She owes it to Adora.*

*"You are so smart, Adora. So, so smart. You deserved those opportunities, you deserved it all" Catra whimpers, the pain in her head growing. "I called you an bitch and a traitor. I told you that I never was going to go with you, that I should have gotten rid of you sooner. It was all a lie, I lied."*

*"I said horrible things too, Cat," Adora´s voice trembles and Catra knows she must be weeping too. "I called you a brat and an asshole. I told you that the things that were to happen to you were going to be on you, your fault. That I wouldn't do things differently. I told you you were becoming in your moth–" Adora cuts herself short in the middle, seemingly realizing for the first time how fucked up the whole thing was. She takes a shuddering breath, horrified with herself. "Fuck, oh god."*

*"You were right," Catra says, shaking her head. "Please forgive me"*

*"It's fine, Cat. I forgive you, I do," Adora rushes to say, fear obvious in her voice. Catra closes her already tired eyes, imagining Adora´s face below her eyelids. She can almost see her*

*there, with her on the destroyed car, as solid as the broken tree and the fuming car. Rose cheeks, perfectly placed ponytail, bright blue eyes. "It's alright, okay? We are going to get through this. We are going to be alright"*

*"I´m sorry"*

*"I'm sorry too," Adora sniffles on the phone, taking a breath. Her words fall over Catra like a cold rain, the kind you love when your world is burning and you cannot breath, soothing and calm. "Just tell me where you are so I can go for you, okay? We can go have some milkshakes and watch dumb movies and sleep in the living room. You love doing that"*

*Catra chuckles, nodding though Adora can´t see her. "Yeah, I do"*

*"I know you do and we´ll do it. And then we will be together every single day after that." It's a promise, Catra knows because she knows the inflection of Adora´s voice every time she promises something, "Just tell me where you are and I´ll be there really soon. Give me the fucking keys, Glimmer"*

*"You don't have a license," that is Glimmer, far away enough from the phone to not be too loud, close enough for Catra to hear her perfectly clear.*

*That last combo comes muffled, slightly apart from the phone´s speaker, Adora and Glimmer arguing quietly for the keys of some car. Catra would laugh at hearing Adora swear, swear to Sparkles out of all people, if she didn't feel so much pain everywhere.*

*"I crashed in my mother's car." Catra blurts, dissolving in tears.*

*She hears the horrified inhale from Adora´s throat, choking her down in terror and Catra hates herself even more. She hates herself for have allowed for this to happen, she hates herself for crashing the fucking car against a fucking tree, she hates herself because Adora´s family died in a car crash when she was fourteen and Catra knows how much it scares her still. She hates herself but she needs help.*

*“It 's– bad. It's so bad. I don´t know where my shoes are.” Catra mourns, staring at the completely destroyed front of the car. A sports car that was paid with her father´s allowance and that is the pride and joy of her mother, black garnet and more expensive than anything Catra will be ever able to afford in her entire life. Catra chuckles, feeling glass shattered under her feet. “She is going to fucking kill me”*

*“Where are you? Are you hurt?” Adora´s voice is a new kind of frantic now, borderline hysteric, edging in feral and terrified and everything in between. It even has risen an octave, high and cutting with Adora´s fear. “Catra, are you hurt?”*

*“I'm bleeding,” Catra confesses, feeling the blood sticking her hair to her temples and the way her chest strains with every breath. Catra sobs loudly on the phone, now fully crying. She cannot hide it from Adora anymore. “It hurts”*

*“Where are you?” Adora pleads, shaking so bad that her teeth click together loudly through the phone. Catra cannot answer for a second and it only drives Adora more insane, her voice breaking in all places. “Baby, where are you?”*

*“I don't know,” Catra tries to move to look around and fails, a whimper falling off her lips. “It hurts”*

*“I know, Cat,” Adora´s voice is desperate and so, so sweet, it covers something dark in Catra´s soul into light.*

*“I´m afraid”*

*“I know, sweetheart. Please just– I don't know where to go.” Adora´s voice trails off, anguished and distressed, completely wrecked to what it usually is. “Are you on the street? What do you see?”*

*Catra breathes deep and makes a real effort to look around her, peeking through the broken windshield of her seat. She sees trees, trees and trees twisted and dark everywhere she looks.*

*Trees and a concrete path so she shouldn't be too far away from town but just enough to not have any store or light near.*

*Catra stretches her neck, straining her eyes to catch sight of anything else to her left or right. That's when she sees it, an old traffic warning barely visible below the branches of a willow with the paint long ago washed out by the weather and almost completely unrecognizable. But Catra knows the figure painted in there, the shape familiar to her.*

*"I think– the intersection between Thaymor and Plumeria. In- in the entry of the quarry. I'm in the Quarry." Catra finally says, gasping for air. The night is so thick around her, enveloping her in shadows. She might as well get lost here and nobody would find her for days.*

*"I– it's dark," Catra mutters, letting her head roll back. She suddenly feels worn to the bone, pulled down by exhaustion alone. "I'm tired"*

*"Don't fall asleep." Adora says firmly. There is a lot of movement on her side. Rushed footsteps, doors getting closed almost too hard, gravel getting moved around by quick feet, the click of a car getting unlocked and the twinkle of keys. "Did you hear me? Don´t fall asleep."*

*"Uh," Catra tries to answer, to calm Adora down but suddenly her mouth feels like cotton, tongue too heavy to move.*

*"Catra? Please answer," Adora is panting, almost hyperventilating now. She pulls her mouth away from the speaker and yells, "Bow!" before returning to Catra´s side. "Cat? Baby?"*

*"I´m awake," Catra mutters, sighing in Adora´s ear. The functional part of her brain still hasn't caught up with Adora´s nicknames so she is free to nuzzle inside their warmth without really thinking about it. Adora exhales all the air in her lungs, slightly relieved. On her side the sound of more than one car door closing echoes*

*on the call, followed immediately by an engine coming back to life.*

*“I'm going for you right now,” Adora affirms in that same tone she uses when nothing in this world will be able to change her mind. She fumbles with the phone a few seconds, the range of the sound changing into something much louder. “I'm going to put you on the speaker. I need you to answer Bow´s questions alright?”*

*“M´kay”*

*“I´m still here”*

*“Okay”*

*The phone creaks and the steadies, the characteristic sound of a car roaring alive and wheels screeching over pavement drowning everything else. A new voice comes into play, kind too and much calmer than Adora, taking control of the situation for a second.*

*“Catra? It´s Bow,” he greets her, huffing a little when the car passes over some pothole in the ground.*

*Catra grins, progressively more out of it as the minutes pass by. “Hey, Arrow Boy”*

*"Hey, kitkat"*

*"It´s you"*

*“Yeah it's me,” Bow smiles on the phone, concern slipping in his voice when he realizes the way Catra´s speech is slurred and clumsy. “Catra? Did you hit your head, sweetie?”*

*“Yes,” Catra admits, wrinkling her nose. “My forehead is bleeding”*

*“Okay. Where else do you feel pain?”*

*“I– I don´t know,” Catra blinks slowly at the top of the roof, leaves falling over her head. “There is a tree in the car”*

*“Did it hurt you?”*

*“I don´t know.” A shiver interrupts Catra, locking her in place. “It's really cold and I´m tired,” Catra considers it for a second, her belly giving a painful turn and a jump, overwhelming her with sudden nausea. “I want to throw up”*

*“That's not good,” Bow whispers and Catra knows it´s not meant for her. The car throttle speeds up impossible so from one second to the other, traveling like the very devil through the sleepy streets of the town. Whoever is driving must be going well past a hundred miles per hour, maybe even more.*

*“Listen Catra I need you to talk to us while we get there,” Bow instructs her, very seriously suddenly. It´s a pity, Catra misses Adora´s voice.*

*“Don´t call my mother, Bow” is the only thing Catra can think to say, frowning to nothing. Bow chuckles, obviously not getting what she means but determined to calm her down.*

*“I won´t.” Someone is sniffling at the other side of the phone, the sound of barely contained tears reaching Catra´s ears. “Something else”*

*“When did Adora learn how to drive?” Catra questions, finally realizing that the one driving must be Adora herself. It is not the thought of Adora driving like the fucking devil what makes Catra´s heart to squeeze in her chest, but the fact that Adora had not touched a car since her family´s accident, much less dared to drive one even if she is eighteen now.*

*“She didn´t!” Glimmer´s voice echoes suddenly and loud, probably from the back seat. Catra giggles, not even bothering to clean the tears off her face.*

*“I taught her,” Bow explains above the sound of Glimmer´s protests. Comprehension falls over Cattra and she hums, nodding to herself. “She is actually great at it.”*

*“Good,” it is good, really good, it means Adora is healing. Maybe these people are not so bad after all. She thinks she can hear the sound of wheels against the pavement on her side of the phone, still far away but close enough for Catra to distinguish them. “I like you, Arrows”*

*“I like you too, Catra”*

*“But I bit you at dodgeball”*

*“Yeah, I remember.” Bow agrees, voice bright, “We still won though.”*

*Catra grins, narrowing her eyes to the dark. There is definitely the sound of a car approaching her way, passing through the treacherous curves that lead to the quarry. The sounds lull her in some kind of way, pulling her deeper and deeper into the fog inside her head, cooing her to close her eyes and relax back on the bend seat.*

*She doesn't even hear the frantic calls of ´Catra? Catra, answer the question please´ or the ´Damnit´or the ´Slow down, Adora!´ or the increasing sound of the motor on the phone until the world is dark around her and the sound is right above her, rumbling so close to the destroyed car that it makes it shake dangerously.*

*Catra hadn't even noticed she had passed out. A pair of hands bring Catra back to reality, cradling her face inside warm palms. Catra blinks awake again, staring directly at Adora´s face a few inches below hers.*

*She is disheveled, is the best way to put it. Her golden hair is almost completely out of her ponytail, falling messy over her left shoulder. Her face is pale but there are small patches of sweat on her cheekbones, matching the panting coming off her chest. Her breath raises mist against the cold air around them and her pretty*

*eyes are wide and scared, pupils like pin points and rimmed in red. Her glasses are slightly crooked over the bridge of her nose and it makes Catra chuckle, fighting the need to fix them with the tip of her finger.*

*"Hey," Catra greets her, as if they had only seen each other a few hours ago and not weeks.*

*Adora smiles back at her, trembling in the corners. Her eyes are terrible, broken, shaken and shrunken like pin points on her face. She looks terrified. "Hey."*

*"You came"*

*"Of course yes," Adora´s eyes wrinkle, tears trapped on her eyelashes. "You look out for me, and I look out for you"*

*She is crouched on the messed up mud beside the car, staining her jeans, holding Catra´s face between her palms and drawing circles over her tear and blood stained cheeks with her thumbs. Catra stares at her and then once more, taking in the whole scene. She realizes finally that the car´s door of her side is open from side to side, unstuck from where the crash made it bend and pulled open with so much force that it hangs broken on its hinges.*

*Adora´s knuckles are red and raw, already bruising over her usually tanned skin where she probably slammed her fist against the door to manage to tear it off the car. Catra didn't even hear the noise.*

*Catra gulps heavily, guilt gathering on the pit of her stomach, nuzzling absently inside Adora´s palms. "I look bad"*

*"I've looked worse," Adora whispers, as light hearted as she can. She looks so close to breaking down into a cry too. She leans closer towards Catra´s seat, taking in the destroyed car with quick eyes. "I'm getting you out"*

*She fumbles with Catra´s shirt for a little, pressing her fingers over her arms, collarbones and nape to make sure nothing is irreparably broken before moving Catra slightly to the side, searching for the buckle of Catra´s seatbelt among the tree branches and the shattered glass.*

*"Seatbelt," Catra points at the thing around her chest, grinning proudly at Adora. It was probably the only thing keeping Catra from being thrown out of the freaking windshield with the hit and against the tree line. Her head feels like a water balloon, she might just actually pass out any second now. "You told me"*

*"Yeah, you finally listened," Adora smiles, not really reaching her eyes. She fumbles with the seatbelt for a while, pulling and pulling from the lock, but it won't give away for her, slightly bent where the tree branches came crashing down next to Catra's side.*

*"Fuck," Adora grumbles, tugging and grunting again when the belt doesn´t unbuckle. Catra´s heart speeds up inside her chest, anxiety and claustrophobia pressing down her lungs like an iron bar.*

*"Adora, take it off," Catra urges her, accidentally digging her nails over Adora´s shoulders. Adora doesn´t even flinch, pulling from the belt with increasing frenzy at Catra´s plea. "Take it off, please."*

*"I got you," Adora whispers between clenched teeth, cradling Catra´s cheek with one hand as the other wraps itself around the thick material of the seatbelt and pulls until the seams rip.*

*She tugs from the buckle several times until it finally gives up under the pressure, releasing Catra from closed compartments. Catra wheezes when the pressure is gone, falling into a fit of dry coughs that only make her head pound even more. Adora catches her inside her arms, holding her up on the seat, whispering reassuring nothing to her ears.*

*“This side is empty,” Bow and Glimmer are at the other side of the car, looking through the broken window of the pilot's seat.*

*“Who the hell was driving then?” Glimmer mutters under her breath, scanning the tree line with narrowed eyes.*

*“I don't know but whoever was left a while ago”*

*The affirmation makes Catra´s belly turn painfully, anger and despair falling short through the swirl of emotions in her head.*

*“I´m drunk,” Catra whispers to Adora, wrapping her shivering hand around Adora´s shirt. She is so pretty, pretty like the ceramic dolls her mother collected, too precious and frail for Catra to touch.*

*“I know,” Adora whispers back. Catra can see the way the corner of Adora´s eyes turn down sadly, her mouth pressing into a tight line, and knows too what she is thinking about.*

*Shame and humiliation of being found like this by Adora and her new friends crash against her like an iceberg, squeezing her chest painfully. “I´m sorry”*

*“It´s not your fault,” Adora says gently, running her fingers across Catra´s face, placing a loose strand of hair behind her ear. It's soaked in clotted blood.*

*“It is. It's all my fault,” Catra laments, whipping tears off her face almost violently. “I´m just like her. I´m a failure”*

*“No, Catra, you are not. You are–” Adora's voice hiccups, overwhelmed with emotions. It makes Catra shiver. “I should have never said that. Cat, you are wonderful.” Adora takes Catra´s wrists between hers, gently guiding her arms to stretch in front of her, inspecting the bruised skin there. “Okay let me see.”*

*She stares at the shallow scratches over Catra´s forearms and upper arms, made by the small twigs of the tree when it came crashing down and the windscreen exploding. They lose*

*themselves on the straps of Catra´s black shirt and then travel slightly over her jaw. Besides them, there is a very nasty contusion already painted over Catra´s cheekbone and temple, bright red and deep purple, closing her eye slightly and covered in blood. The wound over her eyebrow has stopped bleeding, drying over her skin uncomfortably.*

*Adora hisses at the sight, wrinkling her nose. There is a shadow of despair very deep inside Adora´s eyes, of a memory of herself burying her family in the town´s cemetery for an accident like this and Catra wishes she could turn the time and do it all again. Not be stupid, listen to Adora, not listen to her mother, not allow the person she called partner to touch her. Turn and turn the time and make things better, make herself less rotten.*

*"You are freezing," Adora wiggles out of her jacket, a soft looking thing of a cream color and clearly expensive, resting it over Catra ´s shoulders gently. She doesn´t make her pass her arms through the sleeves but the fabric still sticks to Catra´s soiled body like a blanket.*

*"I'm going to stain it," Catra says, trying to wiggle away from it. Adora shakes her head forcefully, pressing her lips into a thin line.*

*"I don´t care," Adora rests her palm back against Catra´s cheek, caressing a tender line over the cheek that is not all bruised over. Her silver eyes are swimming in tears, staring back at Catra with a thousand unspoken words. "I just care about you"*

*They are both so young, so so young. Adora barely turned eighteen in January, Catra is still seventeen for a good couple of months more. There are barely finishing high school, still busy thinking about classes and exams and stupid fights and the Prom Dance Catra refuses to talk about because there would be no world where she could stand seeing Adora dancing a slow piece with some other girl, to see her dreamy eyes towards someone else, to see her maybe even kiss her on the dance floor, young and in love as she deserves to be. Catra could not stand it.*

*Catra can´t stand anything, nothing if it doesn´t have to do with Adora. All the things she has done in the past months have only been made trying to break her own heart and mind and numb her from Adora´s presence, from her scent still lingering to Catra´s scent. You don´t love someone for seventeen years and then try to forget it so easily. Not without hurting yourself irreparably.*

*But now Adora is here, she is here kneeling in the mouth and checking Catra´s messed up body and messed up decisions without a trace of reproach or disappointment in her eyes and Catra knows that no matter in how many way she tries to pull herself apart to dig Adora out of her bones and heart, Adora will always live there, mingled with her very DNA, dug like a thorn crown in the very strands of her soul. Catra called Adora and Adora called back and she came, she came for Catra.*

*"I love you," Catra blurts out, flinching the very second the words come to linger in the air, so completely honest, so raw, pulled from the very depth of her bruised heart. The truth. "I love you"*

*In front of her, Adora´s face shifts completely. Her mouth falls open and her eyes widen, her hands freezing in the middle of her caress through Catra´s face, frozen in the spot where her freckles cluster like nebulas. She doesn't move and doesn't speak, staring at Catra without making a single sound. Catra cringes, the sting of rejection already burning in the corners of her eyes, ashamed for her own instincts and the beating of her heart.*

*"I´m sorry. Shit, I´m sorry, I just–" Catra tangles on her tongue, falling quiet. New tears start to fall down her cheeks and she curses them because they are for a different kind of pain, one that comes deeper. "Fuck"*

*The sight of them shakes Adora awake because she blinks, her huge pupils shrinking again when she sees them falling like cascades down Catra's scratched cheeks.*

*"Hey, hey," Adora coos her, resting her hands around Catra´s neck.*

*Catra tenses, expecting the pressure and the pull, the gesture that will hold her down as she has come used in the last months by other hands. But it never comes. Adora just rests her palms over her collarbones and smiles, all pink lips and teary eyes, looking at Catra as if she were the very stars.*

*"I love you." Adora says, sure, completely open. It tears Catra's heart apart, it stitches it whole again with golden thread. She stares at Catra's young bruised face and smiles, bright as a midnight sun. "I love you too"*

*"No," Catra shakes her head, pulling from Adora's wrists, pulling her away again. "No in the way I love you"*

*Adora doesn't let her go, not this time. She allows Catra to lower her hands but leans towards her further instead, resting their foreheads together. Adora smells like lemongrass and clean soap. Catra smells like blood and charred metal, They mingle together, Adora mingles them together, lacing their fingers and searching Catra's colorful eyes with hers.*

*"Look at me," Adora asks her in a very tiny whisper, nuzzling the tip of her nose against Catra's temple. Catra resists for a moment but she cannot say no, not to Adora, finally opening her eyes and looking back, bleeding scleras against bright blue.*

*Adora exhales, softly, making sure Catra is listening to every single of her words. Catra aches, her head and every inch of her body to the very ends of her heart aches. Adora aches too, aches in the very same way as Catra, hidden and confused for a long time but always there, desperate to boil to the surface, unable to be contained anymore when the person she loves most in the entire world is vulnerable and open and still brave above it all in her arms. Catra has always been braver than Adora in a lot of things, Catra has always been dearer for Adora than anything else.*

*"In that way, In all the ways." Adora says, right against Catra´s face.*

*Catra´s breath stops in her chest but her face remains broken, incredulity written on every faction that Adora can see clearly. Adora´s eyebrows knit together, urgency and an emotion Catra is too afraid to name falling over her pretty face.*

*"Catra– I´ve spent thirteen months in agony thinking I had broken what existed between us, that I had made the wrong decisions and lost you completely. I was so mad at you but I made so many mistakes too. I pushed you, I demanded things from you, I wanted you to change just because I had changed too and when you didn´t I fought you thinking someway it would change your mind.*

*"I´ve spent thirteen months waking up and not feeling you sleep next to me. Thirteen months were the only thing I could think was you and how much I missed you and wanted you back. Looking at you from afar and hating every second I could not hear you laugh and sing. Thirteen months Catra and I hated myself every single second of them because I had traded you for things I thought were more important and I didn´t realize until it was too late, and I wasn´t happy because you were not there to live them with me"*

*Adora takes a breath, wetting her bottom lip with the tip of her tongue, looking at Catra´s wounds and red lips. She is beautiful. Catra doesn´t know it yet but Adora adores her, completely, devoted, and forever adores her.*

*"I´ve been confused for what I felt for so long, You´ve always been the only constant in my life and I've taken you for granted until I lost you and only then I understood how unbearable life was without you in it. That I could not conceive my existence without yours in it. I´ve spent thirteen years and thirteen months loving you and beating myself up for it because I thought you would never want someone like me, because I thought there could not be a world where I could deserve you."*

*"Months dreaming of you, months craving your breath next to mine. Months wanting to break the breach between us and hold*

*you even if you were to hate me after. Months wanting you. I want you, Catra, I love you. I love you so much that my heart might burst with the amount of my love for you"*

*Catra is panting, staring at Adora as if she could not believe a single word yet brightening up from the inside out as if every inflection of Adora´s voice was pumping life inside of her chest. Her chest hovers almost violently with each breath, and she doesn´t know if it is the hit or Adora´s confession but she feels dizzy, exhilarating and terrifying all at the same time. She doesn´t care if someone else is listening, doesn´t care if Arrows and Sparkles are there too, meters away and maybe listening too. Doesn´t care if the world ends right now because at least she´ll have this when she dies, Adora´s open love, finally after so much.*

*Adora wraps her hands at either side of Catra´s face and holds her gently but firm, linking their gazes together. She looks frantic too, as if now that it is all out she could not contain the wave of emotions pouring off her chest and into Catra´s hands.*

*"I love you, I'm in love with you. Bruised or in your worst or happy or sad or joyful, I love you in all the ways and times, and I'm not leaving you ever again. So do me a favor and let me get you out of here so I can live the rest of my life adoring you, alright?"*

*Catra chuckles around a sob, wincing when the movement makes her neck pound in pain. She doesn´t mind though. She might as well be having an aneurysm and be hallucinating the whole damn thing but she doesn´t mind. She feels light, light as a feather, light as a soul pulled to heaven, light as a girl in love. They´ll need to speak about this, later, sit and truly speak about it but for now she feels light. And she laughs instead, her lip busted and her breath still beer smelling, nuzzling her nose against Adora´s warm cheek.*

*"We are both dumb," She says, letting her weight rest over Adora´s hold. She is trembling but she is not cold anymore.*

*Adora nods against her head, hiding her face against Catra´s matted hair. She might be smiling, she might be crying too, Catra lets her. "Yes we are"*

*"We should go to prom"*

*"Really?"*

*"Yeah. But you and me only"*

*Adora hums, careful not to press her fingers too hard against the multiple scratches over Catra´s body. "Us. I like that"*

*"I want to wear a suit"*

*"Of course yes." Adora is fidgeting with the rest of the seatbelt, unwrapping it completely from the tree branches and Catra´s limbs. "Prom, it's a date." She is gentle, soft all around Catra, but Catra can almost feel the heaviness inside her chest, straining her lungs. Adora is scared too, feeling Catra slipping through her fingers like sand. "Don´t fall asleep"*

*"Just a little bit"*

*"No, Cat." Adora gulps so loudly that Catra can hear her, echoing inside her head painfully. She might have perforated an eardrum accidentally because it stings too. "Please, for me"*

*Catra grumbles, fighting the fog trying to take a hold of her mind over her consciousness. "Not fair," and then in a second breath. "I love you"*

*Around them, back on the faraway tree line that returns to the center of the town, a myriad of sirens yelling have started to echo loudly. One, two, several of them, all of the accompanying heavy looking cars that approach closer to their position with every second. They are emergency services but not ambulances or firefighters even. Instead, a group of detective cars and basically the entire police department of the town, traveling so fast that by*

*the time Catra starts to understand what is going on they are just a few minutes away from them.*

*"Wait, is that–?" Bow frowns, his dark eyes studying the almost menacing black cars. Glimmer is fumbling with her pink phone, pressing her lips into a thing line.*

*"I called them."*

*What a bitch. She is very sharp for a person so young, staring at the side of Catra´s wrecked face with hooded eyes and heavy eyebrows. Catra can see her through the golden strands of Adora ´s hair, staring back at Catra as if she wanted nothing else but to leave her in the destroyed car and go back to her bubblegum palace with Arrows and Adora. As if Catra nearly killing herself was bothering her personally.*

*If Adora and a broken cheekbone and the car weren't in the middle, Catra would beat her up.*

*"Glimm," Bow whispers, his face obviously worried. Glimmer shrugs, pointing at the car with her hands, exasperated.*

*"It´s a horrible accident Bow! We can´t just leave it there!" The cars are now almost completely over them. They must have seen the smoke rising from the engine already. Bow remains frozen in place but Glimmer moves, unlocking the slick pink car they had arrived into. She stops just a few steps behind Adora, clearing her throat softly. "The police is here"*

*Catra cannot run and she already knows she is fucked anyway. The detectives are here and nobody else in this godforsaken town has a car like this was. They won´t take long for their pea brains to put two and two together and give a call to Catra´s mother and then Catra will be truly, absolutely fucked. In some part of Catra´ s dizzy head, she thinks Glimmer knows this too.*

*What a bitch.*

*Catra can´t see Adora´s face as the latter moves, shifting her hold on Catra´s body. She rests Catra´s chin over her own shoulder and dips her hands below Catra´s knees and the bruised small of her back, softly pulling her towards her over the car seat.*

*"Put your arms around my neck," Adora instructs against Catra´s ear, rearranging her hold into something tighter and safer. Catra obeys without a word, too tired to fight anymore.*

*At the other side, Glimmer glances at the cars and back at Adora ´s back impatiently, urgency falling on her usually sweet voice. She wants to go, she wants to leave before the cars arrive because god forbids Glimmer Bright is found on the wreck of a car crash helping Catra out of all people. "Adora"*

*"I know, Glimmer," Adora spats, still not looking at her.*

*She doesn't care about being found here, helping Catra´s bruised and drunk body off the car. She should care because she is Adora Montenegro, darling of Etheria and valedictorian and beautiful. She should care like she has done for months now, running alongside new friends and pretending to be like them, chasing for a brighter future than Catra could ever offer to her, a thought that still runs acid down Catra´s heart.*

*Adora should care but she doesn´t, not tonight. She doesn´t care because she loves Catra and in this second they both think this is the worst that could ever happen to them. She presses Catra tight against her chest and inhales several times, gathering herself first to not trip them both into the floor.*

*When she feels the hold safer she hums, lingering her mouth against Catra´s ear shell. "Hold tight, baby"*

*Catra feels the gravity giving up on her as Adora carries her out of the smoking car and into the cold air of the night, carrying her inside her arms, who tremble just a little under the weight.*

*“Gotcha,” Adora mutters triumphally, walking herself and Catra across the wrecked grass.*

*“You need to go,” Catra mutters, blinking at the open doors of Glimmer´s pink car where the latter is already climbing. Adora shakes her head against Catra´s nape, leaning against a tree trunk and sliding slowly towards the ground, cradling Catra inside her arms.*

*“I´m here,” Adora whispers back, cradling Catra´s face on the crook of her neck. Glimmer and Bow´s shadows hover over them when they approach to speak with Adora but Catra cannot make sense of what they are saying.*

*“She is going to kill me,” Catra whispers again but she doesn't think either of them can hear her.*

*The detectives and police department fall over them like a pack of wolves, surrounding both cars and the four teenagers into a closed barrier made of blinking lights and too high noises. Catra cringes inside Adora´s hold and nuzzles her face against her neck, refusing to look back up.*

*She already knows what is going to happen anyway. She is going to be dragged off Adora´s arms and into the back of some police car that will drive her either to the town´s cell or back into the prison of her once beloved home, back into the claws of her own mother. The detectives will tell her mother that Catra stole her car, got irrationally drunk and crashed it beyond repair on the trees of the Quarry because that's just what Catra is. A lost cause.*

*Catra´s mother is going to be sweet with the detectives and grateful, she will cry too making a show of her being a victim in all of this and then she will guide Catra back inside without bothering to worry about her blood on her hair or taking her to the hospital, smiling the entire time until the heavy door is closed again. Then she is going to be who she always is ever since Catra´s father died on the Thaymor Bridge. Is not like Catra can do anything to stop it.*

*“Adora?”*

*“Hmm?”*

*“Would you build me a castle in the woods?”*

*Adora chuckles, cheeks wet as she nuzzles on Catra's temple. “Of course yes, love”*

*For now she allows herself to cradle herself inside Adora´s hold and the shadow of Bow, stepping between the ragging detectives and them, barely even understanding the yells and tugs around her. She promised Adora but she needs to sleep, before everything else happens she needs to sleep, just for a second.*

*They are seventeen and too young but Adora is here and she loves Catra so everything else can wait.*

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***End of Interlude I***

I can sing a fear or a malady

As I drown deep in the wonder

-Haterbeest

Chapter End Notes

Not gonna lie, I cried a little while writing this whole thing

Next chapter will be up this Friday! Until then, be good!

# Alice and The Tea Party

Chapter Summary

If a tree falls in the forest, does anybody hear it?

Chapter Notes

Hello, hello. Welcome to the graveyard

Or more like chapter 4 of our little hunt! Someone said that Interlude are breaks but I never said I would let you rest, did I?

By the way, someone else asked about the blind voting some of you made on Twitter about certain fates. I wonder exactly what y'all did :)

Hope you enjoy this chapter or at least, that it keeps you in your toes. Some of you are smart but you are not reading into lines. You should probably start noticing the chapter titles too, sweethearts

Be careful. See you downstairs

See the end of the chapter for more notes

## Part II. Lungs

## [Alice and the Tea Party]

*And on the wind, it howls (how long can this last?)*

*'Cause that second wind is coming, love, it's coming for all we own*

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**October 25th**

Someone is pounding on the door. Loudly. Too loudly to be this early in the morning.

Adora blinks, chasing away the sticky heaviness in her eyes as best as she can. There is light pouring inside the big room, illuminating the huge couches of Glimmer´s living room. They crashed in here last night, too tired by last day's mess to gather the energy to go upstairs into one of the multiple guest rooms of the manor.

Glimmer and Bow are sleeping on the opposite couch to Adora´s, a thing big enough to fit three people perfectly inside of an immaculate white. Glimmer is stretched to the sides like a starfish, halfway covered in a pink blanket, halfway with her foot on the back of the couch, snoring softly and ignoring the bangs of the front door completely.

Bow is sleeping opposite to her on the same couch, curled into his side and also deeply asleep; his eyelids twitch and he mumbles every once in a while as he dreams, scratching his nose and then stilling back again into sleep. Glimmer has stolen all of his blankets through the night but he doesn´t seem to mind at all, close enough to the still lit fireplace to feel any kind of cold.

Adora is also stretched on one of the couches, slightly slimmer and shorter than her friend´s but just as comfortable. She is tilted slightly on her right side, facing the backrest and without blankets. Her bare feet linger over the arm rests of the sides and her shorts are slightly tangled where she moved around in her sleep. She has knocked her pillow somewhere during the night so her right arm is bent below her head uncomfortably, long ago gone asleep with the awkward position.

Somewhere inside her mind Adora remembers that Light Hope threatened to pick her up at unholy hours of the morning, and by the light coming through the windows the dawn must have very well passed long ago. Adora cannot glance at her wrist watch like this and she doesn't know what hour is but Light Hope has never been one to be late to anything she has set her mind into.

Still, Adora doesn't dare to move a single inch, staring with sleepy and soft eyes at the bundle in her arms, between the backrest and Adora's chest. Catra is deeply asleep too, wrapped on the blue blanket like a spring roll and drooling a little bit against Adora's shoulder, her face relaxed and cheeks red as the morning's heat starts to wash over her too. All her hair is messed up to the side, curls tickling Adora´s face gently; her nose barely visible above the edge of the blanket where she has nuzzled into.

Adora grins, drowsy and ready to go back to sleep, leaning to press a warm kiss against Catra's temple and holding her closer again. She is pretty sure she's wandering on the starts of another dream when the loud knocks against the front door of the manor come back with renewed force, shaking the whole thing on its hinges.

Glimmer finally twitches awake, groaning at the sound as she covers her face with the blanket and kicks to the air, frustrated.

"Ugh," she turns her head slightly to the side, glancing at Adora's tall body wrapped like an octopus across the couch. She is so big that Catra is practically buried below her, almost invisible to the sight. Glimmer narrows her sleepy eyes, huffing softly. "Adora"

"Not my house," Adora mutters, muffled between Catra´s head and the blanket. She hears Glimmer groan again, this time louder, and the characteristic sounds of her friend fighting against the blankets and standing from her comfortable spot on the couch.

"Fuck," Glimmer curses, taking her time to stretch all of her limbs in the middle of the living room before walking to the door, grumbling as the continuous knocking doesn´t seem to stop. at all. "Yes I'm coming! For fucks sake."

Adora hears the soft pad of Glimmer´s bare foot against the marble floor as she reaches the lounge room and the corridor of the door, the twinkle of the white golden doorknob and the heavy pull of the heavier door when Glimmer throws it open. Adora cannot see her from her spot anymore but she can very well

imagine the deeply annoyed frown in Glimmer´s forehead and the scowl on her face as she regards the morning visitor.

“Mermista? What the hell are you doing here?” A bit of fumbling and the shimmering click of Glimmer´s screen being unlocked. Adora closes her eyes again, relieved that it is not Light Hope and that there is no real reason for her to stand up yet. Inside her arms, Catra grumbles a little, still fast asleep. “It's six in the morning, Mermista.”

“You need to come,” Mermista´s voice echoes inside the room, quick and high. Adora frowns at the sound of it, her mind tugging in the edges with a thought. Mermista sounds like she has just run the entire neighborhood on foot, slightly panting and panicking in the seams even.

“What are you talking about? Go where?” Glimmer moves from the front door and closer inside the manor, running her palm over her still halfway sleep face. “Our courses start at ten, today. Hey, hold on–”

Glimmer´s voice trails a little as the sound of another pair of feet walk inside the house, shoes on and rushed across the polished floor and into the living room they are all camping in.

Adora sighs, already feeling how all the delicious sleep abandons her with the small chaos. She still refuses to open her eyes, as much as she can until she feels and smells Mermista´s tropical perfume right above her, hovering over them and Bow like a bird watch.

Adora opens one eye and catches sight of Mermista right in the middle of the living room, her arms at her sides. Except that she looks slightly different to how Adora has always seen her before. Her deep blue hair is undone from her usually pretty braid, falling heavily over her face instead. Her cheeks are sunken, skin almost gray where she has gone frightfully pale. Even her eyes are different, dark irises rimmed in red where she has been crying, making the delicate skin of her eyelids sore and painfully raw.

The sight alone makes Adora freeze in her spot, her heart hammering violently inside her chest. She feels a chill run down her entire spine, making her teeth click violently with shivers, the corners of her eyes prickling with unshed tears.

Adora has seen that kind of face before, on her own when the doctors at the hospital went and told Adora her family was dead; on Catra´s face when her dad died during a rainy night on Thaymor´s Bridge. On every single person that has ever lost someone important to them. A sight of terror and sorrow and unbelievable shock.

"What's happening?" Adora says, immediately awake. Her mind is already running a hundred miles, staring around her to make sure Glimmer, Bow and Catra are actually there with her and then back to Mermista. Even her body is on high alert now, ready to jump and run if needed towards wherever Memrista asks them to for help.

She straightens up on the couch, still holding Catra in her arms who shakes awake too with the sudden movement, her fingers dipping in Adora´s biceps as she blinks awake. Mermista´s black eyes run from Adora´s worried face to Catra grunting awake, and she narrows her eyes, a displeased frown twitching on the corner of her mouth, even above the layers of her sudden sorrow.

"You need to come right now. All of you," Memrmista repeats, holding herself to the strap of her mermaid-like bag so hard that the shimmering strings start to snap slightly. She speaks to everyone but her eyes remain glued to the side of Catra´s face, sucking on her front teeth. "You too, Capellan"

"Good morning to you too, I guess," Catra frowns, pressing her fingers against the sides of her temples to keep at bay the start of a headache.

She mumbles a very soft *Bitch* under her breath but otherwise says nothing more, snapping her eyes away from Mermista´s and from the incoming rays of the sun.

Adora leans absently towards her, resting her nose against the point on Catra´s temple where she knows the migraines always start. Adora´s heart is still beating like a wild horse on the loose, bile gathering on the back of her throat. The room feels so heavy suddenly, so different to five minutes ago when Adora woke up with the sun washing her face and her friends sleeping peacefully around her. She cannot fight off the feeling that her world has suddenly broken in half and it scares the life out of her. The look in Mermista´s face is terrifying her.

"Are you okay?" Bow asks, also completely awake too if a little dizzy with the abrupt awakening. He is searching for his slippers somewhere in the plush carpet, scratching his head as he stares at Mermista too. There is a wrinkle mark on his cheek from the pillow and it is kind of obvious that given the chance he would just flop back to sleep in the next second.

Glimmer is lingering right behind their friend, her fluffy pink nightgown wrinkled and her face completely flustered, crossing her arms over her chest. She has a kind of murderous expression on her face, tapping on the floor with her foot.

"Mermista, I swear to all the stars–"

"Perfuma is dead," Mermista blurts, out of breath. The entire room goes frightfully quiet, even their breaths lowering to a stop.

Glimmer gasps, pressing both of her hands against her mouth, her eyes filling with tears immediately. She takes a step back and trips with the carpet, barely managing to hold herself up by grasping the column of the living room´s entrance.

Bow springs to his feet, his hands and shoulders trembling so badly that he looks about to fall over and pass out; he dated Perfuma for a while, Adora remembers, in the time between Catra´s car accident and Prom, before Glimmer and him finally got together. Adora can see the way Mermista´s words stab him across the chest and shatter him from the inside out.

Adora is about to throw up. She feels the acid in the back of her tongue and her blood rushing inside her ears. She hears Mermista´s words but doesn´t think she can actually understand them for the first couple of seconds, circling in her head like omens until Glimmer´s horrified sob make them lock into place.

Perfuma is dead. Tall, pretty and kind Perfuma who loved to talk about flowers and Scorpia. Who helped Adora through rough patches, who confessed to her in junior year and didn´t even feel sad when Adora turned her down, becoming a kind friend and a person you could always count on. That Perfuma who Adora last saw walking out of the chapel yesterday off Scorpia´s hand, talking about flowers and kindly comforting people still mourning the Mayor.

Perfuma is dead.

Catra is trembling.

Adora looks down and searches for Catra´s face but her head is turned down towards the couch, hidden between the sweetheart curls of her hair and her hand when she presses her palm against her forehead. Adora can hear her breathing deeply several times, can hear and feel the clench of her teeth rubbing with each other, fangs and piercings digging into her lip until it bleeds.

“She is in the flower shop,” Adora hears Mermista say above the rush of blood in her ears, her eyes still gazing upon Catra´s pale cheeks. “You all need to come.”

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It´s chaos, in a different way to the carnival, but chaos after all.

There are several people on the street, basically the entirety of the store owners and their customers gathering on the sidewalks and streets, standing on their tippy toes hoping to catch a single glance of the scene. If there is one thing this town has always

lacked it is empathy. They all cover themselves over their morals and First Ones inheritances, but in reality they do not care about each other, too absorbed in their own lives to care for someone else.

Adora loves this town, with her entire heart she loves it, but this is the first time she realizes just how cold the people she has grown up with can truly be.

Adora stands beyond the yellow tape wrapped outside the flower shop, from street lamp to street lamp, obstructing the walking of curious people so the detective´s department can do their stuff without being interrupted. The coffee shop next door isn´t even closed though, people peeking from the crystal windows and whispering to each other from the tables and chairs. Adora stares at them with hooded eyes before returning her sight towards the open door of the flower shop, gulping heavily. The sun is high in the sky by this point, covering it all in sticky heat.

Glimmer and Bow are at her side, holding each other tightly as they look too. The rest of their friends are here too, scrambled among the crowd. Entrapta is the one further away, lingering in the spaces where people are less gathered and recording in a low voice on her voice tape. They describe the scene and the interactions professionally but Adora has caught their eyes twice through the entire thing. Once when Glimmer parked on the side of the curb and they walked out of the car; second when some noisy woman crashed painfully against Entrapta´s back and Adora snarled at the woman until she apologized to Entrapta. And in both times Adora saw clearly the shadow of sadness in her friend ´s eyes, corners pulled down and cheeks hollow.

Mermista and Sea Hawk alongside his cousins the Star siblings are closer to the street lamps, talking softly among themselves. They all look wrecked, sorrow already pulling down on them heavily. Starla is crying in her brother's arms, her gold and fire hair framing her face and barely hiding her tears, Jewelstar´s arms shaking where he holds her close and trying not to burst into tears at the same time. Tallstar has her arms wrapped around

both of her siblings, her back straight and frowning deeply as Mermista says something to her. She glances towards Entrapta´s direction every once in a while.

Mermista was awfully quiet through the entire trip to the town´s center, her eyes glued to the front of the car except for the moments when Adora caught her glancing at the rear-view mirror, dark eyes and knitted eyebrows. She even was quiet when they arrived, wordlessly guiding them among the labyrinth of people. It was a rare sight, a nerve wracking one, seeing Mermista so quiet so suddenly when she was usually the first one jumping to a crime case like this. Maybe the fact that this time it was one of her friends and not a stranger in a horror novel made it completely different for her.

Adora´s palm is sweating where she holds Catra´s fingers like a lifeline, unable to let go of her for a single second. She can feel their fingers slotting perfectly together, holding to each other so tight that their joints hurt. They are still wearing their night clothes, old sneakers and tangled hairs. Catra is wearing Adora´s varsity jacket over her top and leggings, not even bothering to zip it, and she had thrown a light white sweatshirt over Adora´s chest before walking wordlessly to the car.

The weather is hot but the air is especially chilly today, raising goosebumps on their arms. Catra is distracted though, scanning the group of detectives, the forensic department and the little of the shop they can see until she finds what she is looking for, stealing a gasp from her chest.

Scorpia is sitting outside the flower shop, on an uncomfortable looking and tiny chair someone has placed in the furthest corner possible, between the hyacinths and the open backdoor of a parked ambulance, tucked below a washed out blanket and nothing else. There is a woman in a paramedic uniform speaking to her but she quickly walks away and inside the store after a while, leaving Scorpia all on her own on that sad corner.

Catra bolts for it the second she lays eyes on Scorpia. She squeezes Adora´s hand once and drops it completely right after, slipping through the caution tape swiftly and making her way quickly across the busy front of the store directly towards Scorpia ´s direction. Scorpia sees her coming because her lowered head raises just a little, watching her friend running towards her with dark and hollow eyes.

"Scorpia," Catra gasps, sliding across the floor until she is kneeling in front of Scorpia´s frame, her knees bruised by how quickly she falls against the floor. "Scorpia"

Scorpia blinks back at her, unmoving for a second. She looks terrible, worn down and so, so sad that even Adora from her place cringes with the devastation of it. Scorpia´s shoulders are pulled down, almost completely bent over herself in the tiny chair.

Her short white hair is messed up in every angle, as if she had run her hands several times through it and pulled until her scalp hurt, red patches on her temples and the hairline above her forehead. Her usual pale face is even paler now, almost translucent, from a very light blue to green almost, the veins in her temples and neck clear and pulsing.

She has been crying, it is quite obvious, tear tracks forever stitched to her cheeks, sore eyes and scleras painted in red where she has spent hours and hours weeping. She stares at Catra as if she didn't recognize her for a second until she finally sobs, a very faint whisper leaving her trembling lips.

"Catra," Scorpia says, her chin wobbling uncontrollably where the sadness and the tears start to eat her alive again. "I tried to arrive earlier, I really did. But I made a stop for the roses because Fuma always asked me and I always forgot, you know how I am, you know."

Scorpia chokes around a sob, cleaning her eyes with trembling fingers. Someone has given her a damp towel but it has long ago

gone dry and her skin is still slightly stained in red, dried blood stuck under her fingernails.

"I tried"

"I know," Catra agrees because she doesn´t know what else to say, narrowing her eyes sadly at her friend. She rests her palms carefully over Scorpia´s knees, searching for her sad gaze with hers. "I know you did, Scorpia."

Scorpia breaks around a sob, curling against her own midriff, trying and losing the fight to push back the waves of desolation overtaking her.

She found Perfuma, Adora realizes in a heartbeat, her blood pressure dropping even more; Scorpia must have found her and held her because her clothes are stained in blood, from her knees to her chest, drying against her skin. She looks like a fright against Catra´s smaller form kneeling in front of her, a red beacon of blood trembling inside her friends hands.

"I think I heard her die," Scorpia blurts against a hiccup, wiping tears off her eyes. Catra blinks once, her face blank and cheeks paling even more, all the blood drawn from her pretty face. "I let her die"

"What do you mean?"

"She called me. We– we had a date," each word seems to pain Scorpia deeply but she pushes them out one by one, biting down on her own tongue so hard that she bleeds herself.

"She begged me for help, Catra. She was so scared. I tried to make it on time but when I arrived she– she–" Scorpia´s eyes run towards the open door of the flower shop where the forensic team is walking in and out, carrying several bags coated in bloods.

"Why would anyone do this to her?" Scorpia asks, to Catra, to the air, to nothing. Her face scrunches into a pained expression and

breaks down completely, the most heart wrenching kind of cry leaving her lips.

Catra surges forward from her place on the floor, wrapping her arms around Scorpia´s back and bringing her close into a tight hug, holding her through the worst of it as the cries wreck Scorpia ´s chest.

Adora stares at them from her place, her own tears pooling and falling warm down her cheeks. Shock has started to wash out of her, giving place to the abhorrent and overwhelming realization that Perfuma is actually gone, dead.

For a second there Adora wants nothing more but to run away, to curl back in Glimmer´s couch with Catra against her chest and worry about Halloween or Catra´s birthday or which college she is going to. For a second there Adora craves the need of a normal life, where she can be happy and make Catra happy and where calamity and despair does not meet them at every corner.

Adora blinks back the mist pooling in her eyes, taking a shuddering breath and trying to clear her head as much as she can. She can see Detective Huntara walking out of the flower shop and catching sight of Adora among the crowd. She then looks to the side, noticing Catra as she kneels on the floor and keeps comforting Scorpia's crying body as best as she can. Her sharp face darkness for some reason, lips pressing into a tight line as she beelines across the sidewalk and directly in front of Adora, stopping just a few inches away from the warning tape.

“Montenegro,” she says as a greeting, frowning down at Adora.

A chill runs down Adora´s back, all the nerve endings on her skin standing on point. “Huntara”

Huntara´s eyes study the crowd around them and then come back to Adora. She wraps her hand of the yellow tape and pulls it up, pointing with her chin towards the flower shop. “Come with me”

Tension locks Adora´s muscles in place, apprehension running down her veins. She looks at Catra´s back and back to Huntara, her hands twitching to the sides and in the same place, not moving a single inch.

“Catra is just comforting Scorpia”

“This is not about her,” Huntara mutters, her teeth clenched together. There is a hint of urgency in her voice, beyond the professionalism she tries to keep in control off. She nods towards the flower shop again, sharper than before. “Be quiet and come”

Adora closes her mouth tightly, throwing a quick side glance around her. Her friends have scrambled around the crowd, comforting each other and definitely not paying attention to whatever Adora is doing. Adora hums and walks below the raised yellow tape, narrowing her eyes when several people turn to look at her the second she steps foot in the scene.

“The entire town watching is not quiet enough?” Adora whispers, unable to hold back the hint of sarcasm from her voice.

Huntara ignores her, resting her big hand over Adora´s shoulder and guiding her across the limit of the sidewalk towards the corridor that leads to the back of the store and not the front door.

Adora walks in silence, somehow feeling as if she had been taken prisoner from one second to the other. She tries to calm herself about whatever is happening by breathing deeply, just as her cousin Mara taught her once after the accident, when Adora had so many panic attacks that she was unable to sleep for a week straight.

Catra catches sight of Huntara taking Adora away because she snaps her head towards them, still holding Scorpia but staring directly at Adora´s face. Her eyes are wide and alarmed, confusion and a million questions swimming inside them.

Adora shrugs softly, trying to relax her face so as to not worry Catra more, but she can´t also fight the horrible feeling gathering

in her belly and threatening to choke her down, fearful of whatever she is guided to see taking hold of her emotions.

Catra, Scorpia and the crowd disappear from Adora´s line of sight as she walks across the backyard corridor, even the sounds drowning here. There are several bags of dirt and plant fertilizer to the sides, spilling slightly on the floor and making it mush where Adora steps, staining her white sneaker in dark substance. For some reason that calls her attention, more than it should, because she stares at them even as she remains walking with Huntara by her ankles.

She is just about to reach the backdoor of the store when she realizes the stains sticking to her soles and shoes is not mud or dirt but blood, clotted and halfway dried blood that had soaked through the ground and that lingers under Adora´s feet like some kind of scarlet mark.

Adora fights against the sudden need to throw up, her heart skyrocketing inside her chest. She snaps her head up just as Huntara pushes the door open for her, pushing her softly past the frame and into the flower shop.

Adora´s first instinct is to run. The second one is to scream. The third one and the one that wins is to press her hand against her mouth and bend over herself, retching around her dry throat and burning eyes filled with tears.

The smell is terrible, something only someone that has either worked in a slaughterhouse or goes hunting in the forest would ever begin to understand. It lingers in the air like its own kind of curse, overwhelming even among the sweet smells of the flowers and the long ago consumed incense that Perfuma so much liked to lit around the shop.

Adora closes her eyes until she sees sparks, fighting the wave of nausea in her throat. She can feel Huntara´s palm against her back and she tries to focus on that to straighten up again, taking

several breaths before she turns to see the scene in front of them fully.

Perfuma has been spread over the flowers like some kind of painting you would find in a dark fairytale book. It has been on purpose, flowers picked over and apart until they formed a standing bed against the shelves of the wall, surrounding from her bare feet to her arms and head, crowning her with the white petals of tulips that wither and fall as the heat of the day start to dry them out.

Her pink dress is perfectly in place and completely soaked in red, from the hem of the neckline to the waist, its own kind of crimson flowers bloom where she bled to death. All her blonde hair has been cut off her head, torn and taken away and, unlike the carefully crafted display she is lying into, it looks almost rough, scissored strands and patches of her scalp where it looks as if it had been ripped from the root, leaving her scalp tinted in red too and completely bald.

Adora cannot make out her face as it lies covered by a crude mask, done with loose pieces of tree trunk, twigs and leather and moss and even parts of the very same flowers Perfuma tended to with so much care.

Knitted and sewn together until it all formed the crooked and mocking shape of a deer mask. Long muzzle and soft ears and everything in between, something you would find on an underground carnival or made for a pagan ritual, covering Perfuma´s busted face where the crack of her skull has busted from her forehead to her nose and chin into a gaping wound.

For the split of a second, as Adora stares at Perfuma´s unmoving and dead body, her brain cannot comprehend how she is standing against the wall, defying gravity, until she makes off the wires crossing Perfuma´s limbs. Across her shoulders, upper and forearms, palms, waist, ribcage and legs, twisting and forming knots over themselves where they stab her flesh and hold her up and against the wall like thorn branches.

Adora breaths deep, the taste of blood and decay and flies already flying around lingering on the back of her throat. She is shivering from head to toe, holding herself to Huntara´s arm, the only thing managing to hold her up right now. Huntara is looking at her with an indescribable expression on her face, studying Adora´s face as the latter takes in the brutality of the scene.

Like this, Huntara can see the exact second where Adora´s eyes finally finds the words scribbled on the wallpaper next to Perfuma, in shaking handwritten and done with the very same blood that seems to have been soaking the entire ground, a message or a threat or the scribble of madness of maybe all of it all at once.

*Adora,* it reads over and over again, *Adora. Adora. Adora. Adora. Adora. Adora. Adora. Adora. Adora. Adora. Adora. Adora. Adora. Adora. Adora. Adora. Adora. Adora. Adora. Adora.*

*Pretty hare.*

Adora´s eyes widen and her breath shudders on her throat, the memory of last night and an unknown call overtaking her mind completely.

*Pretty hare,* the person at the other side of the phone had said, whispered almost like a secret. *Pretty hare, I´ll leave a gift for you.*

"I need you to be very honest and tell me what the fuck is going on, Montenegro," Huntara says between clenched teeth, watching Adora´s pupils shrinks inside her blue irises and her face paling, sweat covering her forehead and temples. She is shaking, Huntara can feel it, so bad that she might actually pass out on Huntara´s watch.

"I don´t know," Adora tangles with her own tongue, unable to say or do something else but to shiver and let tears stain her face.

What else she is supposed to say? She brings a hand towards her cheeks and tries to clean them off her eyes but they are non-

stopping. She wrinkles her nose and scratches the bridge with blunts nails, unable to breath well above the snot and the tears.

"I–"

"I have two dead people in two days and your name is written on the walls with blood, Adora. Make this easy for me alright?" Huntara´s voice is cutting, sharp in all edges and the tone makes Adora flinch and curl inside herself, anxiety eating her bones from the inside out

"I–" Adora feels like the world is spinning, out of its axis and out of control, her entire world upside down from one night to the other.

She glances at Huntara and realizes the way she is looking at her, expecting almost, as if Adora had all the fucking answers to this fucked up situation and not as if Adora was three steps closer to puke and fall down on the floor crying.

"Huntara, I don´t know. What the fuck do you want me to say? I don´t know what the fuck is going on!"

Adora´s voice raises, high pitched and scared, echoing inside the entire flower shop and even calling the attention of some of the forenses still working across the murder scene. By this point Adora is shaking so bad that her knees give up underneath her, tethering her to the ground.

She cannot shake off Perfuma´s face from her mind, overlapping with the Perfuma Adora knows and cares about, the one she has laughed with and go to parties with and who is now hanging from her beloved shop like some kind of fucked up martyr and not a person with dreams, someone who was loved.

Impotence runs cold as ice down Adora´s veins, the realization that this was done in her name hitting her in the chest like a war hammer, breaking all of her bones and leaving her bare and shaking on the bloodied floor.

Huntara helps her sit down on a spare chair near to the counter, her back covering the murder scene for the split of a second. It doesn´t matter anymore anyway, it is seared to Adora´s eyelids now, stitched to her thoughts and memories and forever dug deep in her nightmares. She is never going to be able to think about Perfuma and not remember every single detail of what she saw today.

"Has someone contacted you?" Huntara presses, lowering her voice. She is slightly kinder now, even for her, keeping her voice in control to not freak Adora even more. Adora bites into her cheek until she tastes blood on her gums, digging her nails over the fabric of her sport shorts.

"Someone called me last night," Adora gasps, fumbling with her phone for a few seconds and handing it to Huntara, the screen placed on the number that had called her last night, when she felt like the very world was staring at her through the night. "Unknown number"

Huntara presses her mouth into a tight line, taking a photograph of Adora´s screen with her own phone before returning it back to her trembling hands. "And?"

"They said–" Adora wets her bottom lip with her tongue, wrinkles her nose and she tries to focus. The call is clear as day on her mind, freezing cold. "They called me hare. They said they were going to leave me a gift." Adora gasps, looking again at the writing on the wall. She looks at Huntara with wide eyes, her pupils shrinking into pinpoints. "Huntara–

"Be quiet," Huntara snaps, resting both of her hands over Adora´s shoulders. She throws a side glance to the forensic team, making sure they are all focused on their shit and not their conversation before speaking again. Her voice is very low, barely audible for Adora´s ears.

"Listen to me very well, Adora. I don´t know what the fuck is going on but I want you to stay out of sight for now, do you

understand? If people find out about the writing things will get very ugly and you know the people of this town have an ability to find out about this stuff.”

Huntara´s eyes are very heavy, hovering against Adora like a thousand swords. Adora gulps, nodding without a word. Huntara ´s eyes narrow,

“I guess it won't be worth telling you to be quiet about this with your friends but don´t be stupid. Be smart about the people you think you trust.”

Adora´s mouth falls open, dread falling over her like thunder. She doesn´t want to look deeper to what Huntara is implying but it is loud between them, a theory that chills to the bones. That someone Adora cares about might be playing a very sick game of the hunter and the prey.

Adora grinds her teeth until she feels her molars protest under the pressure, her jaw protesting painfully. She cannot shake off the feeling that Huntara might know more than what she is letting through.

“Huntara, what is happening?”

“I don´t know, and even if I did I wouldn´t tell you,” Huntara says, brutally honest. She stands up on her feet, straightening her back. “I called Light Hope, she must be here already. I want you to go with her.”

“I can´t,” Adora rushes to say, panic flaring in her chest. Huntara narrows her eyes, obviously not happy of being contradicted. Adora chews on her words, trying to make herself understand as best as possible. “My friends are here, Glimmer and Bow. And my girlfriend, I can´t leave her now. I– if something happens to her–”

Adora´s voice trails off, tangled around a sob. Huntara is still locking at her but instead of comprehending her eyes seem to darken at the mention of Catra, her mouth tilting into a snarl.

Before Adora can start to wonder about it Huntara is already walking away, waving her hand dismissively.

"Do whatever you want but stay with people,"

Huntara stops halfway towards the murder scene where a group of people have started to lower Perfuma off the shelves and into a black body bag. Her head rolls to the side at some point, clouded and void eyes staring back at Adora, speechless. Huntara seems to think something over because her eyes wrinkle in the corners, lips retracting over her gums.

"*Other* people besides your Capellan girl."

Adora opens her mouth to protest, to scream even or to curse Huntara when she understand the underlying tone on Huntara´s voice, but a young detective is already seizing her from the shoulder, pulling from her and all the way back across the backyard and the corridor until she is again from the murder scene and back on the sidewalk, the light on the midday sun blinding her for a moment.

Adora blinks against the light, taking on her surroundings with narrowed eyes. There are even more people now, if that is even possible, gathering around the limits of the flower shop and frowning deeply, sharing theories and stories with each other.

Glimmer and Bow are on the far end, next to Glimmer´s car; their faces light up when they see Adora again, waving at her and at the car, hurrying her to go with them again.

Light Hope is there too, just as Huntara predicted. She is standing so close to the flower shop, right at the opposite side of where Adora is, that if she were to give three steps she would be in front of the flower shop´s door.

She is not looking at the crows of people or at the sad scene happening around them, her eyes glued instead to the side of Adora´s face the second she catches sight of her.

She is holding her phone in her hand, squeezing it so hard between her fingers that the poor thing might just break in two. She doesn´t point or wave to Adora, instead holding her gaze with a stare so heavy that Adora knows exactly what she means.

*´Come here, right now´*

Catra is still next to Scorpia, at Adora´s other side, two opposite paths. She is looking at some empty point in the distance, frowning deeply; Adora follows her gaze but there is nothing on her line of sight but the street lamp and empty sidewalk.

Catra´s face is grim and tired, lightened only when she turns around and sees Adora again. Still, it is tragic, sadness written on every single corner and pretty freckle of her beautiful face. Her eyes are full of questions, eyeing Adora as if she didn´t know what to do or how to move right now. Her hands twitch at her side where she is not holding Scorpia´s shoulders, desperate to run and hold Adora inside her arms but she remains in her place, waiting for Adora to take the decision herself.

Adora exhales and gives a step forward, still unsure when the heavy smell of copal hits her directly in the nose, covering it all with white smoke. She hadn´t noticed it before, too deep inside her head and what she had just seen, but she notices now, the reason too why probably there are so many more people gathered around now.

Prime is walking in circles outside the flower store. He is wearing a long tunic, pristine white and embroidered in silver thread, brushing the floor where a splash of blood has long ago dried off.

His palms are pressed against each other and his head is bent down, praying and chanting loudly, some kind of hymn that Adora cannot understand. Still, there seems to be a hidden grin in the edge of his mouth every time he walks by, enjoying the art of the ritual and the eyes and voices of the people chanting alongside him.

Two acolytes are walking behind him, of Adora´s age probably, swinging a vase of incense in their hands and lit candles that drip hot wax on their fingers.

Adora stares at him in silence, not daring to make a single sound that might call for his attention, only watching him as he gives one, two, four tight circles between the rest of the crowd and Adora. The humming of the town seems almost borderline insane, making Adora´s head spin.

Huntara walks out of the front door of the flower shop, exhaling when she sees him there. But instead of annoyance she almost seems relieved.

"Priest Prime, finally," she signals to the inside with her hands, guiding him with open arms. "They are about to take her to the pathologist. If you can, before they close the bag."

"Of course," Prime says, looking up finally, a smile stretched on his lips. He doesn´t even look sad. "Allow me to bid the poor thing goodbye with the deity's blessing. In the name of the people."

Adora flinches, her entire body recoiling at the exchange. Huntara doesn´t even notice her there, stepping inside to show Prime the body. Prime however does see her, from the corner of his eyes.His own green irises shimmer at the sight of her, bright under the sunlight.

He starts walking inside the flower shop but still makes a point of turning his head to Adora, nodding at her so softly that it feels unnervingly intimate.

"Adora," he greets her, grinning.

Before Adora can say something he turns his head to the other side, looking at Light Hope among the sea of people and nodding too. The greeting makes Light Hope´s entire face brightens, her eyes shimmering as she bows down to the Priest, hand held together as her praying doubles down in intensity. It makes Adora sick.

“Scorpia, we need you to come,” the same young detective that had guided Adora out starts saying, calling for Adora´s attention again. Catra is standing now, a few feet away from the ambulance, her arms crossed over her abdomen, staring at the detective and Scorpia without saying a word. “We need your declaration.”

“She already gave it,” Catra butts in, her face sour. The detective ignores her completely, holding Scorpia´s exhausted shoulders in theirs.

“Come on, it's for the record. Perfuma’s parents will be there too”

Scorpia´s eyes are miles away, looking at nothing. She doesn´t even seem to comprehend the detective´s words but she nods anyway, standing up from her precarious seat and following them back inside the ambulance.

Catra steps back, anger obvious in her face but not lashing out, just staring as Scorpia walks away from her without even looking back.

There is a piece of cloth over the seat of the ambulance, wrinkled and left there like an afterthought, right in front of Scorpia´s eyes when she sits on the side. Scorpia leans towards it and picks it up between her hands, rubbing what seems to be the edge of pink fabric between her thumbs. Adora cannot make the shape of it from this angle but it almost seems to be an apron, embroidered in the pockets and soaked in red blood too, hanging sadly from Scorpia´s grip.

“Oh, Perfuma. Oh.”

Scorpia holds her breath, exhales, inhales again and falls against the pink fabric that was Perfuma´s, pressing her face against the cotton as she lets out a gut wrenching cry, so loud and heartbreaking that it echoes across the entire sidewalk and the very street, chilling everybody to the bones.

Adora´s breath hitches, her ribcage hurting so much that it might as well rip open and spill all of her blood and organs onto the floor. She runs her eyes from the ambulance to Catra, searching for her face frantically. Catra is already looking back, her palms pressed tightly over her chest and her eyes wide, panic flooring inside of them as she looks back at Adora like she wanted to scream and cry and run to her arms but didn´t know if she is allowed too. They are separated by meters that feel so long and Light Hope´s eyes are still burning on Adora´s back.

Adora cannot handle it. She hears Scorpia crying for Perfuma, her best friend and her love, and stares at Catra standing alone at the other side of the sidewalk and she cannot handle it.

Adora marches across detectives, deputies and paramedics directly towards Catra, dodging elbows and feet and angry stares when she crashes against them without caring to say sorry back, too overwhelmed by feelings to even begin to care.

She walks and walks until she reaches Catra´s side, cradles her face in her palms and kisses her, there in front of everyone to see, intimate and long and full of desperation and terror coiling in her veins.

"I love you." Adora whispers against Catra´s mouth, sore and broken, trembling on all edges, frantic to hold Catra so close that they might as well fuse into one, cradled next to Adora´s heart where neither pain nor sorrow can´t ever reach her. "I love you so much."

"What–?" Catra gasps against Adora´s lips, tries to speak but fails when Adora presses her tongue past her teeth again and against the roof of her mouth, kissing her as if the very air would fail her if they were to step apart.

Adora drinks on Catra´s sore moan against her mouth, digs her fingers on Catra´s nape and brings nearer, pressing their chests together until their very hearts are hammering against each other, trotting and jumping with each brush of their lips.

Adora cannot phantom it, the thought of living what Scorpia is going through, of living a single second without Catra, the nightmare of watching Catra gone, the floor soaked in blood and her precious eyes void. She cannot live with the thought, not again. She cannot even begin to describe the despair and the fear.

So she holds Catra´s bones against hers and pours all her devotion in her throat until they are both shaking and angry murmurs that Adora also ignores are rising around them. Because after all, how dare they? How dare the town judge them for embracing each other?

Catra exhales, brushing the tips of her fingers against the angle of Adora´s jaw, her cheeks rose pink and eyes bright but her expression is sad, weary as she lets Adora hold her in her arms.

“What's happening Adora?”

“Adora!”

Back in the crowd, among the disapproving chattering of some of the people staring at them, Adora can make out Light Hope´s voice, angry and loud as she calls for her.

Adora cannot see her face but she knows pretty well how she looks right now, face flushed and eyes wide with anger; there have been few times where Adora saw Light Hope actually angry but this must be absolutely one of them. A voice that sounds like wind through bramble branches and raw skin promising nothing good under the colorful windows of altars.

Catra´s jaw goes slack and her hold relaxes, trying and failing to step back when Adora only holds her tighter in return.

Another ´ *Adora´* rings on the crowd but Adora ignores it, pressing her nose and lips against Catra´s temple instead, gently but firmly guiding Catra towards the opposite side, where Glimmer and Bow are still waiting for them in the car.

And if Light Hope calls her name again Adora is not one to turn and look back. She might regret it later, but she is not going to leave her friends´ – *Catra's* – side right now.

"I don't know." Adora whispers to Catra only, kissing her mouth and then her freckled knuckles with shivering lips. She avoids the looks of the people of the town, focusing on her hold around Catra´s waist and the open door of Glimmer´s car. "Stay with me."

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They are all in Glimmer's house, gathered around the huge dinner table. There are plates of fruit, little cakes and other candies in front of them placed by the maids but none of them pay attention to them.

Glimmer and Bow are sitting side by side, flopped against the tall chairs. Bow looks impossibly sad, cleaning his teary eyes every once in a while, his scleras long ago gone red. Glimmer looks more angry than anything, biting into her cuticles and frowning at nothing, standing and sitting down again when kicking something in the quiet room doesn´t help with her rage, cursing under her breath several times when the realization of what happened hits her again.

Entrapta in the far end of the table, scribbling on a tablet and picking on a small cake but they are not eating, nor recording on their voice tape or speaking about some new experiment of theirs. Their eyes are sad and hooded, crestfallen and completely thrown aback. It is weird, it is sad not hearing Entrapta suddenly burst into an excited chattering about some of the things that most interest them. It´s a dead give away of just how deep their sorrow runs.

Sea Hawk is in the small couch next to the huge window, thrown lazily from side to side with his arm over his eyes. He was quiet too, which for Sea Hawk was a huge deal. He had tried to hum a

sailor's chant about mourning and letting go off friends but even that had fallen flat under the heavy stare of everyone else so he had just thrown himself on that spot and not moved unless it was absolutely required. His mud stained boots were all over the pristine white fabric but not even Glimmer had the desire to fight it right now.

Adora is sitting on the opposite side of Glimmer and Bow, legs spread under the table, feet tapping over the floor and head rolled on the high backrest, staring at the twinkling ceiling painted as lilac constellations above their heads until she feels the blood flow make her dizzy and her eyes strain from counting absently the little stars. She has changed from her night clothes into something lighter but everything feels wrong right now, from the sleeveless turtleneck to the gray cargo pants, the brush of the fabric over her skin and the tight hair tie on her head keeping her hair off her face and making her head pulse.

Her arms are thrown at the sides of the chair too, one on the armrest digging blunt fingernails over the expensive leather; the other over the chair next to hers absently tangling her fingers around the curls falling over Catra´s back.

Catra sits with her knees against her chest and her soles firmly over the seat of the chair, back coiled over itself as she stares at some point on the wall. Her nose wrinkles every once in a while, perfect sharp eyeliner even as she smudges her finger underneath her eyes several times. She hasn't said a word since the flower shop, standing tense as a bow´s cord next to Adora as the rest of the group started to make their way inside Glimmer´s house too.

She hasn´t said anything but Adora kissed her breathless on the changing room of one of Glimmer´s spare bedrooms, pressing her against the floral wallpaper and her body, voice and lips trembling as Adora tried and failed to wash away the look in Scorpia´s face when the realization that Perfuma was really gone hit her in the bones. Adora kissed her there, her hands tangled on dark curls and fingertips against the angle of her jaw and the base of her ear, deep and warm.

Adora would have stayed right there and then with Catra for the rest of her life, kissing her until neither could breath, tangling their limbs together just to feel their skins together and their bones crackling with the other, their breaths mingling and hearts beating so close that Adora could be sure Catra was actually there, alive and well and in her arms. They would have done it if the situation wasn´t so fucked up, if the air didn´t smell like tears and if the whole group of friends wasn´t waltzing around the manor trying to comfort each other. If they weren't crying and scared.

Instead, Adora sits as close as she possibly can to Catra and breathes deep several times, filling her nostrils with her smell and feeling her warmth on the tip of her fingertips, regarding the mourning room with a heavy chest.

And then there is Mermista, the caller and organizer of the group ´s meeting. She is standing at the main spot of the table, chair long ago forgotten, her hands firmly pressed over the table. She was walking around the huge room and driving everyone slightly crazy until a few minutes ago, when her mind seemed to reach a conclusion to some problem she had not spoken about yet. Her face is very serious as she regards the entire table, makeup messed up from where she was crying before she violently cleaned her face off the tears. Like this she almost looks like a commander or at least a very pissed off person, her ears bright red and eyes deeply.

She opens her mouth but the air seems to fail her because she scowls, gulping heavily and trying again. “And Scorpia?”

“At her apartment, she called Catra a little ago. The detectives dropped her off after they got her declaration” Glimmer says, a tremble in her voice.

She looks about as pissed off as Mermista but she has the decency to soften her voice as she speaks, trying as much as she can to be comforting with the rest of her friends.

”Entrapta will stay with her for now.”

Entrapta raises their head at the mention of their name, eyes flashing. They nod, very sure and firm of Glimmer´s words, her back straight as the sense of responsibility falls over them.

Mermista, however, doesn´t seem in the least convinced because she wrinkles her nose, eyeing Entrapta out of the corner of her eye and back at the table without speaking to Entrapta directly.

“Is that a good idea?” she asks, unable or uncaring to hide the uncertainty in her voice.

All pride of taking care of their friend when Scorpia needs it the most rolls out of Entrapta´s body like a blow to the chest, their shoulders curling and face falling.

Adora sees the immediate change from her spot and can´t help but feel a pang of sadness towards Entrapta and annoyance at Mermista, turning to look at the latter with knitted eyebrows.

Catra is already three steps further from Adora though, her demeanor changing completely at Mermista´s words. She lets her feet fall back on the cold floor and straightens on the chair, throwing her long hair behind her shoulder with an expression so dark on her face that the entire table cringes when they look at her.

“Entrapta knows Scorpia better than any of you. They´ve been friends for longer than you *allowed* them to join your little group and they are perfectly capable of looking after Scorpia.” Catra snaps, her fangs catching with her bottom lip every time by how quickly she speaks. Somehow Catra frowns even more, baring her teeth at Mermista. “And Scorpia is not stupid. She won´t do anything stupid either. She lost her partner, she just needs to rest and stay away from the people of this fucking town and their fucking noisiness.”

The table is tense yet several people are nodding at Catra´s words, agreeing wordlessly. Bow and Glimmer and Adora, even

Sea Hawk on his diva spot on the couch.

Entrapta´s face lightens up a little bit again, too, staring at the side of Catra´s face with something much like gratitude on their eyes before turning back to look at their plate.

Mermista is immovable even with Catra´s words, huffing at her when the explanation isn´t enough to please her. She crosses her arms over her chest, still standing and pointing her chin out with an incredulous look on her eyes.

“Hmm,” is the only thing she mutters, glaring at Catra from head to toe.

Catra goes tense immediately and for extension so does Adora, shaking herself from the heaviness on her bones and preparing to jump in if needed. The mood is already completely rotten, by all means the least everyone needs right now is for their friends to throw themselves at each other's neck. Adora has never been very good at keeping the piece but she will try.

“Do you have an opinion, Mermista?” Catra spits, fired up and hissing. Even Entrapta looks up again, regarding the interacting quietly. Bow raises his hands in front of him, a calming motion that goes completely unattended by neither Memrista nor Catra.

Mermista looks like she thinks about it for a second, narrowing her eyes at Catra before snapping her head away from Catra´s face, even as they are several inches away.

“We'll see about that.”

“That doesn´t even make sense,” Catra grumbles between clenched teeth, digging her nails against the polished surface of Glimmer´s table.

Adora rests her hand over Catra´s shoulder and squeezes once, a silent conversation running between them when Catra glances at her out of the corner of her eye. Nobody catches it but it works

because Catra flops back on the backrest of the chair, chewing angrily at her cheek.

Little by little the tension starts to dissipate and sorrow makes its comeback between all the friends. The only sound between them is the old grandfather clock on the corridor of the manor and their elaborated breaths, silence so heavy that it feels like a whole other presence too.

It's unbearable and it freaks Glimmer out because she surges forwards after a while, leaning towards Mermista´s spot.

"Mermista, I really feel like either drink a whole bar or go to sleep for a hundred years so could you please get to the point and tell us why you called us here again?"

"I´ve already told you in the phone, we need to discuss what happened." Mermista slams her fist against the table, not even cringing when the crystal cut swan decoration in the middle tether dangerously to the side. "Hordak is dead and then two days later Perfuma is gone too? Violently and displayed like a freak show too? That's too much of a coincidence for my liking. I don´t like anything about this."

Adora frowns, confusion making its way inside her mind as she understands Mermista´s words. She drops her arms from the armrests and from Catra´s back and leans against the table, searching Mermista´s black eyes with hers.

Adora had not told anyone about what the murder scene looked like except for Glimmer, Bow and Catra on their way back to the Manor and she doubts any of them had stopped to chatter about it with the rest of the group.

Adora risks a glance towards Glimmer and Bow and finds the same confusion written all over their faces, so she knows she is correct. Catra on her side looks absolutely pissed, something coiling dangerous on the back of her tongue.

“How do you know Perfuma was– how she was?” Adora asks, voice firm but still confused.

She looks at Mermista with weary eyes, heartbeat speeding up inside her chest. But Mermista only groans and rolls her eyes as if Adora had said the stupidest thing possible, running her fingers through her navy blue hair.

“All the town knows by now, Adora, don´t be so innocent.” She says, blinking slowly. “Laid over her flowers with a deer mask like some kind of fucked up ritual. Some guys from the forensics team told another and now the entire town knows. It's all over the local news and the neighbors chat.” Mermista finishes, raising her phone.

Adora feels like she should be offended but all she can feel inside of her chest is mild panic and sadness, knowing that somehow this tragedy had found its way into another gossip among neighbors.

There is also something else, something that Mermista had not mentioned and that Adora doesn't know if she should. The apparition of Adora´s name written in blood on the flower walls.

The image still makes Adora want to throw up, raising fear inside the darkest part of her heart. She had only said that last part to Catra and Catra alone.

And not even Catra had known what to say, sitting on the small couch of the changing room with her eyes yards away and her cheeks coated in tears, fear shaking her up completely as Adora kneeled between her legs and she embraced Adora against her chest.

But if one forense had spoken, maybe another had done so too and then Adora would definitely be locked up for good by Light Hope and isolated from everyone else. And there is no world where Adora would leave Catra on her own right now.

“That´s it?” Adora inquiries, hoping not to sound too eager. She sucks as an actress though because Mermista narrows her eyes at her, a new flame raising inside of her.

“Is there something else you´d like to share with us, Adora?” Mermista asks, very slowly.

The rest of the group turns their eyes to her, waiting too. Catra growls next to Adora, a very clear curse and a yell starting to form on the tip of her tongue.

Adora shoots her hand towards her immediately from under the table, tangling their fingers together.

“No,” Adora says, both to Catra and Mermista. She narrows her eyes too, weariness downing over her.

“Hmm. I'm keeping my eye on you.” Mermista muters, tapping her fingers against the table.

Adora stares at Mermista and beats herself mentally from even thinking about but the whole thing is suddenly so fucking weird and uncomfortable that makes her wonders just why Mermista is acting this way.

Adora is not the only one noticing it because Glimmer is frowning too now, studying Mermista´s posture with the kind of look you never want Glimmer Bright to shoot at you. Doubtful and annoyed.

“You are acting very weird.” Glimmer clenches her teeth, pulling from the sleeves of her black jumper, a striking contrast with her bubblegum pink hair and lilac eyes.

“I want to uncover the truth, Glimmer!” Mermista shouts, throwing her arms towards the air exasperated. “It is obvious we are facing a slasher, a serial killer! And the way it has done the last two murders? It's obvious, *obvious* , this is not its first kill. We are talking about someone that has killed before and enjoyed it!

Someone that thinks what it's doing is just and takes pleasure in it. Very few people can fit that description."

"People of our town, Mermista?" Glimmer tries to chuckle off but even her seems thrown off suddenly.

"Oh, Etheria is full of crazy people, Glimmer you know that."

"Mermista, watching all the Mermistery movies does not make you capable of resolving an actual murder," Adora cuts in, annoyed.

She doesn't want to be here and she is pretty sure that nobody else wants to be discussing this stuff either. She wants to lock herself on a roof and sleep this off with Catra in her arms and not thinking about anything; by Glimmer and Bow´s expressions she knows they want the same. Entrapta looks deeply uncomfortable and Sea Hawk is just there for Mermista as always.

But Mermista won´t give up, instead pointing at Adora with her finger so sharply that it might as well send daggers in her direction.

"Uh, we´ve all done it before, Adora."

"Watching true crime documentaries and trying to guess who the murderer is, isn´t the same as real life." Glimmer agrees, nostrils flaring. Mermista chuckles, her cheeks spotted in red where emotions are getting the better of her.

"Says who? You? Suspicious."

"It is literally common sense!" Glimmer yells, covering her hands with her palms. Her groans between her fingers, taking several deep breaths before looking back up again, visibly calming herself as she regards Mermista and her conspirations once more. "Find. I give in. Talk Mermista, before my nerves explode."

Mermista grins, triumphant. She straightens up with her hands behind her back and starts walking from side to side of the table with a grim voice. "First we need to study our victims."

She leans down and grasps something from behind her, placed on the seat of her chair, slamming it back on the table with too much force. Adora jumps at the sound, widening her eyes.

Mermista has placed something that looks very clearly like a necropsy photograph of Hordak´s body, head in a table, body on the other, the staples with which the mortician closed him back up after the inspection shimmering under the sunny light from the windows. It´s very grotesque and it makes the whole table cringe.

"Hordak, Mayor of the Town." Mermista recites, pointing at the photographs. "He was corrupt and an asshole and stood in that position for far too long, always buying the elections and filling his pockets with the town´s money. It's common knowledge that he made deals with a lot of people to hide their dirty little secrets and chose himself scapegoats that took the blame instead. Maybe a deal went wrong, maybe he made the wrong person very angry. Maybe, just maybe, someone found out that we has going to leave town and move to Eternia to become senator and whoever was did not liked that he would fuck away so decided to make him pay first."

Mermista finishes, out of breath and grinning even as her speech lingers on the air of the room. Everyone looks at her, astonished and definitely not grinning. Bow blinks several times, opening and closing his mouth as he looks at Mermista..

"How on earth do you know all that?" He asks, his voice splintering with wonder. Mermista´s grin just grows as she picks another pair of papers from the chair and extends them to him, nodding.

"Because of this."

It´s a series of files, neatly placed together and even color coded. Adora cannot read them from her place or make sense of them but by the amount of letters in them and the official seals and signatures in every single one it must be some kind of report or

acceptance of something. Mermista had said Hordak was going to become senator so Adora guessed that implied a shit ton of paperwork and people involved in the change and by the saturation of the ink it didn´t look very old.

"I didn´t know that Hordak was going to leave," Bow says under his breath, frowning at the papers before passing them to Glimmer and the rest of the table. He scratches the side of his head, his sweater rising with the movement when he tilts his head in confusion. "Who was going to be in charge then? Elections aren´t for another three years."

"Nobody knew, Bow! That's the point," Mermista exclaims, tapping against the papers furiously. "Only someone either working with him or with access to these files could have known."

Glimmer frowns as she leans back on the chair, taking a peek at Mermista´s chair until she sees where all these papers are coming from. Glimmer´s eyebrows skyrocket on her forehead, her jaw going slack with the surprise when she recognizes the expensive white leather of the briefcase and the embroidered gold letters on the side, an item she has seen dozens of times before.

"That's my mom's briefcase." Glimmer points out, almost shrieking. "Mermista, where did you get it?"

"Uh, your house is literally a castle and your security is shit." Mermista shrugs, crossing her arms. "I just wandered inside her Office to see if there was something of use."

"I didn´t allow you in my house to snoop around!" Oh, now Glimmer is almost yelling. Adora bites down her lip nervously, scooching on her chair. Catra is looking too but she seems deeply bored, playing with Adora´s fingertips over her bouncing knee. "Why were you searching for my mother´s office in the first place?

"Duh. Didn't she just become Mayor in his place? And wasn't she like her right hand in this electoral campaign?" Mermista points to

a paragraph on the paper Glimmer is holding, taping in the words with her black nail. “He was going to put some of his minions in charge just after Halloween and push Angella to the side”

“And you think my mother *killed* him for that?!”

“Well–”

“Mermista, be very careful with what you are going to say.” Glimmer says between clenched teeth, closing her hands into fists at either side of the chair. Bow shifts uncomfortably between Mermista and Glimmer, pushing himself flat against the chair.

Mermista scoffs, narrowing her eyes. “Told as a true accomplice.”

“You know what–?”

“They are hunting us, Glimmer.” Mermista cuts her off, her voice falling from that detective-like tone into something so much darker, lower and grave like a tomb. It shuts Glimmer right up, her mouth closing with an audible click. “Us, this group specifically. I still don't get the relation between Hordak and Perfuma but I know there is something. I just can´t pinpoint it.”

Adora shrinks on her chair, suddenly out of breath, but neither Mermista nor Glimmer notice it. That's good because suddenly all color has drained from Adora´s face.

*Adora. Adora. Adora.*

The wall had said, over and over and over again with her friend´s blood. Adora glances at her phone over the table, biting on her lip, but the little thing remains quiet.

She had meant to call Mara at some point of the day but she had not gathered enough guts yet to hear the same voicemail and the cut off call. On the other hand, Light Hoe had called like a madman after Adora slipped away from her in the town but otherwise nobody had called her again.

Doesn´t mean Adora didn´t jump with every single time it chimed with a new notification.

“Again, you cannot know that.” Glimmer is saying, pinching the bridge of her nose with her fingers.

“I can´t? Now we have Perfuma who would literally cry if we even stood over an ant. Unlike Hordak, she literally had no enemies, she was good with everyone and everyone liked her in return. Good person, role model, a general sweetheart.”

Mermista gasps around the words, suddenly out of breath. Her face is pale too but her knuckles are red when she slams her fist over the table again, furious. It is clear just how deeply Perfuma´s dead had affected her too. They were an unlikely friendship but an old one after all.

“Why kill her then? Kill her and made her look like some kind of princess from a fucked up fairytale book? And all her hair was cut down and taken away because the police did not find it.”

“Oh god.” Bow laments, covering his face with his hands.

“So it means the killer must be filling some really creepy fantasy on that fucking head. Or–” Mermista inhales, stopping for a second to gather her words. “Sending a message.”

“Mermista,” Adora cuts in, voice grave. The whole table turns to look at her, suddenly surprised by the tone of her voice. Adora wiggles just a little nervous on her chair, chewing in her cheek but without taking her eyes away from Mermista. “This is not one of your movies. This is not a game”

“I know, Adora. Do you think I don´t?” Mermista blurts, cleaning tears off her eyes forcefully, leaving dark marks underneath her eyes. “I cared about Perfuma, she was my friend, our friend. She loved us, we owe her to try and find whoever did this to her.”

Adora opens her mouth but no words come out. Mermista is right, of course she is. Adora cared about Perfuma, she was kind, she

was sweet, she was her friend. Mermista´s approach of the situation might borderline the morbid but there is true heart behind her intentions, the desire to bring her friend peace. Adora can understand that.

"You are right." Adora gives up, leaning back on the chair. Underneath the table her hand travels from Catra´s wrist to her waist, drawing lazily circles over her hip where the top meets her jeans. "What next?"

Mermista nods, pleased. She straightens again, her lips retracting over her gums. " Well of course, pointing out our primordial suspects"

"And who are our suspects again?" Bow dares to ask when nobody does, voice nervous as heck. And with reason because Mermista slams both hands over the table before pushing it away, moving the entire damn thing with the pull.

"Everyone is a suspect!"

"Oh, boy," Bow cringes, obviously regretting asking in the first place. Glimmer groans, falling flat over the surface of the table, her head between her crossed arms.

"This killer has lived among us for a long time. It knows the town perfectly well, knows the hours of the town, knows when people are in the square or in the stores or at school even. It knew Hordak was going to leave and made sure to commit the crime when a storm fell down, then was very careful to place all the remains around the square without being noticed, not even by the cameras."

Mermista points to another series of photographs, where the report of the cameras malfunctioning the very same day Hordak had been murdered are clear in red ink.

"It knew when the party took place and also that everyone would be distracted with the funeral after. Went to closing hours to the flower shop that had been fucking busy for the mass and used

that time to kill Perfuma. It is someone smart, cunning and strategist, someone cold that knows exactly what it's doing."

"That sounds logical." Entrapta says from their place, still not looking up but nodding in agreement.

"You just said everyone was a suspect," Glimmer adds, rolling her eyes. It only seems to fuel Mermista even more because her chest starts to hover quickly, words firm but clearly eager.

"I did, but I would be an idiot if I didn´t consider the obvious," Mermista holds her hands behind her back, facing the entire table fully. "If we take in account all what crime investigations have taught me. If we look at the way the crimes were committed, displayed even. If we consider all the previous events in this town, everything violent and terrible and horrible that has happened here in the last years, well, it should be pretty clear who it is."

"Just say it Mermista," Glimmer grumbles, practically on edge.

"Well it's obvious." Mermista shrugs, "Catra is the killer."

It´s like a bomb going off. But not the kind where you can physically hear and feel the explosion where your eardrums almost pop off with the intense sound. No.

It is the kind that is followed by a silence so overwhelming that it makes the entire room drown in it, robbing the air of everyone's lungs.

Every single pair of eyes in the room turn to stare at Catra, unmoving and frozen on her chair. Even Sea Hawk turns to look, jaw slack open with surprise. Most expressions are blank but Mermista´s is heavy, so dark that her eyes look like pools of ink, bearing themselves inside Catra´s colorful ones like a sandstorm meeting a hurricane.

Catra says no word, sitting so tense and straight on the golden chair that her joints and bones are at risk of bursting, straining themselves against every single muscle and patch of skin of her

body. The fabric of her high neck top is of a blue so deep that it almost looks black too, curling around her collarbones and neck like shadow hands, pressing her down between the table and her friend´s stares.

Everyone is looking at Catra but Adora isn´t. Instead she is looking at Mermista with her mouth open and her blue eyes widened, the surprise so big inside her chest that a small and completely unintentional chuckle escapes from her mouth, kind of hysterical and absolutely incredulous.

"Sorry?" Adora snorts out, knitting her eyebrows in confusion. Her brain still cannot comprehend that Mermista is actually not fucking joking until she catches sight of the expression in Mermista´s eyes, so fucking accusatory and sure of what she is saying that make Adora shiver from head to toe.

Oh.

She *is* serious.

Dread and nausea fall over Adora like a tsunami, realization finally hitting her with full strength. It's real, it's actually happening, Mermista has her finger pointed to Catra´s chest like some kind of heroic detective and the room is very quiet, all staring weary at Catra in her spot next to Adora.

Offense and anger dig themselves on Adora´s bones, her muscles springing back to motions when she leans towards the tower, opening her mouth to tell Mermista exactly just in how many ways it is fucking stupid and ridicule her theory, but Catra is already beating her to it, coming back to life at the very same time.

"Oh you bitch." Catra spits, standing up too.

She doesn´t even sound surprised, unlike the hurricane in Adora ´s chest, staring at Mermista as if she was actually, expecting her to do this some day. She doesn´t walk away from the table but she raises in all her height on the opposite side of Mermista, balling her hands into tight fists at her sides. Her shoulders and

back are already shivering uncontrollable though, her teeth clicking together with each word.

“What the hell are you talking about?”

“You didn't like Perfuma.” Mermista continues, never once stepping back from her accusation. “None of us actually, you left that pretty clear.”

Catra bites into the inner side of her cheek so hard that she actually bleeds herself, blood gathering thin around her molars and gums.

“That's not–”

“It's pretty obvious Catra, please.” Mermista rolls her eyes but she looks extremely pissed off, talking to Catra with a tone of voice so condescending that it makes Catra shake with fury. Adora is still astonished, too frozen in place to stop Mermista and when she realizes what is going on it is already too late.

Mermista takes a step forward on the table, signaling Catra from head to toe with her hand, a small grin in the corner of her lips and a glint of hatred and distrust in the corner of her eyes.

“Look at who you are, *Catra* .” She spits Catra´s name like a curse. Even Sea Hawk is sitting now, bouncing his knee nervously. “You are volatile. Unreliable. Black sheep of the town. You hold grudges and hurt people when you don´t like them. You hurt Adora for months just because she wanted to be with people that weren't you.”

Catra cringes and so does Adora, the blow hitting them both the same. Catra is still standing and proud but there are tears quickly gathering in the corner of her eyes, threatening with spilling down, acid and humiliation. But even then Mermista doesn´t stop.

“You got in so many fights at school, got arrested for crashing a fucking car because you were drunk. You don´t belong among us

without Adora. You weren't at the party when Hordak was murdered and I don´t think you were on sight when Perfuma was killed, were you? What dirty secrets was Hordak keeping for you? Or was it the other way around? What did he do that affected you so much as to fucking maul him and tear him apart?”

“This is fucking ridiculous,” Catra repeats but her voice is so strained that it falls flat, breaking on all sides. She is looking at the entire table and back at Mermista several times, seeking for some kind of help that doesn't come.

“Mermista,” Adora presses her palms flat over the table, staring at Mermista´s profile grave and dark as a thunderstorm. “Wait– you cannot be serious.”

“Not now, Adora,” Mermista cuts her, not even turning to look at her. “Oh you think I'm being ridiculous? Fine, then. Let's not forget the biggest clue about you. That dark nasty truth you like to hide from everyone else. That huge sin you think you have managed to keep buried under the ground.”

*Oh no.*

Desperation shots across Adora´s body like a shotgun blast, flaring her ribcage open and raising bruning hell on her veins. She knows exactly where Mermista is going, she knows exactly what Mermista is going to say. Adora had never spoken about it but by the look on Mermista´s face, Adora knows. She knows and she can´t do anything to stop it, already far beyond her control.

“Mermista,” Adora warns, half way growling a threat, half way whining as a plea.

How does Mermista even know? *Not here, not here please, not ever, it's not fair, it was not her fault.* But Mermista doesn´t even flinch, grinning like the harpy eagle that has gotten the cat.

“The biggest most important clue of them all.”

Catra is so tense, like a volcano about to explode, she looks about to scream, she looks about to burst into tears. Adora is halfway standing, springing like a broken cord, searching desperate Mermista´s eyes with hers.

”Mermista, please.”

It 's all useless. Now that it is out, Mermista won´t stop. Mermista knows it, Adora knows it. Catra knows too.

“You killed your mother last year, didn't you? In the New Year, you shot her dead.” Mermista drops, smiling at Catra. “You're already a murderer.”

The world has suddenly gone to fucking hell and Adora didn´t even realized when it happened. She stares openly at Memrista, eyes wide, pupils shrunk on her irises, trembling from head to toe.

When nobody says anything, she looks to the sides, towards the rest of the people she cares about and she calls friends, hoping for someone to say how fucked up the whole thing is.

But her friends are not looking at Adora or at Mermista, instead they are all looking directly at Catra with the kind of expression Adora never wanted them to wear around her. All of them are different, yet all of them are the same.

Surprise, shock, weariness, distrust. Rejection. It all runs in their eyes as they look at Catra and only tame a little when they look back at Mermista, mouths opening and closing like dead fishes when none of them knows what to say. Not even Adora.

Mermista looks at her friends and groans, shrugging so deep that her neck strains.

“What? All the town knows it! We´ve known since it happened! Or what, you think people weren't going to talk? Do you even know this place?”

The last one is directly towards Catra, whose face is almost completely hidden beneath the curls falling over her forehead and neck.

Adora strains her eyes to look at her but as much as she tries she cannot meet her eyes. Mermista is not done yet, though, digging the knife sharper and deeper between them all.

"Catrina Capellan-Weaver," she recites, "killed her mother with a gun and she lived to tell the tale."

Adora knows how much Catra has had to carry with her since last year happened. She knows about the looks of the people wherever Catra goes, knows about the chattering, about the gossip, about the theories and the disappointment every time Adora holds her hand in public.

Adora knows all of this and she has tried to make it better and Catra has never stepped away, never given up under the pressure of their stares, never bending her head down for anyone. Proud and relentless and unstoppable and beautiful among it all.

She knows how hard Catra has fought for her past, for what that woman did to her to not break her, knows all of Catra´s work and how much she has tried to do better, do better.

But this? This betrayal comes from the inside. From people Catra always told Adora never would see her as one of them. From people she thinks about as friends. From people that were supposed to love Catra, not throw her under the bus at the first arise of doubt.

Adora hates this, hates that any of this happened in the first place and that now they are pointing fingers at each other. Hates that she cannot see Catra´s face and that she cannot understand the tension in her bones or the beating of her heart or the fury in her veins. But no matter how many doubts people throw and scream at her, Adora will never doubt Catra.

But Catra doesn´t know this.

Catra stares at Mermista with an absolute blank expression in her face, her eyes void of any emotion of color, so quiet and dim that it makes Adora panic.

Catra stares without speaking and Adora looks at her roam her eyes from Mermista´s satisfied and angry face, then at Mermista ´s back where Sea Hawk lingers, then back at Mermista. For a second, Adora thinks Catra might pound and jump over the table and slap Mermista in the face or throw her backwards and beat her but none of it happens.

Catra pushes the chair back and turns around in her ankles without a single word, walking away immediately. She marches past her chair and the back of Adora´s, not looking back a single time and ignoring the latter completely when she wraps both hands urgently around her forearm, begging her to stay.

"Cat–" Adora starts, pleading. Catra doesn't listen.

Her arm slips off Adora´s trembling hold, falling off Adora´s fingers like sand. The feeling of her walking away makes Adora´s chest squeeze so painfully that she wheezes, terrified. Catra walks swiftly as a panther over the marble floor and then she is gone, past the dinner room, the corridor and the front door that closes with a slam so violent that all the windows of the manor tremble.

Adora gasps, horrified about what just had happened washing over her. She snaps her head back to Mermista, frowning so deeply her head starts to pound with a migraine. She even thinks that it clouds her eyes until she realizes they are tears, gathering on her eyelids and making everything blurry for a moment.

"Seriously Mermista?" Adora barks, standing up from the chair too. Mermista has the nerve to look annoyed at Adora, raising an eyebrow towards her and clicking her tongue against her teeth.

"What?"

She actually doesn´t seem to realize what she had done for Adora to be looking at her like that. Mermista groans, deep from her

rest, rolling her eyes so hard they might strain.

“Ugh, please, I get you two are sleeping together or whatever, but Perfuma is dead. Our friend is dead. Don't you think that's more urgent than hurting her feelings?”

“Catra is your friend too.” Adora says back, pointing at the place where Catra had disappeared into.

Mermista raises her eyes and doesn´t answer, looking at Adora as if she expected for her to realize something. Dread falls over Adora, coiling in the small of her spine like needles. The table is still horrible quiet, avoiding Adora´s pleading eyes when she looks at them.

“Guys?”

Mermista hums, nodding to herself as if she had proven a point. Adora has never been violent or angry but she really wants to punch her right now.

Bow clears his throat before Adora can even duel in thought, leaning towards Memrista with a calming voice, trying desperately to do damage control.

“Adora is right, Mermista.” He says, softly. “Even considering— what you just said, um– There is no reason for Catra to hurt Perfuma. Or the Mayor by all means.”

“Do you know where she was last night?” Mermista inquiries, looking at Bow but turning to question Adora again.

Adora stutters, tangling in her words. “I–”

“Because we all know where we were. I was with Sea Hawk and the Star siblings.”

“Indeed!” Sea Hawk chimes in, u faced by the seriousness of the whole situation. “They are my cousins!”

“As I *said* , we were with them. Scorpia and Entrapta were at their apartment and then Scorpia drove to the flower shop, there are cameras availing that. Where were you?”

“Here with Bow and Glimmer,” Adora answers, almost absently. “We were watching a movie.”

“And your girlfriend?”

“She was with us”

“The whole night?”

“I–” Adora looks at Glimmer and Bow, pleading but when they meet her gaze they look just as lost as she feels.

No, Catra was not with them the whole night, Adora received a call and Catra was gone for nearly an hour until she returned home, smelling like sandalwood. Adora cannot say that, not without Mermista going behind Catra´s throat.

“Please, stop”

“Perfuma had a crush on you for a whole year in high school. She kissed you after practice once. We even thought you two would date. And then what did Catra do? She slammed a dodgeball so hard she barely missed Perfuma and almost broke your nose. So sweet of her.”

Mermista joins her hands, sarcasm clear on every word.

“And then Perfuma was Scorpia's girlfriend, who was in love with Catra too for a while and who also ended up having a huge fight with Catra. It's weird, isn't it?”

“It is not.” Adora says but her voice breaks in the middle.

“Her father died in a horrible incident on the Thaymor Bridge and then she was basically all the time in the chapel´s choir followed as a shadow for her mother who we all know hated her. She never

made friends outside of you. Scorpia and Entrapta took pity on her. Am I wrong Entrapta?" Mermista turns, cornering Entrapta on their chair.

"Uh," Entrapta mutters, ears red. "Catra and I were in the same technology class. And Scorpia was always nice to me and she brought Catra everywhere. It was just obvious to make myself an acquaintance with her. But that doesn't mean we aren't friends– now." Entrapta says in a rush. And even though it doesn´t confirm what Mermista said at all,, that's the only thing Mermista needs to hear.

"She has always been weird." Mermista adds, wrinkling her nose. "I never go for the most obvious choice on crimes, but this is the exception,"

Adora drags her eyes towards Bow, begging from his help. "Bow–" But Mermista is not done yet, stepping down any attempt of Bow to speak and calm things down.

"She was horrible to you in school and horrible with anyone that would try and get close to you too. She is like a shadow around you. She is obsessed with you! I´ve been keeping my eye on her for a long time but she truly surpassed my expectations now."

"Wait. Wait, wait, wait, wait," Glimmer, bless her heart, interrupts, shaking her hands in front of her face. She looks years older in just a matter of minutes, exhausted as she frowns down at Mermista. "What do you mean she killed her mom? Adora?"

Glimmer turns to look at Adora, big eyes pleading and confused. Adora opens her mouth but she doesn't know what to say, eyes heavy. Glimmer's face falls and sours immediately, her cheeks going pale.

"Oh dear goddess. I thought after what happened in the house that Miss Weaver had ki–"

"Killed herself? No, no, Glimmer." Mermista chuckles, shaking her head with a devious grin. "Catra shot her in the face until she was

unrecognizable. She is a lunatic!”

“Mermista, that's enough!”

Adora slams her palms over the table and yells at the top of her lungs, standing fully from her seat with so much force that the chair tethers back and falls harshly against the polished floor.

A new kind of astonished silence makes it over the table; damn, even Adora is surprised, her throat burning where she exclaimed the words until her vocal cords hurt. She had never raised her voice like this to her friends, and just doing it makes Adora a little dizzy but she cannot stand anymore sitting here and hearing Mermista verbally puke things she doesn´t understand.

Adora takes her hands back from the table and breathes deep several times, calming the rush of blood beating in her heart. Shame falls over her at raising her voice, her ears burning hot under the alarmed expressions of everyone else.

“I'm sorry, I just–” Adora buries her face between her palms, sobbing. “God.”

Adora can feel the rush of movement when Bow stands up, starting to make his way towards her. Adora shakes her head, lowering one of her hands to give him a sign to stop.

She needs a second more, to gather her thoughts and calm herself before speaking again. No good can come of her yelling at her friends in a moment like this and she will do no favor to Catra if Adora is the one punching Mermista in front of everyone.

“Listen, she didn't do anything and she is not a killer. She– she can´t be.” Adora gulps heavily, wetting her bottom lip with the tip of her tongue, her hand coming up to scratch at the tip of her bridge nervously. “She isn't, please. I know you don't understand but she is good and she wouldn't hurt Perfuma. Or Mayor Hordak. And whatever happened last year it wasn't her fault.”

“How do you know that?”

“When I arrived to the house–”

“When you made it there Weaver was already dead, Adora. You cannot know what happened.” Mermista says back, completely not convinced. Adora exhales, whipping tears off her face.

“She told me.”

“Because she has always been so truthful to you, hasn't she?”

Adora closes her mouth so fast she accidentally bites herself, pain flaring in her mouth. She feels like screaming again but holds it down, pressing her fingers against the sides of her temples for several seconds before looking at Mermista again. By the time Adora speaks her voice is back to its usual self and her heart is not threatening to rip across her chest.

“Mermista, I miss Perfuma too. But blaming Catra when there is no proof is not– is not alright. She *is* one of us.” Adora makes a special point in the last, holding Mermista’s eyes in hers. “Look, I know things between us were tense for a long time. I know she was not– the kindest towards all of you in high school. I get it, okay? I get you heard or read things, Mermista, and that you all might have an opinion of her but this is wrong. I love her, and I trust her. And if you trust me I´ll need you to trust her too.”

On their seats, both Bow and Glimmer smile, tension slowly rolling off their shoulders though there is still a hint of doubt nestled in the back of Glimmer's eyes. Mermista still doesn't look convinced, not at all, but she huffs, rolling her shoulders back.

“We'll see.”

“Please apologize to her,” Adora begs, looking at her through her eyelashes. Mermista frowns at her, a light blush makes its way on her cheeks. She looks like wants to say no but she also notices the way the entire table is looking at her now, expecting.

“Fine,” Mermista says with a huge groan, clicking her teeth together. Still, it makes Adora's shoulders relax even if just a

little.

“Thank you”

“I think that was enough for today.” Bow says after a beat, standing from his seat. His voice is steady, stepping into the lead easily. “We all need to rest and be safe for now, just while things calm down.”

A general agreement runs over the table and everyone starts moving on their own accord. Entrapta has already gone god knows where and when, all the tiny desserts in their plate taken with them. Bow turns towards Glimmer, mouth open to say something, but Glimmer's phone starts ringing like crazy on her hand, making Glimmer grumble.

“Mom?” Glimmer answers, lowering her voice. “Yes, I´m here. My friends are here too.” Angella’s voice is almost too loud to be heard around the house but not enough to make out what she is saying into the speaker. By the way Glimmer's expression, though, it mustn't be something very pleasant. “Mom, please, I can't just make them all leave…”

She trails off as she stands from the chair and walks away, off the dinner room and into the kitchen, her voice muted as she fights with her mother. Bow shares a reassuring look with Adora and follows Glimmer right behind.

Adora allows herself to fall back into the chair, her forehead resting over her palms. Now that it is over the adrenaline has started to leave her veins, leaving her limbs worn to the bone and exhausted. The rational part of her brain hammers on her head, making her know that she should be off her ass and looking for Catra, but she just cannot move, too overwhelmed by everything that is happening right now.

“We are off too. We are meeting the Star siblings tomorrow.” Mermista says between clenched teeth, strained. “They want to

make a memorial for Perfuma on the square, we'll be helping if any of you want to join.”

She is mad as hell as she picks all the reports and photographs and slams them back on the briefcase, giving a single look to Sea Hawk for him to stand up. She leaves the briefcase over the chair, all the points she wanted to make already said and done.

Mermista circles the table and starts walking towards the frame of the big door, Sea Hawk trailing on her ankles and already talking about the memorial stuff.

Before they call leave completely, Mermista stops next to Adora's chair, staring at her with narrowed eyes and frowned eyebrows.

“Just let me ask you one more thing, Adora.”

“What?” Adora answers, still between her palms. Her chest aches, making her breathing shallow and painful. She doesn't want to do this anymore, she doesn't want to fight her friends anymore, but she forces to look up, meeting Mermista's heavy eyes.

“When she betrays you, because she will. Will you have enough strength to stop her? Or will you let her kill everything you love?”

It's a blow to the chest. Adora wheezes, out of breath, staring at Mermista as if she couldn't believe she had just said that. Mermista shrugs, wrinkling her nose at Adora's wide blue eyes.

‘Think about it.”

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Catra lights a cigarette with trembling fingers, taking a deep breath from it. The puff of smoke overwhelms her mouth and nostrils, raiding in front of her in swirls when it meets the day's breeze.

Catra coughs just a little around the taste, leaning her head backward over the wall, eyes closed. She is tucked on an empty spot of Glimmer's pristine gardens, between the bushes of red roses that almost look painted and the furthest wall of the manor, where neither the security cameras nor the windows can see her.

It's been a long time since the last time she took a smoke, and even longer since she enjoyed it, so the sour taste lingers on her throat uncomfortably, making her wrinkle her nose and hum, annoyed.

She thinks she can still hear the murmur of raised voices inside the house, even as she tries to step as far away as possible, but she doesn't make an effort to try and make out what they are saying.

It doesn't matter, anyway it has never mattered. Catra had always known that none of them ever considered Catra part of them. Why would it come as a surprise now?

*´Oh, Catrina, what did you expect?´* Catra hears in the air, all around her, hammering inside her brain. *´ Just look at the state of you. You and I are the same.´*

Catra kicks a loose rock with her boot, biting accidentally into the tail of the cigarette, anger and frustration making its way inside of her. She is so deep inside her own thoughts that she doesn't hear the bushes moving around softly or the second breathing until it is right above her, leaning barely a few feet away from her.

"Old habits are hard to die, aren't they?"

Catra jumps, hissing on the back of her throat as she meets the hazel eyes of the person in front of her. DT smiles at her deviously, taking pride in still being able to rip a fright out of her, all thin lips and sharp teeth.

Their hair is specially blonde today, almost silver like, long and kept out of their face by the shaved sides. Just as the last time Catra saw them, they wear slim clothes and jewelry, butter soft

tan skin and long nails that brush against their forearms when they cross their arms over their chest, waiting with raised eyebrows for Catra to say anything at all.

Surprise makes it to fury in a single second inside Catra, her cheeks flaming red and teeth clenching together so hard that Double Trouble might just be able to hear them too. Catra drops the cigarette to the grass and extinguishes it with the sole of her boot, a scowl making its way on her mouth when she looks back at DT.

“What the fuck do you want?” Catra growls, digging her sharp nails against the material of the wall. DT’s eyebrows skyrocket, throwing their head back and laughing once and long, the kind of laugh that always made Catra feel like she was just an object for DT to take mirth off.

“Well, well. I came to see a friend, of course.”

“We are not friends.”

“Right then.” DT’s tone sours, eyebrows casting shadows over their eyes and they lean closer to Catra's space. “I thought it was common courtesy to come visit my ex-girlfriend after one of her family members passed away. Again. Isn't it?”

How stupid. How stupid Catra was to ever trust them.

She wants to tell herself that it was all a dumb mistake if the person she was when she was seventeen, but even then she knew the kind of person DT was. That was the entire reason why she started seeing them, why she gave herself to them.

Even then they were cunning, too smart, devious, always plotting something or seeking for something for their own gain or pleasure. They were all Adora wasn't and for a long time seventeen years old Catra drowned herself in it and in the bitterness of her own heart.

Catra bites down onto her tongue that she feels pain flare in her entire mouth, her jaw protesting by how tense she holds it. There is static inside Catra's head, numbing her brain and making her eyes heavy but she holds it back and holds herself about it, pushing the whispers into the farthest part of her that she can as she faces DT fully.

She straightens up from the wall, crossing her arms over her chest. The tip of her piercings dig on the tender skin of her lips, her teeth bared towards DT as all the follicles of her body stand on point, from the small of her back to her nape.

“I should have never told you that.” Catra whispers, drowned around a grunt. She doesn't want anybody to hear her, not in the house or anywhere. She is already a monster in their eyes, she will not give them the satisfaction of more.

DT notices because they chuckle, tilting their head to the side. Their eyes flash almost yellow under the light of the evening sun, washing them both in red light.

“That Hordak is, sorry, *was* your uncle?” The words burn in Catra's skin like raw acid but DT does not give her a single second, chuckling under their breath. “C'mon kitten, you used to trust me with a lot more stuff than the complicated relationship of your mother and her brother–”

Catra slams her first against the wall, the sound loud and positively shutting DT up. They are left with their mouth hanging open, slightly thrown off by the hit. It doesn't last long because DT’s surprised expression melts down into something smart, studying Catra with a new kind of eyes.

Catra's heart is hammering inside her chest, beating so fast that it hurts, straining against her lungs and ribs. Her chest rises and falls quickly, her skin red in the fabric cut between her collarbones and the start of her chest.

“I told you I didn't want to ever see you again.” Catra hisses, words rolling off her tongue like venom.

DT huffs, rolling their eyes. They do not seem at all discouraged by Catra's increasing anger, instead giving a step further in the reduced space between them. DT wraps a long strand of their hair around their fingers, looking at it fall back down soft as corn hair.

For the longest of time, Catra held herself to it, thinking seeing it between her hands would replace the honey strands she really wanted to hold. Now, the sight alone makes Catra want to scream.

“Our thing wasn't that bad, kitten.”

“Our *thing* happened years ago. We were seventeen and it didn't last.”

“And yet I still carry your scar.” DT runs their hand up, towards the side of their face where the faintest of scars cross the end of their eyebrow. Made long ago when their head slammed against the board of a car. Then DT stretches that very same hand, towards Catra, pointing to an invisible spot right above Catra's beating heart. “And you carry mine.”

A shiver makes it down Catra's spine, filling her with dread. She slaps DT’s hand away from her, holding their wrist between her fingers and pulling from it to the side, keeping DT’s hand away from her and in place, her sharp nails digging threateningly on the skin of DT’s arm.

“You left me in that fucking car, DT.” Catra starts saying, very slowly, her words clear and not trembling anymore. Fury has made it completely inside her body now, filling every single cell and spot in her body with grudge and anger. “You knew what my mother would do to me after she found out we took her car. You got me drunk, you crashed the fucking car and you left me there.”

DT narrows their eyes sharply, clicking their teeth together with displeasure. They snap their arm away from Catra's hold, absently rubbing the sore skin with their fingers.

“Hey there, I wasn't the one that made you drink. You did all that by yourself, going through mommy´s alcohol stach.” Catra flinches and DT smiles, a small flash of victory in their eyes. “I did leave you there, you are right on that. But it was for your own good, darling. You needed that wake up call.”

“I needed you to be on my side, that's all I ever asked from you! And you betrayed me!” Catra exclaims, borderline into a shout. Her voice splinters in the middle, vocal cords long ago broken by her own mother's hand. She exhales, running her hand across her face, ramming her hair back and she straightens her back again. “I should have never trusted you. And I should have never let you lay a hand on me.”

Catra starts walking right past DT, avoiding touching them like the plague as she makes it back towards the bushes. DT beats her to it, wrapping their hand around her elbow and pulling back, flushing Catra's back against their chest.

Catra grunts with the slam, already opening her mouth and raising her hand to push them away but DT wraps their hand around Catra's chin and locks her firmly in place, pressing their fingers against her skin so hard that her molars hurt.

“You knew how things worked between us, darling. And you weren't complaining when I was kissing you in your mother's car.” DT whispers, pressing their sly mouth against the shell of Catra's ear, one of their hands running down the side of Catra’s neck.

Catra shivers, struggling to even breathe , pupils shrinking. It feels like she was seventeen all over again as DT kissed her and pressed down on her throat, it reminds her of the only time she allowed them to touch her. DT voice raises, imitating Catra's voice in a tone so similar that it's frightening.

“Kiss me again, DT. Help me not to think. Help me to forget. Help me stop loving her.”

“Agh!” Catra yells, elbowing DT in the chest so hard that they tumble back, losing their grip on Catra.

Catra extracts herself from their hold, tripping with the grass and fallen branches, accidentally holding herself to the bramble twisted on the rose bushes. The small thorns dig on her palms, gathering tiny drops of bloom on her skin.

“Does your Adora touch you?” DT continues, their voice tangled in mirth. Catra does not turn to look at them but she can feel her ears and cheeks coloring in red without her permission, her fondness for Adora giving her away immediately. “ *Oh* , she does. You allow her to, isn't it? What happened to being too afraid to be with someone? To let someone touch you?”

“She is not you” Catra voice is unfazed, boiling under the surface.

“And does she know about me? Of what we were, before you two started to play Romeo and Juliet?” No answer. DT chuckles. “Ah, I see. Am I your dirty little secret of the past? Am I the proof of who you are pretending to be?”

After a long second of silence DT hums, resting their hands on either side of their hips. A cocky expression lingers on their face, one eyebrow raised and lips pressed together when Catra remains frozen in place but still giving her back to them.

“I've seen your Adora around. We had a class together.” DT savors the words, inspecting their perfectly manicured nails. “She truly is a sweetheart, golden heart, big doe eyes, I understand in part why you don't want to speak about me to her.”

Catra snaps her eyes at them, blazing like blue and red fires dancing in her irises. DT grins, relishing on the fact that they have caught Catra's attention.

“Maybe I could pay her a visit sometime soon. I haven't figured out her character just yet–”

Catra moves so fast that DT doesn't even notice it until they are pressed flat against the wall, their head connecting painfully with the concrete and Catra's forearms firmly pressed against their throat. Catra's face is barely a few inches away from them, even though DT is clearly taller, her voice sour when she spats at their face.

“Stay away from her”

She is like a panther about to jump, hovering over DT’s viper face. DT cringes, wheezing under the hold.

“Come on–”

“I'll hurt you.” Catra leans her face against DT’s, her mouth inches from theirs. There is an edge in her voice they have never heard before, not once, not even when she was younger and was trying to prove something. “I'll hurt you DT. If you get near her, if you breathe in her direction, I'll hurt you. It's a promise.”

DT holds their breath, staring at Catra's sharp face for a long second. Whatever they see in it must be enough because they raise their hands in surrender, dropping their voice a little from their twisted game.

“Sheesh. Alright. I'm just getting a rise out of you, kitten”

“Why are you doing this?” Catra demands, not once letting go from her hold. She is slim and slick like a shadow but even inches shorter she possesses so much more strength than people think, easily pinning DT’s struggling body into a choking hold. “Why, after so many years, are you looking for me?”

“I’m just trying to help you. People have hurt you, they keep doing so,” DT murmurs, tongue sharp. They try to keep it cool but it is obvious their confident demeanor has been shaken to the core, voice completely strained. “They don't trust you, they don't

feel you belong with them. The town's talking already, they gossip, the morbid knowledge of the murder trill again. And you are, sadly, the center of that after your mom's shit.”

“I don't need your help neither do I want it. If the fucking town's talking I'll deal with it on my own.” Catra breaths hard, barely managing to pull the words out without yelling.

“And what about your darling Adora?” DT struggles, trying to free themself but Catra's hold just deepens, pressing over DT’s pipe dangerously hard.

Catra has not forgotten that DT liked to press down their hand over her throat when they kissed her on the corridors of school or in the back alleys of stores, ignoring the way it made Catra tense and whimper in pain.

“What will happen when it’s too much, when you become too much for her? She has left you before and for even less.”

”You know nothing about her and you know nothing about me.” Catra drops them back down, stepping away enough for DT to slump against the wall, coughing dry. The small wounds on her palms have left spots of blood stained on their shirt. “You don't have power over me anymore. You don't get to come now and try to take this life from me.”

DT clears their throat, completely sour after the whole exchange. They look at Catra from below long eyelashes, frowning deeply. This is definitely not how they expected this whole conversation to go and Catra knows it.

“Are you satisfied now? Did you get it all out of your system?” Catra asks in the same mocking tone they had used against her, letting her arms fall to her side.

She waits for a few seconds to see if DT will say something and when they don´t, she scoffs, clicking her tongue against the back of her teeth.

“Good, get lost. And if I ever see you getting near Adora I will make you regret it, *darling* ”

Catra turns around without a single more word and makes her way out of the pretty rose garden, right across the sidewalk and towards the line of trees that limit the rich neighborhood, her eyes focused on the woods around her. She feels the adrenaline pumping in her veins and straining her chest but she doesn´t dare nor care too look back neither at DT or at the house.

DT watches her go with heavy eyes, their lips retracting over their gums when they snarl. People have started to walk out of the manor too and to their cars but none of them see Catra disappear in the woods or DT slip among the gardens, hidden like a lizard against the grass.

Catra´s cigarette burns a hole on the evergreen grass and consumes itself with a puff.

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“Don´t go too far!”

“I won´t Tallstar,” Starla answers back, rolling her eyes fondly. Behind her, Tallstar wrinkles her nose, shuffling nervously at the end of the treeline.

“Are you sure you want to go?”

“I am. Those lilies only grow next to the pond,” Starla exclaims back, jumping over a fallen log already covered in soft moss. “They were some of Perfuma´s favorites. I want to give them to her.”

“And if we go with you?” Tallstar´s voice sounds slightly closer, a step further inside the soft patch of grass and fallen scones that cover the Whispering Woods.

“Then Jewelstar would get lost searching for the rest of the flowers.”

“I would not,” her brother says, slightly offended, but it is clear that he would. Starla has grown up with them for twenty years, she knows her brother has the sense of direction of a blind koala.

“Just go ahead and I´ll reach you in fifteen minutes. You can even time it Tallstar,” Starla is already almost completely inside the woods, following the stone paths she knows by heart. She came here with Perfuma many times before, when the friends used to pick flowers either for the shop or for their own journals. In a way, it's closure for Starla, being here one last time in her friend's name. She needs this and her siblings know she does.

“Very well,” Tallstar exclaims, almost completely out of view. “But if you don´t come I´ll come back to look for you”

“Sure, sure.” Starla climbs a tall rock and falls down swiftly on her ankles, shaking her head. Behind her, her brother´s share a last look and go in the opposite direction, sending a quick message to Sea Hawk to let him know where they are and that they´ll be on the arcade store soon enough.

It's the evening and the woods are golden, showered with the warm sun that has started to fall. Starla doesn´t hum or whistles as she usually would do, quiet as she makes her way through the branches and bushes. She has known these woods since she was just a little child, she used to play in the backyards of the building close by with her siblings and later got the habit of walking at dawn or at dusk, feeling the dew on her face and the cold hair through her face.

She has found solace in the sparkling quietness of the trees and the animals that walk around her. In the deers and does and foxes that look at her like a little mouse wandering the woods on her own. She climbs rocks and jumps and falls of them with expertise, sliding against tall hills and walking behind the long branches of wisterias, following a path only Perfuma and she ever knew.

If you were to be from a tall building, looking from a window or lingering near the top of a bell tower, you might be able to see it, and even there it would take you several seconds of straining your eyes to catch it, hidden among all the tree leaves and twisted colorful branches. The biggest giveaway of the spot it's the huge Fire Tree right next to the limits of the clear, a rare sight of tropical redness that has somehow managed to grow tall and strong even among the usual humidity of the woods.

There, below red flowers and green leaves, between thick tree trunks and rocks lies a hidden pond, big enough to make you sweat if you try to surround it from extreme to extreme on foot; wide and deep. There are treacherous roots on the bottom, and if you were to dip your toes on the pond or try and go for a swim in the wrong place, they would tangle around your ankles and pull you down until water filled your lungs and you were no more.

But the risk is worth it, in a way and if you know what you are looking for, because there in the middle of the pond, surrounded by their own leaves, fireflies and even one or two or twenty frogs, grow the most extraordinary of lilies. Of a pink so deep that sometimes, when the light falls over them just right, they look almost crimson red. With soft and long petals and the center wide and golden, growing huge and untouchable just out of reach. They were Perfuma´s favorites. She loved collecting them on her own and gifting them to her friends and her girlfriend, proud of being able to tame the waters of the pond and take care of the precious flowers all on her own.

She taught Starla how to collect them, exactly in which places step between the earth and the water without slipping with the mud. Which kind of branches to pick up from the floor to help herself around the water and test the places where the roots might betray her, careful of where to go when she walks inside the water. Starla has never done it without her before and she hoped to never do it, but here she is now. This is the last thing Starla can do for her friend, be a little brave and search for her favorite flowers to place over her closed coffin before being lowered to the ground.

Starla takes off her shoes and leaves them to the side, above a flat rock, digging her fingers softly into the earth. She is very careful as she makes her way around the pond, helping herself with a tree branch to feel the moss and mud. Once she is exactly where she should she takes a deep breath, inhaling and exhaling several times before giving one step inside the water. One step, then another, the next moment the water is completely at her waist, soaking her clothes thoughtfully.

Starla shivers a little inside the cold water, running her hands over her head to keep her blonde hair out of her face, tight curls neatly kept in braids. She swims a little inside the pond until she reaches what she is looking for, holding the lilies between her palms with a relieved sigh. She takes a pair of small scissors from the front pocket of her overalls and cuts the long stems swiftly, bringing a bundle of flowers back with her. They aren´t many lilies, Perfuma would have not liked if Starla took the entire blooms, but they are enough to be perfect.

Starla walks out of the water and kneels over the mud, facing the pond as she cleans the flowers quickly and inspects their stems, leaving the scissors next to her knees. She is very focused on her work when she hears the soft crack of dry leaves under a newfound weight, way too heavy to be any kind of animal that Starla has seen before.

It is a deadway that somebody else has walked inside the pond´s clear and Starla can´t help but roll her eyes, still looking at her work with the flowers.

“Tallstar, seriously? Where did you leave Jewelstar? And don't expect me to believe you just found your way here. You could have only given with the pond if you followed me.”

Starla wrinkles her nose, nostrils flaring like an annoyed mouse about to bite someone. The steps are clearer now and they are right behind her, the warmth of the newcomer hovering over Starla as a shadow of a body obscures her work. Next to her, she

feels them lean down, taking the scissors from the ground before Starla starts to turn around, facing them.

"I told you I could take care of myself–"

*Swish.*

Starla blinks, mouth slack with surprise. She lingers in her place for one second as the surprise starts to wash out, staring back at the face of someone that is neither her sister nor her brother yet a known face after all.

"Ah" Starla gasps, unable to speak. There is a tingling sensation on her neck, something itchy and cold that starts on the base of her jaw and falls down like rain on the column of her neck, gathering in the hollow of her collarbones.

She brings a hand up, pressing it against the smooth skin of her neck only to find a deep and long opening in it, from side to side of her neck, barely avoiding the jugulars and opening her airway in the same way her jaw and mouth falls open with the shock and the pain.

Sudden waves of pain start rolling over her, overcoming her completely and that's when her body that had locked itself in place to protect her consciousness sprints back into place, bringing her back to reality almost with a cruel slam.

Starla flinches back, holding herself to the killer´s forearms to try and push them away but the blood loss has already violently started and she is left too weak and exhausted from one second to the other, unable to move her way out for a single inch.

Starla gapes, opening and closing her mouth is a sad try  of a scream but nothing comes out of her lips but a gush of fresh blood, gathering in her gums and tongue. She tries to scream, to yell, to trash on the mud and call for her siblings help but there is nobody here but the lilies, the trees, the pond and her. And the killer hovering above her, holding her in place by the back of her nape.

There is a second where the killer takes a step back, dropping Starla´s scissors back to the floor, coated in mud, and Starla thinks she has managed to push and kick and slap the killer enough for her to try and fight back or scramble away. To dig her nails on the killer's palms and draw blood until the killer hisses in pain. And she might have done it too, but the reality is that she is drowning in her own blood and the killer has just leaned back to see the whole show much better.

The killer grabs the back of her shirt and turns her around, pushing her once and hard against the mud, tumbling her flat against the mud. Starla barely has time to give a shuddering and terrified gasp before the killer pushes her entire head and shoulders inside the pond´s water, submerging her under the surface, holding her head in place and keeping her from pushing herself back.

Starla struggles violently, grass and mud everywhere as her knees dig on the ground and make her slip time and time again, keeping her from trying to surge back out. The blue water of the pond has started to paint in red, thick and deep as it gushes out of Starla´s neck and stains every single part of the pond, from the leaves to the roots, to the pink of the lilies ahead of her. Starla opens her mouth accidentally with terror and blood with water gathers inside her mouth and falls down her throat, choking her where the gushing blood does not.

The killer pulls back once, just once, leaning against Starla´s side to get a look of her face, breath hitting against Starla´s cheeks, to look at her veins straining against her temples and cheeks, her eyes bloodshot with pressure and face bruised. The killer had gotten a hold of Starla´s hair, so hard that she feels the follicles protesting and ripping in places, separating from her scalp like pieces of paper. Starla whimpers, worn to the bone and dizzy, her mouth filled with pond water and blood and saliva, dripping off her lips and chin and she tries and fails to take a single breath more.

Through narrowed eyes. Starla thinks she can catch sight of something near her killer´s knees, blurry and damp where water and tears make everything look like a window under rain. A dead hare looks back at her, white coat soaked in the blood from its own neck, head twisted and bent into an unnatural angle. Starla looks at it and the dead animal does not look back.

That is the last thing Starla sees, fallen flowers and empty eyes as the killer pushes her back, holding her struggling body below the scarlett water scattered in lilies´petals until Starla is not moving anymore, floating between mud and grass and roots. She is there one second and the next she is gone, eaten alive by the waters and the sharp end of golden scissors.

By the time the sunset starts to fall she is still floating quietly on the pond, facing the sky instead of the depth of the waters. There is no hair on her head but her hands are tangled one above the other, placed carefully by killing hands, the broken pink lilies and the body of the hare between her fingers. Ophelia in the blue and crimson water that has made her deathbed.

Her siblings call for her in the woods nearby but the willow makes them an echo and they cannot find her.

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The Thaymor Bridge has been abandoned for ten years and it is covered in moss, the woods eating it alive.

It exists in the limits of the town, right in the middle of all the exists, far away enough from the square and giving entrance to the world that separates Etheria from Eternia. It hovers tall and strong over the Thaymor River, a force of nature so violent and unstoppable that if something falls on it, a rock, a plant or a body, it will disappear among the swirling flood of the blue, blue water and never be seen again.

Where does this river go? Nobody really knows it. It loses itself somewhere among the crevices of the forest until the turmoil of its sound it's nothing in comparison to the birds chirping and the predators chasing some prey among the bushes. Maybe it thins and disappears inside the soaked ground, maybe it transforms itself into lagoons and ponds, maybe it ends in a hidden shore in the middle of the dark woods where nobody dares to set foot.

The Bridge was once the primordial source of transportation of the town; all the trains, cars and trolleys used to pass by it, slow and one by one as the old wood creaked under them. Now it is abandoned. left to rot and forgotten by all the people that have ever passed through here, like a bad omen or a local curse nobody wants to wake up.

There is a spot on the bridge where the railing is destroyed; where the metal has been bent open by some external force that could not be contained by the old and unkempt irons, opening like a flower towards the river.

Testimony of a car losing control under the heavy rain of Etheria and flying away, away and away until it crashed against the floor of the river. If you strain your eyes, you can still see pieces floating among the mud, even ten years after.

Nobody walks through here anymore, nobody drives their cars through these parts of the forest, nobody even comes to visit. It lays lonely and imposing between one side and the other, twisted pieces of metal and rotten wood and climbing plants, the only living creatures wandering over it the animals that get to cross by.

Catra likes to linger here, on this high spot of the world where her legs dangle dangerously over the flood of the river and there is nothing between her body and the open air, not even iron or rail.

She wanders here like some kind of spirit and if anybody was to know they would chastise her for it because who in their right mind spends the evening hanging in the very same place where

the trolley that was bringing your father and only your father back home because you were sick and a child lost control and ended up dead on the river below.

Tragedies and tragedies mingling in the air.

But this is the only place where Catra can breathe sometimes, morbid or not, this place between the town that hates her and the woods has become a refugee and she wanders inside it when her mind is buzzing with noise and her body heavy with adrenaline.

This is the only place where Catra gives herself the time and permission to break a little on the edges without hating herself so much, clenching her teeth with the peace she so much craves is stabbed and cut open by the words ringing inside her head.

*´You don't have the guts´*

It's not real, it is not her, but it still sounds the same and it hurts just as much.

Catra sits on the very edge of the broken bridge, facing the river, her knees pressed tight against her chest, curled over her own body as if she was seeking some kind of comfort that she cannot reach. Her knees are covered in moss and drying mud and her feet are slippery, palms itching painfully where wounds take a time to stitch themselves together.

She frowns, shaking her head violently, seaking to chase the voice away.

*´We are not enough. You are not enough´*

"We are not the same." Catra closes her eyes until sparks flare behind her eyelids, teeth clenching against each other until her jaw hurts. Her palms hurt, her body is tired. If she opens her eyes she might just catch the blurry glimpse of a garnet dress hovering next to her, her own demon following her around. "Leave me alone"

*´Look at me, look at what you've caused. You´re paranoic and you´ll never be safe´*

Catra slams the heel of her palm against her temple, again and again until the skin threatens to brush, digging her sharp nails on her scalp and pulling from her hair. “Go away.”

*´But I´m always with you´*

“You are not. You are gone.” Catra frowns and rests her chin over her knees, looking at the swirling water below. “Leave me alone”

“Catra?” Adora´s voice breaks against the static like sunlight, chasing the shadows inside Catra.

Catra turns her head at the source of the voice, tilting her head to stare at Adora. Catra is not surprised to see her there, in fact she is relieved, eyes softening in the corners.

Adora is standing over the riel of the bridge, balancing on one and both feet, close yet far away that Catra doesn´t feel caged between Adora and the river. If Catra wanted she could stand easily and walk away, but Catra stays, a traitor grin making its way on her lips at the sight of her.

Adora sighs, her face and shoulders relaxing when she catches sight of Catra´s fond eyes and tiny smile. She gives a step forward, just one and still hesitant, looking at Catra with a clear question in her face.

Catra exhales, moving slightly to the side, a silent affirmation for Adora to get near. Adora does not need to be asked twice, quickly making her way next to Catra and sitting besides her, her long legs hanging from the wood like another version of a swing. A very tall swing.

“Hey, I knew I would find you here,” Adora whispers, looking at Catra with kind eyes.

Catra cannot control her own heart when Adora is looking at her like that, as is all the stars in the sky had been hung just for Catra to glimpse to, as if she held Adora´s heart on her bare and wounded palm and she could do whatever she wanted with it, crush it down or save it inside her own chest, fluttering and warm.

It´s a kind of love Catra never thought she could have, not ever, not from the person she adores the most, yet here she is, sitting next to Catra´s curled body and smiling as the sunset sun washes over them in golden light.

"What are you doing?" Adora is keeping her voice soft, too soft almost, controlled.

She is trying to not sound freaked out but Catra knows exactly how nervous Adora gets every time Catra sits this close to the edge, divided between reaching her arms towards Catra and trusting her to be careful.

Catra has never misstepped, not even once, and she is not about to start now. Still, it is in a way endearing, Adora´s care for her, it makes warmth spread on Catra´s limbs, chasing the cold away.

"Looking at the water," Catra says, shrugging. She relaxes her position, dropping her legs back over the edge just as Adora, her arms lowered to the side instead of around her chest. She lets her weight fall against Adora´s shoulders, nuzzling below Adora´s jaw, and she can feel the relieved sigh trembling off her lips. "Took you long enough to show up. Where were you?"

"At the Manor, with Bow," Adora explains, letting her fingers run and comb across Catra´s curls, slightly damp with the heat of the evening. "I thought you would like a moment to breathe."

Catra hums, not answering. She needs many things and the only one she really wants is already sitting by her side. She remains quiet for a few long seconds, chewing on the inside of her cheek, her mind calmer but her heart still beating dangerously loud in her

chest. She is tired and she does not want to move right now. Her hands are still resting at her sides, Adora´s resting over her own lap, close but still far away.

Adora clears her throat slightly, still speaking softly but weary, her blue eyes looking past the bridge and the river, almost liquid gold when the rays of the sun catches them

“What Mermista said was really fucked up”

Catra´s breath gets stuck on her throat, her body freezing. All the emotions and exhaustion that had been overwhelming her return back with blunt force, making her shake and move away, leaning back from Adora´s body sharply.

Adora flinches at the loss, her fingers twitching as if she was regretting opening her mouth in the first place and wanting nothing more but to reach her again.

“You think?” Catra asks, bitter and sarcastic, looking away from Adora´s face and into the tree line.

Adora observes her with heavy eyes, her lips pressed into a sad line before exhaling, sitting very straight next to Catra.

“I already dealt with it,” Adora assures her, kicking her feet over the edge. It makes Catra´s body shiver from head to toe. Adora´s body is tense of how badly she wants to touch Catra but she doesn't, respecting even like this. “She won´t say it again, I promise. And she´ll apologize”

“I don´t think she will,” Catra mutters, narrowing her eyes. She holds her breath for a moment and lets it all blow off her lungs with a long exhale, her shoulders dropping back down. “But thank you”

Catra scratches her palms, red and raw and painful, still not looking at anything but the trees. Adora catches the movement out of the corner of her eyes, concern staining her face. Her dark eyebrows knit together into a frown and she moves, her hand

hovering over Catra´s without really touching her yet, searching for Catra´s eyes instead and seeking her consent first.

"Can I hold your hand?" Adora asks in the thread of a voice, so sweet that Catra cannot do anything else but nod.

Adora grabs both of Catra´s hands between her, turning the palms towards her to inspect the shallow cuts and bruised patches. Adora whimpers very softly, so quiet that if Catra wasn´t almost pressed against her she would have missed the sound. It makes Catra cringe in shame, fighting the urge to snap her hands away.

Adora looks a little bit lost on Catra´s palms, looking at them and blinking very quickly, chasing the start of tiny tears away. Like this, under the light of the sunset coloring her golden hair copper and her teary eyes, Catra thinks that the woman next to her might be a phoenix inside, all fire and miraculous tears, covering Catra´s pain with her lips when she leans down and presses a kiss over the sore palms.

"How's your head?" Adora says, raising her head again. There is a small smudge of Catra´s blood on her bottom lip, turning pink into crimson and staining her chin. Catra gulps at the sight, her entire body tingling and sharp like a sword about to cut down into clouds.

Catra shrugs, exhaling through her mouth. What is she supposed to say to Adora? That she still hears her mother in the back like a curse that will never leave her? That she still can see her when she is not there like a spectre that has escaped hell? That she doesn't quite remember how she made it through the woods and into the bridge today? Fuzzy and dizzy and painful? Catra cannot say that to Adora, so she says nothing at all.

Instead Catra raises one of her palms from Adora´s sweet hold, pressing her thumb over Adora´s lip and running it to the side, cleaning the trace of her staining Adora´s soft skin. Adora doesn´t notice this has happened but her eyes darken, pupils blowing up,

looking at Catra in that special kind of way that makes Catra´s soul to come aflame inside her body and her heart to burst on her throat.

Adora leans towards her, her face relaxed and mouth sweet smelling, still holding one of Catra´s hands as she rests her palm softly over Catra´s collarbones, gently caressing the skin above the neck of her shirt.

Adora has done this a million times before, touched her neck in the exact same way thousands of times more, never choking down, always resting, as if this way she could hold Catra´s heart and air inside her palm. She has done it so many times, when she is cradling Catra, hugging her, calming her, joking with her, laughing, smiling, kissing her, making love to her, holding her close.

She is not DT´s sharp nails pressing down when they were ripping a kiss off her mouth. She is not Weaver´s, her mother's broken wine glass slashing Catra´s throat open. This is *Adora,* this is Catra´s heart and soul and she has touched Catra like this a hundred times before but today it´s too much.

Catra flinches away, a look of pain crossing her eyes the second she does it. Adora stares at her, astonished, clear despair crossing her blue eyes and splintering her heart.

Shame eats its way inside Catra´s chest, rotten taste and thoughts gathering on the back of her head. Catra sighs, broken and exhausted, rolling her head back as she looks back at the violent water

“How was that rhyme again?” Catra whispers, digging the nails of her free hand against the wood until she feels splinters underneath her skin. “If a tree falls in the forest, does anybody hear it?”

The questions lingers in the air between them, heavy and sorrowful. She has ruined it again, Catra thinks, the tenderness

between them. But Adora is still holding her hand, gently drawing circles on the back of her knuckles. She brings Catra´s hand towards her mouth and kisses the inner side of her wrist instead, just as tender and sweet as if she had kissed her lips.

“No,” Adora´s voice is low too, so low that it almost loses itself with the flood of water. “But the earth will feel it”

She is the only one that knows Catra´s sorrow and she still loves Catra with her entire heart even when she shouldn't. Catra doesn´t know what she would do with her life without her. Die, probably.

There is not a world where Catra wishes to exist if Adora is not there. There is not a single thing she wouldn't do to keep her love.

Catra sniffles, biting back a rush of tears threatening to fall down.

“They hate me, all of them” Catra says firmly and she knows Adora knows exactly who she is talking about. “She tried to kill me and still I am the one that is hated. I´m the one that has the blame”

“They do not hate you,” Adora says but even for her it´s broken, her eyebrows knitted together.

Catra gives her an unimpressed look that only makes Adora´s frown deepen, searching for the right words to say,

“Everyone is scared of what happened. It hit too close to home. I´m scared too.” Adora exhales, rolling her shoulders back. “Doesn't mean it was right of Mermista to do what she did. I should have said something sooner”

“You shouldn´t. I can deal with it on my own,” Catra cuts her but has no real sharpness on it.

She opens her mouth to say something else but for some reason her own body decides to betray her right in that moment, tears

thumbling off her eyelids and down her cheek, pooling in her chin heavily and dripping one by one against her chest, darkening the already black fabric of her shirt.

Adora´s eyes widen in surprise, urgency overcoming the hardness of her expression. She leans forwards again and this time Catra doesn´t flinch away, cradling Catra´s chin between her palms, thumbing the tears off even as they keep falling and falling like broken stars. Catra tries to speak several times but her voice and breath give her away, shuddering and sad as she cries between Adora´s hands.

Adora hums softly, pulling from Catra closer to her chest, resting her forehead against hers in the oldest gesture of reassurance either of them know, Catra cries and hiccups next to Adora´s cheeks, again and again until she is breathless and worn to the bone but the pain raises off her just a little, allowing her to breath better.

Adora is still cooing at her, lingering kisses all over her temples and down the bridge of her nose, snot and all. There is a thought in Adora´s mind and it seems to win the war of precariousness because she exhales, saying the words right against Catra´s ears.

“I miss hearing you sing”

Catra chuckles, hysterical and sad, shaking her head.

“I can´t, Adora,” she says, pressing her own hand over the place where she knows her mother´s scar lives, always present and always there. “I can't do it anymore”

“I know,” Adora whispers, absently pulling Catra further and further away from the edge. “It's alright”

They lay flat in the middle of the riel and wood and several inches away from the broken edge, backs against the hard surface and one next to the other, looking at the other in silence for long minutes.

Catra´s eyelashes are matted in drying tears and black mascara, hooded and sore on the rims. Adora´s eyes are bright blue and tired too, her eyelids so faint they look like lilacs dawns in the middle of the sunset.

One of Catra´s hands is curled above her own chest, pressing down her bruised heart as she tries to subdue the pain on it. The other one is to the side, over the wood too and held tightly against Adora´s fingers laced with hers.

"What if I fall?" Catra asks at some point, because she needs to, because she knows she is broken and sometimes she needs to know that Adora, who is good and kind and tender and wears her heart on her sleeve, will stay.

Adora grins, not in joy but as the gentlest reassurance she possesses, running the fingers of her other hand over Catra´s forehead.

"I'll be with you"

It's not *´you will not fall´* , not *´I´ll keep you over the edge ´*, not *'I´ll make you better'* . Just *´I´ll be here. I´ll stay, no matter what happens or the sadness, I´ll stay next to you´*

Catra's head is not buzzing anymore.

Catra kisses Adora over the rotten and moss covered wood of the bridge, sweet and lingering, licking the roof of her mouth and tasting the honey of her goodness on the back of her throat.

She leaves a faint stain of red against the angle of Adora´s jaw, so thin Adora won´t even notice it until much later, and kisses her as the sun disappears completely behind the trees.

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"I understand," Glimmer hears the voice loud and clear, her back pressed flat against the wall outside her mother´s office. "And

Huntara? Does she think this is the same as that time?”

Silence for a few seconds. Glimmer curses the fact that her mother insists on using those old fashioned wire phones and not the communication pads and phones everyone else uses. Loud speakers are not really present in wired phones which means Glimmer cannot say what the person says back to Angella.

Whatever it is, it rips a grunt off Angella´s chest, pinching her sharp nose between her fingers. “Very well, I´ll make sure to keep it quiet.” Another second of silence, then, “And Lashor? Finish this, now. Collective hysteria is the last thing I want right now.”

The click of the phone against its base marks the end of the call, Angella´s heavy sigh filling the Office Room. Glimmer thinks about it for exactly three seconds and then bursts past the ajar door and into the room, back very straight and hands pressed into fists at her sides.

Angella barely raises her eyes from her computer screen to address Glimmer´s presence, glued to whatever she is writing quickly. “Glimmer, is the house finally alone?”

Glimmer opens her mouth, her thoughts tangling a little bit in the edges, thrown back by her mother´s questions. She gets her shit together quickly, clenching her teeth together. “Bow just left for his brother's house. The service is doing the cleaning now.”

“Good,” Angella says absently, eyes never leaving the screen. “I need you to understand that I don´t want unannounced visitors in the house for now. Things are very tense and I need you to stay safe inside.”

“They are not visitors, mom, they are my friends.”

The answer back is what finally makes Angella look up, staring at Glimmer´s face above the frame of her screen. Angella´s pink eyebrows fall into a displeased frown, her mouth curling in a scowl.

“Just obey, Glimmer. It´s for your own good. Until we know what exactly is happening I need you to stay where I know you are safe and that is here.” And then she goes right back into keep writing whatever Mayor report she is doing, silently dismissing Glimmer away.

Glimmer cheeks on the inside of her cheek, anger flaring in her chest. “Catra is still out, though.”

“I'm sure she´ll find her way back inside,” Angella says immediately, almost automatically, but her face shifts a little in the edges, eyes narrowing for a split second. It´s quick but Glimmer catches it, her weariness only growing.

“Shouldn't she be also careful? Perfuma´s killer might be wandering the town and it´s dark outside.”

“Catrina is a grown up adult, Glimmer”

“So I am”

“Yes, but you are my daughter.”

*Ouch* .

Glimmer flinches, unable to keep the scowl away from her face for a second longer. She grabs the handle of the briefcase even tighter and lifts her chin, breathing hard. In all this time, her mother doesn´t look at her even once.

“Why didn´t you tell me Catra killed her mother?”

Bingo.

Angella´s fingers freeze over the keyboard, even her breath stopping inside her chest. She finally looks up the entire screen, mouth slightly agape with surprise. Glimmer allows herself one moment to enjoy her mother´s impressed expression before giving a step forward towards her mother´s desk, breathing deeply.

“You knew, didn´t you?” Glimmer presses, clicking her tongue. “And you never said anything”

“She told you?” Angella closes the laptop with a strong swing, slamming it against the surface of the desk. It´s a small gesture but it shows just how angry Angella is suddenly. Glimmer gulps, shaking her head, trying to not lose her cool.

“Of course not. The entire town knows it. I think they want to blame what happened these days on her because of what happened with her mother.” Glimmer narrows her eyes at her mother, lilac eyes against lilac eyes. “Should they be blaming it on her, mom?”

“Glimmer,” Angella stands up from her chair, resting her palms flat against the desk and leaning over it slightly, using the advantage of her height over Glimmer as she always did since the latter was a child and she had been perfectly behaved. “Nobody is blaming anything on anybody yet. And whatever you think you know might not even be involved at all.”

“Then I need you to tell me the truth about Hordak, mom,” Glimmer cuts her, tilting her head to fumble with the zipper of the briefcase. Angella frowns, thrown aback.

“What are you talking about?” Glimmer doesn´t answer, pulling the reports of *Classified incidents* and blacked out photographs one after the other and placing them on the desk in front of her mother. Angella´s face goes from angry and confused to completely horrified and furious, gaping at the papers with blazing eyes. “Where did you get that?”

“It doesn´t matter.” Glimmer tries but Angella is already catching sight of her briefcase in Glimmer´s hands.

Angella sputters around a furious gasp, stretching her hand to try and rip the briefcase away from Glimmer´s hold. But Glimmer just steps back, shaking her head firmly.

“It matters. You were looking through my stuff, Glimmer.”

“The thing is mom, that until this morning I thought you allowing Catra to sleep here was an act of real kindness after her mother tried to murder her,” Glimmer´s voice is sharp, cold as she stares at her mother. “But now I'm wondering if you just wanted to keep an eye on her. And I'm starting to wonder if I should be keeping an eye on her too. So before I do anything, I need you to tell me if there is a reason why Catra would want to hurt the Mayor in the first place.”

Angella´s mouth falls closed with an audible click, her whole body tensing and closing up. Glimmer sighs, a cold and sticky feeling spreading through her chest.

“Tell me.”

For a second Angella seems like she will actually spill the beans, her jaw so tense that it almost pops. But then her entire demeanor changes again, straightening up on her entire height. She looks at Glimmer with narrowed eyes and Glimmer feels so small from one moment to the other, small and breathless like a child missing her father and idolizing her mother.

“You are just a kid, Glimmer. All of you are just kids.” Angella frowns, “Is that why your group was here today, to play theory and point fingers? Leave this stuff for the real detectives to investigate.”

“Oh, the detectives.” Glimmer blurts, laughing. “The same detectives that covered Hordak´s ass for over ten years on any stupidity he did? Like, I don´t know, forsake the maintenance of Thaymor´s Bridge until the railing finally collapsed and the old trolley fell to the river? Those detectives?”

By Angella's expression it is obvious that Angella was not expecting for Glimmer to actually read all the paperwork. Her usually pale face is spotted in red, eyes shimmering with shock and anger.

She wheezes, trying to speak and failing several times before settling in something cold and expressionless, the same kind of face she had given Glimmer so many times when work comes before anything else.

“Glimmer, I'm in the middle of something very important. We can discuss this matter later.”

“You are always in the middle of something!” Glimmer explodes, dropping the briefcase over the desk. “But my friend is dead so today I want you to stop being paralyzed by fear and pay attention to me!”

“Everything I do is for you!” Angella slams her first against the table, several items tumbling to the ground. Glimmer gasps, giving a single step back, eyes wide.

She has never seen her mother so angry before, her pink hair tousled and shoulders shaking violently. But Glimmer thinks it is fitting. Perfuma is dead, dead in a horrible and violent way.

Scorpia is completely heartbroken, her friends are fighting each other, Glimmer is scared and Adora also lied to her. Her best friend who Glimmer loves and trusts knew about Weaver and she didn't tell Glimmer, not even after Catra moved in with her, too blindsided by love to even begin to think the violence might be related.

*I couldn't tell you, any of you,* Adora had said once everyone else left, her eyes so heavy, pretty face pleading and sad. *You're her friend too, please don't forsake her.*

Glimmer is not taking this lightly, she is not taking her friend's safety for granted ever again.

“Then tell me the truth, mom. Tell me why you have so many files about Hordak, about the cover up of his stuff” Glimmer breathes, shaking. “What else are you hiding?”

Angella grunts, covering her eyes with one hand, the other against her hip. She remains quiet for a long time, taking deep intakes of air before letting her hand fall down her face, standing right in front of Glimmer.

Her face looks extremely tired, thin and long, age suddenly weighing her down like a mural in the wall crumbling into pieces.

“I was the one covering Hordak´s stuff. Most of it and for a long time.” Angella admits, voice slow.

The words fall over Glimmer like thousands of bricks, robbing her of her breath.

“What?”

Angella stretches her hand towards her as if she were to cradle her face but thinks it better and drops her hand back down.

“Glimmer, you need to understand. He was a powerful man and powerful men are dangerous, especially men with connections like him. A lot of stuff was at risk after your father died. Our position, our home, our stability, it all would be at risk if I didn't help him, you need to understand that.”

“No I don´t.” Glimmer denies, giving a step back. It seems to hurt her mother deeply.

“I know you don't, but Hordak made some important enemies too, so I need you to stay out of the way and let me handle all of this on my own.” Angella gets even closer, letting her hands fall heavily over Glimmer's shoulders. Her smile is void of all joy, almost frantic. “Now that I'm the Mayor I will fix everything, and I will not rest until whoever is doing this pays. I have that power now.”

“But you had proof. You could have fixed whatever you knew long ago. What if Perfuma was murdered because of something he did? For something that could have been stopped?”

Glimmer sniffles, cleaning her eyes with the back of her arm. Anger gives away to disgust then to fear and then to complete disappointment. She looks at her mother as if she didn't know her, heart pained in her chest.

“You're a coward.”

“Glimmer –”

“I wish dad would be here instead of you.” Glimmer says between clenched teeth, tears falling off her face. “He would be ashamed of what you became.”

Angella's face is terrible, completely pale and broken in half. She stares at Glimmer for a long second, not able to believe what she just heard off her daughter's mouth until her brain finally seems to click it into place, transforming her hurt and shock into plain anger.

“Go to your room,” Angella demands, very slowly. “Go to your room right now, you are prohibited from leaving this house unless I say so, do you understand?”

Glimmer holds her mother's eyes, so similar to each other yet so different, unable and unwilling to give her the satisfaction of an answer. Glimmer turns into her ankles marching across the office and towards the door, hands into fists.

“Glimmer,” Angella calls at the back but Glimmer ignores her. “Glimmer!”

Glimmer slams the door on her way out, stomping down the corridor and towards her own room. The voice of her mother is still echoing behind her but she doesn't turn to look back.

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*End of Chapter III*

Chapter End Notes

NOTE: Catra slept with DT once. It was all consensual, she was a hundred percent aware of what was going on. It sucked anyway. There is nothing more to say about that

Not gonna lie, I'm a little bit surprised that NOBODY so far realized Weaver is dead, because yes she IS a hundred percent dead, that bitch. Also, yes, Catra is extremely depressed be aware the suicide ideation tag was for her, my poor baby (as if I didn't write it myself). Teen Idle is really THE Catra song.

Lots of information today! Angella dips her toes further into the mystery and so does Mermista.

DT makes an apparition ! Some of you guessed right that they were driving the car on the Interlude. Wonder what are their intentions?

Also the place where Starla died might or.not.might be important. Did you know writing murders is really freaking hard too? I'm burnt out tbh but so happy to see you plotting already.

I'm giggling and kicking my feet already.

See you all on Monday! Next chapter is, well, you should rest this weekend. Be good little readers! ( ͡ᵔ ͜ʖ ͡ᵔ)

# The Shroud of Penelope

Chapter Summary

> “She is going to ruin you and I´m not going to allow that, Adora”

Chapter Notes

> Deep breaths everybody
>
> WARNINGS FOR THIS CHAPTER:
> - Graphic descriptions of death
> - Graphic descriptions of murder
> - Wounds, blood, weapons
> - Panic attacks, anxiety attacks
>
> Here it is, the most difficult chapter I have ever done. The feared fourth chapter.
> Maybe get a glass of water or something and please forgive me
>
> Remember that AO3 will be off tomorrow for ten hours so save the fics and chapter you need!
> See you downstairs!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

## [The Shroud of Penelope]

*I'm the paper cut that kills you and the priest that you ignored*

*I'm the touch you crave, I'm the plans that you made*

*But fuck all your plans, I'm bored*

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♕

## October 26th, early morning

“Hey, Mara,” Adora says to the phone, leaning her forehead against the cold window. “This is Adora, again”

It's raining again, finally after two days of unbearable heat, the sky ripping open and pouring all of its strength down the earth. It fogs all the windows of the huge house with its cold, big droplets slamming themselves against the crystals in a way that sometimes makes them tremble, drowning every single sound from the inside out.

The sky is a particular kind of gray that makes everything else look like coated in silver, swirling tumultuous clouds clashing with each other and tearing themselves apart. Adora looks at them from her spot on the small window seat tucked between the library and the frame of the door, her feet resting tucked below her and body aching.

It´s very early in the morning, not even five yet, and her eyes are exhausted and red, testimony of a restless night where neither the rain nor her mind allowed her to sleep and rest. She cannot take off her head the memory of Perfuma hanging like a trophy among flowers and blood; the image of her own name scribbles like some kind of twisted love letter on the walls and the windows and the floors, dripping scarlet and carefully made.

Adora is afraid, she is scared as fuck. She has been trying very hard to keep it together since Hordak´s body was found and later Perfuma´s, but she doesn´t know how much longer she can hold herself straight and brave for everyone else. Mermista was right on something, those murders were related and Adora is the end of the trail of them.

She kept seeing the unknown number on her phone historial, wondering if she had enough guts to dial right back But she found herself frozen in sudden fear at the thought, too tense to even move, like a butterfly stung by a scorpion.

Instead Adora had ended up coming back to Light Hope home, spending hours with her on the space of her office and then, when it was over, tucking herself under too cold and empty blankets and staring at the ceiling of her room until her eyes burned and she walked down to the library just to lay flat on the floor, hair pooling on the floor beneath her head, her back itching.

She wanted more than anything to bring Catra with her, snuck her through the back door and lock them both inside the quiet room, but it had been a miracle already that Light Hope had not murdered her on the spot with how angry she was when Adora walked inside.

Adora had let Catra go at the end of the day, once the night was dark and quiet around them, helping her instead to climb the columns of the balcony and sneak through the window, Adora had held herself on the pink and golden guardrail covered in tiny flowers and leaned to kiss her sweet and slow one last before Catra slipped among shadows towards her guest bedroom.

Adora had silently begged for her to be careful and walked away before anyone could see her, service, Glimmer or god forbid Angella herself. Adora was in no mood to try and talk about what was happening to the town, her friends or her.

Huntara had called, however, several times actually but Adora rejected every single one, cleaning the tears off her eyes and clenching her teeth when they didn 't stop from coming. She is wearing black today, as she was wearing it two days ago, except that this time she doesn´t have to go and pretend she cares, this time she has to walk inside the chapel and say goodbye to an actual friend, beloved and already missed.

But first, she needed to call. She needed to try first, just once today, to see if the phone call would go through or would remain silent as it has done for years now. As always, only the static of the voice message greets her back, ripping a tired exhale from her chest.

“I just– a lot of shit is happening right now and I'm, I'm afraid,” Adora says to nothing, scratching her collarbones until the skin is red and aches and she has to forcefully pull it back down. “I don't know what to do. I– I feel like a shadow is coming for me and it will just get so much worse. I don't know how to protect my friends. And Catra–”

Adora cuts herself short, wetting her bottom lip with the tip of her tongue. The speaker is still quiet, gone, any kind of reassurance or sweet advice she would have received years ago. Adora leans further against the cold grass, wrinkling her nose.

“When you left I was so confused, and I was so hurt, but I need you again. I need you to tell me what to do,” Adora´s voice breaks in the seams, choking her. “I know you don't even have this number anymore but- I just wish you could come back home.”

Mara is Adora´s direct cousin, daughter of an aunt that died too young and that was once Marlena´s – Adora´s mother– sister. She was older than Adora, wiser and kind in all senses, with a lion heart that would never break under any circumstance, with a wonder for the town and the world Adora wished she could have too, and a sense of duty that would even match Adora´s sometimes.

After her parents' accident, Mara had taken Adora with her, fourteen and shaken to the bone, and had nurtured her back to health. She had cared for her, loved her, taught her the kind of stuff Adora´s parents would have done if they were to be alive. Sports and education and following her heart. Mara was respected among the town as a Montenegro and a good person in general, incapable of harm or ill in her heart.

Mara and Catra had been the only reasons why Adora had lived through the tragedy of losing her family. And after the sadness had settled in Adora´s bones and she had come to terms with never seeing her parents or Adam ever again, she understood she was not alone. Catra was there, as a constant, as a pillar of her life; and Mara was there, helping her hold the pieces together and

loving them both and helping her to be better, to seek a happy life instead of a perfect one.

Then Mara had fallen in love, and little by little pieces of Adora's newfound peaceful life had come crumbling down, tilting out of her control before neither of them even noticed it.

Mara and sixteen years old Adora had moved from their shoe box apartment to Light Hope´s huge manor, spotless and bright like a crystal castle, nothing like the mud on their soles when they played with the rain or the ripped holes on their jeans from hiking in the woods.

Light Hope was perfect, straight as a piece of polished diamond and unwavering from her decision and her posture. The only times Adora ever saw her trip or hitch for anything at all were all caused by Mara and somehow that simple act made Adora believe they would love each other forever.

But there was something Light Hope loved more than Mara and that was the chapel. Work, and the chapel and work, following the paths of the First Ones and their visions for a greatest future, with tall towers of nothing real like grass and spotless moments of life. And the swift moment where she laughed next to Mara´s face became smaller and smaller until they disappeared completely.

The last time Adora had ever seen Mara had been a march morning before going to highschool. Light Hope had enrolled Adora without her permission for the trials of both the volleyball team, the track team and even the cheerleaders one, insisting that filling up her activities for her curriculum would serve her a golden spot on the First One Academy when the time came.

Adora was getting ready, slightly asleep still and grumbling for not being able to accompany Catra to her choir lesson when she heard the screams coming from the living room, the broken glass on the floor and what sounded truly frightening and clearly like a slap to the face.

Adora had rushed back down just to find Mara scrambling for her car keys and closing the heavy door of the house without looking back even once; and Light Hope standing in the middle of the chaotic living room, cheek pulsing and red and eyes cold.

Adora had never seen Mara again after that. She never answered her phone, never sent a message back no matter how many times and in how many ways Adora had tried and failed to reach her again, no matter how desperate her pleas for Mara to come back were or how defeated she sounded in the phone. She took her things, her car and everything she was and left without looking back once, like the ghost of a dream that was never real to begin with.

She left fifteen years old Adora with Light Hope who didn´t kicked out only for the fact that she had known Adora´s parents deeply too, specially Marlena´s. Admired her even, like a devotee.

Light Hope had taken over, always with her mind and goals in Adora´s future and the path of life she was sure Marlena and Randor would have wanted for Adora, and for Adam if he had lived. School, perfect grades, sports, mass in the chapel, a princess. Adora held herself to that new constant and things changed and with time Adora changed too, for bad sometimes but for good too.

But no matter how many changes and years passed, Adora could not stop wondering what had really happened to Mara all those years ago, where could she be today or yesterday or at the start of the week. Now that Adora´s peace was crumbling to the ground again, so close to being able to break free, Adora missed her more than ever.

“She is not going to answer,” Light Hope´s voice echoes inside the library, making Adora jump with surprise. Adora turns around to see Light Hope standing next to the frame of the door, her face blank as always but her eyes hard, like cutting glass inside her face.

“Light Hope,” Adora exhales, clutching the phone inside her hands.

There is a very strange expression swirling inside Light Hope´s eyes, not even looking at Adora but at some point outside of the window, towards the rain and the nothing. She opens and closes her hands slowly, finger twitching.

“Mara was– disappointing, at best.” Light Hope continues, her lips slightly curling over her teeth, the only give away of her true feelings.

Adora drops her feet off the seat, resting her bare soles over the cold wood tiles on the floor. She curls her hands over her lap, pinching at the skin under her nails with her heart beating inside her eardrums. Light Hope never talks about Mara, not once, so Adora is not letting go of the thread now.

“I thought you loved her”

“Love gets you nowhere, Adora,” Light Hope's voice is sharp like brittle glass, painful in the corners where her anger sees through her facade of perfection. “ *You* should know that”

Adora takes a sharp breath, the words weighing over her like an accusation, too personal to be anything other but hurting.

Adora shakes her head softly, letting the soft strands of her hair brush her cheek gently. Light Hope had pulled all of her hair into a headaching ponytail a few hours ago and it is starting to pull from the roots of her temples painfully.

“I don't agree, Hope.”

How could Adora ever agree with that when she has Catra? When she knows what it is like to love her and be loved by her? Catra, who is her heart walking outside of her body?

Light Hope´s face twitches, just a fraction, mask breaking in the edges. She holds herself so strange in front of Adora, as if her

body could not hold her anymore, as if there was something festering below the expensive fabric of her work dress and the sharp heel of her boots. Adora shakes at the sight of whatever this is, cold adrenaline washing over her veins.

“Your cousin was supposed to love you and care for you after your parents passed away, yet she ditched you and left you here the first opportunity she had,” Light Hope spats, hands shaking and it's only then that Adora realizes how hard she is closing her hands, digging her nails against her palm. “Love doesn't work”

Light Hope marches firmly towards Adora, gripping the curtains of the window she is leaning into and closing them in one swing, earring all the rain and light off the room.

Adora cringes at the proximity, wrinkling her nose and scratching the back of her neck, standing up from the seat as Light Hope makes sure the window is well secured, almost as if she thought Adora would melt and slip away in the creeks of the woods.

Adora looks at her, weary, studying her posture. Something very weird is going on with Light Hope that she had not seen before. Her dress slightly wrinkled in the skirt, a sight never seen before; her forehead coated with a very light sweat in the point where her buzz short hair meets her forehead. Light Hope´s eyes are almost glistening, frantic and angry even, a rotten kind of thing boiling inside her irises that Adora doesn't know how to place.

“Adora, I hope I was clear this morning. I don't want you running around in town anymore,” Light Hope says between clenched teeth, turning her blazing eyes at her. “You embarrassed me and embarrassed yourself yesterday. In front of the entire town *and* in front of Priest Prime. For your own good I want you to step away.”

Adora flinches softly, wrinkling her nose. She knew ignoring Light Hope at the square yesterday was going to cost her deeply but after Light Hope sent her without a word to her room last night she foolishly thought she could get away unscarred from it. Beginners mistake.

Adora clears her throat, trying to keep her face blank as she scrambles on her brain for something to say. She cannot just stay home and hope everything will go away. “My classes–”

“School is closed for now, you know that,” Light Hope cuts her off, hovering over her like a marble statue. “And by all means, I might just ask your professors to give you the materials here to finish the course instead.”

A pang of fear crosses Adora´s chest, the walls of the library suddenly too tight and closed all around her. She clears her throat, trying to convince herself that maybe Light Hope is just weary about the murders as everyone else is too. That very deep inside her coal and robotic hair, Light Hope might be worried, scared even, and that she cares about Adora more than she has ever let through. Once again, she is proved wrong almost immediately.

“Light Hope, everything is going to be alright–” Adora starts saying but is cut short by Light Hope extending a thick piece of folder paper towards her. Adora frowns down at it, confused as she takes it between her hands and unfolds it carefully, squinting her eyes under the new darkness of the room. “What is this?”

“Read it,” Light Hope orders, every second more on edge.

Adora is not wearing her glasses and even with contacts it takes her a second to recognize it, but finally the beginning letters and the blazing red crest on the top make sense for her. The bold and sharp colors of a college acceptance staring back at her fully.

“It´s an acceptance for Horde College. They accepted me,” Adora mutters in wonder, mixed feelings filling her chest. She has been waiting exactly for this letter for so long now, checking the mail every day and waiting with bouncing knees. And here it is, finally. Given to her from the hand of Light Hope.

Adora raises her head, looking at Light Hope, so tense she feels about to explode. “Where did you–?

“It arrived in the mail, two weeks ago. You know I´m always making sure the mail arrives in order”

Adora blinks twice, horror washing over her. “Two weeks ago?”

“I called and canceled it, I told them you had already accepted another offer. They were most understanding”

Adora gasps, horrified, a violating feeling wrapping itself around her bones. She is listening to Light Hope but still cannot make off her words, clutching the paper close to her chest. “What? Why did you do that?”

Light Hope narrows her eyes at her, clicking her tongue against her teeth. “You know why. You know First Ones Academy has a spot for you already. You are damaging the path that has been laid for you”

Light Hope is annoyed, it's clear on every single corner of her body. That's good, because Adora is furious.

“So that's it?” Adora demands, chuckling nervously. “I don't get to choose for myself? I don't get to decide what I want?”

“No, this is your destiny.” Light Hope steps closer to Adora space, making her press herself flush against the wall, the papers now completely wrinkled inside her hands. Light Hope studies her closely, frowning. “You had already accepted, last year you accepted it”

“Well I made a mistake!” Adora stomps on the ground, running her hands through her hair, messing up the ponytail as baby hairs fall over her forehead. “Who do you think you are to do this?!”

Somehow, just this single movement of rebellion seems to make Light Hope lose her marbles.

Light Hope shoots her hand forward, wrapping Adora´s chin between her fingers, hard, locking her in place. Adora gasps in surprise, suddenly feeling as small and lost like the day Mara left.

“Be quiet,” Light Hope grunts, scowling. “Why did you send an application in the first place?”

“I–” Adora tangles in her words, trying to snap her head away and finding herself unable to do so. “The program–”

“There is no major in medicine in Horde College, don´t lie to me.”

Light Hope stares at Adora intently, every single twitch and nervous wrinkle of her face. Adora tries to keep her face neutral even though suddenly she feels terrified but something must give her away because Light Hope's face falls, a dark cloud like the rain outside fogging her expression into nothing.

“It's where *she* is going, isn't it?” Adora closes her mouth so fast that she bites herself, blood filling her tongue, but Light Hope has already caught up. “You are going to let your future go to the drain for her? After all the sacrifices that have been done for you?”

“Get off me, Hope, you are hurting me,” Adora grunts, clenching her teeth. Light Hope drops her face and steps back still looking at Adora not like a human but like a piece of art that has suddenly found herself stained or a piece of machine that has gone rogue on its master's hands. Adora rubs her chin with her fingers, her heart hammering with fear inside her chest. “You are acting like a madman.”

“She is going to ruin you.” A shuddering breath. Adora´s heart seizes inside her chest, painfully, terror falling down her shoulders at the dark expression in Light Hope´s face, darker than the storm outside or the depth of the woods. Dark and full of hatred. “She is going to ruin you and I´m not going to allow that, Adora”

Adora slumps against the wall, her head connecting with the boring and plane wallpaper painfully. All her nerve endings are on point, burning and aching on the deep of her body and the marrow of her bone. Once again her world is spiraling out of her control and she doesn´t know how to stop it.

Light Hope´s eyes become hooded, her hands linking in front of her body as if she was about to drop into her knees and say a prayer. She stares at a point over Adora´s chest where the small reliquary shaped as a drop that Catra had gifted to Adora after the Montenegro´s funeral hangs next to her heart, narrowing her eyes at it. Adora had not worn it for a while but she placed it gently around her neck this morning, with the overwhelming need to hold herself to the golden metal inside of which her family´s and Catra´s portrait rested securely. Adora had never shown it to Light Hope, but something nasty inside of her tells her Light Hope already knows what's in it.

"I've spoken about this *rebellion* of yours with Priest Prime, when the letter arrived. He was very surprised too that you were planning to leave, and without a word. Just like Mara" Light Hope wets her dry lips with the tip of her tongue, sighing deeply. Adora opens her mouth, horror clogging her throat, but Light Hope raises a hand to shut her down, dark eyes so cold they might cut Adora into pieces. "I have spoken with Detective Lashor too. He says that girl that has you wrapped on her finger will be charged with the murders in no time"

"Light Hope," Adora gasps, voice raw, the mention of harm falling over Catra too being the only thing capable of pulling her out of the depths of despair. "You cannot believe that"

"I believe what I see and what I see is that she murdered her mother and will bring you down with her," Light Hope walks until she is right in front of Adora, wrapping her hand around the reliquary´s chain, pulling from it harshly and barely avoiding not to break it. "I have been very patient and very easy going with this love affair of yours, but enough is enough. I won't let her destroy you."

Adora grunts, shock and pain and betrayal giving away to anger. She pulls herself free from Light Hope´s grasp, pressing her palm flat against her own chest, feeling the hysteric flutter of her heart beneath her fingertips.

“I love her,” Adora says, firm as the earth, “Mara left us, Light Hope, you are right. She left me, she left you and we will never know why. You might not believe in love anymore and it might be Mara´s fault, but it's not my burden and it's not Catra´s. I trust her, I want to be with her, and she is good. Good for me and good for my life.”

“And if she is not?” Light Hope barks, shaken to the core by the mention of Mara´s life once tangled with hers like Adora and Catra are.

Adora throws her shoulders back, tall and strong and devoted like a swan about to take fly. She will not waver, she will not doubt, no matter if the sky comes down in rain of fire or if the entire ground is soaked in red, Adora will not doubt Catra.

“I will not betray her by believing the worst of her.”

“Then I will do whatever is necessary to get her away from you,” Light Hope slams her fist against the crystal table next to her hip, cracking the surface in colorful pieces. “I will not have the path that has been created for you to go to waste and I will not have you become Mara too. I'll do what I need to.”

Adora clenches her teeth so hard the tip of her molars chip under the pressure, narrowing her eyes at Light Hope. All of the sudden her mind has locked down, weary and studying Light Hope under a new light.

“What is that supposed to mean?” Adora asks slowly, clenching her hands against her sides.

Light Hope´s face closed up violently fast, all emotion draining from her face immediately. She stumbles back, fighting with whatever is going inside her chest as she tears her eyes away. She circles Adora, giving long purposeful steps towards the open door.

Adora sputters, incredulous. “You're leaving?”

“I have to work, Adora, you know that,” Light Hope says, voice void and emotionless. She is still not looking at Adora when she tilts her head back a little in her direction “I should be back by the end of the week. I will leave word to Lashor and Huntara to keep an eye on you. I will not have you running around with that girl anymore.”

“Light Hope–”

“Adora,” Light Hope cuts her furiously, voice in flames.

Adora fights with her own need to scream, to yell and howl and slam her own body against the ground because this is just not fair, but she holds it back.

No good will come in picking a fight with Light Hope again and Adora has lost so much already, the papers of Horde College forgotten in the ground. She cannot risk losing a single thing more, she cannot risk losing Catra, not now.

Adora will call Bow later to pick her up, it doesn't matter if Light Hope sends her minions to watch her or not. Adora is on her own and has no other choice, she knows this now.

Light Hope snaps her head away and walks right past the door frame, steps heavy. Adora leans her head back and sighs, deep from within her chest.

She narrows her eyes sadly to the ceiling before straightening again and walking out of the library too, her steps just as heavy as her heart.

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♛

“Leaving already?”

Catra freezes on her steps, already halfway over the balcony’s rail covered in leaves and tiny flowers. Catra closes her eyes counting

on her head just exactly how many marble she has left before she loses her head finally.

Not enough to deal with Sparkles shit today.

Catra drops back on the flat floor, turning to the source of the voice. Glimmer is leaning against one of the pillars of the huge widow, arms crossed over her chest and eyes narrowed, staring at Catra like a fox that has found a stray cat has gotten into its territory.

Catra huffs, running her fingers over her hair, ruffling the ends of the long ponytail that brushes the ends of her waist. She taps her fingers over the stone rail, grinning at Sparkles all glorious confidence and chin raised.

“Are you following me, Sparkles? Don't you think it's a little bit paranoid of you?” Catra asks, her voice sultry and mocking, the sarcasm rolling easily off her tongue.

“Is it now?” Glimmer's questions right back in the same time of voice. They are not so different, Catra of Glimmer.

Catra chuckles, throwing her head back to give one single shallow laugh, incredulity washing over her cold and merciless. “Oh I see. Mer–stupid and her dumb attempt to play Clue really did make a mess of you after all.”

“Her name is Mermista”, Glimmer says, jaw locked. “If you don't want me to be paranoid then why on earth are you slipping off like a freaking thief in the only spot where cameras cannot see you?”

“Unlike you, I don't fancy being watched all the time by my mother,” Catra chews the words, grasping a handful or green leaves inside her fingers and tearing them apart, absently, staining the skin of her fingertips in green. “I'm going to Adora's, I'm sick of being locked here for a second longer”

“Adora is not in the house,” Glimmer says, frowning. She studies Catra´s face, sees the way her confidence tilts in the edges and confusion eats at the ends of her eyes, breathing slightly erratic no matter how hard she tries to hide it otherwise.

“She sent a text saying Light Hope had wanted to ground her but that she needed to get out of the house too. Bow called me, he picked up Adora like half an hour ago. they are going to Perfuma’s memorial in the square”

“Oh,” Catra blinks, her blue eye and the hazel one dark, long eyelashes casting shadows over her cheeks.

She bites into the inside of her own cheek, taking her hands away from the rail so she can cross them over her chest, an embrace to herself that she doesn´t seem to notice she does.

Glimmer wrinkles her nose, stretching her arms in front of her chest. She is still and weary but a new kind of emotion makes it under her skin, like a worm eating its way below her cells and drinking off the adrenaline pumping in her veins. Glimmer doesn´t know how to name it.

“She didn't tell you?”

“Obviously not, Sparkles. Why else would I have this face?”

Satisfaction. That´s the word.

Catra notices too because her eyes harden like crystals, freckled cheeks going from pale to spotted in red. The air is very cold around them, petrichor smelling and sticking to their skins.

Catra has come to know a lot about Catra in the months after Weaver's *incident.* She did not see her right after, locked away in a tiny and warm apartment until she healed, but Glimmer did see her after and she came to understand a lot of things about her.

She is sarcastic and sharp and sometimes even frighteningly smart, yes; always three or ten steps in front of everyone else,

twitching on her toes to jump into action if needed or to step away when it was convenient. She is soft too but only with Adora, only too Adora, and sometimes Glimmer wished she could have accepted Adoras´s pleas and get to know Catra before the incident, because this Catra that stand in front of Glimmer now it ´s different to the one they went to pull out of a smoking car next to the quarry. Glimmer still doesn´t if it is a better change or a worse one.

She is beautiful, she is almost the most beautiful woman Glimmer has seen in her entire life, just below Adora herself who looks like an angel and a golden saint pulled out of a painting, sun kissed skin and honey hair. Catra is lean and strong in all the right places; elegant like a panther, all of her movements perfect and elaborated, treating the ground below her feet like a ballerina's dance floor. The hair Adora so much likes to play with is carefully taken care of, loops of a brown so dark that look like melted chocolate, framing her rich face spotted in freckles. Her eyes are bright and cutting, weighing the world under a kind of light Glimmer doesn´t know.

Before the incident, Glimmer knew she used to sing and that she was extraordinary at it, a nightingale under a rainy day. And Glimmer knew that because Adora would not shut up about Catra, not even once, not even when they were fighting and angry with each other and Glimmer thought they would break apart completely.

She is mesmerizing, captivating in the way a dangerous animal is covered in colors, wrapping the world and Adora in the strings of her heart.

Maybe in another life Glimmer would have had a crush on her, maybe in another life she would have admired her, she almost did in this life. But Glimmer´s mind has been buzzing and alert the entire night, weighing every single conversion, interaction and look Glimmer had with Catra in the present and the past, searching for anything that would give her a clue or a reason to

be worried, to be weary and to be ready to slam her into the ground if needed.

But–

*She is your friend too,* Adora had begged them at the table yesterday, when Glimmer was too stunned by the truth of what really had happened to even begin to think to intervene on the hurricane Mermista had raised. Adora has pleaded to her friends and confided to Glimmer the reason why she kept that single piece of information of Catra´s past hidden for so long. And she was right, Glimmer was not one to forsake her friends, not even those that were acting specially fucking weird right now.

Glimmer loves Adora enough to give Catra a chance.

"Well then I'll just fuck off somewhere else, then," Catra grumbles after a second of silence, turning once again towards the balcony.

"Catra," Glimmer gives a step forward, stretching her arm towards her without actually reaching her. Catra flinches at the sudden movement, absently bringing a hand to her throat. Glimmer wrinkles her nose, letting her hand fall down again. "Stay here, please"

The words seem to have some kind of weight over Catra that Glimmer doesn´t know, hesitating on her place between the manor and the exit of the balcony. She grunts, pressing her mouth into a tight line, slumping against the rail with her arms crossed over her chest.

"Aren't you nervous to be in the same room with a murderer?" Her voice is cold, edging into ire, but Glimmer still thinks she can hear the sorrowful edge on it.

Glimmer rolls her eyes, worrying her bottom lip against her teeth. "Catra, I've heard you snore all the way from your room to mine, I think I will be fine for now"

Catra huffs, kicking her feet against the marble, quiet. Glimmer takes several deep breaths, gathering herself before giving another step forward.

"Adora explained to me and to Bow why she couldn't tell us what happened with your– with Weaver," Glimmer chews on the words, really unsure on how to step inside all of this. She doesn´t want to scare Catra or push her over the edge, but she also doesn´t fully trust her to not lash out. Carefully, Glimmer decides, truthfully yes but with caution. "And to be honest? I understand, I would be super pissed off too if all people remembered from me was the way I could escape from a woman that abused me for years"

"The entire town knew," Catra says, so low and tangled on her tongue that Glimmer almost misses it. Catra is frowning, looking at some point to the side. "Not just about that day, they knew the kind of person *she* became after my dad died. They knew how she treated me and everyone allowed her to do it"

"I guess they thought, being your mother–"

"I was a child"

"Yeah, I know"

They both fall silent, words too heavy to duel on them for too long. Glimmer is so curious, so fucking eager to ask and know everything. Not because she wants to know the morbid details of how Catra blew Weaver´s head trying to defend herself but to understand what happened so she can understand if it has something to do with what is going on now. She holds back because she knows nothing good will come with blowing off the precarious calm between them.

Catra´s breath hitches, a kind of expression crossing her pretty eyes that Glimmer cannot place.

"If the entire town thinks every single bad shit that happens is my fault just because I survived, then they can rot. I did not need

Mermista's friendship, I did not need your mother's love and I do not need you feeling guilty because of it." Catra spits, "I don´t give a fuck anymore."

"Catra"

"Just–" Catra stops her, her nails digging on the flesh of her own tight. "Keep your nose out of my shit, Glimmer, for once in your life."

"Miss Glimmer?" A guard walks into the start of the corridor at Glimmer´s back, bowing her head to her gently. She looks at Catra there too but doesn´t greet her, instead staring directly at Glimmer. "Your breakfast is ready. Your mother left orders to keep you comfortable at home while she is off in the Mayor's Office."

"And Catra?" Glimmer asks, frowning, unable to not notice the exclusion of Catra´s name on the woman´s sentence. The woman doesn´t even move, her perfectly tailored lilac uniform straight as a pencil.

"I wasn´t given any indication of her."

Glimmer clenches her teeth, sighing deeply. She has not spoken to her mother since last night but she is certainly not happy with her and Angella is not happy with Glimmer right back. And things like this only make Glimmer anger get so much worse.

"Listen Catra–" Glimmer starts, turning back towards Catra´s position. She cuts herself short, words falling flat because Catra is not in the balcony anymore, swiftly and quietly climbing away the second the guard came into the picture.

"Fuck," Glimmer stomps in the ground, spitting the curse as she turns around and hurries down the opposite way, ignoring the guard that follows her right behind like a shadow.

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“Ugh, come on  Sea Hawk,” Mermista calls, rolling her eyes. “You ´ve been here for forever, we need to make it to the square.”

“I am coming, my beloved!” Sea Hawk calls back from inside the Arcade where he works.

His voice echoes inside the empty establishment of the empty mall, the neon lasers as their only source of light. Beside the Arcade, every single other establishment is closed and dark, corridors and corridors echoing floors all around them. Not even the emergency lights are on, wrapping everything in that kind of horrid shade only horror movies have, dark and mysterious, only waiting for the tense soundtrack to play. And Mermista knows a lot about horror movies so she doesn't feel particularly happy about being strained here.

It was kind of obvious that the mall would be this fucking empty, after all nobody wants to be strolling around after two brutal murders have shaken the town. Mermista wouldn't even accept to come if it weren't because Sea Hawk forgot his damn truck keys inside the Arcade´s office and because Mermista´s parents took her car from her so she would not go running around while the town was in unspoken lockdown.

Being here in the first place it's annoying and it´s stupid, like going for a stroll in the woods and walking into the open mouth of a wolf, tempting him not to eat you when you smell like fear and cooking bacon. Stupid really.

“Sea Hawk!”

“Got them! Got them!”

More boxes falling and something of glass definitely crashing against the floor, leaving a mess everywhere as Sea Hawk tries to make his way from the back without breaking his neck or at least some other poor item that has crossed his way. Mermista rolls her eyes, annoyance washing over her. She doesn´t even know yet why she still allows him to run behind her like a bright eyed dog.

And she will definitely never admit that its because, very secretly and deep in the furthest places of her heart, she finds it endearing as fuck.

Mermista´s phone starts vibrating violently inside the pocket of her legging, ringing loudly among all the silence. Mermista cringes, wrinkling her nose at the loud sound as she scrutinizes the corridors, bringing the phone to her ear.

"Tallstar, about time." Mermista answers, huffing. The air feels very heavy out of sudden, hovering all around Mermista like a bad omen. Bad, very bad. "Where are you guys? We are already in the Arcade and I´m freaking the fuck up."

Mermista thinks she sees movement out of the corner of her eyes, from side to side of one of the stores. Mermista clenches her teeth, narrowing her eyes as she curses the neon lights and soft twinkling coming from the play machines. She also curses herself for waiting outside of the store instead of inside because really, fucking beginners error.

Mermista pulls from the blue strands fading to the soft yellow of her hair, a silent memorial for Perfuma, frowning at the phone. On the other side TallStar is freaking out, speaking so fast and so unlike herself that her words stumble with each other and break into places, unintelligible as the static of the phone plays a stunt on her.

"What? Calm down, I can´t understand you." Mermista leans towards the corridor, sharp eagle eyes as she takes on every dark corner and place where an idiot might be hiding. She thinks she sees a huge form in the far end but after a few seconds of watching she can make out of the branches of an indoor plant, playing a trick on her eyes. She is going insane inside this place and honestly, how much more time Sea Hawk need so they can get the fuck out? "What did you say about Starla?"

A new sound inside the Arcade calls Mermista´s attention, making her turn around. The sound of heavy steps over the old fashioned

carpet on the floor and a twinkling high echo right behind them, filling every corner. For some reason the entire Arcade has gone completely dark from one second to the other, drowning everything in shadows. Even the Arcade machines and the god forsaken neon lights are off, the stupid little music that comes with them disappearing too. Mermista hadn´t noticed just how quiet the mall was without it.

Mermista´s heartbeat starts to skyrocket, blood rushing inside her ears. She can only hear the steps now, not even Sea Hawk clumsy walk or his dumb jolly songs being whistled all the time. She narrows her eyes further, trying and failing to make off the shapes inside the Arcade.

It´s so dark that she can see herself reflected over the clean crystal when she pushes the door, trying to open it. But When the Arcade is closed it will only open from the inside so she is stuck outside, bile starting to pool in the back of her throat.

She is about to yell Sea Hawk´s name or just to plainly slam the trash can next to her against the crystal when the shadows of the Arcade move and Sea Hawk walks from the darkness, holding his car keys with the shell-shaped keychain in front of his face like a piece of trophy he is very proud about.

"Here they are my dear!" Sea Hawk exclaims, a little louder as he stands at the other side of the crystal door. "And I turned off the power too! This time the circuits won´t catch on fire! Probably!"

"Ugh, about time."

Mermista exhales, rolling her eyes and face palming herself so hard that it hurts a little. She grumbles under her breath, wrinkling her nose when she looks up again at the faint trace of facial hair that Sea Hawk has been trying too hard to shape into a proper mustache, even though he is only twenty years old. She is almost too distracted by it that she doesn´t notice Sea Hawk's face has changed, from bright and triumphant to horrified, his

dark eyes wide and mouth falling open as he mouths something at Mermista that she cannot hear well.

" What?" Mermista leans closer, trying to make out what the hell he is saying when her reflection moves too, dark and looming and covered in a black robe.

No, not her reflection, the reflection of the shadow standing right behind her that she had failed to hear coming before.

"Mermista run!" Sea Hawk screams at the top of his lungs at the same time Mermista gasps, a blood cutting yell that never comes out as it tangles in her lungs and makes her freeze.

It's so violent and so fast that Mermista doesn't even notice it until it's happening. The killer grabs her by the back of the shirt and yanks her back with all its force, using Mermista momentaneum shock and fear to move her around like a puppet without strings. It pulls back and back from her spine until Mermista wheezes and then slams her forwards, crashing the entire front of her body against the crystal door of the Arcade.

Pain floors every single cell of Mermista´s body, her sight going blurry and frighteningly dark from one second to the other. Dizziness and nausea are pulling from all the strings of her consciousness as she tastes her own blood with the tip of her tongue, gushing out of her nose. For the split of a second as her brain starts processing what is happening and the pain blooming in her entire body she realizes she might pass out and that along and such a frightening thought when a fucking serial killer is grabbing you by the nape that Mermista finds enough courage to shake herself awake.

Sea Hawk falls against the crystal door too, from the other side, pulling from the lock again and again missing it when his hands tremble like crazy, all of her muscles and bones shivering in terror at the scene. Mermista clenches her teeth and presses the pads of her finger against the door, trying to keep herself from it by mere inches.

Behind her she can see the killer tilting its head through the mirror, regarding Sea Hawk´s messed-up attempts to open the damn door and save her. Mermista cannot make of the shapes of its face, hidden below the long hood pulled over its head, hiding them like the fucking coward they are. Mermista´s phone is on the floor, fallen and with the screen cracked in the middle, Tallstar ´s voice rising from it hysterically until the killer steps into it with heavy boots, cracking it down completely.

Mermista grunts and then she yells, struggling inside the killer's hold violently. Just as the killer is pulling back off her again, ready to slam her head against the metal handles of the door, Mermista twists, managing to blow a hit to the killer´s right knees, sending it buckling slightly to the ground.

The killer´s hold relaxes on Mermista´s back and that is the only thing she needs to take an impulse with the door and jump back, tripping with the killer´s shoulder as she doesn´t and falling harshly over the floor behind it. Mermista grunts, pain overtaking her back. She looks up to see Sea Hawk´s horrified stare and the killer starting to stand immediately after, turning around to face Mermista again.

“Go! Sea Hawk, go!” Mermista barks loudly, scrambling on the slippery floor on her palms and back, kicking blindly at the killer when it gives a step towards her.

Sea Hawk curses something beyond the door and sprints across the dark Arcade losing himself on the boxes and corners of the back of the Arcade as she tries to make it to the emergency exit as fast as he can. Mermista grunts, managing enough strength to roll from her back to her abdomen, planting her knee firmly in the floor and standing up again. All those years of the track team won ´t go to waste right now.

She sprints across the corridor as fast as she can, zig zagging from side to side and store to store, trying to distract the killer enough with her movements at the same time she pulls from the handles and prays to find any store left accidentally open.

She is not so lucky. Mermista yells, kicking one of the store doors again and again, hoping if she breaks the damn crystal the alarms will go off and the police will come to take this asshole down. The killer, unlike Mermista, is walking. Walking the motherfucker, calm and sharp, studying Mermista´s increasingly frantic moves with something that even below all those shadows looks like morbid curiosity. Mermista cannot make out its body or even height like this, so distracted by the darkness and her own frantic heart that the clever she is so proud of fails her in the most important of moments.

When the crystal doesn´t give out under the pressure of Mermista ´s boot she bolts for it again, accidentally tripping with the feet of one of the metal benches of the mall and falling hard on her face. Mermista grunts, mouth filling with blood where she bites herself so hard it is a miracle she doesn´t rip her tongue out.

She crawls over the floor, desperate to keep moving but the killer seems to have run out of patience from observing her, approaching the very same door she was trying to break earlier. The killer waits, waits and waits next to it until Mermista finally look back at it, holding Mermista´s dark eyes inside the darkness of its face, making sure Mermista is looking when it grabs, very calmly, one of the stones inside the pot of a plant and smashes it with whole force against the crystal, breaking it into so many pieces it´s almost like sand.

Mermista whimpers, covering her face with her forearms to try and save her eyes from the splinters. She can feel several of them crashing against the side of her body, scratching the unprotected skin of her ankles and the side of her cheekbones, blood dripping down immediately. The killer doesn´t even flinch, staring at the broken window as the security alarms start to go off, blasting pink and red light everywhere, the sound sharp and high making Mermista´s eardrums bleed.

The killer leans down, picking up a long shred of shattered crystal between its hands, covered by long gloves of dark leather, Mermista´s heart blasts inside her chest at the side struggling in

the ground to get away. She doesn´t even make it too far away when the killer reaches her again, scrunching behind her and grabbing her from the back of the hair, pulling so hard from it that Mermista´s scalp cries out in paint and she screams with it, spitting saliva and blood into the ground.

The polished pink floors of the mall are so clean that she can catch sight of the broken crystal shimmering under the alarm lights when the killer raises it above their heads and then swings its arms back, draggin the sharp point from the start of Mermista ´s right shoulder and all the way down across her spine and towards the start of her left hip, a gaping wound painting in the skin and muscle of her back that makes all her nerve endings to burst into flames and tears to start falling boiling hot down her cheeks.

“Sea Hawk!” Mermista screams in the haze of her pain, overwhelmed, knees and palms slippering on the floor as her blood starts to slip on the tiles below. “Sea Hawk, goddamnit!”

The killer drops the broken crystal to the side, shattering into dozens of tiny pieces coated in Mermista´s blood. Then the killer wraps its hand around Mermista´s neck, lifting her up with no effort or resistance at all until Mermista´s feet are dangling just a couple of inches from the ground. Her blood drips off her back and dribbles down the back of her legs, staining her blue sneakers in crimson.

“Get off me!” Mermista yells, gurgling around a gush of blood. She is in so much pain but she refuses to go down without a fight, digging her nails into the fabric of the gloves again and again, trying to scratch them off. She shakes her head back, hoping to slam it against the killer's face. “Get off me, you fucker!”

Even holding her inches from the floor the killer is not grunting or panting, not even sweating. It smells like leather and blood and nothing at all, The fragrance of death clinging to every limb and drenching Mermista in it.

Mermista twists on the chokehold, wheezing when the air fails her and her lungs start to strain with the struggle of breathing. She manages to get a hold of the edge of the hood and past it, digging her fingers as hard as she can on the place she thinks are the killer´s eyes. But she is only met with hard material, not exactly fabric but also not metal at all.

The killer hums, grasping Mermistaps wrist between its finger and *rolling* over its own axis, so fast and strong that the snap of the bones comes immediately after as the delicate structure of Mermista´s joint pops off and her wrist breaks into multiple pieces inside her body. Mermista howls in excruciating pain, her jaw protesting for how hard she opens her mouth to scream.

"Hey, asshole!" Sea Hawk´s voice comes suddenly, miraculously next to them. "Let go of my princess!"

Sea Hawk screams the words, pointing every single one as he swings with all his forces a metal bat. The killer jumps back, still holding Mermista but now dragging her in the ground, barely managing to avoid a hit to the ribs as it uses her as a human shield. Sea Hawk stops himself right in the middle of the swing, almost losing his balance to try and to hit Mermista.

Mermista cringes, holding her hands in front of her face, waiting for a hit that doesn´t come. From between her eyes she sees Sea Hawk´s conflicted gaze, pointing at the killer's face with the bat.

"Let her go!"

They are all now next to the railings of the first floor of the mall, close to the steps that guide to the sunken fountain, blue water and siren statues. Mermista feels the killer shrugs behind her seconds before she is thrown off the railing and against the water.

Her body slams with the end of the fountain, miraculously not hitting any Atlantis statue on her fall. All the air leaves her lungs though, making her gape with dry archades, her belly turning into

knots by the pain. Above her Sea Hawk screams in horror, still holding his bat as he looks down at the place she had fallen.

The killer is not moving, considering Sea Hawk posture and weapon with its shadow face, It takes it a second between which Mermista doesn't know what is about to happen until the killer finally steps back, one foot after the other, offering a clear path for Sea Hawk to cross through to reach the stairs and rush next to Mermista. Sea Hawk looks at it with wide eyes, hesitation and fear nestling in his face, unsure as he looks from it to Mermista´s aching and soaked body and then back to the killer.

“Don’t” Mermista gasps, trying and failing to stand up. The blue water is turning red with her blood, making everything smell like metal and charcoal. The blasting alarms are still going, making her want to throw up. “Don't, Sea Hawk.”

Sea Hawk doesn´t hear her. He gives a hesitant step forward, then another, eyeing the killer carefully as it stands on the side of the mall´s corridor without moving, still like an ice statue. It doesn´t move, it doesn´t move and doesn´t move as Sea Hawk walks right past it, staring at the void of thief face until he finally makes it to the start of the stairs and still the killer doesn´t move. Sea Hawk rushes down in an exhale, still holding the bat on his way but too desperate to reach Mermista to even think to beat the killer to a pulp with it.

Mermista feels the wave of the water around her body when Sea Hawk jumps inside the fountain and rushes to her side, knees connecting against the floor painfully as he wraps his arms around her body and gently as he can without disturbing the gaping wound and helps her out of the red water. Mermista yells the whole time, the pain of her pain just overtaken by the way her wrists screams with burning pain, overwhelming her completely.

“I am here, my muse, Mermista my dear,” Sea Hawk whispers next to her head, crossing her arm over his shoulders. “I've got you, let's go.”

Mermista chokes down another scream when she finally steps back into the flat floor of the lowest level of the mall. She has lost a shoe in the struggle and the floor is too cold. She turns her head to look up, where the killer is looking down at them from over the rail, hood crimson under the lights. It didn´t hurt Sea Hawk, it didn´t even try to reach him or push him aside; this killer is going for Mermista and Mermista alone and now she completely sure who this fucker is, she is smart like that. Mermista clenches her teeth, a new wave of fury, anger and pain taking over her rational mind, moving her mouth before she even can or wants to stop it.

"It's you isn't it?! Fucking bitch!" Mermista screams at the killer, throwing her head back with a dry chuckle. "I know it's you Catra! I´m going to fucking end you, I swear to the goddess, you are going to wish that your mother had killed you after all once I´m done with you!"

Mermista looks back at the railing but there is nobody there anymore. The killer has gone, leaving behind the smell of blood. Mermista exhales, shaking her head as she grasps Sea Hawk´s shoulder for dear life, limping across the center of the mall where Sea Hawk guides her across the damn mall.

"Well not today, you fucking asshole," Mermista says under her breath.

"We are almost there, my darling," Sea Hawk says, slightly out of breath, pointing with his chin at the huge doors of the mall where the gray light of the day is calling them. The lights of the alarms are still going, making the entire mall drown in their red color, mixed with the navy blues and deep purples of the fountain at their backs, washing over both Mermista and Sea Hawk like an ocean falling over them.

The killer jumps from the railing to the floor right behind them with no effort at all, pulling itself out of the very shadows and falling swiftly on its ankles. Sea Hawk and Mermista jump in surprise, rushing across the hallway as fast as they can. The killer

starts running against them too, feet swift and quick, chasing them down at full speed. The chasing is over and it is not a game for the killer anymore. Now it is coming for blood.

The mall´s gate it´s too far away. They are not going to reach it in time, not with Mermista limping across the floor like this. She will have to fight tooth and nail for her life, she has no choice, but first she needs Sea Hawk to run. She is about to say this to Sea Hawk, to push him away when he gets a good hold of her battered waist and spins her around, pushing her inside the, for some reason, unlocked doors of the ice cream shop.

Mermista trips inside, not able to hold herself straight when she falls flat on the floor of the store, yelling when the fall catches her broken wrist. She turns around to scream at Sea Hawk but he has already closed the door behind her, crossing the metal bar from side to side of the handle, keeping the killer from walking inside with his own body and Mermista to walk outside with the doors.

"No!" Mermista stands up in trembling knees and falls heavily against the doors, her knees buckling below her and sending her to the floor once more. She slams her palms against the crystal, again and again and again, shaking the whole thing to its foundations. "You idiot! Why? Why?!"

"Because, my dearest Mermista," Sea Hawk says, very softly, almost like a confession between them, or something Mermista always knew but was too stupid to accept until it was too late. Something she feels too but never voiced, "I love you, of course."

Mermista yells at the top of her lungs, slamming her palms over the doors. Sea Hawk smiles at her, tenderly, pressing one lingering kiss over the crystal in front of her face before straightening up again, standing between the door and the killer that is standing still behind him. Listening, waiting.

"If you want to reach my beloved you are going to have to pass through me," Sea Hawk announces, bravely, extending his arms from side to side.

The killer tilts its head to the side, looking at him for a second and then at Mermista, considering. Mermista inhales and holds her breath, praying for the fragment of a second that the killer that wants her might only want her and her alone and will turn around and leave, waiting for the opportunity to haunt her down again.

The killer takes a step back from Sea Hawk, tangles its fingers around his maroon hair and stabs him right in the eye, an inhale and exhale and the blood splashes against the door behind Sea Hawk like a spray of paint against white roses.

Mermista screams at the top of her lungs, convulsing against the closed door as the killer takes the base of the long shred of glass it has stabbed Sea Hawk with pulls it out of his body, holding him up by the hair when Sea Hawk´s eyes roll on the back of his head and his body convulses in pain, his brain and all of his nervous connections barely making sense that they are flooding with blood.

The killer takes the knife again and stabs Sea Hawk again, right across the chest, perfectly aimed, slashing the aorta and heart chamber, shredding it in two with the splintered glass. Out and then once more, right across the neck, from side to side, gushing blood from the throat and into the killer's executioner robe, staining the dark in fresh red.

It is over before Mermista can even process it, Sea Hawk´s body falling heavy and dead at her feet right on the other side of the door. Blood starts to gather past the frame, soaking Mermista´s blue leggings, filling her with the smell of warm meat and fresh blood clotting below her fingers. Mermista cries and cries and cries, snot and tears choking the life out of her yet never getting to actually kill her, staring with wide and panicked eyes at the body in front of her.

The killer scrunches down next to Sea Hawk's body, forearms over its thighs, the shredded glass still held from its fingers. It looks in silence at Mermista freaking out at the other side, slamming the

door with her fists and cursing at it with all the air or her lungs, despair eating her alive.

Then the killer leans forward, dropping the glass down just so it can dig its gloved finger on the arterial blood gushing out of Sea Hawk´s bleeding heart. It raises its gloved finger, right at the height of Mermista´s face, pressing it over the crystal three times. A point. Rise of the finger. Another point. Rise of the finger. A curve, upwards, bleeding red. A bold happy smile made with Sea Hawk´s blood grinning back at Mermista.

The killer takes away its hand and waves goodbye at Mermista´s crying and screaming body, slowly, with mirth. Then it stands up and walks away with calm, whistling its way back into the mall, where Mermista cannot hear it. And where Mermista cannot see it either, the killer rolls its shoulders with satisfaction and pulls back from the hood, taking off the plastic dark mask it had taken from the Halloween store off its face, breathing the fresh air mingled with blood.

Doesn´t even notice the single night camera looking at it walk by.

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♛

Adora sighs, rolling her head back. She is sitting on the curb of one of the multiple streets of the town's square, dirt on the back of her jeans and her palms.

The air is very cold right now, cooled by the morning’s rain, making everything just slightly wet and slightly sticky, but Adora delights in it, the smell of petrichor that she can feel on her skin instead from the other side of the window's glass.

The streets are empty today, most of the people locked tightly alongside their loved ones in their homes, waiting for the storms lashing against the town to pass without touching them. And not exactly the weather kind. The center of the square has started to be fixed for a huge memorial in Perfuma's, and Hordak's, name

but for the rain even that has been delayed and there is nobody here except Adora and her companion, roaming on the street.

The square of the town, as it is usual for towns like Etheria, sits right in the middle of the town, and if you were to stand up right in the middle you would see everything around you like a giant compass.

In the north, the Whispering Woods, surrounding from edge to edge the town, starting in the rotting bridge of the Thaymor river. In the west, the school, with its campus tall and white like castles in the cloud. In the east, the dome of the mall, quiet and empty with the lockdown that would usually be bursting with life on a Friday like this. And for the last, in the south, the bell tower of the chapel, white gold and crystal cut windows, raging in all its glory along with everything else.

There is a very light drizzle falling over the town, thin enough that it is not even rain but cold and fresh, falling over Adora´s heated up face and hair like dew. She sighs under it, her speeding heart calming down under the little drops that get trapped on her eyelashes.

“Here,” Bow flops down next to her, stretching his big legs as he offers her a tiny aluminum package. “Mint gum”

Adora hums, taking the gum from his hands and popping it inside her mouth, wrinkling her nose at the almost spicy freshness of the taste. “Thanks Bow”

“Feeling better?”

Adora shrugs, frowning at her palms. Her head is hurting a little bit, starting in the temples and rolling down her entire forehead and the base of her nape, but it is much less than before, now that she is breathing fresh air and she can see the gray and dark cloud hurling over them. Bow sighs, looking from his friend's face to the line of trees in front of them, Searching and failing to reach some reassuring words to say to her.

“Will you tell me what happened with Light Hope now?” Bow asks after a second, voice very gentle. Adora tenses up anyway, her hands closing into fists at her sides.

“She found out I applied to Horde and freaked out on me,” Adora starts, spitting the words between clenched teeth.

She doesn't tell Bow about Light Hope´s threat towards Catra; she doesn't tell him about her harsh words and her hatred towards the person Adora loves the most, or how those words made Adora scared of what Light Hope could do. She doesn't tell Bow and she probably won't tell anybody else on this earth, too ashamed by it to even voice Light Hope´s doubts, to let them fester on her friend´s mind and on her own; to let them reach Catra´s heart. Adora won't speak about it.

Bow wrinkles his nose, still not looking at Adora, but his face falls too, comprehension clear in his eyes at what Adora do voices.

“Well, fuck,” he says. Adora giggles, slightly dizzy, mirth falling over her at hearing Bow curse for maybe one of the few times in his entire life.

“Yeah, fuck,” Adora agrees, kicking a loose stone on the ground, “She called the Horde and cancelled my acceptation. Told them I was already enrolled in the First Ones Academy.”

Bow snaps his head towards her, his eyes wide like sauce plates. “They accepted you? And she–” Bow gapes several times, his brain barely making sense of Adora´s words. “Wait, are you for real? She did that?”

“Yeah”

“Can you fix it?”

“I don´t know yet,” Adora admits, her eyelashes casting shadows over her face. The drizzle makes tiny drops to run down her cheekbones, like the tears she hasn´t shed.

“And– have you told Catra?” Bow asks again, this time even more carefully than before. He knows about Adora and Catra´s plans to leave together after their courses graduation, after all, he was the one that helped them all study for the admission exams. Adora presses her lips into a thin line, sadness stitches to every single line and corner of her face and the very depths of her blue irises.

“Not yet. I– There is a lot of unfair stuff happening and it is stressing her out.” Adora scratches the side of her neck, pressing her palm flat over her chest when the air fails her for a minute. She tries to give herself courage, to put past her the horror of the last couple of days, to hope it is over now. “I´ll find a way to fix it, and if I can´t then I´ll just reapply next year. I can work while she starts her first year.”

“Hmm,” Bow rests his weight over his palms, looking at Adora´s face full of patience and brotherly wisdom. “I still think you should talk to her about it. Everybody is pointing their fingers at everyone, especially Catra because of Weaver. She loves you and she trusts you, above all of us. If she finds out you kept stuff from her, even this, she might react– not nicely. And I care for you two too much to ever want to see you fighting each other, especially now that we need to be united more than ever.”

Adora blinks at him, the throb inside her heart calming down even if for just a second. A frail but genuine smile makes it on her mouth, making her sigh. “You are the smartest of all of us, you know that right?” Adora says softly, tenderness for her friend flooring in her heart.

Bow giggles, ruffling the back of Adora´s loose hair. “I figured.”

Adora´s phone starts to ring in the back pocket of her jeans, ripping them both from the gentle moment. Adora takes it out with a frown, her breath stuck on her lungs when the bold words of *Unknown Number* blink back at her once more. Bow frowns too, looking from the screen to Adora´s pale face, his mouth already halfway open to question her for her terrified stare.

Adora shakes her head, silently asking him to wait as she drags her finger over the green button and places the call on the speaker, static and a heavy breathing filling the air of the square and the curb around them.

“What?” Adora barks, her entire body tensing up. She waits for a beat, then another, Bow´s face increasingly confused and questioning as the call on the other side remains silent. Frustration starts to itch on Adora´s skin. “Listen, asshole–”

*“He screamed,”* The caller says, a freezing cold voice and unknown static that doesn´t sound human stabbing through Adora´s mind. *“She screamed a lot too. I bet almost all the town could have heard it if they weren't all rats cowering in their holes.”*

Bow snaps his eyes to Adora´s face, eyes wide and full of sudden alert, his mouth agape with surprise. Anxiety is eating the marrow of Adora´s bones, seizing her throat and heart into fear. She looks all around them, scrutinizing the bushes and trees and even the quiet buildings around the square. There is nobody here but them yet Adora can feel eyes hovering heavily against her nape, towering over her like the claws of a demon playing the chasing game with its prey.

“I don´t know what you are talking about,” Adora says to the speaker, her voice choking up as she tries to keep it under control. The killer chuckles on the phone, all broken and unnatural. “You killed Perfuma”

“ *Oh, she was such a beautiful deer. It was perfect.”* Bow gasps, horrified, his hands pressed over his mouth and eyes wetting on the corners; Adora´s heart is beating so fast that she feels like the vital organ will burst out of her chest. The killer stops, humming on the phone as if it was thinking something over before speaking again. *“The little mouse was very quiet though, she made a perfect Ophelia for your fairytale. I am almost too sad I couldn´t reach the eagle too.”*

Adora snaps her trembling eyes to Bow, who looks back at her with the exact same expression. More deaths, more deaths. Adora brings her hand towards her chest, holding Catra´s reliquary tightly between her fingers. She needs to call her, she needs to know she is safe.

"I don´t know who the fuck do you think you are or what game you are playing," Adora snaps to the phone, holding it between her fingers so hard that it creaks. "But I´m not your fucking prey to play with and I´m not afraid of you. If you want something from me then have the balls to face me yourself, fucker, and leave my friends out of it. Or are you too cowardly to do it?"

Adora´s voice is firm, angry, furious even, clear and loud as she tempts luck and calls for the devil. Bow´s hand is heavy over her shoulder where he had placed it to support her. He is shaking a little, Adora is shaking too.

The killer laughs at her, really honestly laughs at her, cracking through the static and the phone and making her shiver, sticky like rotten honey, in a way maybe even familiar and the thought makes Adora want to throw up.

*"Your friends– Ah, pretty hare,"* The killer giggles on the phone, lovingly almost. " *Nothing is too low for me."*

The call cuts off immediately after, Adora´s screen going dark and quiet. Adora yells in frustration, trying and failing to dial back only to be met with the private settings of the calls. As much as she tries, she cannot call back, not like this.

She starts tapping on her phone furiously, still sitting on the damp curb of the street, searching for a number until Catra´s precious face comes into view as Adora speeds dials to her phone. Bow is distracted with his phone too, clicking buttons so fast that he almost drops the pink thing twice until he finally manages to call Glimmer´s number too.

The call starts dialing but the sounds around them have changed too, the previous peace broken as a myriad of police cars, detective cars and paramedics rush across the streets of the square at full speed, their lights turned on and the sirens in them screaming like lost souls pulled out of the underworld. The sight of them makes Adora choke with her own breath, staring at them pass by them so fast that they are blurry, making their way right towards the direction of the town´s mall.

Adora´s call rings and rings but it doesn´t go through, falling quiet when the voicemail answers instead of Catra´s pretty voice. Fear and desperation are eating Adora alive, hanging up and dialing away, her lips trembling either by terror or by the light prayer she cannot help but to plead. Next to her Bow inhales sharply, curling over himself as he presses the phone flat against his ear.

"Glimmer!" His voice is drenched in relief and it only makes Adora want to howl and scream, her own call falling flat again. "Are you alright?" Bow waits a second for the answer, Adora wraps his wrist with her fingers, holding herself to him. "Yeah we are alright. Or well I— something is happening. Police and ambulances are going to the mall." Pause, answer, "I don´t know, you need to come now!"

Adora tugs from Bow´s arm, her eyes huge and alarmed when he turns to look at her. She waves her phone and Catra´s profile picture in front of him, her mouth shivering with terror.

"Okay, okay, Adora and I will see you there. And Glimmer! Catra is with you, right?" Pause. Bow remains very still, his breath shuddering. He turns his eyes towards Adora, the corners pulled down sadly and his head shaking, almost with fear. Adora´s heart drops to her feet. "When did she leave?" Pause and answer again. "Alright, hurry up.

Adora stands up so fast that she gets dizzy, about to throw up. Bow hangs up and stands too, holding Adora´s hands tightly between his when Adora opens her mouth, about to scream.

“Catra left before breakfast. Glimmer doesn´t know where. I– Adora–”

“Don´t say it,” Adora begs him, shaking her head. It's raining even harder now, soaking Adora´s hair from sunlight to dark honey. “Don´t say it, please”

A car stops right next to them right then, slick and dark, the pink and purple light of its siren making Adora and Bow squint. The window rolls down to reveal Huntara sitting on the pilot seat, her eyes skyrocketing on her forehead when she catches sight of the two young adults standing in the middle of the rain with frantic expressions.

“Montenegro, Laurence!” Huntara calls for them above the sound of the siren, frowning. “What in hell's name are you doing there?”

Adora opens her mouth to answer but she finds herself out of words, too choked out for the fact that someone else is most probably dead and she doesn´t know where Catra is. *Little mouse,* the killer had called them. Mouse, deer, bird, a predator haunting Adora´s world.

“We are waiting for our friend Mermista.” Bow says when Adora freezes, stepping closer to the window. “We are helping her do the altar for Perfuma”

A dark look crosses Huntara´s face, her mouth pressing into a line so tight her lips disappear. Adora gives a step forward, her face white as a sheet and her hair soaked.

“Huntara? What is going on?” Huntara looks at Adora in silence for three seconds before huffing, pointing at Bow´s car with her thumbs

“Get in and follow me.” Bow and Adora remain standing, too stunt to move. Huntara growls, slamming her palm over the dashboard of the car. “Now!”

Both friends jump at the sound of her voice, harsh and furious, scrambling with each other as they make it back inside the truck. Huntara looks at them through the mirror and grunts, turning on the car again and stepping on the pedal quickly. Bow and Adora follow behind, sharing one more look as they make their way through the slippery streets of the town.

—

There are a lot of people in the mall by the time they make it there. Besides the emergency authorities, neighbors had crawled out of their houses to look at the new piece of horror, huddled against each other inside the mall and the main gate to stare with curiosity and chatter in morbid tongues. Police are trying to keep them at bay but even them can´t help but turn around and take a peek every once in a while.

Adora remains standing right past the warning yellow tape, unmoving, a mirror of yesterday´s morning so sick that it makes her belly pull painfully. Bow is next to her, holding her hand on his as they stare at the forensic department place the white sheet over Sea Hawk´s corpse, the fabric quickly staining in crimson with his blood.

Next to the destroyed door of the ice cream shop, on the floor and barely held by two paramedics, is Mermista, her black eyes hooded as she stares at Sea Hawk´s body mere inches from her. She is trembling from head to toe as the paramedicos bandage her back and torso with thick gauze and bands, keeping the gapping skin of her back to not bleed out more. It´s a miracle it hadn´t slashed her spine too, it is a miracle she had not passed out. Her knuckles are bleeding red and raw from where she slammed herself against the crystal door until the broke under her rage and she could make it out, just conscious enough to call 9-1-1.

Adora stares at her face with a blank expression, her blood rushing inside her ears. Next to her, Bow turns his head to the side and gasps, letting go from Adora´s hand so he can open his

arms, wrapping Glimmer inside when she rushes from the crowded public and towards her friends, her heart painful inside her chest.

“Guys,” Glimmer cries between Bow´s shoulder, her tears clotting her eyelashes. “You are alright, I was so worried.”

Adora looks at her, still unmoving, not knowing what she is supposed to do or to feel next. Glimmer must notice how tense she is because she detrangles herself from Bow and turns towards Adora, cradling her face between her warm hands. Glimmer looks at her with a kind of expression that Adora cannot place, exhaling heavily as she pulls from Adora´s tall frame against hers and hugs her close, so tight and loving that robs Adora of her breath.

Near the crime scene, Huntara observes the murder scene, turning to look at the friends with a frown forever etched in her face. There is a tablet below her armpit but she doesn´t get near just yet, listening to attention at whatever the forense is telling her about Mermista´s injuries and the causes of Sea Hawk´s death. There is a trail of blood on the floor beneath everyone's feet. The air smells heavily like incense and there is an acolyte already drawing the deity´s symbol on the floor and the walls, muttering prayers with their blue eyes blurred.

At the opposite side of the crowd where Adora is, the crowd starts to yell, muted and angry, grumbling and spitting curses as they are pushed apart harshly. Some of them trip over themselves, other´s steps on their own feet or in the neighbor´s next to them, raising indignation when the person walking through them doesn´t give a single fuck and keeps pushing them to let her pass.

Adora looks at it from over Glimmer´s shoulder as Catra emerges from the crowd like a flower sprouting through snow. Her hair is matted and loose around her face, somehow miraculously dry even though it is pouring outside. She is wearing one of Adora´s green joggers and a sleeveless black turtleneck, her arms bare even with the cold. She looks at the murder scene in front of them and freezes on her steps, her entire face shifting so fast that

Adora almost doesn´t notice it, through so many emotions that Adora, for the first time, doesn´t know what she is feeling or thinking.

Catra´s pretty eyes drag from the trail of dry blood to the place where Adora is standing, her mouth closed, standing straight under the angry looks of the neighbors around her. Blue and hazel eyes against silver ones. She takes on Glimmer´s arms around Adora´s neck, eyes hardening at the sight. Her chin wobbles and her shoulders are trembling.

Adora extracts herself from Glimmer´s embrace, accidentally pushing her to the side, not even thinking about it when she starts to walk across the red corridor. She extends her arms in front of her, mouthing Catra´s name without even really saying it out loud, eyes wide and frantic.

Catra notices the change immediately because her breath visibly shudders inside her throat, knees trembling when she starts running past the people and directly at Adora´s open arms.

Adora catches her, holding her against her chest with so much strength that the impulse of their bodies makes them stumble back a little, lifting Catra a few inches over the floor.

Adora wraps her arms around Catra´s waist and the back of her neck, feeling her fluttering heartbeat with the tip of her fingertips. Catra wraps her own arms around Adora´s shoulders, clinging to her as much as physically possible can, tucking her nose on the angle of Adora´s earlobe and her jaw, pressing a trail of kisses there.

Adora chuckles out loud, hysteric and sad, the tears in her eyes finally tumbling down. Catra is whispering Adora´s name next to her ear, over and over again, digging her sharp fingernails against her scalp to hold her even closer. She doesn´t even say anything else, too far away inside her own mind.

“Adora”

“Catra,” Adora whispers back, lingering kisses against Catra´s throat and the fall of her shoulders. “Oh, my love”

Relief washes over Adora´s body, pushing back the terror for a fraction of a moment. Sea Hawk is dead and she doesn´t know who the *little mouse* is but Catra is alive, alive and well and breathing against Adora´s chest. Adora can survive everything if Catra is well. Adora puts her back to the ground softly, there between the yellow tape and her friends who have stepped aside to give them a quiet moment, cradling Catra´s face between her open palms.

“There you are, my angel” Adora says in a shuddering breath, running her fingers through the messed up loops of Catra´s bangs. “You scared me.”

Catra is looking at her but she is not really looking, her eyes wide and frantic, pupils in pinpoints. This is the first time Adora notices just how pale she is, gray on her usually rich skin, the underside of her eyes sore.

She opens and closes her mouth several times, wheezing when the words fail her just as much. She looks at the body, taking on who it is and what had happened and then back to Adora, shaking her head softly, wrapping her fingers and sharp nails over the laps of Adora´s soft jacket.

“Adora, I– I didn´t–” she tries to say, mouth dry, desperate to say it to Adora, to make her comprehend, to make her understand. “I didn´t.”

“Catra,” Adora laments, running gentle circles over her cheekbone with her thumb. Catra opens her mouth again, inhaling deeply to talk again, frantic to convince Adora when they are interrupted violently.

“You!” Mermista is coming their way, her steps heavy and purposely as she crosses the mall´s corridor, past Sea Hawk´s and her own blood that still soaks through her thick bandages.

She looks furious, her eyes blotted in their orbits and her face inflamed and bruised, hand raising in the air before any can make sense of it. “You bitch!”

Mermista slaps Catra so hard that Catra thumbles back and falls against the hard floor. Adora gasps, arms tingling from where Catra had been ripped off, stunned as she watches Catra bend over herself with pain, her right knee buckling behind her and connecting with the ground.

Catra cradles her own cheek with her palm, looking astonished at Mermista as the latter raises her arm again, this time in a fist, ready to pounce it out against Catra´s head. The adrenaline in her body is so big that she doesn´t even feel her back opening again with the struggle.

“You absolutely bitch! You killed him! You killed him!”

Adora moves much faster, shock washing out of her as fast as it came. She steps between Mermista´s raging body and Catra curled on the floor, raising her arms to the side to shield her from Mermista´s fury.

“Mermista!” Adora yells, flinching when Mermista´s chest slams against hers.

She holds Mermista steady and *away* from Catra, keeping her struggling body several inches from her without letting go even once, which is a whole endeavor considering Mermista somehow is still kicking and lashing, stretching her arms towards Catra as if she wanted to dig her nails on her face and rip it off.

“Mermista, stop!

“Let me go!” Mermista twists in Adora´s arms, digging her nails instead on her face, scratching the side of her jaw until it bleeds. “I told you this would happen, I told you! You whore! You allowed her to do this!”

Adora flinches, hissing with the pain of the shallow wound, red drops falling over her jacket. The sound pulls Catra out of her shock because she scrambles on her feet once again, tripping once when her knee fails her and almost throws her back into the floor.

She throws herself past Adora´s back, pressing her palm flat over Mermista´s face and her other one around her shirt, pulling and pushing until she manages to throw Mermista back into the floor and several inches away,

"Stay away from her!" Catra yells, this time the one stepping between Mermista and Adora. Her hands are closed in fists at her side, trembling with the effort to hold herself back. "I didn´t do anything!"

"You did it! You took him away from me!" Mermista stands back up, throwing herself fully at Catra. "You should be the one dead!"

"Agh!" Catra meets her in the middle, holding her by the shoulders and pushing back, trying to keep Mermista´s hands away from her. Mermista yells and wraps one of her hands around Catra´s neck, on the side of the hidden scar, pressing down to try and choke her.

Catra´s eyes widen, alarmed, panic flooring in her irises. She hisses and wraps her fingers around Mermista´s blue and blonde hair, long ago coated in blood, and pull back from it, ripping Mermista´s hand off her neck and digging her sharp nails on Mermista´s ears in return.

Her expression changes from frantic to furious, the touch in her neck igniting a fire inside her chest that cannot be tamed, making her throw herself forward and start beating and scratching Mermista too. A painful push and pull game that almost makes them fall back on the floor in a mess of limbs and blood.

Bow rushes to the scene, wrapping his arms around Mermista´s shoulders and pulling back from her, trying to avoid the wound on

the back as much as he can.

Adora moves too, circling Catra´s waist inside her arms and lifting her from the ground, keeping her violently struggling body away from the fight. Even though Catra twists and kicks inside her hold, trying to rip herself away, yelling in frustration and ire.

"Enough!" Bow yells, holding Mermista down with his entire strength when Mermista yells. "Enough"

"Fucking bitch!" Catra is screaming, kicking into the air, her lips retracted completely over her gums. The crowd around them gasp as if Mermista had not hit her first, narrowing their eyes at Catra ´s messed up body. Adora looks at it all out of the corner of her eyes, panting where she tries to keep Catra in place. "If you think I did it then come finish the fucking job!"

"Catra stop," Adora grunts, holding her tightly, Catra´s back against her chest. If she keeps holding her this hard Catra is going to bruise. "Stop!"

Huntara rushes to the turmoil, slipping on the blood on the floor and standing between Bow and Mermista and Adora and Catra. Her face is so strained by anger that she almost looks purple, yelling at the top of her lungs. The data pad on her arms falls into the floor with a loud crack.

"Stop this right now!"

"Starla is dead," Mermista cries, slamming her body against Bow so hard that he has to kneel to physically keep her from breaking down. Her words make the whole mall cover into a deadly silence, the smell of blood and bleach lingering on everyone's noses. "Her siblings, she was missing since yesterday, they found her in the woods. She was drowned to death, she was– she was stabbed and drowned. Someone put a fucking dead hare in her hands."

On her spot, Adora stops moving, her hands tightening on her hold around Catra´s body. She feels like she is going to throw up, inhaling sharply. She looks at her girlfriend's face out of the

corners of her eyes but all that she sees in her expression is anger, digging her fingers over Adora´s knuckles where they rest right below her diaphragm.

“Perfuma, Starla, they are dead. Sea Hawk is dead and it's all your fault!” Mermista kicks again, slamming her fists against the floor over and over again. “I´m going to fucking kill you!”

Catra shakes away too, spitting at Mermista´s direction, all lioness fury and blazing red eyes. “Stay away from me!”

Mermista screams again, bloodcurdling and horrid, echoing through every single corner of the mall and beyond. She screams and screams and then Catra starts screaming too, loud and unintelligible, holding herself to Adora´s forearms and rolling her head against her shoulder. She is frighteningly close to having a crisis and Adora is terrified. She didn´t thought Mermista would ever act like this.

Adora looks all around them, searching for an exit where to take Catra through. That is when she sees them, huddled on a corner close to the main gate, Scorpia and Entrapta stare at the scene with wide eyes.

Scorpia looks kind of green, looking at Mermista and a Sea Hawk ´s body and back again, her palm pressed against her mouth. Entrapta looks completely shaken up too, their long purple hair messily contained on the pigtails at the sides of their face.

This must be terrible for them, for Scorpia, for all of them. They have just lost another two friends in less than a two days, tragedy falling over her. Scorpia has lost the love of her life. Adora is trying to shelter hers.

The detectives have managed to hush most of the public away now, leaving Adora enough free space to carry Catra´s still fighting body through. Adora turns towards Scorpia, voice strained and panting, her eyes heavy with a silent plea.

“Scorpia,” Adora calls, sweat breaking on her forehead. “Scorpia”

Scorpia snaps her eyes from the blood to Adora, recognition on her face when she sees Catra in her arms. She doesn´t even seem to have been paying attention to the whole shit show, or at least not enough to care about what Mermista is yelling.

She looks from Adora´s face to Catra, comprehension falling over her, and she shakes herself back awake, ready to step in and help. If there is something Adora will always be thankful for is Scorpia´s unwavering loyalty to Catra, and her faith in her. They need it more than ever now.

"We´ll take her," Scorpia says before Adora can ask anything, recognizing the pleading expression on her face. "We can– we can come to my apartment and calm down there while everything passes. Right Entrapta?"

"I believe that would be prudent," Entrapta nods, fidgeting with their hands. "We could make tiny cupcakes. Data says they always make Catra´s mood better. And Scorpia´s tea."

Scorpia nods too, stretching her hand. Adora has placed Catra back to the ground, in front of Scorpia, so the latter wraps her hand carefully around Catra´s forearm, pulling from her gently to coe her to start walking.

"Come on, Wildcat. The car is outside."

"No wait, wait," Catra shakes herself, planting her ankles hard against the floor, her right knee trembling furiously.

Her expression has gone from furious to completely pale again, frantic as she looks from Scorpia´s exhausted but patient face to Adora. Catra holds Adora´s eyes inside of hers, her throat wobbling with the knot that curls around her vocal cords and larynx, choking her in her own breath and words.

"Adora," Catra wraps her fingers tightly over Adora´s shirt, almost ripping it with her nails. She looks frantic again but there is a new kind of expression on her eyes. "Adora, I didn´t–"

Fear. She is afraid that Adora thinks it is Catra´s fault.

“You are freezing,” Adora whispers, pushing down the knot living in her own throat.

She finally lets go of Catra´s back, putting herself on purpose between her line of sight and the scene behind them where a lot of voices and yells are still slashing against each other. Adora shrugs out of her jacket, placing the warm red foil over Catra´s shivering shoulders, resting her palms over her upper arms.

“Listen to me,” Adora says, teeth clenched. “You cannot be here, I need you safe and I need you fine. Go with Scorpia and Entrapta, I´ll be there soon too.”

Catra stares at her with her mouth agape, incredulity washing over her eyes when she realizes Adora is pushing her away from the entire situation. She doesn´t stomp on the ground though, like she would have done years ago when they were younger, nor does she lashing out or screams at her. Instead she just stares openly at Adora, a look so heartbreaking in her eyes that it mirrors its hurt on Adora´s chest.

“No,” Catra mutters, breaking in the middle. Her teeth clench, hard as her heart squeezes painfully inside her chest. “Are you mad? I won't leave you here on your own. Adora.”

“Catra, please”

“I said no. I'm not leaving without you–”

“Catra!” Adora snaps, loudly, shaking Catra by the arms, shaking her so hard that Catra's teeth click with each other. It calls the attention of everyone that is left on the mall. “Leave!”

Catra flinches under Adora´s voice, hiccuping in surprise. Adora´s eyes narrow, beating herself up internally for raising her voice to Catra in the first place. But she remains unmovable, letting go from Catra´s arms and passing her over to Scorpia´s. Scorpia wraps her arms around Catra´s chest and brings her close, half

way a embrace half way a pull, guiding her off the mall once more.

Catra doesn´t even turn to look at her, her eyes never leaving Adora´s, a thousand of unspoken words passed through them until Catra finally closes her mouth with a harsh click and turns in her ankles, following Entrapta and Scorpia back to the parking lot.

Adora exhales, shaken up to the core by the last moments in her life. Her entire body is shaking up too, almost throwing her to the ground too when adrenaline starts to wash out. She catches movement on the corner of her eye as Detective Lashor marches quickly towards the door too, yelling and red in the face, his fist raised in the air.

“Wait a damn minute!” He shouts, stomping on the ground. “Capellan! Come back here, you are under arrest!”

“Under what charges?” Adora growls, digging her nails under her palms until they bleed. She steps between the door and Lashor, towering above him even though he is tall himself.

Lashor sputters, incredulous and almost offended by the questions alone. “Murder!”

“She didn't do it,” Adora spits, back tensing.

“The survivor pointed at her directly!”

“She wasn't here. She didn't do it”

“Then where was she when this happened?”

Adora hesitates, suddenly unable to continue because she truthfully doesn´t know.

“With me,” Glimmer comes out of nowhere, stepping into the heated conversation. She stands between Lashor and Adora, completely calm, her face clean and hair perfectly placed, unfaced

by the man´s rabid stare. “At the Manor. We had breakfast together and stayed home until Bow called us to let us know about this. You can ask in the Manor, my employees with confirm what I´m saying.”

Adora blinks at her friend´s back, unable to speak. Adora knows it is not true because Catra wasn´t with her when Bow called her but she remains quiet. And she doesn´t even try to say something else, afraid to ruin the lie. Glimmer is, after all, the daughter of the new Mayor, she is some kind of princess now and she doesn´t lie. There is no reason for Lashor not to believe her. There is no reason for her to lie just to protect Catra.

The reason is Adora but Lashor doesn´t know that, and Adora doesn't realize it either yet.

Lashor gapes, his jaw locking with frustration.

“Fuck!” He yells at the top of his lungs, kicking on the ground as he turns around and returns to the scene.

In front of them the emergency team has started to move, finishing taking the last pieces of evidence and flashing snap against snap of photographs. Mermista has been taken away, somewhere between Bow and the EMTs have managed to guide her to the ambulance through another gate; Adora can hear the sirens driving away from the mall.

Huntara is on the very far end of the corridor, arguing heatedly with Lashor, murmuring something about getting some videos to someone instead of acting like a little bitch. Her digital pad is nowhere to be seen.

Air is failing to Adora, crushing her down, making her heart seize inside her ribcage, robbing her of her breath. She feels exhausted, unbelievably tired, the weight of the world falling over her shoulders and threatening to crush her down.

“Adora,” Glimmer calls her name, gently. Adora runs her eyes back to hers, lilac and open and gentle. Adora can see herself mirrored

through them, the expression in her face and the tension in her body.

She just yelled to Catra in front of everyone and shook her, hard. There must be bruises the size of grapes below her ribs.

"I–" Adora wheezes, stepping back. "I– I need to get out of here. Just–"

Adora steps back and back until she trips with the door of the gate, crossing it in a rush. Glimmer´s sad eyes follow her out but Adora cannot see them.

Adora walks into the parking lot of the mall, breathing hard. It's pouring now, heavy drops washing over her entire body and drenching her from head to toe. There is nobody out here anymore, no curious neighbor or judgmental person, not even the emergency teams. Bow´s truck is in the far end. Scorpia´s car is not here either, taking Catra with it. Adora can see the expression in her eyes below her eyelids, the paleness of her face, the pulsing red bruise forming on her cheek, the tears stuck on her eyelids.

Portrayals of betrayals.

Adora rolls her head back and cries out in the middle of the rain. The rain hides her tears and the thunder in the sky hides her yell when she opens her jaw and screams, pouring all of her anger into the water. She cries and screams until her vocal cords go raw from tearing themselves apart, her chest shredding into pieces. Her heart aches, it hurts, it burns, it tears itself apart. She cannot breath, she feels like she is having a heart attack, her lungs collapsing over each other with each painful breath.

Adora stands below the cold rain until her tears feel like another part of her skin and the rain loses its strength, falling back into a light drizzle that still manages to freeze her to the bone. She stands very still in the middle of the parking lot, looking at some void point and at anything at all.

She hears the gate of the mall opening and closing at some point, glittering rain boots walking across the flooded parking lot. Adora´s socks are soaked through. Glimmer stops right next to her, slightly angled towards her face, her face coming into view in Adora´s line of vision.

"Adora?" she calls for her, her voice hesitant.

"What is it, Glimmer?" Adora´s voice is very calm, blank even, exhausted after pouring it all into the storm.

Glimmer flinches at the soreness in Adora´s voice. Her pink eyebrows knit together. Her hand hovers above Adora´s rapid chest. "I just wanted to know how you were"

Adora chuckles, still unmoving, blinking against the drizzles and the past tears. "I´m not having a very good day, Glimm"

"Yeah, I know," Glimmer worries her lip between her front teeth, giving a step forward, resting her palm fully over Adora´s chest.

Her fingers tangle around the golden chain of the reliquary. Adora is kind of a mess, soaked through like a willow after a storm, her golden hair dark and heavy with water and her face pale, making the tiny moles scattered over her cheeks pop. She is beautiful even after a torment, even after tragedy. Beautiful like a ghost roaming this earth, stuck on the grasp of an invisible demon.

"Don´t cry"

"I can´t help it," Adora whispers, voice low and harsh.

Her lips are trembling a little, from the cold or the sadness or for both. And her eyes are the bluest Glimmer has ever seen them, blue, *blue* like exploding nebulas, blue like the water of the river, blue like labradorite crystals, a storm that pulls Glimmer in.

Glimmer doesn´t even know why she does it, or what makes it take the impulse. Maybe it is because Adora smells like tears, maybe it is because the underside of her eye is raw and red,

maybe it is because Mermista´s nails are still marked on the side of her face, anger in physical form after losing someone she loved. Maybe it is because things have gone to absolute hell.

Maybe it is because she is Catra´s and not Glimmer´s and Glimmer loves her life but she will always wonder *what if?*

Glimmer rises on her tippy toes and leans in, pressing her closed lips softly over Adora´s cold ones.

Neither of them move for a second and it is over as fast as it begins. Adora doesn´t close her eyes, staring at Glimmer´s shut eyelids in silence. Adora doesn´t even feel a shiver, or the need of a surprised gasp, or the flutter of a heart. She doesn´t feel cold or warm. She feels nothing, and it is sad because Adora cares for her but she tastes wrong, she smells wrong, she feels wrong. She is not Catra.

Adora steps back, just one step, long and firm, merely a fraction of a second into it. Glimmer falls back on her ankles, almost losing her balance when she loses the stability of Adora´s body close to hers. Glimmer gasps, pressing both of her hands over her mouth, horrified when she realizes what she just did.

"Sorry, I just–" Glimmer stutters, searching for Adora´s eyes frantically. Adora´s eyes are casted down, hooded where her long and golden eyelashes hide the blue from Glimmer´s sight. Glimmer sighs, regret and sadness falling over her. "You just looked so sad"

Glimmer´s voice falls, drowning them both in heavy silence. Glimmer´s palms are damp from where she held Adora´s soaked clothes; her face tingles, numb, either by the cold or by the unwanted touch. She feels shame starting to pool in the bottom on her belly and tries to ignore it, to push it back, but she still can feel it creeping in the back of her throat

"Glimmer," Adora whispers, very calm.

Glimmer looks up, coming face to face with Adora´s eyes, almost silver now, rain drops like tears dripping from her eyelashes. She doesn´t look angry, or annoyed or disgusted, which Glimmer is terrified of, and some kind of faux spark of hope itches on her chest.

"Yes?"

"Catra is my life," Adora says, clear as a bell. It is a declaration, a hymn long ago known. Adora´s eyes are so bright at the sound of Catra´s name, at the mention of her, the mere thought of her, that it makes Glimmer stumble back. "I don't only love her. She is my soul and my heart. I am undone without her, I´m not me without her."

"I know," Glimmer gulps down the acid gathering in her vocal cords, closing her fists at her sides.

Adora blinks, her entire face softening. She tilts her head to the side, a sad expression nestling in her pretty face. "Bow loves you"

"I know I love him too. I–" Glimmer presses her palm against her forehead, beating herself internally. "I just wanted to know what it felt like," she confesses with a groan biting her tongue. Reality is washing over her again, and with it, mortification. Adora´s eyes don´t harden, simply staring at Glimmer´s face without moving. "I´m sorry, I don´t know what I was thinking."

"It´s alright," Adora exhales heavily, running her hands over her long hair, pushing the wet strands off her face. She looks up at the sky, wrinkling her nose, her voice sore. "It´s alright, things are– so fucked up right now. But– you are my friend Glimmer, it won´t change."

Adora drops her arms back to the sides, regarding Glimmer with a much softer look. Glimmer exhales, slightly relieved at her expression. The last thing she wants right now is to ruin what she has with her, and with Bow. She loves them both, in different ways and forever. She is just scared to death right now.

“Are you sure?” Glimmer insists, biting the inner side of her cheek. Adora nods.

“Yes”

“Adora–”

“I don't want to talk about it anymore, okay?” She cuts her off, still gently but much firmer. She is still holding herself slightly away from Glimmer, even though her body remains relaxed.

Glimmer grimaces, nodding. “Okay”

The gate of the mall opens and closes again, Bow walks out and scans the soaked parking lot, jogging towards them when he catches sight of them standing in the middle of the street. He looks shaken up and tired too, but his eyes remain kind and bright and guilt boils inside Glimmer´s chest at the sight of him.

“Guys?” Bow says, out of breath. “Hey, things are getting a little bit heated down there we should go”

Adora looks at him and nods, both of them starting to make their way back to the truck. Adora´s shoes make a little squishy sound every time she takes a step, soaked by the rain. Reality snaps Glimmer back into her head, remembering there is a reason she needed so desperately to talk with them.

“Wait, wait, guys! There is something I wanted to tell you both,” Glimmer wraps her hands around both Bow and Adora´s upper arms, hurrying them to the side of the car where they can huddle and talk. She looks all around them, making sure they are actually completely alone before talking between her teeth. “I heard my mother speaking on the phone with the detective last night. She– she might have implied that this was not the last time this happened?”

“This?” Adora frowns, her face darkening with confusion.

“The murders and how they are happening. I couldn't hear more but my mom did say *like before.”* Glimmer fidgets with her hands nervously, pulling her phone out to show them a couple of images. “I tried to search about it on the local new´s archive but the page tells me all archives before our years is under private lock, which is weird as fuck. See?”

“So, you think whatever happened back there and what is going on now is related?”

“It could be, or at least it could give us a better idea of what is going on and how is the killer targeting it´s victims. This is too close to home to be a mere coincidence and my mom is acting weird as fuck. If she is hiding whose fault this is then we have to find out before the killer hurts someone else.”

A shared shiver runs down the three friends, raising their skins in goosebumps.

Bow is looking at Adora with a certain kind of weight, a silent conversation going on between them before Adora looks away, frowning at the ground. Bow claps his hands together suddenly, a small smile stretching on his lips when a new idea comes to mind.

“Hey, what if we go to my dads´ library? There must be old newspapers somewhere around there. If it was something from before we were born I can definitely tell we´ll find it there.”

“Are you sure?” Glimmer asks, looking around them nervously.

“Yes, I have the keys.”

“Then let´s do it.” Adora snaps, tense as a cord suddenly. She turns around in her ankles and marches forcefully towards the back of the truck, throwing the car door open. “Bow I'm changing on the back. I brought a bag of clothes from Light Hope’s house. I'm soaked.”

“Sure!” Bow answers with a smile that flatters the second Adora jumps on the back of the car, slamming the door behind her. He

eyes at Glimmer nervously, looking from her to the car. “Um, what happened?”

“Nothing,” Glimmer says with a heavy sigh, wrapping her hand tightly against Bow´s fingers. “Let´s go then”

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A cloud of dust rises from the old newspapers when Bow places them heavily over the old table, coughing violently. The closed library is very dark, dusk already rolling outside of the window even beyond the thick storm clouds.

The three of them are huddled on the main table of the library, dozens of registry books, old newspapers and some other papers that they don´t even know where they got from scattered all around their arms and elbows, threatening to fall against the floor if any one them does as much as sneeze.

Bow flops against the back of his chair very carefully, groaning as he peeks at what Adora is reading. “Something?”

“Nothing” Adora answers with a huff, letting her head fall hard against the table. She is tired, exhausted to the bone, and the smell of wet books is making her sleepy. Her forehead bangs over the wood, making the papers shake dangerously. “What about you?”

“Can I interest you in the Witch Trials of Etheria?”

“Ugh. Not now, thanks”

Bow chuckles pointing at the papers even though Adora doesn´t see him.

“Where are you right now?” Bow asks, ruffling the hair of Adora´s bangs.

“Twenty two years ago.” Her voice comes muffled against the papers, waving her hand loosely at the mountains she has already gone through.

“Okay. I'm taking the previous year.” Bow stretches over the papers and takes the next half, extending them in front of him, the yellowed pages almost stuck with each other with how old they are. Bow looks to their side, where Glimmer is sitting on the front of the table, her head leaned against a single paper. “Glimmer? Did you find something?”

Glimmer is holding the paper right in front of her face, gripping it so hard she might as well rip it in half. Still, when Bow calls for her she raises her head slowly. She looks at Bow and then at Adora floppen on the table, blinking once as she shakes herself into reality again.

“I´m not sure yet,” she whispers, placing the paper face down next to her. She leans back on the folder of papers she is going through, chewing on her lips with frustration. “I can´t fucking believe there is not a single freaking newspaper that can help us. All I have found are news of the town´s biggest pie and dozens of calls from the chapel to become acolytes.”

“Ew,” Adora mutters from her place, faking a puke gag. Glimmer giggles, ready to stand up and take another couple of newspapers when Bow slams his open palm against the table, standing up from the chair with the impulse of his discovery.

“Wait! Wait, wait, here!” He exclaims, slamming the newspaper in the middle. Glimmer and Adora sprint off their chair, leaning over the table too as Bow reads. “ *Another murder in Etheria, the third on a row raises fear among the locals* ”

“What month is it?” Adora pushes several newspapers around, frowning deeply.

“Uh, march”

“Here,” Adora extracts two more newspapers from the batch, placing them next to Bow´s. “March 12th then March 16th. Two women were found murdered in the woods and another one inside her own home.”

“Do we know them?”

“Uh, no I don´t recognize the names. Glimmer?”

Glimmer reads over Adora´s shoulder, scrambling her brain at the surname without reaching any kind of recognition. “No. Their families must have moved out after this”

“This says they were all in their early twenties, completely alone when it happened.” Bow´s breath shakes, squinting his eyes at the tiny letters on the paper. “When their bodies were found they were placed like pieces of art, every single one of them. Town ordered a curfew after the third one.”

“Just like now,” Glimmer gasps. She bends over and grabs her handbag, extracting from it a black and thin square with the screen black. She presses on the start button quickly, the purple light of the detective´s logo shimmering on the screen. “I took this from Huntara”

“Glimmer!” Bow exclaims, gapping at her. Adora looks at her with wide eyes too, chuckling nervously when Glimmer shrugs, stomping in the ground and crossing her arms.

“What?! She didn´t notice!”

“I bet she will, eventually”

“Well, I don´t care” Glimmer says between her teeth, tapping on the data pad until a dozen images start sprouting on it, one after the other like a morbid folder. Glimmer sighs, placing the pad over the newspapers. “Here, it´s, um, photographs of Starla´s body”

Adora gulps heavily, her heart straining in her chest when she looks from Glimmer´s pale but urgent face to the screen. Starla is

laying on a pond, floating against the green water like another lily pad. Her hands had been placed over her chest, knitted together with a piece of branch. Her throat was open, a gaping hole and dry after bleeding her to death and all her hair was gone, scalp raw where the strands had been forcefully torn from her skin. And there, right between her joined palms, instead of a message painted with blood in the walls laid a small dead animal, bent twisted in an unnatural angel and white coat soaked in clotted red.

Adora exhales, her head hammering and her breath quick, adrenaline shooting up and down every single cell of her body. Bow moves closer to the screen, his face sunken and horrified but trying to make sense of the whole scene, pushing back the horror enough to help him think.

"Is that a rabbit?" He asks, narrowing his eyes. Adora shakes her head, falling back on the chair.

"A Hare," she whispers, letting her face fall between her open palms. Bow snaps his eyes at her, mouth agape.

"Oh"

"Listen!" Glimmer is too distracted reading the newspapers and the report of Starla´s and Perfuma´s murders, "None of the victims were related to each other but they all shared the same characteristics. Young, beloved by the neighborhood, smart and blond–"

Glimmer stops herself dry, voice stuck on her vocal cords. She snaps her eyes from the newspapers to Adora´s face, who has leaned back from her palms, returning her friend's gaze with a defeated stare. Adora tried to ignore it as much as she could but there was no doubt anymore, the invisible demon she had felt since all of this began finally reaching her.

"Adora. Perfuma, Starla, even Mermista, they all had some kind of hair resembling blonde."

“I know,” Adora mourns, barely containing tears.

“Adora?” Glimmer asks, obviously on the edge. “Is there anything you want to share with us?”

Adora exhales, cleaning her face with the back of her arm. She hadn´t even noticed the tears beginning to fall down her face, dripping down her chin and soaking her shirt. She returns her friend´s stare, gathering herself of bravery.

“The killer has been calling me”

Glimmer´s jaw goes slack, eyes widening almost comically. Bow inhales sharply, less surprised than Glimmer, after all he had been there this morning when the killer called Adora, but just as horrified as her.

“Excuse me?!” Glimmer exclaims after a few seconds. bringing her hands to her hair.

“I– at first I thought it was a joke then I thought I could keep it under control but–”

Glimmer throws her hands up, exclaiming at the top of her lungs. “Adora!”

“I know. I know,” Adora laments, resting her forehead over her closed fist.

“You better start talking now or I swear on my father´s name”

Glimmer chews the words, barely holding her need to shake Adora by the neck when Bow rests his palm on the small of her back. Glimmer looks at him with an exasperated face, horrified and angry, but Bow is so much more calmer, a storm also going on inside his eyes but contained, trying to keep things calm.

On her chair, Adora fumbles with the old newspaper, her eyes roaming through the names of the women long ago murdered. Broken dreams, broken lives, just like now.

“The first one came the day of Hordak´s funeral,” Adora says, not meeting her friends´ eyes. “When I was outside your house. It called my name, it said it would leave me a gift. That night Perfuma was murdered.” Adora gulps, guilt choking her. “I tried to call back but it was useless. I told Huntara but it was useless too. I didn´t receive a call after and I– I guess that I hoped it had been all a horrible coincidence after all.”

“But then this morning,” Adora continues, wetting her sandpaper lips. “It called me again, when Bow and I were in the square. The killer– It said *he screamed.* It was talking about Sea Hawk, and Mermista. I think it was mocking them but it was angry too. I– I don´t think it meant to kill Sea Hawk, I think it was after Mermista to continue the spree but Sea Hawk got in the middle. And before hanging up, it said nothing would be too low for it.”

“Fuck,” Glimmer curses, sitting back on her creaking chair too, blinking at the spiderwebs on the ceiling. Adora looks at her pleadingly, her eyes impossibly sad.

“There is more, Glimm. The killer has been leaving messages to me on the murders. It left my name written with blood all over Perfuma´s flower shop,” now Glimmer not only looks horrified but also furious. Bow looks about to pass out too. Adora flinches, shame and terror making her dizzy. She points at the photograph of Starla, her finger shivering. “And um, it always calls me *pretty hare* which is fucking disgusting.”

Glimmer slams her palm over her own face, white as a sheet. A little bit green too. She might puke after all.

“Deity help me. Just, take me now I´m ready,” Glimmer digs her fingernails over the wood of the table, scrutinizing Adora´s face. Adora shrinks under her furious stare. “Why on earth didn't you say something before?”

“Huntara knows, I told her when Perfuma was murdered.”

Glimmer slams her fists on the table, positively sending all the books into the ground. “And us?! We are your friends, we could have helped you, protected you!”

“Glimmer don´t you see?!” Adora stands up again, extending her arms to the sides. Her eyes are frantic, pupils like mere pinpoints on the sea of her irises.

“All of this! It is happening because of me. The killer wants me, me! And I don´t know why it hasn´t just fucking killed me already but all this people, our friends, they are getting hurt and murdered because of me!” She slams one of her palms against the table, so hard it must hurt terribly. The other one wraps around the golden reliquary in her chest, holding herself to it like a lifeline. “What if I tell you and you both get hurt or killed because of me? What if this, this asshole kills everything I love before it gets to me? Then what?!”

“Oh, Adora” Bow whispers, pressing his lips into a sad line. Adora shakes her hair softly, golden strands brushing her face and collarbones.

“I´m so tired, Bow,” Adora says to his friend, pressing her fist against the middle of her chest, rubbing the place where her heart beats. “I´m tired.”

She falls back on her chair curling over herself. She hugs herself, crossing her arms over her chest and hanging her head low. Bow ´s face is terribly sad, walking until he is able to kneel right next to Adora´s chair, enveloping her shivering shoulders into a hug.

Glimmer, however, is still very tense, thoughts and ideas roaming inside her brain like a hurricane. Her heart aches for Adora and fear pumps into her veins but she cannot let go of the thought that has made its roots inside her very soul. She narrows her eyes at nothing in particular.

“Does Catra know?” she asks, biting her own tongue accidentally. “About the calls and the hare stuff?”

Adora lifts her eyes towards her, eyebrows twitching. “I told her about my name in Perfuma´s shop and about the nickname from the call. She was upset too.”

“Has she heard them too? The calls?” Glimmer inquiries, pressing further. “Could she recognize the voice?”

“It´s not even a real voice, Glimm. It´s words passed through some kind of filter to make them sound inhuman. I can´t even make sense of them.” A nasty feeling falls over Adora, her entire body tensing under Glimmer´s calculating gaze. “I´ve never been called when someone is with me, until today with Bow.”

Glimmer sighs, her lips retracting over her teeth when she scowls. “Adora–”

“Don´t”

“Alright” Glimmer turns around sharply towards the table, picking up the same yellowed paper “There is something I found here earlier.”

She places it on the table right in front of Adora, almost gently, crossing her arms over her chest. Adora narrows her eyes at it, catching on the swirling letters of the top under the dim light of the old library´s table lamp. “What is this?”

“A birth certificate. Of Hordak. The original one,” Glimmer says, strained.

Adora blinks at her, still clearly confused. “Okay”

“Look at the surname Adora”

Adora takes a sharp intake of air, looking down again. Bow stretches to read the paper too, taking in the tiny letter scribbled with an old writing machine. There it is, right next to Hordak´s name, almost too bold with black ink.

*Imp Weaver.*

“There was a report on my mother´s briefcase. I read it before I returned it. It was a petition for Hordak to change his surname before he bought his place as Mayor, over ten years ago.”

Glimmer says, barely able to push the words out with how hard she holds herself. She feels about to scream, just as she was when she found it fifteen minutes ago, hidden between old nursery registers.

“Hordak was Weaver´s brother. He is Catra´s uncle”

Bow falls back into his ankles, his face stunned. He looks surprised as fuck. Adora, however, doesn´t even move, staring at the name without blinking as she wrinkles her nose, scratching the bridge with her blunt nails. Glimmer´s terrifying satisfaction to have found this new piece of evidence goes to the fucking drain the second she realizes the looks on Adora´s face.

“Oh, Adora,” Glimmer groans, dropping her arms to the sides. “Did you know?”

Adora looks up from the paper, returning Glimmer´s gaze. She nods very slowly, fidgeting with her fingers.

“Yes. Catra and I– we've been together almost our entire lives but I didn't know until much later. Weaver never spoke about other family members around my parents. It was Catra who told me a little after we got together um– officially. He didn´t cared about Weaver or Catra and she didn´t had a connection to him in return.” Adora explains as calmly as she can. Still, she loses her marbles a little bit at the look on Glimmer's furious eyes. “She told me, Glimmer, she is my best friend and my girlfriend!”

“Who has been acting really weird! Who is running away from home and goddess knows where the entire week?! Can´t you see?” Glimmer walks in a tight circle in her place, pushing her short bangs off her face. “Why didn´t you tell us when they found Hordak?”

“Because I didn't want you two to look at her like you are right now,” Adora confesses, heartbroken. She finally loses the battle of the tears, drops falling off her cheeks and splashing on her hands and knees. K

“The entire town already blames her for her mother´s death, the entire town looks at her as if she was some kind of defective being and not the most wonderful person I've ever met. It´s now fair.” She holds the fabric of her pants tightly between her fingers, looking at Glimmer pleadingly. “It´s not Glimmer”

A sting of shame makes it through Glimmer´s chest, making her ears flare with guilt. In a way she knows Adora is right, just as she knows how real her tears are, dripping with the weight of blaming herself and enduring people blaming the person she loves.

In a way, Glimmer knows she is not one to judge, if Catra wants to hide the people that were supposed to love her the most and that only left her to fence on her own; Glimmer would have done the same because Catra and Glimmer are not so different from each other. In a way, Glimmer knows she is not one to talk, because she kissed Adora in the parking lot and that it is in itself a whole betrayal too.

As Adora said earlier, things are completely fucked up.

“Okay, I´m sorry. I´m sorry,” Glimmer kneels in front of Adora´s chair, resting both of her palms over Adora´s shoulders. “It's just, the killer is targeting you, Adora, directly. Perfuma is dead, Starla is dead. Mermista would be dead if Sea Hawk hadn´t protected her. People are dying. If it is someone from our present or a ghost of the past, we need to start asking ourselves these things, please, I don´t want anybody to hurt you. And I don´t want anybody else to get hurt either.”

Adora is crying. She nods, letting her tears drip into Glimmer´s hands too. Glimmer tries to muster a smile towards her, softening her voice.

“I´ll be kinder to Catra,” Glimmer says too, words apologetic. Adora´s breath hitches. “Let´s just– let´s just cover our bases, alright?”

“Okay.”

Adora´s phone starts ringing there, making the three of them jump. They share a heavy look as Adora turns the screen on, leaning to catch sight of Scorpia´s phone picture shimmering in the middle.

“It´s Scorpia,” Adora confirms in a heartbeat, unlocking the phone and bringing it to her ear. “Hello? Scorpia is everything alright?”

Adora stands up, walking to the limits of the registry room, speaking quickly and out of breath with Scorpia. Glimmer stands up too, turning around to find Bow roaming around the papers almost desperately.

“Is there anything in the newspapers, Bow?” Glimmer approaches him, resting her palm against his back. Bow´s eyebrows are knitted, confusion in his face.

“Um, this newspaper is from the 6th of April, weeks after the last one, it talks about the sudden end of the murders and the heavy loss of the four families that lost a loved one.”

Glimmer blinks, frowning too. “Four? I think we said it was three”

“That's where the newspapers cut themselves short.” Bow turns his head to look at Glimmer, his lip curled down. “I think someone got to this first, Glimm. There are several  papers missing.”

Glimmer´s eyes widen, looking around the empty library and back at Bow´s face. The library had been closed since the Hordak incident, and as a public establishment, there were very limited people with access to it. Bow and his brothers and official members of the town´s office only. The door was not forced either.

“Who was the last person that entered the library?” Glimmer asks, her mouth dry.

Bow scrambles for his phone, pulling the little device to search on the library's digital record. Even as an old place as George and Lance´s library is, all people that get in should place some sort of identification to be granted access. They did it themselves when they walked in a few hours ago. A useful piece of technology Entrapta installed for them to protect the old books.

“It was this morning,” Bow´s eyes widen, his mouth going slack. “Oh”

“Who it is?”

Bow turns to look at his girlfriend, his eyes hooded “It was your mom, Glimmer”

Every single thought inside Glimmer´s head stops. She stares at Bow´s face like she couldn´t understand the words coming from his mouth, opening and closing her own in shock. Why would her mother be here at all? Maybe she had the same idea as them to look in the old registers? If the digital archives were also locked for Angella then the next move would be this? Did that mean she knew who was behind everything? Did it mean she was trying to hide something?

“Hey, guys?” Adora comes back into the room, sniffling softly. Her eyes are red but she is not crying anymore. “Scorpia says there is a storm alert tonight.”

“How's Catra?” Bow asks, voice gentle.

“Better, all things considered.” Adora pinches the bridge of her nose with her fingertips. “The town´s office has called for an obligatory curfew too, in an hour. I think we should go to Scorpia ´s and spend the night there.”

“Won´t Light Hope freak out on you?” Bow asks, worried. Adora shakes her head, shrugging.

“She is out right now. And even if she weren´t I don´t plan on separating us until this is over.”

“I agree.” Bow turns to look at his girlfriend, his eyebrows twitching. He doesn´t say anything about the missing newspaper or Angella´s sudden involvement, respecting the moment Glimmer decides to do it herself. Oh how life likes to turn around and bite Glimmer right in the ass. “Glimmer?”

“Sure,” Glimmer says absently. She leans to pick up her back, picking all the papers and throwing them inside as carefully as she can so as to not mess up the library´s immaculate order. “We should tell Catra and the others about this too. If we are going to survive this, we all need to be on the same page.”

A flicker of relief shimmers inside Adora´s pretty eyes, thankful. She wraps her arm over Glimmer´s shoulder, squeezing her gently. “It's going to be alright, Glimm”

“Of course it will,” Bow chimes in, smiling from ear to ear. He wraps both of his arms around Glimmer and Adora, bringing the three of them in one of their characteristic embraces, cheeks nuzzling together. Adora hums, Glimmer giggles. They need this, all of them, they love each other too much to let the other break. “After all, we are the Best Friend Squad. And we will stay together.”

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Scorpia's apartment complex is pretty, clean and very tall. If it weren't for the old fashioned elevator on the side, it would probably take them a couple of minutes to reach the fifth floor through the marble staircase.

The trio makes it to the last door of the floor and rings the doorbell twice, waiting impatiently. Outside the rain has opened up over Etheria again, the heavy drops crashing against the roof and the obscure windows around them. The night is very thick too

and if you were to peel outside all you will see would be fog and rain.

The door of the apartment jingles a little and then Entrapta's voice comes muffled from the other side, slightly muted by the metal and the wood.

"Code!"

Glimmer, Adora and Bow blink, confused. They look at each other with raised eyebrows and then back at the door. Glimmer tilts her head to the side, wrinkling her nose.

"Code?"

"Incorrect!" Entrapta chimes, still definitely not opening the door.

Adora cannot help but snort, rubbing her forehead with her fingertips. Bow sighs, shaking his head. Glimmer rolls her eyes so hard that she might get dizzy, voice strained as she tries to keep it together.

"Entrapta, it´s us." She says very slowly. "Glimmer, Adora and Bow"

"How can we know that?"

"Maybe if you look through the peephole?" Adora offers, trying to contain her laughter.

She looks and feels slightly better and in other circumstances this would be deeply amusing, especially because of Glimmer's exasperated face. But it is late and a lot of shit has been going on. Adora only wants to come inside and look at Catra's eyes, cradle her face and face how angry she probably is right now.

The door jingles again as Entrapta moves a chair towards the door and looks through the peephole, humming in agreement. "Umm, yes, definitely looks like you"

“Thank you.” Glimmer exhales, grinning if a little exasperated still. The chair moves away again so Glimmer wraps her hand on the doorknobs and turns it around just to find it as tightly shut as it was before. “Entrapta!”

“I just need the code!”

“How are they going to know the code if you haven't told them which one it is, you dork?” A second voice echoes inside the apartment, loud enough to be heard through the door. “Just open the damn door”

Adora's eyes shimmer, her cheeks going a very faint shade of pink. That's absolutely Catra's voice, slightly annoyed but still fond of her friend. Adora has been missing her like a heartbeat the entire day and knowing that they are mere feet apart, Adora's heart feels like it won't be able to hold on much longer without having her by her side.

The apartment door finally opens for them, Entrapta greeting them from the other side. Or as much as a greeting as it can be, because they are scribbling on a data pad quickly.

“Well? Come in” Entrapta says without even looking at them, stepping to the side so the trio can walk in. “I still think an entry code is needed to protect us from intrudes. That way the killer cannot take us by surprise! Data doesn't lie!”

“And what was the code after all?” Bow asks softly, leaving a package of papers on the dinner table on the side.

“Technology!”

“Of course," Bow nods, agreeing with Entrapta completely. “Well that's easy to remember.”

“Don't bother yourself. Now that it has been compromised I have to change it!”

“Sure,” Bow giggles, shaking his head fondly at them.

Adora drops her package of papers too, turning to look around the apartment. It is a nice place, small but comfortable. There is a dinner table right next to the door and further back a tiny living room that looks so comfortable it makes Adora sleepy. On the right there's the door of the kitchen and then the corridor that leads towards the two bedrooms. Maybe the most beautiful thing of it all are the huge windows in the living room, opened even during the rain to let the cool breeze in.

The curtains and the carpet on the floor are pink and there are dozens of pots with pretty plants in every corner and table. Traces of Perfuma everywhere.

Adora's eyes land on Scorpia, standing awkwardly close to the table. She rubs her upper arm nervously, past the red ink of the tattoos on both of her forearms. She looks tired and worn down but her eyes don't look as dead as they were the last time Adora saw her in the flower shop. All of her shirt white hair is pushed back and slightly damp and she smells like soap and shampoo. She probably just got out of the bath.

Adora smiles kindly at her, fondness flooding in her heart at the sight of her friend. She tilts her head to the side, speaking softly.

“Hey, Scorpia”

Scorpia blinks at her in recognition, the tension in her shoulders slipping out of her for a fraction. “Hi guys”

Adora gives a step further and opens her arms, inviting Scorpia inside if she wants. And she does, because she has the softest of heart and she needs to be taken care of right now.

She wanders her way inside Adora's embrace and hugs her back, her talk frame towering even over Adora's. Adora stumbles back a little and wheezes out of breath but smiles all the same, rubbing Scorpia's strong back with her palms, nuzzling her sad frame inside her arms.

“How are you doing?” Adora asks in a whisper, just between them. She can feel Scorpia sight against her chest, the thread of a sob always living there.

“I'm getting by,” she whispers back, squeezing Adora once more before leaning back so she can regard everyone else. Both Glimmer and Bow's eyes are soft too, smiling at her kindly. “Having Trapta and Catra here has been helping. Even if today–”

Her words linger and disappear, no need to keep saying what is already known. Scorpia's dark eyebrows knit into a frown, the corner of her lips curling down.

“Is Sea Hawk really– gone?”

“Yes” Glimmer confirms, her hand seeking for Bow's to hold. Entrapta looks down too, writing slow and heavy with sorrow on their data pad.

“Oh,” Scorpia rubs her sore eyes with the back of her hand, gathering herself a little. “And Mermista?”

“She was taken to a hospital in Eternia, she is going to undergo surgery for her back. Her parents will keep her there for a while.” Bow explains, running his hand through the thick curls of his hair. He knows this well, after all he helped the emergency teams to get her into the ambulance after they had to sedate her to move.

“You think she'll be alright?”

“Physically? Yes. But besides that–” Bow's eyes sadden even more, looking at everyone in the room. “I don't know. I don't know how any of us is going to be for a while”

Scorpia looks back down, rubbing her hand against the back of her neck. “I understand”

Adora rests her hand over Scorpia's shoulder, squeeIng gently. “We are so sorry, Scorpia.” She tries to not break but her voice catches on her throat in the end.

Scorpia looks at her with grateful eyes, palming Adora's knuckles. “Perfuma always told me to keep going forward,” she inhales, pressing her hand against her chest just like Adora doesn't sometimes when things are too much. “I'm trying to do that for her. I think we all should, to honor her memory”

“We will,” Glimmer agrees, cleaning the tears from her eyelashes.

Scorpia approaches Bow and Glimmer and hugs them too, sighing on the shared embrace once more. Adora looks at them with a tiny and sad smile on the corner of her lips, running her eyes from them to Entrapta, who is back sitting at the table next to a bunch of plates.

“How're things going, Entrapta?”

“We made tiny baker goods!” Entrapta announces loudly, signaling at the dishes where Adora can now make the form of several kinds of pastries. From cookies to cupcakes to pop cakes to tiny tarts even. Some are charred and black, others look like a kind of Newtonian fluid, and then others that look like someone pulled them from a french patisserie, perfectly piped and beautifully decorated. “Well Scorpia burnt hers and I made a miscalculation of my batch, but Catra´s are a hundred percent edible! She is quite good at this”

“Of course I am.” Catra's voice comes, raspy and soft.

Adora turns around quickly to look at her walking out of the kitchen, standing still a few feet away from Adora. All of her hair is pulled back on a ponytail, letting see through the reddish spot on her cheek where Mermista had hit her. Her waist-apron is stained with flour as it is the tip of her nose. She is holding a towel over her palms and a huge plate of cookies over it, still smoking with warmth. Her pretty eyes hang themselves in Adora's blue ones, looking at each other sweet but heavy.

Catra shifts on her bare soles, barefoot over the floor and slightly nervous, looking at Adora from below her long eyelashes. Her lips

rest together, curling the dimple on her cheekbone.

“Hey”

“Hey,” Adora greets her back, out of breath. She can feel her own cheeks quickly painting in pink.

Catra must see something in Adora's face too because her eyes soften, the corners of her mouth twitching with a secret smile. She breaks the space between them, handing the kitchen towel and the smoking plate to Adora, who holds it automatically.

“Here, put them on the table,” Catra says, pointing at the table with her chin. Adora nods absently, only turning around from her to put them next to the papers.

“Toffee cookies!” Bow exclaims, leaning immediately to grab one.

“Don't eat them yet, they are hot,” Catra scowls him, cleaning her hands with a second towel. “I don't want you burning your tongue”

“Aw, Catra”

Catra rolls her eyes at him, catching sight of the newspapers splayed now next to food. She tilts her head to the side, arching her eyebrow. “And all that?”

“We found out some– stuff. About what is happening.” Bow explains, leaning to grab a few tarts from the plate next to Entrapta’s elbow.

Entrapta gasps, delighted as they look at the yellowed papers with a new kind of interest. “Scientific research!”

Glimmer nods, regarding Scorpia with an apologetic look. “We should go through it, if you are alright with that Scorpia.”

Scorpia looks back at her with her eyes watery, fidgeting with her hands but still nodding, her back straight. “I am. It's important,

right?”

“Very”

“Okay, I'll make space on the table.”

“Let us help you”

Bow and Glimmer start helping Scorpia to move empty plates around, chattering softly with each other. Entrapta shrieks in excitement, already going through the first bunch of papers and mutering on their voice recorder.

Adora turns to look at Catra again, who is already looking back. They stare at each for a few seconds, basking in each other's presence before moving. Catra extends her left hand towards Adora, who holds it immediately, lacing their fingers together.

Catra guides her wordlessly across the dinner room and back inside the kitchen, a small and thin corner of the apartment with a kitchenette and a fridge on the opposite wall, the window on the opposite side of the door closed to keep the heat from escaping.

Catra squeezes Adora's hand once and drops it again, walking back to her station near the long counter where a batch of dough is already waiting for her over a thin bed of flour. She starts kneading it immediately, her long fingers sure and professional as she finishes what she was doing before the cookies distracted her from it.

Adora leans against the counter, watching her girlfriend with patient eyes. Neither of them mind the silence, they have existed and loved each other for a long time to know silence between them doesn't mean indifference but safety. Still, Adora can't help the worried wrinkles that form on her forehead.

“I haven't seen you bake in a while,” Adora whispers, scratching the inner face of her wrist nervously.

Catra shrugs, placing the dough carefully inside an already prepared ceramic bowl, placing a towel over the mouth to let it puff. “Yeah, well. I'm stressed”

Adora looks at her moving across the kitchen like an extension of herself. Cleaning the counter, washing her hands, taking a tray out of the fridge and checking on the cookies still baking on Scorpia's oven. The smells inside the kitchen are amazing and the warm light is very tender inside this small space, the reflection of a comfortable and kind life where Catra and Adora can live without fear and hiding.

Adora’s heart squeezes inside her chest and she fumbles in her feet, eager to say something, anything at all. Anything to break the wall of guilt and anger against herself that has been festering inside of her since the mall and that she had barely managed to push back through the day.

Adora opens her mouth, inhaling sharply, her throat aching to break open. Catra beats her to it.

“Before you say anything, eat this,” Catra murmurs, standing right in front of Adora.

She is holding something small inside her fingers, round and of a rich brown, covered in cocoa powder and tiny sprinkles, holding it just a few inches from Adora's face. Adora lets her mouth fall open immediately, allowing Catra to gently drop the chocolate truffle against her tongue.

Adora's eyebrows skyrocket, the rich flavor filling her tongue as she savors on the dessert, making her tongue water with sweetness.

“It's delicious,” Adora says after gulping down, still delighted with the after taste. Catra nods, resting her palm against Adora's neck, the other on the side of her jaw.

“It is,” Catra’s pupils are blown up, her breath sweet against Adora's nose. “Now kiss me”

Adora doesn't need to be told twice. She wraps her arms around Catra's waist and holds her tight against her chest, slotting their lips together into a sweet but searing kiss. Catra hiccups inside of it, her mouth falling open just a slit, just enough for Adora's tongue to lick a tender line over her bottom lip and then beyond, pressing the taste of the truffle still lingering against Catra's mouth.

Adora gasps against Catra's lips, separating then diving back in several times, devoted to Catra's mouth and taste until she finally can lean back a little further, just enough to whisper between them.

“Cat”

“Shh, it's alright,” Catra coos her in the thread of a voice, caressing Adora's temples with steady fingers. Her eyes are bright as nebulas, drinking in the sight of Adora completely. “Kiss me again”

Adora whimpers and complies again, unable to keep herself away from her for a second longer. Adora walks Catra backwards across the kitchen until Catra's back is pressed against the cold glass of the window, pinned between it and Adora's body. And neither of them care if somebody can see them through the pulled curtains or from the street, wrapping their arms against each other and kissing with all the devotion in their hearts.

This is what Adora was craving so much. This is the missing piece on everyone else's mouth. Catra's taste, her smell, the touch of her skin against Adora's. She is like nothing in this world, she is Adora's personal blessing and never her curse.

Adora kisses and Catra kisses her right back, no grudge or anger lingering behind. They kiss until they have to physically stop because they are in Scorpia's apartment and they can hear their friends speaking in the other room.

Adora leans back but she still cannot tear herself away, peppering tiny kisses like freckles all over Catra's cheeks, nose and forehead. Catra giggles against the kisses, nuzzling her button nose on the angle below Adora's strong jaw, resting a single kiss over the hollow of her throat.

It makes Adora hum and it makes her chest give a little tug of bravery. She hooks her hands below Catra's knees and the side of her hips and lifts her up with ease, smiling against Catra's surprised yelp as she places her softly over the corner of the clean counter.

Catra grumbles but wiggles back a little over the marble, just enough so Adora can stand between her legs. Adora dips another kiss against Catra's cheek bone, short and honest, running her warm palm this time below the fabric of Catra's tight crop top.

Catra's eyebrows skyrocket but there is no lustful intent beneath Adora's touch. In fact, Adora is breathing hard, inspecting the skin below Catra's ribs when she had held her in the morning. There is nothing but smooth dark skin there but Adora keeps looking, making sure there are no bruises or tender spots left behind by her own hands.

Catra exhales, studying Adora studying her back, learning her all over again in just a few seconds. When Adora looks up to inspect the bruise in Catra's face, Catra wraps her hands around her wrists, lowering her hands gently over her own lap.

“Alright, now tell me what is going on with you?” Catra asks, arching her eyebrow.

Adora's heart drops to her shoes, stuttering. Of course Catra had realized just how on edge Adora truly felt, from the very beginning. “What?”

“What's with the face?” Catra presses her fingertip over Adora's forehead, wrinkling her nose. “You look like you ate a lemon like an apple, which you have definitely done before.”

It's a small joke, meant to ease Adora's anxiety, but the latter is already spiraling. There are a lot of things Adora needs to say to Catra, a lot of shit that 's going on. Adora needs to tell her about the danger they, *Adora,* are in and in return that Catra is in. Adora needs to tell her how much she loves her and how much she needs her.

For some reason, there is only one thing that beats the rest.

“Glimmer kissed me,” Adora blurts out, wheezing. Her own face shifts from frantic to alarmed as she realizes she said it in the worst possible way but there is no turn back.

Catra's face changes too from tender and worried to completely blank and then, terrifyingly, completely furious. “Wow”

She says it like spitting a curse, tearing her hands away from Adora to cross her arms in front of her chest, looking away sharply. Adora panics at the loss, resting her palms gently against Catra's upper arms.

“She is just confused. It's been hard for everyone.” Adora tries to explain, blood rushing inside her ears. Catra clenches her teeth, her piercing catching on her lip so hard that it makes her flinch in pain.

“Yeah she is so confused that she missed her boyfriend and kissed mine instead.” She spats, narrowing her eyes. She is trying very hard to be furious but the tears gathering in the corners of her eyes give her away immediately.

Adora knows what she is thinking, Adora knows the fear in Catra's heart. Fear of, for some reason, not being enough for Adora. Even though Catra is the sole reason Adora breathes, even though she is all Adora adores and loves. Even though she is strong and beautiful and resilient and has survived, even now, she is still afraid. The town, her mother, Light Hope and now even their friends have made her afraid and angry in return.

Adora is supposed to make her feel safe, to make her feel loved and cherished about everything else, to nurture her even when the world may be falling down. But even her can't help the ache that always lives inside Catra's heart.

“I stepped away,” Adora whispers, voice sore and raspy, holding all of her regret.

Catra closes her eyes for a second, inhaling deeply. “I know”

“I'm sorry”

Catra drops her eyes to their hands, lacing them back together. Her voice is less sharp and angry now, sorrowful as she plays with Adora's fingertips. “I understand”

“Not only about Glimmer,” Adora rushes to say, suddenly out of breath. She grips Catra's hand tightly, urging her to look at her. “Cat, I'm so sorry about everything that happened in the mall. I shouldn't have shaken you and I shouldn't have raised my voice to you. I put you on a horrible position again and I hurt you, again”

Adora's chin wobbles violently, tears pickling on the corner of her eyes. Catra looks at her with her pupils blown wide, her eyes soft. The warm light of the lamps makes her irises look like small fires, digging their ways inside Adora's heart.

Catra huffs after a second, her own sadness melting a little in the corners. She still looks shaken up though and her cheek has tiny thunderbolts marked below her freckles where the slap broke small blood vessels. Catra rolls her shoulders back, running her hand  from Adora´s up to her neck and then her mouth, pressing her sharp nail softly over Adora´s red kissed lips.

“Only you would beat yourself raw for this stuff,” Catra murmurs, almost for herself. “You are just being your usual self, Adora, I get it. And you– you're doing your best trying to protect me even when I barely think I deserve protection at all.”

Adora´s heart squeezes inside her chest painfully, making her exhale. “Cat”

“Nobody has ever loved me like you,” Catra´s voice is strained, stealing the breath from Adora´s lungs. “And I'm scared, Adora, I'm really fucking scared too. So I understand. I really do.” Catra looks at Adora from below her eyelashes, blinking slowly. She smiles tiny at Adora´s conflicted face, caressing a line from her mouth to her cheekbone. “Dummy”

Adora sighs, nodding so softly it's almost not there at all. She lets her forehead fall against Catra´s and then down, resting her cheek over Catra´s sharp collarbones, leaning against her warmth. Catra hums, wrapping her arms around Adora´s neck and her wide back, exhaling when Adora rests her palms against the small of her back.

“I don't think any of this is your fault,” Adora says, still resting on the angle between Catra´s neck and her heart but loud enough she knows Catra hears her.

Catra takes a sharp breath, accidentally digging her nails over Adora´s shoulder blades. “I–”

“You know I don´t. I would never think that. I would never blame you for what is happening” Adora places a gentle kiss right below the place where the scar lives, absorbing Catra´s shivers inside her arms. “I would never betray you like that,” Adora reassures her, letting her eyes fall closed. “I promise”

Catra sighs heavily, resting her cheek over the top of Adora´s head. “Okay”

“And I´m sorry. I didn´t mean to make you cry”

“It's alright, princess”

Adora leans back, pressing her palms over the counter and resting her weight over them, avoiding crush Catra. She raises her head

to meet their eyes, nuzzling their noses together softly. “I love you”

“I love you too, Adora”

Adora surges forward, slotting their mouths together once again. This time though it is more urgent, fired up, filled with some kind of crave only both of them know. Catra whimpers in surprise at the taste of it in Adora´s mouth but melts just as fast, letting Adora press their chest even closer.

Catra can feel the rapid beat of Adora´s heart below her white sheet, fluttering when Catra wraps her fingers against the back of her golden hair, tilting Adora´s head just enough to deepen the kiss further. Adora cannot hold back the whine that escapes her mouth, there right between Catra´s sharp teeth and soft tongue. Adora´s hands wander down, across Catra´s legging and towards the back of her knees, wrapping them there so she can drag Catra across the counter and closer against her.

Their bellies brush together with the movement and their teeth knock together accidentally with their surprised gasp, separating them just millimeters before they are gravitating together again. Catra´s left hand is still wrapped around Adora´s head, the left cradling her scratched jaw inside her palm. She wraps her legs tightly around Adora´s beautiful wide hips but still leans back a little more, panting for air and looking for her words. The clear string from their joined mouths betrays her immediately.

“My cookies–” Catra tries, her eyes rolling on their sockets and eyelids fluttering close when Adora´s mouth travels from her lips to the angle of her jaw, biting softly against her earlobe.

“They can wait,” Adora grunts against Catra´s skin, stretching one of her arms to blindly shut the oven off.

She grasps Catra´s chin between her fingers and guides her back towards her mouth, kissing the breath out of her as if she could not go another second without her inside her bones. Slow and

sweet and *hot.* Catra moans and gives up from trying to fight it, letting her entire self relax against Adora´s body.

They shouldn't be doing this right now, and definitely not in the kitchen counter but Adora kisses her with so much devotion and hunger that all coherent thoughts fly out of Catra´s head immediately. Adora can do whatever she wants, Catra is hers completely.

"Uh," a third voice comes inside the kitchen, stuttering near the kitchen door. "The papers are ready."

Adora rips her mouth of Catra´s mournfully, turning her head to the side to look at Glimmer clearly uncomfortable and definitely looking intently at the wall and not at them. Catra grumbles something unintelligible under her breath and lets her head fall against Adora´s shoulder, hiding her flushed face.

"Um, sure," Adora manages to say, gulping. She tries to run a hand across her face and hair, still holding Catra inside her arms, tampering messed up strands back down. But there is just so much she can do about the beet red of her entire face and the glistening in her eyes and lips. Glimmer is definitely not looking but she is also definitely completely tense, her hands opening and closing at her side.

Catra palms Adora softly, a silent ask to let her go. Adora steps back immediately, still holding Catra´s hands inside of her as she helps her jump back down the counter. Unlike Adora, who is looking either at the floor or at Catra only and who definitely looks like she was just caught making out with her girlfriend in their friend's apartment, Catra *is* looking.

Her hair is still in place and her makeup spotless, except for her lips. But instead of cleaning her lips with the handkerchief Adora offers her, she makes a point to lock Adora´s head in place in the same way Adora had just done to her. Adora´s heart shudders but Catra does not kiss her again, cleaning the marks of her red lipstick off Adora´s face with her thumb, there in the middle of the

kitchen and right in front of Glimmer. Adora tries to say something but she just wheezes, completely enthralled by the shit eating grin hidden in Catra´s mouth.

Catra finishes her job and tilts Adora´s head slightly to the side so she can press one last kiss right against the corner of her mouth, releasing Adora´s face with a soft hum. Adora is still dumbfounded when Catra starts walking out of the kitchen without another word, slamming her shoulder *hard* against Glimmer´s when she walks past her and out of the room.

Glimmer wrinkles her nose, rubbing the sore point in her shoulder and turning to look at Adora´s face with an accusatory look.

"You told her?" Glimmer says, barely containing a yell inside a whisper.

Adora blinks at her, slowly catching up to what Glimmer is talking about. She shrugs, rubbing the back of her neck. "Of course."

"I thought you didn't want to talk about it," Glimmer looks mortified, splashes of red coloring her cheeks.

"She is Catra." Adora says as explanation enough. "And she is my girlfriend, Glimmer."

Glimmer groans, stomping in the ground before walking out too, Adora close behind. "Great. Now she is going to kill me."

Bow and Entrapta are already by the table, going through a handful of papers and talking with very serious expressions. Scorpia is closer to the main door, biting into a cookie nervously as she listens to the conversation without saying a word; she kind of looks like she is about to pass out but she is being very brave about it.

Glimmer bee lines towards the dinner table too, not even looking back and avoiding Catra´s face at all costs. Catra has leaned against one of the columns of the apartment, her arms crossed over her chest and her foot planted against the column to keep

her balance, looking at the rest of her friends in silence. Her colorful eyes follow Glimmer´s back the entire way but she doesn ´t move and she doesn´t really look like she is going to beat her up. Yet.

Adora snuggles close to her, wrapping her hand around hers and breaking the tension on her body. The rain outside has stopped and inside the apartment smells good, like cookies and petrichor and the sandalwood of Catra´s perfume. Adora basks on it for a second and then her phone goes up.

Every single person inside the apartment goes still, turning their head to look at Adora directly in the face. Adora has frozen too, eyes wide as the phone rings and rings on the pocket of her pants, making even her teeth to shackle with it. Catra has frozen too, staring at the side of Adora´s face, her pretty face pale. Glimmer is looking at Catra. then at Adora as she takes the phone out, then back at Catra, realization falling over her too.

She was wrong.

"Hello?" Adora says, the call on the speaker. Catra´s hand is sweating inside of her palm.

*"Little hare,"* the killer purrs against the phone, echoing inside the apartment like a bell. " *How are you tonight?"*

Adora gulps, locking her eyes with Catra´s, finding something to anchor herself to the ground inside her beautiful eyelashes. She is so precious, Adora wishes she could  see her bake and sing and kiss her forever.

"What do you want from me?" Adora asks and she is proud from the way her voice does not flatter or break in the middle. "All of this is for me, isn't it? You said it yourself. It´s a gift for me. Tell me why"

There is a very quiet sound outside of the apartment, drowned in Adora´s voice and the call. None of them hear it until it is right in

front of the door, knocking softly, so softly, that Scorpia is the only one to react.

*"I thought about what you said and you were right,"* the killer says, chuckling on the phone. Catra is holding Adora´s hand so hard that it hurts.

"I´ll open," Scorpia murmurs, out of it, her mind miles away from the door as she hears for the first time the voice of the person that murdered Perfuma and their friends. Adora looks at her moving towards the door at the same time Catra does.

*"I should pay you a visit myself."*

The call cuts off and Adora is about to scream but it is already too late, even as Catra sprints forward, dropping her hand. Scorpia´s hand is already on the doorknob, turning it around and opening the door. She doesn´t even remember Entrapta´s code.

"Scorpia, wait!'

The door creaks on its hinges as it slams against the wall, shaking on its foundations. The six friends freeze in their place, staring with wide eyes at the red figure lurking on the other side, quiet as a graveyard.

It´s big, tall or maybe it feels like that because of the red robe that covers it from head to toe, curling on the floor like spilled blood. Wide as a shadow and heavy but it still makes no sound, breathing quietly or maybe not even breathing at all as it stands still right beyond the frame of the door. Neither of them can make out of its face or its hands and even as it moves to the side when they look below the hood there is only darkness, black fabric and nothing else, yet it still feels like it was smiling, a demon pulled out of the pits of hell craving for their blood.

Adora´s heart is hammering inside her chest and she is not holding Catra´s hand. Things happen very quickly.

“Oh no,” Scorpia mutters just as the killer snaps back to life, turning towards her, standing closest to the door, in a rush. The killer extends a black hand and grabs Scorpia´s arm tightly between its fingers, the other swishing the the side as it pulls a hunting knife out of the folds of its crimson robe.

Sound returns to the apartment like an explosion. Glimmer screams, ringing on Adora´s eardrums painfully. Scorpia screams too, a drowned yell as she lift her right arm out of instinct alone and the killer swings the knife fully at her face, Catra crashes against Scorpia and wraps her hands around her shoulder, yanking her back with so much strength that they both fall into the ground heavily. The sharp end of the knife catches on the skin of Scorpia ´s arms and cuts a clean line from her elbow to her wrist, blood bursting red and warm all over the floor.

“Shit! Run!” Catra screams from the ground, pulling from Scorpia ´s pained body to try and stand up again. “Run!”

The killer snaps its void face towards her, body locking into a shiver, almost trembling with how hard it contains itself. There is something it must see in Catra because its whole demeanor changes, from looming and threatening to completely violent, throwing itself against Catra fully.

Scorpia stands up in a rush, her opposite hand trying to keep the blood from her arm, her face pale. She pulls Catra up with her but the killer reaches her too, seizing her from the ankle and yanking her back harshly. Catra's entire body slams against the ground, her right knee twisting and crushing against the floor.

Catra yells, the pain in her already busted knee flooring even worse now, knocking her right back with a pained whimper. “Adora!”

“Get your fucking hands off her!”

Adora runs with all her strength, slamming a ceramic lamp against the killer´s temple, so hard that it bursts into dozens of pieces

and makes it stumble back. The killer snaps its black gaze towards Adora and even inside all the darkness she knows it is staring at her directly, drinking in the sight of her so near yet so far away still. Adora drops the remains of the lamp into the floor with a shiver and kneels on the floor, wrapping her arms around Catra´s waist and pulling her up into a swift movement, pressing her back against her chest. “Let's go, let's go!”

Scorpia, Adora and Catra run towards the corridor, barely avoiding another swing of the killer's knife as it shakes from the hit, not even slowering its pace. To the left, Glimmer and Bow yell, lifting the dinner table and dragging it across the entire floor, pinning the killer against the wall and the wood. The killer huffs but even that is silent and the robe doesn't even wrinkle, a morbid display of show and carnival as it mocks and executioner cloth.

Scorpia fumbles with the window of the kitchen but it is too small for any of them to crawl through and too high to even think about it. Catra is trying to follow her but her knee is hurting like a bitch and she is limping, cursing furiously when she stumbles back into the ground. Adora catches her in her arms before she falls, turning them around to face the scene in front of them once with her heart inside her throat.

Glimmer and Bow have managed to jump over the legs of the table and scramble towards the living room. But once that the pressure of them holding the table is gone the killer moves again, kicking the table so hard that it breaks into two, sharp splinters of wood flying everywhere. They catch Glimmer´s cheek and she whimpers, tiny drops of blood dripping off her skin.

“The bedroom!” Adora barks, stringing her vocal cords, “The bedrooms, now!”

Bow grabs Glimmer´s upper arms and drags her across the carpet with all his strength, holding his breath when the killer swings the knife so close to his ear that it catches the start of his ear. making him wince in pain. Scorpia runs too, holding an already blood

soaked towel against the wound on her arm, her face soaked in tears.

Adora relaxes her grip on Catra just so she can nudge her towards the corridor too but a terrified whimper breaks their walk, making them all turn around in fear. Entrapta is stuck between the living room and the huge window behind them, frozen in place with terror as the killer takes notice of them too and starts making its way towards them. Scorpia gasps in horror, stopping in her steps hard.

"No! Wait, no!"

The killer slams its knife against the wood of the window frame and reaches for Entrapta´s hair, wrapping the purple strands inside its black fingers so hard that Entrapta yells in pain, shaken around by the same hand. They try to fight it back, kicking and lashing on the floor as the killer lifts them from the ground a few inches but they are too scared to do major damage, chest moving as fast as a hummingbird about to fall down from the sky.

Terror and adrenaline courses down Adora´s veins, already moving forward to stop it, to to as she can, to fight tooth and nail and break this demon's hands out of its body if it is needed so it can put Entrapta back into the fucking ground. The killer swings its arms back and forward and throws Entrapta off the window of the fifth level of the apartment building without a single second thought or breaking a sweat. Like a red plague would crush a violet under its boot and Adora is already running but Catra has always been faster than her.

Catra extends her arms in front of her and throws herself against the window frame too, barely managing to catch Entraptas arms between her hands and not fall at the same time. The metal frame digs in the skin of her abdomen painfully, making Catra gasp and wheeze in pain but she still doesn't let go, half of her body out of the building and hanging from the window, holding Entrapta from falling into their death with her hand alone.

Entrapta yells, both in absolute terror and in pain, their shoulder clicking horribly inside their skin and a joint might have popped off after all. Catra yelps, digging her sharp nails into Entrapta´s skin to keep them from slipping away from her hold. She can feel her face red with effort and her heart bursting inside her chest, tears flooding out of her eyes by the way her body strains and by fear alone.

Inside the apartment the killer is mere feet away from her vulnerable body, unable to move away if it would swing against her again, not without dropping Entrapta in the process. The killer knows it because it turns around, calmly grabbing the knife back from the wood and turning back to Catra.

Catra can feel it moving heavy and sticky like a clot around her and she wheezes, a terrified sob going past her lips, tightening her grip on Entrapta´s wrist.

"Entrapta! Hold on!" She screams, wishing somebody, anyone would hear them on the street. "I´m not letting go, alright?! Hold on!"

Entrapta turns to look from the ground to her face with terror written all over inside their lilac eyes, tears also cursing down their cheeks and pooling on their chin, falling sadly through the dozens of meters down below.

Inside the apartment Adora jumps over the couch at the opposite side of the killer and wraps herself around Catra´s waist completely, placing her entire body between her and the knife of the killer. Catra gasps at the touch, crying even harder at the touch of Adora´s arms safely keeping her in the frame.

The killer stumbles back at the sight of Adora, knife hovering still for a few seconds. Adora´s stormy eyes widen at the sight, her mouth going slack with surprise,

The killer´s hesitation it´s enough for Glimmer, Bow and Scorpia to jump into the dinner too. Glimmer has a kitchen knife into her

hands that she wields like a fucking madman, throwing blindly stabs without a single aim but a lot of heart towards the killer´s chest. The killer jumps back easily but it doesn´t take on account Bow swinging a heavy chair against its face, knocking it back against the wall of the diner like a rabid dog.

Adora gasps, wrapping her arms even tighter around Catra´s waist and pulling hard off her, dragging her back inside the room as much as she can. But there are two weights hanging from the window and Adora´s sneakers fail her in the middle, the carpet giving away below her soles as they slip back against the window.

"Catra!" Adora yells, bulking her knees against the wall to try and avoid the three of them falling against the concrete and towards their death.

"Fuck, fuck, fuck!" Catra is screaming, blinking against the darkness of the night. That is when she sees it, blissfully illuminated by the light of some neighbor that turns on the light because of all of the screaming, the dark paint and creaking metal of the emergency stairs that hang just a few meters at their side.

"Can you reach the stairs?!" Catra asks, do the best she can to swing Entrapta from side to side, giving them enough impulse to reach the railing with their hand. Entrapta is still terrified as fuck, a damn bat frozen by the light, looking at Catra without understanding. Catra becomes frantic, shaking Entrapta´s arms as she feels Adora´s own hands trembling violently around her waist with the effort. "Entrapta!"

Entrapta shakes awake by the screaming, looking at the same place Catra is. Some spark of understanding shimmers inside their eyes, nodding furiously against the cold night. "Yes!"

Catra bites into her bottom lip so hard that she bleeds herself and swings Entrapta to the side with all her strength, biting back a yell when she feels her knee, pressing harshly against the wall, bend and pull horridly against the brick. Entrapta inhales, holds their

breath and lets go from one of Catra´s arms, stretching their own as far as they can and somehow managing to wrap it around the rusty metal completely. Catra cries in relief and with a last pull lets go from Entrapta completely, watching them hold themself against the rail with all their forces and jump to the other side, falling against their butt on the dark stairs safely and away from danger.

Adora feels the loss of weight and Catra´s relief sobs in her fingertips and pulls back harshly, bringing Catra back inside the apartment completely. Catra´s knee gives up below her and stumbles her against the floor, falling hard against Adora´s chest. Pain flares up Catra´s entire leg, from her knee to the start of her hip, making her curl inside herself with a drowned scream, crying as she wraps her hand over the aching joint.

Adora bends towards her immediately and inspects her knee too, taking in the way Catra´s legs and entire body are shaking so badly that her teeth are clashing together. She must have a sprain or her sciatic nerve has clipped, between the fall of the morning and the horrible pull of the killer and holding Entrapta on the window. It´s a miracle it's not broken but she is not counting her blessing just yet.

“Mother fucker,” Adora says between clenching teeth, sweat gathering on her chest and on the back of her shirt, sticking the white fabric against her skin. She runs her hand against Catra´s feverish forehead and pushes her soaked curls back, holding her tightly against her body to reassure her down.

In the limits of the living room the killer grabs the leg of the chair Bow is wielding and pulls from it, sending it tethering against the floor. Bow gasps, surprised, failing to react when the killer throws itself towards him. The knife has fallen somewhere on the floor but the killer doesn´t even bother to look for it, wrapping its black hands around Bow´s throat and pressing down. Bow chokes on his breath, eyes widening in sudden terror. He falls back against the cold floor, his head connecting painfully with the ground, gasping for air when the killer twists its hand and presses even further.

“No!”

Glimmer crashes against the back of the killer, swinging her own knife down. The killer twists around just in time and elbows her in the stomach, grabbing her from the back of the shirt and slamming her hard against the destroyed table. The distraction works though because for a second the killer lets go from Bow´s neck and that is all he needs to push the killer away from him.

Bow lifts his legs, presses his sneakers against the killer´s cheat and pushes back with all his strength, sending it flying back too. The killer stumbles against the glass door of the kitchen and crashes against it heavily, pieces of glass scattering everywhere around the apartment´s floor.

Bow rushes to his feet and runs to Glimmer´s side. helping her on her feet again. Glimmer winces and she is bleeding from her eyebrow, dripping on the floor and staining her pink shirt in red. Adora hurries to her feet too, bending down to gather Catra inside her arms; she holds the back of her tights and her back tightly and pulls up, carrying Catra against her chest.

Catra whimpers and flinches with pain, struggling inside Adora´s arms, kicking loosely at her without real strength under it. “I can walk”

Adora, Bow and Glimmer rush onwards through the open door, tripping on broken pieces of furniture all around. Scorpia, bless her soul, is already lingering on the frame, still actively bleeding but incapable of moving, hesitating to even breathe, much less to run away and leave them all there.

Behind them, below the pieces of broken glass, the killer stands up again, breathing heavily this time. The hood of the crimson robe has fallen down, revealing below tight black fabric covering head and neck, making any of them incapable of making its factions. And even worse, right above its face it lays a carnival mask, grotesque and twisted, made of some kind of clay and plastic and mocking any kind of jester or beauty that you would

find on a Halloween night on Etheria. The mask of a red demon looking back at them and stained in long ago dried blood.

“Scorpia, go!” Adora snaps her head towards her friend, holding Catra tightly between her arms.

“But–”

“Go! Get help and go!”

Scorpia rushes across the corridor of the department complex, reaching the spiral stair that faces the middle in record time. All of the departments are placed the same, around in a circle with the solely spiral marble staircase in the middle, leaving a void eye of nothing right in the middle. If you were to peek through the solid staircase you would see the white marble floor of the lowest level.

Bow and Glimmer run out of the apartment too, holding each other and tripping with each other several times. Glimmer pulls out her phone with shaky hands and dials the emergency number there, painting and completely terrified. The call goes through immediately, the sweet music of the car slipping from the other side.

“Mom!” Glimmer screams into the phone, crying heavily.

“Glimmer?” Angella answers back, clear worry obvious in her voice.

The killer rushes across the door and crosses the frame too, throwing itself towards them violently. It has managed to grab Glimmer´s kitchen knife and it wields it expertly in front of its demonic face, making Glimmer and Bow scream. They are not going to make it to the stairs like Scorpia, not in time, not without a loss. But they all can see the golden gates of the old fashioned elevator just a little to the left, waiting for them closed but patiently.

Adora is running too but the adrenaline is failing her, her arms already shaking from holding Catra on the window and

threatening her to stumble her back down.

“Put me down, Adora!”

“No!”

“Careful!” Glimmer screams, watching as the killer turns around and tries to grab Catra by the hair. Adora pulls away but her foot catches with the carpet on the floor and she falls against the floor, hard, rolling a few inches into the wall from the apartments around them.

“Glimmer what's happening?!” Angella yells at the top of her lungs. In the car she doubles whatever speed she is going on, driving like the devil across the town.

“We are in Scorpia´s apartment!”

Catra has rolled on the floor too but she shakes herself much faster than Adora. She stands up on wobbly legs, wrinkling her nose at the excruciating pain in her knee and leans down, pulling from Adora´s wide biceps until she is back on her feet too. Adora is bleeding heavily from her nose, running down her chin in rivulets of a red so similar to the killer's rob that is frightening. Adora rests her palms over Catra´s upper arms and sputters around a mouthful of blood, silver eyes narrowed with pain, splashing softly over Catra´s freckled face.

“What are you doing out of the Manor?!”

“Mom, please!”

Catra looks at the killer coming from the corner of her eyes. She presses her hands against Adora´s chest and pushes her towards Bow and Glimmer, closer to the elevator, with all the strength she has left. Adora gasps as she stumbles back, trying and failing to hold Catra, to bring her with her, to protect her, her blunt nails leaving shallow scratches like tiger lines all over Catra´s arms with the amount of desperation pouring out of Adora´s chest and heart.

Glimmer and Bow catch Adora before she can fall on the floor, wrapping her in their arms. Just a few feet in front of them the killer grasps the back of Catra´s shirt and drags her back, slamming her against the wall so hard that her head bounces against the concrete, knocking the air out of her. She flops on the carpeted ground unconscious for a second, her body curling with immeasurable pain.

"Catra!" Adora cannot breath.

She cannot breath and she cannot think, she cannot feel her heart beating inside her chest or the blood running across her veins. She cannot see nor smell, not even scream until she realizes she is screaming, screaming and screaming and screaming so loud and so bloodcurdling that her vocal cords are tearing themselves apart, filling her mouth with acid and copper taste. She cannot feel herself in this earth, all of her senses, all of her being focused on Catra´s body laying flat on the ground, her hair splayed below her like a hallo, blood dripping off her temples and her nose and staining her precious face in red.

Adora kissed her in the kitchen. She kissed her in the kitchen and before that in the Thaymor Bridge and in Glimmer´s house and it Light Hope´s and in the square; in the school and in the woods and in the Prom ball and in every single space of this godforsaken town. She has kissed her lips and her face and every inch of her warm body, sharp in the edges and so absolutely gentle everywhere else. She has kissed her, has made love to her, has held her in her arms and danced across both cold and warm grounds.

This is Catra, her Catra. This is her best friend and her partner and her girlfriend. This is the woman Adora is going to marry when she gets enough guts to ask her finally. This is the girl she met when she was five years old and the one she stuck around through all the rest of their years; this is the teenager that was so much better than everyone else's judgment of her and who only proved day by day. This is the woman that survived. This is Adora ´s whole world, her entire heart, her soul and her life. This is the

angel Adora swore to protect when she was five and seven and fourteen and seventeen and twenty and she is bleeding on the ground at the hands of someone that wants to destroy Adora from the inside out.

Adora yells, a sound so brutal and grotesque that makes her own friends flinch. She throws herself on her hands and knees and starts crawling on the ground towards Catra, digging her nails on the ground and dragging herself across the floor like a corpse pulled out of a grave for her lover.

“Adora, no!” Glimmer wraps her arms below Adora´s armpits, pulling her back frantically..“We need to go! It's going to kill you!”

It only proves to be highly ineffective because Adora is tall and wide and strong as fuck and she pushes Glimmer away like a moth to the wind. “Get off me! Catra!”

The killer kneels besides Catra, ignoring Adora´s screams. It grabs Catra´s shoulder and yanks her harshly to the side, displaying her flat on her back against the carpet. Catra whimpers and blinks away, her eyes narrowed but fogged with pain, staring back at the killer's dark face.

The killer wraps its dark hand around Catra´s chin and holds her in place and for a single second of clearance Catra and Adora realize that it saw them, it saw them kissing on the kitchen, from other building or from the ground, who knows but it saw them and it is using the shared moment of tenderness to terrify them and hunt them down.

The killer lowers its head down, pressing the mask against the side of Catra´s face. It smells like blood and sweat and something else Catra´s brain cannot place among the pain. It breathes hard against her skin, slick and hot, making Catra kick and recoil.

“Stray,” it says, like a curse, slamming the back of Catra´s head against the floor before she can make out its voice among the haze.

The killer raises his arm, dangling the sharp end of the knife right above Catra´s heart. Catra´s breath tangles inside her lungs and stops, her heart feels like it is going to explode and she is drenched in her own blood and sweat. Tears roll down her cheeks hot and acid, clogging her sight and her throat with their strength.

´ *It was about time, Catrina´* her mother says inside her head, digging her phantom nails on her flesh. ´ *I´m waiting for you´*

It is so much like so many times in her life that she doesn´t fight but she also doesn´t feel afraid anymore. In fact, she doesn´t even close her eyes, staring directly at the darkness of the killer's face without blinking or looking away. If this is how she is going to die, she won´t coward away.

Silently she throws a prayer to Adora to look away, to survive. To hope she knows Catra is grateful, for everything Adora has done for her, for loving her, for wanting to protect her when the world said otherwise. Catra does not believe in prayers but Adora does and Catra loves Adora so much. She is the only reason Catra still wants to be alive.

Catra feels the cold air as the knife swings down and the warm touch of a body throwing itself over her, wrapping her head and torso inside tender but strong arms. The blade of the knife stabs Adora right through the right shoulder, like warm butter, no resistance at all, opening blood vessels and flesh like deflowering a tulip with sharp nails.

"Agh!" Adora screams, pain exploding all of her nerve endings.

Her blood starts pouring out of her shoulder, staining her skin and dripping down her nape and hair, turning the golden strands from honey to burnt copper. The blade barely misses her artery by some kind of miracle but it doesn´t make the pain to be less, coiling inside of her body like a parasite.

The sound of Adora´s scream snaps Catra into reality, pushing back her own pain and the fog on her brain, burying her mother back into the graveyard in her mind. Catra wraps her arms around Adora´s shoulder, cradling her soaked head between her palm.

“Adora,” Catra cries, wrapping her palm against the blade and slipping with Adora's blood, slicing her own palm open in the way.

The killer, however, also recoils, letting go from the knife's handle and stumbling back, the red fabric of its robe tangling on its feet. It hesitates for a second, watching, almost like a statue, watching and watching as Adora's blood falls and stains her white tank top and the floor below.

Catra rolls onto her abdomen and Adora leans back, kneeling on the floor and panting against the pain on her shoulder. Catra crawls towards her, wrapping her arms around her chest and holding her weight inside her arms, trembling so violently that Adora is trembling too. They are both drenched in each other's blood, frightening pale and weeping silently on each other's shoulders. Adora's nails dig on the ground and splinter, anger, pain and the desperation of getting Catra out of here clogging her throat. They have both promised to look after each other and they are both to do so.

The killer reacts before neither of them can, shaking itself awake with newfound strength. It pulls the hood back in place and walks towards the girls, leaning down. Catra looks at it and twists around wrapping her hands around its wrists and tugging from them, pulling it down to make it stumble again. The killer scoffs and slaps her across the face, pushing her away.

Adora growls, feral and out of her mind, her eyes wide and silver as broken moons. She tries to move, to stand up and fight back but the killer wraps it's hand around the handle and pulls the knife out mercilessly, more blood rolling down Adora's shoulder and making her scream harder, her mind clouded by pain. She cannot fight like this.

The killer wraps its hand around Adora's neck and presses down, lifting Adora slightly off the ground, choking the air out of her. Adora wheezes, digging her nails on the black gloves, kicking blindly at the killer. The killer tilts its head to the side and considers her for a second, running dark and demonic eyes through her bloodstained face. It takes her in, completely, breathing deeply to inhale the smell of her skin, bloodstained and blood oranges.

Adora barely has time to take a breath as the killer leans down and cuts a sharp line against Adora's side, superficial but long, from the back of her ribcage to the start of her abdomen. Adora gives a drowned yell and the killer throws her to the side with force, rolling over the carpet and away.

Catra rushes from the floor and back to Adora's side, her knee trembling violently but pushing it back so she can pull Adora up and back to her feet. The killer is looming back towards them, dragging the sharp blade against the rail of the stairs.

“Bow!” Catra yells, her head swimming. There is horrid pain across her temples and she wants to throw up, she must have one hell of a concussion and she still feels like she is going to die, but she cannot pass out right now, turning to look at the other two with pleading eyes. “Glimmer!”

Both Bow and Glimmer run towards them too, wrapping their hands around Adora's armpits and pulling from her, dragging her towards the elevator doors. They are so close, so so close but the killer is unwavering like a thick cloud and throws itself over them again.

Catra turns around and wraps her hand around the killer's wrist, on the dominant hand that holds the knife, twisting it to the side as she presses the other flat inside the hood and against the demon mask, pushing it back with newfound strength.

Anger and pure, unfiltered hatred has made it inside her heart at sight of Adora's blood, poisoning every single cell inside her body

and making her crave the same violence and gore they are drenching in.

“Take her!” Catra screams, balancing on her good knee and tugging to the side, managing to knock down the bloodstained knife from the killer's hand. It clangs against the floor loudly. “Bow, take her!”

“No! NO!” Adora is struggling inside her friend's holds but she is bleeding, the stain on her side growing further and further as the seconds go by. “Catra!”

“I'll catch up,” Catra says, voice strained. Her hair is matted with blood, tangling her curls together. Her right knee is flattering, pain exploding on her body yet she remains unmoving, pushing back. “Just get down!”

“Catra no!” Adora kicks into the floor digging her ankles on the tiles and slipping with her own blood. Bow drags her as best as he can, fighting her and the pain on his throat at the same time.

Glimmer rushes towards the elevator and pushes the button, miraculously opening for her. Behind them Catra grunts and raises her bad leg, making a monumental effort as she slams her knee against the killer's ribs, pushing it further and further back down and towards the door of the emergency stairs placed next to the last apartment. Catra screams with the hit and balances on her soles, her face twisted with pain. Even injured and about to throw up, she is an excellent fighter, and she refuses to go down without a fight. They can hear the neighbors calling the police inside their house but none of them goes out to aid.

Glimmer jumps inside the elevator, stretching her hand towards her friends. The old elevator racks dangerously, starting to slowly go down even if she has not pressed any buttons yet and the door is still open. Glimmer turns around, smashing the up button again and again until she physically feels it giving out, flattening and sticking completely, smeared with Adora's and her own blood.

“Fuck!” Glimmer yells, slamming her fists against the control panel, trying to make the elevator stop moving down.

“Glimmer stay inside!!” Bow exclaims, turning his steps away and from the elevator and towards the start of the stairs, dragging Adora behind him. There is a trail of blood on the floor.

“What?!”

“We'll take the stairs! Take Catra and go!” He says without looking back, resting Adora's arm firmly over his shoulders and dragging her quickly step by step. Adora rolls her head back against Bow's shoulder, digging her nails on the tender flesh of his hand to try and make him flinch, to tear herself away from him and go towards Catra.

Catra is fighting for her life, dodging a hit from the killer and kicking it against the open door of the emergency stairs but the killer is too strong too and it holds on, chasing Catra's aching bones. It manages to hold her by the wrist and swings her to the side, rolling in the carpet again. Glimmer jumps inside the elevator, her sight almost completely obscured now, the concrete walls forming a barrier between her and the corridor.

“Catra, get in!” Glimmer yells, stretching her hand. “Now!”

Catra sees her and she crawls in the ground on her hands and knees, stretching her own arm to try and grasp Glimmer. Their fingers brush on the fingertips, desperately fighting to hold each other but the elevator is already too far gone and it disappears inside the concrete square, dragging Glimmer with it.

The last thing Glimmer can hear is a pained scream, new turmoil breaking on the corridor and Catra's painful  yell. “Stay away from me! No!”

The last thing Glimmer sees is the killer kicking Catra's ribs so hard that she screams at the top of her lungs, writhing on the floor and then going fearfully still, unconsciousness reclaiming her

again. Catra's figure and the shadow looming above her disappears with the elevator's door.

“Catra!” Glimmer yells, pulling from her pink hair. “Bow! Adora! Fuck!”

Glimmer screams inside the elevator, slamming her closed fists against the old copper walls. The elevator goes down and down like a broken merry-go-round until it finally reaches the end, opening with a mocking ding into the ground level.

Glimmer stumbles out and into the polished linoleum, looking at the stairs nervously. She takes a breath, ready to scream her friend's name, to run back up again if needed too, when a new hand wraps around her shoulder and yanks her harshly backwards, almost pushing her into the ground. Glimmer snaps her head back so fast her neck protests, catching sight in the lilac eyes and link hair of her mother, standing right behind Glimmer with the most furious kind of look.

“Mom!” Glimmer exclaims, holding herself to the white sleeves of her mother's shirt. Relief washes over her immediately and immediately evaporates into nothing, catching sight of Angella’s eyes festering inside of hers.

“Glimmer, what on earth were you thinking?!” Angella screams, shaking Glimmer's shoulders violently.

“Mom!”

“Why were you so reckless?! So stupid! I told you to stay on the manor, why do you never listen?!”

Glimmer slaps her mother's hands away so hard that she recoils with pain, gasping at Glimmer even daring to have done that in the first place. But Glimmer does not fucking care, stepping back from her mother sharply.

“Why do you always do this?! Stop treating me like a child!”

“I´ll do it when you stop acting like one!”

Above their heads Adora screams, low and brutal and furious, fighting with Bow at some point of the stairs as she tries to crawl her way back up. Glimmer cannot hear Catra anymore and dread falls over her, a horrible sensation washing through her entire body.

“I need to go for my friends,” Glimmer announces, not even looking at her mother, voice blank. She turns towards the stairs and tries to rush up. She barely manages to give a step in before she is yanked back so hard that her ankles threaten to sprain.

“Glimmer, no.” Angella is holding Glimmer so hard that she must be leaving bruises in the form of her fingertips all over her upper arms. Her expression is chaotic, hair a mess and eyes side and horrified. She smells a little like sweat and a little like incense.

Glimmer struggles inside her mother's grip, shaking her head. “They are my friends!”

“Glimmer! Stay away!”

“Adora is there! She must have gone back for Catra!” Glimmer exclaims, pointing at the stairs with her arms, trying and failing to hold her mother's gaze with hers. “And Bow, Bow stayed too. I have to save them! I don't care what you think, I don't care what you believe, I’m going! ”

“GLIMMER!” Angella screams so hard that it echoes inside the entire building. “STAY AWAY!”

Glimmer gapes at her mother, frozen. She had never spoken to Glimmer like that, not even once, not even after sickness took Micah and they were strained for a long time. Never like she were to push Glimmer out of the building herself, as if she didn't care for anything or anyone else that isn't Glimmer, even as she hears Adora tear her vocal cords apart above their heads.

“The killer is there with them,” Glimmer explains, slowly, almost too much, trying to make her mother understand the words.

“I know,” Angella clicks her teeth together, her eyes obscuring immediately. A shadow of anger falls over her, making her tall and unapproachable. There is fury in her voice, rotting in her tongue as she says the words. “I know it all.”

Glimmer remains frozen in place, unknowing of what to say and do next, too scared of her own mother to even move. Angella uses this distraction perfectly, pushing Glimmer gently backwards until she is closer to the exit and away from the doors of the elevator. Rain has started to fall outside again, soaking the ground and filling the reception with its earthly smell.

“Do not move from here, I prohibit it to you” Angella commands, dropping her hold on Catra's arms and jumping into the elevator. It closes for her, the doors joining with a little ding before it goes back once again. The elevator doors eat Glimmer's mother completely and take her away, with her thousand questions and her secrets, her hands closed in fists and her eyes angry.

Glimmer reacts too late, her lip recoiling over her gums as she stomps angrily on the ground, yelling. “Mom! Agh!”

Glimmer runs towards the stairs, ready to rush up too only to come face to face with Bow's handsome and bloodstained face. He is still carrying Adora's almost limp body, marks of nails on his face and clothes wrinkled by the struggle. Adora put on a fight walking down and it shows, her hair matted with blood and tousled and her cheeks red with exertion. The stain on her side has stopped bleeding out but she winces every time she moves into that side.

“Glimmer!” Bow exclaims, feeling relieved as fuck. Glimmer weeps, throwing her arms around his neck and nuzzling on his cheek.

“Bow! Adora!”

Adora grips Glimmer's shirt tightly and yanks her towards her. Her face is chaotic, frightening, it makes Glimmer shrink with sudden fear and a surprised gasp. Adora's eyes are terrible, scleras completely bleeding in red, making the storm blue of her irises look violet under the flickering lights of the building. She is trembling violently as she regards Glimmer, her lips blue and pale in places.

"Catra. Is she with you?" Adora demands, voice broken. She looks behind Glimmer's back but there is nobody here but the three of them. Adora's breathing starts to pick up again, wheezing and acrid like rotten fruit. "Bow, you said she was with Glimmer. You said she was with Glimmer! Catra!"

She is borderline hysterical, if not completely gone already, fighting back against Bow's hold. The wound on her side opens again and starts bleeding once more, matching the blood dripping off her shoulder. Glimmer cradles Adora's face between her palms and forces her to look at her, meeting her bleeding eyes with hers.

"My mom went for her," Glimmer says, trying to reassure her and reassure herself. "My mom is here and she is going for her right now.

The words make it past the fog inside Adora's brain but they still aren't enough. She shakes her head, stumbling back and then forward, swinging dangerously to the ground even though Bow holds her straight.

"I need to– I need to go for her," Adora is saying, almost to herself, her eyes roaming through the entire building and at anything at all. She must, too, have realized the overwhelming silence drowning the place.

Glimmer whimpers, shaking her head, her hands still loosely wrapped around Adora's face. "No, Adora–"

"Glimmer stay away from me!" Adora explodes, baring her teeth at Glimmer. "I need to go for her!"

Frustration eats Glimmer alive, festering all kinds of worry or sadness blooming inside her chest. She closes her hands into fists and pulls off her hair, dropping her hands back down to hold Adora's wrist hard inside her fingers. She puts herself right in front of Adora's bloodied and messed up face, screaming at her, uncaring of the violence painted there.

“Stop it! Just stay here with us!”

“Don’t touch me! Let me go with her!”

There is a rush of cold air and a momentum of silence.

Then the body crashes violently against the floor,

Blood splashes on their faces, an almost gentle spray of red painting their skins crimson, a rush of red and pain and coldness that stains the entire floor with its color. Glimmer stares at the floor quickly staining in red with wide eyes, her breath stuck on her throat. She cannot think and she cannot feel anything, nothing but the cold drip of blood in her face and the rain breeze slipping through the building´s gate.  Her eyes stares at the middle of the tiled floor in front of her and cannot make out what they see, blessing her with ignorance and shock for one blissful second.

Her mother's body looks back at her with blank eyes, forever frozen in the same expression. Surprise and fear. Her head is bent backwards, chin facing her shoulder blades and Glimmer can't even begin to understand that it´s facing the wrong way. Her skull is broken, in pieces, crushed against the strength of gravity and the hard floor that has made her dead bed, soaking her in red blood. It stains her forever pink hair and her pale skin, coating her body and the marble and Glimmer´s face and legs.

Someone is screaming. Glimmer turns to look at her friends. Adora is staring too, her face green, her eyes wide and pupils small, but she is quiet, just looking with her heart on her throat and her beautiful face stained in Angella´s blood. Bow is holding

her, helping her not to collapse on the floor, still pressing his palm against her bleeding side. He is also looking though, his dark eyes wide, his body trembling violently, gaping as if he couldn´t bring the air inside his lungs.

Someone is screaming but it's not real, it is in Glimmer´s head. The sound of her own drowned yell choking her from the inside out as she stares and stares and stares.

Angella Bright is dead. Her mother is dead. The last thing they did was fight.

The doors of the elevator ding again, opening behind them with mocking calm. Catra is inside, curled in the furthest corner of the golden elevator. Her legs are pressed against her chest, her arms wrapped around her chest, nails digging on her ribs. She is wheezing, gasping for air, eyes open wide and body trembling. There is blood all over the floor of the elevator, marks of Catra´s hands as she crawled on the floor and collapsed against the corner, blood from her palms and her temples and her mouth. Bleeding but alive, she is alive.

Glimmer looks at the exact second Catra realizes Angella´s broken body is on the floor because Catra lets out a blood curdling scream, echoing across the entire building. She slams her palms against her head repeatedly and breaks down violently, digging her sharp nails on her scalp and pulling down, eyes bloodshot and face coated in her own sweat, tears and blood.

Adora slips out of Bow´s hold and scrambles towards her in a heartbeat, slipping several times on the floor with her bloodstained sneakers and the blood gushing out of Angella´s skull.

Adora presses her hands against her own stab wound and quite literally crawls on the polished floor and inside the old elevator towards Catra, gathering her inside her arms the second she is near.

She wraps her in her arms and cradles her blood matted hair in her palms, shushing her gently into a sweet lullaby, rocking them both softly. Catra hides her face in Adora´s neck and cries loudly, holding herself to her body like a lifeline.

Adora´s back is turned towards the rest of the scene, all of her attention focused in Catra and Catra alone, limbs tangled and lips against temples. Nothing else matters but her, nothing else is important but her, her. *Her* .

Glimmer stares at them from her frozen place, blinking very slowly. Glimmer´s pink shoes are soaked in red and she hates her. Glimmer stares at Adora´s loving arms around Catra´s body, at Catra´s pretty eyes bloodshot with tears, at Catra´s shivering body and bruised body, at her red ears where Adora repeats *I love you I love you I love you* to her over and over again, and Glimmer hates her.

Glimmer hates Catra, because how dare she? How fucking dare she? She did not lose a mother, her mother didn't even love her to begin with.

How dare she, to wrap her body around Adora´s and seek for her warmth? Adora should be embracing Glimmer, not Catra, not her. It's not fair.

Bow´s arms wrap around Glimmer´s shoulders and bring her close, reassuring her. Absently, Glimmer is aware that he is trying to do the exact same thing Adora is doing but she can´t even feel him.

She cannot tear her eyes away from them. She cannot look at her dead mother with her pink hair colored red and she cannot look away from Adora´s lips resting over Catra´s freckled face

It´s not fair.

Scorpia comes running back, bursting through the door and soaked from head to toe. Detective Lashor and Huntara are running behind her, just as soaked by the rain too, followed tight

behind by Entrapta, who is holding their shoulder and wincing in pain.

Scorpia´s eyes run through all of her friends´ 's faces and then finally down, following the trail of fresh blood pooling on the floor. She gasps when she lays eyes on the scene, bending in half with a gag, unable to contain the pull of her stomach. There are little pieces of flesh and bone all around the floor, scattered after the fall.

"What the fuck happened?!" Lashor screams, fumbling with his belt as he tries and fails to take out his gun without dropping it.

Huntara looks up, pale too and shaken up, narrowing her eyes at the tall levels of the building and the spiral stair until she sees something moving from the fifth one, hovering above them all like a shadow.

"There!" Huntara screams, wrapping her hand over the handle of her own gun.

The killer looms over the stop of the stairs, looking down at the blood scene below with morbid attention. Its face cannot be seen by the crimson mask and black clothes, the robe gone, but for a second Glimmer thinks it is smiling, disappearing back into the shadows of the building. The knife tethers off the rail of the staircase and falls down towards the floor, following the same path Angella had done with her fall and clanking in the tiles like a broken bell.

Huntara and Lashor rush upstairs, screaming orders for backup and ambulance on their radios and then screaming at each other. It will be in vain, anyway, the heavy doors of the emergency stairs open and close and the killer is gone, ending this horrid now with a swirl and a smile.

Bow kneels to close Angella´s eyelids with trembling hands, his fingertips soaking with the blood coming from her nose and mouth, misted eyes bearing themselves forever inside Glimmer´s

own eyes. They will follow her every single day for the rest of her life.

On the floor Angella lays dead, soaked in blood. Entrapta and Scorpia hold onto each other, falling heavily against the wall, crying silently. Bow kneels on the floor and covers his face with his palm, his eyes hidden from Glimmer so she doesn't see him cry.

Glimmer looks at the copper elevator and Adora kisses Catra on the bloodstained floor. There are words written in blood on the skin between Catra's shoulder blades. A morbid message, for Adora.

*A gift, your heart.*

It has let her live and it has taken Glimmer´s mother instead.

It doesn't stop raining outside.

---

*End of Chapter IV*

*End of Part II*

Chapter End Notes

> God, is brutal out here *nervous chuckling* maybe someone should start praying to someone now ehehe
> I had that last scene written for six months, just waiting. I can´t believe is finally seeing the light of the day. Also I´m sorry to everyone that liked Sea Hawk, he shouldn´t have gotten in between the hunter and its prey :3
>
> See? I told you it wasn´t Catra. Leave my girls alone now (lovingly)
>
> As our schedule was a little bit moved by AO3, I´ll see you all until wednesday for Interlude II!

I can´t wait to read your new theories now.
Love y´all, be good!

# Interlude II

Chapter Summary

"I hate you"

Chapter Notes

Dear goddess of the forest, protect y'all
Today you take another look to the past, months ago on that fateful New Year's evening

Did I cry? Maybe. We are officially over half way there and there is still a lot of information to come in future chapters!!

But today, angst! I promise next chapter will have the long awaited and promised fluff. See you downstairs!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

**[Interlude II]**

**New Year, almost a year ago**

---

*"Are you crazy?"*

*Catra is sitting over Adora´s vanity, her feet against the seat of the chair, back leaned over the mirror and arms crossed. Her hair curls just below her breast bone, slightly damp by the shower and dark. They lose themselves among the black of her shirt, bouncing over her exposed neck and collarbones softly.*

*The room is as always spotless, a familiar discipline considering who it belongs to, and even Catra cannot help but to wrinkle her nose at it; the tall walls of white, the white furniture, the gray carpet, the perfectly placed shirts and pants and dresses.*

*The only splash of color that truly lives here is the bed, with sheets of dark blue and the coral pillows, but even that it is perfectly tended and made.*

*It doesn't even look like, just an hour ago, Catra was panting against those very same pillows. Her face nuzzled on the feathered material and her nails digging holes on the perfect navy blue sheets, wrinkled and pulled asides all around them. The mattress dipping and shaking with every thrust of Adora´s hips as she took Catra´s intimacy like it was the very first time all over again, worshiping her virginity and resting her lips over Catra´s neck into a kiss.*

*Right now though they are not making love, Adora is walking in and around the room cleaning the traces of them and Catra is angry.*

*"Adora, this is not what you wanted. You told me this is not what you wanted"*

*"I know but–" Adora wrinkles her nose, throwing her sweaty clothes into the rack without even looking. Her hair is perfectly brushed back into her immaculate ponytail, pulling from the baby hairs of her temples. "Listen, I've been thinking about what Light Hope said and she is right about some things. The medicine program could bring me a lot of good opportunities for the future."*

*"But you don´t want to study Medicine like fucking Light Hope. You want to study Literature, like your mom," Catra pressures, digging her nails into her upper arms.*

*Adora sighs, scratching her eyebrow. She is still not looking at Catra, eyes casted to every side and lips pressed into a line. "Well, I changed my opinion"*

*"It's not something that just occurred to you a month ago, you´ve been telling me this since you were ten." Catra bites into her tongue, holding back the need to grab Adora and make her look*

*at her instead of at the floor. "Your classes are oriented to literature, you even choose your second year propaedeutic schedule based on it."*

*Adora makes a strange noise with her throat, looking sharply through the window. Dread falls over Catra´s body, locking her in place.*

*"You choose your schedule for literature, right?" she asks, furious at the way her voice comes shaky and unsure.*

*She hates feeling unsure, she hates feeling like she is walking at the edge of a tightrope. It's been a long time since the last time she felt like this with Adora, which makes all even worse.*

*Adora sighs, pinching the bridge of her nose with her fingertips. "All the top colleges have made me offers, Catra. The First Ones Academy gave me a full scholarship already. They are ready for me as soon as I finish the courses for this year. They– they're even allowing me to skip and get in this January"*

*"But you don't want that," Catra says, completely unsure, completely lost. She searches for Adora´s blue gaze but cannot find it, avoiding her like something undesirable and not loved. "Do you?"*

*"I–" Adora starts but can´t finish, exhaling deeply. She runs her fingers down the ponytail, smoothing imperfect strands back down, her eyes miles away and her eyebrows knitted together.*

*Oh*

*Catra´s heart is breaking, in ways and for reasons she didn't think it would ever break. By the only hands that she trusted would never drop her heart against the floor.*

*Catra takes a shuddering breath, standing from the vanity and into the floor once again. Her feet are very cold as are her hands and cheeks, blood slowing its run across her heart and past her body. She was so warm before but now she is just cold, sipping*

*inside the marrow of her bones. Catra hates feeling cold, it feels like dying, it feels like being alone.*

*"I thought we were going to go to Horde together," Catra whispers, biting into the tender flesh of her bottom lip.*

*She wishes she could sound furious instead of so fucking sad but she cannot help it, the sting of betrayal slicing her soul open. Adora´s eyes finally snap towards her, recognizing the tone immediately. She goes pale, urgency falling over her factions as she searches for Catra´s face with her stormy blue eyes.*

*"Cat, please." Adora pleads, resting her fingertips over Catra´s jawline.*

*She wants to caress her, to hold her close, but Catra is holding herself so tight right now, staring back at Adora heavily. And Adora, truly, really, doesn´t know what else to say. Doesn´t know how else to make her understand that what she is choosing right now is not her choice, that it burns, that is killing Adora slowly and painfully on the inside, that she is selling her soul to the fucking devil.*

*That Adora is a coward and doesn´t have the guts to say no. Not her choice, never her choice, it rarely is, but that she can still make something good out of it. She cannot let Catra know how bad it hurts because then Catra would never let her take this path.*

*In a way it's a curse, being known so deeply and sweetly by the person she loves the most.*

*Adora wheezes, out of breath and out of words, dropping her hands back at her sides and away from Catra´s skin.*

*"Can we please talk about this after the holidays?"*

*"We've been talking about Horde since we were seven," Catra continues, unable to say anything else above the pressure*

*growing inside her chest. Adora winces at the betrayed sound in her voice, closing her hands into fists.*

*"I know, I just–" Adora lets her head roll back, staring at the white ceiling of the room.*

*She had stars painted on her childhood home, now everything is plain white and soulless, a crystal castle she cannot escape from. The reliquary shimmers golden around Adora´s neck below the light of the midday.*

*What else can she say to Catra? That she has to do this not because it's only convenient but because it is the best thing for the kind of person Adora is? That Hope told her over and over and over again how little would she accomplish studying what she really wanted, taking the life she craved until Adora was dizzy and afraid?*

*That Adora itches? On her back and arms as if Catra hadn't seen it before? That Adora compromised with Light Hope to be the best and choose the best when the latter allowed Adora to live in her house after she was left to fence on her own?*

*That Adora is terrified to become Mara? A person that she loved and she admired and that in the end was nothing and did nothing. That turned around and left like nothing, a person that was supposed to take care of Adora and that abandoned her.*

*Ideas planted inside her mind by Light Hope´s hands and nurtured with grudge, festering Adora´s crave for freedom and her heart. Rotting her to the bone, manipulating her, twisting her, convincing her to follow her steps.*

*How can Adora explain Catra that? How can she convince her to let go of the dreams they had when they were children and they knew nothing of the world, when Catra holds herself to those very same dreams like a lifeline?*

*"Listen, this can be good. It can," Adora insists, mustering a tiny smile. "I can become so much with this."*

*Catra is not smiling, not at all, staring at Adora´s face like she didn´t recognize her at all.*

*“Horde and the First Ones are in entirely separated places from the city.”*

*Further, actually. You would need two separated trains to meet, from the treacherous terrains of the Fright Zone to the polished floors and tall skyscrapers of Eternia City. Adora whimpers, slightly frantic.*

*“We can still see each other every time we can.” Adora says, desperately. She doesn't know who she is trying to convince more, Catra or herself. “And we can call each other all the time”*

*Catra stares at her in silence for a few seconds, mouth closed. She is so beautiful, so absolutely beautiful for Adora and for everyone else. She still smells a little like the incense from the chapel on the morning´s mass, singing nightingale like with the choir. She is all sharp edges and heart bursting with sweetness, freckles like stars and cheeks rosy from Adora loving her on their shared bed. Her eyes shimmer with unfiltered emotions, even as they are angry, furious, swimming inside the hazel and the turquoise. Precious.*

*“You're doing it again,” Catra spats, taking a step back. Away from Adora.*

*Adora tenses, all of her nerve endings shivering. “Catra”*

*“You're putting everyone else above yourself. You're letting them step all over you and sacrifice what you want for some stupid dream Light Hope has for you,”*

*Catra clenches her teeth so hard that it is audible inside the otherwise quiet room. Adora feels a rush of adrenaline run down her spine too, firing up all the flame inside her chest.*

*“My parents–”*

*“Why do you insist on acting like you were stupid?”*

*The room goes frightfully quiet, drowned in a single second of tension. Catra exhales, wrinkling her nose; her face is red and her eyes are damp with unshed tears, shame and guilt already rotting in the back of her throat, filling her with self hatred and anger. She hates speaking like this to Adora, she hates being this person, this person that is rotten and has been rotten for a long time, crumbling all the good things that live between them like sand castles. She hates herself.*

*Adora gapes and recoils, staring at Catra´s beautiful and furious face. She closes her hands into fists and curls around her own body, breathing hard. Still, she is not saying anything, looking at Catra waiting. It is an opening, for an apology, to step back before things go further to hell than they already are.*

*‘All you do is ruin things’ Weaver's voice echoes inside Catra's brain, covering it all in darkness. Words her mother has said over and over again to Catra, at home or in public or inside the chapel, until she finally ended up believing them. Until they push her on the person she is today, the one that cannot believe good things can belong to her and that is ripped off them when she tries to hold on.*

*Catra has never been good at keeping good things in her life, and Adora's is the best thing in her life.*

*“Catra.” Adora whispers, between an exhale and a plea, holding her breath. Catra gasps too, grasping the front of her own tank top tightly.*

*“You always do this!” Catra exclaims, unable to keep the poison inside her chest, pouring between them.*

*Only now she has realized what Adora is wearing. The white shirt, the perfectly tailored dress pants to match, golden sandals and perfect hair. Nothing like the clothes she really likes to wear, comfortable jeans and tank tops and sneakers smeared with mud.*

*A projection, a fake show of someone perfect that Adora is not. It makes Catra's blood boil.*

*"You did it in high school with those idiots, playing make up and princesses even though it was burning you from the inside out. And you are doing it now, playing Light Hope´s stupid puppet again and again and again!"*

*"Catra," Adora repeats and this time is lower, without the softness with which she always says Catra's name. A hard edge, a warning. She has never said her name like this. Catra doesn't listen.*

*"What are you going to do when Light Hope tells you to move into the big city forever? What are you going to do when she makes you work at her hospital under her rules?" Catra is panting now, her heart on her throat, her gums filling with venom. "What are you going to do when she tells you to fuck someone else? Are you going to do that too?"*

*Adora physically recoils, her back tensing. There is venom on her bloodstream too, born from her own heart. It´s acid and it burns, it itches under her skin, all of this wrong directed fury boiling to the surface, threatening to destroy and break and hurt too. She cannot even hear the hurt and fear in Catra´s voice, drowned up by Light Hope´s voice, too distracted by her own fear.*

*"Stop"*

*"When are you going to grow some back bone and stop people a fucking people pleaser?!"*

*"Catra, enough!" Adora screams. She has never screamed at Catra before. Her hands wrap around the reliquary, tugging from the precarious golden chain, straining the delicate links. Now Adora is furious too. "You do not get to talk to me like that. You do not get to come here and lay in my bed and call me stupid or scream at me or being fucking paranoid for nothing!"*

*Catra stumbles back, clearly shaken off. This is the first time Adora´s voice has made her shrink, even during the months they*

*were strained in high school. This is the first time Catra has well and truly shut up with shock, her teeth clicking painfully together.This is the first time Catra believes that they might end up breaking each other and this, wholly.*

*Her whole body stiffens, defensive and scared all at the same time. She might break them in the end but she cannot let Adora go without getting this in her head first.*

*"I don't? I don't get to tell you when you are being fucking stupid?"*

*Adora is far beyond understanding. Her cheeks are red with anger and there is a light sweat in her forehead, breaking the perfect picture. Good, Catra thinks, maybe she is still there after all.*

*"No, you don't. You don't get to step over my decisions or what I think it's important or best for me. I know what is best for me"*

*It hurts. It feels like Adora´s words mean so much beyond just the school or the career or Light Hope. Catra is afraid.*

*"This is not the best! This is what Light Hope wants!"*

*"Light Hope has a plan and it's a good one, it's logical."*

*"She hurts you!"*

*"And?!"*

*Adora straightens her back, chin pointed upwards, looking at Catra below her eyelashes. Cold, far away from her. For a second there she doesn't even look like Adora at all, but as some sick doll Light Hope has molded and twisted since she was a teen.*

*"I could do so much from it. I saw it in the end, why can't you? You could just– you could just go with me!"*

*"I'm not going to go there," Catra runs her nails through her hair, pulling from her curls angrily. Her back is straight too, holding*

*herself unbreakable in front of Adora. "The First Ones will never accept me, you know that. I don't have the money or the connections"*

*It would be easier for Catra to be angrier if Adora didn't suddenly become so desperately hopeful, so sickeningly pleading.*

*"You could. If you just worked harder–"*

*"No, Adora," Catra chews the words out, not even flinching when Adora´s face falls.*

*Catra takes a step forward, raising her hand. She wants nothing more than to snap the fucking tie that keeps Adora´s hair held together, to run her fingertips across her face in a caress and brush the golden strands behind her ear. Instead Catra presses the pad of her finger against Adora´s chest, right in the middle of her breast bone, talking to her strained and angry.*

*"You are making a mistake"*

*Adora clicks her teeth together, eyes darkening. Her hand wraps around Catra´s wrist and pulls it down, away from her, letting go of her as if it burned her.*

*"I know change scares you but you don't get to do this. You don't get to treat me like this just because you don't know what to do with your life yet. Me going to the Academy is not the end of the world. You are freaking out on me for stuff we can work out."*

*"I want to live my life with you," Catra says and it shuts Adora right back off, wheezing with pain.*

*Catra closes her eyes for a second, inhaling deeply, feeling the words festering and saying them all the same.*

*"It's not about working it out or not, Adora. It´s not about seeing you on the weekend or in the free day of your fucking life that you can spare for me. It's not about you not putting me first, never. It's about you. It's about sacrificing yourself and everything over*

*and over again. It's about* you *choosing everything about yourself. About you letting yourself be used and manipulated. I´m sick of it! I'm sick of the person you are pretending to be!"*

*Adora is on edge. She has been on edge since Light Hope told her she had no choice but to accept the First One´s. She has been on edge since Mara left, since her parents and Adam died, since she was charged with fate and expectations and not love. Adora is on edge and the edge is sharp and it cuts Catra.*

*"Well then maybe I'll just go to the Academy just so I won't have to hear you whining and whining anymore! I don't belong to you and you don't get to decide what I want, Catra! Who the fuck do you think you are?!"*

*Catra is poisoned by her mother. Adora is poisoned by Light Hope. They poison their love together.*

*The golden chain of the reliquary snaps under Adora´s fingers and crumbles into the floor, spilling open, face down. Catra gasps, pained. She receives the blow as if Adora has physically struck her, as if she had grabbed a sword from the bare air and stabbed it across Catra´s heart. Backstabber, betrayed, forsaken.*

*Adora´s jaw goes slack, her eyes widening, her body trembling. Her own words start to make sense for her, crossing the barriers she had raised around herself, the ones keeping her true self drowned and chained to her soul. Horror washes over her, ears ringing, her heart squeezing down painfully, words echoing inside her brain and drenching her heart.*

*"Fuck," Adora whispers, pressing her palms against her mouth. "Fuck, no. No, no. Catra–"*

*"Nobody," Catra has never looked at Adora like this. Blank, eyes void, miles away, she is hearing the same words repeated again and again inside her mind. There are tears gathering in her eyelashes and falling against her cheeks like rain. "I'm nobody"*

*“No. No, no, no. I didn't mean it like that. I’m sorry. Baby, I'm so sorry.”*

*Desperation starts eating Adora alive. Guilt and regret and anger, so much anger, at the world, at her life, at herself.*

*“I didn't mean it like that. I didn't mean it at all.” Adora tries to explain but even for her it doesn't sound like enough. Catra is still looking at her, with her sad, sad eyes and her tears and her pretty face and her overwhelming silence. Adora whimpers, extending her hand towards her face, desperate to caress her skin and cradle her close. “Catra–”*

*“Stop,” Catra speaks the safe word clearly, blinking slowly. Adora stops immediately, mouth ajar with horror and shock. “Don't touch me, Adora”*

*Adora´s mouth opens and closes several times, breath and words tangled on her lungs. She retracts her hand against her chest, missing the warmth of Catra´s skin, missing the weight of the reliquary against her breast. But she won't touch her, not if Catra does not want her to.*

*Catra looks at her in silence, drowning inside, splintering in pieces, unsure and hurt. She looks at Adora as she takes a new breath and tries to speak again, her sweet voice threatening to break down too. They are so close to breaking right now, Catra cannot endure it.*

*“Don't speak, just–” Catra rushes, whispering carefully the words but firmly. “Don´t”*

*She can see clearly how they choke Adora, how it makes her unsure and confused and afraid. She blinks once, twice, blue eyes blurry and spilling down in tears, unable to hold them back anymore. They smudge the white and gold make up in her eyes. Catra shrinks into herself too, making her wince.*

*“Okay, okay.” Catra says, almost to herself. She brings her hands to her face and breathes against her fingers. She smells like Adora*

*´s lavender shampoo and every single second in silence hurts them both. "We are fucking up, we are fucking this up again"*

*"Catra–" Adora tries, a knot straining her voice, clogging her throat. She looks seconds away from breaking down and Catra looks and feels like that too. They have made a mess of each other and they cannot bear to tear the other apart anymore than they have already done.*

*"Listen, let's just rest for a second." Catra says, tilting her head to the side, her hands falling sad and limp against her sides. "I´m– Adora, I´m hurting you. And you are hurting me."*

*Adora whines and cries, shaking her head softly. Catra tries to smile reassuringly at her but she can´t, her cheeks trembling and hurting just from trying to.*

*Instead, Catra bends down and picks up the reliquary, caressing the cold metal with her thumb. She straightens up and stretches her hand, very carefully taking Adora´s wrist between her fingers. Catra uncurls Adora´s hand carefully from the fist it has closed into, caressing the length of her fingers to chase the ache away. Then she places the broken necklace against her palm, closing her fingers again and stepping back.*

*"I'll see you at five, okay?" Catra says, straining her voice to sound hopeful, to sound softer.*

*They have plans today, Adora is to pick up Catra from Weaver's house at five on point and they are going camping in the forest and the mountains they so much love. It´s a ´them´ thing, it´s an opening, to heal what they have broken today.*

*"I´ll see you at five and we can talk about it again in the cabin. We´ll figure it out, so don't be late, okay? I know you´ve never been late to anything in your life, so don't start now," Catra half heartedly jokes, choking around a wet giggle.*

*She looks up at Adora´s eyes, hoping to find a glimpse of relief or of eagerness even, tenderness and hope to fix this, just like Catra*

*feels. They have always been so attuned to each other. But when Catra meets her eyes Adora just looks conflicted, sad and absolutely fucking conflicted, pulled apart from the inside out.*

*"Adora?"*

*"I–" Adora wets her bottom lip, sniffling. "Light Hope and the Brights organized a dinner to celebrate today and I–"*

*All the warmth that it had trying to bloom again inside Catra´s chest dies again, frozen, cold and still like a thorn without a rose. She shakes herself completely away from Adora, chuckling hysterically, throwing her head back and barking a strained laugh.*

*"Of course," Catra exhales, narrowing her eyes.*

*Adora looks heartbroken, holding the necklace against her chest. Newfound anger starts to slip down Catra´s bones, tinted with betrayal like black ink against white snow. She starts making her way towards the door, avoiding touching Adora at all costs.*

*"I don't even know why you want me here if you have already made your choice"*

*Adora wheezes, wrinkling her nose, trying to keep the tears at bay so she can talk. "That's not fair"*

*Catra turns around abruptly, eyes blazing and heart bleeding.*

*"You know what's not fair? What's not fair is that you are half of me. What's not fair is that I've loved you my entire life, Adora, and I'll love you until I'm dead," Catra gasps, clenching her teeth and holding herself to her own heart. "And even after everything, even after you promised, I still only get to have a small fraction of your love. I am only a small fraction of your love."*

*Adora flinches, feeling the pain in her body like an open wound.*

*"Catra, please," she begs, pressing her palms against her chest, "I need you"*

*Catra hesitates on the door, her hand shivering violently over the doorknob. She waits for a second, just one, very quiet and still. If Adora comes to her, she will stay, she knows she will. But the second stretches into a minute and Adora doesn´t come. Catra chuckles sadly, shaking her head.*

*"No, you don´t," she whispers, closing her eyes. "You never have"*

*"Catra–"*

*"Just–" Catra shakes her head, looking away from Adora´s beautiful eyes. "Happy fucking New Year"*

*The door of Adora´s room slams shut so hard that tiny pieces of the wall´s paint come crumbling down.*

*Catra makes her way out of the manor through the stairs and not through the window like always, like a thief, like a poet, like a secret. Catra doesn´t stop to look back and Adora doesn´t follow behind.*

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*Catra is flat over her thin mattress, staring at the black ceiling of her room. Or as much as a room the attic of the old house can be. At least it is not raining anymore, because it sucks major ass to have several buckets catching the rain from the holes of the roof and Catra always wakes up cold and bone aching in the morning.*

*Her phone is over her chest, screen down, gripped between her fingers and the fabric of her shirt but she doesn´t dare to look at it right now. She has spent three hours fighting herself and the godforsaken thing, writing messages and deleting them completely right before sending them. From long apologies that you would probably never believe they pour out of Catra´s fingers and mouth to curses even, flipping off, to apologies again. The whole thing is deeply messed up.*

*Catra wrinkles her nose at the darkness and groans, kicking her legs against nothing. She kind of wants to slap herself in the face and wants to throw herself off the roof, anger and frustration and*

*sadness doing a mess out of her. Her eyeliner is all smudged and there are deep black marks on her cheeks from where her mascara gave up against the tears and decided to melt off too.*

*It´s four and a quarter in the evening, she should be getting ready to leave by now except that she doesn´t fucking have to because Adora made her decisions and in them there was no place for Catra.*

*Expect that, maybe just maybe, Adora didn´t think she had any other choice. Maybe, just maybe, Adora was just scared and following a path already placed for her because it was easier than confronting the fear of the unknown that lives inside of her.*

*What a coward, what an angel. Catra knows a lot about darkness. Who is to say that if she had been presented with the same opportunities she wouldn't have made the same decisions. They were two faces of the same coin, after all.*

*She wouldn't have forsaken Adora, though.*

*Deeply fucked off.*

*The cell phone rings once and remains quiet, then rings a second time, a silent signal that Catra knows well. One message is everyone else. One message, three seconds, second message is always Adora. Catra fights back the need to throw her phone through the round window of the attic and picks up her phone, turning the screen back on.*

***A || Come with me, please***

***A || You don´t have to stay there***

*Catra sighs at the tiny words on the screen, biting her tongue.*

***C || I have nowhere else to go***

***Seen a second ago, typing***

***A || This is Glimmer's address***

***A || Please come***

***C || Why would I? I wasn't invited***

***Seen, typing***

***A || I don´t  want you to come if you don't want to,***

***I don't want to pressure you more that I've done already***

***A || But I want you with me. And more than anything I want to be with you***

***A || I adore you***

*Catra´s breath shudders, staring at the bright screen. This is Adora and she knows she is genuine. She knows after so long, after so much shit has happened between them, that she really is trying to make Catra understand how much she cares about her and how much she respects her if Catra wants to step back. How much she honors her and the decisions she makes.*

*If it had been anybody else, she would think it might be a try to manipulate her, to confuse her and make her accept something she doesn´t want; something coated in fake sweetness and fake reassurance and fake sense of safety, only meant to be done to control her.*

*Catra´s eyes widen, realization falling over her. Isn´t that the same thing Light Hope is doing to Adora? Using her, controlling her, pulling the person she really is from the inside out?*

***A || I love you***

***A || You´re my best friend and the love of my life***

***A || And I´m a massive asshole***

*Catra chuckles, shaking her head, cleaning her tears.*

***C || A little bit, just a little bit of an asshole***

***C || I´m really fucking angry with you still***

***C || But I love you too***

***Seen, typing***

***A || I´m really sorry***

***A || I miss you***

*Gosh. Adora is being stupid but so is Catra. Catra doesn't want to live like this, she wants Adora no matter what.*

***C || I´m sorry too***

***Seen, 4:38 pm***

*Catra sighs and  stands up from her bed with a grunt, rolling her shoulders back. She approaches with soft feet the closet she has in the small room, opening it with a frown. She had a backpack already ready to go camping but she guesses that´s completely useless now.*

*Catra doesn´t own anything not even remotely ´fancy dinner´ like. Jeans and leggings and leather, comfortable shirts and tight tank tops. A few dresses maybe, but they are all slick and either way too casual or way too revealing for the occasion. She doesn´t want Angella Bright or fucking Light Hope to have a heart attack if she arrives with a leg slit and net tights.*

*There is also the chapel´s clothes, the ones Weaver forces her to wear on every mass. White and gray robes, swirling and heavy on her shoulders, green jewels sewn to her hair, standing like a crown jewel in front of the choir. The sweetest voice you'd ever hear, echoing on the high ceiling and stained windows, an angel pulled out of grace and held captive.*

*The only reason she has ever endured that torture has been because Adora is always there. In every mass, front row, middle seat, right next to Light Hope´s stone cold side. Her hands holding the choir´s lyrics and not looking at the paper at all but at Catra and Catra alone, with her storming blue eyes and her red lips, listening intently to the inflection of Catra´s voice ringing in everyone else's ears.*

*And because after, when the loud and heavy bells marked the end and the town and priest were too busy entertaining each other in mercy shows, Adora would take Catra away into the corners of the chapel´s bell and kiss her breathless against the colorful windows, a manifestation of devotion for everyone else to see if they were to look at the sky and not at their own feet.*

*Catra scoffs, ears burning red, pushing the robes aside with a grunt. She isn´t wearing that unless she is forced to. Singing might be her only escape, the thing she loves to do the most in her entire life, but she isn't wearing those prisoner clothes to go to another kind of pristine show.*

*Catra has a single pretty thing in the wardrobe that could be used right now. It's a lace tank top, sleeveless and with a sweetheart neck, of a maroon so deep that it looks like dry petals against her dark skin. It was Adora's once, resting in her chest and shoulders before Catra took it to bring her smell inside her own room and it has remained there since then. It reaches just below her belly button and leaves her collarbones and neck completely exposed but it and her trustworthy nice black jeans will have to suffice today.*

*Sometimes Catra wishes she could be different. More like Glimmer Bright. Prom Queen material, peach sweetheart, pink skirts and pearl necklaces. Tender, delicate. Pulled out of a royalty frame. Someone that looks good next to Adora´s white clothes and golden hair. Someone that doesn't ache to love.*

*Instead Catra is all thorns and black shadows. Raw, sore. Painful to touch.  Painful to hold. Volatile like a lightened firecracker and*

*disastrous through every single thing in her life. Sometimes she wishes she could be Glimmer Bright.*

*Catra fixes her dark makeup and her hair, frowns at herself in the mirror and walks downstairs at exactly 4:45pm. She is early even but she is too nervous to remain in the cramped attic for a second longer. She hasn´t heard the witch moving around the old house in a while so, with a little bit of luck, she might have passed out in her bedroom or just plainly left the house to go act all high and mighty with the people of the country club.*

*That's all Catra´s mother does, after all, wasting the money of Catra´s father in expenses luxuries, forsake Catra and get wasted. Until a few years ago, Catra was spiraling for the exact same path.*

*Catra tip toes down the stairs, peeking through the railing at the lower level. It´s a beautiful house, old fashioned, with old wood which smells remind Catra so much to the forest of the town that she loves. The exterior is painted dark black and the handles and all the little metal details are copper.*

*Once upon a time, there was wallpaper in every single room of the house, pretty looking, with flowers or little scribbles that would decorate the walls alongside the old pictures of the people that would have been Catra´s family if they hadn't passed away already. All on her father's side, grandparents, great grandparents, her father's brother. Family that would have loved her deeply.*

*Catra was happy here for a long time, she was the happiest she could have ever been as a child. Running up and down the stairs and playing on the greenhouse off her father's hand. Jumping up and down on the bed of her childhood room, the one with the only balcony that faced the daisies garden instead of the street. Curling around Adora´s side when she came to sleep over, Adora who was also young and also happy and weird and Catra´s, even there.*

*Now, however, after years have passed, the wallpaper has been torn down, replaced by plain and cold paint. The frames and pictures have been taken town and plainly thrown in the trash where not even Catra could dig far enough to rescue them, replaced by silver mirrors in every single wall, testimonies of narcissism and self proclaimed beauty.*

*Now the greenhouse is abandoned and the garden is dry, covered in weeds and dirt nobody ever cleans. Now the old house Catra loved is spotless clean by her own bleeding hands, thrown in her knees and hands and scrubbing every single crevice until her nose was burning by the quimics and her mother had enough of watching her bite back tears.*

*Catra won't break under her pressure, but sometimes she wishes she could throw herself off the balcony Weaver has made her own.*

*Catra reaches the end of the stairs with a silent sigh, relishing in the silence and her apparent victory of almost going off the house without being heard. Her phone is in her pocket and she has forgotten her wallet and her bag but it will do for now. She doesn't need them where she is going, unless the Bright´s want her to pay for her plates of food which wouldn't surprise her at all but it would make Adora mad.*

*The front door is almost in front of her, shut close and quiet, the light of the evening sun slipping through the glass. The kitchen is at her right, quiet and empty, with its yellow cabinets and yellow curtains and linoleum floors, the only place on the entire house that the witch couldn´t completely destroy to erase the traces of Catra´s father. Catra painted and decorated this kitchen with him and once the money ran out in expensive cars and even more expensive decorations, the kitchen was not as important to change as the rest.*

*The living room is at Catra´s left, walls red that always give Catra a headache and spotless white couches and feathered pillows, with the cabinet on the corner full of different kind of wines and*

*alcohols and the floor to ceiling tall mirror right in the front wall, reflecting everything happening in the kitchen and the stairs.*

*Catra can see herself reflected in the mirror, her clothes that barely manage to fit the glamor she is expected to achieve for the Brights and Light Hope, her heavy eyeliner and dark eyeshadow, her hair half up in a braid.*

*She can see herself and her own eyes as she takes on the whole living room and realizes she is not as alone as she thought she was before, as her eyes fall from the mirror to the white, white couch and meet the green eyes of her mother, looking back at her with a half grin in her mouth.*

*"Going somewhere?" Weaver asks, slick and low. She is thrown over the white couch, her legs over the armrest, her back against the pillows, swirling a huge and expensive glass filled to the brim with red wine.*

*Catra´s nerve endings stand on point immediately, her breath stopping in her throat. She knows she is completely capable of walking out of the door and away but if Weaver is in this kind of mood things can go pretty nasty for Catra, pretty soon.*

*She could ignore the witch and then the latter could beat her to a pulp. She has done it before, several times with the belt of her garnet dress until Catra´s arms, legs and back were marked with dark lines and she could not move several days after. She has done it before and for less than just ignoring her and Catra does not feel like leaving Adora hanging just because Weaver feels the need today of being a complete monster.*

*Honestly? Catra has much better things to do.*

*"I´m going out," Catra says between clenched teeth, looking at some point on the couch and definitely not at Weaver´s eyes. "I´ll leave you alone so you can do whatever you want."*

*"This is my house, Catrina, of course I can do whatever I want."*

*Actually, this is Catra´s house. Her father left it for her on the will. As if, even if he didn't know he would have such a tragic death, he was already preparing to protect Catra in any way he could. But it should have also never occurred to him that his wife would go absolutely fucking nuts after his death and become and absolute monster with their only child. Which is exactly why he left all the money and properties in her care until Catra reached the age, and by the time that moment came, Weaver had changed everything to her own name. Being the sister of a corrupt Mayor came in hand sometimes.*

*Catra had nothing from her father anymore, nothing but this house even if her name was not in the scriptures anymore. This house and the single picture she has of her father and herself when she was younger, saved carefully inside the reliquary Adora guards.*

*Catra sighs heavily, looking away. It is 4:50 pm already, she needs to leave now if she wants to reach the Bright Household in the next neighborhood in time. And she doesn´t own a car, or a motorcycle, not even a bicycle, so she has to do the travel on foot.*

*"I´m just going to leave, Sharon," Catra mutters between clenched teeth, giving a single step forward.*

*"And if I don´t want you to?" Weaver takes a long sip off her glass, humming. This is not the first time so by now Catra knows by heart the type of voice Weaver carries every time she is wasted to hell and back. Slow, slurry, way too alert to be good, disgustingly calm and sweet.*

*She sounds like that right now, like a storm about to slash the earth but still enjoying planting seeds of fear first.*

*"You are drunk," Catra spats, frowning at her. Weaver throws her head back and barks a laugh, her black hair spilling over the pillows like shadows.*

*“Am I now?”*

*“Yes. Drunk and pathetic.”*

*Weaver hums, looking at Catra from head to toe from the hem of her glass. She huffs a giggle at Catra´s clothes and her face, grinning full of hatred.*

*“Look who's talking”*

*Catra bites back the need to step back, to flinch and recoil in herself. She knows Weaver is targeting all of her weak points just with those words. All the tender spots inside Catra´s soul that will never really get to heal completely. Her looks, the way she sees herself, the way she loves or hates herself. Her body, her face, her hair, her  voice even. Her mistakes.*

*Weaver has never let her forget that she destroyed the fucking sports car in the quarry, not even years after, not even after she beated her so hard after the police dropped her in the house that Adora had to come to the house days after and drag her to the hospital herself. And she probably won´t let her forget it until the day she dies.*

*Catra is not the same person she was then, though. She is better, slightly, but better. She survived.*

*“I haven't drank in three years.” Catra says, back straight, her chin held high.*

*She finds a way to feel stronger than Weaver, better, taller, greater. She is not the one that is drunk out her wits, she is not the one alone on the couch of a soulless house. She has grown, she is smarter, she is loved, even if Adora and her might part ways, she knows Adora loves her. She is loved, it helps her live.*

*“Find something else to use against me.”*

*“You're going with Adora, aren't you?” Weaver cuts her in, tethering Catra´s heart. The way Weaver says it, it is full of*

*hatred. "You little whore."*

*Catra takes a sharp breath, her eyes fluttering close for a second. Weaver seizes the opportunity to dig the knife further and she takes it, chuckling the entire time as she sits straighter in the cough.*

*"Adora should have been my daughter, did you know that?" Weaver says, voice sultry, words tripping with each other, messing with Catra´s head and with her heart. "She is beautiful, she is smart. Valedictorian of her generation, an athlete, a diplomat."*

*Catra feels her heartbeat on her temples, hears the rush of blood inside her ears, bloodstream boiling hot and hurting every place in her body. Today has been a horrible day, a bad day that started with mass and ended here, in the middle of the red and white living room with her intoxicated mother and her wine and her words like knives themselves.*

*"How did you do it? How did you convince her into your ways?" Weaver leans forwards into the seat, narrowing her eyes at Catra. Catra has not her eyes, not a single trace of green in them. Instead she has her father's eyes and her grandmother´s, shared on her face like gifts. Catra knows Weaver hates her for it. "How did you seduce her into your bed? Between your legs?"*

*Catra recoils, a hiss making it past her lips. Weaver might say a lot of things, she might diminish Catra until the impossible, punish her, beat her, torture her, manipulate her, poison her. But this is too much.*

*This is humiliating. Her intimacy with Adora, in any way or form, is theirs and theirs alone, Weaver trying to poison it too makes her want to scream.*

*"Damn. You are sick." Catra spats, breathing hard. Her hands close in fists at her sides, nails digging painfully in the tender skin of her palms. "Adora is so perfect, isn't she? She can make her decisions alone."*

*She decided she wanted me, she wants to say but she doesn´t. Because if Weaver realizes how much it hurts and disgusts her trying to plant a seed of hatred on her love with Adora, she will never stop doing it. Because, in a way, Catra is still afraid she might not be enough for Adora to stay with her.*

*For a minute in the morning, when Catra was on Adora´s bed and Adora´s mouth was in her breastbone, whispering love against her skin, she thought nothing bad could happen to them ever again, not with Adora next to her. But she has always been just that in Adora´s life, a whisper among golden halls, a thread of a voice on a royal life she is taking. And as much as they love each other, in a way Weaver is right. There will always be more important things for Adora than her.*

*"She is everything you could never be in a million years. She could have been mine, if Randor had married me." Weaver chuckles, running her hand through her raven black hair, pushing it back long and straight and off her eyes. Her eyes dig in Catra´s, blazing hot, meant to kill. "Instead I'm stuck with you, you who are nothing."*

*´Who the fuck do you think you are, Catra?´ Adora´s voice echoes inside her mind and Catra has to make a real effort not to break down and cry.*

*She knows she didn´t really mean them but it still aches like a rotten rosemary branch across her heart. She knows Adora really didn´t mean them but it is almost five in the evening and she is not here. She didn´t mean it but what if she did?*

*Catra´s own mother has made her personal mission to destroy Catra in every single way possible, why wouldn´t Adora who is what Catra loves the most on this world, do the same in the end?*

*Catra exhales, wet in the edges, tears that she refuses to spill smudging the corner of her eyes into black. The eyeliner slips inside her eyelids and stains her scleras in black, running in a single line down her cheekbone like a traitor.*

*“Why don't you love me, mom?” Catra asks, she cannot help herself.*

*She cannot help how stupid she feels asking her this, after everything she has done to her, after everything. After all the years of humiliation and of pain; after using her and hurting her in front of people that was supposed to nurture her and to cherish her and that never did anything to stop it.*

*Catra asks because she needs to know, she needs to know what she did wrong to be treated like this for the person that is supposed to give you her love.*

*Weaver snaps her head back and laughs, fully, all sharp white teeth against red, red lips and green eyes. It tears on the cords of Catra´s heart.*

*“Love you? I didn't even want to have you.” Weaver drowns the last of the wine with a heavy gulp, her neck moving up and down as the alcohol burns on her throat. “But your father, oh your father. He was so happy to have a little brat. And he gave me everything in return. Money, this house, cars. Love.”*

*Weaver shakes her head, looking through the window. It´s a quiet day, most of the town are inside their own homes, celebrating with their families and eating, embracing each other, talking with each other, loving each other.*

*This is not Weaver´s first glass of wine. Hell, this isn´t even her first bottle; there are empty wines rolled over the expensive carpet of real fur, staining it in red.*

*“He was so stupid, so good. But we do the best of what we have and I couldn’t have Randor Montenegro anymore. He had gone off and married that slut. So your father had to suffice and for a time it was enough,” Weaver drags her eyes back to Catra´s, digging in her irises. “Until you made him get killed”*

*“I was a child,” Catra gasps, furiously wiping the tears off her cheeks. “I was sick and a child. He came home earlier to see me*

*because you were out drinking in the town." Catra points at the empty bottles, the glass in Weaver´s hands, the poison red colored in her lips. "It was raining, the trolley lost control, the bridge broke. It was not my fault."*

*"And yet he left you all the same."*

*How cruel, this is supposed to be her mother. How cruel.*

*Catra cradles her face inside her own palms and sobs silently, screaming inside, breaking herself apart. She is trembling so violently that she feels like she might pass out if she dares to walk towards the door now. She hates this day, she hates this hour, this second, this life. She hates the old grandfather clock in the living room wall about to go off. Catra hates it all.*

*"I heard she is leaving you too." Catra freezes, her heart stops. "Light Hope has been announcing it to the chapel on every opportunity she has."*

*"You could never have reached the achievements Adora has, but even I believed for a second that she would stick around. I guess your pretty eyes and pretty voice weren´t enough for her in the end."*

*Weaver serves herself another round of wine, swirling it inside the glass. It´s a pretty glass, cutted, expensive, nice. Weaver leans back to see Catra's broken face.*

*"She doesn't love you, Catrina. She might have for a while but not like you have, never in the way you´ve loved her. And now she has finally come to senses and placed her future above your legs. You surely were fun and a good fuck, but she doesn't love you the same, and she doesn't love you enough to stay with you."*

*Catra marches towards her, steps heavy, hands closed. Catra isn´t even wearing shoes, why is she never wearing shoes?*

*Catra stops right in front of Weaver and leans down, face to face, nose to nose. They are nothing alike. Weaver is a shadow,*

*twisted, cold, unmoving, rotten in grudge. Catra is a nightingale, flying free under the sun of the new year, song and light and rebellion, things she doesn´t even see or know about herself. Things slipping through her fingers.*

*"You are such a fucking bitch," Catra says, letting grudges and anger fester her too. Weaver leans her head back to see her better and smiles at her, the plague moving fast.*

*"And yet you are so much more like me than you think." Weaver´s grape and rotten breath hits Catra in the face. "I wish you had died too."*

*Catra grabs the handle of the expensive wine, tears it from Weaver´s hand and slams it into the floor. It breaks in dozens of pieces, tiny ones, infinitesimal ones, quiet ones. Splitters and ragged and tiny and small and broken. And a larger one, a single larger one, the base of the round glass broken in the middle, a sharp stake made of a glass so fine that it almost looks like ice, dripping red drops of wine into the carpet and soaking on the wood floor.*

*Catra breaths hard, spitting the words right into Weaver´s face. This isn't her mother anymore, she never was, she has no mother at all.*

*"I hate you."*

*The grandfather clock trembles and plays. Five o´clock, on point.*

*Catra straightens up and turns around, following the wood path towards the door. She is not looking back anymore, she is not turning around a second time. Her eyes are fixated on the door and the copper handle and wanting to run. She is going, she is leaving, she might never return to her beloved home after this but Catra is done. She is done.*

*Weaver grasps her from the neck and slams her against the rail of the stairs, the metal crushing and trembling under the weight of Catra´s body.*

*Catra gasps, the air leaving her lungs, her ribcage pushing and pulling and squeezing painfully. Mind numbing and overwhelming pain overcomes her completely, hearing the horrid crunch of her own body when she falls against the polished wood floor. She has ribs broken, several of them, brushed, crushed, snapped and they hurt. They hurt so much and yet Catra cannot scream and talk, too shocked and scared to even whimper and whine.*

*Catra rolls on her belly, crawls on the ground. There are tears stuck on her eyelashes, there are tears on her eyes, on her face, on the floor. She is in pain and she cannot scream.*

*Weaver is chasing her, like a blood thirst demon, she is chasing her. Slow. Hunting. She bends down and holds Catra´s hair, picking her up from the floor with so little resistance that Catra chokes on her breath.*

*Surprise makes it for fear and anger and Catra struggles violently but Weaver drags her through the corridor past the closed front door and slams her face against the frame of the kitchen door with all the strength she has, which is surprisingly, a lot.*

*Catra falls back against the floor, between the wood and the linoleum of her yellow kitchen. There is blood on her face now too, mingling with her tears. It drips from her nose to her chin to her collarbones, staining Adora´s lace shirt in dark spots.*

*It´s a pity, it really is a nice shirt. It´s a pity, Catra could have been in the forest. It's a pity, Catra wanted to look pretty today.*

*Catra digs her nails on the frame of the kitchen and stands up on wobbly legs, holding her palm against her aching face. Her knee is trembling horribly, threatening to make her stumble down. She fell with her entire weight over it, bending it sickly. It is never going to be the same after this.*

*Catra turns around as best as she can, just in the right moment, just in time to see Sharon Weaver, her mother, scrambling with*

*the trunk placed near the foot of the stairs, throwing stuff all around until she finds what she is looking for.*

*A box, and inside the box, a gun. Black too, small too, polished and lethal. A sick gift from Weaver's brother that she had saved there for goddess knows how many years, waiting until it was trembling with the excitement of taking a life.*

*Catra chokes in her breath, fear pooling in her heart.*

*"No, no." She stutters, watching with wide eyes as Weaver fumbles with the safety of the gun, tripping with her own feet. She is drunk, she is so drunk and she is going to kill Catra. "No"*

*Catra doesn´t want to die.*

*She wants to live, live, live in this world even if this world doesn´t love her back. She wants to make it out of here, survive. She wants to meet Adora with the Brights, visit her on weekends at her pristine college, support her in what she choses no matter how much Catra misses her. Kiss her, hold her, marry her if she still wants her in the end.*

*Catra craves, Catra desires. She wants. A life for herself, a way to escape, to be free. She wants. She doesn't want to die.*

*"Ah!" Catra charges against Weaver before the latter can finish figuring out how to work out the damn thing.*

*Their bodies crash together, limbs against limbs and raven hair against oak one. They fall heavily into the floor, so hard that Catra bites her own mouth and breaks her bottom lip in two. So hard that Weaver wheezes and lets go of the gun, rolling a few inches away from them.*

*Weaver stretches her hand and digs her fingers against Catra´s side, crushing her already bruised and pained ribcage. Catra screams at the top of her lungs, the pain finally untangling from her vocal cords and making it past her mouth and lips, echoing inside the entire house and even outside, across the*

*neighborhood. Yet none of the neighbors in their pretty houses with their pretty families come out to help.*

*Catra presses her hand against Weaver´s face and rips down, her sharp black nails drawing bloodied lines across Weaver´s entire face, from the eyebrows, across the bridge of the nose and down the cheekbone. Shallow yet still painful, superficial yet they still draw blood. They are enough for Weaver to scream and flinch away. Enough for Catra to push her away and scramble on the floor, grabbing the handle of the gun with both hands.*

*Catra stands in front of the open kitchen, trembling from head to toe. Her knee is on fire, her face hurts, her chest aches with broken bones. Her hands shiver as she holds the gun in front of her, fingers aching with fear.*

*It's only been five minutes, a lot of things can happen in five minutes.*

*"Stop" Catra chokes, she pleads, crying so hard that her sight is shit. She can barely see past her nose, all the world drowned in black eyeliner and tears. "Stop. Mom, stop"*

*Weaver has stood up too, tethering in her feet. Her eyes are gone, iris blown out, completely insane, completely crazy. There is no thought or reasoning behind her green irises but hate and bloodthirst, something that had been festering for so long inside her already rotten body and soul and that has only now seen the light of the day. That had hated that very same light from the moment it touched her skin.*

*She approaches Catra slowly, her hands at her sides, barely seen among the skirt of her garnet dress. Catra grips the gun harder, trembling. Her father taught her to shoot when she was younger, when he used to take her to hunt into the forest near the graveyard and the chapel and Catra hated every single second of it until she was finally allowed to roam the woods in calmness. She never thought it would come to this in the end.*

*Her father taught her yet again another way so she could survive. She knows how to shoot, she is good at it and she doesn't want to. This is still her mother and inside of Catra, inside some weird, wretched and forgotten abyss of her heart and soul that still carries Weaver´s name, Catra has never stopped loving her.*

*"Mom, please." Catra begs, lowering the gun just an inch. "Please"*

*Weaver leans towards her, almost as if she were to embrace her and not to murder her, resting her free hand against Catra´s jaw and caressing a gentle line over her cheekbone. Catra shivers, her heart giving a jump, starved for her mother´s love. She doesn´t even see the large place of wine glass held in her mother's hand and hidden in the folds of her dress until it is too late.*

*Weaver raises her other hand, presses the glass against Catra's throat and swings it to the side, ragged, violent and deep. Catra gasps, pain flooding her body as she shoots twice, trembling but sharp, blood spilling on the ground. The world breaks, her heart crumbles down.*

*Catra is on her back.*

*There is something in Catra´s mouth. It fills her gums and gathers on the back of her throat, pulling her, poisoning her, choking her down. The floor is cold where she is lying, the linoleum hard against the base of her head and absently she thinks it is going to be a pain to try and clean it later.*

*There is something in Catra´s mouth and it tastes wrong. It tastes like salt and like rotten roses, a little bit like skin under the sun and a whole lot like sea water gathering in her teeth. Catra tries to speak around it, but she fails. She opens and closes her mouth and the taste lingers and she cannot breath.*

*She doesn't even realize it is her own blood until her ribcage squeezes down painfully and she wheezes, a gush of fresh blood making its way past her larynx and towards her nostrils, dripping down her face in rivulets of red.*

*She is bleeding, she is bleeding to death.*

*In a way, she always knew she was going to die young. Even from childhood, she knew this life was going to tear her apart. She just never thought it would be like this. She never even thought it would hurt this much, and it sucks. She hoped that, at least, it would have been painless, easier. But she has never been that lucky.*

*Her fingers twitch at her sides, nails digging in the slippery floor, wetter and wetter below her body as her own blood creates a coffin for her on the ground. Her hand aches, joints protesting where she curls her hand in a fist and absently Catra remembers that she was holding a gun and then that the gun went off several times. The powder´s smell still lingers in her palm, forever stitched to the back of her tongue and somewhere inside her chest she knows her mother is dead.*

*Catra opens her mouth and tries to talk. She does, she really does. She doesn't even try to yell, just to mutter something, anything at all that makes her realize that she is not actually dead. But when her lips part, sticky with blood and her chest wheezes with a shuddering breath, nothing comes out. Not a gasp, not an exhale, not a single trace of a voice echoing inside the cold floor of the cold kitchen. Nothing.*

*Catra has been left voiceless, not a word, not a song, nothing else. Her broken vocal cords lay dying in her own pharynx.*

*Something has changed, this Catra knows now.*

*Something has forever shifted inside of her, already rotten but now completely dead. She has been stolen of something, something in her heart defiled. Something has been broken into so many places she will never be able to put them back together, all of them torn apart little by little by so many hands, by so many accomplices, for so many times until she was lying like this on the floor, until her blood was soaking her yellow walls. Forever broken.*

*When she was seven, there was an animal in the woods near the chapel. Catra remembers it as well as she remembers the light of the sun in her face or the sounds of the hunt or the damp dew of the morning sticking on her cheeks. As well as she remembers the blood dripping off her hands when she held it against her chest. That was the first time Catra smelled blood.*

*The air smells like gunpowder, Catra´s fingers ache with the weight of the gun going off in her palm. The clock in the wall marks 5:06 pm*

*She misses Adora.*

*If Adora had been there to pick her up at five on point like they planned, maybe nothing would have happened. Maybe Catra´s blood wouldn't be soaking the ground. Maybe she would be dead too.*

*She hopes Adora is happy. She hopes she finds a new love and gets out of this time and lives her whole life happy. She hopes, every once in a while, Adora thinks of her when she hears a nightingale sing.*

*Catra gurgles around her own blood, opens her mouth until her jaw hurts and screams, a silent ring in the middle of blood, gunpowder and nothing.*

*Nobody hears her.*

—

***A || Cat, we are going camping,***

***I don´t give a fuck what Light Hope wants***

***A || There is nothing more important to me than you***

***A || I´m going for you right now***

***Not seen, 5:01 pm***

***End of Interlude II***

The fairest flower that e'er I saw

Has withered to a stalk

– *The Unquiet Grave*

Chapter End Notes

NOTE: On this fic we take virginity as a symbol of honor and worth and not as a first time having sexual intercourse. When it talks about worshiping virginity it's meant to talk about Adora honoring Catra and her body by being intimate together.

Someone commented this in the last chapter so I assure you that Weaver is 100% death! She did die! And she deserved it!

Thank you so much for sticking around on this crazy story. See y'all on Friday!

# Shepherd's Masquerade

Chapter Summary

"We are one"

Chapter Notes

FLUFF (ﾉ≧∇≦)ﾉ ミ┻━━┻

Hello hello, how are you doing? How are feeling after the last chapter and last Interlude? Very heavy chapters lately but we are getting some fluff finally.

But first, angst. Angst and fluff that's the deal.

We are so close to the end! Have you guessed who is the Unwanted Animal by now? Some of you have started to join the strands but no completely! Hopefully today will clarify a lot of stuff for all of you \ (◎o◎) /

WARNINGS FOR THIS CHAPTER
- Descriptions of death
- Descriptions of murder
- Angst, panic attacks, death aftermath
- Descriptions of sex (marked with ****)

Without much to say for now, I'll see you downstairs

See the end of the chapter for more notes

## Part III. Heart

## [Shepherd's Masquerade]

*You make the bed up silent on the floor, so no one will hear us*

*You try so loud to love me.*

*I cannot seem to hear*

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❀

## October 27th

The water of the shower falls like quiet rain, filling the small bathroom with fog. It is hot to the touch, almost too much but not enough to be unbearable, splashing against the beige mosaics and the floor of plain tile. It is all very impersonal-like and very clean, perfectly matching the smells of the hospital room just beyond the closed door. It's not very private either, with the sentinel toilet and mirror right in front of the shower, but it's empty right now and it is nice.

Adora turns around, wrapping her arms around Catra´s back and her waist, helping her inside the slippery square. Catra´s hair is completely matted in red, chunks of sweet curls sticking together one on the other and against Catra´s face, drying on her skin and pulling from the fine hair on her jaw.

The blood that had traveled from the side of her temple and down her face has long ago dried on her face but at least her forehead is clean, thankfully washed out by the nurses that stitched her skin together in the hospital room. But the rest of her skin and clothes are still completely covered in blood and that is on Adora to fix.

Adora is very careful, so careful that she is almost slow. She pulls the soiled shirt off Catra´s chest, careful to not disturb the five stitches in her love´s temples, throwing the cloth off their sight immediately. Then she kneels over the soaked floor, rolling down the hem of her pants and underwear and slipping them off together one leg at a time, making sure Catra balances herself as she rests her hands over Adora´s shoulders.

Adora is very gentle with her right leg, tenderly taking the fabric out and pushing it away too before lowering her sole back into the

ground, making sure she doesn't apply too much pressure over the bruised knee. Catra shouldn't even be standing on her feet right now, but she refused to sit on the chair the hospital handed them for this exact scenario, so Adora needs to be careful.

Adora stands up again and makes quick work of her own clothes before wrapping her arms around Catra´s body and pushing her softly backwards, letting the spray of the shower fall over both of them, gentle, warm and cleansing. Adora rests her big and scratched up palms over the small of Catra´s waist and the back of her neck, nuzzles her face against the angle of her own neck and lets her rest her entire weight over her chest, holding her safe and sound against her body as the water falls over them.

This is not the first time Adora does this, this is not the first time she cares for Catra like this. She helped her shower every single day after Weaver's incident and even months after, when the fear was too much and the feeling of the water falling raw against her face reminded her to choke with her own blood. Adora has done it before and she prayed to never have to do it again, but she will again and again for as long as Catra needs it. And for as long as her own heart needs it too.

The water washes away the blood, each other´s and Angella´s, falling across their bodies and swirling on the floor and down the drain. First it is heavy, crimson and thick, crumbling off their skins like clots or ribbons of red. Then it becomes thinner, and thinner and thinner until the water is completely transparent again. It might wash away the red and the smell but it can´t wash away the pain.

They´ve been in the hospital for hours, passing from room to room and enduring the heavy eyes of every single patient, familiar and medical personnel that caught wind of them walking through the pristine white corridors and rooms with their bloodstained clothes. None of the detectives that escorted them there even cared to try and protect their faces and identities, too busy barking orders and directions to each other with their radios to even pay attention.

Bow and Glimmer had been hurried to another room, followed by a myriad of doctors and nurses. It could be maybe because they were scared or worried for Glimmer, because she could and should have been screaming and throwing herself into the ground and crying and ripping her chest apart but instead she was so deadly quiet that the medics thought she would go completely catatonic and she could have a dangerous meltdown if she wasn´t vigilated. Bow, as always, had followed right behind, throwing a knowing stare towards Adora before disappearing behind the white door of the room.

Adora and Catra had been pushed into another room, closer to the x-ray section. Or more like the nurses had tried to place Adora in a different room to check on Adora´s wounds while Catra was getting scanned and Adora threatened to leave on her own foot if they didn´t let her be right outside the room while the doctor walked in. Adora knows she can be difficult when things don´t happen like she wants, but she can be an absolute nightmare when Catra is involved and the poor nurses had to face that.

"You need to let us medicate you," explained one of the nurses, resting her palms over her hips.

Adora shook her head, digging her nails on the plastic chair. She knew she looked terrifying, covered in her own blood and patched up with white gauze by the paramedics that long ago had soaked into red, against her shoulder and her ribs. She knew people were looking at her with strange faces and then with widened eyes when they caught wind of who she was but she couldn't care less about them.

"I don't need to," Adora repeated yet again, crossing her arms over her chest. The movement hurts like a bitch but she has long ago stopped bleeding so she is convinced she will be just fine while Catra is rolled out. The nurse doesn´t agree because she can barely suppress an exasperated groan.

"Miss Montenegro, you got stabbed. It's a miracle it didn't sever your artery but you still need to get that closed. If you don´t let

us medicate you we are going to have to stitch you completely awake and it is going to hurt.”

“I don´t care. I'm not risking falling asleep,” Adora clenched her teeth tightly, wrinkling her nose. “I´m staying with her”

“I assure you everything will be alright while Miss Capellan is checked up.”

“I said no.” Adora barks, making the poor nurse jump in surprise.

A pang of guilt tugs from Adora´s heart, her defenses slightly crumbling into the floor. She sighs, resting her head against the back of the chair, voice falling into a much softer and apologetic tone.

“Look, I understand that you want to help me and I'm being a giant pain in the ass instead. But I´m not staying away from her for a single second, alright? I'll stitch myself up if I need to but I ´m not moving from this chair”

“Fine,” The nurse throws her hands towards the air, rolling her eyes hard. “At least let us give you analgesics”

Adora hesitates for a second, the negative already sitting on her tongue. She doesn´t want to risk it but the wound does hurt a lot and the nurse is right in a way. She cannot take care of Catra like this. “Okay”

“Finally,” the nurse grumbles just as the door of the room opens again, the doctor walking outside.

Adora stands up in a rush, tethering to the side when she pulls from her side painfully. The doctor stares at her, surprised, her eyes wide as she takes on Adora´s blood-soiled clothes and her wounds still without treatment.

“Miss Montenegro, shouldn´t you be getting stitched up right now?”

“How´s Catra?” Adora cuts her off, shaking her head. The doctor makes a humming sound, wrinkling her nose.

“I can only give information to familiars of the patient–”

“Castaspella,” Adora cuts her in, her eyes frantic. “Please”

This is the same doctor that had treated Catra after Weaver. She was in the surgery room, she saw Adora in the waiting room covered in red and frightened. She stitched Catra´s throat back together, she was the one who told her she wouldn't sing ever again. She is Glimmer´s aunt, she just lost her sister in law and she knows Adora is, in more ways than one, the only family Catra has.

“No fractures but she pulled from that knee very badly. She needs to rest.” Castaspella says with a sigh. Her eyes are red and sad, rimmed in dark bags. “She´s got a concussion and she will need stitches too. But she won´t need to stay the night, neither I think Detective Huntara would allow it, she is putting you all in a security hotel.”

“Okay,” Adora absorbs the words, nodding to her and to herself. “Okay”

“She didn´t speak at all, either” Castaspella´s face shifts, her eyes always so professional, splintering and crumbling too. “Did she– did she see it?”

“I don´t know,” Adora laments, shaking her head. “I don´t know”

Castaspella nods, her sight wandering into a blank point of the wall. None of them had seen the body after the forensic department had arrived, covering Angella´s twisted body with a blanket that quickly soaked into red. But Adora knows she was brought to this hospital, the only one of the town unless you wanted to drive all the way to Eternia, and that she is in the basement right now. On the mortuary, being prodded and moved around as the morticians confirm that she effectively died of

having her skull crushed against the floor. That Angella Bright is, in fact, dead.

Castaspella knows it too and it shakes her to the core. She pushes herself awake by some new thought, making her eyes sparkle and set aflame again, returning her gaze to Adora´s eyes.

"I need to see Glimmer now. I trust you to take care of your Catra now."

"Of course."

"And Adora," Castaspella adds, pointing at her shoulder and bloodied shirt. "Don´t be difficult."

Adora smiles, a little bit hysteric, shaking her head from side to side. "I´ll try"

Adora can feel her own stitches under the warm water of the shower, washing her own blood away. Fifteen stitches over her side, not deep enough to worry anyone but just enough for her entire side to fire into pain with each movement. More stitches over her shoulder, closing the stab wound together and for that one the nurses tried to convince her to stay the night to check on her and were quickly shut down by Adora once again.

Being stabbed and stitched is not fun but Adora has had a good dosage of morphine and she endures it, shushing Catra from side to side gently under the shower. She helps her wash her hair off the sweat and blood and detangles de curls with her fingers, combing them softly as they reach the end of her waist. She can feel Catra´s long eyelashes fluttering against the skin of her good shoulder, her lips trembling and wet with the water and it takes Adora way too many seconds to catch up that she is openly sobbing, holding herself to Adora´s shoulder blades with all her strength.

"Cat," Adora whispers sadly, leaning back so she can see her face under the water. Catra´s eyes are completely bloodshot, the hazel

and the blue drowned in red as they look back at Adora, pupils shrunk and the corners raw from tears.

“She is dead,” Catra whispers, her voice broken and sad. “She is dead”

Adora´s face falls, her own eyes filling with tears at the heartbroken stare in her girlfriend's face. Her heart is breaking, all over again, it is breaking, splintering and ripping holes in her ribcage, bleeding inside her body and soul at the sight of Catra´s tears mingling with the bloodied water. Adora nods, as softly as she can, cradling Catra´s bruised cheek inside her palm, caressing a tender line across her cheekbone and down her shivering lips.

“I'm sorry,” Adora whispers back, unable to bite back her own tears. She tries to hold Catra steady, tight inside her palms, holding her before she breaks down too. “I'm so sorry, my love.”

Catra´s face is terrible, messed up and fraked up and still completely beautiful, blinking quickly, trying to keep her own tears at bay.

“I– I´m sorry, I´m sorry,” Catra pleads, choking on her own breath. Choking in her words even though it is not her fault that it had happened in the first place. Catra has never been guilty of anything, not even when the world tried to make her the monster, not even when everyone else thought otherwise.

“I tried, I really tried, but she wouldn't listen. She was– she was trying to protect Glimmer. She pushed me away and I couldn´t– I just couldn't reach her–” Catra chokes on her voice, biting into her mouth so hard that Adora flinches, rubbing her bottom lip with her thumb to reassure her, to not hurt herself more.

“I know you did, angel,” Adora says around a sob too, the walls of her heart tearing themselves apart at the sight of Catra breaking herself in pieces too. “It´s not your fault, baby, it´s not. It's going to be alright.”

Catra hiccups around the tears but her eyes are heavy, full of meaning and of words that are tangled still on her vocal cords. Her fingers dig a little over Adora´s shoulder blades, holding her as close as possible against her and locking her eyes with her.

"Adora, it let me live," Catra says, clenching her teeth. Adora freezing inside the shower, her hands still cradled around Catra´s pretty face twitching lightly. Here nobody can hear them, not the detectives lingering outside the hospital, not their friends, not the killer. It´s just them, holding each other under the lukewarm spray of water. "It let me live, on purpose. It could have killed me, it *wanted* to but it didn´t. It wanted me to give you a message instead"

Adora gasps, running one of her hands from Catra´s jaw, down behind her neck, pressing it firmly over Catra´s narrow back. Adora saw the words, she read them, she felt them underneath her fingertips as she fought the need to scream and to rub them out of Catra´s body before she could see them herself. Adora saw Huntara kneeling on the elevator floor and flashing photograph after photograph of Catra´s bare back before Adora could even understand what was going on.

A message directed to Adora, delivered on the freckled skin of the love of her life.

"It´s alright now," Adora hears herself say, strained. It is drowned in rage, in fury, even as she tries to tame it down, threatening to burst off her chest in a furious scream because how dare it. How dare this monster hurt her, to place its hands over Catra´s skin and use her to plant fear inside Adora´s heart. "You are okay. I´m not going to let it hurt you, I swear to you."

Catra´s eyes dig on hers, suddenly sent ablaze. Her hands move from Adora´s shoulder blades to her arms, holding Adora´s wrists inside her hands, feeling her rapid heartbeat below her fingertips.

"It said it would wait, until you were there again." Catra says, voice sore. Adora´s blood freezes inside her body. "It said it

wanted to make you watch.”

Adora´s jaw goes slack, her mouth falling open. Something nasty and rotten starts to spread inside her chest, filling every single of her cells and covering her in it like black pitch. She feels a lot of things in that moment, fear, sadness, sorrow, terror, but all of it gets overpowered as rage starts boiling like a volcano about to erupt. A dark hand with a dark reach, threatening all that Adora has tried to protect above everything else, trying to reach her soul and her heart and crush it under bloodied feet. Hunting for Adora and leaving a blood trail behind and in that moment all that Adora can feel is mind numbing wrath.

“I´m going to fucking kill it first,” Adora grunts, clenching her teeth so hard that she feels her molars chip under the pressure. “I ´m going to find that animal and I'm going to kill it before it lays another hand on you.”

Catra´s eyes soften, from wide and urgent to something softer, still tense in the edges but tender when she looks at Adora. Even as angry and frantic she looks right now, there is nothing but tenderness in Catra´s heart for her. She has always been the most beautiful thing in the world for Catra, the dearest thing inside her heart. She cannot bear to see her suffering anymore.

“I don´t care about me, Adora. I'll face whatever comes for me,” Catra admits, sadly, resting her forehead against Adora´s, caressing the bridge of her elegant and crooked nose with her fingertips. “I just want *you* to be safe, I want you to make it out of here. Promise me, Adora, promise me that you are going to survive this.”

“ *We* are going to survive this,” Adora grunts, bringing Catra´s hands towards her face. She kisses her knuckles, the raw joints bruised after fighting off the ghost chasing them to kill them. And then below, the inner side of her wrists, the length of her arms, the angle of her elbow where her smell lingers even after a bath. On every single inch of her upper arms and freckled shoulders until she reaches the hollow of her collarbones, ghosting her

trembling lips over the scar in Catra´s neck and resting her mouth against her stitched up temple. “Together.”

“Together,” Catra echoes, finding Adora inside the dark spiral she is drowning in. Back to the now, where Catra is inside her arms and where Catra needs Adora next to her. “Just stay, alright? Stay with me.”

“Of course yes,” Adora wraps her arms into a bow around Catra´s sweet waist and carries her a little off the ground, holding her weight and her heart inside her palms, their bare bodies woven into each other, knitting them together like roots of older trees. “For as long as you need me”

“I need you always,” Catra whispers against Adora´s soaked hair, nuzzling on the crook of her neck. Adora hums, kissing her shoulder, lulling them both into a sweet kind of embrace, holding to each other while the world crumbles into pieces around them.

“Then I'll be with you forever”

—

They are placed inside a security house, just as Castaspella said. Or as much as a security home the detectives can manage in such a short period of time.

With the new mayor's death the town’s administration is unofficially in chaos. It is still night time but once morning comes it will be just a matter of time for the entire town to know about Angella and then everyone will be truly completely fucked. Which is why Adora, Catra, Bow and Glimmer are thrown into an old building that 's more of an abandoned hostel that has no other guests but them and where the security cameras don´t work and the second floor creaks with every step.

At least it's clean and quiet, far away from the actual hotels of the town and secured enough so you'd really have to make an entire trip across the entire circuit of cars to reach it.

The detectives take them there in a huge van that looks more like an old prisoner's carriage, all black and completely closed off to the world. The silence inside the back of the car is deafening, sad and completely messed up, weighing over all of them heavily. Glimmer and Bow are sitting on the cushioned seats right behind the pilot and copilot, quiet as a tomb. Bow tries to search for Glimmer´s eyes, rubbing circles over her knuckles and palms, but she is completely detached from the now, looking through the inked windows of the car.

Glimmer´s face is pale, so pale that the fine veins of her face pop green against her skin. Her cheeks always rosy and round up are sunken inside her face and the lines below her eyes are completely raw and red after crying so much. Adora knows she went hysterical in the hospital room and that Castaspella had to sedate her during the entire time, even though Castaspella wasn´t supposed to treat her at all. In that moment, however, Castaspella wasn´t a doctor but an aunt, the only thing left for Glimmer to hold onto.

Sometimes, while they make their way across the sleepy and unaware town, Glimmer´s eyes roam from the windows to the seat where Adora and Catra are. Or more likely, to the place where Catra is sitting, her bruised face resting against Adora´s shoulder with her legs thrown over Adora´s lap. Her knee is cradled inside the black compression sleeve the hospital had handed her and her hair still wet by the shower, dozing off inside the circle of Adora´s arms as the latter holds her against her chest.

Adora looks at Glimmer watching them in silence and returns her gaze as kindly as she can, smiling softly and reassuringly at her even though her heart is a mess inside. Every single time, Glimmer snaps her eyes away, closing her hands into fists inside Bow´s palms.

The detectives guide them across the small and abandoned motel, showing them their rooms and stepping back immediately after without another word. They sit in front of a small police car right

in front of the motel and remain there the entire night, chattering among themselves and drinking heavy coffee to try and remain awake through the entire guard. Adora can see them from the window of her room, shaking her head at them and they frankly pathetic try to protect them before closing the heavy curtains, behind her.

Bow guides Glimmer silently inside their room, right at the other side of the corridor where Adora and Catra are, whispering sweet nothings that she doesn´t answer back. They all know it is going to take her a while, to assimilate it, to process it, to understand that her mother is truly gone. Glimmer just saw her mom fall from the tall stairs of the building and into her death, she saw her on the floor bleeding out and none of them will be able to help her erase that from her mind. Adora knows, she knows first hand, what is to lose a parent so suddenly, so quickly, so unfairly. She knows Glimmer will survive but it's going to take her a long while before she can really make peace with it.

At least they are all safe, for now.

The small clock on the nightstand marks one in the morning and Adora cannot sleep, staring at the red numbers blinking back at her almost mockingly. There is an itch below Adora´s skin that doesn't go away no matter what, no matter how she moves or how long she holds her breath, eating it´s way below her muscles and digging itself inside her bones.

She is anxious, she is restless and if she stays a second longer unmoving over the soft mattress of the room, she is going to scream or hit herself in the face, whatever comes first.

Adora sighs next to Catra´s side, observing her in silence as she sleeps. Catra´s back is pressed against Adora´s chest, nuzzling herself against the pillows and the blankets as tight as she possibly could. She is still wearing the turtle neck shirt Adora had helped her put on after their shower and the back of her neck smells like the neutral soap of the hospital. She is deeply asleep, completely worn down by the fucking day they just had,

exhaustion knocking her put before sadness could overtake her again.

Adora runs her fingers over the hair that curls against her temples, careful of the sterile patch covering the wound there and the movement makes Catra hum inside her sleep, her heartbeat steady inside her chest. Adora stares at her under the lilac light of the room, at her fluttering eyelashes while she dreams and at the small opening of her ajar mouth when she sighs in her sleep every once in a while, warm and sweet against the plain white sheets and exhales, squeezing her arm around her waist once more before letting go.

Adora untangles herself from Catra´s side as softly as she can, placing pillows below her back to keep her from rolling around in the mattress. Adora won´t be long, but she still makes sure the blankets are well wrapped around Catra´s body, from the toes to her shoulders.

Adora leans back towards Catra before standing up from the bed completely, resting a single sweet and long kiss against her freckled cheek, closing her eyes at the smell of Catra´s sleepy body.

"I adore you," Adora whispers against her warm skin, kissing Catra ´s forehead again. Catra hums in her sleep, her body relaxing further on the bed. Adora grins at her, tiny and sweet, brushing her curls off her face and standing up completely.

Adora closes the door of the bedroom very quietly behind her, standing on her socks and pajama shorts in the quiet corridor of the empty motel. Adora sighs, resting her forehead against the cold wood of the door, closing her eyes at the pressure weighing over her head. She feels like she is going to throw up, to scream or to slam her head against the floor, all at the same time, overwhelming and firing up the cells inside her body.

"´Dora?" Bow´s voice comes into the corridor, ripping Adora from her thoughts.

She leans back from the door in time to see Bow tiptoeing quietly across the corridor, directly towards her. He is also in his pajamas and sleep crop top, an old bag with papers hung from his shoulder and the data pad Glimmer had taken from Huntara held in his hands. The detectives had allowed them to gather a few things before throwing them in the motel, things they would while being here like clothes and their phones. Adora is not sure how Bow managed to take the library papers and the data pad from Scorpia´s apartment but somewhere inside her chest she is relieved he did.

"Hey, Bow," Adora greets him in a whisper, rubbing her eyes clean with the back of her hand.

Bow´s eyes soften at the sight, opening his arms to her. Adora takes the offer immediately, walking the few feet that separate them and throwing her arms around his waist, sinking in the embrace as deeply as she can. She needs this, she needs her friend right now.

"Hi, ´Dora," Bow murmurs against her head, petting the side of her hair. He sounds very tired too but still wise and calm, eyeing the closed door of Adora´s room with knowing eyes. "How´s Catra?"

"Calmer. Analgesics kicked in and she fell asleep," Adora says, leaning back from his arms so she can run her hands across her hair, pushing it all away from her face. "And Glimmer?"

"Not very good," Bow admits, his shoulders falling. "But she also fell asleep. With the amount of things the doctors sent her, I hope she sleeps through the entire night"

"So do I."

Adora rubs her upper arm with her palm, shifting in her feet. She has so much to say, all of it tangled in her vocal cords yet she doesn´t know how to express it, how to pour it all in the space between them and in the space where Glimmer is and Catra is. It

tastes so sad and so regretful that Adora doesn´t know how to gulp it down her throat and talk about it.

"Listen, Bow–

"It wasn´t your fault." Bow stops her before she can keep going, raising his hand towards her. He places it gently over Adora´s shoulders, mindful of the stitches below the straps of her shirt. "Or Catra´s, or any of us"

Bow pulls from Adora, wrapping her into another hug again. He smells clean too and, even though they are the same height, he still feels taller, surrounding Adora´s swirling head with calmness. He leans the side of his cheek against Adora´s temple, squeezing her back softly.

"Be strong," Bow whispers, petting the back of her head softly.

Adora cannot help the tears gathering in the corners of her eyes, returning the hug with a single nod. In a way, Bow has become so much like a brother to her that it sometimes still catches her out of guard. After Adam´s death and her parents, he was there. He has been a rock in all of this, gentle and smart and calm. He has cared for Adora and, more important for Adora than herself, for Catra, even when everyone was considering her a demon and a killer, Bow never doubted. Adora doesn´t know what she would do without him and she never wants to find out.

"Okay," Adora nods again, cleaning her tears and straightening her back. She needs to be on her both feet right now. She can allow herself to crumble a little but not completely, not when the danger hangs over them so closely.

Adora looks at the bag with papers and the data pad, pointing at them with her chin. "Doing some reading?"

Bow sighs, wrinkling his nose at the things.

"Yeah, I´ve been going through everything again." Bow rests his arm over Adora´s shoulder, guiding her gently through the

corridor. “Come on, I saw a garden in the back, we can go through there. I´ll make you a sandwich after.”

“If you put it like that,” Adora says, trying to mimic the gentle smile on her lips. She does look back, though, towards the door of her bedroom, her eyebrows twitching. “Catra–”

“Let her rest. I´ll come check on her and Glimmer in a few minutes,” Bow reassures her, bumping his nose against Adora´s temple. “But I know you and you really need this right now. Otherwise you are going to freak yourself out and then all of us are going to freak out.”

“You are right.” Adora agrees after a beat, pressing her palm against her chest. Yes, she does need it. If she doesn´t take a moment right now she will never be able to go back to sleep. “Have I told you I really love you Bow?”

“Not as much as I´d like,” Bow jokes, light hearted, tickling Adora softly on her good side. “Let´s go. We´ll be back before they even wake up.”

“After the sandwich”

“After the sandwich, of course. Let's go.”

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The night is full of sounds after the rain, crickets and birds and other insects and animals roaming the fields and bushes and tall trees all around the building. Double Trouble leans against the column of the main room, huffing when the dust and the water dripping from the roof drips into their expensive clothes.

They´ve been here for the past hour and DT is already sick of it all, the cold of the night slipping inside their bones and freezing them to the core. If they get pneumonia out of this, they swear silently that it will not go unpunished, even if they have to do

justice out of their own hand, which would be tremendously annoying given they just did their nails this morning.

The clock on the screen of their phone marks almost two in the morning, a whole forty minutes after the message arrived, and for a long minute DT has the thought of calling back the unknown number it had come from. Except that they had been instructed very clearly to never call back, no matter what.

Honestly, DT thinks it is a bit idiotic this whole anonymous thing, as if they didn´t know already who had been texting them to meet the entire week, or as if they hadn´t meet each other in secret places so DT could give the information requested. But they suppose people as important and well seen in the town as this one need to keep appearances as much as they can, and the payment is juicy, so DT will have to suck it up and make do for now. This is the first time they are requested in such a fucking creepy place though, which is not alarming at all but absolutely annoying.

Finally after another five minutes of waiting, the heavy door of the building opens and closes again with a deep creak, letting the cold fog and the smell of fog sleep inside. DT groans, rolling their eyes inside their sockets so hard they almost strain. They can´t help the annoyed grumble stumbling off their lips, not even caring to turn around to greet their benefactor.

“Finally. You've got me waiting for hours,” DT complains, running their fingers through the long strands of their blonde hair. “This thing of sending me messages from disposable phones is not needed, you know?”

They wait for a second, for the questions to come, but their benefactor is very quiet today, stepping softly over the marble floor and stopping a few feet behind DT. Their breath is calm and quiet, almost so quiet that if DT hadn´t heard the door and the steps, they wouldn´t even know it is there to begin with.

“Alright then, let's cut the shit.” DT snaps when their patience runs low, tapping their black boot on the floor. “Listen, this has all been very stimulating and very monetary positive to me, fun even. I mean, this is the first time I´ve been requested in secret places of the town to share the secrets I know and it's nice in a way, very nice actually. I missed messing up with that sweet little kitten and her sweet little face, though following her through the woods was not my or my boots favorite thing to do, you know?”

DT chuckles without mirth, chewing on the mint gum inside their mouth. The benefactor is still in silence but it listens attentively, allowing DT to speak their mind. DT huffs, spitting the gum against the floor, uncaring of where it lands. They roll their shoulders back, a scowl painting on their sharp mouth.

“I don´t give a fuck if you keep sending me follow Catra or even her blond haired bitch for once wherever you want to see what they are doing. Even that day you sent me to *your* house to question her and she almost caught something was going on. But this is getting out of hand. There are like, a lot of dead people dropping all around and you already got me coming at two in the fucking morning when I could just go to your office. I mean, with all that new power and all the things you have already covered, it wouldn´t be so hard to make my visit pass without notice.”

DT runs their tongue over their sharp teeth, testing the ends of their fangs with the tip. They are indeed extremely annoyed about following Catra the entire morning yesterday and sitting in that uncomfortable car watching her move around the place where she had come to hide like a stray cat. It was good money for not doing virtually anything, but it becomes tedious after the second hour of watching a person clean the weeds of a garden and nothing else. *Especially* when so many other eventful activities had happened in the town on the last day.

When DT got involved in this they thought it would not only win them money but also get them a golden ticket into the first row of this show. So far though it had been nothing but disappointing

“So if I´m going to put my neck in the line just to bring you new information, I´m going to need you to up that payment into something fairer.” DT drops with a sly smile, shrugging. “I mean, I already told you everything I got from Catra. All of her little secrets since she was a seventeen year old brat. I knew you were so very interested in my knowledge of the story of her mother's abuse towards her even though you already knew it. And about her stupid love affair with the blondie too, she really *is* obsessed with her. So it's only fair, don´t you think? If you pay me more I can even help you dig more inside the chapel like you wanted.”

DT waits, ready to keep their cool and convincing facade until they get what they want. They are an expert on getting everything they want. Except that, as the seconds pass by, no voice comes around. DT grunts, finally turning around to narrow their eyes at the shadows of the building. The shadow of the person is lingering by the door, quiet and unmoving, mingling with the darkness in every single inch of this night.

“Uh, hello?” DT calls, shaking their hand in front of their own face, calling for their benefactor´s attention.

Annoyance is settling deeper and deeper inside of them, clouding any other rational thought in the mind they presume so much of being sharp and agile.

“Missy Mayor Bright? I mean, it's not very interesting for your theory but do you want to know where Catra has been going or not?”

DT narrows their eyes at the darkness, stepping forwards, steps purposefully and heavy until they are almost completely in front of the heavy door and the shadows make sense from them. Except that, in the place where the figure had stood it is not there anymore, just a long column crumbling in the base, twisted and dark, confusing DT´s sight.

Their heart skips a beat inside their chest, clogging their throat with sudden terror. Outside, the night has gone completely quiet,

all the animals shutting down and hiding, as if even them had caught wind of the predator hunting for DT´s blood right now.

A step creaks behind DT, heavy, purposefully done,meant to call for their attention. Goosebumps run down DT´s arms and the back of their neck at the sound, crawling their way freezing cold across their spine.

A shadow moves in the exact same place where DT was, leaning off the wall, cut by the light of the moon slipping through the stained glass. DT presses their back against the crumbling column, too locked in fear to even register that they should have started running long ago.

“Angella?”

The shadow hums, something that sounds so much better a laughter and a whistle, melting with the sounds of the violent breeze crashing against the roof of the building. It is so low and so terrifying that if it weren't right in front of Double Trouble, they would have missed it completely.

“Angella Bright is not here now,” the shadow says, slow and sultry, mocking, stepping fully into the ray of the moonlight. The teeth are bright white, flashing with sharp canines and venomous tongue running through the upper lip when the animal smiles. “She is very busy rotting in the ground”

Under the light of the moon, the eyes look bleeding red, crimson against ink pools of darkness, craving grooves of terror inside Double Trouble's heart and they know, DT knows deep inside their rotten soul too, that they are about to die. And that it will be painful.

“Wait,” DT wheezes, recognition making a mess of their insides. They dig their sharp nails on the marble of the column, choking on their breath. They weren't expecting this, at all, and it only makes the shadow’s smile flash. “Wait, you are– you–”

The shadow laughs, loud and full of mirth, towering above DT’s figure when it slides right in front of them. It leans towards them, taking on DT´s terrified stare with hungry eyes. Its breath smells like rotten sweetness and decay. “I am your death, Double Trouble. That's who I am.”

DT turns around on their ankles, heart hammering inside their chest as they reach for the closed door. But terror makes them slow and their expensive boots slip on the dirty floor, making them trip and fall on their face.

All the air bursts out of DT’s lungs with the hit, pain flooring their mind and making their eyes blurry immediately with tears. Beyond the rush of blood inside their ears, DT can hear the killer's steps walking calmingly towards them, relishing in DT making an idiot of themself.

DT can hear the killer chuckle at some point as it scrunches next to DT, tilting its head to the side to watch DT’s face. The dark robe hanging from its shoulder hides the moonlight from DT´s sight. They have fallen on a crumble of rocks and dirt on the floor, making her face raw with shallow scratches, blood and spit gathering in DT’s mouth and dripping on their chin. There are scratches all over Double Trouble hands, making the skin tingle and itch uncomfortably, aching and numb from the fingers to the elbow.

Double Trouble looks back at the killer's eyes drowned in red, breathing hard. DT knows they don't stand a chance, not with this person. They might have if it had been anybody else, but not this. DT is a performer, a show, but they are not a fighter.

“How?” DT questions around a mouthful of blood, desperate to find a way to get out, a way to explain or even to manage to turn this around in their favor. Trembling like a pathetic terrified viper convulsing on the floor. “How did–?”

“How did I know? I don't enjoy people snooping on my business and you, little brat, have been more than obvious.” The killer

extends a hand towards DT, wrapping gloved fingers around their neck and pulling back from them with no resistance at all. DT´s gasps in terror, being moved around like they weighed nothing, back pressing painfully over the pieces of rocks below them. "I might tell you a secret though, you love those, don´t you? Come hear"

The killer digs their nails against Double Trouble´s scalp bringing them towards its face, eyes locking together in a kind of masquerade dance that cannot be avoided. The killer does not wear a mask right now, not tonight. Today it is tired of masks, today it wants its victim to look at its eyes and see the life leaving them slowly, without barriers between their faces. It is always the most delicious part of it all.

"People love confessing their sins on holy ground but sometimes that marble floor is just made of blood and they don´t even realize it until they are falling from the stairs and into hell," the killer whispers, clear and excited. "And you, little snake, have a lot of sins."

The killer rises its fist towards Double Trouble´s face, hovering in the shadows. DT struggles on the ground, voice choked and terrified, digging their own fingers on the murderer's shoulder and chest, trying and failing to push it away.

"No, wait. Wait, please–"

The fist falls against Double Trouble´s face like a warhammer, cartilage and skin of the nose breaking and splitting below the strength of the blow, spilling blood all over their face. Double Trouble sputters, recoiling away from the pain and the hit but it is already way too late, the fist falling again and again, over and over again against their face.

*Squelch,* a fist against the cheekbones, ripping them open with the force. *Squelch,* knuckles over eyebrows and down the length of the nose, blowing up fine blood vessels and painting the tanned skin in red and purples and black, like ink spilled over the sand.

*Squelch,* against the mouth, filling gums with crimson and chipping and breaking white teeth under the blow, pieces of white bone breaking skin and falling against the pharynx and the throat. *Squelch, squelch. Squelch.* Blood, blood, skins and bones.

For long minutes the only thing that is heard inside the dark building is the sound of bones against skin, of bones breaking and joints popping and horrid gurgling as it clogs throat and airways, filling the air and the floor with the salted and copper smell of fresh blood spilling all over the walls and the columns. For the longests of minutes the only sound inside this rotten smelling place covered in old moss and dampness that calls for the rot, are the sounds of the murderer beating Double Trouble´s face into a pulp, until every single sharp and beautiful and carefully taken care off faction on their thin face disappears below blood and bruises and spit.

The murderer leans back for a second, watching with a smile on its face as Double Trouble chokes on their own saliva and the gushes of blood coming from their nose and mouth. Their hands hover over the murderer´s wrists, still trying to fight back, still struggling on the floor even though the pain is completely overwhelming and they cannot see anymore, sight clouded by tears and scleras drowned in red.

The murderer looks back at Double Trouble´s bleached and inflamed eyes, humming with amusement at the looks of their face, their speeding breathing, the drench of their sweat and blood soaking expensive clothes against their skin. The murderer leans forwards towards Double Trouble´s beaten body, furrowed eyebrows as it takes a deep, long sniff over their forehead, filling it´s nose and lungs with the smell.

"Ah," the killer hums pleasantly, smiling from ear to ear. "You smell like fear"

Double Trouble shivers and starts kicking violently, blindly trying to hit their killer with their feet and exhausted hands. They even manage to throw a punch or too, way too weak to make damage

at all but desperate enough to make the murderer grunt with annoyance at the display of resistance. The murderer clicks its tongue against its teeth, shaking its head almost as if it was disappointed in DT for even trying to put on a fight against their own death.

“I could have left you alone but oh,” the murderer wraps its fingers on the blonde strands of hair, pupils blown wide at the sight. “You have such pretty hair”

It twists and then pulls, ripping several chunks of hair right off their scalp and into the ground, curling all around their bodies and feet. DT screams, loud so loud if they were to be anywhere else it would have woken up rows and rows of families with the echo of the howls. But the graveyard is too quiet and empty, and dead men don't tell tales.

Double Trouble screams and screams, tearing their vocal cords apart as the murderer keeps pulling and ripping all the yellow strands off their head, soaked in the blood pouring from the follicles and skin. They scream until there is no voice, no yell, no howl loud enough to convey their pain and they fall voiceless and restless over the cold floor, unable to whisper a single more vocal or whimper off their busted and broken mouth.

“No, don´t stop,” the murderer laments when silence falls between them, gripping Double Trouble´s chin tightly between its hands. “Keep going”

The killer slips its fingers inside Double Trouble´s mouth, pressing down on the bloodied cavity, not even flinching when the splinters of the broken jaw rip on the fine leather gloves. It grasps Double Trouble´s bottom incisors between its thumb and index and pulls down, down and down until it feels the gums giving away and the roots moving with the sheer pressure, tongue and denture starting to crumble in its fingers.

“We are going to be here for a long time”

—

The battered body rolls off the beams and falls against gravity, thick rope straining against the weight. The feet dangle several inches from the floor, one black boot lost, the other bent in an unnatural position. Blood both fresh and long ago dried dripping on the floor below, pink almost under the light of the sun that starts to creep through the twisted branches of the trees.

The animal stands right in front of the stained glass window, arms at either side of its body, staring without blinking and without breathing as the corpse dangles hung from its own personal gallow. The ripped off yellow hair is knotted into a sweet bow on its hands, waiting to be delivered as a gift or a warning.

The teeth are on the floor, fallen over the blood. They will serve to call for the forest predators to devour the body as the animal opens the heavy door and leaves it ajar, the smell of blood and sweat staining the woods. As always, the graveyard is quiet and the chapel bells are loud across the trees.

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## October 28th

The curtains of the room are closed but Catra still can hear the chirping of the birds loud even through the windows. It would be nice and comforting any other fucking day but today it´s just deeply and completely annoying, making Catra´s temple drum painfully and her head to start to ache.

Catra stirs awake, shaking off the last delicious strands of good sleep she had somehow miraculously pulled last night. She can´t remember the last time she slept without waking up by a night terror creeping on her mind but she supposes deep trauma and absolute exhaustion of running away from a serial killer would do the trick for anyone else too.

Catra nuzzles her face on the stiff pillow and nest further over the duvet, seeking blindly for the warmth she had fallen asleep around last night and finding nothing in return. Catra´s eyes open harshly, her pupils shrinking from blown up to pin points inside her colorful irises, sudden fear overcoming her when she realizes she can´t feel Adora´s arms around her nor she can feel the sweetness of her sleepy breath against her nape. Adora is not sleeping behind her and suddenly Catra is completely awake and completely overwhelmed by fear once again.

A gentle hand shoots towards her from the other side of the huge bed, resting the palm over her temple and across the back of her head into a soft caress, pulling Catra out of her terror with the sweet touch. Catra looks up, meeting Adora´s soft and sleepy blue eyes right in front of her.

"I´m here," Adora whispers reassuringly, face sleepy.

They must have switched sides somewhere through the night because Adora is now on the side closest to the door. She must also be up for a little bit now because she is sitting on the bed, holding a wrinkled and old piece of newspaper on one hand while the other still caresses circles across Catra´s curls, smiling tenderly.

"Good morning"

"Good morning," Catra murmurs with a relieved sigh, falling right back into the comfortable sheets around them. She hums around Adora´s fingers, feeling the way her touch chases the headache away. "You smell like coffee"

"Bow and I made some last night." Adora explains, shifting her touch. She drops the paper into the floor and nuzzles right back inside the sheet, curling around Catra´s still sleepy body. She smells good, not only like coffee but also like mint gum and a little bit like soap. "And cheese sandwiches. I brought you two"

Catra hums, letting her eyes fall closed again. “There is food in this place?”

“There is a kitchen,” Adora says with a shrug, pressing her nose against Catra´s temple. Catra lets herself float into the nice warmth of sleep and Adora´s touch but the words also start making sense for her.

“Why were you making sandwiches at wee hours of the night?” Catra questions, opening her eyes again so she can see Adora´s pretty face. There is a very clear imprint of a pillow´s wrinkles on her cheek. She must have been sleeping very soundly too, if the tiny mark of droll on the corner of her mouth has anything to say about it.

“Bow thought it would help me calm down. I– I couldn´t sleep.” Adora admits, her eyes wrinkling sadly.

A pang of sadness crosses Catra´s heart too, leaving her breathless for a second. Memories of the last day start to flood her mind, making her tremble even below the covers. Adora feels it because she smooths a line over Catra´s forehead, gently chasing the sadness away even though her own face is crumbling.

“I´m alright. We are alright,” Adora reassures her in the thread of a voice, pressing a kiss over Catra´s nose bridge.

“Bow and I were up until like six in the morning. He is very particular about sandwiches if you must know,” Adora jokes halfheartedly, trying to tame the sorrow lingering above them.“He was right though, I slept like a log when I came back to you.”

Catra relaxes, even if just a fraction, nuzzling her cheek against Adora´s. She looks around them, taking in the sight of the small motel room, the tightly shut door, their bags with clothes thrown on the corner near the bathroom door and the closed windows that don´t let her see the light of day.

“What time is it?” Catra asks, straining her eyes to try and see the numbers on the small clock behind Adora without moving at all.

“Four in the afternoon”

Catra´s mouth goes slack, surprise clear in her face. She knows by the time they all got out of the hospital and dragged in here it was well past midnight but she didn´t thought they had slept for that long. Fourteen hours long to be exact. “Wow”

“Yeah, I know,” Adora chuckles, the dimple in her cheek curling adorably. “I was surprised too”

Catra watches her in silence for a moment, running her fingertips across Adora´s face. She looks significantly better than last night, less pale and less bruised over. The sterile patches on her shoulder and her ribs are still visible even below her sleep tank top, but she doesn´t flinch every time she moves like she did last night, as much as she tried to hide it from Catra. There are less patches of red on her neck and limbs and her face looks softer, even if it is still tainted by the shadow of grief.

Catra exhales, letting her face fall against Adora´s, their cheeks pressing together. “Have you been up for long?”

“Like fifteen minutes,” Adora murmurs back, resting her palms over Catra´s waist. “I was going through the newspapers again.”

Catra hums, blinking at the brightness that the small lamp brings into their room. Silence falls again between them but this time is more comfortable, slipping inside their bones like sleep. They are still exhausted.

Catra feels Adora´s fingers running up and down the curve of her waist, feeling gently every inch of her skin when they travel across her ribs and down her spine, holding her close and tender against her chest. Catra can´t bury the gentle tremble that crosses her body and Adora stills, sadly, waiting in case Catra wants to step away.

But the last thing Catra wants to do right now is step away from Adora. Instead she leans her head backwards and meets Adora´s stormy eyes away, holding her gaze inside hers before falling towards Adora´s pink and busted lips and then back at her eyes. A silent plea that only they know and that Adora meets in kind.

They kiss dearly over the soft duvet, limbs tangling with each other. Catra hums around Adora´s lips, pressing herself closer against her, mindful of her stitches and her own stitches but incapable of existing so far away from her, even if it is a few inches.

Adora meets her in the beginning and the end and the middle, her palms brushing from Catra´s spine to the small of her waist and the back of her neck, tilting Catra´s head softly, guiding her gently so she can deepen the kiss. Adora´s tongue lick a gentle line over the roof of Catra´s mouth and presses down into her tongue, drinking on Catra´s sweet sigh against the corner of her mouth.

Catra´s knee still aches when she moves it to cradle Adora´s hip and she flinches accidentally, wrinkling her nose. Much to her dismay, Adora stops immediately, parting from her warm mouth and damp breath to look down, ghosting her sure fingertips over the compression sleeve and the bruised skin that lives there. Catra grunts, mildly annoyed and completely clouded still by the kisses, searching for Adora´s mouth again with eager touch.

Adora kisses her back but she is already distracted, rubbing her palm up and down Catra´s thigh, caressing the pain away as best as she can. Her other palm cradles the back of Catra´s head gently, careful of the point where the killer slammed Catra´s head against the floor and just the memory alone makes Catra shiver, a whimper making it out of her mouth. She can feel Adora leaning away again but Catra doesn´t allow it, running her fingers over soft golden strands, placing them behind Adora´s red ears and holding herself to the side of her neck.

She sighs on the kiss and so does Adora, running her peach lips from Catra´s mouth to her cheekbones to her nose and temple and back down her lips, gathering all of each other´s sorrow on the tip of her tongue and transforming it on the base of her throat into a sweet hum, reassuring each other that the other is really here, fine and alive and dear in their arms.

A knock comes from the other side of the door, quiet but still sure, tearing them of their daydreaming. Catra lets her head fall back on the pillow and Adora rises hers, wiggling them both softly into a more sitting position as they face the closed door of the room.

"Coming," Adora calls, clearing her throat when her voice rings sticky sweet. She untangles herself carefully from Catra´s body with a lot of sorrow and makes the journey towards the room's door.

Adora stretches her hands and grabs the handle, halfway towards the lock when the memories of last night crash against her. She tilts her head back enough to see Catra already looking back, still tangled on the sheets but with her eyes wide and alarmed, the same train of thought running inside her head. Adora exhales all the air in her lungs and turns back towards the door, standing on her toes so she can see through the peephole.

Pink hair is the first thing she sees and it makes Adora want to shiver suddenly, the memory of pink hair drenched in blood forever stitched in her eyelids. It takes her a second for her eyes to narrow and take into the full stretched image through the hole, her brain processing that below the pink hair is her friend's face and not Angella´s.

"Glimmer" Adora mutters, unlocking the door quickly and swinging it open as gently but fast as she can.

Glimmer stands on the other side of the door in silence, her hands at either side of her body.  Her short pink hair is completely messed up, rumpled in places and matted in others. Her face is the palest Adora has ever seen her with, clear veins in her

temples and patches of red over her neck and collarbones. Adora has never seen her eyes like this either, so sad and inflamed, the red overcoming the soft lilac almost completely. She looks terribly, completely heartbroken and torn into pieces but even she seems to have caught some much needed sleep.

“Glimmer,” Adora repeats, her eyes softening. “Hey, are you alright?”

Glimmer blinks at her without really seeing her at all. She stares for a second and then her eyes fall behind Adora´s back, looking at the inside of the room. Catra has pushed the sheets away and stood from the bed, standing quietly a few feet behind Adora. Adora follows Glimmer's line of sight and sees Catra too, catching her balancing precariously on her good leg.

It's instinct really, nothing else but pure and honest instinct when Adora moves towards Catra, crossing her arm around her waist and resting her weight against her own body to help her stand without straining her leg. Adora drops a swift kiss over Catra´s bruised temple and returns her eyes to Glimmer by the door.

Glimmer´s eyes have hardened, from void nothing to blazing purple like amethysts, staring at both of them with a heavy weight in her pupils. Adora shrinks a little at her friend´s expression, already opening her mouth to alleviate the tension. Glimmer beats her to it, sharply looking away, her jaw locked into a tight line.

“Huntara is here to talk with us,” Glimmer says, strained and hard. “She is in the lobby with Bow, we´ll see you there”

She turns around and leaves without another word, stomping loudly in the corridor. The door swings open behind her, letting the dim light of the motel lamps shine inside the room. Adora blinks a few times, awkwardness and worry washing over her but unable to find it in herself to run after her, not now. She knew things would be very difficult from now on and that it will take them a long time to heal from this.

Catra, however, does tense inside Adora´s palms, her whole body shivering. She lets out an exhale and leans her forehead over Adora´s shoulder, closing her eyes so hard that they hurt.

“She is never going to forgive me,” she whispers, trying very hard to bury just how much it's hurting her. “She is always going to hate me for surviving on that fucking elevator.”

Adora´s eyes wrinkle on the corners, sadness squeezing her heart painfully. She hates this, she hates that this happened to Catra, she hates that she couldn't do anything at all to avoid it, she hates that is pulling them all apart. Adora hates it with all her heart.

Adora cradles Catra´s jaw inside her palm and kisses her cheek tenderly, nuzzling her nose against her temple. “Give her time”

Catra sniffles, wrinkling her nose at the tears gathering in her eyelashes. Adora catches the tears with her fingertips, pressing kisses all over her dear face, smothering sadness with tenderness. It's the only thing they have left now.

“Come on, angel. Let 's go see Huntara before she comes to collect us herself”

“We are on pajamas”

“That's on her for coming at such hours of the day”

Catra chuckles at the joke just as Adora expected her to do, but her shoulders remain tense, locked into a perpetual shiver. Adora ´s eyes narrow in the corners, leaning her nose and mouth against Catra´s head.

“Let´s go”

—

“Alright, let's go through it all again” Huntara leans back on the chair with a grunt, pinching her nose with her fingers.

They are all huddled in the tables of the motel´s reception, sitting in a small circle. Huntara is at the top of the papel, dozens of papers, photographs and voice recorders over the table on her side. There are several portfolios on her feet, black and with the symbol of the detective's department except for one, of a white stained in dried spots of brown that Catra recognizes as the same one Mermista stole from Angella that day. Just a few days ago, actually.

“When the killer attacked you, who was it going for?” Huntara inquiries, wrinkling her nose. Catra can feel Adora flinching next to her, her face hardening and hands trembling. Catra extends her hand towards her, linking their fingers together.

“All of us, I guess,” Bow says after a second of silence, shifting uncomfortably on his chair. He understands too why Huntara needs to ask them all of this stuff now, even if most of them already gave their declaration last night. It doesn´t make things less tense, especially when Glimmer is so dead silent next to them.

“It attacked Scorpia because she was the one that opened the door but Catra pulled her back and it tried to grab Catra then.” Bow keeps saying, scratching his forearms nervously. He looks exhausted. “Adora helped her and we just ran after. We wanted to shelter in the bedrooms but the killer cornered us.”

“That's when it pushed Entrapta off the window?”

“Yes,” Bow says with a heavy gulp, his hands trembling over the table. “It– it looked like it wanted to kill us all right there and then. All of us, except–”

Bow cuts himself short, his voice failing him as he looks towards Adora´s chair. Adora knows he doesn´t meant to do it but she cannot help the pang of guilt and devastation crossing her heart with the simple look. Huntara is looking now too, as is Catra and even Glimmer, bearing her red rimmed eyes inside Adora´s tired ones.

Catra leans further towards Adora, holding her hands extra harder inside hers. She is trying to reassure her, this Adora knows, but not even her touch can help now the fire boiling inside Adora´s skin, covering it all in black.

"Capellan" Oh well, now, that´s just fucked up. Cornering Catra with her friends. Adora tenses in her seat, her heart suddenly pounding inside her chest. She knew this was going to be asked but it doesn´t make Adora want to yell less. "I want you to tell me what happened last night, when nobody was watching you."

Adora´s jaw throbs with anger, her head pounding. Next to her, Catra´s eyes are hooded, her body curled on herself even though she tries to hold herself as proud as always, and Adora knows it is not because of the pain of her body. She knows that what happened last night will weigh over all of them forever, but she is so tired of people pointing their fingers at Catra and treating her like an animal. She is tired, Catra is tired too, but even with all that, she is still herself, and she is still a friend and she is a whole lot fucking braver than any of them could ever be.

"Where is Scorpia?" Catra asks, voice firm, firmer than any of them, her eyebrows locking on a frown. "And Entrapta"

"I´m the one making questions, Capellan" Huntara tries to cut her back but Catra is unmovable, shaking her head once.

"I know what you are going to ask so answer me, Huntara. I know what you want me to say but I want to know where the fuck is Scorpia and Entrapta, so if you want me to speak start talking for once," Catra´s voice is low and clear, angry, barely held back. By all means it had only been work of the shock and the pain that Catra had not demanded to know where their friends were before. "Aren´t they in danger too?"

Huntara´s face hardens, her eyebrows twitching with frustration. "They are persons of interest, yes"

“They are not persons of interest, they are my friends. They are the people that asshole tried to kill too. Scorpia was wounded, Entrapta fell of a fucking window.” Catra yells, her pupils shrinking. Adora holds her hand extra hard but Catra´s hands are shaking so bad that it makes her teeth click with each other. “Why are they not here?”

Huntara looks like she would like to smack Catra in the face and Adora straightens up on her chair, very slightly flexing her shoulders and locking her jaw. Adora knows Catra can take care of herself but Adora is on edge since last night, and she is very close to bursting out, so it would be in Huntara´s best interest to not start shit right now. Huntara seems to realize the same thing because she flops back in the chair, scowling.

“They´ve been placed in another security home for now,” Huntara stops, weighing her words. It is quite obvious she doesn´t want to answer but under the heavy look of not only Catra but Adora, Bow and Glimmer too, she forces herself to. “We, Lashor and me, considered it appropriate”

“Appropriated how? That asshole attacked us all”

“Yes, but you were the only ones that had direct contact with it. If it wanted to go for them, it would have left you all alone.” Huntara bites into her tongue, regarding the four young adults heavily. “You all have shit carrying with you, and until all is cleared up and this motherfucker is caught, I´m not taking my chances with any of you.”

“I think is fucking stupid to separate us”

“I think you don´t call the shots on that Capellan,” Huntara barks, leaning towards the table. Catra leans too, tensing immediately. Adora and Bow hold their breaths, regarding the scene with heavy hearts, but neither of them move closer to the other. Instead, Catra arches her eyebrow at Huntara and the latter scoffs, taking a cigarette out of her leather jacket and lightning up with a big

puff. “Fine. They are safe, a person of trust is keeping an eye on them”

“Who?”

“That's confidential,” Catra opens her mouth, no doubt ready to start cursing her out. Huntara shakes her head, raising a hand for her to calm down. “But I understand. And I assure you they are alright. Their wounds were treated and they are safe. I´ll make sure that they are given phones so you can talk to them as you please. Alright?””

Catra closes her mouth again, struggling internally. She shoots Adora a glance and only there Adora can notice how truly scared she is. Adora squeezes her fingers gently, nodding. “Fine, okay.” Catra blurts, falling back on the chair´s rest. “Thank you or whatever.”

“Hmm,” Huntara regards Catra´s face heavily, her fingers tapping rhythmically over the table. A cold breeze runs over the table and all of them know what is next. “What happened up there, Capellan?”

Catra´s eyes crumble, looking away from Huntara´s hard face. Her body undoes a little on the seams, sorrow pulling off her strings harshly. Silently, Bow holds Glimmer´s hand inside of his, running his thumb over her cold knuckles. Catra had not spoken about last night with anyone but Adora; in a way, it was obvious Huntara was going to come specifically for this. Catra just didn´t thought it would be in front of everyone, not like this. It's tearing her apart.

Next to her, Adora leans towards Huntara a little, looking at her pleadingly. “Huntara”

“No.” Huntara denies, slamming her finger over the hard surface of the table. “Answer to me. Right here in front of Adora. Right here next to Angella´s daughter. Tell me what happened.”

Now it is Adora who wants to hit Huntara across the face. She turns to the side a little, catching Glimmer´s eyes already looking back, not at her, but at Catra, who is curled over the table like a sad bloom.

Catra digs her nails against the fake wood, breaking shallow scratches over it, blinking slowly. The images of last night haunt her and if Adora wasn´t there to hold her hand right now, she would probably never be able to push them out of her mouth.

"The killer told me it would kill me when it pleased it. That it could, that it would. And that it would make Adora watch," next to her Adora takes a sharp breath but Catra doesn't dare to look back at her. She hasn´t even dared to look at herself in the mirror. "It took my own blood from the floor and wrote a message for Adora on my skin. I think– I think it wanted to carve it there but the knife had fallen somewhere else."

If the room was quieter, Catra would have swore that she could hear the way Adora´s heart was rising next to her, slamming against her lungs and ribcage violently. Adora had seen the words, had washed them away from Catra´s skin, but Catra had not told her the last part. She had not told her just how scared she was, how much pain she was feeling, how loud her mother´s voice was in her ears when she thought somebody else would take her life away. She might never tell Adora, she doesn´t even want to remind herself.

"I couldn´t move, I couldn´t breath, I- I fought back. I fought it back." Catra says, clenching her teeth. And it is the truth, she fought tooth and nail, even though pain was overwhelming her, even though it felt like being shocked by a thousand lightning and her skin slashing open. Catra fought. "That asshole was going to run away, it went through the emergency stairs, I saw it disappear through the door and I thought it was over. I was so tired"

Catra takes a breath, closing her eyes tightly. She reaches for Adora in the dark and Adora meets her there, resting her

fingertips over her wrists, counting the beats of her heart on the tip of her tongue.

“The elevator opened again and I thought it was–” Catra hesitates, her bright eyes risking a look towards Glimmer´s. “I thought Glimmer had come back, but it was not her.”

Glimmer´s back straightens in her chair, her face shifting through so many emotions that it´s almost impossible to point them all. She looks like she might break down and cry and she also looks like she might sink her teeth in Catra´s throat. Smart lilac eyes like a fox studying her face sharply, even sharper than Huntara does.

“Angella, she was so desperate and so angry too. I´d never seen her like that before. She yelled at me to get up, she was pulling me off the floor but I was so tired and I–” Catra tangles in her words, hugging herself with the arm Adora is not holding. Her body feels cold and broken, cut like glass, and she is way too close to become hysterical. “She grabbed me by the arm and dragged me to the elevator. Told me to get it together, to stay awake and stay alive. I was so confused but then I saw her eyes and I saw that she was just scared.”

Catra always knew that Angella never loved her, that she could never love her. Her opinion of Catra had long ago been tainted by Weaver´s hands and Catra never could do anything to fix it after what had happened. After all, nobody wants to stay by the side of a girl that everyone knows murdered her mother, and nobody would ever catch themself loving one either.

Catra knew that all Angella wanted to do in those moments was to protect her own daughter from the monster breaking everything in pieces and Catra would never be able to blame her for that.

That's the only thing Catra wants too, to protect Adora, the person she loves the most, even at the cost of her own life.

“She wanted to know where the killer had gone and I told her. I pulled from her hand too but she kept saying she knew what was happening and that I needed to get down right in that second. Then she started to go to the stairs too.” Catra gasps, out of breath. She feels so heavy right now, pulled down by an invisible weight she cannot shake off. Adora is there next to her but not even her can hold her completely. Catra is so scared to look at Glimmer´s face she doesn´t even dare to move.

“I begged her not to, I tried to explain to her but she wouldn´t listen. She threw me on the elevator and pushed the button to make me go down. She said she would take care of it and I– I just saw her standing there looking at me go down when the staircase door opened again and I, I–”

Catra fails and falls, breaking down in a sob. Catra, who had never cried this much in her entire life, breaking in front of everyone else like a splintered cup against the floor. Catra can feel Adora´s hands over her shoulders, her warm nose against her own tear soaked cheek, but all Catra can see is Glimmer above Adora´s head, her tired lilac eyes and heavy stare. The sadness that hangs out of her by knowing herself orphan alone from one second to the other. The confusion, the anger, the sorrow, all of it Catra knows too well. She lived it herself, completely different but lived it after all. Catra understands and it breaks her.

“Glimmer,” Catra blurts around a burst of tears, cleaning her eyes almost violently. “I´m so sorry”

Glimmer looks at her without even breathing, her eyes dry and empty from tears. They look at each other for a long time until Glimmer snaps her head away, looking at the evening sun with tired eyes. Catra bites back a whimper and throws her head back, silent tears rolling down her cheeks with the movement. She is angry with herself, furious, because she should have known and yet she hoped. She is furious because she is sick of crying and she wishes she could just stop.

Adora snaps her eyes away from Glimmer and turns completely towards Catra, wrapping her inside her arms immediately, whispering reassurances in her ears. As much as she wants to mend things between them she knows she can´t do right now. And her priority is and always will be Catra above it all. They will have to all learn to forgive each other with time.

Bow turns to look at Huntara, who has fallen silent and deeply in thought watching the group of friends breaking each other by tragedy itself.

"Shouldn´t you just check the security cameras instead of making us go through this all over again?" He sounds pissed.

Bow´s annoyance makes Huntara trip, her eyes widening with surprise, melting into defensive anger immediately. "There are no security cameras in that apartment building, Laurence"

The words make Adora snap her head right back at her, her eyebrows skyrocketing in her forehead.

"Wait, but then how–" Adora starts to wonder, her jaw falling slack. "You have no fucking clue who is it, do you?"

Huntara regards Adora´s realization for a long second, her right eye twitching with pressure.

"I don´t," she confesses finally, letting her forehead fall against her fist. She looks all of her years now and more, bent down by the weight of her own guilt. "For a long time I thought–"

"You thought it was me," Catra finishes for her, cleaning the last of tears with her fingertips. She is still shivering but she holds herself as straight as she can, relying on Adora´s hands to hold her up.

Huntara´s dark eyes meet Catra´s, weighing her and studying her, white hair braided to the side. She smells a lot like strong coffee and like incense, buried deep below the sweat and the cigarette still burning in her mouth.

“Where have you been, Capellan?” Huntara questions her, leaning over the table. Catra looks back at her, her mouth pressed into a tight line. “Last night, your Bright friend over there told me you have been acting very weird and disappearing suddenly when the murders happened. So if you are not doing it I want to know where you have been.” Huntara tilts her head to the side, pressing further when Catra says nothing. “Well?”

“I´ve been home,” Catra finally says, looking at Huntara heavily from under her long eyelashes. Next to her, Adora blinks, sorrow and dread falling over her.

“You mean–” Adora starts, unable to continue. Catra looks at her with a sorrowful expression, nodding softly.

“My house, the one Weaver took away from me.” The house, the house with colorful windows and the yellow kitchen and the wallpaper walls covered in red paint. The house with the black paint where Catra almost died.

“The bank took that house after the incident,” Huntara mutters, frowning.

“I know”

“That´s trespassing”

“I know,” Catra shakes her head, tucking a strand of hair behind Adora´s ear, a movement so automatic and sincere it makes Adora´s heart throb. “But be for real Huntara, nobody is going to buy that house, not after–”

Catra falls quiet but it is obvious for anyone there why nobody would ever want to purchase that house again. That poor old house will rot in the end and crumble under the humidity of the woods and the weight of the moss and all that will ever live there will be ghosts.

“What were you doing there?”

“I've been fixing the garden. My father's garden.” Catra explains between her teeth, ears burning. This is personal and it is private and she doesn´t want to say but she needs to, otherwise Huntara will never finish trying to hunt her.

“Listen, I don't have any proof of what I'm saying. I didn't tell Adora either. I´ve been going there the last three weeks at night and before school. I just–” Catra takes a breath, biting down on her lip harshly. The tip of the piercing grazes against her busted lip painfully. “That was my home”

There is sadness in her voice that nobody is able to deny. That had been Catra´s home, even in the worst moment of her life. She had been ripped and defiled out of it and she will never be able to live past that but for years and years that was the place she loved and that now only holds memories, most of them bad.

That was her home and she is so young still, there is nothing wrong with wanting to hold yourself to the broken pieces of the life you used to have, that you used to adore. Catra was there almost every night for the last few weeks. She was there the night of the Halloween party and the rain caught her until she walked inside the greenhouse and stayed there until she knew the lightning and the storm had passed. She was there the night of Hordak´s funeral, walking among the tiny blooms of daisies that she had not seen in years. She was there on yesterday's morning, never praying yet still asking her father wherever in the fabric of the universe to shelter her and Adora. She was there.

“I could have you arrested the night for that,” Huntara says with a tired sigh, scratching her eyebrow. “I´m not going to do that, though”

Catra blinks at her, exhausted, unable to keep the accusation of her voice. “You don't think I'm killing Adora´s friends anymore?”

Huntara looks at her from the brim of a glass of juice that looks and smells suspiciously too much like liquor, pointing at Catra´s bandaged knee with her square chin.

“How long has that leg of yours been giving you problems?”

Catra´s teeth click together, biting her tongue accidentally. “Since New Year”

“Catra,” Huntara says, holding Catra´s eyes completely. “Did you kill your friends?”

Catra looks at her with the same intensity, barely holding her breath. “No”

“Okay,” Huntara accepts, leaning back in her chair. Catra exhales, still spiraling but calmer, just a little bit of the tension pressing down in her chest lifting.

Adora, however, is nowhere as calm. In fact, she is losing her mind, her breathing quick and her throat clogging with a sob and a scream, running her fingers over and over Catra´s temples and cheekbone, brushing the bruises and red patches and catching her tears on her fingertips. She feels a tug inside her chest, tearing the string of her heart painfully, pulling from her nerve endings and bursting in her skin like invisible blisters, making her dizzy and sick and tormented in ways she cannot even say.

Her world is crumbling down and it´s her fault. Her friends are dying and it´s her fault. Catra is crying and it´s her fault. It´s her fault, it´s her fault, that´s all she can think, all that she can feel, all that she can feel inside her chest. Things have gone to absolute shit and today is Catra´s birthday.

“It´s my fault,” Adora blurts out, unable to hold it back anymore. “All of this, it's my fault. It wants me. Me. I´m the reason it´s doing all of this.”

“Montenegro–”

“It could have killed me, several times,” Adora interrupts Huntara, her teeth clicking together anxiously. “It could have killed me when I held Catra on the window and then in the– the corridor, when it tried to–”

Adora chokes in her words, overwhelmed. Catra´s palm is soft inside of hers and it only makes Adora remember the fact that, if she hadn´t acted fast enough, the killer would have cut her heart out of her chest. It was going to do it, right there in front of Adora to see. I was going to kill Catra. Adora almost lost her and she barely can live with that.

"It could have killed me, Huntara, so easily, but it didn´t. A stab to the shoulder, a rip to the ribs, you think those were really trying to murder me? No." Adora´s voice is rising now, echoing inside the old smelling lobby and overtaking her completely.

For a moment there she cannot see or smell or hear anything else but the last night, repeating over and over again like a broken radio playing the same song several times.

"Don´t you see? This is all because of me. All this death, all this sorrow, it's because of me"

"You don´t know that–"

"I do!" Adora slams her palm over the precarious table, sending several objects tethering to the ground. Everyone at the table jumps in surprise, even Glimmer, her blank eyes flashing with something alive and just as angry as Adora feels right now. "I told you it had been calling me and what did you do about that?!"

Huntara´s face is wrinkled and angry, clearly thrown aback by Adora´s outburst. But Adora is done holding back now. "All those calls are from disposable phones"

"So I should just suck it up and wait until it decides to kill someone else?" Adora asks with a frantic chuckle, shaking her head with incredulity.

She is aware that everyone is looking at her with different kinds of expressions, from surprised to sad to weary but the only one that Adora can feel and care about is Catra´s. Her pretty eyes are so sad and so tired that it makes Adora want to pull from her hair and scream.

“It cuts their hair and place them like fucking pieces of fucking art. It told me it wouldn't stop. It *won´t* stop. It's trying to kill who I love. It wants to kill Catra, my Catra and you are still asking her if she is a murderer! And all you are doing is sitting here and asks us the same shit over and over again instead of doing your fucking job!”

Adora gasps, choking in her own breath. There is sweat on her forehead and her throat feels sore, raw by the yelling and the rage. She is standing up, she didn´t even notice when she did it, the chair fallen into the floor and her palms pressed against the table.

Adora takes her hands away, running them through her loose hair instead of slamming them against something again. Her joints ache as she pulls from the golden strands, pushing back tears with her stitched up shoulder and her bruised knuckles, trying as hard as she can to not cry again.

“I´m sorry, I just– I´m so tired of being treated like a prey,” Adora whispers, gulping around a heavy knot on her vocal cords.

Catra is standing up now too, looking at Adora with a thousand silent words inside her eyes. Adora doesn´t know what she sees in her blue eyes, she has never known what Catra sees inside of her, but whatever it is it feels Catra with tenderness. Not with pity, never with pity, but with gentleness and love, reaching Adora inside her own darkness. Catra steps into her space and presses her palm against Adora´s chest, right above her sternum and the golden reliquary, pressing down firmly, pushing back the pain inside Adora´s body with her touch.

Adora exhales against the touch, raising her arms and wrapping them around Catra´s shoulders, bringing her close into a hug. She holds her so hard that for a moment she is worried she might hurt her but Adora cannot stop, cannot have her away for a single second right now.

“You are not a prey,” Huntara says with a sigh, softening her voice. “We are doing all we can but the Mayor´s Office is a mess right now. If the killer is targeting you personally then that's why I need you right here right now more than ever. At least here I can keep an eye on all of you”

“Your officers are not very efficient,” Adora mutters, wrinkling her nose. She saw them from the windows  sleeping like tree trunks inside the car, snoring so hard that if Adora had peeked out her head she would have definitely been able to hear them.

“I know,” Huntara groans, rolling her eyes. “Listen, I know we haven't been the most– efficient with our work sometimes. We– I have failed to do so many things. And I've covered a lot of shit from others,” her voice trails off a little in the end, eyes jumping from Catra´s back to Adora´s eyes so fast that none of them catch it.“But I'm trying to do the best I can to make this person pay.”

“Okay, okay.” Adora accepts, lowering one of her hands to rest it over Bow´s shoulder, seeking his warmth too.

Bow answers immediately, his hands wrapping over hers with a gentle squeeze, the other one still holding Glimmer´s hand softly, kissing her knuckles. Glimmer´s expression is still far away but her eyes seem to be shimmering for something, staring at some point by Huntara´s knees with a thoughtful tilt of her pink head.

“I´ve contacted most of your extended families by now, Bow´s and Doctor Castaspella. I'll talk with them to take you all out of town for now,” Huntara adds, rocking precariously on the chair. “I called Light Hope too but she didn´t answered”

“She is out of town on the hospital in Eternia where she works as a lawyer,” Adora adds, sudden weariness falling over her. She had not been thinking of her in such a long time that it felt like days even if they were just hours, and now that Huntara has mentioned her, a new wave of distrust starts to fester in Adora´s chest. “Call the hospital, they should know where she has gone.”

“Alright then. Get out of here, all of you.” Huntara dismisses them finally, waving her hand towards the corridor that leads to the bedrooms. “And stay inside the motel. If you leave I´ll notice it.”

“I´ll highly doubt it,” Adora mumbles with a roll of her eyes, wrinkling her nose when Huntara shoots her a warning look, “but thank you, Huntara”

“I´ll send the officers some food for you later. For now go back to sleep,” Huntara stands up, throwing her extinguished cigarette into the table. “You'll need it.”

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Lashor sits on the small seat, wiggling uncomfortably. He has never been the most adept or fanatic of this, but Huntara had always insisted that it would help with the weight of things, and after doing it for a few weeks now, even he has to admit she was right.

The dim light of the purple and pink crystals shimmers a little through the holes of the door, illuminating Lashor´s feet and hands, even among the thick darkness inside the wooden box. He doesn´t say anything at first but he knows he is being listened to and after a while he opens his mouth, pouring all that he has to say into the shadows.

“I´m sick of this,” he says, frowning. “Huntara now doesn´t believe the little Weaver bitch is the culprit but there is nobody else that could have done what happened. Everyone has alibis and none of them are known murderers, I don´t know what game Huntara is playing but I don't like it for a single second.”

There is silence for a second and then the calm voice comes, slow, almost like smiling, echoing in the reduced space like a bell blasting off.

“And Adora?”

“Ugh, she is in a secured motel with her rude little pussy and the, now fucking dead too, Mayor´s daughter. Thank you for that by the way.” Lashor bites back the need to spit into the ground. “Huntara gave me the location and dropped them for me to keep them separated. I think she might have thought the other four could be involved in something deeper so she made me be sure the other two would be safe.”

“Does she suspect something?”

“Nothing as far as I know, but she has been going through Angella Bright´s things. She will figure out sooner or later that she came here too.”

“Then she will have to be silenced too, for Adora´s sake, and Etheria´s. Remember, all of this is for something good,” the person at the other side of the crystal wall hums, playing with the hem of the red robe. “It's fine, It's been fun but I am getting tired of this little game too.”

“What are you going to do?” Lashor inquiries, clicking his tongue against his sharp teeth. On the other side the person almost seems to sigh, chuckling very slowly.

“Well, well. If the little hare doesn't come out of her hiding herself, then I´ll have to lure her out myself”

“And how do you plan to do that when they are all on high alert now?”

“Ah, that is simple,” the killer leans its head back, smiling around the smell of blood still lingering on the red, white and green robes. “By going for her heart.”

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“There,” Adora announces brightly, resting her fists against her hips. “Perfectly closed”

She leans back, inspecting her work with bright eyes. The double lock of the door is perfectly closed and the chair below the handle is firmly stuck. There is a clothes hook passed through the look and the other side of the door keeping the door from bursting open and even the little space between the carpet and the door has been covered up by towels. It´s a little bit too much but Adora is not taking her chances right now, and she wants, no, needs a moment for Catra and her only.

Behind her, sitting on the foot of the bed, Catra chuckles, shaking her head softly. She is in the white shirt Adora had handed her and that is way too long for her, covering the start of her thighs and her black underwear, and nothing else, barefoot as she fidgets with her hands resting over her lap. She looks at Adora with fond exasperation, managing the tiniest of smiles.

"No door is unbreakable, Dora," she says in a whisper, looking at the barricaded door with an arched eyebrow. Adora looks at the door too with her nose wrinkled, thinking so hard that her eyes cross and Catra laughs again.

"Well if someone wants to burst in they´ll have to go through *me* first," Adora sets forth after a few seconds, raising her arms to the sides and flexing her biceps for Catra to admire.

On any other occasion Catra would have rolled her eyes and joked to Adora about how full of herself she is, but her sarcasm dies down on her throat when Adora moves. With that strap white shirt and the shorts to match, Adora´s chest and back strains against the fabric, muscles firm against the soft cotton, outlining the shape of her shoulder blades, neck, her abdomen and the round edge of her breasts.

Much to Catra´s dismay, she giggles, actually literally giggles, face beet red and ears burning. Adora drops the light hearted position, her eyes softening at the sound of Catra´s laugh ringing inside the cozy room. She loves her laugh, she has missed it so much.

Adora has to admit, even for an old motel, once the curtains are pulled closed and the light of the lamp is soft sun-like, the carpet doesn´t look as ugly and the bed looks so much softer. Especially if the love of her life is sitting there, her cheek pink and her body relaxed.

Adora pads over the carpeted floor until she reaches the end of the bed too, sitting at the left of Catra. It's kind of funny and all kinds of tender because where Adora´s legs are so long they splay over the beige carpet in front of her, Catra´s toes barely touch the floor. Adora looks at this and laughs and Catra notices, pushing Adora softly from the shoulder, a glimpse of their usual banter and mirth sparking between them.

They are very quiet for a second but it's not uncomfortable, not like the silences in the lobby had been. This silence is more tender, softer in all edges, cradling them too in comfort and quietness. It feels nice, existing right next to Catra, breathing her air and nuzzling in the warmth of her body leaning against her arm and shoulder. It´s nice and cozy, smelling the clean soap of her hair and the sandalwood of her skin, even as clean sweat starts to gather on the back of her nape by the warmth of the room. Adora loves this single moment, breathing it in and drinking from it until Catra is all that she can feel.

Adora fidgets with her left hand, closed into a soft fist, holding back her racing heart. Catra doesn´t notice it, too distracted by drowning herself in Adora next to her. The touch of her long golden hair against the curve of her bare shoulder, the apple-like smell of her breath, the pink clustering on her cheeks like pressed roses and the shimmering of her blue and silver eyes as she looks at Catra like she had hung up the stars in the sky only for her to admire.

Adora is *looking* at her, with so much meaning and so much adoration that Catra cannot hold back the shiver running down her spine and raising her skin on point, craving to be even closer to Adora than she is right now.

“What?” Catra asks, shiness buried in fake annoyance, softly pressing the pad of her finger against Adora´s big forehead below her messy blonde bangs. “You are making a weird face.”

Adora huffs at her, gently taking Catra's wrist inside her right hand and lowering it down. Adora plays absently with Catra's fingers, pressing the pads of her own over the sharp ends of her black nails. Like this, she can feel Catra's pulse on her palm. Like this, Adora can feel her so close inside her heart that she cannot hold herself back anymore.

“Today it's your birthday,” Adora whispers and it's all kinds of sweet and gentle but it's also sad, the way in which she says it. Nostalgic, regretful almost, mournful to have to say this in these circumstances but exhilarating too, because this is Catra and Adora loves her in every single moment of their lives.

Catra blinks back at her, obviously stunned by the affirmation. She looks around the room staring at the soft lamps and the bold numbers of the clock that mark six in the evening, their bags of clothes on the floor and tiny pumpkin Adora picked up from the kitchen for Catra to adorn their temporary room. All those little knickers and tiny specks of light that tell her that yes, today is October 28th. She is twenty one now.

“It is,” Catra nods, tilting her head.

Her birthday had never been something too special to her, neither something that was celebrated at her home. It must have, before her father passed away, but those memories were so far away now that they looked almost buried in the edges, covered by a mist of time. Like a dream she wasn´t sure she had at all in the first place. And the only reason she celebrated later in her life was always Adora, in the Montenegro house or later just the two of them sharing the tiniest birthday cake under the moonlight.

Catra has the impulse to shrug but she doesn't, catching the way Adora's eyes shimmer, oh so blue with a glint of sadness. The way she is looking at Catra is like every single time she looks at her,

with her heart on her sleeve, but also so much more, heavy like fresh honey and tender. Her eyes are so bright that anything that Catra wants to say evaporates immediately off her head, leaving her gaping and breathless for a second.

“I was going to make you something special,” Adora grasps a bouncing curl between her fingers, tucking it gently behind Catra's ear., caressing her cheekbone with her thumb. “I had a whole day planned and everything”

Catra takes a slow deep breath, feeling the way her cheek and ears color immediately into red. She still rolls her eyes though, huffing a little to alleviate the sudden fluttering inside her ribcage.

“Yeah, you love plans,” Catra mutters, looking at the duvet beside her, pulling from the fabric absently. She hums, slowly turning back to look at Adora´s face. She doesn't even feel her move. “I really don't feel like parties anyway–”

Catra´s breath hitches on her throat,  surprise and tenderness blooming in her lungs and clogging her throat, suddenly, gently, like a sun peeking golden through heavy clouds of rain. Adora has extended her left hand towards her, right in front of Catra´s colorful eyes, holding between her thumb and her index the small object she had hidden on her palm. The warm light of the lamps catches on the gems on the ring softly.

“Who said anything about a party?”

Adora´s voice is the softest it has ever been but also the most nervous, an edge of anxiety clinging in her sweet words. Her eyes are the most silver Catra has ever seen them too, pools of mercury and cobalt worshiping Catra´s profile with their tenderness. And if her own eyes weren't locked on the tiny ring held gently in Adora´s fingers, she would see they are blurred by unspilled tears, making Adora flush in soft pink.

Suddenly Catra´s brain has become moss and she is out of words, the voice she had long ago lost pulling from the cords of her throat and the strings of her heart. Tenderness and love and also, for some reason, fear start to flood inside her heart, spilling out into her lungs and ribcage and throat. Love, unspeakable love for Adora, but also the scratch of fear that this might just be another dream, another hallucination hunting her down and eating her heart, about to rip her away from Adora again.

"It´s–"

"My mom's ring," Adora whispers, catching a tiny tear from Catra´s eyelashes with her other hand. She must see the way Catra´s heart is pulling from inside her eyes because her face melts even more.

"Before the accident she told me she would give it to me when I was ready. I didn't understand then but I do now," Adora cradles Catra´s cheek inside her palm, reassuring her gently, softly, as reverently as she can, hoping that, by touch alone, Catra will understand the amount of love Adora holds for her. "I think, even then, she knew I loved you. She knew I would spent the rest of my life with you"

Catra hiccups around a sob, unable to contain the tears anymore. She lets them fall freely down her scratched cheeks and bruised lips, falling quietly over her lap. Adora is crying too now, for a very different reason than fear or anger or terror, She is weeping for love and what better reason is there to be than crying your heart out for the woman you adore.

"Catra?" Adora calls her name, guiding her face gently so she is looking at her eyes again. "You are the love of my life but you already know that"

Catra wrinkles her nose and giggles around a wet sob, her eyes narrowing softly when she tries to stop crying and she can. Adora smiles softly at her, catching every single tear but still standing a little bit away. She wants to kiss her more than anything right

now, but she needs to say this first. She needs for Catra to hear it, to understand it, to believe how much Adora adores her and loves her. She needs Catra to hear all the reasons why Adora wants to marry her more than anything in her life.

Adora wets her bottom lip with her tongue, breathing deep several times. Her hand runs from Catra´s cheek to the side of her jaw, barely brushing the start of the scar that lives in there and Adora hopes absently that Catra also understands that Adora loves her with everything and every single part of her, no matter how soft or how bruised. Catra is looking at her so softly, so urgently too, that she is not able to hold back a single word anymore.

"You are– you are my soul walking outside my body. You are my heart breathing in this world." Adora smiles at Catra´s hazel and blue eyes, the corner of hers wrinkling tenderly. "You are all of my joy and all of my laughter. You are all of my sunny days and all the drops of the rain. You are all of my tears too because every single part of me belongs to you. Because you have loved everything about me no matter how ugly or how wonderful. You ´ve loved me even when I wasn't as perfect as everyone wanted me to be. You loved me even when I was stupid and pushed you away and I will never be deserving of your love but I want it all the same."

Catra whimpers around a cry, looking down between them to try and tamper her own tears away. Adora rests her nose against Catra´s forehead, nudging her softly,

"You are my hands. You are my eyes. You are my skin. You are my heart and my life. You are my beginning. You are my last vow." Adora´s thumb brushes gently over Catra´s lilac eyelids, ghosting over the freckles that live in her cheekbones and that she has spent so many hours counting over and over again, marveled every single time a new one comes into life. "You are everything I ever wanted or wished for and every single day I'm grateful that I could find you so early in my life because otherwise

I would have spent every single second searching for you, until the end of my days”

Adora drops her hand, taking Catra´s trembling one between her fingers and bringing it to her lips, kissing her knuckles with shivering lips. “We are going to survive together. And after I want to marry you, if you want to.”

Catra giggles, the tight knot inside her throat making her voice squeaky and softer than anything she has felt before. She can feel Adora´s golden eyelashes brushing against her cheeks, the ghost of her pink lips brushing over her forehead and patched up temple without getting to kiss her fully. She smells good, clean, like old wood and lavenders. She smells like home and Catra knows she will never be able to love anybody like this, she will never love anybody else that is not Adora. Catra will love her in every single way and with all the forces of her heart and soul until the end of this life and all the others. Until the very end of the universe itself, until there is nothing more but stardust and darkness and them gravitating around each other. Adora is Catra´s heart and soul too, she is her home, and there is not a single world where she won´t reach for her, and there is not a single world where Adora will not come back for her.

“For how long have you been holding on to that?” Catra asks, trembling and damp. Any other day her voice like this would have made her cringe but today it just makes her cheeks red. Catra doesn´t only mean the ring and Adora knows that, smiling around the words.

“Since I was fourteen,” Adora whispers, pressing a kiss over Catra ´s cheek and leaning away, just so she can search for her eyes on hers. “It has always been yours, even when I didn´t know if I could have you”

Catra looks at her with round, wide eyes, her breath catching in her lungs. “You've been waiting for seven years?”

“Longer,” Adora admits, exhaling when Catra´s warm fingers wrap around her wrist, nuzzling inside Adora´s cold hand. “And still waiting, technically”

Catra´s eyes shimmer with emotions, looking at Adora with all the tenderness of the world. “Of course yes, dummy.”

Adora smiles and leans forwards, following the gravity on her own sun, her lips meeting Catra´s in a sweet caress. They both sigh when their mouths touch, exhaling on each other's throats at the taste of each other. Catra´s hands come up, cupping Adora´s jaw between busted fingers, holding her as close as she could possibly be, her tongue painting swirls over the roof of Adora´s mouth and the soft surface of her tongue. Adora hums around her teeth, barely managing to not drop the ring when she wraps her arms over Catra´s waist, feeling the rise and fall of her chest against hers.

They lean back just a second, just one, just enough so Catra can hold her trembling hand in the air and Adora can slip the delicate ring on its place, the finger and the hand that will be its home forevermore. The jewels are placed like petals, six tiny opals around a central alexandrite, cradled in gold and old fashioned, it lived in the hand of Adora´s mother for a long time, the only heritance she could keep after Mara left and that now lives over the soft dark skin of Catra´s finger.

“How does it fit so well?” Catra asks, cleaning the errand tears of her eyes. Adora chuckles, lingering kisses all over Catra´s temples.

“I measured your finger while you slept. You are a very heavy sleeper, you know?” Adora runs her fingers against Catra´s nape, lulling her with the gentle touch. “I had it resized when we came back from the cabin”

Catra turns her head to look at her from below her eyelashes. The corners of her eyes are a little bit red from the tears but her

mouth is turning up with a smile, curling the gentle dimple in her cheekbone that Adora is so fond of.

"I really do love you. I love you so much, did you know that?" Catra murmurs, running her fingers over Adora´s busted hands. Adora smiles around a tiny sob too, caressing the shell of Catra´s ears with soft fingers.

"I do," Adora leans forward again, letting her eyes fall closed once more, "I love you too."

They kiss again, for long and sweet minutes, lips meeting, separating and reaching for each other again. Catra rests her hands over Adora´s shoulders, avoiding the stitches as much as possible, and Adora holds her waist between her palms, painting invisible circles on the soft skin below the shirt.

Catra feels all of her emotions bubbling inside her chest and throat, passing through her lips into a giggle, laughing warmly and full of joy right against Adora´s mouth. Adora smiles too, peppering kisses over each single freckle of her face, drinking in Catra´s laughter and feeling the same kind of joy filling her from head to toe, a happiness so honest and so tender like neither of them had felt in a long time. Free, it tastes sweet like freedom and warm like love.

"Come here," Adora says between kisses, standing up from the bed. Catra looks at her with suspicious eyes full of mirth, her cheeks colored in red. The ring in her finger feels light as a feather, a ribbon of red and golden tidying them together already.

"What are we doing now?"

Adora wiggles her eyebrows, leaning towards Catra into a deep Bow, her hand stretched in front of her in a silent question. "Our first dance."

Catra can´t help the laughter escaping her mouth, so completely fond of Adora that she feels like her heart is going to burst out of her chest and fly into the night sky.

“We´ve danced before,” Catra points out smugly, sliding her hand into Adora´s calloused palm, allowing her to help her stand up in her tippy toes. “I taught you to dance"

“You did,” Adora agrees, placing her hand on the small of Catra´s back. Her other hand comes up, running gently through the length of Catra´s arm and lacing her fingers together, holding their joined hands against her heart. “But today I'll be guiding you”

Catra hums, tethering in her feet. Adora shifts their weights then, carrying Catra ever so slightly off the floor, just enough so Catra´s bare feet can stand right over Adora´s socks, holding all of Catra ´s weight against her own chest and alleviating the pull of Catra´s knee.

Catra blushes at the change of positions, ever so slightly starting to rock them back and forth gently, tucking her head against Adora´s neck. She smells like home. “Good”

They don´t have music but they don´t need it. Adora surprises Catra by not only rocking them from side to side but actually giving a step forward, moving Catra alongside her with ease. Catra giggles against her neck and then her giggles become a full blown laughter when Adora spins them both into a small circle, barely avoiding tripping them both into the carpet by some sweet grace.

Catra steps down on her good leg to keep their balance and Adora takes sweet advantage of that, twirling Catra under her arm, making sure the whole time that her bad knee is free of the pressure and smiling from ear to ear when Catra laughs so hard that it echoes through the whole bedroom. Catra lets herself be guided, closing her eyes and trusting in Adora´s arms to catch her.

Adora gathers her inside her arms again and wraps her gently over her chest, humming very sweet and low under her breath, little sounds like the start of a song filling the space between

them. She could never sing like Catra used to be, but where Catra ´s voice has failed she can fill in the cracks, and if Catra has lost the music in her life then Adora will make the music herself just so she can keep dancing with her inside her arms.

" *Dance, dance, only with me near your heart,* " Adora sings in a whisper against Catra´s ears. An old song she remembers her father used to sing to her mother when they danced across the kitchen floor. *"Dance, dance, lean close to me. Never to part"*

Catra´s breath stops inside her lungs, her heart giving a jump at the sound of Adora´s voice next to her head. Adora´s eyes and hands are so tender wherever they see and touch Catra´s body and skin, her voice low and her mouth pulled into a small smile, giving Catra songs she had not spoken in such a long time. She wraps her fingers on the soft golden hair on Adora´s nape and leans her forehead against the column of her neck, unable to keep the warm tears from coming to her cheeks, dripping gently against Adora´s collarbones.

" *Dance, only with me* ," Adora murmurs, placing a soft kiss on the crown of Catra´s head. "´ *Til all our sweet music is gone"*

They come into a soft stop just as the song finishes, breathing in each other´s air. They both lean back to look at the other, chests slow and heartbeats drumming so hard that the other can feel it in their fingertips.

Adora looks at Catra, bright multicolored eyes, red cheeks, soft dark skin, her curls caressing her face like the frame of a priceless painting, and she knows deep in her heart she could never love more than she loves her right now and yet she also knows that she will. Every single second of every single day that is to come, Adora will love her more and more until there is no more love in this universe to give and yet she still will find a way to love her more.

Catra looks at Adora and exhales, looking at her silver and blue eyes, the moles kissing her face like constellations over pink

nebulas, the honey of her hair and the red of her lips and she knows Adora is hers and Catra is Adora´s, to love and to nurture and to protect no matter what. She knows they do share a soul after all, finding each other through thousands of years of the fabric of the universe and the wheel of time. She knows she has found a home next to Adora´s heart and in exchange Adora has placed her own heart inside Catra´s palm and trusts her to cherish it and Catra will. With all her devotion she will.

Catra cradles Adora´s jaw between her palms, pressing her thumb against her lips. Marveled, she is marveled that she actually gets to have Adora, to hold her in her arms. She will never stop being marveled at the fact that she does not deserve her yet she has her, in every single way, in all the ways they are and could be and will be, Catra has her.

Adora caresses her waist, still holding her against her chest, and they kiss again, open mouthed and warm and filled with unspoken desire. Whoever that hasn't kissed like them does not know about passion. Whoever that has not loved like them does not know about devotion.

This time the kiss is intense, still full of love and tenderness but also coated in desire, sour and satisfying. Thirsty, craving for delicious deliverance. After so much fear and terror, after so much sadness and violence, they need each other more than ever. Bodies sliding against each other, mouths pressing, tongues dancing never fighting, inhaling the breath of the other's lungs and caressing necks and waist like pieces of marble.

Adora gasps against Catra's sweet mouth, licking a line against her upper lip and the end of her angel bites, absorbing the shiver that runs down Catra's feverish spine right after. Her heart is a mess, happy and chaotic all at the same time, crawling its way out of Adora's body to nestle next to Catra's heart. And Adora *craves.* She wants and she desires more than anything right now but even knowing Catra has given herself to her today and a thousand times before, she still needs to ask.

“Can my hands really touch you?” Adora whispers against Catra's ears, blue eyes bright as moons, caressing her cheekbone with her fingertips.

“Yes,” Catra murmurs, her eyes falling closed, letting her head roll back on Adora's sure hold.

“Can my lips really kiss you?” Adora begs against Catra's jaw, painting a line of kisses over the corners of her mouth, worshiping every single freckle and mole and tiny scar with her breath.

“Yes”

“Can my tongue really taste you?” Adora pleads for consent against Catra's collarbones, brushing her palms against Catra´s bare ribs, cradling the gentle curve of her breast between her trembling fingers.

“Yes,” Catra gasps, a whimper and an acceptance all at the same time, digging her fingers over Adora´s shoulderblades to bring her as close as possible.

“My love,” Adora says, searching for Catra´s misted eyes again. Catra is already drowsy and sleepy in her arms, body melting and giving herself completely but even there Adora needs to reassure her first. That not sleeping together today or any other day doesn´t mean there is absence of love. That she can step away if she wants and Adora will respect her body and her choices and will find a thousand other ways to worship her and love her anyway. “We don't have to”

Catra looks at her in silence, blinking very slowly, trying to make sense of why exactly has Adora stopped. “You don´t want to?”

“I do. I always want you.” Adora rushes to say gently, lingering a kiss over Catra´s warm forehead. Still, the stab of guilt deepens further inside of Adora´s heart, screaming at her how selfish she is for this. “I just– so much it's going on, so much shit has been happening to us because of me.”

“It's not your fault, princess”

“It is. And I– I want to protect you,” Adora says in a gulp of air, suddenly frantic, twirling Catra´s soft curls across her fingers. “I want to shelter you. That's all that matters to me. So we don´t have to do anything at all–”

“Adora,” Catra whispers, sore and painfully honest, cradling Adora's face between her hands and stopping her spiraling thoughts. She looks at Adora as if she were the most wonderful thing in the entire world. “Wed me”

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Adora's breath hitches inside her throat, her pupils blowing up overtaking the cobalt and silver inside her irises. She takes a second longer to stare at Catra's pretty face in front of her, her long eyelashes and freckled cheeks and surges forwards, slotting their lips back together.

Catra hiccups against her mouth, her eyes falling closed the second their lips meet again, ready to embrace each other in every single way possible. Her heart is hammering inside her chest yet is the steadiest it had ever been, drumming again and again inside her ribcage until it's beating and Adora's sweet lips are the only thing she can feel.

As always, Adora is sweet, as gentle as she could ever be, but there is something else in her mouth too. Something bittersweet and tingling like a sour patch. An edge of eagerness, of lovely desperation, of desire drenched in love. Her body aflame as she wraps her hands around Catra's waist and runs her fingers below her sleep shirt, feeling her with her fingertips, drinking on Catra's warmth, alive and tender, right below her hardened palms.

In a way it feels like so much more than just bedding each other. Tonight it feels so much more meaningful than their first time together, eighteen in the quiet room of a cabin. It feels like so much more, so much sweeter, so much more wonderful and at the

same time sorrowful. Souls meeting and desperately trying to hold onto each other, greeting the other, waving their strands together like roots, embroidering in each other´s lives in knots.

It feels like wedding to one another, like vows without words shared, like promises spilled in the other's mouth. Here in this quiet and plain hostel room with the warm light of the night lamp and the thick curtains and the soft bed.

Adora leans back from Catra's mouth with a gasp and she misses her immediately but she moves around her, across her, ghosting her pink lips over Catra's cheekbones into feathering kisses, so sweet and tender they make Catra sigh. Adora travels up and down, making all the traces of Catra's face like a starry map, learning her all over again. She caresses her forehead and the dip of her jaw, the secret mole that lives behind her eyebrow, the hidden kiss on the corner of her lips, running her palms below Catra's soft nightshirt and holding her so close next to her own heart that she can feel her living and breathing right there, nuzzled against her heart.

“Tell me what you want,” Adora whispers in the shell on Catra’s ear, absorbing her shiver inside her arms.

“Undress me,” Catra answers back, just as low, barely containing a whimper when Adora licks a line against her mouth. sweat gathering on her bottom lip before kissing her again, a silent confirmation that she is listening.

Adora lets her hands travel up until her thumbs hook with the edges of the white shirt, tugging from the clothes carefully, so gentle that when it reaches Catra's neck that the latter has to bite back her tears. Adora helps her out of it gently and slowly, brushing her hair back in place once the fabric is gone.

Like this. Catra is almost completely bare to the world, skin vulnerable and open under the lamp. She is not wearing a bra or a compression top below so the skin of her breasts rise in goosebumps with the warm air, dark nipples and freckled curves

that Adora knows by heart and that she cannot keep her eyes away from. Adora raises her palm and gently cups them again between her fingers, running her thumb right over the hardened pebble as she leans and kisses Catra´s mouth once more.

Catra doesn´t even try to bite back the moan that escapes her throat and echoes between their mouths, her eyes rolling back on her head just by the touch of Adora´s fingers alone. Adora hums against her lips, resting a single kiss more against the divot of her jaw and the column of her neck before lowering down, falling over her knees in front of Catra.

Catra´s breath stops inside her lungs at the sight of Adora like this, right in front of her, kneeling like a devotee that has stumbled with an errand angel. And Adora is looking at her in that way again, the way that speaks of undeniable devotion and unbreakable love. The one that makes Adora´s eyes shine so blue that they look like oceans in the middle of her face and that makes Catra´s heart fly into the dark sky by their weight alone. Catra cannot help raising her own hands, placing themselves at the sides of Adora´s face and cradling her cheek and her forehead once again, observing her so marveled by her existence alone that Catra has to blink several times to convince herself that this is not a dream.

From her place on her knees, Adora smiles at her, soft and tender, mirroring Catra´s wonder as she looks back at her too. Adora´s hands rest over Catra´s shins and then travel up, across the entire length of Catra´s lean legs in a faint touch, wrapping her palms on the back of Catra´s hurt knee and lifting it gently, bringing it towards her face. Adora kisses her knee with reverential touch, right against the dark compression sleeve and then above it, on the skin that lives there, hoping that with touch alone it will heal faster.

Catra is beyond words by now, her eyes locked on Adora´s beautiful face, hands on her face and dark hair falling like curtains where she leans to look at her better, hiding them both in the privacy of shared darkness.

Adora´s hands start moving again, up and up the fine hair on her legs until they reach the external face of her thighs, resting warm and slightly sticky fingers there. Catra holds her breath and returns Adora´s heavy stare, nodding in consent. Adora´s thumbs hook against the sides of the black underwear and pull down, rolling the tender fabric across thighs, knees and legs and taking it out with so much devotion that Catra´s knees almost buckle underneath her. Even then, she is sure Adora would catch her.

Adora leaves the fabric and returns to her journey, her breath hot and eyes so bright and blown out that th black of her pupils almost drowns the blue completely. Catra is so close now, so close to her nose and her lips and the tip of her tongue that Adora can taste her already, damp like morning dew and ready, but she doesn´t dive forward to that secret place only both of them know.

Instead, Adora rests her lips right over her navel, between soft skin painted with beautiful stretch marks and the thick curly dark hair below. Adora breathes on Catra´s body and can perceive the perfume of her skin and the slight sweat living there, perspiration and excitement traveling through both of them. Adora´s mouth moves upwards again, reaching the tender rolls on Catra´s abdomen, nuzzling her nose against Catra´s belly button and smiling when she feels Catra´s hands tremble around her hair.

Adora´s hands rest over Catra´s knee and the low of her waist and she kisses her belly, looking up at Catra´s face through her golden eyelashes, waiting for whatever Catra wishes to do next. Catra looks at her with her chest rising and falling rapidly, a red blush quickly staining from her cheeks through her entire face and collarbones, making even the soft start of her breast to flush.

She doesn´t want for Adora to move ever again, content on being like this for the rest of their lives, but there is just so much craving Catra can hold inside her chest and right now it is spilling out of her ribcage, twisting her and pushing her to pulls from Adora´s lovely face and motion her to stand up again avidly.

Adora does so immediately, no need for words, holding her balance when Catra´s lovely hands fall from her hair and face to her shoulders, pushing the straps on her own white tank top down her shoulder, mindful always of the stitches. Adora doesn´t care about stitches though, or about brushes or about phantom pain. She breathes deep and allows Catra to run her palms down her biceps and elbows, pushing and pushing from the shirt until it pools next to Adora´s wide hips and then falls over the floor with a flop next to her shorts.

Adora leans her forehead against Catra´s and sighs deeply, guarding inside her heart the way Catra´s trembling hands run up and down her arms, feeling with her soft pads and sharp nails all the little crevices in Adora´s skin, traveling from her arms to her shoulders and then down, across chest and ribs and on the the side of her stomach, where other scars live.

There are blasting scars on Adora´s body, right there, made of the crashing car of her parents when the accident happened and Adora barely made it out alive. And then another ones, lines of pale pink and whitened skin crossing Adora´s back and waist. For a long time, Adora hated those scars, despised them, held grudges to them, angry at the painful reminders that for some reason she was the only one left alive. For the longest time, Adora couldn´t look at herself in the mirror without feeling anger at herself. But then there was Catra. Eighteen and finally together after years of confusion. Catra and her sweet hands and her devoted touch, her lips over them and her hands caressing them in the same way she does now, saving Adora all over again, helping her heal from the pain.

Adora does not hate those scars anymore. She thanks them, every single day she thanks them for keeping her alive just enough so she could hold Catra inside her arms after all.

Adora rests her temple over the crown of Catra´s head and exhales, looking at Catra´s fingers tracing all the edges and soft red patches. She wants to say something but all her words leave her immediately, soaking in the feeling of Catra adoring her too,

worshiping too, breathing against her neck and kissing the edge of her jaw. She is still so soft, even when Adora knows how restless she is becoming, even when she can almost smell the slick excitement running on the inside of her thighs, eliciting Adora´s fire and desire for her like a torch blasting into blue fire.

"Tell me," Adora begs in a whisper, squeezing Catra´s skin with reverent touch.

"Lay–" Ctara takes a breath, wetting her dry lips, unable to be ashamed of the way her voice breaks at the sound of Adora´s raw plea. "Lay on bed for me?"

Adora nods against her head, taking Catra´s wrists between sure fingers and bringing her hands towards her face just so she can place one more kiss against her knuckles before moving forward.

Catra looks at her with breath held as Adora climbs the white bed and lays on the soft duvet, body bare and exposed to Catra´s eyes. Her back rests over the round pillows, cradling her hips, shoulder and neck and her legs fall long and slightly open in front of her, staring back at Catra´s blushing face with tender patience.

Like this Catra can see all of her, from the red and bruised skin of her shoulder and the side of her ribcage to the honey and milk of her skin, moles like kisses scattered all over her face and limbs. She can see the fine blonde hair on her legs and armpits and on the low of her navel, the thick line that widens between her limbs and that Catra adores. She can see pink lips in her mouth and then pink lips below, slightly brown in the edges and damp too, eager and awaiting for Catra to move when she wishes to.

Catra exhales and balances on tethering legs, following Adora over the bed. It's not their bed at the cabin and it's not Adora´s bed at Light Hope´s house, but it is still theirs for tonight, holding their bodies as they embrace each other.

Catra is careful but her knee still protests over the movement and Adora shoots her a worried look that Catra pushes back with

gentleness. Catra crosses her leg over Adora's hip and sits on her lap, careful of not hurting the wide slash on Adora´s side. She rests her palms at either side of Adora's throat, lowering her hips very slowly, brushing the skin of Adora's belly against her aching slit as they finally meet.

The touch is so overwhelming, even like this, that Catra needs a whole second to breathe and not come undone in the edges, gasping and moaning when every one of Adora´s breaths makes their skins slide together slick and hot. Adora looks at her from her place on the soft pillows with such a beautiful expression that Catra hiccups with pleasure, her hips twitching forwards softly, chasing the passionate touch with eagerness. Now that they are finally together, none of them can wait anymore.

Adora lays on the bed completely, body relaxed, her hands next to her head tangled with the golden strands of her own hair and her mouth ajar. staring back at Catra´s flushed face with so much devotion inside her heart that she has to make a physical effort not to shoot forward and worship her immediately. She lets her move as she pleases, chasing her own pleasure and firing up Adora´s with every single rock of her hips.

Adora can feel her wet lips against her abdomen, sweat and slickness mingling together, making them dance on steps only they know of each other. Wet sounds start to rise inside the calm room, sloppy and damp like ocean waves that nestle inside Adora ´s ears and make their home inside her memories forever. She wants to remember every single second of this, the night they wed each other in the warm room of the last safe place in the world.

Catra rides Adora´s belly sweet and heated, so lost suddenly inside the haze of pleasure that her hands resting at the sides of Adora´s neck twitch and press forwards a little, slightly choking Adora out of her breath. Catra´s eyes widen and her body locks for a second with alarm, mouth fallen open with a moan and an apology knitted together, taking her hands away from Adora´s chest.

Adora stops her before she can go much further, holding her wrists between warm fingers. She shakes her head, licking her own sticky lips before talking, breath so hot it rises like fog between their heated bodies.

“Keep them,” Adora begs her, moaning right after, pulling from Catra´s hands until they are back around her neck. She likes it, she is hungry for them, the feeling of Catra´s sharp nails against her skin. “You can keep them there.”

Catra gasps, her face hot with their love making, feeling her entire body shivering at the same time her folds skin Adora´s skin. “But–”

“Catra,” Adora whines, lifting her hips at the same time Catra rolls her down, helping her brush them together deeper and lower, slicker. “I need you.”

Catra whimpers, unable to contain a moan, her upper body falling forward a little. Her hands wrap around the base of Adora´s neck and rest her weight there, careful to not squeeze down painfully or to cut Adora´s breath but still hard enough that her nails prick the frail skin of her nape.

Adora gasps, her eyes rolling back in her head at the feeling of Catra's hands on her throat and her folds rubbing damp against her abdomen. Adora has never really enjoyed friction nor penetration, not by her own hand, not even from Catra´s. It´s just a part of who she is and she could either have it on certain occasions or live the rest of her life with neither. But this, Catra´s pleasuring herself with Adora´s body, looking at her precious face wrinkling with lust and desire, hearing her pants and moan above her  and feeling her hands over her body, this makes it for Adora so much better than anything else. This is Adora´s source of pleasure, Catra´s.

She lifts her knees and plants her soles firmly over the duvet, lifting and lowering her hips at Catra´s rhythm, moving her entire body with her as she rides the starts of her first orgasm against

Adora´s skin. Catra´s eyebrows twitch and knit together, her eyes narrowing almost closed and mouth falling open, kiss bitten lips and crystalline spit coating the sensitive skin. All those little signs Adora  has come to learn mark the crumble before the fall, overwhelmed and about to spill like a cascade.

"Oh, love," Adora moans, wrapping her hands around Catra´s waist. Her palms are so big that they almost circle Catra completely, thumbs touching over her navel. "My love"

" *Ah!"*

Catra is out of words, looking at Adora from beyond the haze of pleasure, her eyes misted over by warm tears. Her forehead is coated in sweat and her hair is damp already, skin flushed and hot. Adora loves her, she adores her with her entire heart. She looks at her coming in pieces above her, around her, against her and Adora loves her more than anything. The sweet ring that joins them together rests over Catra´s dark skin and her skin over Adora´s pink throat.

"That's it. You are so pretty, so beautiful like this," Adora is whispering, panting and moaning too. "Are you going to cum?"

" *Ah! Hah!* Y– yes, yes. *Ah!"* Catra whines, biting over her bottom lip so hard that it colors red immediately, inciting Adora to devour them again. Still, Adora remains where she is right now, holding Catra´s hips, barely realizing that she is holding down so hard that she might bruise in the morning, the pads of Adora´s reverent fingers painted on her skin like reminders of devotion.

"You are so beautiful, *ah,* " Adora fights a wave of pleasure, holding herself back. She cannot lose sight of Catra´s face, not right now, not when she is like this. She doesn´t want to miss a single thing even though her own hips are coated in slick.

"I want to take you after you come. Is that okay?" Adora seeks permission, waiting until Catra is looking at her again, turquoise and hazel eyes overtaken by her pupils, so big and bright that

Adora can see herself reflected inside of them, Messed up blonde hair over white pillows and silver eyes.

“I want to be inside of you. Here.” Adora presses her thumb over Catra´s belly, caressing the tender skin in a circle. And Catra knows what she means in a heartbeat because she whimpers when Adora runs her thumb down, ghosting it sweetly over her aching clit. “ *Here”*

*“Yes, yes,”* Catra accepts, nodding furiously. Her hands lose their grip around Adora´s throat and she falls forward, barely avoiding crashing against Adora when she presses them against the duvet instead. Her hips are moving desperately now, chasing the high frantically.

Adora sits up, unable to stay away from Catra for a second longer. She lifts from the pillows and wraps her arms around Catra´s waist, taking Catra's breast inside her mouth. She kisses and sucks immediately, kissing the soft nipples and licking them with the tip of her tongue. Watching with tender eyes as Catra almost bends herself completely around her tongue, digging her sharp nails against Adora´s scalp.

The change of position makes their bodies slide together in a different way, Catra´s damp slick bumping softly over Adora´s engorged clit, and that is the only thing Catra needs to come undone completely.

*“AH”* Catra wraps her arms around Adora´s golden head and exhales loudly, cuming against her belly. Adora gasps at the feeling too, feeling Catra spilling over her skin freely.

“There you go,” Adora coos her, pressing kisses over her shoulders and collarbones. “So good, so beautiful Cat, so incredible beauty. I love you so much”

“ *Ah,* I love you,” Catra gasps around a drowned hiccup, out of breath. “I love you, Adora”

Adora holds her through it, gently tending to the shivers echoing across her body from the orgasm. Catra rests her entire weight over Adora´s body, leaning her sweaty face against Adora´s damp hair, fighting to regain her consciousness and her breath.

Her hips are still twitching every once in a while, spent but not satiated just yet, searching for the touch of their skins once again. Adora smiles when she realizes what is happening, pressing her mouth against Catra´s jaw.

"Sweetheart," Adora nuzzles the side of her neck with her cheek, ghosting her lips over the starts of the scar without getting to touch it at all. "You are very wet"

Catra´s entire body shivers at the words, a new rush of fresh slick running down her thighs and dripping between their bodies like rain. She is more than ready now, this Adora knows. Catra knows it too because now that the floodgates have been opened she doesn´t seem to be able to stop.

Very carefully Catra untangles herself from Adora´s limbs, already missing her once they lean away. Catra makes a real effort of not falling in the bed with a flop, climbing down from Adora´s lap and rolling against the duvet face down. She tilts her head to the side over the pillow, catching Adora´s black eyes and making sure she is looking very well when she plants her knees on the bed and lifts her hips over the air, open and exposed for Adora to take as she wishes.

Adora almost falls from the bed by how quickly she moves, jumping down the blankets and messed up sheets to reach their bags. She wants to defend herself to Catra and explain to her that she did not, in fact, pack the strap hoping something would happen. That it was there to begin with, clean and probably forgotten by Adora´s scrambled mind from their last day in their cabin before the start of the courses. That they had others and she just forgot and noticed it was there when they were changing clothes and still she never hoped they would use it tonight.

But all thoughts fly away in her mind when she slides inside the black harness and turns around to face Catra again, catching the expression in her eyes. Her cheek is pressed against the pillow and her pupils are wide like full moons, staring at the strap hanging between Adora´s legs with her mouth ajar and slick. She looks completely fucked already and completely out of it, hips rolling in the air every few seconds, pushing against the invisible pressure as she begs with her eyes for Adora to hurry up and hold her again.

Adora rushes back to her side in a heartbeat, climbing over the bed without even thinking about it. She looks at Catra´s slick folds, taking in the sweet sight of them with reverent eyes. Absently she thinks about looking up for lube on the bag too but Catra is already so slick when she looks at her, pulsing pink and wet that she knows she doesn´t need it at all.

There is a point in Catra´ back that Adora loves. It is a hidden spot in the middle of her spine, between the sweet rolls that form on her waist and the lumbar vertebrae, a tender corner clustered in freckles like kisses that Adora only gets to see when they are sleeping or when Adora is bedding Catra from the back. She likes to press her thumbs against it, likes to lower her mouth and linger kisses over it. She can see it now as she wraps her hands around Catra´s waist and Catra moans into the pillow, already tasting what is to come. Adora loves this little spot and for that she leans down to ghost her lips over it, caressing it with a gentle whisper.

"I´ve got you," Adora murmurs, kissing it lovingly before leaning back.

Adora shifts her hold on Catra´s body, softly but firmly pushing from her to the side until Catra´s legs give up and she falls back into the duvet, cushioned by Adora´s hands and the blankets. Catra has barely time to understand what is happening as Adora starts to turn her around again, placing her with gentleness flat on her back, moving all around her to cradle her inside a makeshift nest of comfort.

“What are you doing?” Catra asks, voice slightly sore and still panting softly, watching as Adora grasps a few throw pillows and places them below her hurt knee, supporting the limb gently so she doesn´t apply more pressure on it than what she already did.

“I want to hold you,” Adora whispers back, lingering a kiss over the bandaged knee and moving again. “Be good and keep your leg there, love”

She gets a few more pillows and puts them this time right below the small of Catra´s waist, arching her back softly, getting her in the sweet position she already knows will drive her crazy with sensations. Catra knows it too because she groans, feeling more slick coating her folds and legs, begging to be taken already.

The air inside the room is warm but it still drives Catra insane every time Adora moves around her and she can feel the ghost of the strap close to her folds just to pull back again, making her silent promises and stretching the edge so much she doesn´t know what to do with herself, pull from her hair or moan.

The color of the strap is of a shade so similar to Adora´s skin that if it weren´t by the harness it would melt into one with her body, hanging perfectly long and wide enough, teasing Catra with it´s head already slicked in her release from every time it gets to near.

Catra moans and kicks blindly with her good leg over the sheets, eagerness and yearning eating its way inside her body and organs, begging for Adora to get close.

Adora hears her because she finishes tucking Catra inside their makeshift nest and leans towards her, placing her hands at either side of Catra´s face and resting her entire weight over them, holding her body over Catra´s completely. The sheer show of strength and the stretch of her biceps with the movement make Catra´s eyes roll back on their sockets.

“Tell me how do you want it, sweetheart,” Adora asks against Catra´s ear, licking the shell lustfully. Her golden hair is completely loose now, falling like a curtain that hides them from the rest of the world. Catra nuzzles deeper against the bed and pants, eyes filling with tears.

“I want you”

“I know that, baby.”

Adora lowers one of her hands, still holding her entire weight only with the other, running her slick fingertips from Catra´s sternum and all the way down her chest, across the edge of ribs, her bellybutton and her navel, reaching down until she can brush those fingers against the release dripping off Catra´s slit, coating her fingertips with them. She then brings her hand up and dips them inside her mouth, holding Catra´s clouded eyes when she does so.

“But I still want you to tell me.”

“Gods,” Catra prays, rolling her head back in the pillows.

Her hands are over Adora´s shoulders, unsure if to push or pull her, holding her so hard it will definitely bruise. When Catra looks at Adora again her eyes are completely taken by her pupils, drowning the colors and overtaking her eyes fully.

“Deep, as deep as you can. Don´t stop”

“Alright,” Adora nods, fondling Catra´s breast with her damp fingers and bringing the small flesh into her mouth again, lavishing with teeth and tongue until Catra is shaking in the bed below her. “Gently”

“No,” Catra growls but Adora shakes her head in negative, looking at her with eyes so blue they almost seem ethereal.

“That was not a question, love,” Adora says, sweet but also firm, so gently commanding that Catra whimpers, holding Adora´s head

between her palms. Catra nods swiftly, accepting whatever Adora commands of her, pushing her hips down on the blankets, almost blind with desperation.

Adora hums, kissing Catra´s slick mouth deep and hot, resting her tongue against hers and peppering her lips at the same time she takes herself on her hand, spreading Catra´s release over the length.

She wraps her other hand below Catra´s good knee and lifts it, resting it over her own hip as she presses the strap against her entrance. She drinks on Catra´s eager gasp and pushes forwards as softly as she can, caressing past Catra´s folds and the pink lips below and all the way inside until the head of the strap is resting safe and warm inside Catra´s sex, stretching her open deliciously.

Catra throws her arm over her eyes and moans, accidentally hitting the sore stitches on her temples on the way. Adora exhales, pupils wide, making sure her hurt knee is still safely resting over the pillows before moving her hands upwards. She grasps Catra´s wrists between her fingers and gently pulls it away from her eyes, lacing their fingers together instead and pressing them over the bed.

Adora nudges Catra´s face with her nose, silently calling her to open her eyes again. She waits patiently until the air returns to Catra´s lungs just enough for her to take a breath and open her eyes a slit, looking back at Adora´s face with her precious eyes.

"It's alright," Adora reassures her, pushing the strap deeper just an inch. A full body shiver runs down Catra´s body, her mouth falling open with silent moans.

"I'm here, I have you, Cat." Adora pulls out almost all the way and then pushes back inside deeper, gasping when the edge of the strap brushes over her own engorged clit making stars spark below her eyelids. " *Hah* , color?"

" *Ngh,"* Catra tries to answer but all that comes out is a long, chest deep exhale, whimpering against Adora´s lips. *"Hah!"*

Adora´s eyebrows knit with concentration, sweat gathering on her forehead. She is eager but she doesn´t move forward, waiting for Catra to allow it first.

"Love, your word"

"G– green," Catra finally manages after a beat. She holds Adora´s blue eyes in hers, looking at her with all the love and devotion that lives inside her heart and the sight alone makes Adora´s heart to skip a beat, her hips twitching forwards, deeper so much deeper, stretching and sinking inside Catra with devoted passion. " *Ah, Adora* "

Adora kisses her sweetly, all teeth and lips and tongue, brushing her messy and sweaty bangs out of her face, breathing in the musky precipitation of her skin and the perfume of her breath against her throat.

Adora knows she is ready, she can feel her, and she is ready too. So she holds Catra´s hand even harder and rests the other in the back of her nape, locking their eyes together, holding Catra in every single way possible as she moves her hips into one long, hard thrust.

Catra´s mouth falls open, jaw slack, her eyes so wide as she feels the length of the strap entering her almost completely, dragging through her walls and kissing her in ways only Adora´s lips can match. Adora observes her the whole time, her own eyes hooded and mouth watering at the look in her lover´s face, gathering it all inside her heart and guarding it there forever.

Adora gives another hard thrust and Catra slams her head back against the pillow, her beautiful neck tensing with the sweet moans coming off her mouth. She is loud, for the first time in months, she is allowed to be loud.

All of her dark hair is splayed over the white fabric messily until it looks like wings cradling her face and Adora, in the middle of her haze and devoted passion, thinks it's fitting because Catra is her angel, plain and simple her angel.

Out and then in, another thrust that slips further and further. Catra´s legs twitch with each movement, her injured knee accidentally hitching forwards but Adora stops her gently, smothering it back down this time over her hips and the back of her own long pale legs, helping her keep it unstrained even among the strong passion of their love making.

"You are sweet," Adora whispers to Catra, pointing every single word with a kiss.

On her temples, on her forehead. On the bridge of her nose and her lips. On the shell of her ears and her jaw. Skipping her neck and diving into her collarbones, whispering the words over her small breasts with kisses like vows.

"You are not only the love of my life, Catra. You are my entire heart"

*"Ah,"* Catra wants to reciprocate but she doesn´t know where she ends or starts anymore. She can feel Adora dragging the strap all the way back to the entrance and then thrusting against her again, no resistance at all, gentle all the time, so slow sometimes that it pulls from the strings of Catra´s sanity. *"Hah! Ah, Aah, hah!"*

"It's alright. Let go," Adora reassures her, gathering her inside her arms completely. She kisses her mouth tenderly and then the corner of her eyes, catching the warm tears brought by their union in her lips. "Let go, Cat. I'm not going to drop you"

Catra whimpers next to Adora´s cheek, the last strand of tension in her body snapping in half, allowing her body to relax completely and that is when the strap slips to the very hilt inside of her and she can feel Adora everywhere.

Catra rolls back her head over the duvet and the feather pillows, mouth slack and eyes hooded, unable to hold the whimpers and moans escaping her tongue and uncaring.

Uncaring of it all, uncaring if someone hears her, uncaring of holding back. She lets it all out between Adora´s mouth and the charged air all around them, allowing herself to be taken and worshiped and wrapped in such devastating devotion that she can feel Adora living inside the marrow of her bones.

She can feel her entire body moved by Adora´s, her spine arched, her hips lulled, rocked back and forth by the thrusts of Adora´s hips and the strap slipping inside Catra with each delicious thrust. Further and further and deeper and deeper. Deeper, so deep that Catra doesn't even know where is going anymore and yer deeper again, pressing against all the points inside of her that bring her the utmost of pleasures.

From here she can see her phone thrown carelessly over the night table, vibrating and shimmering with an incoming call. Somewhere inside her head she thinks to answer because she absently stretches her hand, fingers twitching, but then Adora´s arm comes to wrap around her head, wrapping her inside the crook of her elbow and her bicep and all coherent thought leaves Catra´s head completely.

Adora cradles her inside her arm as her other hand travels down, hooking below Catra´s good knee and bringing it further upwards, opening Catra in a new way that almost makes her scream with pleasure against her lips.

Catra´s elegant heels are digging in Adora´s back, one right below her butt, the other against the divots of her waist, slipping with the sweat coating Adora´s golden skin. Adora´s hair is completely damp now, of a dark honey that mingles alongside Catra´s curls with each thrust and each movement, weaving them together even further.

Catra smells so good, so much like everything good in Adora´s life that she cannot help herself when she holds Catra´s waist between her palms and brings her closer towards her body, sliding her over the bed until Catra´s butt is lifted off the mattress from the strength of Adora´s thrusts.

Adora drinks Catra´s surprised gasp and nips a line from her collarbone to her jaw, on the unscarred side, reaching the back of her neck. Adora breaths her in and digs her teeth, biting on Catra ´s nape.

Catra moans loudly, her arms shooting forward, wrapping themselves around Adora´s neck and resting over her strong back. She doesn´t mean to, she really doesn´t, but then Adora licks the bruised skin of her neck with a silent apology at the same time she circles her hips once and thrusts into her so hard that Catra´s eyes roll into white that she cannot help it. She digs her nails on Adora´s bare back and scratches her shoulder blades deeply, feeling the shallow wounds redding right below her fingertips.

Adora hisses immediately, accidentally biting down on Catra's bottom lip with surprise, her beautiful face scrunching in a second of swift pain. Catra snaps her hands away immediately, falling back to the pillows next to her head, holding the sheets between her fingers so hard that she tears little holes in the fabric.

"I'm – I'm, *ah* ! I´m sorry," Catra apologizes, eyes narrowing with regret and guilt, immediately sick with herself because in this sweet shared moment she hurt Adora. Out of all things, she physically hurt her.

But in Adora's face there is no discomfort or pain or annoyance; instead there is such a desperate kind of look that it makes Catra's voice hitch in her vocal words, surrounded in awe by the devotion on Adora's irises.

"Stay," Adora asks her, reaching for her hands again. She is panting heavily and her cheeks are completely flushed, deeply red

and eyes bright. Her hips have slowed down but she is still thrusting sweetly inside of Catra, not daring to leave her for a single second.

Adora gets a grip of Catra's wrists and lifts them up, gently placing them over her own shoulders again, smooth and gentle over the skin of her back. Catra's eyebrows twitch, confusion and the tiny specks of fear dancing on her eyes.

"I'm, *hah,* hurting you."

"You aren´t," Adora shakes her golden head softly, leaning down until the bridge of her nose is resting over Catra's forehead. The strap keeps pushing and pushing against her clit with her gentle thrust inside of Catra, tethering into an edge she wasn't expecting and that only gets fueled by the feeling of Catra's nails against her skin. " *Ah* , stay. It 's okay, *ah* ."

Catra wants to protest, to insist to Adora that she doesn't want to hurt her for a single second, but then Adora makes something especially delicious with her hips and Catra's entire body gets rocked with the movement making her nails dig again this time right in the middle of Adora's spine.

Adora moans again, leaning her forehead against Catra's, licking the roof of her mouth with her warm tongue. She thrusts inside of her again with so much force that the headboard of the bed slams against the wall and the lamps on the night tables tremble.

Catra is so warm right now that she can hear clearly the sounds that they are making together. The heavy panting, the high pitched whimpers, the sore moans; the sound of the bodies sliding against each other and the wet slide of the point where they join together.

Catra opens her eyes and searches for Adora's, holding her blue gaze in her irises when Adora presses in and Catra scratches down her back again, barely missing the patched up ribs, shallow lines that never get to bleed.

Adora comes by the feeling of Catra scratching her back and the strap rubbing into her clit. Her body locks for a long second, face tucking against Catra's jaw and her earlobe. She holds her breath and then exhales all the air inside her lungs heavily, twitching against Catra's body until all that she can see is her and all she can feel is fireworks.

Catra blinks at the ceiling, still restless, circling her hips against the strap but otherwise unmoving, holding Adora's twitching and hot body against her.

"Did you–? Oh," Catra marvels, drawing invisible circles over the scratched skin of Adora's back. Neither of them were expecting that but oh how deliciously welcome it is, how wonderful is for Catra feeling Adora enjoying herself by her touch alone, coming undone on Catra's hands. " *Oh* , I love you"

Adora is still trembling, fighting to regain her breath next to Catra's ears. Catra wraps her fingers over the damp strands of hair on Adora's nape, shushing her softly as Adora comes back into her senses. She never sung again after what happened but now she dares to hum, very softly and under her breath,

Catra lets her hands wander down over Adora's shoulders, across her scarred ribs and back, swirling on the light perspiration in Adora's waist and dipping ever further. Catra runs her nails over Adora's butt cheeks, softly, not really scratching but enough that Adora gasps at the touch and red lines paint on her honey skin.

Catra makes them travel from the firm curve towards Adora's navel, stretching as far as she can to reach between them and sink her fingertips on the damp thighs below the curve of the strap still buried inside of her, gathering Adora's release on her fingers.

"Catra? *Ah.* My love, what are you doing?" Adora asks in a soft whisper, kissing Catra's breast.

Catra gasps, tilting her head to the side so their eyes can meet again. Adora's pupils are wide as moons and her cheeks are red as roses and it only makes Catra grow even more restless.

“I wish I could feel you,” Catra says frantically, her hips searching for Adora and her hands slipping in her soft skin. She knows her words are stumbling and her sanity is slipping but she cannot stop it.

“I wish I could feel you against me. I want you, in me. I want you in my bloodstream, I want you in my bones. I want you inside,” Catra hiccups, cradling the side of Adora's flushed face inside her palm. “I wish you could cum inside me”

Adora's face is terrible in the most wonderful of ways. She looks at Catra with surprise painted all over her factions, her mouth opening and closing several times.

For a moment the claws of shame start to reach for Catra's heart but they are quickly rushed away when Adora leans down and kisses her in such a heated way that it steals all the breath from Catra's lungs.

Adora runs her tongue against Catra's as her body leans back, the strap slipping out of Catra's body with a slick sound. Catra's eyes snap open when she realizes what is happening, whimpering as the sweet pressure of the toy leaves her, slicking her thighs and leaving her open and pulsing.

“Adora?” Catra asks in a sore plea, frantic now that Adora has learned away from her completely.

She feels restless and unsure for a second until she lifts her head from the pillows and catches sight of Adora loosening the harness just enough so she can get a grip of the strap and pull it into her hand, slowly but surely placing it below her own aching slit. Catra chokes on her breath, desire but also worry blooming on her chest

“Wait. Wait, you don´t have to–”

“Shh, it's alright,” Adora reassures her, caressing Catra's forehead with her fingertips at the same time she lowers down her hips over the length of the strap, already glistening and slick with Catra's cum. “Trust me, it's alright.”

Adora holds Catra's pretty eyes in her and starts humping her hips, running her wet folds over the entire length of the strap, from the base to the head and back. It never goes inside but she has already cummed once so it is enough to coat her release against the soft but firm surface, dripping on the space between their thighs.

Catra rolls her head into the pillows and moans, not taking her eyes away from Adora for a single second but incapable of not wiggle over the bed, her hips pushing down and bumping into Adora's navel with expectation.

Once Adora is sure the strap is perfectly coated she takes it away from her with a moan, her eyes narrowed in pleasure as she slips it back into its place on the harness and tightens it again, hovering the slick head back against Catra's entrance. Catra bites into her lip until it hurts and whines, her hands traveling to the sides of Adora's neck to keep her near.

“ *Ah”*

“I'm going to be in you, alright?” Adora says, voice completely raw and eyes so dark she looks feral, barely containing herself on not slamming the strap back inside. She caresses the underside of Catra's eyes with her thumb, holding her gaze swetly. “So deep that if the gods want to tear us apart they are going to have to carve me out of your soul and your skin with their hands"

*“Ah! Yes.”* Catra nods against Adora's lips, crossing her arms around her neck and keeping her as close as possible to her as she feels her sinking inside of her again and again, bumping their cores and melting them into one. “Yes. *Adora* .”

Adora looks at her with the most tender eyes, lingering kisses against her mouth. “I love you”

“I– I love you too,” Catra says around a whine, sinking further and further around Adora´s warmth.

“Here.” Catra says suddenly, mingling with a moan when the wet strap slides past her walls and against the most intimate part of her body, Adora melting inside of her. Catra places her own hand over the side of her neck, right above the jarring scar, looking at Adora with pleading dark eyes. “Kiss me here”

Adora's breath stops, a pang of hesitation running down her veins. This place, the only place off limits, the untouchable unspeakable place that brought Catra so much pain.

“Cat–”

“I'm yours.” Catra vows, caressing Adora's face with the most tender of fingers. “Make me yours. Your wife”

Adora does not need to be told twice. She never wants for Catra to plead for anything in her life, much less between them, much less inside their bed. Adora leans her head forward and rests her lips over the raised and pink skin of the scar, reclaiming back all the pain and the fear and leaving only love behind.

She never bites or nips on the long ago healed but still tender skin, lavishing it instead with her tongue and her lips. She kisses all over the jarred edges, every single inch and raised spot and soft crevice and then in the center, worshiping and caring for the skin, devoting herself completely to it with all the adoration inside her heart. She licks and kisses and whispers promises of love over the scar, feeling Catra growing restless and frantic below her body, her hands slipping in Adora´s hair and her back.

“My angel, my rose, my love.” Adora murmurs against Catra´s skin, nuzzling her nose over the pink mark. “My wife, I'm yours too”

Adora drives her hips back again and holds for a second, waiting until Catra is looking back at her again before slamming her hips back, sinking the strap inside her completely with one swift thrust. Catra´s pupils widen so hard that her entire eyes almost look completely black, shimmering with spilling tears,

" *Ah, ah. Ah!* Deeper," Catra pleas, sinking her nails over Adora´s biceps and the back of her neck. Adora hisses, crumbling into a moan when her hips hitch and Catra´s whine turns into a purr.

"Catra"

"Deeper Adora." Catra repeats, her eyes rolling on their sockets, beautiful neck straining when she drops her head against the pillow. There is nothing else inside her head but the sound of Adora´s name, repeating over and over like a hymn. "Adora. *Adora* "

Adora thrusts back inside of her, the upper side of her thighs slamming against Catra´s buttcheeks. The strength of the thrusts is so much that Catra´s legs are lifting off the bed, slipping against the small of Adora´s back, toe curling and tingling with the sensation of Adora´s length entering her again and again and again.

Adora tilts her hips to the side at some point, lifting Catra´s good leg in a certain way until her knee is bent towards her bouncing and kiss bitten breasts. The movement makes her somehow slip even further, meeting with nothing but liquid warmth and the waves of Catra´s ocean.

This is as far as she can go, she cannot go further; she is kissing the deepest, seacrest paper of Catra's body, a place she had never reached before, heated up like a rose placed under the sun. Catra whimpers so hard that is the edge of a scream, her pretty eyes soaked in tears and spilling down over her cheeks, forehead feverish with heat.

“There,” She whispers, voice gone. “There, there, *oh* Adora. Adora”

“My love,” Adora whispers back, cradling her face with trembling hands and kissing her, not able to ignore the way Catra´s body almost bends in half with each thrust.

Catra moans inside the kiss, caressing Adora´s red ears with shivering fingertips, meeting her eyes with undeniable desperation and such a deep love that catches Adora out of guard.

“V- vow to me,” Catra asks of Adora, pressing their foreheads together. “Please”

She is close, as closer as she could possibly be. She can feel it on the end of her toes and fingers and in the hammering of her heart, blooming golden and beautiful on her belly and the middle of her spine. Adora looks back at her full of devotion, smiling sweetly, even sweeter than their passion is burning up between them.

“I love you,” Adora vows, punctuating each one with a sweet thrust. “I love you so much”

*“Ah”*

“Half of my soul”

*“Ah”*

“All of my heart”

*“Ah, ah!”*

“My best friend”

*“Nghh”*

“My first love, my only love”

*“Ah, Adora, ah!”*

“My lover, my wife”

“There, *oh,* I can feel you”

“All that I am, all that I'll be, all of me”

“I'm going to– I'm going–”

“Catra, my Catra.” Adora meets Catra´s eyes inside of hers, holding her as she comes undone. “I'm yours”

Catra comes so hard that she passes out for some good three seconds. She rolls her head on the pillow and moans, followed behind by Adora´s lips never leaving hers, drinking on her sweet and tiny whimpers and helping her through it.

Adora can feel her, gripping down over the strap and spilling heavily between them, even if it shouldn´t be possible, Adora feels her red walls holding her inside, her fingers twitching over her shoulders, her precious mouth damp as their joined saliva stretches between them and her warmth as she cums and Adora cannot do something else but to follow her there too, coming heavily and trembling above Catra´s body.

Adora catches herself in her hands, careful of not crushing Catra under her weight. She wraps Catra inside her arms, though, her biceps flexing when she runs her forearms below Catra´s back and embraces her against her chest, tucking her sweetly between her neck and the side of her jaw.

Catra´s breathing is ragged, her entire body trembling from head to toe inside Adora´s arms. Her arms are thrown over Adora´s shoulders and loose like strings, with just enough strength to brush Adora´s skin every once in a while with a soft caress.

Adora tilts her head to the side, pressing gentle kisses all over Catra´s cheeks and temples, She pets Catra´s damp curls softly, running her fingers over her bangs and pushing them back, searching for Catra´s pretty eyes.

“Cat,” Adora whispers, calling for her. Her own body is trembling too, tiny hitches of her hips and navel still rocking them softly over the mattress. “Are you okay?”

Catra exhales against her cheeks, resting her palm over the column of Adora´s neck. Nod. Yes

“Was I too rough?” Adora asks, worry slipping inside her bones. Catra still looks so out of it, open and loose in Adora´s hold, her face, neck and chest covered in deep red blush.

Shake of the head. No.

Catra opens her eyes then, just a slit, just enough to look back at Adora through long eyelashes. Her eyes are completely clouded, fogged by the orgasm and the sensations of their bodies still joined together, but she looks slightly more alert now, looking at Adora with sweet eyes.

Catra manages a tender smile, filled with love and adoration. Her hand moves from Adora´s neck to the side of her face, caressing her cheekbone with her fingertips.

“You were beautiful,” Catra whispers, and her voice is so sour and wonderful that Adora trembles. “You are beautiful.”

Adora smiles, wet in the edges, unable to contain her own joyful tears as she leans to kiss Catra´s lips again. She moves a little, placing her knees further on the bed and pulling back softly, meant to slip out of Catra as gently as she can.

She has not even moved an inch when Catra presses her cheek against Adora's nose bridge and cums again, whimpering against her mouth.

*Gods*

It catches them both off guard but is so sweet that they sink into each other again, limbs wrapping back together as close and hard as they can, every single inch of their bodies touching the other.

“You are so beautiful,” Adora murmurs, caressing Catra´s hips as they tremble and hitch, riding the last waves of her orgasm.

“Stay–” Catra wets her lip, mortified, her eyebrows knitting together. She caresses Adora´s face, wrapping her fingers around golden strands. The ring is a sweet reminder between both of them, as it is the reliquary in the night table as it is their heart beating together.. “Stay inside. Just a little longer.”

“Yes.” Adora kisses her mouth, nodding. “Yes”

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Adora wraps her in her arms against the mattress and kisses her cheek and jaw sweetly, nuzzling her nose against Catra´s temples. They remain silent for a few minutes, basking on the warmth of each other, touch starved after so many days running from fear and violence.

Adora leans a little to the side to not crush Catra´s chest and wraps her head inside her arm, tucking her panting face against her pulse point. Catra´s arms come up again, wrapping themselves over Adora´s waist and, the other hand resting safely over Adora´s chest, feeling the beating on her hand right below the pads of her fingers.

After a moment of silence Adora hums, running her lips over Catra ´s lilac eyelid. “What are you thinking about?”

Catra takes a moment to answer, unable to place completely into words everything she is feeling right now.

Love, yes, but also so much more. Devotions and happiness and joy and tenderness. Fear too, desire too. Emotions that let her know that she is just human and in love, that she loves above everything. All that she feels for Adora since they meet, years and years ago when they were six and Adora moved back with her family to Etheria and they were so young and so lucky to find each other. When they were older and already in love and they

almost lost each other. When Catra lost herself completely, when Adora reached her and brought her back.

All that she feels for her right in the tip of her tongue and that she doesn´t know if it's going to come as tears or as a laugh. All that she can feel is Adora´s warm body and the metal of the lovely finger in her hand.

"We are one," Catra says in the end, kissing Adora´s jaw and neck, allowing her eyes to fall closed again. "We are one"

Adora´s eyes soften, the most tender of smiles making a home on her lips. She runs her fingers below Catra's chin and tilts her head backwards softly, placing a single sweet kiss there.

"We are"

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**Voice message from Scorpia ||** *Hey, Wildcat, it's Scorpia. Detective Huntara gave me a new phone to call you. I'm alright, Entrapta is fine too. They have a dislocated shoulder and I got a few stitches but otherwise we are safe.*

*They placed us in an apartment and took our testimonies again. We got some visits too.*

*I think one of the detectives still needs me for something related to Perfuma later, I´ll call you when I´m back.*

*Be safe where you are, alright?*

*Tell Adora I said hi.*

*And happy birthday! I love you, wildcat.*

**10:06 pm, Heard**

**Voice message from Catra ||** *Why would they want you again? I swear that those fucking idiots don´t know where their ass end and their mouths begging.*

*Be fucking careful, alright Scorpia? If you need me, call me back and I´ll go for you to kick their asses I don´t give a flying fuck what the detectives think*

*I love you too, Scorp. I really do. Please be careful.*

**11:58 pm, Heard**

Catra towels the last of the water soaked her hair, dropping the towel into the back of the chair with a huff. She is back sitting on the end of the bed except that this time the mattress has been completely pulled from the duvet and sheet, crumbled wet and sex smelling on the far corner of the room. It is night too, around ten in the night, the darkness thick when Catra peeked through the heavy curtains.

She is alone right now, the sound of the water rushing inside the closed bathroom as her only company. Adora is humming sweetly in the shower, Catra can hear her even here, her spirits lifted after their hours together. They showered together, wrapped still in each other's arms and helped the other wash away the sweat and release of her bodies. But Adora has always enjoyed spending a few extra minutes under the cold spray, once all the warm water has gone, just to cool her head down.

Catra is alright with that, she also needs a few moments of her own after an intimacy like that. Her legs are still trembling a little and all of her lower body is tingling with the remains of their love making, raising goosebumps in Catra´s spine and shoulders every once in a while. Her entire body is covered in kisses and love marks, tender patches over the dark copper of her skin that make her shiver when she presses her fingers over them. Testimonies of Adora´s adoration even after they had slipped away from each other intimacies and yet they couldn´t remain apart for much longer.

They are scattered over the bruises in Catra´s body and she wrinkles her nose at those but caresses the ones made by Adora ´s lips, Her knee is back on the compression sleeve after the shower and even if it doesn´t hurt as much as last night it still makes her hum with annoyance every time it sparks with pain. She hates feeling useless in any way or form, no matter how little it might be, and having a busted knee right now makes her want to pull the damn thing and throw it in the trash. At least the clean black tank top Adora had handed her and the jogger pants are soft against her skin.

A quiet knock comes into the other side of the closed door, tearing Catra away from her thoughts. She stands up in precarious legs, approaching the peephole and taking a look on her tippy toes. Glimmer is standing on the other side, all of her short pink hair held back with a headband, her eyes tired but much more alert than how Catra saw her a few hours ago.

A rotten feeling pulls on the bottom of Catra´s belly as she undoes Adora´s locks, opening the door with a light tug. It is very clear that Glimmer was neither expecting Catra to be standing on the other side or happy to see her at all, because her mouth falls into a tight line and her eyebrows knit together, snapping her eyes away from Catra´s face and towards the inside of the room.

"Where is Adora?" Glimmer asks, not even bothering on trying to be polite. Catra bites back both a sigh and an insult, pointing at the closed door of the bathroom where the shower is still going on.

"She is finishing showering," Catra explains, clearing her throat when her voice still comes scratchy.

Glimmer eyes her with suspicion at the sound of her voice, frowning deeply. She inspects the warm bedroom from her place on the door frame, taking on the closed curtains, the undone bed and the sheets crumpled on the corner. She snaps her eyes back to Catra´s face and eyes her more meaningfully, catching the

kisses painted on her collarbones and the low of  her jaw, the pink blush on her cheeks and the bright shimmer in her eyes.

"Oh," Glimmer´s face crumbles completely, her eyes falling and her entire expression locking into something so much harder. "I´ll just come back later"

"Glimmer," Catra is not able to hold back, grasping Glimmer´s wrists inside her fingers. Glimmer snaps her arm away as if Catra had burnt her but she doesn´t yell at Catra, instead staring at her full of expectation. Catra gulps, shame gathering in her chest but getting her shit together, stepping aside from the door. "Please come inside"

Glimmer thinks about it for a long second before scoffing, marching inside with her head up and her back straight. She is holding a bundle of old looking papers in her hands, no doubt the reason she had come in the first place, droppin them on the table of the room and ignoring the chairs completely.

They stand still and in silence for a very awkward and heavy moment, unable to share a word. It makes Catra´s skin crawl with discomfort, a scream crawling in her throat, and she selfishly hopes that Adora will walk out of the shower soon enough so she can end this torment but Catra has never been so lucky.

She stares at Glimmer´s face carefully, studying her expression. She looks ready to hit Catra if their eyes were to meet and she is holding herself so tightly that her nails are digging bruises on her upper arms, crossing her limbs over her chest. She kind of looks deeply angry for realizing what Adora and Catra must have been doing before.

Somewhere inside Catra´s chest shame and anger tug from each other, trying to take first place. Catra wants to be furious with her right now because, after all, Adora *is* Catra´s; Glimmer was the one that kisses Catra´s girlfriend and that has always resent her for having her and she has no business on what their intimacy looks like or when they do it. But on the other hand, Catra cannot

find it within herself to be angry with Glimmer after Angella´s death, not right now, so she sucks it up and waits until Glimmer is ready to talk.

At some point Glimmer´s wandering eyes end up on Catra´s hands at her sides, catching sight of her fingers. Glimmer stretches her arm without warning and grabs Catra's left wrist harshly, tugging from it towards her face to take a better look.

Glimmer knows the ring two, she saw it once or twice when she visited Adora´s room in high school, always tucked inside the small velvet box like a secret nobody gets to know. It now rests over Catra´s finger like a vow for the rest of the world to see, a gentle lace between lovers.

Glimmer drops Catra´s hand back with a scoff, shaking her head with an incredulous chuckle. Catra rubs her wrist, eyes hardening. She knows what Glimmer must be thinking, what is festering inside of her right now. A woman she loves and a woman she despises, promising to each other in the aftermath of her mother ´s death. It doesn´t seem fair and as much as it hurts Catra, she understands her.

“I know you hate me,” Catra says, rubbing her upper arm with her palm, the one carrying the ring. Glimmer´s eyes snap towards her, her pink eyebrows skyrocketing a little with surprise just to fall right back after, staring at Catra with a blank expression.

“I don't hate you –”

“You do,” Catra cuts her off, blinking when Glimmer´s teeth click painfully with each other. “I understand. I would hate me too.”

Glimmer looks at her with blazing eyes, pressing her mouth into a thin line. Absently Catra expects her to curse her out or even hit her but she doesn´t, still standing a few feet away from Catra. Catra stares at her, breathing deep before talking again.

“Adora is– she is the most wonderful thing in the whole world,” Catra says under her breath, tilting her head. That calls Glimmer

´s attention because her eyes return to Catra´s, suddenly caught by surprise. “How long have you been in love with her?”

Glimmer´s eyes widen, her upper lip retracting over her gums with a deep scowl. “I´m not–”

“Bow is wonderful too,” Catra keeps saying, softly, cornering Glimmer before she can start yelling at her, “He is your soulmate, I know that, you know that too. None of us will ever doubt how much you love him. But it doesn´t mean you stopped loving Adora,”

Glimmer is looking at her with incredulity, her cheeks spotted in red.

“Adora is my friend,” she spats, and Catra nods, sighing.

“I know,” Catra shrugs, confusing herself as to why she suddenly needs so much honesty too. “How long?”

Glimmer stutters for a good couple of minutes, out of words until she finally gives up. She squares her back and chews on the words, ears red.

“Since we were fourteen, when she got into high school after the accident.” Glimmer mutters, shrugging. “She was– so weird. So fascinating for me. This beautiful teen that looked like an angel and couldn´t stop falling from the top of trees or jumping over insects or tripping with her own feet,” Glimmer chuckles, shaking her head sadly. “I knew the Montenegro's were homeschooling their children from my mother's mouth, but I never met her until then, not even in town. Guess she was spending her entire time with you instead.”

“She was,” Catra confirms, not even sorry in the way Glimmer flinches a little. “Our families were friends, Glimmer. Even after my father´s death, Marlena y Randor took me in with them while Weaver was tearing my father´s name, inheritance and pushing the rest of my family away. I wouldn't have survived without them. I wouldn't have survived without Adora.”

Glimmer's eyes narrow, her mouth pressing into a fine line, shrinking inside herself. She tries to bite back the question in her mouth but she needs to ask it, if they are doing this, she needs to ask so she can move on with her life.

"Why did she fall in love with you?" Even for her it sounds wrong.

Catra runs her fingers through her curls, clenching her jaw. The ring is very tender in her fingers, cradling her in warmth even now

"I don't know, Sparkles. I don't fucking know," Catra narrows her eyes, looking at the unmade bed and their shared clothes. "We were always together. I know you remember because Bow presented us with you when Adora enrolled. We– I don´t think we could have been apart from each other even if we tried. And we tried, we almost broke each other and still"

Catra's voice trails off, looking at Glimmer pleadingly. "I don´t know why but it´s– it´s always been us. It´s *us* ."

"I *know* that, Catra"

"Okay," Catra exhales, pulling from the skin of her joggers, Adora ´s joggers, nervously. She gives a step forwards, hovering her hand over Glimmer´s forearm without getting to touch her. "She loves you, Glimmer. Adora wears her heart on her sleeve, you know that. You are one of her best friends and she cares about you, especially now."

"I know," Glimmer repeats but this time sounds softer, her arms falling down from their cross and into her sides, her fingers flexing absently. "I think I always knew it. Even before you two got your shit together. It's just– ugh."

"I know." Catra says, raising her shoulders. "I don't blame you, I've been in love with her since I was six years old. I get it."

"Aren´t you angry about what happened in the mall?" Glimmer asks, and her eyes are heavy, pulling down with a thousand kinds of sorrow. Catra shakes her head, hugging herself.

“No, Glimmer.”

“Okay"

Catra doesn´t want to say that months ago the same thing could have made her spiral down, that she would have fought her and beat her and made them both angry and rotten. She doesn´t want to say that she knows now that nothing in the world could ever sway Adora´s heart away from her, that she carries Adora´s heart inside the pocket of her jacket and mingles the strands of her soul inside her chest. Those are things that are true but that Glimmer doesn´t need to know, even if in a way Catra thinks she already knows.

She needs to say something else, though. She needs to pour it out of her chest before it rots her and festers in her organs and bones and she needs it to say to Glimmer right now, now that they are both standing with their hearts bare. Now that Catra´s guilt and sorrow is threatening to choke her.

“Your mom loved you so much,” Catra blurts out, choking with a sob. Glimmer´s jaw fall open, her pupils shrinking inside her irises, so much like Angella´s eyes that it makes Catra´s head spin. She keeps talking before Glimmer can shut her down, pouring it all out like venom. “She cared for you and she was worried for you. That night– yesterday, she said she wanted to protect you. She said she didn't want to be a coward anymore, I don´t know why she said that but it fueled her.”

Glimmer flinches, clenching her teeth, “Catra–”

“Glimmer, your mother was really brave,” Catra chokes on her breath, unable to contain more tears to come. “I– my mom, I wish my mom had loved me like yours loved you. Angella was really brave and I'm so sorry. You can hate me all you want and I ´ll always be sorry for what happened. I wish it hadn't happened at all, I wish she had not gone up those stairs, I wish she had left me there. And I´m sorry. I´m so sorry”

Catra waits for a beat, tears stuck in her eyes, a sob breaking through her throat. Then she sees Glimmer move, looking from the corner of her eyes as Glimmer makes her way around the table, standing right next to Catra. Catra wants to say something, alleviate the silence and the pain, call for Adora or lock herself with her back in their tiny motel room but she does none. Catra needs this and so does Glimmer.

Glimmer shoots forwards, opening her arms and wrapping Catra fully inside of them, holding her head and shoulders against her body into a painfully but honest hug. Catra´s jaw goes slack with surprise but Glimmer is silent, holding Catra close and absently petting the back of her curls with her palms.

"I´m sorry," Catra repeats, dam breaking free, weeping in Glimmer´s arms.

Glimmer shakes her head, letting her tired eyes fall closed. Her voice is sore and completely broken. "It´s alright"

"It´s not"

"No, you are right," Glimmer accepts, sighing deeply. "It´s fucked up"

It´s a silent acceptance, of forgiveness, and it is still cold and it is still broken but it is there. Catra knows she does not deserve it, she knows that she will rot in guilt forever, but she cannot help but sink into it.

Adora walks out of the bathroom right in that second, called by the faint whisper of voices beyond the door, her heart on her throat. She gasps silently at the scene, face to face with the love of her life and her friend embracing quietly and sorrowfully in the middle of the room.

You would never understand how important these people are for her, not even they know, not even Catra comprehends. But Adora knows and she sighs with the start of relief, holding the golden reliquary against her chest to ground her down. Glimmer who has

her teeth clenched so painfully that her jaw and neck strains and who looks at Catra´s bruised face with heavy eyes, glimmering with something unspeakable. Catra whose pretty eyes have fallen closed and whose body is trembling with guilt and shame, letting herself be held. Adora holds her breath as throws a silent prayer to the sky because maybe, just maybe after all they might all just make it out alive.

Glimmer and Catra step down from each other with a heavy exhale, cleaning their eyes, pulled apart by the feeling of eyes over them. Bow has arrived at the room too, at some point and so quietly nobody even heard him, standing in silence next to the frame of the door and watching the scene with tender eyes. Adora looks at him and he looks back at her, sharing the same stare filled with emotions, unspoken words passed through them too.

Bow walks towards Glimmer and wraps her into a tight hug, holding her sad and mourning body inside his arms, allowing her to cry freely when the sadness overcomes her again. Nobody forgets that her mother is dead and that she misses her dearly, that she feels guilt for the things that happened between them, and nobody blames her for being sad or angry. So Bow holds her and lets her pour it all out inside his arms, pressing sweet kisses over the crown of her head.

Adora moves too, hair still dripping and making her shirt stick to her back, barely waiting a second to meet her eyes with Catra´s before gathering her inside her arms fully, raising her from the floor a little with the impetus of the embrace. Catra grabs her arms around her neck and nuzzles on the side of her head, sobbing silently, and Adora reassures her back, caressing circles on her back and kissing the shell of her ear. Promising her everything will be alright.

The four of them wiggle closer together, almost tripping with the carpet several times and wrapping each other into a full embrace, arms around shoulders and waist and tucking their faces on the crook of necks. Bow rests his hand over Glimmer´s neck and the other over Catra´s head, crossing past Adora´s neck, petting

them all softly. It feels good, embracing each other after such long and difficult days. After tragedy and after sorrow, it feels good being able to hold each other.

Adora steps back a little, breaking the embrace softly as she cleans her eyes with trembling fingertips. She smiles at Bow and Glimmer, resting her palm over the small of Catra´s waist.

“Hi, you guys”

“Hi,” Bow greets her, nudging her side with his shoulder. “I wasn't expecting this but I do love hugs”

Adora chuckles, shrugging softly. Bow squeezes Glimmer´s shoulder reassuringly one more time before moving forwards, stepping into Catra´s space. They share a look where Bow waits patiently for consent and Catra gives it with a tiny nod, holding her breath when Bow wraps her completely into a hug.

It is a very excited hug because Catra huffed a little, out of breath, palming Bow´s forearms patiently and trying not to squirm away immediately after. Bow hums, squeeze the life out of Catra´s ribs before placing her back into the firm ground stepping away. He doesn´t get to go too far though because he catches sight of Catra´s palm resting over his wrist and his eyes go wide like sauce plates, jaw falling open.

“Wait, this is–” Bow takes Catra´s left hand, much gentler than Glimmer had also done before. inspecting the delicate finger with his breath held. He snaps his eyes towards Adora who is already looking back at him with a tender look, nodding softly.

“It is,” she confirms, holding herself to the golden reliquary hanging from her neck. Her eyes meet Catra´s and all both can feel is overwhelmed love and relief, cradled in a single second of warmth.

Bow lets out a high pitched exclamation, jumping up and down on his place without letting go from Catra´s hand. “Fuck me! Oh gods! You asked her”

Adora laughs loudly, snorting, but Catra´s eyes go wide too, realization of Bow´s words hitting her with gentleness. "You knew"

"Of course yes! Come here, congratulations!" Bow wraps her in another hug, incapable of holding himself back. He almost lifts her right back off the ground with the strength of it, rocking her from side to side excitedly. "And Happy Birthday, kitcat"

"Ugh, get off me," Catra mutters under her breath, pushing from Bow´s shoulders without real ill below it. She gathers herself with a huff before returning Bow´s soft and happy eyes, unable to hold herself back when her own eyes melt too, happiness spreading inside her chest huge and undeniable. "Thank you, Arrows"

Bow´s ear to ear grin becomes into something much softer, the corners of his eyes wrinkling when he pets the side of Catra´s temple gently. "I think your dad would be very happy for you."

Catra´s breath catches on her throat, her eyes prickling with warm tears. She takes several breaths and nods, letting Bow hug her again. "Yeah, I think so too"

Adora and Glimmer are looking at them in silence, eyes soft from Adora´s part. Glimmer, however, turns her eyes towards Adora, inhaling sharply. Adora has never looked more beautiful than she does now, surrounded by love and cradled in the happiness of a loving future next to the only woman she has ever loved. That is something Glimmer has always wanted for her, that is something she could never hate Catra for.

"Congrats, Adora," Glimmer says under her breath, managing a tiny and sincere smile when Adora turns to look at her. "I´m happy for you, I really am"

Adora´s eyes soften in the corners, her shoulders falling with silent relief. She wraps Glimmer into a swift but sweet hug, squeezing her gently."Thank you, Glimmer"

It takes them a little bit longer but finally they all manage to sit around the table, cleaning tears and getting comfortable. Catra and Glimmer share a look over the table but it is not as tense as before, grudge and guilt easing a little. It only seems fitting, after all, that Catra is the one confronting and comforting Glimmer after her mother´s death, that she is the one speaking the words and the one helping Glimmer face the reality of what happened and that they need to move forward if they want to survive,

“So are you both coming to have a sleepover?” Adora jokes, lighthearted, stretching her legs below the table. She hopes for her friends to laugh or to confirm it even but all Bow and Glimmer do is look at each other, wrinkling their noses.

“No,” Glimmer says, shaking his head. “We want to show you both something”

Adora´s heart sinks inside her chest, absently searching for Catra ´s hand under the table, holding her firmly. “I don´t like that face”

“You are going to like this even less,” Bow says softly, his thick eyebrows knitted together. Adora had not noticed Bow was carrying Angella´s briefcase until he placed it over the cheap table, taking more papers from the inside.

“I took this from Huntara when she came. She didn´t even notice, I think she was too busy smoking outside and yelling at the officers for falling asleep,” Glimmer explains, sighing deeply. She must catch the way Adora´s eyebrows skyrocket in her forehead because her whole body goes defensive, gurgling loudly.” “It was my mother´s. so it's not pick pocketing if you squint.”

“Of course,” Adora says absently, chuckling nervously. Glimmer shoots her a heavy look but it melts immediately after, the mist of sorrow falling over her entire expression.

“When my mom– when she went up the stairs, she said she knew what was happening. That she knew everything. And before that

Bow and I discovered that she went to the library too to take some newspapers out. So I thought she should have something in here that made her realize what is going on.”

Glimmer scrambles through the yellowed papers until she finds what she is looking for, the front page of a very old newspaper folded in half. The edges are torn slightly, as if someone has ripped it from the whole newspaper and tucked it quickly inside a bag, wrinkled when Glimmer unfolds it over the table.

“Adora, you need to see this.” Glimmer mutters, sliding the paper across the table and towards her.

It's the report of a murder. It is right there, bold in black letters and almost too loud, dated from the very same year the first murders had happened. *Another girl murdered by Etheria´s slasher,* it reads, followed by tiny letters and, the most striking of it all, a frame to frame black and white photograph right in the middle.

Adora leans towards the paper, looking at the paper with narrowed eyes, her breath stopping in her throat. She knows the two people standing there, side by side and smiling, their arms around each other. There is no color on the paper but Adora can still clearly see the golden of their hairs falling over their shoulders, stormy blue eyes and dimples in the cheek. Is like looking in front of two mirrors reflecting each other, their happy stares bearing inside Adora´s chest like a thorn.

“That 's my mom.” Adora whispers, running her fingertips gently over the young woman at the left. It is her, how could Adora ever forget her face even as young as she looks then. Adora loved her so much. “And my aunt Serenia,” she adds, tapping her finger over the gentle face of the woman on the right. She frowns, shaking her shoulder uncomfortably, looking at the bold title of the newspaper and back at her family's faces. “I don't understand, my mom said aunt Serenia died in an accident.”

“She didn´t, Adora. She was the fourth girl murdered years ago.” Glimmer says as gently but eager as she can, clenching her teeth together. Next to Adora, Catra inhales sharply, squeezing Adora´s hand almost painfully. “She was the last one and the– the most brutal.”

Glimmer exhales forcefully, taking back the old newspaper so she can read outloud, her eyebrows knitted together. “They found her body in the woods, near the destroyed remains of the old Etherian church. All– um, all of her hair was cut off, her throat slashed in half. She- she had been hung from the branches of the trees, held like a bird at mid fly. This paper says the bones of her joints had been broken and her– her ribs had been extracted and taken backwards. Like wings.”

“I–” Adora looks at Glimmer horrified, bile pooling on her throat and threatening to make her pass out. “Gods. Oh,goddess”

“Adora,” Catra whispers, bringing Adora´s hand towards her lips, kissing her knuckles gently. Adora´s body is trembling so hard that she is worried that she might hurt herself, trying to alleviate some of the horror with kisses. All the tenderness and safety and love that they had managed to build like a barrier around them inside this bedroom has started to crumble into pieces.

Glimmer exhales, obviously pained to have to say this in the first place. She narrows her eyes sadly, pressing her lips into a thin line, looking back at the photograph of both sisters. “She looks so much like your mom”

“My mom and Serenia were twins. Like Adam and I,” Adora explains but her voice is far away, strained and shivering.

“Yes,” Glimmer agrees, her heart jumping inside her chest with anxiety. “And you are identical to your mom”

Adora´s eyes snap back to her with a new kind of weight, dark under the dim light of the lamps. Glimmer leans over the table,

searching for Adora´s other hand, holding her fingers inside of hers.

“I think your mom and dad moved out of town right after it happened because that's when the murders stopped happening.” Glimmer stretches for a new paper that Bow hands her silently, placing it over the table too. “There is a newspaper here with the announcement of your parents' wedding followed right behind with their departure. It happened the same day. It´s a very short notice but my mom marked it with pen, she must have thought it was very important.”

“Important how?” Adora snaps. She doesn´t mean to bark and Glimmer knows it but she can´t help the flinch in her shoulders at the strained sound of Adora´s voice, so far away from her usual cheerful and sweet self. Adora is on edge, she is scared.

“How old were you when your family came back?”

Adora blinks at her, surprised. “Um, we moved from Eternia back here when I was six. Right after my parents met Catra´s dad and his family. And, um, Weaver,” Adora throws a swift look towards Catra, her shoulders falling. Catra´s eyes harden just a little but her hand is still holding Adora´s, her own fingers trembling and sweating. “They convinced them to come back but I never thought we had been away for this”

“Did she ever mention something?”

“Nothing at all. Mentions of aunt Serenia were very short and always the same, mostly done when my grandparents and Mara came to visit.” Adora´s eyes unfocus, staring at something that only lives inside her memory. She speaks in a whisper, under her breath, shaken to the core. “Mara never told me anything”

“Why were you never in school during those years? Why were you always homeschooled and isolated from the rest of the town?” Glimmer presses on, frantic, her own thoughts pushing down on her and making the entire room freezing cold. “Everyone here

knows each other from years and years ago, all of us knew about your family yet we only really saw you until you turned fourteen. You were never on the square or the mall or the chapel. Why?”

“Glimmer, what are you getting on?” Adora finally snaps, her voice lowering. She feels itchy all over, her skin flaring under the soft clothes and the touch of Catra´s hands. Glimmer pulls from her short pink hair softly, biting into her cuticles.

“I think this is older than you. I think that this started with your mom.” Glimmer pulls the other pieces of newspaper, placing them on the photographs of the other victims and Serenia. Then she takes out of the briefcase the new photographs of their friends, Perfuma, Starla, Mermista at the hospital, leaning on her fingers and pointing at how similar they look to each other. Beautiful, honey haired and young. “Someone wanted your mom, for the same reasons it now wants you. She moved back here but then she– she died. And now you are almost the exact same age Marlena and Serenia were when the first murders happened. Everything is happening all over again!”

There is a very soft knock on the outside of the closed window, like a tiny rock crashing softly against the glass. The four of them go still as statues, staring at the thick curtain weary and tense, Another small knock comes, more insistent this time, flaring the friend´s nervous system with anxiety.

Bow stands up before any of them can stop him, walking very quietly towards the window, grasping the fabric between two fingers and breathing deep several times before looking outside. His tense shoulders drop with relief but his face is still swimming with confusion, eyebrows raising on his face.

“It's the officers from outside.” He says, pushing the curtain a little for the rest of them to see. The two officers Huntara had left to take guard are standing on the street, the lights of their cars lighten up and their expressions hard. Bow closes the curtain again, jogging towards the door quickly. “Let me see what they want”

He leans to place a swift kiss over Glimmer´s head and throws Catra and Adora a reassuring look before rushing through the frame of the door and outside, leaving the rest of them with their heart on their sleeve. Adora huffs, cleaning her eyes from tears with the heel of her palm, trying to calm down the rapid beating of her heart without much success.

“Glimmer, this is crazy. Mara, she would have said something,” Adora´s voice trembles at the mention of Mara´s name, her expression tethering with doubt. “She would have told me. Serenia was her mother.”

“Serenia died when Mara was just a baby, Adora,” Glimmer says gently, shaking her head. “Why the hell did Mara leave?”

“I don´t know.” Adora lets her head fall into her palms, groping the strands of her hair so hard her scalp hurts with the pull. “I don´t know, Glimmer, I´ve spent years asking myself that same question.” Glimmer watches as the whole weight of the world falls over her, throwing her off her axis completely. “What is happening?”

“It's alright,” Catra whispers next to her, brushing her hair off her face and tucking it behind her ears. Catra turns to look at Glimmer, her eyes ice hard and tired. “Is there something else, Sparkles?”

“That's all I have for now but there are more papers here that my mom marked and a data pad,” Glimmer throws everything inside the table, bouncing her knee nervously. “We are missing something but I just can't put my damn finger on what it is. But– there is a letter here Adora, and I really fucking need you to read it.”

There is a soft sound behind them, ripping their attention back to the door. Bow is walking back inside with slow steps, his eyes clouded, hands trembling to his sides. His lips are shivering and he looks completely out of it, barely managing to hold himself steady. The two officers are lingering back in the corridor, looking

at the group with serious eyes and speaking in hushed voices on the communicators pinned to their uniforms.

Glimmer stands up from her chair, so fast that she accidentally tilts the chair backwards and it falls against the floor. She rushes next to his side, her heart on her throat, dread pooling on the back of her mouth. “Bow”

Adora stands up too, so tight and tense that she looks like a cord about to snap in half. Her shoulders are shivering and she has gone completely pale, dark bags below her pretty eyes deep as bruises. “What is it?”

Bow opens his mouth and closes it again, unable to speak for a second. He stands still on the door but his eyes are not on Glimmer or on Adora, bearing themselves in Catra´s pretty and suddenly terrified face.

“I–” he tries, the corners of his mouth pulling sadly. “I´m sorry, Catra”

Catra stands up from the chair, shaking from head to toe that she might crumble into the floor. Sorrow is crawling on the inside of her heart, tearing it to pieces.

“I'm really sorry”

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❀

The walls of the house are painted in black and the details are copper, columns and balcony crawling with soft moss and mold and decay. Adora stares at the so familiar yet so dreaded windows of the house and trembles, biting on the inside of her mouth hard. She has never wished to come back here, no even once.

It's been such a long time. The last time she was at Catra´s home, the yellow paint of the kitchen was covered in blood.

Glimmer and Bow are leading the march through the street, Adora following close behind. Her arm is tightly crossed around Catra´s shoulders and her forearm, holding her flush against her side as they dodge police officers, curious neighbors, paramedics and the forensic team, slipping below the yellow tape and standing fully in front of the steps that lead to the porch.

Four steps exactly, and the second one creaks if you stand a little bit too long on the left side. Catra knows those steps by heart because she used to jump on them when she was back home from school. She used to paint them and clean them and sit on them waiting for Adora to come and pick her up.

There is a body laying on those steps, spreading dark blood on the dark paint.

"Let us through," Glimmer grumbles, pushing back two officers that approach the group and start trying to push them back into the crowd. "Let us fucking through"

Catra can listen to her but she cannot make sense of what she is saying. She cannot make sense of what is happening around her, of the people chattering around the block, of the voice screaming inside her head. She cannot make sense of the shadow with her mother´s form that lingers in the corner of her eyes and that disappears every time she blinks, drowned by shadows and smiling at her.

She cannot feel Adora´s arm around her or her breath over her cheeks when she speaks to her, when she says something, when she apologizes. As if it was her fault, as if the person holding the knife against the body had been her, as if she had torn apart someone Catra loved and not held her the entire night inside warm arms. Catra could never blame her for this and yet, she cannot hear her or feel her right now, completely drowned in despair.

Scorpia´s body looks back at her with void eyes, her dark pupils shrunken, covered by the veil of death against the starry night

above their heads. Her white hair is short again and it's wrong because Catra knows it was long and soft like cotton, easy to braid like Perfuma taught her to do. Perfuma, who is also dead. Perfuma who might have caught Scorpia in her arms when her soul was ripped from this world. Perfuma, who took Scorpia´s hand and led her gently to the other side, smiling all the way after waiting for her. The only way Catra could ever accept what is happening right now, the only way she will ever be able to find solace in mourning.

Catra steps forward, standing over the stone sidewalk of her childhood home. She has dropped Adora´s hand at some point because she cannot feel her warmth anymore, replaced by the freezing cold night and numbness. She can´t feel her face and for so, she doesn´t even notice she has started to cry until the tears make her vision blurr and they spill down her chin, crashing against the pavement like rain.

"Scorpia," Catra whispers, walking and walking until she is right in front of the cold body, looking down at it without moving. "Scorpia? This is not funny, you know?"

Someone has taken the lamb mask off Scorpia´s face and Catra is thankful for that because otherwise she would have not been able to look at Scorpia fully. There is still fresh blood staining her pale chin and neck, pooling near her ears, but otherwise her cheeks and forehead are clean, paler than Catra has ever seen them before. Her maroon shirt is dark too but just in some places and it takes Catra a second too long to understand that they are stab wounds, draining her into the ground, bleeding her dead on the steps of Catra´s home.

She is resting over the wood and the stone like a saint that has been sacrificed for a greater deed, or a terrible one, arms over her chest and the floor, red floor, like covered in rose petals but soaked in crimson blood instead. The lamb mask has been made with a hare´s skin and it is still warm, waiting patiently for Adora and her heart to arrive.

“Scorpia,” Catra repeats, choking in her breath. She calls but Scorpia does not answer back. Next to her, inside her chest, hovering over her shoulder like a demon, she can feel the invisible weight of her mother's hands, petting the soft baby curls that grow behind Catra´s ears with mocking care, pressing her ghostly mouth filled with old blood next to her neck.

*´She is dead ´*

“No”

*´She is dead. Dead, dead, dead ´* Weaver chants, torturing Catra, even in death.

Catra shakes her head harshly, letting the tears carve marks against her cheeks. She thinks how someone told her once that you were supposed to be able to feel when something happened to someone you loved. She felt when Adora crashed in her parents car, like a tug on her soul that made her tumble to the ground with pain. She did not feel it when her father fell into the river. She did not feel it when the killer stabbed Scorpia´s chest with clumsy aim and left her bleeding on the floor. Maybe it was a soulmate thing, maybe it was just a big joke from the world. Maybe Catra is just truly, absolutely broken now.

“Scorpia,” Catra chokes, falling heavily on her knees next to Scorpia´s head, uncaring when her knee flares up in agonizing pain at the crash over the stone. “Scorpia?”

*´ Why aren´t you dead?´* Weaver asks, almost as if confused, rotten against Catra´s cheek. *´ I killed you ´*

Catra extends her hand, brushing her fingertips over Scorpia´s cold knuckles, stained in red and frozen. She is not warm anymore, Scorpia is always warm. Warm and gentle and she loves hugs, she loves hugging her friends. She loves hugging Catra even when the latter groans and pushes her playfully away, Scorpia has never shy herself away from embracing Catra when she needs it.

Catra can remember the last time they hugged, In Scorpia´s apartment before death chased them apart. Warm and gentle like the cookies they shared, kind, filled with reassurance to one another. Scorpia wrapped Catra´s much smaller form inside her arms and Catra, for the first time in a long time, embraced her back, slender arms around wide back, thanking silently that she was alright.

Now Scorpia is cold and she will never hug anybody else. She will never hug Catra again. She will not walk her up the steps of the altar. She will not be there to dance with her on the wedding floor. She will not heal from the pain, she will not fall in love again. She will not be there ever again.

"No, no." Catra whispers, realization finally ripping through her bones and making it to her chest and brain, "Scorpia. Scorpia, wake up." Catra chokes on breath and tears, clogging her throat and making her deaf and blind, all that she can feel is Scorpia´s cold hand when Catra presses her palms over her shoulders and shakes her once, hoping she will wake up when she never will. "Please, no. No"

*´ Oh, Catrina. Look at you. All alone again.´*

"No, Scorpia," Catra chokes,  sorrow finally clogging her throat and making her burst into tears. they travel down her cheeks and smudge the dark of her makeup into bruises. "Oh, no"

She could scream but she doesn´t, she could howl and slam herself against the floor and the steps and crack her skull open on the columns of her home but her legs have gone numb and she cannot feel her soles. All she can do is let out the most heart wrenching sob and fall heavily against Scorpia´s stone cold chest, crying her heart out over the maroon shirt stained in blood.

It stains her cheeks and her hands, it sticks to the curls bouncing in her forehead and spreads against the forearms but she cannot move away. Catra´s already broken and crumbling heart splinters

in unfixable places and bleeds her from the inside out, mirroring in the tears drowning her face and slamming against her temples.

An officer or two approach her, they seize her arms and pull her harshly away but she fights them violently, digging her shivering fingers in Scorpia´s shoulders and open neck and holding herself to her. Someone is screaming at her, right next to her, someone else says that she is compromising the scene and asks her if she is out of her mind, asks her if she wants to be taken to jail instead but Catra screams at them and refuses to stand up.

Adora arrives to her side in an instant, falling over her knees heavily, painful even. She wraps her arms around Catra´s waist and doesn´t pull from her, instead sheltering with her body and back against the angry officers and screaming at them to leave her alone. Catra can hear Adora furious above her, straining her vocal cords and cursing her lungs out, allowing Catra of a second longer to mourn in her best friend´s chest.

Catra doesn´t even know how it happened, she doesn´t even know how. Nobody will ever read it or know but it has happened and the only thing Catra can hope for as she nuzzles her cheek over Scorpia´s cold chest is that she had not suffered and that it was quick.

"I´ve got you," Adora whispers against her ear, chasing the shadows away even if she cannot see them or hear them at all. Adora runs her hand through Catra´s forehead, push her curls again and hold her crying body, absorbing the heartbreaking inside her own body. "I´ve got you"

Behind them, on the street, Glimmer is crying silently on her palm, her head pulsing and in pain with the sting of cold tears. Bow snaps, kicking against the pavement and then against an errand trash can on the street, yelling at the top of his lungs.

"Fuck," he yells, warm tears running down his cheeks. "Fuck!"

Huntara appears among the crowd, bee lining towards Glimmer and Bow, sparing once swift look towards Adora holding Catra´s crying body before turning her attention towards the other two. Glimmer sees her arrive and her blood freezes inside her body, fury running down her veins and chest, making her breathing speed up inside her chest and choke her with anger. She steps right in front of Huntara and before the detective can say anything at all, grabs the data pad on her hand and slams it against the floor, stomping over the broken pieces of screen with her pink shoes.

“Huntara what the fuck happened?!”

Huntara has the decency to look appalled, embarrassed even, her tanned face pale and her white hair tousled, hands trembling at her sides where she keeps them into fists. She looks at Glimmer´s furious lilac eyes and turns around to glance quickly at Scorpia´s dead body. “I– I don´t know”

“What do you mean you don´t fucking know?! You said she was safe!” Glimmer pulls from her own hair, snapping pink strands that tangle on her fingers. “Where is Entrapta?”

“They are still in the safe house,” Huntara answers, robotically, running her hands across her forehead and nose, “Listen, your friend walked out of the safe house and went out hell knows where!”

“And why did the officers not stop her?!” Glimmer presses, barely biting back the need to hit Huntara in the face. The last thing she needs right now is to be thrown into prison for hitting her in the face. “Where were you?!”

“I went confessing with Priest Prime and then back to the office, Bright. Do not point your finger at me!”

“You are completely incompetent! If you would just look at these papers and listen to us then you might have–”

“Miss Bright, that's enough!”

“Listen to us!”

Glimmer is still screaming her lungs out at Huntara, calling the entire neighborhood's attention. Bow stands behind her and says nothing but his face is terrible too, trembling from head to toe and angry; there are a few papers on his hands, wrinkled and at mid read, taken in a hurry when they were dragged to the police cars. Huntara looks about to snap too but doesn´t have the guts to do it, yelling back at Glimmer every time she answers back.

Adora has managed to gently extract Catra from Scorpia´s side, guiding her as softly as possible towards the side of the house, sitting her on the plain pavement with her back towards the house. The air near them smells weird, like old blood and past rain and something acrid, acidic, something that burns the nose and the back of the tongue. Adora wrinkles her nose around the smell but doesn't pay attention to it, scrunching in front of Catra´s shivering body and cradling her face between her hands.

“Cat,” Adora calls her, caressing her forehead with gentle fingers. Her own eyes are wet with tears, unable to hold them back at the look of Catra´s devastated face. Her face is tearing itself to pieces inside her chest, unbearable guilt staining it all in red. “Catra, sweetheart”

“Scorpia is dead,” Catra whispers, voice raw. She is looking at Adora but not really, wrapping her fingertips around her biceps. “Scorpia is dead”

A sob escapes Adora´s mouth, cleaning with her thumbs the unstoppable rush of tears from her eyes. “I´m sorry, I´m so sorry. This is all my fault.” Adora whispers, breaking in pieces too. “Please forgive me, please forgive me, Cat”

The sound of Adora mourning too seems to be able to pull Catra out of her head because her clouded eyes turn towards Adora, searching for her silver eyes. Catra´s pupils are shrunk and frantic, staring at Adora´s face like she was just seeing her for the very first time now. Her face is terrible, terrified and pale, patches

of red on her neck and cheekbones and bruises underneath her eyes.

Her trembling hand shoots upwards, wrapping her palm around Adora´s neck, brushing her thumb over her jaw, a fine line of red marking over the pale of Adora´s face. She looks at Adora with such an amount of desperation that it makes Adora´s breath stuck to her throat.

“Scorpia is dead and I– I can't lose you Adora. Not you” Catra whispers, her teeth clicking with each other violently. She is holding Adora so hard inside her fingers that her joints hurt, “I can't go through that. Don't make me– don't make me go through that, please, I can´t.”

“You won't.” Adora urges her, running her fingers through Catra´s ears and hair, leaning to press a desperate kiss against Catra´s lips. It hurts a little bit, lips against lips and teeth crashing together, Adora presses her tongue against the lip to ease the pain and kisses her again, tears and warm breath. It´s comfort, it is frantic and terrified, meant to reassure them both amongst the terror. The world is crumbling down. “We'll be together, alright? We are together”

“No, you need to leave.” Catra's nails prick accidentally on Adora's skin, her pretty eyes frantic and skin clammy with sweat. “It's not going to stop until it gets you. You know it. You need to get out of here because if you stay it's going to hunt you and if it does–” Catra's hands shake, her eyes widening with terror. “If it does– if you die because of me– I, I´m going to– I´m going to die.”

“Catra–”

“Adora, please.”

Adora clenches her teeth and pulls her shirt off, cleaning the blood from Catra´s face and arms with the fabric. The air is very cold where it touches against Adora´s bare arms and back, exposed below the straps of the white tank top below. Catra runs her palm

past Adora´s bandaged shoulder and the base of her collarbones, feeling Adora´s pulse point underneath the pads of her fingers.

“I´m scared,” Catra whispers, shaking and exhausted, leaning her head against Adora´s temple. “I´m fucking scared, Adora.”

“Don't be afraid,” Adora presses her palm over the side of Catra´s neck, caressing the ragged edges of the scar with her fingertips, holding them both. Her blue eyes are blazing red on her face, red underneath the light of the ambulances and the police cars and the blood on the house.

“I'm getting you out, alright? We are taking the car and I'm getting you out of here.” Adora draws invisible circles on Catra´s forehead, lingering kisses over her cheeks, “And after I´m going to find it. If it's me who it wants then I´m going to face it myself and I'm going to end this no matter what. I won't let that animal hurt us again”

“Adora, no”

“I promise,” Adora says against Catra´s mouth, brushing her fingers over the ring in Catra´s finger. She closes her eyes tightly, her head heavy and her chest burning with determination. “I promise.”

They kiss dearly for a few more seconds, sharing their breath and their love and fear. Adora wraps Catra´s limbs around hers and holds her tightly against her chest, rocking them both sweetly into a gentle reassurance.

A hand falls quietly against Adora´s shoulder, calling for her attention again. Adora tilts her head to the side, meeting Glimmer ´s wide and frantic eyes out of sudden. The hand that is resting over Adora´s shoulder is trembling and there is a torn piece of newspaper on her other one. Huntara has retired somewhere near Scorpia´s body and Bow is closer to the line of the trees, switching nervously on his feet.

“Adora,” Glimmer calls under her breath, very careful of not disturbing Catra curling inside Adora´s arms but still insistent. “You need to come for a second”

Adora clenches her jaw, holding Catra closer. “Glimmer, not now”

“Just a second,” Glimmer´s voice is much firmer now, eyes hard, falling through Adora´s body. Suddenly Adora feels cold all over, adrenaline running from the tip of her fingers to the back of her throat. “This is very important. Come. Now”

Adora holds her eyes and nods, squeezing Catra´s shivering shoulders. She extracts herself as softly as she can from Catra´s arms, wrapping the soiled shirt over her bare shoulders. When Catra looks at her, alarmed, Adora just shakes her head, placing kisses all across catra´s cheeks and lips.

“Stay right here.”

Catra looks back at her with her big owl eyes and nods after a second of hesitation, Letting go of Adora´s shirt with a heavy weight in her chest. Adora grabs her wrists gently between her fingers and raises them to press a kiss over her knuckles and the inner side of her wrists. When Adora stands up again her legs are numb and her body is heavy, and it hurts, letting go of Catra´s hand hurts. It feels like stabbing her heart wide open and out of her chest, right now. Their fingers cling to each other on the pads and then let go completely.

Adora follows Glimmer across the street, looking over her shoulder at Catra sitting next to her empty house the whole time. She ignores neighbors and police stares and even trips twice, refusing to tear her eyes away from her fiance for a single second until Glimmer pulls from her hand really hand, making Adora return her eyes towards her.

“Adora”

“What?” Adora snaps, looking back at Glimmer with a deep frown. Glimmer slams the paper on her hands, tapping over the wrinkled

surface harshly.

“My mom was right, she did figure it out!” She exclaims, eyes so wide inside her head they might just fall off their sockets. Adora blinks at the paper without understanding, looking at the same picture they were looking at an hour ago.

“What do you mean?”

“Look here, look who is behind them! Look where they are!”

Adora narrows her eyes, straining her sight. Serenia and Marlena are standing in the steps of an old looking door, stone columns and stained glass, old copper covered in black gold and crystals in the back. It's the old Etherian church, the one that was demolished years ago and to which´s remains Adora used to go play in when she was just a child. In the photograph it rises on all it´s might, barely hidden by the light of the midday sun falling over the lens.

And there, right behind Marlena, hidden among the jarred shadows, there is a third person standing and barely caught by the camera. It is a young man, of the same age as the twins, with hair so clear it looks white and bright green eyes among the darkness of the church´s door.

“Nordor Kurr asked for your mom's hand in marriage,” Glimmer whispers in a hurry, her knuckles pale where she holds the paper. “He did it in front of the mass, it was a whole deal and it was big news in the town. They were meant to marry but your mom eloped with your father and they got married in secret instead. And I– I don´t think that man ever got over that humiliation. I think he took revenge.”

Adora looks at the picture blankly, speaking absently. “Who the fuck is Nordor Kurr?”

“Adora,” Glimmer rests her fingers over Adora´s jaw, pulling her back from her thoughts. “It´s Priest Prime. It was his name before ordering into the First Ones.”

Bow is lingering near them, his face worn out. He hands Glimmer another wrinkled paper without looking at Adora. Around them the crowd has gotten messier, more crowded even, the forensic team, the officers and neighbors walking all around the street and the house. The air smells worse now, like clotted blood and ether.

"There was a letter on my mom´s briefcase, I, I read it at the hotel and was going to show it to you before the officers went for us. It´s dated from early this year and was directed to Mayor Hordak and Priest Prime, to both of them, as a request. From Light Hope. A request for you to be accepted into the chapel once you were finished with college."

Adora's eyes are huge, rimmed in red. "What does the chapel have to do with anything?"

"Adora, you getting into the Academy was not a coincidence, she wanted you to become a First One in every sense of the word. Light Hope wanted you to become not only a priestess for Prime, but his left hand. First One´s Priests can take spouses, and he convinced Light Hope to offer your hand to him," Glimmer gulps around a heavy knot, holding Adora´s shoulders when she feels like she is going to fall into the ground. "I think– I think this is why your mom never let you go out of her sight. She must have suspected what Prime did years ago in her name. And I think this is why Mara was so angry. Because she knew that Prime had washed Light Hope´s brain to get you near him when you were to become an adult."

"But," Adora´s brain feels like molasses, heavy and sticky, "But Light Hope–"

"Adora, this is him. All of this is him! He was obsessed with your mom and took revenge on her for marrying your dad. He killed those women, he killed your aunt. He killed our friends. He killed my mom when she figured things out! She covered all of Hordak's secrets so she must have crosses paths with the letter"

“And Light Hope must have told him you planned to leave with Catra for the Horde,” Bow adds in, speaking for the first time. He looks at Adora heavily, his hands into fists. “It must have triggered him again. He killed Hordak to hide the tracks and started killing the friends that resembled you.”

“People all around town go and confess all their fucking secrets to him. My mom, Huntara. He knows where you have been and where to hurt you.” Glimmer digs her fingers over Adora's fingers, accidentally pulling from the stitches. “He is leaving messages to you to drive you mad. He is hunting you for sport! He's leading you to a trap!”

“But then why kill Scorpia? She doesn't resemble me.” Adora asks out loud. “Out of all places related to me, why leave her in this house-?”

Adora´s voice dies in her throat, her eyes widening with terror. She snaps her head back, looking towards the little corner of the house where she had just been but the pavement is empty. Dry flowers and nothing else. Catra is not there.

“Where's Catra?” Adora´s heart speeds up inside her chest, choking her, driving her mad. “Where is Catra?!

Adora yells, rushing across the street with her heart on her throat. Glimmer and Bow run behind her too, their faces frantic as they start looking around. There are so many people around them, so many cars coming and going, the thick darkness of the woods surrounding them on this loud night where the only thing that can be see among the clouds and past the high tree tops, is the tall tower of the Chapel and the hovering full and red over it.

“Catra!” Adora screams, straining her vocal cords, standing in the point where Catra was sitting, in the point where Adora left her. “No, no, no. Catra!”

Terror crawls on Adora´s throat, tearing its way inside her heart. She is in the black house again and Catra is slipping out of her

fingers again, unable to be able to hold her against her chest no matter how hard she tries. Adora turns around and looks among the darkness, hoping to catch Catra among the crowd or next to Scorpia´s still laying body or even in one of the police cars, but she is nowhere to be seen, gone like a ray of light hidden by the night.

Adora digs her nails against her own chest until it hurts, until the golden chain of the reliquary tangles with her fingers and the pain in her limbs mirrors the pain hammering inside her heart in chest. Until the pain matches the storm going on inside her head, chaotic and dangerous like a hurricane slamming against the earth, violent like the earth breaking in the middle and corrupting the air, lethal like acid rain. All the good and tender things inside her soul are covered in the shadows that had been chasing her, staining her completely, unable to carve them out again.

Adora´s phone starts vibrating violently inside the pocket of her pants, the sweet tune she saves for Catra and Catra alone ripping her out of her head. She takes the little thing out of her pocket with trembling hands and stares back at Catra´s pretty face on the screen, running her thumb so hard over the smooth screen that she almost drops it twice.

Glimmer and Bow have gathered at her sides, panting and sweating after running around the block looking for Catra. Adora presses the phone against her ear, her eyes narrowing with horror, when she hears the heavy breathing on the other side.

"Catra?"

*"Adora."* the cracking voice answers on the other side, using Catra´s phone to break Adora´s heart. *"Beautiful, beautiful Adora. How are you doing, pretty hare?"*

Adora clenches her jaw and bites into her tongue until she feels blood pooling inside her mouth, her bright eyes so blue under the night that they look like lighthouses. The phone cracks a little

where she holds it, straining under the strength of her hand, veins raising in her arms and her neck.

"Where is Catra?" she asks, very slowly, chewing on each word sticky and full of rage. On the other side the voice chuckles, tapping softly over the speaker of the phone, almost like a caress.

*"Oh, don´t you recognize me? My love?"*

"You are not her." Adora snaps, running her nails over her own neck, scratching down until she paints lines of red over her own skin. She feels caged, caged and out of breath, trapped like a prey under claws and Catra is not here, she has been taken away like bait for Adora to catch. "Where is she? Where the fuck is she?"

*"Are you sure?"*

"Answer me! ANSWER ME!"

Adora is screaming at the top of her lungs now but she doesn´t care. People are looking at her but she doesn´t care. She cannot do it, she cannot do this again. She cannot lose Catra again. She looked away for a second again and someone took her from her again. Adora cannot do it.

There is a strong sound on the other side of the phone, a dry hit and a groan and the characteristic cracking of someone kicking and moving around, slamming her body against unseen restraints and managing to tear her throat free, screaming back at Adora like a soul that is being pulled to hell.

" *Leave her alone* " Catra is screaming, far away from the speaker yet loud, her voice cracking in all places with terror. " *You motherfucker, leave her alone!"*

"Catra!" Adora cries on the phone, tears falling down her eyes heavy and dark. Adora pushes through a burst of tears, tugging from her own hair until her scalp hurts. Her voice breaks in all places, unable to hold back her mourn.

" *Adora!"*

It´s alright, it´s alright, sweetheart." Adora falls forwards, barely held up by Bow´s arms around her waist. This all feels too familiar, too close to the heart, too much like those times. Too much. "Tell me where you are. I´m going to get you, just tell me where you are, baby."

*"No! Don´t come here! Don´t come!"* Catra howls, fighting against something Adora cannot see. She sounds in pain, she sounds terrified and tired and still trying to be brave. " *Please don´t come!"*

*"That is one pretty ring, little hare,"* the killer purrs, dropping the face filter voice. Clear and loud and real.

The ring, ring, Marlena´s ring now Catra´s. The ring Adora placed there just a few hours ago, a promise between them and for the rest of the world to belong to each other. Adora shivers at the sound, digging her nails on Bow´s hand accidentally, trembling so hard her teeth are clicking together.

*"Stay away from me!"* Catra howls, kicking something in her fight. She wheezes through the phone, letting through a laughter so out of breath and so painful that it tears Adora´s souls into pieces. " *You're pathetic. You´ve always been pathetic, desiring what you can´t have like a fucking animal on rut. A pathetic excuse of a man and pathetic excuse of a fucking bitch!"*

A hand slaps across a face and Catra sputters, unable to hold a sob against the sparks of pain. And it is red, all that Adora can see or hear or taste is red. Red like blood, red like the moon, red like Catra´s lips. Red.

"Do not fucking touch her!" Adora slams her palm against the columns of the house and against her own body, so hard that the stone cracks and her knuckles break open and bleed. "I'm going to kill you! Did you hear me?! I´m going to fucking kill you if you touch her!"

The killer chuckles, a low and dry laughter that echoes across the speaker like a venom, like a sickness. Like a storm that Adora pushed back for far too long. Somewhere behind him Catra whimpers, gasping for air, when she fights her restraints and falls against the cold floor. Adora´s eyes narrow, chest paining so hard that she doubts her heart is even there anymore.

*"Then come for her. Come for your little stray"*

*"No, no, Adora! He is going to kill you. He is going to kill you, Adora. Stay away! "*

"Catra, no," Adora looks all around her, at the night and Bow´s eyes and Glimmer´s expression and the darkness and she cannot see any of them. "No. No matter where you are I´ll find you, I´ll always find you."

*"I love you"* Catra begs, choking on her breath. Someone is pushing against her throat, ripping the air and her soul out of her. Another dry hit and a grunt, Catra gasps wherever she is. Her voice is very low now, echoing in Adora´s ears only. She is afraid but she doesn´t say it. " *I love you, I love you, Adora. Please, don´t come. Promise it, promise me."*

Catra grunts one more time, her voice failing her and lowering down completely. Adora snaps like a broken sword, running her nails against her neck until she bleeds herself. "Catra!"

" *This game has been fun, little hare, but I'm tired of it,"* he says, clicking his tongue against his teeth. " *You can come for her, if you want her."*

On the square the clock turns into midnight and the bells of the chapel go off loudly, echoing through the phone and across Adora´s ears, a call for doom, a last call for the lovers to come together. The phone call cuts off fully and Adora is left alone there, hearing her own breath and missing Catra´s completely. She cannot hear Catra anymore and her heart and soul is gone, trapped like a bird in a golden age in a harpy´s lair.

“No, no! NO!” Adora slams her phone against the floor, breaking in dozens of pieces “Bastard! Fucking bastard! No!”

Adora pulls from her hair until golden strands of her hair come crumbling on her fingers, gold dyed in copper, her scalp screaming. She kicks and breaks and screams until the people gathered around her step back from her, scared of her, disgusted and terrified.

“Adora. Adora, I need you to calm down!” Glimmer is tugging from Adora´s arm, hanging from her strained bicep and trying to pull back from her. But Adora is just so tall right now, so big yet so small at the same time, panting, hovering above the world yet as small as she could possibly be, trembling like a leaf and unmoving like a goddess statue. “We need to call detective Huntara and Lashor and they can–”

Adora snaps her eyes towards Glimmer and the latter closes her mouth so fast that she accidentally bites herself. Adora´s face is terrible, completely devastated, completely worn by war. If she hadn´t broke before now she is in pieces, grasping at the air as if this way she could grasp for the hands of the woman she loves.

Adora quite literally pushes Glimmer away, ignoring her when she gasps surprised and stumbles in Bow´s hands who catches her before she falls.

Adora doesn´t see any of this because she hurries across the street like a haunted spirit, not even cleaning the tears running down her face as when she jumps into an errand car and slams the door behind her, roaring the engine back on immediately. For the first time since she was fourteen, she doesn´t even wear a seatbelt.

“Adora?” Glimmer calls for her, tripping on the floor as both her and Bow try to catch her up. “Adora, you can´t do it alone! Adora, wait!”

Adora steps on the pedal and rushes away so fast that the wheels scream against the pavement, right against the line of the trees. She is a spirit, she is a corpse, chasing for her soul among darkness, fighting the river and tearing down the church.

She follows the chapel´s spiral like a compass across the night, the bells still slamming against her heart.

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*End of Chapter V*

Chapter End Notes

Congratulations to those that guessed that Prime was the killer, as I said, easy but not quite as much. There are still a lost questions to answer and a lot of pain to go through ehehehe because I´ve you´ve realized now, the stray is now in danger

Also I hate myself for killing Scorpia, don´t even talk to me about that

Our posting schedule is changing again! Next week is our finale week so the days will be as described next
Chapter 6 Monday July 8
Chapter 7 Friday July 12
Epilogue Sunday July 14

CAN´T WAIT TO REAL FOR YOUR COMMENTS. SEE YOU ON MONDAY FOR THE CONFRONTATION!!

# Sing O´muse, The Wrath

Chapter Summary

'She is a miracle'

Chapter Notes

*giggling and kicking my feet* I made a bet and I am excited about it.

Sorry the update was until the evening but I had work. But here it is, are you ready? Slightly shorter than usual (just 20k) but I'll make up for it.

Run for your lives, little hares! Time to face the Antler Demon!

And time to see Mara

See you downstairs!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

## [Sing O´muse, The Wrath]

*Be good, be good, be good, be good, be good, be good, be good*

*And he replies 'No'*

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⚜

### October 29th. Midnight.

Adora stops right in front of the chapel, jumping down the barely stopping car with her heart in her throat. She is not waiting for a single second more sitting there, rushing across the empty and cold grass and throwing herself at the pristine new door.

It´s  very cold tonight, freezing cold, and Adora´s ears are ringing where the bells of the chapel stopped echoing in the town but kept ringing inside her head. Her lips are chapped from the cold and from the terror, pale and broken where Adora bites into herself so hard she bleeds herself, staining the fragile skin in purple.

Adora can see the inside of the chapel through the stained windows framing the heavy door, her breath creating mist and broken snowflakes against the glass, her palms pressing so hard against the metal of the barriers that her skin colors red with the cold and the harsh hold. There are thorns on the windows, thorns without roses crawling all around the walls and twisting in black above the religious figure atop of the frame and Adora wonders absently how nobody else ever noticed how much poison and rot has always lived inside of here.

Adora pushes her hand against the metal door, holding her breath when it gives up easily. She is clenching her teeth so hard that her molars chip on the edges and her jaw screams with pain, threatening to lock itself against the strained muscles. Anxiety and anger are running down Adora´s arms as she steps inside, the most raw of furies and hate, hatred like no other when the first breath of incense mingled with blood fills her lungs.

The chapel is freezing cold and dark, as dark as it could possibly be, almost all the candles blown out except for the ones placed on the tall altar on the north wall. The wax drips black with the green fire, falling against polished floor and the red petals of poppies and tulips scattered all over the altar- Red, just red, not a single other color in sight but black and red and the green flames.

Above the black gold of the altar´s table, a figure rises, the bones of the Deity displayed from side to side, arms open and head tilted to the side. Carefully curated so the light yellow of the mineral is clear below the light that enters through the dome of the ceiling, Phalanges and femurs; pelvis and spine; humerus, metacarpals and collarbone. Skull, polished and adorned by crystals and gems, from the nasal bone and all the way across the

frontal and parietal bones, falling across the zygomatic arch and mandible. The long ago fallen teeth have been filled with diamonds and cerulean gems and the cranium has been adorned with a crown of red metal, heavy and sharp in the form of the First One´s symbol, two bat wings with a ruby in the middle of the empty eye sockets.

Adora gulps at the side, thrown back for a second as she looks at the bones and rot cradled on its usual red robes, heavy fabric, stained in old blood, the very same robes she had seen in Scorpia ´s apartment over the killer´s shoulders. Adora had seen the deity every single day since Light Hope first dragged her here to pray and kneel and hear the choir sing. And there, cradled around bone and gems and nails to the frail skull, are strands of blonde, of a different tone, of a different color, braided carefully into loops. Perfuma´s, Starla´s, Scorpia´s and other´s that even here are hard to place. Except one, blonde and gray, old, crumbling, the strands of hair of Adora´s mother that were desecrated off her coffin after her death, a wig of rotten adoration for a fake goddess.

She had seen the people of the town throwing themselves to the bones feet and beg at the Deity´s toes to help them, to forgive them, to spare them from eternal flame, lavishing the far away sternum and ribs with sticky tongues full of empty prayers and heavy eyes full of charged desires. Had seen them bleed themselves on the steps of the altar and cry tears on the marble and the flowers, placing corpses of animals and dry antlers and rotten flowers at its feet as if this way alone the Deity would turn her skull towards them and lick their mouths and smile too.

Adora had seen this old corpse hanging from the ceiling and dripping oil into the black candles on every mass and every early morning, hovering above her neck like a guillotine about to slash down, and had gulped and bitten back an exhale of fear. She didn ´t know where it came from but it was already there when Light Hope dragged her to the chapel for the first time. And she never knew why but the sight alone made her want to scream. She had heard the praying whispers on her head over and over and over

again and felt their weight on her back as the murmurs turned towards her and muttered in her ear, *Look at her, she is a saint too.*

A piece of heaven where Adora had been tried to be made a deity herself and from which Catra had been exiled after her mother´s death. As if Catra wasn´t an angel herself, banished. Now Catra lays on the cold marble in front of the altar´s steps, laying on her side and unmoving. All of her hair is covering her face and neck and her shoulders are shivering a little under the harsh cold.

Adora rushes to her side with her heart on her sleeves, tears slipping treacherously from the corners of her eyes as she throws herself against the floor next to her.

"Cat," Adora calls, cringing at the way her own voice sounds so scared and unsure, so absolutely broken at the sight of her love lying like this. Adora gathers Catra in her arms, cradling her still warm body in her hands, gently tucking her against her chest and neck.

A mask has been placed over her face, made of a golden hare´s skin, pulled and sewn over leather until it took the shape of a cat's face, covering her features. Adora grabs it in fury and snaps the fine ribbons that keep it tangled against her curls, almost violently, She throws it to the side without sparing a single more look to it, running her own shivering fingers across Catra´s clammy forehead, staring at her precious face under the dim moonlight.

There is a nasty bruise forming on Catra´s temple and across her cheekbone, pulsing red and purple and painful. Shallow scratches adorn the curve of her jaw and her lip is busted, the piercing cutting a clean line on the bottom lip where she fell against her face. There are lilac and purple lines painted on the base of Catra ´s neck, her delicate skin exposed without the safety of fabric and terrible to look at. Someone has pushed against her throat, ripping the air out of her and the sight alone makes Adora´s blood boil inside her veins.

She is not a demon but she is going to kill him. She is going to kill him like a monster to an animal.

"It's okay, baby. It's okay." Adora whispers, rocking Catra softly over the floor. "I'm here"

In her arms Catra stirs awake, called by Adora´s voice from the very deep of her subconscious. Her pretty eyes blink open, just a slit, enough for the hazel and blue to look back at Adora´s dark silver eyes. Her body curls into itself when she realizes Adora is really there, on the floor of the chapel and holding her, shivering hands rising to grip themselves against the white fabric of Adora ´s shirt, holding her as close to her as possible yet shaking her head at the same time .

"No," Catra mourns, clenching her teeth together. She is trying to look as angry as she could possibly be but her body is betraying her, sinking inside Adora´s warmth and the safety of her hands even though Catra keeps trying to push her away. "No, Adora. Why did you come? Why?"

Adora caresses the arch of Catra´s cheekbones with her thumb, brushing over the cluster of freckles like stars on her skin. Out of the corner of her eyes she can see Catra´s left hand, her slender fingers against Adora´s wrist, holding Adora sweetly. Her ring finger is bleeding, raw and scratched over, the skin hurt and slightly slashed open where the engagement ring was ripped out of her with violence.

Adora grasps the trembling hand and brings it towards her mouth, kissing the sore skin with sweet fingers, uncaring when the blood stains her bottom lip and chin with red.

"Because you are Catra," Adora whispers around tears, nuzzling her nose against Catra´s temple. "My Catra. And I would do anything for you"

Catra´s eyes narrow but her pupils blow up, overcoming all the color in her irises, blurring with tears. She looks so scared and so

sad too in Adora´s arms and the sight makes Adora remember another time, where there was also blood and also sadness and Adora didn´t know what else to do but to hold Catra as close as she could and reassure her with her touch.

“Then let me go, Adora” Catra begs, choking on her breath. Her right hand travels to Adora´s head, running her fingers over the tender baby hairs behind Adora´s ears and up her temple, thumbing the corner of her mouth. “It´s enough. It´s enough, okay? You´ve done enough. So please, please go. I´m ready, alright? Just live,”

“Catra, no”

“He is going to kill you,” Catra squirms in Adora´s arms, biting back a yell of pain when her knee bends. She is spiraling inside her own head, dangerously close to the edge of a panic attack. “He told me, he is going to kill you. I'm going to ruin you even more and he is going to kill you, and I– I–”

Adora closes her mouth with an audible click, chewing on the inner side of her cheek until it bleeds. She holds Catra´s shoulders tighter and rolls her softly, tilting Catra´s shaking head towards her when the other flinches again.

“Catrina, look at me,” Adora snaps, firm and loud, shaking Catra off her panic. Adora´s eyes have hardened but her touch is still firm and she is still looking at Catra with adoration. “I´m not going anywhere without you and you´re not going anywhere without me. It's me and you, alright? Me and you at the end of the world. I'm done fucking sacrificing each other and I´m done leaving you alone.”

Catra´s eyes are wide, clearly thrown back by the tone in Adora´s voice. “But–”

“Are you really going to let this fucking idiot choose how we die? Come on, after everything?” Adora says between clenched teeth, caressing Catra´s neck absently. “You´ve never heard anyone in

your life, not even me. You are strong and stubborn and a fucking brat so don´t tell me that you are going to start to have the backbone of a fish right now”

Catra giggles unintentionally, pushing back a new rush of tears. She bites into her busted lip and shakes her head, feeling more like herself as the seconds go by even if they are both still trembling with fear. “No”

“No, right? So help me lift your pretty butt off the ground and get you out of here so we can finish this, alright?” Adora gulps back a knot full of terror, gently crossing Catra´s forearm over her neck.

Catra nods, wiggling into a more sitting position even if her head is pounding like a warhammer and she feels like she is going to throw up.

“Okay,” she mutters, gripping the hand Adora keeps over her waist like a lifeline, sliding her legs in front of her. “So bossy”

“Learned from the best.”

Adora gets a good grip of Catra´s waist and pulls her up, holding her over unsure feet. The floor is slightly slippery with candle wax and oil and Catra tethers dangerously to the side when she stands up, her shoes stained with blood and mud. Below the joggers the skin of her shin is scratched raw, made with broken branches and dry grass after she was dragged across the woods and thrown inside the chapel like a broken doll. It makes Catra wince when she pulls weight into it, gripping Adora´s shoulders until her knuckles turn pale.

“Ugh”

“It's alright,” Adora whispers, pressing sweet and desperate kisses all over the side of Catra´s face. “I love you. I´m not dropping you.”

“I love you, too” Catra holds her breath and nods again, tucking her head below Adora´s chin. “Thank you for coming for me”

“Always”

Adora narrows her eyes at the darkness, studying the apparently empty chapel as she takes a step back, holding most of Catra´s weight against her body. She weighs nothing for Adora, barely a strained take of breath.

Adora hears the calm steps before she sees the figure appearing in front of them, her head turning sharply towards the sound. Priest Prime walks, slow and confident, from behind the tall altar, chuckling as her slaps his long palms together into a slow applause.

He is wearing the Priest robes, the ones of white and green embroidered in thread of silver and gold and heavy with the sewn precious gems on the hems, The ones that are only used during important occasions like blessing, or weddings. Never to funerals. The weight pulls down from his tall shoulders but he doesn´t seem to notice it or to even care about it.

The long leather gloves on his hands are stained with old blood, long ago dried, as it is the tip of his shoes, and when he appears on scene finally Adora cannot think of anything else but that he smells like rot. Rot and decay and everything a corpse smells like, Moss and humidity and dead cells all covered in the overwhelming stench of incense and myrrh. Adora looks up at the altar and at him as his body stands right below the Deity´s bones and, like this under this frightful angle, the First One´s hieroglyph rises right above his head like antlers over a pale skull.

“What a beautiful display of lovers´adoration,” he laughs, pressing his hands over his slick mouth as if he was praying. “Montenegro and Capellan, even your names sound like they were pulled out of a masterpiece.”

Catra holds her breath, her heart hammering next to Adora´s chest. Her shoulders nuzzle against Adora´s, absently pushing her behind her bruised body, teeth clenched. Adora´s face falls, from tender towards Catra to completely blank to the demon in front of

her, staring at his joyful face with nothing but hatred, raw and complete, poisoning her veins and pooling on her throat and vein.

Prime catches the red stare in her eyes and he laughs again, pressing his palm against his forehead and pushing his white hair behind him, staring at Adora with sick adoration and rotten desire. Even his face seems flushed, taking on pleasure on what is happening now like he had done watching all those young women bleeding out on his fingers.

"Adora. Dearest Adora," he chants, pointing at her. "It is so good to see you like this now, without masks"

Adora clicks her teeth together, giving a tiny step back, holding Catra against her the entire time. She can see the altar better now, the dry and weary flowers and the dark candles and the faux demon mask placed almost as a second thought over it. She doesn´t know how long it has been laying there but maybe it has been there the whole time, the entire town blind to what was staring at them right back in the eyes.

Prime follows her line of sight and he chuckles when he sees the mask there, shaking his head with mirth. He takes it between his gloved hands, holding it besides his face and dangling it softly, like a toy. Under the moonlight and the candles, his eyes look more green than ever.

"Oh, this? Did you like it? I thought it would be a nice touch considering the theme of the hunt."

He looks back at it, wrinkling his slick nose and dropping it back to the floor. He shrugs, her entire posture and demeanor screaming confidence. He is not afraid of what is happening, he knows that he is going to win the race in the end so he is not worried.

"It´s tacky. I much prefer the ones I made specifically for your friends and your love." Prime points with his square chin at Catra ´s fallen mask next to her feet, smiling from ear to ear. "Don´t you agree, Adora? Your mother loved literature so much, she

always talked about it, she even skipped mass to read in the graveyard. I think it is an homage to her. That beautiful, beautiful Marlena, I was so devastated by the way she died. She didn't even allowed me to get near her again before she bled out on your father's car”

Catra gasps, holding Adora so close that her joints hurt, her skin itchy where the mask was after Prime knocked her out with a hit. Adora chokes with her breath, her eyes widening in her pale face, her entire chest tightening as the words make sense inside of her head. Bile gathers in her mouth and she throws it all out with a spit, saliva and blood crashing against the marble in front of Prime ´s feet.

“You are a bastard,” Adora growls, her voice low and drowned into a grunt. She can feel wrath boiling in her skin like an itch that doesn´t wash away, eating her skin and muscle alive like bacteria and poisoning her from the inside out, bursting out of her in blisters. “You are going to pay for all that you did, I swear to your fucking Deity that you will”

Prime´s face falls, his arms dropping next to his body. He shakes his head in disappointment, clicking his tongue against his sharp teeth. He is so white like this, like a specter, albinism on his skin and hair and emerald on his irises.

“Oh, Adora. Are you still insisting on this?” Prime gives a step forward, climbing down a single step. He points at Catra with his thin finger covered in leather, tilting his head to the side. The rosaries on his neck tingle with each movement. “You will only hurt the one you love in the process. More than you have already done”

Adora hisses, curling around herself as if the words were actual knives stabbing on her chest. It pains her deeply and strains the strings of her heart, robbing her out of her breath. She holds Catra's waist and hand on her fingers but suddenly all she can feel are tears and blood on her skin and when she looks to the side all she can see are Catra's precious eyes open in fear and her neck

gaping and bleeding, a sight that had been carved below Adora's eyelids and chased her nightmares for months now.

All she can feel is sudden terror and overwhelming guilt until Catra touches her jaw gently with the tip of her fingers, brushing her thumb over Adora's bruised lip and bringing her back to the present where Catra is bruised but she is still alive. Where she can make it out of this alive and live the rest of her life baking and wishing to sing as Adora promised her she would do. Adora is going to hold on to that promise with her entire being.

“Don't listen to him,” Catra begs but Prime's voice is sharp like a sword and it digs itself deeper and deeper inside Adora's soul, festering her like unwanted rot.

"Am I wrong? Am I wrong to say you have already hurt her enough?” Prime gives another step, playing with something dangling from his fingers. Below the dome of the chapel Adora can make the shape of Catra's rings, bloodied and shattered in the middle. “Weaver might have pushed the glass against her neck but you broke her heart, Adora. You are guilty of her pain. Do you think that is love?”

“What do you know about love?” Adora snaps, wrapping her hand on the back of Catra´s nape at the same time she steps back, dragging them slowly closer to the chapel´s door. Prime´s eyes turn cold, his lips pressing into a fine line at the sight of Adora caressing Catra.

“I know a great deal about love, Adora.” He says between sharp teeth, slick tongue and slick words dripping off his mouth. “I know it makes you weak and it makes you vulnerable. It makes you prone to pain. To bleed”

Adora shakes her head harshly, looking around them. The chapel ´s benches are empty and the stained windows of the wall are tightly closed and covered in metal barriers with thorns on them. Adora had never notices before just how claustrophobic and

terrifying this place is, hovering above them with it´s tall ceiling and the bell of the tower hanging right above their heads.

"Your mother caused me a great pain, Adora. Your beautiful mother with her beautiful golden hair and her beautiful dark eyes." Prime stares at Adora´s face, tilting his head to the side like a harpy eagle studying Adora and Catra with sharp green eyes. "You inherited your father's eyes, however. But oh well not all of us can be perfect, not even you Adora. Isn´t it?"

Adora gives another big step back, circling Catra´s waist with her arms. She can almost feel the cold breeze of the night air hitting their backs from where she left the chapel´s door open and for a second she worries Catra might catch a cold. They are almost so close to the door that Adora thinks she can feel the end of the marble with the soles of her feet and her heart gives a jump. She knows Prime won´t let her go this easily, already stalking them like a predator about to jump for its prey, but maybe this way she can push Catra back enough from the imminent confrontation.

Adora shifts her hold on Catra´s waist and gives one last step back when she feels the cold surface of metal pressing right against her temple, freezing her in place completely. Adora snaps her head recklessly to the side, staring right back at the lethal end of a gun barrel directly towards the middle of her head, hovering there like a promise of death if she moves a single second more.

Catra sees the gun too and gasps, holding Adora´s tank top between her fingers so hard that she almost breaks the fabric and accidentally scratches Adora´s arm, trying to push Adora behind her.

On the other side of the chapel Priest Prime sighs heavily, narrowing his eyes at the sight as if it weighed him heavily. Or bored him deeply.

"Well, that´s annoying," Prime mutters as the person holding the gun against Adora´s face gives a step forward, closing the door of

the chapel heavily behind him and placing the lock behind, cutting the only way for Adora and Catra to escape.

Adora gasps, stepping in front of Catra and holding her behind her back, facing the gun completely as she stares back at the man's face with wide eyes. “Detective Lashor”

“Do not move, Montenegro,” Lashor orders. His hands are trembling and it makes the finger placed above the trigger shiver dangerously, the gun already unlocked and ready to fire if needed.

Adora narrows her eyes, shock draining out of her as she understands the situation, surprise replaced by anger. “What the fuck are you doing?”

Lashor dangles the gun dangerously in front of Adora´s face, screaming at the top of his lungs. He looks chaotic, desperate and pathetic, his eyes bloodshot and his tanned face pale, all of his bald head covered in a nervous sweat. “I said do not fucking move!”

Adora holds her breath, unable to hold back an incredulous chuckles as she shakes her head. She looks back at Lashor with so much disdain that the detective gives a step back, taken off guard by the dark expression on Adora´s face. “Oh, you absolute asshole. You imbecile, he is not going to protect you.”

“Quiet!” Lashor screams, his eyes wide with terror and anger.

He is still pointing the gun at Adora as he walks forwards, tuning his head to glance at Prime, who has finished walking down the steps of the altar. His arms are behind his body and his face has fallen into a blank stare, walking with calm as he approaches the detective.

Adora pushes Catra back, towards the benches and the spiral staircase that leads to the choir´s nook and the start of the tower, With door closed and blocked by Lashor they don´t have another option but to stay as far away from Lashor as possible. Prime

stares at them out of the corner of his eyes, the corner of his mouth twitching with rotten mirth at their sight before turning his attention back completely towards the corrupt detective.

“Lashor,” Prime greets him with a small nod, grinning. “It is a beautiful night we are having today, isn´t it?”

“This was not the deal!” Lashor yells, lowering the gun just a little bit, his hold loosening by the anger. “You said you would use that girl to attract this bitch, you wouldn't say you would kill her!”

Prime tilts his head to the side, his eyebrows twitching together with faux confusion. “And what exactly did you expect would happen?”

“Not that! Huntara is going to realize pretty fucking fast I was the one that called for Scorpia to come into the house!”

Catra´s breath dies on her throat, hitching on her lungs so painful that she lets out a small gasp of horror. Her pupils shrink inside her eyes and her entire face shifts with fury, anger and horror drowning her entire body like a tidal wave sweeping against the coast with all its might. Catra drops Adora´s hands and steps forward in a rush, her hands trembling at her sides where she balls her hands into fists so tight that her nails break the skin of her palm, blood pooling on her fingers and wrists.

“Piece of shit, you piece of shit!” Catra screams, throwing herself against Lashor, uncaring if he is still dangling the godforsaken gun in front of her face like a toy. Adora holds her before she can fully throw herself against him, circling her back and pushing her back almost too hard, keeping her body between Lashor´s unsure one and Catra´s struggling one like a human shield.

“I said stay still!” Lashor yells at the top of his lungs, eyes wide with terror.

“Cat, no. No,” Adora pleads, wrapping her entire body around Catra´s furious one, holding her down with all her strength as she kick and yelling full of fury, trying to escape Adora´s firm hold to

throw herself at Lashor and kill him herself with her hands if needed. Adora shakes her head firmly when Catra tries to push her chest away, petting the sweaty curls with trembling hands. “Stay behind me, please”

“It's his fault,” Catra howls, full of mourn and wrath, her eyes completely bloodshot where the pain and sadness of Scorpia´s loss overwhelms her completely. “It´s his fucking fault.”

“I know,” Adora whispers, pressing her mouth strongly against the bruised side of Catra´s head. “I know, Catra. I´m sorry, I´m so sorry. But please stay with me. Please.”

Prime looks at the whole scene with his eyebrows high on his pale forehead, deeply amused by the whole thing. He returns to look at Lashor´s pathetic face with a small smile, shrugging.

“I asked you to do simple favors for me, Detective. Simple favors in return for my support and my followers´ to support your campaign as future Mayor of the town.”

“Do you think that's how I´m going to become Mayor? By being on fucking jail?!” Lashor lowers the gun on accident, running his hands desperately across his bald head. Prime gives another step in front of him, resting reassuring palms over Lashor´s forearm and wrist. “You said I would blame the Capellan girl to solve the case myself and become Mayor next. I did not help you cover your fucking traces and deleting the video record from the apartment building just for you to fuck me over now.”

Prime nods, as if deeply in thought, gently shushing Lashor with reassuring hands. Adora and Catra tense on each other's arms, tasting the change of demeanor on Prime´s voice in the tip of their tongues.

“You are right, Lashor,” Prime agrees, smiling softly, “I haven't given you what you deserve”

In Lashor´s defense, not even Adora saw Prime move. Maybe it is because the chapel is too drowned in darkness or because Prime

does it so swift and quietly that not even Lashor notices him taking the gun off his hand until it is pressed against his sweaty forehead and blowing his brain off.

Catra and Adora give a drowned yell as the dead body of the detective falls back inside the huge baptismal pool behind him with a wet hit, splashing harsh rivulets of blood and cephalic mass everywhere on the floor and the water, staining the marble and the white fabric of Prime´s priest robes. The sacred water starts to color immediately with crimson, drowning any kind of holy meaning with the weight of blood, the body floating for a few seconds over the surface and then sinking completely, red water falling off the edge and flooding the marble floor.

Adora stares at the gore with wide eyes, her cheeks coloring red with the rush of adrenaline running down her veins in cold lava. She holds Catra´s shoulders so hard they might just bruise, pushing back and back from her until they are both almost tripping with the tall candelabra placed next to the old wood benches.

"Fuck," Adora exclaims under her breath, looking back at Prime´s face.Next to her, Catra´s breathing is quick and elaborated, panic settling on her bones at the clear display of violence. "Fuck"

Prime looks at the gun with a frown and throws it away, scowling as if it was something disgusting to even touch. He throws his head back, inhaling deeply, gathering the smell of fresh blood and death inside his lungs as if it were the most pleasurable of perfumes he has ever encountered. "Ah. So disappointing, really."

His head snaps to the side, long neck like a cryptic version of an owl, staring and Adora and Catra cornered terrified against the line of benches and candles. His mouth stretches into the most horrid kind of smile any of them have ever seen, from ear to ear long and sharp as a knife, letting see through from his molars to his incisors, yellow against his pale face.

“Now, what were we doing? Ah, yes,” Prime brings his hands in front of him, holding them in front of his face as if he was about to throw himself into his knees and pray. “We are bringing this hunt to an end”

Adora bites back into her mouth, straightening in her place. Her shirt is sticking to her back with sweat and all of her hair is loose, falling over her eyes and cheek and tickling the small of her back. Catra´s hands are sweating inside of hers, digging their nails on each other´s palms as they hold to each other as hard as they possibly can.

“Killing me is not going to bring you what you want,” Adora barks, gripping the side on one of the benches so hard her knuckles hurt. “You never had my mother and you´re never having me”

Prime blinks, leaning his head to the side. His grin flatters in the edges a little and then comes back in full force, narrowing his eyes to Adora almost sweetly.

“Who said anything about killing you?” He laughs. He catches Catra´s astonished eyes and Adora´s confused stare and huffs, pushing his hair back with drumming fingers. “No, Adora, no. My beautiful hare. I do not wish to have you, or to take you as a wife as Light Hope so much hoped for.”

Prime laughs at that last sentence, scratching down his scalp and neck, chasing the itch away with amusement. He stretches his hands towards the green flame of the black candles, dipping his fingers inside the fire without flinching under the heat. His hands reach the candle snuffer hanging next to the candelabra, heating up the copper above the flame with uneasy tranquility. The metal is plane and round, adorned by swirls with the First One´s symbol and vivid crimson under the flame.

“Your mother, she was truly one of a kind. There could be nothing compared to her, and her purity and beauty. I was glad when her death was mended with justice.” Prime runs his tongue over his teeth, red against yellow. “But you? Oh, Adora you are something

else, completely. You compliment me in a way your mother could never do. I want you to see that, I want you to stand by me and help me bring this town and this world into the purity it is so much missing."

Prime gives a step forward, Adora and Catra give a step back, a sick and twisted kind of dance where they play around each other waiting and chasing and running from the one that is going to move first. Prime´s eyes are bright like flames where sinners dance around and the smoke of the incense is heavy and thick, making Adora blink several times to chase the blur from her vision.

"I killed your mother´s friends and sister to bring her sorrow after she sinned by delivering herself to your father like a little slut. I killed them one by one like the animals they were and they screeched when they were dying with their impure souls and fearful hearts."

Prime drags the words on his tongue, chewing them on his tongue and cheeks. He dips his hand on the hot powder on the incense, gathering the black ashes on his palm like playing with sand. Adora bites herself and bleeds, her arms shaking from how hard she is holding herself back. Catra´s weight on her side is the only reason she is keeping herself away by now.

"I killed your friends to get your sweet attention and now that you are finally here, under the eyes of our Deity, I must cleanse your sin too. I must do this before you can truly belong to us.." Prime smiles, rotten sweet, the moonlight shimmering on his eyes like wendigo´s eyes. "I won't take my gratification in wedding you or in bedding you, Adora, not at all. I will save your soul. I am going to rip the animal you love into pieces in front of you and that, that will bring me enormous pleasure in return."

Prime swings his hand to the side, throwing the hot ashes against Adora´s side. The black powder falls into Adora´s gray eyes, burning and aching immediately and Adora cringing with a drowned yell, cringing around the sudden pain. Catra moves

towards her immediately, seeking to shelter her but Prime is already expecting that, twisting his arm to grab a handful of Catra´s curls and pulling back from them with his entire force, ripping several strands bloodied and aching on his palm.

Catra screams, pain gathering in her head and shoulders, yanked back from Adora´s arms and towards Prime´s body so suddenly that her throat closes in panic. Adora blinks around the thick ashes, tears falling heavily from her eyes as she tries to clean them off violently. Her hands stretch forward and grab Catra´s forearms tightly, the other one slamming against Prime´s face and pushing back of him with her entire strength until he tethers and lets go of Catra´s hair.

Prime grunts, furious when he raises his arm and throws the hand that holds the candle snuffer like a spear, pressing the boiling red metal over the stitches in Adora´s shoulder, digging on her flesh and burning her.

The smell of charred skin and burnt thread fills Catra´s nose immediately, gathering in the back of her throat and threatening her to make her gag. Adora screams next to her, so high and terrifying that the few nightingales on the bell tower fly away in terror, the sound echoing through every single wall and windows of the Cathedral.

Prime´s hand has started to wrap around Adora´s neck but Catra digs her nails on his flesh and tears away, opening deep and bleeding wounds on his pale flesh, past the hard leather and the frail fabric, blood gathering below her nails and pain making Prime snapback, yelling in pain and anger. The candle snuffle falls on the marble floor with a high sound, losing itself below the benches when Catra starts pulling Adora from Prime´s hold.

“Stay away from her!” Catra screams, pushing back her own pain and fear, baring her teeth and the priest and facing him completely. The oil lamps next to the incense holders are so close to her hip that she can feel their warmth throughout the fabric of her clothes.

Prime grips Catra´s hair and Adora´s hurt shoulder tightly, his fingers staining with the blood dripping off Adora´s wound and pooling on his palm and wrist. “Adora belongs to me, little sister!”

“No she doesn´t.” Catra clenches her jaw, pressing her teeth harshly until she feels them chip. She stretches her hand, wrapping her fingers over hot metal. “She is mine.”

Catra throws the boiling oil over Prime's face, not even cringing when the burning smell worsens and the screams echo again through the entire Cathedral, Prime´s suffering and rage engulfed below the sticky heat of the oil that starts to bloom blisters of melted skin and blood immediately. The oil drips down and catches on the fabric of the robes too, flaming it in green fire from a second to the other and Prime tethers back, fighting the flames of his own fire and screaming until Catra´s ears are ringing with the sight and the sound.

“Adora!” Catra screams, pulling from Adora´s elbow and cradling her brunt and bleeding shoulder, too scared to see the extent of the damage made by Prime and too frantic to stop crying over it. “Adora, we need to move! Move!”

Adora sputters around pain, breathing hard. her white tank top is quickly staining from white to red, soaking on her chest and the side of her body. Her hand finds Catra´s and she points towards the spiral stair with her nose wrinkled. Prime´s screaming body is still convulsing on the floor as he fights the flames, blocking the entrance past the baptismal pool where Lashor's corpse is laying. But Adora knows the bell tower, she and Catra had snuck through the small emergency door on the top enough times after mass. Right now is their only hope to get out. With a little bit of luck, Prime will burn to death on the floor.

“Up,” Adora exhales, narrowing her eyes. She grabs her aching arm around Catra´s waist and pulls her towards the stairs, breathing hard. “Go to the tower”

Catra throws a stare behind them, looking in terror as Prime starts to rise up on trembling legs again, staring back at them. The entire right side of his face is blistering and bloodied, the green eye gone blind when the boiling oil met the iris and sclera. He is looking at them with such an amount of hatred that catraps breath dies in her throat, her chest squeezing painfully.

"Adora"

Adora has seen him too but she cannot fall into panic, not right now. She gets a better grip of Catra´s waist, supports her knee and drags them both with more insistence across the Cathedral. "Catra, go! Don´t look at him, just go!"

The old wood of the stairs creaks with each step as they stumble up the steps, holding to each other and barely avoiding falling. The wood and the structure here is much more fragile than the rest of the Cathedral, made long before the First Ones came to Etheria and ravaged all the statues and old gods with their new religion.

If they were to lean too hard on the railing it would come crumbling down into pieces. If they were to try and break free through the windows the stained glass and the metal would slash their bodies before they could even figure out how to twist their bodies through the cracks. The huge dark bell is right above their head and right below, like falling through a long and ethereal rabbit hole, there is the table of the altar covered in flowers and rot.

Adora peeks through the railing and gulps down a heavy knot, holding her breath as she keeps dragging Catra alongside her. Things have gone to absolute shit and there is chaos inside her mind and her body, boiling her skin and tearing her heart apart. Catra is panting next to her ear by the effort of climbing the stairs and her knee and she smells like charred oil and sweat. The skin on her palm is slightly burnt after she held the oil lamp but Adora can´t even look after it right now, all of her energy focused on

reaching the end of the stairs and not dropping Catra and holding back all the anger and bitterness inside her heart.

She can hear Prime´s words repeating over and over inside her head, pounding like the bleeding wound does with overwhelming pain. All of it, absolutely every single word makes Adora want to turn around and face Prime herself, face to face, and tear the rest of his melting skin off his face.

She can see Catra´s pained face next to her and can see the face of her mother, Marlena, and of her father too. Two of the people she loved the most in her entire life besides her brother. She can see the faces of her family before she lost them and can see Catra ´s face right now, just as scared and bruised and coated in tears as the last time Adora saw her family's faces.

She can see Catra´s face, so close to the day she found her bleeding and almost dead over the floor of the yellow kitchen, all what happened as she was taken to the hospital and into surgery. She can see Castaspella walking out of the surgery room with her scrubs and her shoes covered in blood and her pale face and Catra´s sweet face on the hospital bed, twisting with horror and pain when the realization of what had really happened finally sunk in.

So many horrible things had happened to them, so twisted and so fucked up, all od the slashing against them ike a rain of knives. So much terror for two people that had only tried to be together above anything else. It is all so horribly familiar and so different at the same time that Adora´s fragile psyche is slipping in the edges, threatening to pull her down, threatening to make her scream, threatening to make her cry. Her eyes are completely bloodshot and dry from the burnt of the incense and it makes tears roll one after the other over and over across her cheeks, staining her skin and chin with black tracks.

They are almost halfway through the stairs and Adora can see the blurred shape of the emergency door beyond her heavy tears.They are close but not nearly close enough, tripping several

times on the splinters of the old wood. They are almost eight meters above ground and the pull of gravity is weighing over them with anxiety. Who would have thought that, just a few months ago, Adora and Catra were kissing on the corners of these very steps, like quiet lovers bethroding to each other in secret, hidden from the rest of the town.

Adora helps Catra jump a small hole on the stairs when Prime reaches them finally, reaching a hand to Adora´s nape. He grasps the back of her neck and yanks her backwards with so much strength that all the air inside Adora´s lungs gets expelled out of her chest. She squeezes Catra´s hands but even injured and bleeding Prime manages to slam her against the stained windows, ripping them from each other completely.

Adora´s head crashes against the glass and the metal thorns, splitters of crystal bouncing against her face when she falls heavily on the ground. The sharp pieces cut a deep wound of Adora´s skin, across her right cheek and the bridge of her nose, Blood drips across her face and down her chin and neck, staining her completely in crimson with the active bleed. It's not profound but it is enough to cover Adora in her own blood.

Adora gasps against the hit, digging her nails on the wood steps where she had fallen into. Her ribs throb and her head is pulsing with pain. She holds her weight on the floor with trembling limbs, shaking so bad her teeth click together, blood gathering in her mouth where she bit herself accidentally and that she spit in a rush of red saliva.

Adora looks up, her hair falling on her face, staring right back at Prime´s eyes hovering right above her head. His Priest robe has been torn from his body, completely destroyed by the fire, leaving him only in the red cassock below. His face is terrible, completely disfigured by the hellfire and the oil, chunks of skin hanging from the edges of his jaw and dripping with yellow liquid and dribbling blood.

Catra is behind him, staring at Adora´s fallen body with horrified eyes and all happens rather quickly from there. Catra´s face locks from terror to raw fury, throwing herself with her entire weight against Prime´s side. She seeks to sink her nails into the melted and pulsing skin, kicking on his legs and pulling from his white and gray hair harshly. The hit manages to tether him to the side, the thorns of the windows cutting on the slides of his clothes and slashing against his arm.The pain drives him mad because he swings around, turning his attention from Adora to Catra with dark fury, twisting around and cracking his own bones to reach her.

Adora watches horrified as Prime grabs Catra by the neck and twists her entire body on his hand, cutting her breath and slapping her hands away with the hold. He uses the distraction to slap Catra´s hands away, slamming her body heavily when he throws her against the hardwood steps above them, further away from Adora. Catra rolls on her back and crashes, the back of her neck slamming against the edge of a step and it is a miracle the hit alone doesn´t kill her instantly or severs her spine from root, instead making her yell so hard she dissolves into a fit of coughs, curling over herself when the pain.

Adora sputters something that tastes like Catra´s name but tastes like rotten blood, crawling on her hands and knees up the stairs to reach her. She is closer to the side of the railing now, and if she were to stretch her hand she might just brush the sole of Catra´s feet with her fingertips, straining stitches and burns and scars.

Prime looks at her do so with an almost friendly stare, dragging his green eye from Adora´s aching hand to Catra´s panting body curling and twisting to try and reach Adora too, narrowing his eyes. Even at the doors of death, they are still trying to reach for each other, still trying to look after the other even bleeding and bruised.

Prime throws the flaps on his cassock behind him, taking off from the folds the long surface of a knife, the same one used in the Cathedral to cut the sacrificial neck of doves on the altar. Adora´s eyes go wide at the sight, her crawling growing restless and even

more desperate, rising to her knees and falling right back into the steps. Her body hurts so much and it's only when she glances quickly to the side that she realizes one of the thorns has found its way on the side of her abdomen, carving its way on her skin and muscle.

Adora snaps her head back, shaking her head and yelling, drowned with her own blood as Prime leans towards Catra and lifts her chin with the tip of his shoe, his huge hand wrapping itself completely around Catra´s neck.

"No," Adora gasps, closing her hands on fists, "No, no."

Prime stabs Catra on the side, digging the blade of the knife into an awkward angle across the skin of her body. It´s a clumsy stab really, done with eagerness but not with sharp intelligence or careful preparation, by someone filled with heated emotions and fury. Like this Adora knows it won´t manage to cut organs or bleed her out but the sharp blade cuts the muscle like butter under its push and blood starts pooling immediately, soaking the fabric of Catra´s shirt and traveling down the step where it splashes lightly against Adora´s already bloodied face.

Catra opens her mouth and lets out a blood curdling scream, echoing across the entire Cathedral, shaking the very windows to their foundations. She slams her own head against the wood to try and chase the pain again and cries in pain when Prime pulls the knife out, subconsciously seeking to press her palm against the pulsing wound to keep it from bleeding out.

Adora slams her hands on the wood and pops her jaw open, holding the railing with one hand and the hem of Prime´s clothes with the other. She pulls back from him from the floor, alternating her bloodied eyes between him and Catra´s convulsing body. Prime turns around for a second and kicks her in the face, catching on her cheekbone with fissures cleanly in half by the kick. Adora´s entire head goes numb under the sudden pain, letting go of his clothes and fighting the need to pass out with her entire strength.

Prime lowers down, grasping Catra´s neck once again and lifting her up like she weighed nothing. He holds her in front of his face, frowning down at her as if she had disappointed him deeply, wrinkling his nose and sniffing the side of her face. Catra´s breath hitches on her throat and she looks like she is about to scream again but she spits at his face instead, gasping around a insane chuckle and gurgling in blood at the expression on Prime´s face.

The air here is freezing cold and it moves the long rope of the bell a little, ruffling Catra´s hair and making the smell in Prime´s rotting face to worsen. No matter what he does right now, if he kills them or tears them into pieces, he will always carry with him Catra´s mark wherever he goes. He might try to hide it or to cover it or to twist it around but he will always know Catra did this and he cannot handle that.

"Your mother couldn't even finish a simple work," He grunts against her ear, lowering her a little and pressing her against the precarious railing. Catra´s pupils shrink inside her irises, all fake mirth and driven madness slipping out of her bones and replaced with rooted sadness and fear.

Adora stares in terror as Prime smiles when he notices the heartbroken expression on Catra´s face, letting go of her completely. The rotten railing gives up under Catra´s weight and splitters, breaking into pieces. Catra, in pain, wounded and exhausted loses balance and falls backwards, nothing to hold her anymore as gravity pulls her down right in front of Adora´s eyes, falling into the dark void that eats her fully like a bird into a predator's open mouth.

Adora grasps the railing and throws herself towards the void too, not even thinking about it, catching Catra´s arm by merely seconds. She screams in pain, her entire body protesting at the strain but she holds Catra completely, keeping her from falling into the darkness. Catra screams too when the pull makes her bounce back, miraculously not breaking her arm or displacing her joint but curling in the middle of void and air, the wound on her side bleeding and gaping with each movement.

Adora clenches her teeth, wrapping her hand so hard around Catra´s forearm that her beautiful dark skin starts to bruise immediately. Half of Adora´s body is still in the stairs, the edge of the stairs digging painfully on her body; the other half of her body is dangling off the staircase and into open air, Catra´s fingers are drenched in her own blood and shivering violently, seeking to hold Adora´s arm back but slipping right off with the slick crimson.

"Adora!" Catra screams, panting. She is afraid. Adora is afraid too.

"I got you! I got you, hold on!" Adora screams back, digging her nails on wood until all of them break and bleed.

Adora grabs the unbroken piece of the railing as hard as she can, begging it won´t snap. She tries to pull back from both of them, bringing Catra with her but her grip slips with the blood and the slick skin, flinching off Adora´s hold and into the void of the Cathedral.

Adora screams and reaches for Catra again, accidentally digging her nails on Catra´s forearm and dragging them back, managing to hold her by the wrists with her fingers. In her desperation, Adora´s broken nails shred painful lines across Catra´s forearm, blood dripping out of them immediately. Adora sobs at the sight but doesn´t let go of her anymore, squeezing the delicate bones of her wrist on her fingers.

With the stumble Catra´s legs tangle accidentally on the rope of the bell, pulling out of her with enough strength for the mighty metal to swing from side to side, tethering as it rings loudly across the Cathedral. Once, twice, the sound that calls for mass ringing across the woods and the entire town, making them all deaf for a second and shrink into unfathomable terror.

"Adora," Catra gasps above the sound of the bell, straining her neck to look back at Adora´s bloodied and strained face. Even now her eyes soften, tears tumbling off her eyelashes and falling to the floor below. Her pretty and huge eyes are opened as far as they can go, fear crawling off her skin and bones. "Adora."

“I'm not letting go!” Adora screams back. Her head and chest are pounding as blood gathers on them, cutting her breath short with the increasing pull. Even her lungs are screaming, avid for air but too terrified to take air. She wants to pull her up but she cannot do so without letting go off the railing. “I'm not letting you go!”

“Adora, I can´t- I can´t hold on.” Catra mutters, choking when they slip further down.

Facing down to the void is overwhelming and dizzy and it makes Adora want to scream and throw up. The expression in Catra´s eyes makes her want to tear her hair from root off her head,

“Catra, no!”

Catra´s fingers slip again, her hold growing weaker and weaker by the second. Right now the only thing holding her up is Adora´s hands and nothing else.

“I´m tired”

“I can´t lose you again!” Adora tears her chest out, black tears dripping off her eyes and falling against Catra´s precious face. Below Adora, Catra holds her breath, staring back up at Adora with all her emotions written on her face. Adora grows more restless, speaking around the words like poisonous honey. “Alright?! I can´t do it, don´t make me do it. You are not getting away from me ever again so I´m not letting go!”

Catra presses her mouth into a fine line and lets her own tears run down but nods, making an effort to pull herself up without much success.

The door of the Cathedral slams suddenly, shaking on its hinges without getting to open. And then once again and again, echoing even louder than the now quieting bell. Someone is pounding against the door from the outside, loudly, with something very hard by the sound of it. But it falls flat against the thick material of the door, barely even managing to make a dent from the other side.

“Catra!” It´s Bow, it´s voice Bow´s voice, fed up and scared too, banging against the door again. “Catra! Adora!”

“Adora!” And Glimmer, Glimmer is here too. They must have gone into a wild goose chase around the woods after Adora left, only finding the way across the night when the bell of the Cathedral started to sound. By the sound of it it is only them and the door is too thick, even if they manage to tear it open they might just not get inside in time. “Hang in there! We are going for you!”

Prime walks down the step he had leaned into, watching with amused eyes at Adora trying to hold herself and Catra without falling. He chuckles, running his pale and skeleton-like fingers across the strands of his hair, tilting his head to the side.

“I left gifts for you, Adora.” He purrs, chewing on the words like molasses. “Only I understand you. Only I can love your soul.”

The railing where Adora is holding herself is starting to give out, splintering in the middle and cracking. The wood splinters fall against Adora´s face, missing themselves in the blood. They are running out of time and Adora´s shoulder is tearing too, the stitches falling open, dripping blood against Catra´s freckles.

Catra sees the railing at the same time Adora does, feeling the weight of the fall ever heavier above her. She pleads to Adora, unable to allow her to fall and break like the branch of a tree because of her, unable to allow her heart to accept that.

“Adora, please”

“No!”

“Do you think she will ever love you?” Prime asks, digging the sharpness of his words on Adora´s heart.

He is so much closer now, almost completely over Adora. If he wished he could stab her, or kick her, or open her neck, or force her hand to open and drop the precious weight on her palm.

“Truly? Do you think she will ever adore you fully? No” Prime shakes his head sadly, sighing deeply. “Just let her go, Adora. Allow me to walk you into the light.”

Adora holds her breath, grunting and gasping as she feels herself lowering further and further across the stairs. She can feel her face red by the effort and red by blood, sticking to her hair in thick strands. She digs her knees on the stairs and holds the railing for dear life, the old wood giving away like sand in her fingers.

Adora shakes herself off Prime’s words, blinking down at Catra's face. She lifts her arm and raises Catra but the muscles of her arms pull and tear, giving up and dangling again. Catra gasps as she hangs from Adora's arm, managing to rub her thumb over Adora's pulse point, so soft it's almost strange among the violence of it all.

“I love you,” Catra says, hiccuping. She nods, reassuring Adora as poorly and as soft as she can. Below her the shadows of the red flowers look like crowns around her head. “I love you, it's okay”

Prime scrunches next to Adora's hovering body, looking at her with his head tilted to the side. He stretches his hand and grasps a bloodied strand of golden hair, placing it behind Adora´s ear, a mocking show of a caress, a mocking mirror of the way Catra usually brushes Adora´s hair out of her face when it is not held into that damn ponytail, something sweet slowly getting poisoned too. And Adora cannot flinch or cringe away, all of her focus and all of her strength placed in her hand around Catra´s and her body giving up under the pressure.

“You and I, Adora, we aren't so different,” Prime whispers, shrugging. “We are the same”

Adora looks at Catra´s face, eyes meeting each other. Bloodshot and tired and bruised like purple blossoms but still theirs, still each other´s. Hazel and turquoise and silver and cobalt. Adora shifts her grip on Catra´s wrist and forearm, managing a tiny and

sweet smile towards her even though her eyes cannot stop crying. She nods once and she can see the way Catra´s pupils blow up, realization falling over her. Her shivering fingers brush Adora´s pulse point, holding her breath.

Adora doesn´t turn to look at Prime but she does speak to him, voice strained and sore, completely raw by the screaming and the effort to hold on. Her hand on the railing shifts too and she feels nauseated for a second but it gets quickly buried. She is holding Catra´s eyes, nothing bad is going to happen as long as she holds her eyes.

"I am nothing like you," Adora snaps and lets go of the wood.

Adora feels Prime´s hand brush her hair when he tries to hold her but the gravity is much stronger and quicker than him and Adora is already falling into the void by the time he moves, yelling in anger.

Someone must hear the quiet prayer that Adora sends to the nothing, because she manages to pull Catra into her chest even as they fall down the bell tower, curling around her body like a shield made of flesh and blood and golden hair. Catra´s shivering arms wrap around Adora´s neck and Adora´s trembling hands rest on the base of her neck and her waist, tilting them both to the side, trying to shelter Catra´s head and frail spine with her arms and body alone.

They feel the pull of the fall on the bottom of their abdomen and the rush of freezing cold air on their cheeks, turning their tears into frost and the drops of their blood into red snowflakes. It's horrible, it's terrifying and it stops the beating inside their chest with fear but at least they are together, at least they are holding each other. Adora promised it, after all, that she would follow Catra if she were to fall, that she would follow her in the very depth of the Underworld and guide her back to the sun as many times as she needed them. She is here now, she won´t forsake her now, not even in death.

They crash against the tall table of the altar, the wood legs breaking with the hit and falling against the floor immediately after. The red flowers are a small blessing, cushioning their fall like clouds and thorn mattress. The stems digs on their skiing but the soft petals keep them from breaking bones and limbs like pieces of glass, It's another blessing that they don´t die on the impact but it hurts, it hurts so much that their shared breath rips out of their lungs like bullets and they cringe with overwhelming pain, their hold into each other slipping a little and finally coming undone.

They roll down the steps of the altar, stopping over the black marble on the floor. Adora curls on the last step, fighting to get back her breath and pushing so many kinds of pain and suffering that she doesn´t even know where to begin or end stitching herself.

Her eyes open a slit and she can see Catra, in front of her but still too far away. She has rolled around the corridor of the Cathedral, between the brown of benches, barely stopped by the foot of the candelabra around her. She is on her side and unconscious, or as unconscious as could possibly be. Her chest moving quickly with a pained panting and her back towards Adora, all of her pretty and bloodied curls covering her face and hiding her away.

There is a scratching below Adora´s skin and beneath her eyes, increasing and pulling off her nerve system and the rush of blood in her veins as she stares at Catra´s unmoving body in front of her. She wants to crawls on her fucking nails and knees towards her, rool her in her back and hold her, cradle her inside her chest and scrap her own skin to it falls over Catra´s like a second shield, covering all of her wounds and sheltering her from the pain. But as Adora tries to move she finds out that she can´t, she cannot do it. She can feel her body and she can move her limbs but the weakest part of her humanity is failing her and she cannot move,

“What was that?” Adora can hear Bow´s voice beyond some point of the stained windows. His tone is frantic, angry even and

desperate, slamming something against the metal barriers that bounce back towards him immediately after.

Glimmer must be with him because Adora can hear her gasp, even where she is, looking through some small part of broken glass and the scene below the altar.

“Oh goddess, oh goddess, no. Bow hurry up!”

Prime´s steps are the loudest thing inside the Cathedral right now, walking down the staircase with a calm rhythm. His fingers drum over the frail railing, humming on the back of his throat when he catches sight of the scene too. The corner of his eyes seems to sparkle when he sees Catra unconscious and Adora struggling to stand up and far away from her, the cassock flipping a little with the cold breeze that comes through the broken windows.

He makes his way across the broken pieces of the altar and the crushed flower, lowering down and kneeling right next to Adora´s shivering body. Adora has found the blood in her fingers and legs again but her legs are trembling so bad still that even when she tries to push herself away she falls against the steps again, her head bouncing over the marble painfully.

Prime hums, tracing his fingers across Adora´s bruised face, cleaning the blood from the wounds that stain her cheeks and chin with his thumb. Adora wants to bite into his fingers and tear them off from root for daring to touch her. For daring to touch Catra.

“Aren't we? Aren´t we the same?” He continues asking, as if Adora and Catra hadn´t fell from heaven itself. As if it was just another lesson and Adora was just too rebellious to listen.”We desire prohibited things. Sinful ones.”

Adora gags and spits on his face, saliva and blood dripping from the horrid side of his cheek and into the cassock, It feels good,

doing it, it feels like a curse even though Adora is on her back and her body is locked into a shiver,

“Catra is not a sin,” Adora manages to say, shivering voice and strained vocal cords, her teeth clenched until they chip. “She is a miracle, to me, to my life. And I am hers, completely hers.”

Prime´s eyes go wide at Adora´s words, his breath hitching on his throat. For a second Adora think he is going to lash out, that he is going to scream in fury and hit her or hit himself but instead Prime straightens his back and opens his arms wide at his sides, like welcoming the darkness and the blood and the rot, throwing his head back into one long, loud laughter,

“I see!” He exclaims, laughing until the veins of his eye pop and his pale face flushes with red, the cackles and laughter echoing from the very foundations of the cathedral to the bell, a sound so unsettling that Adora´s skin raises in goosebumps and cold acid falls down her spine. “I see, I see, I see! Hahahaha! I see now!”

Prime looks at the bones of the Deity still hanging above their heads, joining his hands into Prayer, as if thanking Her for the understanding, the clarity, the epiphany and the ecstasy.

“ *She* is your deity, isn't she?” Prime giggles, falling on his palms, pressing them at either side of Adora´s head, gripping the marble with sharp nails until the material itself comes undone on his fingertips. “Your religion, your goddess. She is who you devote yourself to. Your reason, your blood, your tears, your sweat. She is your soul, truly your soul.”

Prime´s hands lower, pressing his sweaty and cold palms at either side of Adora´s throat, his sharp and blood stained nails carving moon shapes against the skin of Adora´s neck. He presses the heels of his palms down, pushing against the rings of her throat and the delicate bone of her collarbones, tearing apart the air from her bronchi tree and lungs, stealing the voice out of her vocal cords and straining the cords of her bruised heart.

He is choking her, not to kill her but to torture her. Not to murder her but to control her, to let her know no matter what she did or does he has the control over her life however he wants it, to take or to forgive as he wishes.

“Tell me, Adora, how much do you love your Catra?” Prime asks against her ears, pressing down on her throat. Adora gasps, kicking blindly below the weight of his body over hers. She digs her nails on his hands and pushes off his shoulders but it slips with her blood and exhales in pain, unable to take a single breath without feeling blinding pain. Prime laughs at the weak display, baring all of his yellow teeth to her. “Pray to her, then! Rejoice in her!”

Prime chokes Adora, delighted in the way her face starts turning red with the effort and her eyes and lips burst with the lack of air, struggling violently below him. Adora kicks him and pushes him away but every single time he presses further and further against her throat, sparks of pain flashing below her eyelids.

The violence makes Adora´s consciousness start slipping off the edges, dark tendril crawling on her vision and threatening to make her pass out. She gapes, taking several intakes of breath but the air doesn´t make it inside her lungs as much as she tries to, her heart making a tremendous effort to keep pushing the blood inside her system.

She knows she is either about to pass out or throw up when a second weight crashes against Prime´s hands, bloodied and scratched palms wrapping around Prime´s face and digging her fingers on his wounds, pulling back from him.

“Let her go!” Catra screams, hitting him in the face and scratching his hands too until they start to drip blood, She is terribly pale and the side of her shirt is soaked in blood but she is still fighting with all her strength, pulling from one of Prime´s fingers until she feels it strain and break, snapping the joint clean in half. “Stop, let her go!”

Prime screams in pain at his broken finger but he still doesn´t let go from Adora´s throat, snapping his eyes towards Catra. She is strong and brave and resilient even injured and bleeding as she is, but even like this Prime is so much taller than her, towering over her like a demon.

"Catra! Adora!" Bow screams beyond the glass, punching the glass with his bare fist.

"Bow!" Catra calls for him, exhausted and desperate, wrapping her own hands around Prime´s neck and pushing too, seeking to choke him and rip him out of Adora´s body. "Bow!"

"Catra!"

Catra squeezes on Prime´s pipe and he gasps, letting go of one of his hands from Adora´s neck as the air fails him. The other one is still pressed against the base of her throat but Adora can take a sharp inhale of air, frantic as it fills her ribcage and makes her cough wet and choking, gurgling on her own spit, her head pounding with pain.

Catra tries to attack Prime, drag her nails across his face and knock him completely from Adora´s side but he grabs the back of her hair with one hand as he presses on the hollow of Adora´s neck with the other, swinging Catra with unnatural force against the stairs of the altar.

Catra crashes against the marble with so much force that the material chips, her entire body screaming in pain and mirroring into the air with a hollow scream. Adora gasps at the sight, tears falling heavily off the corner of her eyes. Catra is upside down and on her side next to Adora, her legs against the top of the steps and her head on the last step, fallen on her side and convulsing as the waves of pain overtake her. The wound on her head starts to bleed again and her face wrinkles with suffering, fighting to keep her eyes open to look back at Adora´s bloody eyes.

Adora and Catra lay side by side, Adora with her body towards Prime as he returns both of his hands around her neck, Catra with her feet towards the altar, faces mere inches away. They can see each other, they can smell the other's breath, Catra´s cheek against the marble, Adora tilting her head as best as she can inside Prime´s hold so she can see her fully. They look at each other and try to reassure each other with their eyes alone, bleeding and in pain.

Adora looks at Catra panting next to her, her eyes so red they almost look drowned in red tears. And she is so beautiful, even like this, even while Adora slowly dies and Catra hiccups with pain and fear, she is so beautiful. Beautiful like an angel fallen from heaven just to catch Adora before she falls.

Beautiful like the very first time Adora saw her, six years old and the most beautiful creature in the entire world, held to her father's hand and looking back at Adora with her huge owl eyes and her nightingale song, chasing Adora through the tree trunks of the forest and laughing in her ear when they fell to sleep over the moss.

Beautiful like when they were fourteen and tragedy came crashing on Adora´s life for the first time, so young still, kids still but always by Adora´s side, braiding her hair and holding her hand at the funerals. Walking Adora through sorrow and helping her survive.

Beautiful like when they were seventeen and they fought each other, hurt each other, almost teared the other apart and then the car accident and even there she was beautiful, drunk or sober or laughing or crying, letting Adora know what what her heart wanted the most was granted, from the very beginning that it was hers. That Catra was hers and that Catra wanted her in return. To love and cherish.

Beautiful like New Year´s Eve.

Beautiful like last night, dancing in the quiet motel room and kissing Adora under the night lamp that reflected her ring and whimpering against Adora´s mouth. Beautiful, the most beautiful creature Adora has ever met and that for some reason was granted for her.

Adora tries to stretch her hand towards her to reach her and hold her sweetly but her body is failing her, too weak to even keep kicking for her life. Her fingers twitch where her hands lay next to her head, only the pads managing to brush very lightly the disheveled curls over Catra´s forehead, brushing a tender line like the ghost of a kiss over her eyelid.

"I´m sorry," Adora whispers, barely even there, gasping and out of breath. "I´m sorry"

Catra blinks back at her very slowly, a silent sign between them. The acceptance of an apology Catra does not need, the reassurance of love no matter what. Her multicolored eyes narrow on the corners and she manages a sweet smile, the most tender of them, giving it to Adora even now. A promise, that no matter what it was worth it, all of it was worth it because they loved each other more than anything.

Catra´s fingers twitch too, moving towards Adora´s face but Prime rips them away again, lifting Adora off the ground and towards his face, still holding her neck into a choke hold as he lowers his rotten and burnt mouth towards her.

"I´ll place your fake goddess on the altar first, Adora. So you can pray to her properly." He promises, glancing at Catra as he stands up, carrying Adora with him.

He drags Adora away, pulling from her body across the chapel´s corridor, pulling from her neck and hair. Adora´s long legs trail behind her, feet catching on the floor when she looks back at Catra still laying on the steps behind her, further and further away from her reach.

The tall ceilings of the Cathedral make Adora´s gasping and low kicking echo, coming back to her like a thousand war hammers and still leaving her deaf and weak right after. Prime stops right next to the baptismal pile, lifting Adora until she is right in front of his face, her shoes dangling just a few millimeters off the ground. Prime smiles at her, all blood and broken teeth and burnt skin, smiles and smiles until it wrinkles the corner of his eyes and his green eye flashes in crimson red.

"Do not worry, Adora. I´ll put her bones there, right next to the Deity´s effigy"

His slytherin eyes flash as he points at the skeleton hanging from the ceiling. The smile stretches on his face until it almost touches the ends of his jaw, tracing the shapes of the bones with his eyes before turning them back to Adora´s.

It's some kind of full circle, for him after all. The owner of the skeleton had the same eyes,

"Right next to Mara´s."

Prime lets go from Adora´s neck, pushing her back. Adora falls into the baptismal font filled with Lashor´s blood, sinking completely into the crimson liquid that quickly threatens to drown her. The thick material fills her nose, mouth and ears light cotton, salted and copper tasting, disgusting to the touch. It soaks her hair and her clothes and strains her skin, covering her face like a mask made out of still warm blood and flesh.

Adora cannot close her eyes and she cannot even close her mouth, gurgling around holy water and blood. She feels like sinking down yet she also feels like flying, suspended in one infinite second of shock and terror where her nerve system shuts down completely and her heart stops on its tracks, dying in a way yet still beating.

She smells death and she sees red, red, all of it is red, she cannot feel anything else that is not an itch and red. And even here,

below the dense mass of the water with her back meeting the marble end of the font, Adora can hear the echo of screaming, new and old. The phantom of terror and violence that happened here without even realizing. The echo of memories where Mara came to confront this demon and he skinned her alive and hung her bones below the dome of the chapel. Right in front of everyone's eyes.

Adora can see her among the shapes of the red water, Mara´s gray eyes and dark hair and the thickness of her hair when she hugged Adora after a nightmare. Dancing on the floor of the small cabin and laughing out loud when Adora got confused about the stuff her parents kept her protected from. Kind and brave and loving, she loved Adora, she was her cousin and she always loved her. Familiar love was so important for them always and kept them together even after tragedy.

She did not forsake Adora or abandoned her. She didn´t left without looking behind. She knew what would be of Adora if Light Hope continued her plan to make her a First One, she knew what had happened to her own mother, to her aunt Marlena. And if she didn´t know, she found a way to figure it out. She was saving Adora by facing the monster that dressed like a Priest and she died trying to shelter her.

Once again, love had saved Adora and in return she had lost Mara. Once again, Adora is floating on the brink of life and death and she is losing someone she loves, the only person left on this world that Adora adores. There are screams inside her mind and screams carved on the walls of the Cathedral and there are screams outside the baptismal pile, new, heart wrenching and bloodcurdling.

Catra is screaming. Beautiful, sweet and precious Catra, Catra who has suffered so much, Catra who has been left alone by Adora too many times. Catra, Adora´s Catra is screaming while Adora drowns.

Adora gurgles into the blood, her body shaking from head to toe, It´s just a few seconds but they feel like eternity when she digs her nails on the marble base and opens her mouth wide against the bloodied water, screaming at the top of her lungs. It's drowned and quiet below the water but it raises waves across the surface, gurgling and bubbling up and up and up as Adora pushes herself up, pushing away the weight of Lashor´s corpse and chasing for the dim moonlight.

Adora´s hand shoots out of the crimson water, holding herself to the edge of the font. She pushes up until her head crosses the surface of the water, red liquid dripping out of her and into the floor as she climbs out like a ghost pulled from the very hell. She soaked in blood, from the golden hair now the color of red fire to her entire face and skin and clothes, turning her white clothes into red and painting her eyes in death´s colors. She chokes on blood and spits it out, gathering in her gums and teeth and the base of her tongue. She can´t even make it if it is Lashor´s or her own blood, dripping off her busted lips and running down the curves of her cheeks in red tears.

Adora drips blood everywhere on the floor as she stands up in shivering legs, staring with red eyes at the altar in front of her. Prime has dragged Catra by the hair towards the broken remains of the altar, throwing her at the feet of Mara´s bones.

"Fuck you! Go fuck yourself! What did you do to her?!!" Catra is screaming at his face, pushing his arms away and kicking him in the groin but her side is still bleeding and when she gets distracted trying to reach the baptismal font for Adora. Prime tangles his fingers around her curls and slams her head against the floor, bouncing painfully. Catra wraps her arms across her head and whimpers, curling on herself right below the skeleton´s feet.

Prime has gathered the knife again, dangling it between his fingers where the ring still shimmers on his pinky. There is a golden chain wrapped around his palm too, and when Adora narrows her eyes she catches sight of the reliquary, *her* golden

reliquary that had been hanging from her neck and now on Prime ´s hold too.

She hadn´t even noticed when her ripped it from her neck before pushing her against the font, and she hand´t seen the way Prime ´s eyes flashed when he opened and the old picture of Marlena looked right back at her. But he has it, yet again what doesn´t belong to him he has it and Adora is done. She is done.

"She is not coming for you now," Prime grunts, unaware of Adora as she starts walking red and bloodied back to him, her steps as quiet and calm as his were, Instead, he is too focused pressing the sole of his dirty shoe against Catra´s side, pressing in her wound and smiling when she screams. "She is not coming for you now, little sister. Today you are finally going to die, just as you have always wanted, isn´t it? Wasn´t that your confession? You *want* to die."

Adora leans to the side, reaching for the fallen pieces of the altar. With the stumble after their fall from the bell, the symbol of the First One´s has fallen from the skull´s crown, Mara´s skull, strands of the blonde hairs from Adora´s friends scattered in the sticky floor.

Adora wraps her palm around the base of the symbol, lifting her easily on her hand, not even feeling as the sharp thorns on the base dig in her hands. She cannot feel anything at all, nor pain from her wounds or fear or cold. She cannot even feel love, it is there but she cannot feel it right now. It's there, nestled around Catra´s beating and frantic heart but Adora is too far away from it. The only thing Adora senses right now is the blood covering her and Prime´s words towards Catra. The only thing she can feel right now is rage.

"You should have died months ago but I´ll fix that now," Prime grasps Catra´s chin on his hand, shaking her so hard her bones shackle inside her body. Catra hasn´t seen Adora either. She spits on Prime´s face and recoils when he slaps her back, smearing his blood on her face. "In your last moments you will be alone,

Catrina, and you will be afraid. You will suffer. This is how the Deity has chosen for you to die."

Adora stretches her hand behind Prime, peeking above his shoulder like a creature pulled from a forest myth. Through the red mass that is her face and hair, the white of her eyes melts into bruised purple and red and the blue of her irises flashes, her fingers tangling around the cassock and her cold red lips resting against Prime´s earlobe.

"Prime," Adora says, raw, sore, like an open wound that doesn't close. Her temple against Prime´s, her eyes carving tombs on his face. "Get your filthy hands off my wife"

Adora stabs the broken side of the symbol against his shoulder, a mirror of the wound he inflicted on her own body days ago, sending him tethering backwards with the hit. Prime gasps in surprise, pain overwhelming him and he trips with the hem of his own cassock, falling on his back against the steps of the altar, a weak reflection of the way he had thrown Catra against the very same stairs.

He tries to stand up quickly but Adora turns around on her soaked sneakers, slamming the sole against the broken side of his face and pushing him back. She feels the characteristic crunch of the nose bridge against the force but she doesn´t even flinch, staring with her head tilted to the side as Prime snorts and gurgles with a gush of his own blood.

Adora leans down and takes a golden spear fallen from one of the angel statues in the wall, wrapping her fingers around the middle and lifting it easily. Her biceps strain under the weight, skin dripping red, the veins of her arms popping with the effort of holding herself back. She dangles the spear like some kind of ancient warrior as she follows Prime down the steps and steps right next to him.

Adora watches him squirm on the floor, holding his face and sputtering, surprise and humiliation digging holes in his heart and

soul, making him flinch on himself with humiliation and pain as the place where Adora had hit him quickly starts to stain the white strands in red. She stares at his face when he snaps his eyes towards her and then towards Catra and opens his mouth to scream something but Adora is already moving before he can even try to shout the humiliation he means to say, stabbing the end of the angel spear against Prime´s other shoulder, ripping flesh and muscle with ease and digging on the hard marble below, impaling him on the floor.

Prime´s screams are horrifying now, ringing inside Adora´s ears. Even with all the violence he had committed against innocent people, he must have never stopped to consider just how much suffering wounds really carried. Now, as the sharp gold of his own trophies crush his bone into splinters, he gets to feel just a fraction of the pain he had really caused years ago and now, all the sorrow and pain that the families of his victim´s carried, that Adora´s family had carried and that had made its home inside Adora´s heart because of him.

It will never be enough, but at least now he gets to feel what being truly helpless feels like.

Adora hovers over his figure like a red Saint over a fallen dragon, dripping blood and without blinking even, holding his rageful eyes inside of her blue, blue ones. She could stand right there and watch exactly how far he could go before the pulsing wound makes him pass out from the pain but she is turning around already, called like a moth to a forest fire by another voice, frantic as Prime´s breathing is but sweeter, so much sweeter.

“Adora”

Catra is pushing herself up on her two feet, tethering back to the ground when her knee fails her and makes her stumble down. Adora catches her on sure arms, the anger inside her veins tammering a little with shame when the blood coating her stains Catra´s clothes and skin too. Adora wrinkles her nose, bumping

her nose softly against the side of Catra´s head, regarding all the bruises, cuts and stabs with blazing eyes.

"Come here," Adora whispers, lifting Catra´s body on her both arms, carrying her weight off the floor and against her chest.

It must hurt, it should hurt because Adora is still actively bleeding from so many places but it is barely a feather against Adora´s heated skin. She doesn´t even feel the strain or the pull of it. Adora carries Catra past the broken altar, glancing at the bones, Mara´s bones, hanging next to them before walking them down completely.

Adora stretches a hand, holding Catra´s entire weight with just one hand and wrapping her fingers around the thin metal threads that keep it hanging in the air. They snap like silk under the strength of Adora´s fingers and the bones come crumbling down the ground immediately after, no longer held by puppeteer strings, crashing against the floor instead.

It feels, in a way, disrespectful, to treat Mara´s bones like this. But Mara has been dead for such a long time now, so many years of Adora´s life thinking she had left her to fence on her own with the wolves ready to devour Adora whole. Mara is not here anymore and her bones are not even hers anymore. Desecrated and used like an object for everyone else to admire, not to mourn. It is time for her to turn into ashes and leave this place too.

Adora carries Catra down the steps, reaching a small nook hidden below the choir's balcony and the priest´s pedestal. It smells strongly like incense and myrrh here, hiding a little the stench of blood, and it is dry, the last flame of dark candles burning out and illuminating the corner softly. Adora gently sits her down on an errand bench on the corner, kneeling between her legs and regarding her wounds with frantic gaze. Beyond the altar Prime is still sputtering, moaning in pain and fighting to regain his senses.

Catra is covered in blood too, her hair sticking to her temples, completely matted. Her face is damp with a cold sweat and there

are so many bruises in her arms and collarbones that the pink scar in her neck is almost too tender of a shade against the purple and red patches, making Adora flinch at the sight. Her knee is pulsing painfully, ligaments and muscle straining and barely held from snapping by the compression sleeve still wrapped around it.

Adora rests her bloodied fingertips over all the tender spots in Catra´s body and traces them gently, quietly checking them up and their severity, catching places where she will need to be stitched again. She runs them up the curves of her hips and the little divots and creases of her spine, checking the bruised body after such a fall, making sure nothing is broken or hurt beyond repair.

But Catra´s mind is anywhere but in her own wounds, her hands coming up desperately to cradle Adora´s head below the soaked strands of her hair. She stares at Adora´s face frantically, her eyes wide open and her lips trembling, studying Adora´s unnervingly calm face with eager eyes, absorbing all of Adora´s wounds inside her chest too.

"Adora," Catra says, voice splintering in all places, so low that if they weren´t pressed against each other Adora would have missed it.

Adora smiles at her, as reassuring as she can, which is not much. She knows that she looks like a fright right now, terrible and wounded and covered in so much blood that it seems as if she had crawled her way out of a sacrificial pit. In a way, she had. She knows she smells worse and that the feeling of running her fingers across Adora´s stained body should be horrifying yet Catra doesn´t seem to be able to pull away, brushing her fingertips so softly over Adora´s temples and face that all anger gets replaced immediately by tenderness alone.

"My love," Adora greets her around a mouthful of blood, suddenly dizzy. "Are you cold?"

“Blood,” Catra stutters, her eyes so wide and surrounded by sore red that they hurt to even see. She touches Adora as if she were looking for the place where she is bleeding out, trying to press her palm against the wounds and slipping where all that comes back is blood. “You are– so much blood”

“It´s not mine,” Adora reassures her, holding Catra´s hand between her fingers and placing a red kiss gently over her wrist. It is not, or at least Adora thinks most of it is not hers, she can´t be sure but she'll say what she needs to calm Catra´s heart.

Back on the marble floor, Prime has found his voice again, his furious shouts rising in the Cathedral as he tries to rip himself away from the spear.

“Adora!” He calls, wrapping his hand around the golden metal and failing to dig it out of the hard floor. “Adora! I am going to kill her! You cannot hide her from me!”

Adora closes her eyes at the sound of the screams, hearing her own breathing and Catra´s speeding heart inside her ears, competing with the violent rush of blood on her head. There is nothing else in this world that she wants more than to sink into the warmth of Catra´s hands and belly and close her eyes, letting the dark night take over them and send them both to sleep. But she is covered in blood and Catra is covered in blood too and the demon chasing them is still alive and screaming to try and get them both. They  cannot live like this, not anymore.

Adora sighs deeply and cradles Catra´s face between her palms, tilting her head backwards, pressing a still bloodied mouth against hers. busted lips and bleeding gums and shared heavy breath. Catra hiccups around the stinging taste and Adora softens her hold in case she wants to lean away; but Catra only holds her tighter, running the flat of her tongue over the roof of Adora´s mouth and biting on her bottom lip, exhaling when Adora hums into her mouth and kisses her back so deeply that Catra´s back arches inside her arms.

It's probably not very hygienic and quite unhealthy but they can´t find the strength to tear each other apart from the other´s body, biting down on soft lips and brushing away the smears of blood from the other´s cheeks with their palms. Catra doesn´t even realize Adora is starting to stand up, ripping herself away from her until Adora´s lips leave her, full of sadness and longing, yearning for her warmth immediately. Catra´s eyes snap open, staring frantically at Adora´s hovering body, a new wave of desperation overtaking her.

"No," Catra begs, holding Adora´s wrists and pulling down from her so hard she stumbles back into her knees. Catra´s arm is still stinging with the scratches from Adora´s nails. "No"

"He's never going to let us live," Adora says slowly, the screaming behind them increasing.

Catra closes  her mouth so fast that she bites herself, looking back at Adora´s blue eyes with a thousand emotions written on them. She knows Adora is right, she knows her words speak that true. She knows Prime will burn the world and life after life no matter where they go until he finds them again. He made it very clear long ago, that he would never allow Catra to have Adora and for Adora to go.

"Then let me go with you," Catra says in a breath, already standing up.

Adora shakes her head harshly, pushing back from her gently but firm until she is sitting again. "No"

Catra´s lip curls over her gums, snapping at Adora´s beautiful, red face. "I am not afraid of him anymore, Adora"

Adora´s eyes narrow sadly, tangling her fingers softly over the curls in Catra´s forehead and bouncing them, a small gesture of playfulness that speaks of tender love. "I know"

"I have to face him, too. I can´t– I can´t let him win over me."

“You don´t have to,” Adora holds Catra´s face firmly, holding her eyes. “Catra, you´ve suffered enough. It´s enough. He won´t win and he won´t have you. You are alive, you will live. That´s all you need to win over him.”

Catra´s eyes twinkle, her bottom lip wiggling. “Let me look after you, too. Let me protect you”

“You already are,” Adora presses her hand against Catra´s collarbones, from the end of the painful scar to the center of her sternum where Catra's heart beats quietly, a silent vow between them. Catra´s eyes are charged when Adora looks back at her. “I have to do this on my own. I owe it to my family. To Mara. To ourselves.”

Adora gets a grip of an expensive purple fabric thrown on the back of the priest's chair and rips it into long pieces, managing a precarious but well done bandage around Catra´s torso, controlling the bleeding and the stab wound. After all, Adora is a pre-medicine student and she has learnt a thing or two about anatomy and wounds. Then Adora holds Catra´s hand gently and places it softly against the side of her own body, silently teaching how to press on the wound against her skin. Catra gasps and kicks in pain but she keeps it there, refusing to pass out or bleed out now.

“Stay here,” Adora instructs her softly, holding her face and kissing her forehead. There is so much gore between them right now but it doesn't get to stain the love they hold for each other. It´s a strange kind of love, theirs. Too strong, too heavily, too held above hell. “No matter what, no matter what you hear. Stay here, promise me”

“Okay,” Catra gasps, nodding, “I promise”

Adora steps out of the small nook, departing from the only faux safe space inside this place. Absently, Adora hopes that when it is over, no matter what happens, this place will be burnt to the

ground. That no other soul, no matter how broken or lost, will find its way inside this rotten place, with these rotten beliefs.

Prime has managed to rip the spear away and stand up on unsure feet, crunching over the floor like a rabid animal waiting to tear its prey apart. His shoulder is bleeding profusely and there is a gaping hole where the joint is supposed to be, the arm hanging by his side unmoving and heavy. Adora must have torn up nerves and arteries because the way it drips blood like a fountain and the fingers not even flinching from the pain is telling enough.

Adora stands several feet away from him, regarding him with cold eyes. She is as red as the demon statues and masks being strangled to death by angels on the stained glass, but her back is straight and her eyes are hooded, almost uninterested when she looks back at Prime, bored even when he snaps his teeth at her as if he were to actually bite her and rip a piece of flesh behind.

"Where is she?" Prime questions, blinking at the dark space behind Adora, where the bones are crumbled and the flowers pressed and where he cannot see Catra anymore. His useful green eye wrinkles in the corner when he narrows them, his melted cheeks stretching into a grotesque smile when he starts to chuckle, madly, insanely, the sounds jarring like chalk against glass. "Oh, *oh.* Did you hide her, did you hide your little pussy?"

Prime chuckles, shaking his head. He uses the bloodied spear like a cane and a weapon at the same time, dangling the sharp end fearfully close to Adora´s face. Adora doesn't even blink.

"Are we playing hide and seek now? Uh? I fuck you up and I get to hunt your bastard lover after? Nice, I like it," Prime pushes his hair back, spitting a gush of blood and saliva. His eyes have gone crazier, splashes of red and green on his pale face. "Did you like it, Adora? Uh? Did you like being between her legs? Inside of her? Was it worth it?"

Adora´s eyes narrow, the underside of her eyes twitching, anger falling down her bloodstream again at the sheer humiliation of

Catra´s and her intimacy in the mouth of this viper, but still she doesn´t move. She will let Prime make the first time, she will let him decide how this goes.

Adora remains very quiet, staring unmoving at Prime´s increasingly frustrated face in front of her. He snarls, spitting again when he yells, demanding a word from Adora´s mouth.

"Answer to me!" he exclaims, furious for Adora to give her enough attention or decency of answering but Adora is quiet as a tomb, standing only as a statue, almost without breathing.

In a way she is a lot like her aunt too, even if Adora never met her, even if only Prime knows it. Serenia also refused to scream when he murdered her. She also refused to speak, she also refused to look at Prime in the eye as he stabbed her to death. She held herself above even when she bled out in the middle of the woods. Mara was a lot like her too, her skull cracked and still spitting curses at Prime, her throat opened and still holding herself above the baptismal font to tell Prime he would never get Adora. Adora is a lot like them, brave and angry. A lover, like Marlena, a lover with a doomed soul.

Prime screams, furious when only Adora's silence meets him, swinging his good arm and the spear with all his strength towards her open body, soft tank top and joggers soaked in blood, nothing to protect her, no armor, no swords, nothing. He had promised no to kill her without breaking Catra first but he will have to make an exception now; maybe he can leave her alive just enough for her to see him rip Catra´s heart out of her ribcage.

Except that, tonight, he is not attacking from behind. He is not hunting or chasing or cornering his victim in dark and lonely places where they cannot run or ask for help. He is not dealing with poor and sweet Perfuma, or quiet and lovely Starla, or brave and gentle Scorpia. He is not dealing with Angella Bright or with Hordak or with any other of the souls the town still didn´t know about. He is not coming from behind or from the side, not hiding among his shadows and schemes anymore. He is coming upfront

and Adora is ready for him. Smart and kind Adora, who Mara taught how to fight.

Adora moves like a serpent herself, quick and calculated, meeting the side of the golden spear with her forearm and pushing it to the side. Her wrist twists and her fingers wrap over the cold metal, eyes frozen blue and lips pressed together, yanking the weapon out of Prime´s grasp with a simple pull, sending the heavy pole tethering behind him.

Prime´s eyes widen but Adora is already moving next, resting her palm over his injured shoulder and pulling him close until he bends down on all his height, falling heavily against Adora´s fist, punching him square in the broken nose. Prime sputters blood and gasps but he manages to hold himself from Adora´s side, digging his sharp nails against the stitches and pulling down, ripping them from root and tearing Adora´s frail skin in jarred wounds below the shirt.

Adora screams, recoiling with overwhelming pain, losing her grip for a second on Prime´s shoulder. He is taller than her so when he straightens up on tripping feet his face hovers above hers, his thin hand finding its way across Adora´s hair and pulling back from her neck, snapping her head back so hard she worries about whiplash.

Sparks of pain illuminate the corners of her vision and she gasps, watching between blurred eyes as Prime rises his own fist towards her face. Adora gasps and clenches her teeth, swinging her arm towards the side and hitting Prime on the face. Her own fingers find their way on the melted eye socket and she digs them there like digging them in sand, until all her nails and pads can feel is liquid and festering flesh giving away on her hold, the blind orbit snapping on her palm and blazing the nerve into fire.

Prime screams like an unholy demon, pulling and pulling from Adora´s hair until several strands come away on his fingers, completely copper and red, no longer golden. Even in his pain he manages to twist Adora around, slamming her against the edge of

a wood bench where the sharp metal of the back finds her cheekbone and make Adora howl with pain. She is sure her zygomatic arch is broken now and even if it isn´t it does hurt like a bitch.

Prime reaches for her again, grabbing the back of her shirt and the side of her chest, trying to pull her up with an unholy chuckle,

"Call for her," he taunts her, slamming his knee below the cassock against Adora´s ribs. Adora gurgles on the blood, hers and Lashor ´s and Prime´s and Catra´s too, gasping for air. "Call her!"

Adora yells, rolling on her side and kicking against his legs, the sole of her shoe meeting the ball of Prime´s knee with an audible crack. Prime stumbles on his broken knee and howls, reaching with his nails against Adora´s face and racking them down her neck, painting shallow lines there, dribbling down and losing themselves with all the gore.

Adora grunts and slams her elbow against his face, shaking herself from his hold but he grabs her ankle and pulls her back, making fall against the hard and cold floor too so hard that blood splatters from Adora´s nose and against the marble, making her sight obscure for the split of a second.

"Come for her, Catrina!" Prime is screaming, out of breath and on the floor too but so loud that his voice strains. "Come out, come out of your hiding, kitty. Or I will kill her and it will be because of you!"

"No!"

Adora twists on her back and stretches her arm, fisting a handful of white hair on her hand and bringing it down with her. Prime is not expecting her because he gasps when he falls on his side and he gasps again when Adora harrows her nails on his burnt cheek and slams Prime´s head against the floor. Once, thrice, again and

again like he did to Catra´s own head until Prime winces around his own body and curls, pushing Adora away weakly.

Adora feels her more than she hears her, a pull of her soul and a tug of her heart and she knows, she just *knows* that Catra is crawling her way back, her throat clogged and her heart beating so hard that it threatens to stop several times. The fluttering of her heartbeat on Adora´s ears and senses and nose. Adora snaps her head to the side, towards the darkness of the destroyed altar and snarls, kicking Prime´s forearm when he reaches back for her and pulls her leg, knocking her on her side.

"Don´t come, don´t fucking come!" Adora howls into the dark, choking on her breath when Prime stretches his arm and aims for her neck again, squeezing on her pipe before she punches him in the throat, standing up on unsure feet.

The phantom of Catra´s voice comes like a breeze on Adora´s ears, firm, scared yet gathering itself with bravery, calling for her when Adora´s voice fails her and all that is heard in the Cathedral are ragged breaths.

"Adora"

"Catra, I beg you! Please, don´t!"

Prime charges against Adora, slamming her back against one of the tall pillars of the Cathedral. He slaps Adora across the face when the air leaves her lungs, pressing his bleeding forearm against the hollow of her throat. Prime is gasping, gagging, eyes chaotic and hair and body a mess. He is feral and uncontrollable, a killer on the loose and if he gets a single glance of Catra, Adora knows he will now play with his food anymore. He will kill her, plain and simple, snap her neck in half and kill her at Adora´s feet.

"Why not?" Prime asks against Adora´s face, stroking her red hair with trembling fingers. He smiles, all teeth and rotten breath

against Adora´s nose. “Why not let her come? Don´t you think she would be able to take it? Do you think she is weak?”

Adora throws an all words bite towards him, seeking to rip his nose clean out of his face. He leans away at the last second, still pressing against Adora´s neck. Adora´s teeth click painfully with each other, splashing fine blood on his face when she grunts and squirms violently on his hold.

“Don´t you think it might bring some nice memories from her mommy?” Prime continuous loudly, knowing damn fucking well that Catra can hear him. “From what Sharon did to your Catrina? From what she did to her in return? She is a sinner. A murderer like me, too, you know that. You know it well. She will *always* be broken.”

Adora´s crystal blue eyes snap towards him, huge and angry, blazing with such a shade of blue that they almost look white. They almost don´t look human. Her hand seeks at the sides, finding what she is looking for quickly among the folds of Prime´s clothes. After all, Prime could not resist the need to give the final treacherous blow and Adora knows it.

“Just shut up, already!” Adora snaps, wrapping her fingers around the handle of the knife and yanking it back, twisting it in her palm and stabbing the sharp blade across his face from cheek to cheek with unnervingly perfect aim.

Prime gasps and when he does the blade cuts right through the corners of his mouth like butter, clean, sharp as a sword. The knife clicks back against the floor with a metal ring, dripping blood everywhere as Prime's surprised expression gives up to one of sheer horror when the muscle and skin that keeps his jaw in place gives up and the entire lower half of his mouth hangs down against his throat, tongue rolling out and blood with spit dripping everywhere.

Bile pools in the back of Adora's throat at the sight of the blood and gore. She coughs heavily and she gulps, pushing Prime's

bleeding body away from her. This time, he slips out of her with no resistance at all, stepping on the hem of his own classic and falling heavily against the floor.

Adora's chest is rising heavily, up and down with her panting. Her entire body aches but the adrenaline pumping inside her bloodstream still protects her from feeling it, extracting herself from the column of the chapel to walk towards Prime again.

The Priest is slithering on the ground, on her back and butt, one of his hands pushing against the floor and the other covering his mouth, absently trying to hold the mouth together without gurgling on his own fluids. He is trying to stand up but his body has finally reached its limit, the burnt on his face and his destroyed arm, the slice of her mouth open and blood, so much blood, staining the fabric of his clothes and soaking on the ground. The sight makes Adora want to throw up but there is too much anger inside of her right now to care.

She leans down and grabs the hem of the knife again, bringing it towards her face. She runs her fingers across her golden hair matted in red blood and gathers it all inside her palm, twisting it softly as she runs the sharp blade of the bloodied knife across the strands and switches with one cut.

Her soaked short hair shrinks immediately, curling in waves behind her ears and brushing the end of her chin and the back of her nape. The long strands rest now on Adora's palm, red like liquid fire and unmoving, a mirror of what Prime had done with his victims, a reclaim of her own body. The knife drops back on the floor.

“Where are you going?” Adora chews the words, closing her hands into fists at her sides, her hair between her fingers. She steps over the knife and pushes it away with her shoe, cleaning the blood dripping from her nose and face with the back of her hand. “I thought you wanted to cleanse me”

Prime´s breath shutters, his teeth stained in red where the jaw and the maxillary don´t get to meet anymore. He mutters something under his breath but it goes missing around the roll of his tongue. The smell of burnt skin and rot is penetrating inside the chapel, the incense and myrrh long ago burnt out.

Adora blinks and looks at his face but she also looks at Catra´s face below her eyelids, hanging from the bell tower, bleeding in the elevator, crying against Scorpia´s dead chest. She is better than Prime, so much better, held far above him like the altar and the bones were hanging from the ceiling. But she is tired, and Catra is tired too, she can feel her in her bones. Tired of blood, tired of violence, tired of incense and choir and the phantom of Weaver still digging her claws inside of her.

Adora is tired of being a saint and she is tired of running away. She is sick of him.

"I thought you wanted to purify my sins." Prime reaches beside them for the broken pieces of the heavy symbol, but Adora kicks him in the side, hitting the thick metal spikes out of his hold. Her shoes catch on the fingers Catra had broken and bends them in half. "But you have a great deal of sins yourself, don´t you?"

Adora stands right above Prime´s body, bending her knees and letting herself fall over him. Her knees slam against the floor and slip upwards, holding the angle of Prime´s elbows and keeping his arms from moving. Her entire weight rests above his torso, pulling down from his struggling body, locking him in place.

If his face wasn´t severely wounded and his body wasn´t bleeding in so many places, many he would have been able to push her again. But then again, Adora is also on edge and her own body is holding from a tightrope, yet she holds him down completely, slipping around his wrist and limbs like veins with thorns. She leans towards his face, baring red teeth towards him,

"You chased my mother out of her home. You murdered my aunt, my cousin. My entire family was broken and then you defiled my

mother´s tomb,”

Adora raises her hand and lets the strands of hair fall over Prime´s face, sticking to his bleeding skin and scattering across the ground by the freezing air. They lose themselves among the benches, alongside the fine strands of so many others.

Adora clicks her teeth together, her bangs falling over her eyes like curtains, the skin of her neck itching with the new length of the hair and the drying blood. Adora grabs Prime´s closed fists and forces it open with her nails alone, ripping the ring and the reliquary out of his grip. The tiny jewels fall to the floor with a small crack and Adora has the impulse to lean and grab then, hold them against her chest, but she shakes her head, meeting Prime´s insane eyes with hers.

“You tortured my love, you called her a bastard wife. But you are nothing compared to her, you are nothing at all.” Adora licks her busted lip, grunting. “Do you want to know the truth? I wed her, I vowed to her. I took her in ways more holy and sacred than your chapel and your religion could ever do. She is *mine* but more than anything I am hers. *All* that I am she loves and all is hers.”

Prime looks back at her with wrinkled eyes and then, much to Adora's horror, starts laughing again. His eyes roll on his sockets and he throws his head back, arching below Adora's knees with a long and stretched out cackle.

Adora's entire face burns with rage, humiliation crippling on her skin. She grabs Prime's dangling chin between her fingers and locks it in place, tearing the frail muscle there further.

“Look at me,” she demands, shaking him until he turns his eyes, the blind and the seeing one back to her face. The corner of his good eye narrows, running his tongue through the slick words, making a real effort to speak the venomous words around his broken mouth and his blood.

“You are so much like your mother.”

Adora's pupils shrink, leaning down to speak right next to Prime's ear. Somewhere in the chapel a window bursts open violently, pieces of glass and metal being pushed around heavily and a loud call, drowning every single sound inside and letting the cold breeze of the night slipping inside through every corner and altar, blowing all the candles off.

Adora leans back again, chest heavy and eyes hooded, staring down at Prime's fallen face and scared eyes. Green against red.

Her hand finds the bottom of the heavy, broken symbol as Prime's fingers twitch, his arms shaking as if he was making an effort to try and reach his hand towards her, run his bleeding and broken fingers through the uneven strands of her chopped hair and wrap his palm around her neck. His clothes are completely soaked in red now, the thick liquid coming from his mouth and throat making him gurgle when he speaks.

"My pretty, pretty hare."

Adora lifts the sharp symbol over her head and slams it down with a loud yell, The sharp metal of the wings carve their way down Prime´s face and the heavy base reaches the back of his skull, fine and delicate bone splintering into dozens of pieces and digging backwards instead of forward with a horrid squelch. Prime gasps with surprise but the sound is almost like an afterthought, an agonizing exhale. Blood spaches over Adora´s face and inside her mouth but even among the horrid terror she does not stop, she can´t find the light back home. All she can think about and feel is how much she wants him gone, *gone.*

Adora screams and lifts the symbol again just to slam it right back against Prime´s skull, over and over and over and over again until the bones turn into powder and the skin and muscle and nerves give away. Until the melted skin breaks again under the pressure and sharpness of the edge of the very symbol Prime had devoted himself and the entire town under, ripping away flesh and clogs of blood like pieces of moss and broken trunks. The heavy metal makes a disgusting sound against flesh and tongue, breaking

bones in the form of teeth and the cartilage of nose; busting the eyeballs until it drips tears and vitreous humor; snapping arches of skull that dig past sinuses and shoots their way inside the soft material of the brain, gray and white and bleeding too, crashing on the expensive marble floor of the faux Cathedral like rotten plumbs and broken watermelons, staining everything in blood.

Adora goes and goes and goes until the body is not moving under her anymore; until the hands that tore lives are not wrapped around her wrists and waist anymore. Until the slick mouth that spoke venom cannot speak anymore. Until the breath that brought with him nothing but sorrow and threats and blood is dead and gone by the very same hands that so much wished to possess and absorb.

Horror alone is what makes Adora stop. Her hands ache by how hard she holds the heavy metal, soaked completely in blood from the fingertips to the elbows, She is panting and she is suddenly exhausted, her body weighing her down completely, her very soul slipping in the edges. She stares down at the face that is not a face anymore and exhales, trembling and scared as she lets the First One symbol fall back into the floor, slipping from her hold.

Adora closes her eyes and tilts her head backwards, staring at the open dome of the chapel through which the faintest of drizzles have started to fall down, wetting her cheeks and blood soaked hair like gentle kisses, like reassurances of the earth alone. Like the caress of the people she loves and that are gone now, telling her she can rest, telling her it´s enough.

Adora lets her eyes fall closed, still over Prime´s dead body, and lets out a strangled yell, breaking down finally. Tears gather in the corners of her eyes and slip down heavily across her cheeks and chin, cleaning paths among the redness and falling against the gore below her knees. She cries and cries hard, harder every single second when she wraps her hands around her face and sobs until she can´t breathe, allowing herself to sob and tear and cry until she physically cannot do it anymore.

A new sound calls for her attention, soft steps over the soaked floor. Adora runs her exhausted and bloodshot eyes to the side in time so see Catra walking across the corridor of the chapel with slow steps, her hair cradling her face. Bow and Glimmer are by her sides, each one crossing one of her scratched and bleeding arms over their shoulders, helping her stand up and not crumble to the floor when her knee bends with pain every few steps. Their clothes are wrinkled and torn and their faces are covered in sweat, small pieces of glass still tangled on their hair. They must have finally managed to break a window without metal barriers and jump inside, going to Catra´s aid immediately. Adora is grateful, she looks at Bow and she is grateful.

Outside there are new sounds too, loud and annoying, the characteristic ring of the police cars and ambulances finally making their way towards the chapel, as always, late. Catra holds Adora´s terrible expression and her own eyes soften and melt, tears gathering on her multicolored irises and spilling down too. She doesn´t even pay attention to the dead body of the priest that had been hunting them, all of her heart and all of her attention directly on Adora crying to the skies above.

Adora stands up in trembling feet, slipping twice in the bloodied floor and walking just a few feet away from the corpse before her body completely shuts down and she collapses against the cold floor again. Catra is already moving by then, dropping her holds on their friends and shooting forwards, cradling Adora inside her arms and holding her against her chest when Adora´s body does not respond anymore and lays limp and tired, unable to move.

Catra tucks Adora´s face gently against the scarred side of her own neck and hushes her gently, hiding her from the violence with her own curls and petting the now short strands of Adora´s own, She wraps her aching limbs around Adora´s pained ones and press them so close to each other that their heart meet through the layers of fabric, ribcage and skin.

“Adora,” Catra cries right next to Adora´s cold ear, “I got you, I got you now.”

Adora wants to giggle and smiles next to Catra´s neck, reassured and relieved by the touch of their skins, still warm and still alive, together. But all that comes out is a very strained wheeze strangled on her vocal cords, her body shivering so violently that her teeth click together several times.

"It's alright, it's over," Catra is whispering, lingering sweet kisses across Adora´s face. Her hands around Adora´s neck and jaw feel heavenly, a gulp of fresh water among the fires of hell. "It 's over. He is gone.

Adora hiccups next to Catra´s neck, her hands too tired to raise them and wrap themselves over Catra´s waist and chest. Her eyelids feel weighed down by gun powder and her mouth feels stuffed with cotton. The only thing keeping her awake and conscious right now is Catra, Catra and her smell, Catra and Adora ´s need to feel her safe around her. Catra always and ever.

The door of the chapel trembles with a hit, the lock being chainsawed open by the emergency services. So many sounds, so suddenly, that overwhelm Adora´s head and her trembling soul, making her gasp with tears.

"I´m alright," Catra murmurs next to the corner of Adora´s mouth. Maybe Adora spoke the words out loud, maybe Catra just felt their tug inside her heart too. Whatever it is, she knows Adora and she holds her now. She looks after her now. "You can rest, Adora. You can rest now."

Adora inhales, gathering Catra´s smell inside of her lungs and resting her soul inside Catra´s palms, nodding next to her face. Adora manages to rest her palms over Catra´s back and embraces her close too, holding the color of her eyes inside her as she finally allows her mind to slip and she falls into the bittersweet darkness of unconsciousness.

She still can feel Catra´s touch, even asleep.

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*End of Chapter VI*

Chapter End Notes

I want to personally congratulate and give a cookie to the person that pointed out the Deity's bones on a comment. Congrats, you found Mara. I told you she was looking

Uff! That was honest to good so hard to fucking write but I'm so happy it's over now. And I'm so happy Prime's violence is over for our babies. And look! They made it out of this one alive! Wohooo!

She you on Friday for the closure! Until then be good! Can't wait to read you down below :3

# Montague and Capulet

Chapter Notes

Montenegro and Capellan are very curious last names

Don´t you think?

WARNINGS FOR THIS CHAPTER:
- Suicide ideation beware
- Descriptions of murder
- Blood, wounds and gore
- Mentions of death animals

See the end of the chapter for more notes

## [Montague and Capulet]

*Oh, and you rip my ribcage open and devour what's truly yours*

*And our screaming joins in unison, I cry out to the Lord*

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♥

**October 31th, Halloween**

**The Seventh Anniversary**

They spent two whole days in the hospital, which all things considered is quite a short time for the amount of wounds inflicted over them.

The ambulances arrive at the chapel around fifteen minutes and twenty two seconds after the police finally manage to break the door open and burst inside, as if the horror had not already passed. Adora and Catra are both placed on different gurneys and Catra threatens with biting the paramedics hands off if she is not placed on the same ambulance car as Adora, no matter if she is

actively bleeding from her side or if she needs attention immediately.

It's quite a tug and pull and almost a fight breaks out until Bow manages to convince Catra that he will ride next to Adora´s still unconscious body as long as she allows the paramedics to give her the attention she so much needs. The fact that she had not already fainted from blood loss was a give away of exactly how stubborn Catra could be about Adora´s safety and care.

In the end Catra is also strapped to her own gurney and rolled away as they place an IV on her arm and start monitoring her. She does pass out in the travel to the hospital in the end, but by then they are receiving the attention they need. They both can rest.

Adora knows all of this because Bow told her once she woke up again, sitting at the foot of Adora´s feet while they both watched over Catra´s sleep in the bed next to Adora´s. She had been quietly placed there, in the very same room, barely two or three feet from each other after Catra´s surgery for her stab wounds. Adora had quietly held her bandaged hand between hers and hand´t let go since there, waiting for as much time as she needed and grateful to have her close right now.

Absently, Adora knew this must have been Castaspella´s doing, a small blessing for the two of them after everything. And maybe it was because she imagined just how deep their devotion for each other ran, maybe it was because she knew Adora would try to burn the hospital to the ground if they were to keep them separated. Whatever the reason, when Adora caught Castaspella ´s eyes through the window of the hospital room, Adora nodded at her in recognition. A silent thank you.

Adora would have lied if she were to say that it didn´t sucked every second she laid on that hospital bed. Every single inch of her body ached and morphine was her new best friend for the time being. Besides the previous stab to the shoulder and the slash to her side, she now had fractured ribs, an extremely nasty

burnt on her aching shoulder, a concussion and so many bruises, scratches and red patches across her body that she barely could see the actual tone of her skin below them. Her cheekbone was fissured and a nasty bruise has made its home over her face, from the temple to the arch of the cheek, purple and black and painful to even look at, much less to touch.

She had also accidentally cut herself when she slashed her hair in a rabid impulse but at least the soft strands were soft around her neck and head now, cradling her head like a small halo. Catra had blushed tenderly when she caught wind of the golden short hair, her eyes wrinkling in the corners gently. Even still halfway under the effect of the anesthesia and the medicine, she had managed to mumble how beautiful Adora looked and squeeze her hand before falling asleep again.

Unsurprisingly for the medics and sickening for Adora, Catra had taken the worst part of it. Her knee was just too close to snapping completely and she had been placed in strict bed rest for the rest of their days in the hospital. She had been taken to a CT and MRI twice and diagnosed with a mild concussion that could have been extremely dangerous if they had fallen from the tower in a different way; it would not put her life in danger but the migraine that could come with it would be violent for the first few days. Her ankle was twisted and her ribs bruised all over, and beside the now completely stitched up and tightly wrapped stab wound that had not come past the muscles, her arm was completely scratched up by Adora´s own nails after trying to hold her up.

Red and purple too, aching and half out of it too. Catra knew it was not a pretty sight and the thought of it made her want to skin into herself. But for Adora, she was beautiful, beautiful always no matter what and not matter how. Holding Catra´s hand those two days strapped to the bed, standing up from her own bed with precarious feet and slipping inside Catra´s below her bedsheets to cradle her against her chest even though the nurses scolded them both after, was Adora´s only source of peace and happiness. The beginning of the rest of their lives.

By the start of the second day they were almost completely awake again, speaking in soft voices. Catra laughed every time Adora made a bad joke of their shared wounds and the hospital and the sheer sound made Adora´s eyes wrinkle with happiness. Bow stayed around for most of it, sitting cross legged on the end of Catra´s bed and sneaking cheese sandwiches for them when Catra complained about the hospital food.

Glimmer took a little longer to walk in, the pain of her mother still too fresh inside her heart. But when she did her face looked better and her face clearer, her shoulders less tense now. She cursed Prime like a fucking sailor on the loose and cried next to Adora´s hospital bed but by the start of the evening she was giggling too, rolling her eyes at Bow´s lighthearted stories and nuzzling on the uncomfortable chair. She even shot a frail smile towards Catra´s side, much by Adora´s delight.

Huntara also walked inside, her eyes casted down and her face slightly pale but still straight as a ruler. The four of them were extremely quiet when she walked inside the room, staring at her with heavy eyes until Huntara finally decided to talk.

"I think I should start by saying that no charges will be raised against you," Huntara says, staring directly at Adora´s face.

Adora frowns, her nose wrinkling. Her mouth tastes a little bit as if she had taken a mouthful of salt. "They won't?"

"No," Huntara leans against the opposite wall of the hospital room, clicking her tongue against her teeth. "You defend yourself against a murderer. Whatever you had to do is going to be considered self defense. Nobody is going to blame you or chastise you for that"

Adora stares at her face without moving for a second, blinking very slowly. "I see," she nods, exhaling slowly. She holds catra´s hand and doesn´t meet Huntara´s eyes. "Thanks"

“And I– apologize, for everything,” Huntara adds, meeting Adora and Catra´s eyes. Catra is quiet but Adora´s face falls into a deep frown, her mouth pulling down from the corners.

“You didn´t listen to us,” she murmurs, unable to keep the accusation from her voice.

“I know,” Huntara agrees with a deep breath, rolling her lips over her gums. “We found Lashor´s phone on his body, it seems he and Priest Prime had a deal. Lashor would provide him information about you and the investigation procedures and in exchange Prime would make sure Lashor would become Mayor in the next elections. Priest Prime must have gotten rid of Hordak and later he– um.”

Huntara´s voice flatters, her eyes hovering over Glimmer´s face and dropping again. Glimmer takes a sharp intake of breath, wrinkling her nose, her eyes drowning with tears. She is more angry than sad now, clenching her teeth tightly.

“He got rid of my mom,” Glimmer finishes when Huntara´s voice fails. Huntara sighs and nods, running her hand over the back of her neck.

“I don´t think that was the whole reason. Your mother– she was a very smart woman, Glimmer. Angella realized what Priest Prime was doing when she looked through the newspapers. And she had access to a lot of dirty stuff Hordak did through his time as Mayor. But before she realized what was happening she used to go to him to confess, all of us did. I did too.”

Huntara´s voice weaves and loses itself a little, eyes unfocused as she remembers all the times she went for Priest Prime´s words, for his advice about the violence that was happening without knowing he was the cause of it.

“I told Prime about our suspects of the murder and between him and Lashor, tried to blame Catrina. And then I told Lashor where was your friend Scorpia and he lured her out, that's how Prime

got a hold of her. And even before all of this, all of us knew Prime and Hordak used to do dirty business together. I knew, Angella knew too but we were all quiet. I am so sorry it came to this."

Adora looks at Catra out of the corner of her eye, studying her expression softly. Catra´s entire face shifts with grief at the mention of Scorpia, the corners of her mouth pulled down. Scorpia´s mothers had come earlier all the way from the Mountains to speak with Catra and mourn with her too. They had been very kind and very understanding, not once blaming Catra for what had happened or putting the blame over her. Bur Adora knew she carried with it and will probably carry it for the rest of her life. The fact that negligence for the part of the same people that were supposed to protect them was the very reason that tragedy had happened still made Adora´s blood boil.

Glimmer´s line of thought wasn´t too far away from hers. The mention of Angella and the insinuation that she had spent a long time covering for dirt and other stuff hadn´t go unnoticed and it was heavy over her heart and shoulders. As if she had to carry for the sins of her mother now that the latter was not here.

The detective must have realized the same thing because she lets her hand fall heavily over Glimmer´s shoulder, squeezing it almost too hard.

"Your mother made mistakes, like all of us. She trusted in the wrong people, she must have said a lot of things that Prime later used against her and all of you. He might have even tried to make her an accomplice but– in the end, she was very brave. She stood up against him and protected you all with her last breath. We should honor and remember that."

Glimmer returns her sight heavily, sighing after a few seconds of silence, her shoulders flopping. "Yeah. Yes, I guess you are right."

The room falls quiet for a second, the bip of the machines around them and the smell of disinfectant and clean gauzes filling their nostrils. It´s a very quiet and calm evening after it rain through

two days whole, the soft light of the sunset slipping below the plastic curtains.  Huntara stares at the four friends and takes a breath, rubbing the bridge of her crooked nose before speaking again.

“There is something else,” She says, crossing her arms over her chest. “We found another body, in the graveyard near the mausoleum. Double Trouble, did you know them?”

Catra goes very still in the bed, soft enough that Huntara doesn´t notice it but the rest of her friends do. Her progressively more pinkish cheeks goes a little bit pale and she snaps her eyes away, staring at some point of the wall behind Huntara. She answers with her nose wrinkled, chewing in the words like they weighed her terribly.

“I did,” she says, absently seeking Adora´s hand. Adora holds her immediately, tangling their fingers together as she stares at Catra with curious and sorrowful eyes. “Are they– are they dead?”

“Yes,” Huntara confirms after a moment of silence. “It seems that happened a little before Scorpia´s own murder but we´ll know more when the autopsy is done. However, I checked their phone personally. It seems Angella started paying them to follow you around.”

“Angella?” Catra blinks, taken aback, her face falling from heavy to confused and then plainly sad, eyes narrowing in the corners.

She knew Angella didn´t trust her, but paying Double Trouble to follow her? Keeping her in check by sending the person that had hurt Catra in the past, being knowingly or not, though Catra suspected Angella knew or suspected she somehow knew they were more than just acquaintances for a moment, was a whole new reach of betrayal. It hurts, almost as much as Angella´s death, almost as much as learning she really had never been loved by her. It will take a long time for Catra to be able to heal from it.

“Yes. Angella had informants everywhere, even on her time as the Mayor's assistant. She paid Double Trouble handsomely for any information about you,” Huntara explains, worrying the inside of her cheek. Adora goes tense on the bed too, tense and tired. “And later, when she realized you weren´t involved, she paid them to follow Prime. And as far as we know, Prime was not going to let them get in the middle of their business.”

The four friends exchange a look, a heavy expression running through all of them. A lot of bad shit has happened in the last few days and right now they feel too worn to the bone too even look further into the meaning of all of that.

“But– then why were they not displayed like the rest? All of our friends were used as bait but Double Trouble was just– tossed aside?” Bow inquiries, frowning as he draws gentle swirls inside Glimmer´s wrist. Huntara shrugs, truly unsure of the reason why.

“I don´t think it was in his plans to kill them until he realized Double Trouble was following him. And I– I don´t think you want to know how we found their body”

The four shake their heads in negative immediately, taken aback. Huntara nods, digging her hands inside the pockets of her pants. She knows this is too much for all of them, that the wounds are still fresh in their bodies and souls, but she needed to speak with them first. After all, she also feels a great deal of guilt right now.

“And Adora,” Huntara adds after a breath, rolling the words in her tongue as cold unease starts to drip down her back. “We cannot locate Light Hope anywhere”

Adora blinks back at her, her big almond eyes sparkling with confusion and then falling with fear, a spark of the same feeling Huntara has right now clear on her pretty face. She holds Catra´s hand tighter inside her fingers, rubbing the middle of her sternum with the other hands in an attempt to calm her rising heart.

“The last time I saw her she said she would get in touch with you,” Adora whispers. A new expression horses her eyes, sadness with apprehension, her body absently pulling itself closer to Catra ´s hospital bed. “She said you would send Catra to jail”

“I never spoke with her.” Huntara denies, wrinkling her nose. “Maybe Lashor”

Adora nods but it is very robotic, thinking the words over and over and closing her eyes for a second before opening them again. She looks older than she was a week ago, worn down and bruised.

“Do you–” Her voice breaks a little on the seams, making her take a shuddering breath. “Do you think she is dead too?” she asks and it is shaky, as if she really didn´t wanted to hear the answer.

“I don´t know,” Huntara admits, kicking the foot of the bed loosely. “But we know she was in a way very deeply involved with Prime´s plan so while we clear everything I want you to be very careful”

“Okay,” Adora nods, gulping heavily. Catra is looking at her back, caressing her knuckles and pressing a soft kiss over the red knuckles. She is very careful, it is obvious for everyone in the room, the way her eyes melt with tenderness and her mouth pulls with a worry frown yet is completely sweet as she stares at the side of Adora´s face, guarding her even in silence.

“Rest,” Huntara orders and it is not even towards Adora alone. She points at Catra, Bow and Glimmer too as she puts on her jacket again. “I have a shit ton of papers and messages I have to go through but I´ll send someone to pick you all up tomorrow. We are sending you to a safe apartment on the limits of the town and then you are going to Eternia until we determine everything is safe.”

She makes sure everyone is nodding in agreement before leaving, skipping over the floor with a new message from the detective's office. A lot of new information about Prime´s and Hordak´s dirty

business in the town is coming through, as well from Angella´s personal data pad. She is definitely pulling an all-nighter today.

Glimmer and Bow end up falling asleep in the guests' couches of the hospital room, sharing a blanket and snoring softly on each other's arms. At night the warmth is comfortable, even for a hospital, a small blessing from being granted a private room in a private floor of the huge hospital. Being almost murdered by a psychotic serial killer has its good things sometimes, or as good as they can be around something deeply fucked up.

The night nurse comes to check on them and right after she is gone Adora slips out of her bed, carrying the IV and serum bags on her arms. She hands them blindly on Catra´s tripod and slips below her sheets right after, very careful to not wake up their friends in the process. Catra is already waiting for her, opening her arms the second Adora jumps over the mattress and wrapping them around her neck immediately, bringing her into a tender embrace. Adora hums against the side of her head, pressing soft kisses all along her temples and smothering her in tender caresses across her spine and arms below the soft gray fabric of their hospital pajamas.

Catra opens her eyes to meet her among the dark, her scleras still bloodshot but her expression calm, watching Adora with a thousand words unsaid.

“Hey,” is the only thing Catra needs to say, booping the tip of Adora´s nose with her fingertip. Adora smiles and kisses her pad, nuzzling inside the warm palm that follows it with a lazy grin.

“Hey,” Adora whispers back, sighing deeply. “I love you.”

Catra´s eyes wrinkle in the corners and fill with tears, dripping silently over the cover of the pillows. “I love you too.”

Adora brings Catra´s left hand towards her face, pressing tender kisses over her knuckles. Her ring finger is still tightly bandaged with soft medical bands and it smells clean after the nurse

cleaned it for her. Catra blinks at her finger too, wrinkling her nose in that pretty way Adora loves.

"You think they are going to have my ring in custody for much longer?" Catra whispers between them, looking from her slowly healing finger to Adora´s eyes. Adora´s face melts with tenderness, grasping an errand curl of her hair and gently placing it behind her ear.

"I don't think so. Maybe just a few more days while things calm down," Adora shrugs, nuzzling deeper on the pillow. "I can ask her for it tomorrow if you want."

Catra hums, stretching her hand too. She runs her fingers through the short strands of blonde hair curling around Adora´s hair, playing with the short ends and smiling when they tickle the back of Adora´s neck and make her giggle.

"I like it," Catra whispers, a spark of kindness and overwhelming love deep inside her eyes.

"I like it too," Adora exhales softly, "Feels lighter."

Catra grins, a little weaker on the edges, already half asleep. Adora hums and tucks her below the angle of her neck, resting them both gently on each other's arms. They fall asleep for the first time in days without fear and without the needs of heavy meds, relaxed by the single fact of being together inside the uncomfortable and small bed of the hospital.

In the morning, around midday, they are discharged of the hospital, walked and watched very closed by two officials that follow the four of them down the elevator and across the most private door possible of the hospital, right outside the tiny parking lot where the hospital personal parks their cars and where two slick black cars are already waiting for them.

They all wear very comfortable clothes, gray and white shirts and sweatshirts and joggers that buckle on their ankles. They almost look like they had all broken from the mental wing from the

hospital, which wasn´t far enough from the level they were actually admitted to so it´s fitting.

Bow has his arm wrapped over Glimmer´s shoulder, his crop top sweatshirt raising a little with the movement; Catra helped him cut the fabric with scissors in the bathroom before the nurses could say anything at all. He speaks very softly to Glimmer, lingering kisses every once in a while over the top of her head. Castaspella had insisted on covering all the details of Angella´s funeral to let Glimmer rest but even with that Glimmer could not stop being  stressed and sad for the whole ordeal. She wanted to help, to make good in her mother´s memory who had been brave to the end, but there was also profound sadness inside her chest. She would need a lot of time to heal first before moving on with her life. Before she keeps existing without her mother.

Adora is standing a shy few feet behind them, her arm tightly crossed around Catra´s legs and mouth next to Catra´s temples. Catra had refused the crutches so between the heavy analgesics and her weight resting next to Adora´s she was skipping across the hospital with almost a too cheerful step.  She looked so much better than the previous days too, her cheeks rosier and her skin healthier, bruises slowly fading into the first shades of green. She gasps every once in a while when the stitches on her side pull too painfully but Adora is always there for her, nuzzling her neck and whispering sweet reassurance against the curves and freckle of her face.

The four of them are eager to get away from the hospital and into another safe place, still moving around like cattle from one place to the other but calmer than the previous days, a faux sense of security falling over their young shoulder when the officers rush to open the car doors for them.

It all goes to absolute shit when one of the officers reaches Adora and places a hand over her shoulder, shaking her head in negative when Adora gives a step to climb the backseat where Glimmer and Bow are already sitting.

“Not you. You are coming with me.” The officer says in a tone of voice that leaves no questions, already tugging from Adora´s shoulder. She had given her sweatshirt to Catra so she is only on the white tank top below and the more she keeps standing on the empty parking lot the more her skin raises in goosebumps.

Adora´s eyebrows skyrocket, her mouth pulling into a surprised frown, completely taken aback. “Why?”

“Protocol. Light Hope is still missing so we need to secure her house and you need to take your documents out of there too,” the officer tells her, opening the door of the second car. Glimmer and Bow have climbed back out of the first one to see the commotion and Adora´s fingers are still tightly wrapped around Catra´s but the officers pries them open, shaking her head. “Huntara´s orders. You´ll be back together in a hour, two tops”

“Let me go with her,” Catra rushes to say, wrapping her arms across Adora´s chest, pressing her front against Adora´s back. Adora is deadly quiet but Catra´s eyes are wide and alarmed, her lips retracting over her gums. “I can help her pack.”

“No,” the officer denies her, slightly pushing her back from her shoulder and pulling from Adora´s arm. “You are all considered protected witnesses from now on. We are not allowing any of you to wander around unsupervised.”

Catra opens her mouth, lips retracted over her gums and ready to snap but Adora shakes head, gently cradling the side of Catra´s face. Adora doesn´t like this any better than her but fighting the police and Huntara right now is now going to bring them anything really good. Adora is tired and just wants to sleep and be with Catra so the sooner this whole endeavor is done, the better.

“It´s okay,” Adora reassures Catra, running her thumb over her bruised cheekbone. “Stay with Bow and Glimmer. I have my phone with me, I´ll send you messages every second.”

“Don´t leave, not again,” Catra whispers, just between them, private, and Adora can see she is suddenly frantic again, afraid again of having to phantom a second longer away from Adora after all what had happened. “Stay with me.”

“I will,” Adora leans and presses a fluttering kiss over Catra´s forehead, trying to hide the sudden fear overwhelming her too. “Just an hour. I´ll bribe Huntara to give me back the ring too.”

Adora leans to the side a little, pressing Catra´s forehead against the side of her jaw and throwing a swift look towards Bow and Glimmer. They are also tense, staring between the officers and Adora and absolutely considering the possibilities of fuck off and take their cars themselves or following Adora to Light Hope´s house themselves.

“Stay in the apartment,” Adora asks her friends, “I won´t be long. Right?” The last part she says it more strained, throwing a tense stare towards the officer who is already nodding back, her mouth pulled into an annoyed scowl.

“Yes, sure.”

Adora extracts herself gently from Catra´s hold and smiles at her once more, leaning one last kiss against her cheekbones before turning around her ankles. giving slow and definitely not happy steps towards the second car.

Glimmer and Bow have to pretty much drag Catra all the way to the first car with them, guiding her inside as the other officer closes the door tightly behind them. Catra is deadly quiet the entire time, looking at the shattered screen of her phone and back out of the window with increasing restlessness. She is tapping on the floor of the car with her foot and biting her nails until they bleed and she has to forcefully pull them back in her lap, ignoring Bow´s attempts to lighthearted conversation.

They don´t make it too far from the town. In fact, they are way closer to Light Hope´s house than any of them originally thought.

It's just a short trip across the forest line and that fact makes Glimmer´s stomach turn uncomfortable, wrinkling her nose uneasily.

The building where the car parks is just like any other apartment building, much similar to Scorpia´s but shorter in height and the sight makes Glimmer gulps down heavily, pushing away the knot on her throat and sighing deeply.

"Hey, Catra? What if you chose the bed this time? I know Adora sleeps fights a lot–"

She looks blindly for Bow´s fingers, lacing them together tightly, and turns around, her mouth already open to say something to Catra when she realizes there is actually nobody behind them anymore. The car door is swinging a little with the breeze, open from side to side, and not even being bothered to be closed and the back seat is completely empty. The branches of the tree line of the forest are still moving a little, a tell tale than Catra crossed them as quickly as she could with her busted knee, seeking to follow and reach Adora no matter where.

Glimmer grumbles, pinching the bridge of her nose and kicking on the floor. A nasty feeling stirs on the pits of her belly, reborning from the ashes and clogging her throat with anxiety. "Shit. Awesome, just great"

"Where is the other one?" The officer has just noticed Catra´s absence after Glimmer and Bow didn´t follow them inside the building, their eyes frantic and angry as they look from the back seat to Bow and Glimmer´s faces. "What the hell happened"

"She obviously went to reach Adora," Glimmer answers, rolling her eyes, trying to shove down the sudden fear crawling on her arms. "This is what happens when you separate those two after a serial killer tried to murder them three days ago"

"Fuck," the officers curses, rushing to call from the car´s radio. "Fuck!"

Part of Glimmer wants to follow Catra into the woods and drag her by the hair back with them or just plainly go together to Light Hope´s house. After all, Glimmer still feels like she has a whole deal of stuff to make up for Catra. Another part of Glimmer, the one that is completely exhausted and still mourning, just wants to lie on the floor and close her eyes.

Glimmer is about to turn around and ask Bow to just go inside and sleep for two days more when the spare phone the department had handed her starts ringing too loudly on her side pocket, demanding for her immediate attention as it rings and vibrates over and over again.

Glimmer takes it out with a frown in her forehead, staring back at the *Unknown number* blinking on the plain screen. Bow shoots her a quiet stare, nervous and restless all of the sudden too, biting his chapped lips and nodding, his nails digging moon carves on his palms.

Glimmer unlocks the phone and presses the green button, running her finger over the speaker until the sound of static becomes clear in the space where they are. “Hello?”

“Bright!” Huntara screams on the phone, making the speaker ring. There are a lot of sounds where she is, cars honking and the strain of an engine and Huntara panting on the speaker and cursing loudly when she passes another honking car. “Is Adora with you?”

“Uh, no?” Glimmer frowns, looking at Bow´s dark eyes with anxiety crawling all over her chest. “Your officers took her to Light Hope´s house for her documents. She said it was your order”

“Shit!” Huntara yells, slamming her palms against the car wheel until the honk goes off. “Fuck!”

“Huntara what the fuck is going on?” Glimmer demands, her voice straining and breaking with tension. She feels very cold suddenly, even below the warm air of this autumn day.

“Prime didn´t kill Hordak,” Huntara snaps so hard her teeth click audibly. “It wasn´t him.”

“What are you talking about?”

“Priest Prime was seen in the Cathedral that night, he was giving the Autumn Mass at eight in the evening. And later the Autumn Blessings. The whole thing was over at around seven in the morning. Hordak was murdered in the very early hours of the dawn, there is no possible way he could have killed him! Get out of my way!” Huntara screams, cursing another passing car. She has changed her trajectory, driving as fast as she can.

Glimmer goes pale as a ghost, staring an absent point in the woods and then at Bow´s wide eyes. “But I– I don´t get it.”

“There is someone else, someone that helped him!” Huntara is crossing the entire town like a soul pulled out of hell, still screaming on the phone and somehow not losing control. “We managed to track Light Hope´s phone! She never left Etheria and the last call she made was to Double Trouble´s phone number the night they were murdered! She was the one who lured them there so Prime would kill them!”

“Fucking hell,” Bow is in movement already, turning on his ankles to speak with the officer who is still fighting with the radio of the car. Glimmer slams the door closed and turns towards the line of trees, stepping right on the edge. She can see a small path of ruffled leaves and broken branches where Catra has gone through. And she can hear the nearby rush of the Thaymor river crossing below the old bridge. “We are going to Light Hope´s house right now!”

“No! Stay the fuck there!”

“Catra is gone!” Glimmer explains with an equal scream, pulling from the short strands of her pink hair. “She slipped right under our nose and went to get Adora!”

“Damnit!” Huntara slams her feet on the brakes so hard that even where Glimmer is she can hear the motor protesting before it roars back to life. “Light Hope– she placed an order in the chapel directed for Priest Prime. A petition actually, For Catra to be shipped off to a First One boarding school. That place is fucking famous for psychological and mental torture.”

Glimmer frowns, completely confused. “Why would Prime have any power to send Catra anywhere?”

“What exactly do you know about the Weaver family?”

Bow is jogging back towards her, his face strained with anger. By his expression and the way the officer is scowling and shaking their head, Glimmer already has a very good idea that they are refusing to take them anywhere else. “Uh. Sharon Weaver was Catra´s mother. And Hordak was Sharon´s brother, I found out a few day ago about that–”

“Brothers!” Huntara interrupts her, grunting under her breath.

Glimmer blinks, mind coming to a stop. “What?”

“Brothers! Sharon and Hordak had a big brother. Nordor Kurr! He was born with albinism and her mother believed him a saint, an angel even, so she gave him the family´s surname while the younger ones got the father´s name,” Huntara explains, out of breath. Cold acid runs down Glimmer´s veins as the peculiar name clicks inside her head. “He is–”

“Priest Prime,” Glimmer exhales, the corner of her eyes burning with terrified tears. “Priest Prime was Catra´s uncle”

“Yes! He is the only family she has left!”

Bow´s breath stops inside his lungs, harshly tangling on his ribcage. Hectares at Glimmer´s face but Glimmer´s eyes are lost in the tree, her mouth opening and closing several times. There is a heavy weight placed on her forehead and pressing down her brain, making her short of breath and her heart to speed up so

hard that it hurts inside her chest. Bow is dialing Adora and Catra ´s phone number over and over again next to Glimmer but neither of them pick up, the line going flat as soon as he presses the dial button.

"Stay where you are!" Huntara orders with a tone of voice so harsh that it would bend back any person's sense of rebellion. But not Glimmer´s and not Bow´s, not when it comes to their friends. "Your mother kept the records of her investigation on her data pad, I´ll watch the mall videos to confirm my suspicious. And I´m going to the house right now! Do not move from the apartment!"

Huntara hangs up immediately as her car stops, cutting the communication quickly. Glimmer stares at the dark screen without moving and then very slowly turns to look at Bow´s terrified face. She tries to speak but fails several times, feeling how time slips out of her hands the longer she hovers on the edge of the Whispering Woods.

"Do you think she knew?" Glimmer whispers, narrowing her eyes. Bow shakes his head, shoulders shaking.

"I don´t know"

Glimmer looks back at the woods, inhaling slowly. She is scared, she is scared of what she is going to see, she is scared of what she is going to encounter once she steps past the white threshold of Light Hope´s house, once she crosses this thick forest and the crumbling bridge and arrives to a place that minutes ago felt so foreign and not feels like a prey´s trap, ready to devour them all whole once they sniff too close.

"Let´s go"

"But Glimm–"

"Bow," Glimmer turns to look at her boyfriend with huge, pretty eyes, smart like a fox and pleading. "My mom– she took so much time before she finally wanted to speak up and by the time she

did it was too late. I don´t– I don´t want to do the same, I don´t want to be late when we are so close to help them."

*I don´t want to be a coward,* she thinks but she doesn´t say it. Still, Bow seems to be able to hear her clearly because after a second he nods very slowly, linking their fingers together and pressing a kiss on her forehead before stepping into the woods, ignoring the screaming officer behind them.

They rush across the trees as fast as they can, panting when the air fails them and they have to take a second to breathe and not collapse down with exhaustion. They jump through thick bushes and fallen tree trunks, rushing across the thick paths covered in moss and being very careful when they reach the abandoned bridge and cross the rotten logs with shivering feet. If she wanted,

Glimmer could reach her own home from here, going a little bit to the south where the sun is warm and skipping on stones until she sees the pink and lilac walls of the manor. But instead, she walks north, following Bow´s sure feet when she suddenly gets lost and doesn´t know where to go next. He guides her through the close tree trunks until they finally manage to catch sight of the shell whites and deep blues of Light Hope´s huge house.

The police car where Adora and the officer had departed the hospital´s parking lot is parked neatly right outside the quiet and humongous house. The gardens are perfectly neat as always, marble statues and no green, just gray and crystal blue and the First One´s symbol hanging perfectly placed right above the door. There is another car here too, one that is not Adora´s, an old red pick up that she shares with Bow on the weekends and that right now is in his house.

This one is white, from end to end, with the rear lights green, usually spotless now slightly covered with a fine layer of dust over the windshield. It is Light Hope´s car, parked right outside the garage door and quiet too.

Glimmer gulps a heavy knot laying on the base of her throat. She and Bow skip up the steps of the porch, reaching for the door at the same time and without a second thought. On insight, they should have formed a plan, talked about it and discussed it, going through the back door even, but after so much, neither of them think that.

Bow turns the doorknob and pushes the heavy white wood and crystal door, pushing it with his shoulder but it bounces right back, almost knocking him on the nose with inertia. He gasps in surprise, staring at the door as if it had personally offended him, his hand shaking violently.

"What is it?" Glimmer mutters under her breath, her chin wobbling and her hands shaking with anxiety. Bow shakes his head wordlessly, trying again to open the door and cringing when it bounces again.

"There is something blocking the door," he says, clenching his teeth.

Bow takes a deep breath and clicks his tongue against his teeth, taking once swift and strong impulse and pushing again until the door finally gives in with a dry hit, something thudding on the other side and rolling away. The door falls open very quickly but Glimmer and Bow sprint back, with an horrified gasp.

There is a body on the other side of the door, face down and unmoving. The police uniform gives it away and the blonde hair is soaked in red, gushes of blood still bursting out of the head, mortally wounded and bleeding on the floor of this perfectly white and perfectly beautiful house.

Glimmer presses both of her hands against her mouth, pushing back the rush of bile and puke gathering in the back of her mouth. She cannot move more than an inch, swinging softly on her feet and wrenching back violently.

“Shit,” she whispers, her voice sore and trembling. “It's the officer that took Adora”

Bow takes a sharp breath, gathering himself from bravery as he kneels down, very softly rolling the officer on her side, seeking to place her in the recovery position. She might be just wounded and still alive, so it matters to try. But when he finally manages to place her over her arm he yelps back, barely containing a yelp.

There is a perfectly circled hole right in the middle of the officer´s forehead, so perfectly placed that it looks almost surgical. It didn´t even leave a mess behind, unlike Lashor´s head off Prime´s hand. There is no brain matter and not even too much blood on the marble floor below its body. Bow presses his mouth into a tight line, placing the officer on her back and closing her hooded eyes.

“Bow?” Glimmer asks slowly behind him, unable to see the officer´s head as Bow shelters it.

Bow shakes his head, pulling his jacket off and placing it almost too gently over the woman's face.“She is dead”

“Shit.” Glimmer mourns, kicking on the floor. “Fucking hell”

She is still lingering on the porch but she shakes herself awake and steps inside, circling Bow and almost falling to the ground when his arms shoot suddenly towards her, stopping her in her tracks before she can give a single step forward.

“Look,” he whispers, pointing at the corridor right in front of them, the one that leads to the golden white stairs and the spotless soulless kitchen.

There are red marks over the floor, long and fresh, sticky, foot prints made in blood that lead calmly up the stairs. One after the other, the soles are well marked, the pad of the feet slightly blurred where the weight was placed too harshly. Feet soaked in blood making their way up the careful carved steps and towards

the higher levels, a dark path with dark intentions. More blood, always so much more blood.

“It's barefoot,” Bow whispers, standing up and turning towards Glimmer´s horrified face. He rests his warm hands over her shivering shoulders, shaking her softly to make her look at him again. His face is slightly desperate, biting down on chapped lips until they bleed, and he is shaking, adrenaline coursing through his veins. “We need to find Adora and Catra and get out of here. Now”

A heavy thud comes from the floor right above them and then the slam of a door. Heavy vices that neither Glimmer nor Bow can quite place yet, but they can tell they are angry, furious even, yelling loud words and followed by another heavy hit. Then there is the scream.

“Ahhh!” it echoes across the entire house, painful and raw, terrifying, born from fear alone. “AHHHH!”

Terror clogs Glimmer´s throat, her vocal cords closing and her entire body shivering. She recognizes that voice, of course she does. She would recognize it anywhere, Glimmer had lived and breathed that voice since the very first time its owner walked inside the halls of highschool, sad and beautiful.

“It´s Adora,” Glimmer exhales, her pupils shrinking inside her irises. She rushes forwards, reaching the end of the stairs without even caring when her boots mess up the footprints on the floor. “Adora!”

Another scream meets her, this one even more tired and just as scared. It sounds like it hurts. She jumps into the steps without thinking twice and runs up the stairs at full speed, slipping with the blood twice until she reaches the wide expanse of the second floor and its ivory white carpet.

It is deadly quiet now, almost too much, the screams and yelling drowned out suddenly, making the whole house drown into the

worst kind of silence. Glimmer bites into her tongue and holds her breath, ready to scream Adora´s name again.

Bow rushes next to her and covers her mouth with his palm quickly, pointing towards the long corridor with his chin. There are steps coming towards them, heavy, slugged even, walking down from the second set of stairs just past the end of the corridor, approaching their way.

"Shh," Bow rushes forward too, wrapping his hand "Don´t scream, Glimm."

He looks around them quickly, glancing at the doors of empty bedrooms around them. There is a very small space that looks like a broom closet halfway open.

"Run that way, come on. Come on!" Bow seizes the opportunity immediately, bringing Glimmer alongside with him and closing the door tightly behind them.

Bow snuggles back on the closet, the handle of brooms and mops digging on his back. The sharp dry branches of a shorter kind of broom dig painfully on the side of Glimmer´s body, scratching her lightly above her clothes. They almost feel like brambles against her skin.

There is a very fine ray of light that can be seen below the heavy door, white and artificial with the lights of the corridor. From this angle, Bow and Glimmer can see the way the fine light gets cut when a person walks right in front of the door. The steps don´t stop or wave as it passes right past the closet, not even stopping to take a peek or to wander inside. They go and go and go until they lose themselves on the long expanse of the corridor, quiet and gone.

Bow pulls down his palm from Glimmer´s face slowly, trying to calm down his heartbeat. Glimmer exhales too, digging her nails and fingers over Bow´s legs to hold himself steady.

“It left,” she whispers, leaning her face to try and catch a glance of Bow´s among the darkness. “Did you see who it was?”

“No,” Bow shakes his head, taking the branches and pulling them aside from them. Very slowly he kneels towards the slim door and pushes it open, glancing at the now empty corridor. There is nobody there anymore but the print of their step is clear in the red splashes of blood fallen over the expensive carpet.

“They are bleeding,” Bow murmurs, looking at the floor. He untangles himself from Glimmer and steps outside first, making sure the corridor is actually empty before helping Glimmer step out too. “Come on, let´s go the other way”

“Alright,” Glimmer agrees in a whisper, walking further inside the house out of Bow´s hand.

They carefully open each one of the doors and glance inside, meeting only white and empty rooms with the First One symbol in all the windows and nothing else. Each one, one after the other the same, mirrors of each other. There are no traces that people actually lived and breathed here, not even when they reach the biggest one, the one that belongs to Light Hope and once was shared by Mara. There is only a firm bed with silk silver sheets, windows and First One´s paraphernalia everywhere.

Once they make sure the rooms are completely empty they keep walking forward, following the steps of the second pair of steps and into the last level of the house. The one that leads to Adora´s bedroom, the library and another empty room.

Adora´s door is closer and Glimmer and Bow both reach them quickly, stopping frozen on their tracks when they take sight of the red mess scattered all around the corridor. From the inside of Adora´s room and all the way across the threshold and the corridor. Long and blurred, the tell of a body dragged across the expensive floors and a handprint over the white wood of the door.

“There is blood,” Glimmer gasps, horrified, holding herself from Bow´s arm. “There is blood. Bow–”

“Don´t– don´t panic,” he stutters, breathing hard. “Don´t panic”

He pushes Adora´s door room open with a swing, blinking quickly at the light entering through the open windows. The room is empty, Adora´s bed perfectly tended and the space quiet. And it is red, the bed, the floor, the clothes, they are red. The floor is clustered with things from the bookshelves and clothes of the closet. As if someone had been raking the place right before blood splattered everywhere around.

Under the warm rays of the sun  the blood is not even sticky at all, dry but still red. Quiet like a tomb with the testimony of violence. Glimmer´s tears stick to her eyelashes, itching on her skin when they fall down against her chin and chest. She bursts inside, slipping from Bow´s hold, searching among blood and scattered clothes and all the small pieces of Adora´s bright and living room in search for her without finding her.

“Adora,” she calls, voice trembling. “Adora, please. Let´s go.” Nothing answers her but silence, quiet and frightening. “Adora”

Another heavy sound slams on the corridor past the room, so hard that it makes the entire house shake on its foundations. Bow rushes outside, looking towards the corridor with wide eyes, panting heavily. Glimmer gasps too, holding herself to her shirt and gasping with fear.

“What was that?”

“I don´t know,” Bow looks behind him, managing to find an old baseball bat among Adora´s sports stuff in the closet. He holds it a sword between his palms, raising it above his head and staring at the corridor with his eyebrows furrowed. “I´ll go”

“Wait, no–”

“Glimmer, go the other way. Search for Catra too, please,” he begs, looking at her with bloodshot, frantic eyes. “And if you find any of them, get them out, don´t wait off for me”

“Bow,” Glimmer rushes to her feet, tripping with the blood and falling into her knees heavily. Bow flinches but he doesn´t move from his place, still staring between her and the corridor as another hit comes. “Bow, please, stay.”

Bow looks at her for a long, long second, considering, quiet, but in the end he shakes his head firmly and walks into the corridor, rushing across the white halls as he follows the sounds. Glimmer rushes to follow him but by the time she walks outside of the bedroom he is already gone, lost among more empty rooms and doors and windows of stained glass.

Glimmer bites into her lip so hard that she bleeds herself, fighting her own terror and fear, fighting the horror gathering in her throat at the sight of the blood and the uneasy exhaustion in her bones. She gathers herself of bravery and gives a single step forward, deciding to follow Bow and her friends to the end of the world if needed. She won´t stay hovering in the middle of the corridor like her mother did once.

A hand shoots towards her, wrapping around her bicep and pulling backwards harshly, making Glimmer scream.

“Ah!” She turns around, sharply and blindly fighting her way out of the hold without much success. The owner of the hand holding her shakes her violently and Glimmer gasps, finally staring back at the person´s frantic face next to her. “Detective”

Huntara looks out of breath and tired and she is bleeding. The side of her shirt is soaked with blood, dripping where a knife had been stabbed and then dragged back against her body with perfect aim. She is already bleeding out, gushes of crimson blood soaking on her pants and shoes but she manages to hold herself up by will alone,

“Out,” she grunts, dragging Glimmer backwards with her with so much strength that it hurts. “We need to get out of here. Now”

“But–” Glimmer hesitates, her voice failing her.

She is unable to fight against Huntara´s strength and height, following her around when she handles her back down the stairs and into the second floor, following the same bloody path Huntara had left on the carpet trying to find her way out of the humongous house.

Glimmer grunts and gasps, tripping several times with the steps, the carpet and her own feet, sneakers stained in blood, before she finally manages to dig her ankles over the floor and make the both stop, almost tethering harshly on the floor.

“Stop, stop. My friends are there. Adora, Catra–”

“She is dead,” Huntara snaps, her eyes wide. This is the first time Glimmer has seen her like this. This is the first time she catches the real stare on her lilac eyes. Wide, pupils as pinpoint, bloodshot and skin bloody. She looks ashy in a way and pale on the other, the veins on her neck straining until they pulse. Wild and overcome. Afraid. Huntara is afraid. “She is dead, Bright, let's get out of here, now”

The words fall like a cold cascade across Glimmer´s spine, making her gasp, making her flinch and curl into herself with pain. She shakes her head, blinking when the start of the first pain of stairs comes into view.

“No,” she whispers, gulping around the knot clogging her breath, repeating herself. “No, my boyfriend. Bow. He is here, he went there looking for them”

Huntara stops cold, cursing loudly under her breath as she looks back, staring at the corridors they had just rushed from with wide eyes. She is weighing her decisions, she is considering it. If running away and save her own skin or do the job she swore to fulfill and come back for another innocent about to fall.

“Shit, fine,” Huntara finally spats, pushing Glimmer towards the stairs and stepping back towards the corridor. “Leave, right now. Get reinforcements here. More police, the firefighters I don´t give a fuck but get them now.”

“Detective, who is dead?” Glimmer cuts her off, grabbing her arms with desperate hold.” “Who is dead. Which, which one of them is dead?”

“Leave,  Huntara repeats, stronger and angrier, running across the corridor without looking back at her. “Leave!”

Glimmer is left at the end of the corridor and alone again. She stares at the floor in the floor and the white in the halls and the church like windows and gulps back bile, her heart speeding up so fast that it is a miracle that it doesn´t burst out of her chest with anxiety.

She never knew Light Hope, not as well as her own mother did and never like Adora did after Hope took her in. But this whole time, not even during the massacre and the violence of the past days, Glimmer ever thought her possible of something like this. Of so much pain.

If Adora is dead then– then nothing else matters anymore. Glimmer would have lost her forever and everything they fought so hard for the last days would be for nothing. If Catra was dead then Adora would need Glimmer, more than ever she would need her; to survive, to keep living, to get over heartbreak and get out of this alive. She would need Glimmer and Bow would need her too. They would be together, the three of them and they would get out of this together and alive.

Glimmer cannot step away now.

She rushes back towards the third level of the mansion, rolling her ankle painfully when she climbs the staircase in two and two, skipping over blood and sweat and the phantom smell of death. She lowers her steps near to Adora´s bedroom, picking inside

with her eyebrows furrowed before giving a step forward into the corridor.

A horrid scream that Glimmer does not recognize comes and then the unmistakable bang of a gun going off , the sound blasting across the entire house like a bomb. Glimmer bites back a scream, shivering violently as she hears the clear struggle of bodies moving, fighting each other, pants and grunts and a drowned yell in a room further to her.

And then, the swish of a blade against flesh, over and over again, followed by a body falling to the ground. And then another. Blood spurting from wounds and soaking the floor again.

Glimmer knows someone is dead, the smell of fresh blood filling the corridor says it all. Glimmer knows someone is dead then but she doesn't dare to put a name into the possibilities but, absently, she prays for two people she doesn't want to find dead. And she hates herself but she offers to the gods the other two lives in exchange.

It is a nightmare and for the first time in her entire life, Glimmer doesn´t seem to be able to wake up.

“Bow?” Glimmer whispers, trembling and wrinkling her nose. “Adora?”

She walks with very careful steps, reaching an open door and pushing it softly. This door is dark, painted black and heavy, and when Glimmer pushes it open she finds herself in an office, perfectly ordered and pretty even. There are dozens to hundreds of books in the bookcases nailed to the tall walls and a desk in the very middle, empty besides the open scriptures of the First One´s chants. There is a tall chair behind and a triangle window in the back, of stained glass representing the fall of angels from the sky and the rise of gods to cast their evil out.

It is Light Hope´s office, the place where her soul lays, where she prays, where she begs, where she flogs herself in front of the

window begging for forgiveness after letting herself be distracted by Mara´s colors and vibrant sins.

It´s Light Hope´s office and it is empty except that it isn´t not completely. The floor is soaking in blood and the precious stained crystal is broken in the bottom, slashed and shattered by the bullet that crossed it and crashed against the trees below.

"Oh, god" Glimmer whispers, walking inside the huge office. "Oh no"

It is empty except that there is a body on the floor, bleeding from the side, soaking the crop top in red. A body that doesn´t breath as his chest doesn´t move up and down, up and down, a cadence Glimmer knows and that it is lost now. A body with tight curls and dark skin and pretty black eyes that now lay closed as his skin is blurred with his own blood, resting on his back like a fallen knight during battle.

Bow´s corpse is on the ground, bleeding out, and there is someone kneeling over him, her hands soaked in blood as they press over his skin. A killer, a perpetrator, a murderer, watching him die in silence.

"Ah!" Glimmer screams so hard that her chest hurts, her vocal cords straining themselves, bleeding themselves, hurting her, killing her too from the inside out. Bow is dead  and this animal is still hovering over him like lingering for the smell of his death. "Ahhh!"

Catra snaps her head up, staring back at Glimmer with her bloodshot mismatched eyes. There is blood in her face, splashed in her freckled cheeks and the soft curls of her hair. She is beautiful, even now, even like this, with red staining her butter soft skin and the soft black of her clothes. Even her neck is beautiful, long, pretty, sweet, marked like a swan reached by an arrow, like nightingale wings ripped by red claws. All in her is pretty, all in her is red.

Glimmer´s breath speeds up until she is gasping for air, straining her lungs and choking her with her own spit and horror. She grabs at her chest and wheezes, pressing herself flat against the wall behind her when her brain doesn´t know where to stop screaming and where to start to run.

It´s a beautiful day outside, filled with air and sunlight yet Glimmer has never felt more cold in her entire life, staring at the stained window and Bow´s unmoving body and Catra rising to her feet, her leg shaking a little and her hands calm. She looks so pretty even standing on her shoes over death and Glimmer has never hated her more in her entire life.

"Bow!" Glimmer screams, calling for him to stand up, to go towards her, to be alive, alive, even knowing he has already bled into the ground by trusting hands. "Bow!"

"Sparkles," Catra says, voice sweet, still somehow saying that stupid nickname to Glimmer even as her raised palms are stained with Bow´s blood.

"No, no!" Glimmer shakes her head, moving across the wall and the bookcase, circling Catra. There is another door next to Catra´s spot. It lays wide open and leads to another portion of the office that Glimmer can´t see yet, swallowing her whole when she steps into it´s shadows. "No!"

"Calm down," Catra says but even for her the words seem foreign, acid on her tongue.

"Fuck! Fuck you!" Glimmer is howlering, closing her hands into fists and digging her nails inside her palms until they bleed across her fingers.

She is staring at Catra´s face but all that she can feel is hatred, pure and raw hatred. Fury, anger, murderous desire. She wants to sink her nails on her face and tear down, rake them across her cheeks and nose and neck and make her bleed too. Make her cry too. Make her suffer and bleed out too, with her pretty curls and

her bruises and her, for some reason, pleading eyes as she stretches her hand and wraps it softly across Glimmer forearm, trying to pull her gently towards her.

“Glimmer, calm down”

“Do not fucking touch me!” Glimmer screams, slapping Catra´s hands away so hard that her knuckles color red immediately. “Stay away!”

They are both in the second room now, a wide space with mirrors on one side and stained windows on the other. Tall white ceilings and First One´s symbols on the walls. The expensive room built as an indoor chapel that reeks like death and blood and that makes Glimmer gurgle with her spit the second she steps inside.

She doesn´t even get to take it all in, the third tiny room that leads to a confessionary or the wooden floors because she stumbles with something on the ground and falls back painfully on her back, the side of her head crashing with the floor.

Glimmer gasps, leaning on her hands to absorb the fall but she slips instead, something wet and slick gathering in her fingers and soaking on the sleeves on her shirt, Glimmer snaps her head to the side, meeting Huntara´s clouded eyes and gurgling throat, bleeding profusely from the stab wound on her chest, pace right against the middle of her heart.

Glimmer doesn't even yell this time, panting as she wrenches her entire body away from the blood, cringing when Huntara gasps around an agonizing breath, filling her nostrils and mouth and dripping down her face in rivulets of red. She is still alive but barely, holding herself to the strands of life by a miracle alone.

Glimmer drags herself back, grasping in whatever she can to get as far as possible from the bleeding body. He palms finds something slim, stranger shaped and very cold, sticky even her Glimmer runs her blood drenched fingers over it, the pads

managing to understand she is feeling the edge of a shoe before her head does.

Glimmer turns her head around very slowly, staring with wide, frantic eyes at the rotting corpse behind her. Right below the stained windows, right below the symbols, showered by purples and lilac and blues and grays and goldens. Light Hope´s body lays dead too, drowning in decay, swirled by flies that feast on her brain and her open skull where the hand ax has opened her head from side to side, dripping sticky blood on the floor below her body.

She is dead, covered in wounds like whip slashes and punctures like rose thorns. Her always perfect clothes stained, her expensive shoes loose and crooked. Her skull short hair soaked in red. There is still an expression of surprise on her face, forever painted on her clouded eyes and in the crook of her mouth. The more Glimmer sees her, the more it is horrifying. The more the flies go inside her nostrils and outside her blackened mouth, eating their way across sinuses and palate.

"Oh goddess, oh god!" Glimmer wants to scream but she fails too, unable to breath even above the stench coming from Light Hope ´s decomposing body, flesh falling from her body or maybe completely slashed by sharp knives. Little by little.

Glimmer stands up in a rush. barely managing to hold herself in unsteady feet, wobbling from side to side. There is so much dead and pollution around her that she cannot think, scream or talk.

"Glimmer, please listen to me," Catra tries again, cleaning her hands as best as possible with the fabric of her joggers. She is not even looking at the blood and rot around them, too focused on Glimmer, too used to the horror.

Glimmer points her finger at her, her eyes so wide and open that they threaten to fall from their sockets. She gasps, fighting for her breath and finding her voice among horror, already looking

everywhere for something that might help her get out of here alive.

“You murderer!” Glimmer exclaims, spitting at Catra´s feet. It falls in a gush of saliva over Catra´s white and red sneakers and for a second Glimmer absently thinks that she wasn´t wearing those before. “I knew it! I knew it!”

“Don´t scream, please don´t scream.”

Rushed steps reach their way, hurrying and tripping twice, clumsy even. They sound like the kind of steps of someone that has just woken up or that it´s intoxicated. Or maybe even like the steps of someone that has just awoken after passing out, careful but unsure. Coming from the confessionary on the side.

Adora walks out of the tiny room, her short hair matted in red where she was reached by a hit and it blew the stitches on the side, bleeding all over again. She looks terrible, her tank top covered in blood and her hands shaking like crazy and red too, from her wrists to her elbows and falling down in drops towards her soles. She is not even wearing shoes.

And still, she is beautiful. Somehow Glimmer sees her and she sees her absolutely beautiful, broad shoulders, slender wrists and pretty eyes. Bruised and shaken up but completely beautiful as she stands on wobbly feet near the altar.

She is pale as she looks at the scene in front of her, blue eyes like crystals running through each single body and then towards the front, skipping Glimmer completely and digging in Catra´s hazel and blue eyes, holding their gazes wordlessly.

“Glimmer”

“Adora!” Glimmer exclaims, running to her side. She wraps her hands around Adora´s bicep and holds her close, pressing her flush against her side and dragging her several steps behind, towards the quiet altar where ambers are still burning up. “You are bleeding!”

“I got hit,” Adora exhales, glancing at her sideways but still looking at Catra´s face, weighing her in. “Cat–”

“Adora, stay back!” Glimmer screams, pointing at Catra with a shaking finger. Catra doesn´t even seem to flinch under the accusatory hand, breathing very slowly. “Stay away from her! She is the killer! She was helping Prime. Prime was her fucking uncle!”

Adora blinks, finally dragging her blue eyes from Catra to Glimmer. She has such bright eyes, so blue. “Really?”

“She has been lying to you! She– she killed Bow!” Glimmer mourns, choking with a rush of sudden tears.

She wishes she was closer to Catra for a moment, just for the pleasure of slapping her across the face and dragging her by the hair until she faces Adora and kneels at her feet. Until she begs for forgiveness for what she had done to all of them. So Glimmer can see the exact moment Adora stops loving her.

“She killed Bow! She killed Bow!”

“Glimmer, please don´t–” Catra whispers but her voice is flattering, immensely heavy.

“Shut up!” Glimmer stomps on the ground, looking all around her to look for a weapon. There is no knife in Huntara´s dying chest so maybe, just maybe it is around here, on the floor. Maybe it is still grasped on Catra´s freckled hold. “You fucking bitch! I'm going to make you pay!”

Glimmer pulls from her own hair, torn apart between holding Adora´s entire tall and shivering body between her arms and leaning away to pull the ax from Light Hope´s brain and throw it at Catra´s chest.

“I´m going to kill you, I´m going to fucking kill you, Catra!”

"It's not her," Adora is saying. Her voice has changed, strained, frightened maybe, full of some kind of tender love, full of some

kind of layered bittersweetness.

Her hand is shaking violently when she rests it across Glimmer´s chest and over her shoulder. Her other arm brushed against Glimmer´s upper arm, moving very softly, almost gently. It's comforting, in a way, Adora´s warmth against Glimmer´s coldness. It feels good, like her lips under the rain.

"It's not her, Glimmer"

"Of course it is her! Why do you keep saying that she's not–?!”

It happens very quickly, very swiftly. It´s a blessing, almost, a small mercy. A testament of their precarious yet long friendship. Glimmer almost doesn't even feel it at first but when she does it is warm. Too warm. Like lava, like a burn, scorching hot as it travels from Glimmer´s ribcage to her shoulder and collarbones, reaching her neck as a skeleton hand. Wrapping around the base of her skull and making everything numb and cold.

Something is dripping down her side, past her hip and soaking the outside of her thigh, making her clothes stick to her limbs where the warm liquid keeps dripping and dripping one by one. She doesn´t even realize it is coming out of her own body until she looks down, catching sight of the handle of the hunting knife deeply embedded past her skin and muscles. It guts right between the curve of the ribs  with frightening precision, cutting its way past pleura and scratching the surface of arteries and veins.

Glimmer´s words stop in her throat, her voice and breath leaving her completely. She blinks at the knife handle and at the golden hand that holds it very slowly, taking a shivering breath that tastes like a mouthful of salt.

"Oh"

"I'm very sorry Glimmer," Adora whispers next to her head, her lips brushing against Glimmer´s temple when she leans down ever so slightly.  "But I did tell you to stay in the apartment"

Adora pushes her back until Glimmer stumbles with Light Hope´s cold and dead feet and falls down on the floor too, the knife slipping out of her ribcage and chest like melting metal. It hurts, it hurts a lot. Now that the knife is out, everything Glimmer can feel from the roots of her hair to the tip of her toes, is hot, agonizing pain.

She wheezes, suddenly out of breath, her lungs constricting inside her ribcage and strangulating her heart, an aching push and pull of air as she starts to feel the temperature of her body skyrocket and then fall down completely like a broken piece of mercury, chilling her to the bone.

She is cold, she is so cold, feeling her own blood soaking on her purple and pink clothes and sticking to her skin, barely able to take a pained and betrayed breath when she looks up and towards the scene in front of her. Her fingers slip with her own red blood, pooling on the rich wood below her.

Adora hums, narrowing her eyes for a second and sparing her just a swift look before turning around, walking in the opposite direction of Glimmer´s bleeding body. Adora brings her hands in front of her and stretches them, moaning softly around the nice stretch that pulls from her stitches and bruises. The skin of her biceps pulling and swelling with each movement and her back tightening, wide and strong.

Her hair is sticking to her nape with sweat and her eyes are glistening, taking on the bloodshed inside the room with a quiet smile.

There is a change in Adora, something new. No. Something different, something that Glimmer in all her cunning mind and her sharp eyes and her devotion for her, never got to catch up.

Something that looks like an animal, no, a hunter, a predator walking slick and sure across the moss paths and the tall glass of the raining forest beyond the window. The eyes of a panther or the beautiful colors of a snake or the quiet slide of a spider.

There is something in her that it's almost enticing, rotten sweet like a poison calling for you and guiding you to your death. A forbidden fruit in a forbidden tree, A marble statue with the feet smooth by kisses and red blood. Something golden, something black.

Dangerous, her entire demeanor is dangerous, walking with her barefoot and bloodstained soles over the wood floor as she crosses the space between her and Catra, standing in front of her elegant figure with a little wiggle. And Catra is looking a Glimmer with pain and sadness written all over her face, in all of her factions and the strides of her irises, just looking at Glimmer without moving a single inch from her spot.

And for a second, Glimmer panics. She really does panic. For a second she wants to scream to Catra, to get away, to turn and run and get help, to escape from the sharp end of this sharp story.

For a second, Glimmer thinks Adora will tighten her fingers again around the knife handle, bouncing in her palm like a toy and swing it to the other side of Catra´s neck, betraying Catra too, robbing her of her breath too.

For a second too long, Glimmer hopes it will be like that. That she will not be the only one betrayed and mortally wounded. For a second, Glimmer prays that Catra doesn´t get to have Adora in the end, not even like this. So selfish, so fair. Deeply fucked up in all senses but Glimmer is bleeding out in the floor and Bow is dead, her mother is death. It is only fair, isn´t it?

But then again, the one thing Glimmer has never been able to understand is that Catra is Adora´s and Adora is Catra's. They *belong* to each other, like earth and moss belongs to a deer roaming the forest, quietly staring at you as it tries to decipher if you have figured things out.

Catra is Adora´s and Adora does not want to break her or betray her or forsake her. Quite the contrary. Adora would ravage this world raw in exchange of her breath.

Adora´s entire body changes again when her blue, blue eyes meet Catra´s, lightening up like a sun after an eclipse or a flame meeting gasoline. Red and golden like the threads of Destiny that join them.

Loving. So absolutely loving that Glimmer´s stomach gives a jump and a turn and she is left breathless for a much different reason than bleeding to death on the floor.

Adora looks at Catra as if she had found the answers to all her prayers inside of her eyes. As if there was no blood in the space between them, nor tears or pain or death. As if Adora would do it all again, everything exactly the same just to be able to cradle Catra´s face in her palms like she does right now and press their foreheads together. Strung on each other´s web and bittersweet smelling, uncaring of the way Adora´s blood soaked hands draw fingerprints across Catra´s neck.

"Are you alright, my love?" Glimmer hears Adora whisper, right next to the skin of Catra´s cheek.

Catra shivers, bringing her hands up, resting her palms over Adora´s red knuckles and lacing their fingers together, quietly sharing the blood. Her shoulders are trembling a little but her posture is straight, looking at Adora´s red and black rimmed eyes with her own owl-like ones.

"Yes," she whispers, nodding softly. She tilts her head to the side and nuzzles the side of Adora´s face gently, letting Glimmer know everything she needs.

They are together, now and before and forever, they are together.

"Okay," Adora narrows her eyes, sparing a swift look towards the office beyond the door and back to Catra. "What about Bow?"

A strange kind of expression crosses Catra´s colorful eyes, ending in a sad pull of her eyelids and a tiny sigh. She wraps her hand on Adora´s shirt, right above her heart, shaking her head. "Out"

Adora presses her mouth into a fine line, her eyes hardening against a void point of the house chapel. “Okay. I´ll deal with it later”

Adora´s fingers find their way down below, slipping underneath Catra´s soft top and caressing gently swirls over her hip and waist. Her other hand rests right next to the column of her neck, holding them and their eyes together, a gentle embrace and an even more tender caress. Adora´s strong back covers most of Catra´s figure from Glimmer´s sight line, speaking in a sweet whispers inside the faux privacy of their hold into each other.

“Do you want to leave?” Adora asks, honest and kind, allowing Catra of the decision, no matter what it is. If Catra says the word, Adora will do it. She would walk her to the heaven's gates herself if needed.

But Catra just shakes her head, dipping her fingertips strongly over Adora´s bruised collarbones. Her pretty eyes are blazing like fires in her face, looking at Adora with a kind of intensity that would bring any god's devotee to their knees.

“No.” Catra says, clenching her teeth strongly. “No matter what, I'm staying with you from now on.”

Adora´s blazing blue eyes look right back at her with the same kind of intense adoration and the corner of her mouth curls into a sweet smile. She rests the pads of her fingers against the angle of her jaw and brings her into an even sweeter kiss. Open mouthed and tender, sweet like cherries and sour like the tangerines they used to share in the forest outside of the Chapel´s gardens.

Catra is left breathless by it, by the intensity of Adora´s mouth and the strength of her hold against her body, an unspoken vow crossing them from heart to heart as every single time they share the breath of their throats and the warmth of their mouths. Right here, above blood in the floor and stained crystals and dead and rot. Lovers pulled apart finding each other after bloodshed.

Adora leans back and peppers the side of Catra´s jaw and cheek in tiny kisses, whispering into her ear very gently to stay where she is before detangling herself from Catra´s body, turning back towards Glimmer´s bleeding body but not before pressing another longing kiss above Catra´s red mouth.

Glimmer is looking at them with such an open expression that it is an open book, free to read. From her surprise to her pain to her disgust even, clear like light in the way her eyes and pale cheek scream betrayal. Betrayal, *betrayal.* In all the ways possible, a betrayal that travels so deep that is unbearable.

And still, still, Glimmer is left dizzy. Turn around and confused, things slipping out of her feet and crashing her to the ground with confusion. Her entire world crumbling down and shattering into pieces.

"I– I don't understand," Glimmer says finally, meeting Adora´s blue eyes from over the death. Adora blinks at her, once, her elegant eyebrows twitching with a confusion so sincere that it is almost offensive.

“You don't?” Adora stares at Glimmer´s eyes for a few seconds, studying her and her blood from the inside out. Then Adora´s pretty face falls, like snow falling from a cherry tree, her face filling with comprehension and her nostrils flaring with frustration, annoyance even, clicking her red tongue against her crooked teeth. “Ah, you really don't.”

And the way she says it is almost like a scowl, disappointed. She shakes her head softly and drops her shoulders forward a little bit as she thinks, throwing her head back to stare at the black painted ceiling. Even there, there is a splash of old blood.

“I really thought you would have figured it out by now, Glimmer,” Adora says and her voice is serious but it is also tinted with a slight shadow of mirth, like a child that has done mischief and now is excited to explain the why and the how. “I guess I thought you were smarter than you really are.”

Next to Adora´s bare feet, Huntara gurgles in her blood. Her busted and purple bruised nails dig on the wood of the floor, staring at the ceiling above her and then at the sides. Her eyes go wide, all the white sclera tinting into red immediately, her lips blue, a giveaway of oxygen not running across her veins and heart failure on her chest.

She rolls on her side with all the strength she has left, starting to crawl on her palms and knees until her nails all break and the floor starts to paint with a blood trail behind her.

For a moment it looks like she is going to go to Adora, who is staring at her agonizing body with the most boring kind of expression in her pretty eyes. But instead, Huntara starts to make her way slowly but surely towards Catra, her slick palms searching for her ankles to hold onto.

"Ca- Capellan," Huntara wheezing, out of breath and out of blood. "Capellan."

Adora scrunches next to her, cutting Huntara´s path between her bloody body and Catra´s. Adora meets Huntara´s eyes and, very slowly, shakes her head, stretching her arms in front of her almost as if she were to embrace Huntara´s face.

Adora wraps her fingers tightly at either side of Huntara´s temples, her palms firmly planted against the angle of her strong jaw and she smiles, sweetly, big until it wrinkles the corners of her red eyes. She looks almost pretty like this, like a Chesire cat, like a tender executioner, like a merciful saint. The last face you see before dying is almost like the face of a god.

"Please, be quiet," Adora says to Huntara at the same time she snaps her hands strongly to the side, breaking Huntara´s column cleanly in two, The crack of the bones is so sudden and surprising that Glimmer gasps and chokes.

Huntara´s body goes limp immediately, tall and strong, none of it matters when she crumbles back into the floor like a puppet with

its strings broken when Adora lets go of her. Adora looks at her in silence for a few minutes, admiring the fruits of her work with a quiet satisfaction as she stands up again, cleaning her palms over the fabric of her pants.

It is so easy for her and it is so easy for Glimmer to realize this is not her first time at all.

Catra cringes too at the sound, wrinkling her nose at the sound of the dead body falling down. But besides it, she looks immutable too, staring at Huntara´s death eyes and snapping her eyes away immediately after with a very slow exhale, letting her arms fall back on her sides.

Glimmer´s eyes are digging themselves on Adora´s face, taking in the way she looks giddy, happy even, endorphins and adrenaline running across her red blood and swinging softly on her toes. In a way she looks almost drunk, soft and excited and tilting from side to side very very gently, following the string of a song that only she can hear inside her head.

Glimmer sputters, blood and saliva crashing on the floor by her knees. She presses her back tightly against the wall and clenches her red soaked teeth, sucking on her pain and her anger. And her sadness.

"Why?" Glimmer asks, and even dying because she knows she is dying, she is proud of the way she says it. Firm, without flinching or waving or doubting. Just a single question for so much despair.

Adora´s blonde eyelashes flutter a little when she narrows her eyes, running the flat of her tongue over her own sharp white teeth. She smiles at Glimmer, still swinging but so much interested now in her.

“Oh, you want the whole villain monologue?” Adora asks, biting softly on her bottom lip. She shrugs, nodding softly. “Okay, I´ll give it to you. I know you like horror movies”

Adora leans down and grabs the handle of the bloodied knife that she had thrown into the ground when she had approached Catra, refusing to even get near her with the deadly blade. Now, though, she wields it easily on her fingers, running her thumb over the shallow side as she runs her eyes from side to side of the room.

“Where should we start?” Adora´s voice is low, the lowest Glimmer has even heard it. Low and slick like melted chocolate, gathering on her molars and sticking to her tongue.

Glimmer is trembling from head to toe, accidentally looking from Adora´s expecting face to Light Hope´s broken shoe next to her, horrified still by the vision of her rotten skin. Adora follows her eyes and sighs, her outh frowning into a small thoughtful pout.

“Yeah, I guess we should start there,” Adora agrees.

She points the end of the knife towards Light Hope´s corpse, dangling the sharp end right above her broken skull. Unlike Glimmer, her eyes are not horrified and she is not cringing with the terror of the sight. She looks as Light Hope as if she was nothing more than a broken piece of wax on the floor, considering her with lighthearted eyes.

"You see, Light Hope, she was a bitch," Adora starts saying, grinning down at Glimmer. “Do you really think I didn't know what she was planning to do with me? That I didn't know the arrangements she had with Prime for my future? I've known since I was fifteen, Glimmer. She *told* me.”

Glimmer´s eyes go wide as sauce plates, her breath hitching in her throat. She is hurting so much, she doesn´t know how much she can hold on. “But, then why–?”

“What? Why did I pretend I didn't know?” Adora snaps her eyes from Glimmer´s place face to Light Hope´s dead one, considering it. Her entire face falls again, eyes hardening like glacier and cheeks rosy, her mouth pressing into an expression of so much contained hatred and anger that it stumbles Glimmer back a little.

“Adora Montenegro, the survivor. The last one of her family, and what a respectable family it was.” Adora chants and her words doesn´t seem like her own. They sound as if she was reciting them, repeating them to the air after they were told to her over and over and over again until they got seared in her brain.

Adora hooks her fingers over the straps of her own shirt and pulls them down. the stained white fabric wrinkling over her chest. She pushes it down and down until it rolls on her waist and broad hips, leaving her on her white sports top only. Like this, the butter soft skin of her belly and back and completely exposed to the air.

“Is she an angel? Is she blessed?” Adora keeps saying, spitting every single title like a curse that burns her tongue. “Is she a miracle? A promise? A Saint?”

Glimmer can only see Adora´s front, but behind her Catra inhales sharply, staring at some point of Adora´s back that only she can see. Adora places her hands at the sides of her head, twisting her fingers in the mock of horns. Or antlers, all knife blade and red stained palms.

“A demon maybe?” Adora says, chuckling without joy.

She drops her arms back down still holding the knife dangerously close to her own face and skin. But she does it easily, quickly, in a way that says that she has held a knife like this a thousand times befores. In the forests maybe, in the middle of her room even, dreaming to dig it again and again in the flesh of someone she was hunting down.

Adora tilts her head at Glimmer, mad grin falling into something so much more threatening, extinguishing any kind of laughter or joy from inside her chest. Very slowly and very deliberately she rests her palms over the skin of her belly and ribs, knife and all, guiding Glimmer´s lilac eyes.

For a moment Glimmer is confused but then she sees them, white lines, pink lines, faded lines of faded scars that cross her skin,

jarred and uneven. Then Adora turns around, to the side showing Glimmer completely the truth of her body like only Catra had seen before. The sight alone makes Glimmer whimper.

Right on the base of Adora´s waist, crossing from side to side like done with a cruel whip and an even crueler hand, are wounds, so much more wounds, inflicted on her body and flesh until she bled, until they scarred, until there was nothing but raw skin. Paths like lightning accompanying the scars from the car accident and the scars of Prime, old and new and everything in between. Testimonies of a quiet torture and a quiet pain long ago kept into secret.

Catra knows these scars like her own, like the palms of Adora´s hands. She has seen them in the aftermath, she has tended to them and stitched them together even. She has wrapped them in soft bandages. She has run her fingers over the jarred skin. She has rest her slick ankles when Adora is bedding her because she knows Adora needs it, the feeling of Catra´s skin damp by their love making over the show of cruelty; because she knows Adora needs to cover them with something born out of love and not out of fanaticism.

Catra knows them, and even mourning because of their existence, she loves them because in a way or another they are now Adora ´s. Adora hates them, Catra loves them but Catra has always loved all the parts of her that Adora hates the most. Including the ones coated in blood.

“Do you think I'm a miracle, Glimmer?” Adora asks, her chest heavy with panting, looking at Glimmer from above the curve of her scarred shoulder, Who would've known she hid so many scars underneath her white clothes. Glimmer takes a huttering breath and looks down making Adora hiss. “Look at me. Look at them”

Adora turns around in her ankles again, slipping inside her shirt once more. She stares at Light Hope´s broken and dead body and remembers every single second she whipped Adora inside this

very same room. And she remembers every single second of the morning Adora tore apart her skull.

"Light Hope always said that to fulfill my destiny I should repent of my sins. The sin of living that day, the sin of falling in love. That, if I really wanted to become a First One in my family´s name, then I needed to be cleansed. Every day. As if my family really would've wanted that, as if my mother would´be allowed it."

Adora runs her nails across her arms, scratching her skin raw. Unlike Weaver with Catra, Light Hope was always careful of not hitting her in a place everyone else would notice.

"Let me tell you, Glimmer, bramble brooms itch, a lot. And if you don't tend to the wounds properly, they scar. Did you know that?"

Adora approaches the corpse with soft steps, her soles barely audible over the sound of the heavy rain pouring outside, She places her feet firmly on the side of the body and pushes to the side, sending it falling over the floor. The flesh makes a horrible squelching sound when it connects with the wood, post mortem liquid slipping from the open mouth and feasting the flies.

"Light Hope did so much fucking shit. She was the reason Mara left and never came back. I didn't understand it for a long time, but I see now. She told Mara about what she wanted to do by sending me with the First Ones. And Mara said no. The last member of *my* family, the person she was supposed to love unconditionally, went to her death when Light Hope made a deal with Prime, when Light Hope sold me out for a higher position in the First One´s eyes."

Adora runs her fingers over the handle of the ax, looking at the body with hooded eyes. Her voice is angry, terribly sore, full of anger, but her demeanor is relaxed, open even, staring at death without regret and without flinching.

“She has been messing with my life like puppet strings. She hid my college acceptance on the Horde just so I would stay in the First Ones Academy. And she put her fucking lawyer nail into Catra’s register about her mother´s death so the Academy wouldn't accept when she sent her application. Even when she just enrolled to be with me, even when she is so much smarter than me.”

Glimmer can see Catra, a few feet behind Adora, holding herself to the door frame. Her eyes are so much more broken that Adora ´s, pulled down by sadness, the corners of her mouth turn down sorrowfully. She holds herself proud and strong for Adora but she still leans towards the wall, looking at Adora´s beautiful and dear face and only at her. The only wish inside her heart.

“I wasn´t planning on killing her so soon. She was supposed to make it until after Prime's death to cover for everything else, that was the plan. But luck has never been on my side and she drove me fucking crazy in the end.” Adora says through clenching teeth, the veins in her neck and jaw popping with the strain. “I can handle her whipping me, beating me, making me kneel on her fucking altar and pray but she threatened Catra to jail her if she didn't leave me. She wanted to ship her off in a place where she would only be tortured and hurt."

Adora glances at Glimmer out of the corner of her eyes, staring at the soaked place in her friend´s pink shirt where her blood is sipping through. "I don't like people threatening Catra, Glimmer."

Adora straightens up again, moving towards Huntara. She leans down just enough to open the front pocket in Huntara´s blood soaked uniform and pulls from it a cigarette and a lighter, placing the reddened end inside her mouth and turning it on swiftly, The gray smoke curls around her cheekbones and nose, making her look like fog.

This is the first time Glimmer sees her smoke, ever, taking long breaths of the long cigarette and blowing the smoke through puffs

from her mouth and nose. It seems like a known habit, born out of dark times.

"Huntara and Lashor for their part? You would never meet detectives more corrupt than them," Adora says, exhaling a mouthful of smoke. "Hordak paid them both a lot of money to hide his crimes. The foul construction of Thaymor bridge that ended up taking the life of Catra´s father. Robbery, maimed elections. Murder."

Adora says the last word with a heavy weight, rolling the vowels on her sharp canine and phishing them out through the smoke.

"Huntara and Lashor knew it all for a long time and they did nothing, filling their pockets and making blind eyes. And Lashor was always Prime´s puppet in return, to fuck or to fuck with others I don´t care but always using him to cover the shit." Adora spits at Huntara´s face. "Both of them tried to take Catra to jail after Weaver tried to kill her. After her *mother* tried to murder her, they still obeyed Prime´s orders and tried to maim her, tried to stain her. How the fuck did they think they were?"

Adora looks down at Huntara´s dead body, smoking out of her cigarettes and with her blood still in her hands. They leave a small path of red on her chin every time she takes the cigarette out of her mouth to speak.

"Even now, when Huntara realized the killer was not Light Hope but me, she tried to get out of it very quickly. She offered me a deal for my secrets so she could keep her life. Can you imagine? Can you imagine this adult woman begging on her knees to save her life in exchange for a few coins? She deserved to go too."

Adora gives a few deep smokes to the cigar and hums around the sour taste, dropping it back to the floor next to Huntara´s face and extinguishing it with the bare sole of her foot. She squats in front of Glimmer shivering form, lacing her fingers between her bent knees. Glimmer looks at her in silence, pressing herself as far as possible against the wall and gapping slightly. There is

something inside Adora´s blue and red eyes that makes her afraid, she is afraid of her.

“Don't you see, Glimmer? All of this, the violence, the horror, it was all because of me.” Adora says sweetly, grinning lopsided, chewing the words in her teeth. “I *planned* it all.”

Glimmer gasps, tasting her own blood in her tongue, panting heavily. Like this Adora looks like a predator hovering above a prey, a wounded prey on the ground that stares up at her hunter ´s eyes with some kind of morbid fascination that cannot be hidden.

"But – but Priest Prime– the murders, the newspapers–”

“But, but, but,” Adora mocks her, chuckling. "Oh, did you like the little search I sent you into? I put a lot of thought into it and I'm so proud of how it all came out because if I'm honest it was really tiresome to plan.” Adora boops Glimmer´s nose and she smiles. “It was fun distracting you though.”

Glimmer´s head is moss, it is fog and it is a burning forest, all that she thought she knew crumbling down into pieces all around her. She sees Adora starting to stand up again and grabs her forearm quickly, holding her down with her shivering fingers and her blood soaked palm, so hard Adora´s skin will surely bruise.

“Adora, listen to me,” Glimmer begs, trying to find an explanation for this, an exit. A world where Adora has not betrayed them and everything they believed in. “This is not you, Adora, please”

“You really don´t know me at all, do you?” Adora wonders, looking at Glimmer´s sadness with pity. “Do you know how my family met the Capellans? They were hunting partners. My mom was a really good shooter, so was Catra´s dad. They taught us. Catra hated it, but me? I loved the trill, the chase, the planning. Not the blood or the trophy, but the journey there. And I enjoyed it, Glimmer, I enjoyed hunting down all these fucking people that deserved to live the same hell they made us go through.”

Adora snaps her arm out of Glimmer´s hold, sprinting to her feet. She runs the back of her hand below her nose, blurring away the small traces of a nosebleed, smudging them over her skin. She is trembling too now, from head to toe, born from a place different to Glimmer´s fear but still coated with an old kind of terror, one that happened not so long ago and that poisoned everything.

"You always said I was too smart, Glimmer, and you were right. And there were times when I wanted to rip people to the ground, when I knew that I could bleed them to death and nobody would ever know it was me. It was easy. It is so easy for people to look up towards images that they believe are angels and never see the blood. But I never did it. Do you know why?" Adora points at Catra´s slim frame behind her, tears gathering in the corners of her eyes. "It was because of her. Because of Catra"

Adora sniffs, scratching herself until her skin is red and pulsing. Her eyes are red and wet, completely bloodshot by past and new tears. There is a new kind of desperation in her face and her body, cracking the walls around her heart and spilling through her ribcage, pressing down her lungs and making her heart burn with pain, a kind of ache that Adora has felt for almost an entire year now, unable to ignore, unable to ever fix or forget.

"Mara told me about Serenia," Adora confesses. "I didn´t know when I was younger, my mom always tried to protect me from the past. But Mara, she knew what we know now, she knew Prime had done something to her mother."

Adora´s eyes get lost in memories for a second, puffy and raw, remembering Mara´s tears when she told the story to Adora in the cabin of the woods. When she remembers Mara´s bones hanging from the Chapel's ceiling like a trophy, now placed in bags and waiting for someone to honor them and put them to the ground. Behind Adora, Catra moves out of her stop, taking a very slow step forward, looking at Adora with her eyes filled with tears.

“Maybe it would have been better if Mara had thrown herself to the river after all, like everyone said she had done. Instead of the death she actually met,” her voice shutters. “That's how you know Light Hope never really loved Mara. Monsters like her cannot love.”

Adora´s eyes meet Catra´s, holding her inside her heart tenderly, in the only space inside her love where neither anger or rage or revenge or poison could ever touch her, could never reach her, until they did.

“Priest Prime was an even bigger of a bitch, I´m going to give you that." Adora´s breathing is speeding up, leaving her breathless for a second. “Neither he or Hordak ever cared for Catra, not even because she was their niece, or a child or an adult. Or a human. Hordak was too busy getting drunk and accepting bribes from corrupt construction systems and filling his pockets with money. And Prime was too busy praying to his deity and waiting for me to grow up. He was blind and deaf to Weaver beating Catra purple with her belt on the confessionary to make her obey”

Catra flinches with the mention, her own breath stuck to her lungs. She bears scars too, beyond the ones scattered in her body, like mirrors of Adora´s. She wore them like armor around her body and heart for many years, hoping this way she would survive all the rest. She almost did, until a scar she could never hide or erase opened her throat and her heart. A kind of scar Adora cannot help and of which she cannot ease the pain.

“Though, come to think of it, Prime trying to get my attention was very on point to hide everything else.” Adora murmurs after a second silence, exhaling deeply.

She catches Glimmer´s horrified gasp and she runs her almond eyes towards her, tilting her head.

“Ah yes. Prime didn´t kill everybody. He came out of his little hiding like the rat he was because of Hordak, because of me. He went fucking nuts, Glimmer, and I underestimated him, that´s on

me. But I just couldn´t miss my goal just because he lost his head thinking I was sending the wrong kind of message to him. Just because the imbecile thought I was sending a call of us being the same. But in the end I admit Prime´s little endeavor was useful”

“Endeavor?” Glimmer spats, pressing her hand tighter to her side. She feels weaker and weaker as the seconds go by, voice and anger failing her. “They were our friends, your friends!”

“I know. Look, I didn´t wanted for him to kill anybody. I didn´t mean for this to get this messy.”

Adora extends her arms to the side, from wall to wall of the small chapel. The colors of the stained window fall on her face, painting her beautiful factions in reds and purples, making the crystal blue of her eyes look like liquid.

“Perfuma, Starla, Lashor, they were all Prime's doing.” A sad look crosses her eyes, the only spark of real regret blooming there. “Scorpia too, I would never have touched her. She was nice, Catra cared for her and she cared for Catra.”

Adora looks at Catra now almost completely at her side, holding her golden eyes inside of hers, worshiping her even now.

“I'm never going to forgive myself for causing you more pain.” Adora whispers, choking around a small sob and the words are for Catra and for Catra alone. An apology, a mourn for Catra´s heart.

Catra gasps, the tears falling heavy and free down her cheeks, marking paths on her freckles. She nods and tries to clean them out but her chin is wobbling, betraying her and her sadness. Adora´s eyes fall too, so sad at seeing Catra cry that she looks like a whole other person. Not a murderer or a hunter but a woman in love. A woman that would kill for love.

“I never meant for our friends to get hurt.” Adora confesses, her voice slightly softer, talking to Glimmer but still looking at Catra. Always, always. It has always been Catra. “I knew killing Hordak was going to pull Prime out of his cave, but I never thought he

would do what he did. And I´m sorry, I really am, Glimm. For all of them."

"You don´t," Glimmer spats, digging her fingers into the wall behind her. The smells around her are making her dizzy, twisting her stomach until she is nauseated. She looks up and meets Adora´s cold eyes, baring her red teeth at her pretty face. "You are not sorry at all, Adora."

Adora hums, narrowing her eyes, her sorrowful expression falling immediately. She runs her fingers past her golden and crimson bags, pushing them out of her face.

"I don't know how to explain this to you, Glimmer. But let's try this," She leans towards Glimmer, her face so close to hers that their breaths meet. Glimmer´s cold one and Adora´s boiling hot. Adora´s eyes are steady like stone and cracking like consuming fire. "There is nothing in this world more important to me than Catra. Nothing. No destiny, no goal, no revenge even. And nobody. Not Mara, not Perfuma, not Starla. Not your mother. Not even you, Glimmer"

Adora´s eyes spark with another memory, never really meaning to be cruel but being anyway.

"I told you in the mall, Glimmer. You might kiss me all you want and try to make me love you back, but I will bleed you to death anyway. *She* is my life."

Glimmer swings her arm, the one that is not holding the air inside her collapsing lungs, throwing it towards Adora´s face in the attempt of a hit. But Adora is so much faster than her and leans back immediately, giggling sweetly when the impulse makes Glimmer tether on the floor.

Glimmer curses under her breath, out of air with the movement. Her lungs make a horrid crunching sound every time she moves and she wonders if it can actually be heard out loud or if it exists

only inside her eardrums. She wonders if Adora would care if she hears it but she guesses that she wouldn´t.

“My mom died for your stupid revenge?” Glimmer says with a scowl, falling on her both palms, almost slipping with her own blood. Catra´s feet flinch towards her direction, just the smallest of fractions, but Adora is still standing between them.

“Your mother wasn´t as innocent as she wanted to look like and you know it, Glimmer.” Her lip retracts over her gums into a scowl, closing her hands into tight fists. “She hid a lot of things, Glimmer. She covered a lot of shit. And when she felt guilty about it she decided to be fucking noisy. She paid for the things she didn't do”

Glimmer looks at her full of hatred, the want to scream at her and tear the skin out of her face for speaking like that of her mother overpowering everything else. But the way Adora speaks of Angella also calls the more reasonable part of Glimmer´s mind, blowing out red alarms inside her brain.

She starts to put two and two very slowly, her heart skipping a beat inside her dying chest. She still can see her mother´s broken skull and dead eyes underneath her own closed eyelids, so much like Light Hope next to her.

“Prime–” Glimmer gasps his name, gathering enough strength to lean back against the wall. “He didn't kill her, did he? That night, he went for *you* but he wasn't the one that killed her.”

A sharp flash crosses Adora´s eyes, a flash and a scowl. She looks dangerous right now, even more than before, lightened up by something, a word or an insinuation. Her golden bangs curls over her forehead softly and her teeth are so very white over her red mouth, looking at Glimmer patiently, without speaking, waiting for her to come to her conclusion on her own. After all, Glimmer has always been cunning, like a fox.

"But– if Prime didn´t kill my mom–” Glimmer frowns, remembering that night over and over again inside her head.

She has gone through every single second of it since Prime bursted on Scorpia´s door, thinking about all the ways it could have gone different, about all the ways she, herself, could have done things any other way so that maybe her mother wouldn´t have ended death on the last floor. Even now, looking at Adora´s cold eyes and staring at her red hands, it still doesn´t make complete sense.

“And you– you were there, you were attacked and you were there with me when my mom–” Glimmer coughs, wet and copper tasting, “I don't understand"

Until she does.

Glimmer´s pupils blow up like new moons and then shrink completely, mere pinpoints inside her lilac irises, gifts from her mother. She drags her sight from Adora´s tight and hovering body past her and all the way towards Catra, digging herself inside the blue and the hazel. Catra is trembling from head to toe, her forehead covered in a cold sweat at the words, her hands shaking violently.

"Did you kill my mom?" Glimmer asks, slow, so calm that it even takes her by surprise. She digs her eyes and the teeth of her anger on Catra´s flesh and holds her captive there, demanding from her the truth. "Did you push her from the stairs? Was that you? You killed my mother?"

Catra flinches, air leaving her as if Glimmer had slammed a warhammer against her chest. Which is the least of things Glimmer wants to do right now. She cannot stand up and even if she could she would not have the strength to throw herself against her, not with Adora between them. But oh, how much Glimmer wants to rip her apart right now.

“I–” Catra stutters, trying and failing to say something, to make sense of it. There is nothing in this world she could ever possibly say, not at all. No explanation or excuse at all. And Catra knows

this, the little bitch knows it as Glimmer looks at her with resented eyes. She knows it. “I´m sorry”

Betrayal is a very bland word, pale compared to the chaos being born inside Glimmer´s chest right now. Fury only manages to scratch the surface. Even after everything, even after the conversation they had that night on the motel, even after looking at Glimmer´s face and Huntara´s face and telling a fairytale to hide her crime, Catra still has the nerve to look at Glimmer with her pretty and damp eyes and beg for forgiveness.

She should be dead, Glimmer wishes she was dead right now.

"It wasn't her fault," Adora says immediately because of course, *of course,* putting herself on the line of fire to protect Catra no matter what and no matter who dies.

“Your mom caught wind of what was going on when she started to search the newspapers, just like you did. And I expected her to come to the same conclusions as you, after all, I made sure to place those records very well so she would stumble on them.” Adora explains, sighing. She places her full back against Catra´s figure, even feet away, sheltering from Glimmer´s murderous gaze. “I *wanted* her to find them, to place doubt on Prime´s persona, to signal publicly before tragically meeting an end by *´his´* hand.”

Adora huffs, rolling her eyes, daring to be annoyed even after everything. She walks towards Huntara and searches on the folds of her jacket, extracting the very same data pad Glimmer had stolen from her and that later she had delivered into Huntara´s hands, thinking the worst had happened, thinking they had survived together.

“It was all going so well, but then Angella found a security camera at the mall that caught the face of Sea Hawk´s killer.” Adora frowns, clenching her teeth. She throws the data pat on the floor, crashing the screen violently on the ground in front of Glimmer´s knees. “I misstepped. Your mother saw me stabbing him, she saw

me chasing Mermista. She saw me taking off that stupid mask I wore to distract them and instead of joining the threads against Prime, she did it against me. And she still had the nerve to go confess with Prime about what she had seen, to ask for holy forgiveness and repent for all her sins."

Adora steps on the pad, crushing the crystal and wires under her sole until it finally cracks right in the middle, breaking completely and erasing forever the traces of Adora in it.

"At least she had the stupid idea to save the only copy in them on this godforsaken thing. And you did not have the brains to go through her encrypted files. You had me worried for a second there, Glimmer." Adora spits the words, chuckling and grinning around them. Her eyes are wide and red but her face is still completely calm, completely in control. She still holds the strings here.

"I thought of letting her live, Glimmer. Catra *asked* me to let her live even after your mother never found in herself to love her, not even a little," Adora sniffs, opening and closing her hands. "But your mom and her noisiness ended up finding those missing camera tapes. That night? She didn´t go upstairs to help Catra, she didn´t go to be a hero against a killer. She didn´t even believe Prime was there trying to kill us all. She went there to arrest her, and me, But she didn´t find me there."

Adora grunts, baring her teeth. Catra is crying, very softly, almost without a sound, dark tears staining her face and pooling in her chin.

"Angella threatened to deliver me to the police, to lock me away forever. Catra was just trying to protect me" Adora explains, opening her hands in front of her, almost like offering Glimmer some kind of understanding or peace, almost like begging her to not hate Catra but her.

There is regret in every single of Catra´s tears and every crevice of her cheeks but Glimmer cannot look at it, she cannot believe it,

too drowned by Adora´s ruthless words. She looks at her and she hates, she hates, hates, hates. Hates.

"I should have known." Glimmer murmurs between her blood stained teeth, choking Catra with her words and her eyes. "Mermista was right, you killed your own mother"

Adora slaps her so hard across the face that all Glimmer sees for a second is darkness and sparks, clouding her vision and almost making her throw up. She hears Catra´s pained sob but above it all she hears Adora´s feet shuffling as she grasps Glimmer´s blood soaked shirt and pulls her towards face, hissing the words of her cheeks.

"Do not fucking speak to her like that, Glimmer. Or I´ll have you on your knees begging for her forgiveness before you die," Adora spats, dropping Glimmer right back into the floor, so hard the hit echoes in the chapel and on the levels below.

Adora exhales looking at Catra´s overwhelmingly sad face and back at Glimmer, panting heavily as she fights very hard the need to stab Glimmer across the face.

Adora scrunches down in front of Glimmer instead, resting her forearms over her knees. She blinks at her very slowly, tilting her head to the side, all of her pretty blonde and short hard curling around her nape.

"I should have killed Mermista when I had the chance." Adora whispers, almost to herself, biting down on her own lip so hard that the already bruised and frail skin goes red immediately. "People of this town, they really like to frame Catra as some kind of monster, don´t they? From the old woman at the chapel to your mother, to the reader with their nose pressed on the letter-filled pages of the local newspaper, to you."

Adora stretches her hand, grasping a lock of pink hair between her blood stained fingers. She rubs the soft hair between her

thumb and index, smiling sweetly, so very soft that it throws off Glimmer completely.

“Glimmer, don't you see?” Adora murmurs, looking at Glimmer full of patience, almost as if expecting her to say something specific. When she doesn´t, Adora grunts, dropping Glimmer´s hair and leaning back on her strong ankles, clicking her tongue against her teeth disappointingly. “No you don't, nobody in this stupid town has a brain.”

Adpra closes her eyes and takes a breath, counting inside her head, one by one, memories and the hour when a clock stopped completely, quick and relentless like the rain that falls outside. When she opens her eyes again, her irises are almost completely red, a trick of the light, a mirror of her heart.

“Tell me, just how easy would it be for someone that is bleeding out of her neck to discharge an entire load of bullets on a woman's face?” Adora raises her eyebrows, cooing Glimmer to answer but not waiting a single second more to dwell on it. “Hmm? How easy is it to leave your mother's face a disfigured, gaping hole while you are choking on your own blood? Is that even possible? To aim at her face perfectly and not the mirror behind her when she is tearing your neck open with the shattered glass of your vice?”

All the blood drops off Glimmer´s face, her ribcage squeezing with shock and fear. Her limbs and torso go numb and her buzzing head comes to a complete stop, white sound and the echoes of screams and Adora´s eyes the only thing living there. A confession that only Glimmer gets to hear.

“It was you?” Glimmer asks in a breath but she already knows the answer. Adora´s face splits into two with a huge smile, tapping her knuckle against Glimmer´s forehead excitedly.

“Ding ding ding.” Adora sings, nodding sweetly.

Her grin cracks in the edges, twisting with a rage so deeply rooted that is red and boiling, poisoning her from the inside out. She is losing it, whatever remains of control living inside her head, Adora is losing them.

Glimmer can barely see Catra´s face, locked by Adora´s insane expression, but she can make out of the rapid breathing leaving her chest and the clicking of her teeth when she shivers. She remembers too, she was there, bleeding on the floor.

"I should have killed her sooner, she wouldn't have laid her hands on Catra then." Adora´s eyes unfocus for a second looking at something that is not there anymore before coming back to the present, shimmering when she looks at Glimmer. "You should have seen the look of her face before I blew it out."

Adora drops Glimmer´s face and sprints to her feet, walking in circles around the small room like a wounded animal trapped inside a cage. She approaches the windows and then the mirror in the side, biting on her nails and cuticles and scratching the inside of her wrist until the blood on her skin mingles with her own.

Adora stops in front of the mirrors for a second, looking at herself as if for the first time ever. She stares at herself, her hair, short after defying Prime, after coming first; she looks at her eyes, blue and silver and red; at her hands and skin, bathed in blood after everything, the one that can be seen and the one that cannot.

She looks at herself as if she didn´t recognize the person in front of her and then her eyes snap towards Catra, holding her dear and beautiful inside her, her face brightening at the recognition of her standing in unsure feet behind her, *looking* at Adora with all the tenderness and all the sadness in the world.

"The detectives did a disgusting job to keep the causes of Weaver ´s death a secret." Adora says, still looking at Catra softly before snapping her eyes away. Her face is furious when she turns to look at Glimmer, all the softness melting out of her. "And then, fucking Double Trouble just had to go and spread the rumor that

Catra had done it as some kind of fucked up revenge because she dumped their ass. And everybody, *everybody* on this fucking town believed it."

Adora chokes with her breath, trembling. "Catrina Capellan killed her mom. Because of course, sweet perfect Adora could never, right? But I did, alright? I did."

"Adora," Catra calls for her but Adora is too far gone now, lost inside the same seconds that she has been trapped into over and over again for months now. No matter how much Catra calls her, Adora cannot hear her over the noise.

"They didn´t even care that Weaver had slashed her neck open, they didn´t even care that she had almost bled to death. They didn´t care when Weaver started beating Catra when she was a kid and they didn´t care either when she opened her throat. It was just gossip, just a new story to tell, for this liching town to suck into." Adora slams her closed fist against her chest so hard her bruised ribs crack a little under the pressure, echoing horribly inside the room. "But It was my fault she did it in the first place. It was on me."

"Adora–"

"I was going to go to Weaver's house to pick her up." Adora is talking to Glimmer but she is not really looking at her, her eyes somewhere else, her voice completely splintered. "I was going to help her pack and bring her with me, we were going to spend New Year together, be together."

"But instead we fought, I fought because I was going to accept Light Hope´s stupid plan of going to the First Ones Academy, because once again I let her manipulate me. The perfect puppet, always. We fought and I hurt Catra and I wasn´t there at five in the evening of New Year´s to pick her up. And I let her be there, on her own. It´s on me. It´s on me don´t you see?!"

Adora scratches her head with the point of the knife, soaking her own honey hair in gold. Even Catra looks terrified now, for a much different reason than Glimmer does.

Adora´s voice is high, higher than life. A whisper and yet at the same time a scream that echoes on every corner of the death chamber. She is completely out of it right now, letting go off the strings of her own revenge that now wrap invisible around her vocal cords, seizing her heart and pressing her down against the earth violently. She is shaking and crying yet not a single tear drops down her oh so red eyes, as if they were all running down Catra´s cheeks instead.

"And when I finally got my fucking shit together and got there she had slashed Catra´s throat open. *My* Catra. My love. Her blood was on the kitchen floor and she was crying so much. She was dying. She was bleeding out so easily. I´ve never hated the color red more in my entire life. And Weaver was laughing, laughing. She saw the life leaving Catra´s eyes and she laughed. That fucking, pathetic, damn drunk." Adora bites into her tongue and it fills her mouth with blood. "Weaver started beating her at eleven. Then Hordak followed, and Prime. Mother, uncles, family. All hidden always. And I tended those wounds every single time and I never said anything. I was the biggest coward of them all and there was Weaver now, laughing."

Adora chokes on her spit and blood, spilling down her open lip and chin, staining her pale collarbones with crimson. Her hands are shaking so bad that the knife tethers violently towards the ground, barely avoiding her bare feet. She is blinking hard, pushing the images away that live burnt to her eyelids, unable to keep them from overwhelming her and drowning her down.

"So I took the gun from the floor and even then Weaver had the fucking nerve to smile at me and say everything was going to be better now. She tried to walk me away from her, she tried to make me look away like I always did, to make blind eyes to her abuse even though I was supposed to protect her, even though I had promised to."

“My love–”

“I aimed the gun at her and shot her in the side and she fell and even there she asked me why, why, why? Why?! And she told me it wasn't worth it, she told me Catra was not worthy, that I could do so much more. That she was pathetic and insignificant and that I was much more and fucking shoot her in the throat she would stop talking!”

“Adora, please love”

“And the look on her face, that look. Oh, *oh.* For the first time I knew she understood. For the first time ever she was afraid. She was terrified. She wanted to beg, she gurgled on her blood and she begged me to live and in the floor behind her Catra was bleeding to death too because her mother could not love her even once. My beautiful Catra. It wasn't fair, Glimmer. It wasn't fair! So I shot Weaver in the face until her bones splintered and her eyes burst open and her flesh ripped into pieces. And I did it againand again, and again, over and over and over again until I had no more bullets and she finally shut the fuck up!”

Adora slams her hand against the mirror next to her over and over again with every single word, pointing her confession with her voice and the slam of flesh against broken glass digging sharp splinters on her knuckles and palm. Adora, however, doesn´t even seem to feel it, hitting and breaking herself until the entire mirror is broken and fallen on the polished floor and her reflection breaks and falls with it.

Adora takes a breath and dissolves into a wet giggle, feral, her crystal blue eyes rimmed by red, her pale skin covered in red. She still looks like an angel but different, terribly sadder, painfully more broken. Fallen.

She turns her bloodshot eyes to Glimmer and shakes her hand to the side, dripping heavy drops of blood on her legs and the floor, pooling like their own kind of mirror, still chasing Adora everywhere.

“I'm going to tell you a little story, Glimmer.” Adora chews the words, licking her bottom lip dry. “A girl survives a horrifying accident. A girl makes it out alive and suddenly all the dreams and expectations of her family are hers to take, and she takes them. She takes it all. The weight of her dead family, brother, mother, father, aunt, cousin. She flogs herself in every single way possible to make the caretaker happy so she can have a few minutes of freedom each day. She takes the chapel and the symbol and the repentance, the submission, and think she will be able to make it out alive and free because she loves”

Adora raises her bleeding hand, pressing her fingertips against her own temples, staining red everywhere.

“A girl loves another girl, a beautiful, brave, strong girl. A girl that is her soul walking outside of her body. Her heart, her love. Her angel on earth after hell. She is everything she has ever wanted, she is her salvation. The only good part of her and her heart. And then, and then, a girl picks expectations over her love.”

Adora gasps, opening her eyes as if surprised by the turn of her own story, so deep inside her anger and madness that there is no more light in her eyes.

“You know what's the catch? The catch is walking inside a yellow kitchen and seeing your soul in pieces. The catch is pressing your palm against her neck as you feel warm blood seeping through your fingers. The catch is holding her against your chest for thirty seven minutes and sixteen seconds until the paramedics finally appear. The catch is running your nails over your wrists in the ER room because they tell you it's not worth giving her blood anymore so maybe this way they'll collect yours and give it all to her. And it freaks the nurse so bad that she ends doing her fucking job!”

There are scars on Adora´s wrists, faded, as quiet as everything else inside her heart. Reflections of the ones in Catra´s forearms. Both born out of desperation, both born out of fear and the need

to stay together no matter what. They will always itch and will always burn and will always hurt. A forever kind of pain.

“The catch is watching her be the most beautiful person on earth and being threaded like a demon when you are the real monster. The catch is watching the smile leaving her mouth and wanting to burn this fucking planet to the fucking ground!”

Adora turns around and digs her fingers around the strands of her hair, pulling violently until several of them come crumbling on her palms and she screams. Out of anger, out of rage, out of profound sadness, She screams and rages and hits, the floor, the mirror, the bodies, herself. She digs her nails on her flesh and the open air and tries to tear apart the memories and the lingering pain with her bare hands, as if shooting herself in the heart will mend the one that has been broken already.

She hits and slams and yells until her throat is torn apart like her lover´s and her lungs just cannot do it anymore, breaking down into pieces just as she does. Until her knees and elbows are bloodied, until her palms ache and bleed, until she is crying finally and instead of tears they are blood, thick, rancid, clotted, pooling on the hollow of her throat. Until she is unable to give Catra her lungs, her eyes, her face, her arms and legs, her hands, her joints, her blood, her very heart and so she just screams instead.

Catra catches her in the middle, unwavering by the hurricane of Adora´s hatred. She wraps her arms around Adora´s hyperventilating chest and holds her still in the middle of the room, absorbing it all inside her own battered and bruised body. She drinks Adora´s yells and presses her cheek against her red tears and just holds her, unable to do anything else but to hold Adora´s hand and heart as hard as she possibly can.

Catra was louder before, she is quiet now.

“Adora,” Catra says and it's almost a lullaby, almost like a song but never quite like it again. “Adora”

“I don´t know how you could ever forgive me for what I did to you.” Adora laments, gurgling in sadness and tears.

Catra shakes her head softly, her own face and hair soaked by blood now. “You did nothing”

“Exactly,” Adora grunts, wrapping her large and killing hands delicately around the base of Catra´s neck, holding her so softly and precious, almost as if afraid to break her or hurt her accidentally. Again. “I didn´t do anything.”

Catra wants to say something more, it is obvious. She wants to fight Adora of her own hatred and save her too. She wants to free her too of the own hell Adora has drowned herself into but she still cannot reach her, pulled down heavily by her own tears and her own pain, chaining them both like blood upon snow.

“Don´t cry, love” Adora whispers, cradling Catra´s cheeks between her bloodstained palms. “I´m sorry, I never wanted you to see any of this, baby.” She is breathless, desperate to make Catra understand, to comfort her. To shelter her and unable to do so. “This is my fault”

“It isn´t” Catra shakes her head, voice lost among her exhales. She meets Adora´s silver eyes with hers, holding her so close to her chest that it hurts. “It isn´t. I am guilty of this too.”

Adora´s eyes narrow sadly and she brings Catra back into a tight embrace, tucking her head below her chin and wishing more than anything that she could absorb her inside her chest where she wouldn´t feel pain or fear ever again.

Adora glances at Glimmer´s horrified stare out of the corner of her eye, uncaring if Glimmer looks disgusted or fearful or resentful. Or everything in between. Uncaring if Glimmer hates them.

“Catra has never hurt someone, except for your mom and it was an accident.” Adora defends her, putting herself between the sword and Catra all over again, becoming the sword herself. “She

is my angel, I´m rotten Glimmer but she is my only, *the* only part of me that is worth saving. It has always been her."

"This is not love," Glimmer manages to blurt, tasting the tingle of her own blood. She says it is so full of hate than anyone else would have flinched, Catra does inside of Adora´s arms.

But Adora is unwavering, unmoving in her love like a mountain against a breeze. Nothing would ever erode the stone of her love, nothing could ever crumble it down. She has loved her since she was sixteen and every single day after that. She has always loved her and that love has only transformed with time and life, smothered and carved gently by the waters of Catra´s river.

"You know nothing about love and you know nothing about pain." Adora kisses Catra´s temple, looking at Glimmer red and terrible. Such a terrible contrast under these colorful windows. "Your father died of pneumonia when you were a toddler, Glimmer, right? Was it peaceful? Were you by his side? My mother´s pelvis was crushed by the dashboard and her guts gathered on her ribcage. The steering wheel dug itself inside my father's skull and he bled to death in the pilot's seat. Adam fractured his neck when he fell from the seat, he was still looking at me. I remember the smell of their blood Glimmer"

Adora wraps her arms around Catra´s waist and brings her closer to her chest, so hard and so desperate that she lifts Catra a few inches over the ground. Easy, so easy, she has done it hundreds of thousands of times before, she would carry her anywhere so her feet don't meet the bloodsoaked floor.

"I held Catra in my arms as she bled to death. And it was slow, so slow. You don´t even get the chance to do anything. I held her in my arms and clipped her veins with my fingers and she bled all over me."

Catra´s back is facing Glimmer, hidden by Adora´s arms but even here Glimmer sees how hard both of them are trembling. Plagued by nightmares and memories.

“Do you know that feeling? Do you think seeing your mom fall from the stairs even gets near? Have you been in the ER room and there was so much blood on the floor that you wondered how much of it could lay there without killing your love? Have you heard her shallow breaths in your ears or have you heard the heart monitor going flat twice before they finally get her into the surgery room? Have you counted her scars with your fingers? Have you seen her tethering in the bridge of the here and the nothing and barely holding her alive?”

Adora puts Catra very carefully back into the ground, making sure the floor where she stands is not stained. She has already knotted her own shoes in Catra´s feet to keep her warm. Guarding her from blood is nothing in comparison.

“You know nothing at all. You don't know what a love like this feels like. You don´t know how to love Bow. You are not even in love with me, you are just in love with the idea of me. Like everybody else.” Adora spits the words on Glimmer´s face, digging the knife of her betrayal and her anger even deeper inside her friend´s heart. Glimmer knows she is right but it still hurts, so much that she cannot breath. “If you knew then you would understand. Then you would see what you would do for a love like this”

Glimmer grunts around pain, biting back a scream when she moves and a gush of blood leaves her body through her fingers. She feels closer to fading away every single second but she refuses to die without knowing the whole truth.

“What about Sea Hawk? He did nothing to you so why was he part of your revenge?”

“He wasn't.” Adora nuzzles her nose against Catra's ear. “That day in your house, Mermista made Catra cry.” Adora grins, shrugging. “So I made Mermista cry right back.“

Adora untangles herself from Catra´s limbs, very heavily, mournfully. She lets her go with a small squeeze of her fingers

over her waist and a kiss over her bare shoulders, swinging in her ankles every once in a while.

She dips her hand on the left pocket of her joggers and extracts something from it, a bundle of napkins that give off a smell so foul that Glimmer gags, pressing herself against the wall and fighting a rush of punk on her throat.

Adora doesn't seem affected by it, dangling the bundle inside her palm like a king hovering a bag of golden coins over a thirsty person, shifting the weight on her fingers and feeling the edges of the small treasure inside with the tip of her fingers.

“Double trouble on the other hand.” Adora starts, her small grin flourishing with the satisfaction of agony. “Did you know what they did to Catra when they were together? When she was only seventeen? When I was not there to see?”

The mention of Catra and Double Trouble´s relationship takes Glimmer by surprise, making her well placed anger mingle with another wave of shock. She didn´t even know they knew each other, much less that they were a couple. Glimmer has never cared about knowing too much about Catra, but now that all the cards are on the table, she can see that yes, this is all because of her, *for her.* A sick and poisoned betrothal gift.

“Ah, you didn´t even know that, right? That´s alright, I didn´t allow anyone to know, Catra didn´t want anyone to know. But they tortured her, mentally, they manipulated her and her pain, her fear. Nudged her fears with pointy fingers until she almost destroyed herself.“

Adora bites into her lip and untangles the bundle completely, letting the napkin fall softly to the side, letting the yellowish and bloody teeth shine through with the light of the morning. There are still pieces of gum held to them, flesh and root and the phantom of nerve endings brushing over Adora´s palm where she tore them out of Double Trouble´s mouth herself.

“They used *me* against her. They made her cry with my name, my face, my voice, the memory of me. They took from her, things that can never be replaced. Things that should have been Catra´s only.” Adora stands next to Huntara´s body and holds her breath, packing the teeth inside the pocket where the cigarette was, buttoning it back up with a tender pat and a smile. “Can I be honest? I enjoyed it, Glimmer. The others? It was a plan, a strategy well or badly done but a plan after all, and I stuck to it. But Double Trouble? I enjoyed killing them so much, I wish I could do it all over again. Just like Weaver, just like Prime.”

Glimmer kicks in the ground weakly, clenching her own teeth together until they ache and crack and spitting towards Adora´s spot, hoping it will reach Catra too.

“You're not getting away with this”

“Ugh, Glimmer” Adora rolls her eyes and sways her hand towards Glimmer, pointing at her agonizing body with her long fingers. “You are dying, you are going to die, you know that. Your lungs are collapsing and your ribcage is filling with blood. The knife clipped your artery and you´ve been hemorrhaging since I took it out. You have minutes left with luck and the help won't get here until much later.”

Adora gives her a wicked smile, shaking her shoulders proudly.

“I study medicine, you know? And I know you. I always know everybody, I know exactly where to hit, I know how. I never fail a stab. I'm a hunter, an excellent one.”

Adora leans down, grabs Huntara´s limp hand and digs her cold nails over the skin of her own feet, scratching herself with Huntara until her feet bleeds, dripping tiny drops of red into her sole. Adora doesn't even flinch or wrinkle her nose at the sting, dropping Huntara again and shrugging.

“This is how this is going to go. Given Light Hope has been rotting for a while here, Huntara is going to take her place. She is going

to get accused of making deals with Prime, just like Lashor. She asked me to be taken here, her people know that. It won´t be hard to suppose it was to kill me. She killed her officer, Bow and you. And because that useless detectives office won´t want anymore attention to them, they will close the case really fucking fast, just like they did with Weaver´s”

Adora shakes her shoulder, a rotten shimmer glimmering in her eye when she looks at Glimmer´s face.

“I´m the planner, remember? That´s what I´m good at. You are not a character in a movie, you are not the final girl. Nobody is miraculously coming. This doesn't have a happy ending for you. You are going to die and I'm getting Catra out of here safe and alive. I don´t fucking care how many people do I have to kill in the process.”

Glimmer grows desperate, crawling her way in the floor and digging her nails on the wood until all of her nails splinter. She looks at Catra this time, at her and only at her, bearing her hazel and blue eyes with her lilac and pink ones, trying to shake from the strings of her heart to make her listen, to make her understand, to make her pity her even.

“Catra. Catra please,” Glimmer begs, clenching her jaw. “Do one fucking good thing in your life!”

“Hey,” Adora grunts, frowning deeply. The treat in her face is evident and it makes Glimmer flinch with fear. “Don´t make me lose my patient”

“I´m sorry, Glimmer,” Catra murmurs, her voice sore, jarred. It's so strange, this is the first time Glimmer notices how much her voice had changed after Weaver tried to kill her. “For Bow too, I´m sorry”

Glimmer shakes her head, boiling hot tears running down her cheeks. “He was your friend too. He cared for you like a sister. He loved you”

Adora looks at her curiously, a twitch on her pretty eyebrows. Catra holds her breath, opening and closing her fists at her sides, digging her nails on the sides of her thighs. Her eyes are swimming with tears, abnegating her eyes and bursting down her cheeks in heavy paths, washing sweat and blood away.

"I know. I love him too." Catra seeks for Adora, tangling her fingers around her white and red shirt, holding herself to her like a lifeline. "But I can't lose Adora, Glimmer. I just can't. I'm sorry. He– I think Bow would understand. Please understand too."

Glimmer cries, closing her eyes around a rush of tears. She sees Bow´s face below her eyelids, smiling, laughing next to her cheeks, understanding over anything else. She was so unfair to him, she loved him so little compared to how much he loved her. And now he is gone too. No matter how little time Glimer has left, not even in the afterlife she will ever forgive herself for it.

And she can see Adora and Catra´s face in her eyes too. Tired too, quiet, full of sadness and now full of rage. Glimmer never took it on herself to want to really understand neither of them, not even after New Year.

She should have known, she should have known that almost losing each other in the way they did would break them, would push them over the each. She should have looked closer to Adora and seen her pain too, not only her golden halo. She should have loved Catra a little more, be kinder, more patient, less harsh.

She cannot help what her mother did. She cannot help what neither of the people that made Adora and Catra's life a living hell did. She cannot even help herself.

Who knows? Maybe Adora is right. Maybe Glimmer would have actually done the exact same thing for a love like that; old, rooted in their souls, tender and passionate and everything in between. Maybe Glimmer would have also chosen horror. Maybe she would have also chosen death.

“I could have helped you, I could have helped you make justice for what they did to you,” Glimmer whispers, crying. The sharp corners of Catra's eyes fall, her breath shuddering.

“I know,” Catra says, turning her head towards her. “The thing is Glimmer, that they didn´t deserve justice. *I* didn´t want justice. I didn´t want forgiveness, or apologies or blessings.” Catra clenches her teeth, lacing her fingers with Adora's. When she looks at Glimmer, her eyes also look red. “I wanted them dead. All of them”

Adora exhales, looking at Catra with such a soft stare it looks completely strange yet absolutely in place with everything else. She has never looked at anyone else like this.

“This all could be avoided, Glimm.” Adora murmurs and she sounds almost sad. “We could have been happy, put this past us. We would have been friends forever. I wanted to let you live, even now. As one last favor to Bow. I owe it to him.”

Adora's voice softens there and she turns around slightly to look in the direction of his body, her mouth pulling down mournful. But then her lip twitches into a scowl when she looks towards Glimmer, darkness hovering in her irises. She is looking at Glimmer with such a sudden enraged stare that Glimmer flinches with terror, her breath speeding up, suddenly terrified that Adora might ax her on the head too. She looks like she is thinking about it.

“Though, if I can be honest? I´ve been wanting to kill you since you pulled that fucking stunt of calling the police when Double Trouble crashed the car with Catra in it.” Adora runs her red tongue over her teeth, tasting her words through her gums. “Weaver beated Catra to a pulp that night, you know that? I had to take her to the hospital myself days after. Another pretty thing Hordak and your mother kept hidden. It all happened because of you. But you didn´t even care.”

Glimmer's tears are mingling with the blood, choking her down. She can't talk, she can barely think now. She is basically dead by now, her blood soaking the floor completely, sticking on her fingers, her knees and her teeth. Everything looks blurry now, fogged by tears and by sweat and by the pull inside her head begging her to sleep.

"I told you it was not going to end well, Glimmer." Glimmer can hear Adora´s voice in front of her, cold, void of any kind of softness. She hears the rush of fabric when she moves away, approaching Catra´s side, her palm against her scarred neck and her lips over her tender temples, cooing her away from the bloodshed and the guilt. "Come on, angel"

There is silence for a moment, so long and so heavy that Glimmer believes herself alone now, left to bleed and rot inside this house alongside Bow and Light Hope and Huntara´s cold bodies. It feels sickening, it feels wrong, it feels terrifying to lay here on this cold floor on this cold house and bleed out. Like a nightmare you can never wake up from, harsh and unable to undone.

She wonders for a moment if this is what Catra felt that day, laying on the floor of her kitchen room, gasping for air and for blood. If it was also cold, if it was also scary. Glimmer can´t blame her after everything, she also doesn´t want to die alone.

"Glimmer," Catra´s voice comes as a whisper, low and quiet and right next to her. Glimmer manages to open her eyes just a slit, meeting Catra´s irises near her face, holding her dying eyes with hers. "Hold my hand."

Glimmer chews around a mouthful of blood, pushing her own body to move. Her hand twitches next to her, parting from the stab wound on her side and searching for Catra´s. Catra meets her in the middle, wrapping her fingers around Glimmer´s palm and guiding her hand down.

Catra is not crying and she is not pale, blooms of pink in her cheeks and hidden kisses on her neck, but she looks sad,

thoughtful almost. Pitiful, even. A thousand of emotions running inside of her.  She is pretty and she is full of scars, as many as Adora´s. They really are two faces of the same coin, to shares of the same wound.

“Does it hurt?”

Maybe in another life. Glimmer really hopes that in another life she could've been better for them too. That all of them could have been better for Catra and Adora so they wouldn´t have to spiral into hell trying to save each other. Maybe in another life, not in this one though.

“No.” Glimmer assures her and she knows it is true as soon as she says it. She cannot feel anything anymore, not her blood or her fingers when Catra presses them in another way over her side. Nor pain or cold. Just numb drowsiness, cooing her to go back to sleep. “I'm sorry, for– for my mom, for what they all did. And I´m sorry for what I did to you.”

“I´m sorry too,” Catra takes a breath, nodding softly. Forgiveness, after so much pain and finally. She was always better than anyone ever gave her credit for. “Go with your mom and dad, okay? You can go”

Glimmer feels Catra running her fingers over her pink hair, lulling her further and further inside her own head. But Glimmer cannot see her anymore, darkness overtaking her irises and numbness eating her body alive. She cannot move or talk or see, just hear Catra´s pretty voice calming her before it is all done.

Even after all the horror, she is not letting her go alone. Catra wasn´t alone either when it happened, someone held her in her deathbed too.

“Just let go”

## Fourteen years ago

## A Patch of Moss in the Woods

Adora jumps up and down on the moss, falling on her ankles. She doesn´t go further an a few inches yet she feels like flying, the sky taking her inside her arms and twirling her around on her warm breeze before letting her back down with a soft push.

Adora´s small hands are slightly clammy, held tightly around other small hands as they dance on a circle in the middle of the forest, over patches of grass and dew and fallen leaves underneath their bare soles. Under the dim light of the sun crossing the moon shaped fruits hanging from the branches and the sounds of the river rushing hard and alive like guitar strings.

Up and down, up and down and then to the sides, following the sounds of flutes and tambourines that only they know, that only they hear inside their heads. That they have repeated dozens of times before as they do this little dance of theirs, a ritual of their own.

Up and down and to the sides. Dance.

Catra is singing. It is the most beautiful sound Adora has ever heard, young and inexperienced still, but painfully honest with its beauty. It echoes among the forest and the tall crowns of the trees. It calls for the birds, the nightingales, tilting their head curiously when they hear her sing, as if wondering if she is actually one of them or just an angel stumbling on this piece of the woods.

*La la la. La la la. La la,* she goes, running in her teeth and the dimple of her smiles the stories they have told each other, like little fairy tales or fables, knitting them into songs only they get to know, only they get to listen. *La la la,* and a dance.

Catra is singing and Adora loves her.

There are blue, yellow and green leaves on their hairs and flowers crushed over their skin, a rough attempt of paint here in the middle of nothing. Berries on their cheeks and mud on their ankles and moss on their clothes. If they could, they would sew themselves dresses out of lotus leaf and hats out of old bird nests, wrap hay around her wrists meand tie tree barks to their feet.

If they could, they would be nothing else but another part of the Whispering woods. Dew on their faces and laughter on their chest, running with the rabbits and watching the swan eggs hatch between their everlasting loving parents. Drawing lines in the mud, sleeping over the roots of huge trees and chasing each other playfully across the meadows. Catching crickets and eating wild strawberries, pulling twigs off each other's hairs and dancing at the rhythm of their own clapping.

If they could, they would build each other's castles here, with stained glasses over old lover's tombs. Untouched by blood and hatred and horror.

They are children, seven, playing in a forest that sees them fall in love. Catra loves the trees, the little animals, the drops of rain, the ruins of the chapel, the old tomb, whistling and singing and hearing the echoes come back with the sound of the wind.

Adora loves Catra.

## Winter, Ten Years Ago

## After the Bridge

"Come on, babygirl, keep walking"

Adora skips in the stones and moss, Catra's young hand clenched to hers as she guides her through the woods.

On the ruins of the old chapel, there is a single wall that has managed to stand alive. Just one, two columns and bricks, with a

beautiful window right in the middle, swirls of old metal and crystals on the glass. A lovely display of the Etherian’s religion before the First Ones.

It is hidden in the forest, past a secret pond and below a tree of evergreen leaves and blue and amber flowers that remind Adora so much of Catra's lovely eyes. It's impossible to find if you don't know exactly where you are going, but Adora and Catra know this path well, they have snuck here for years and years since they first met each other and Adora's heart skips a beat when she catches sight of it finally coming into view.

In front of the wall and the window, there is a tomb. Long ago gone smooth by the pass of time, the inscription on the surface is no longer visible, just dark marble and carved swirls of flowers and the tiny runs that day that, once upon a time, lovers were buried here. It only seems fitting that it was part of the only things surviving here, it only seems fitting that Adora and Catra found it.

Adora guides Catra through the known stones and helps her skip her feet towards the tomb, sitting over it. They are so small still that their bare feet dangle over the moss scattered floor.

Catra is quiet. Everything about her is still loud, her curly hair, her rich skin, her freckles, her blazing eyes, her purple clothes, but today she is quiet. It will be a long time still before she knows true silence.

This is the first time in months that her mother allows her to leave the house, and only because Adora stood stubbornly outside the door for half an hour until Weaver finally gave up and quite literally threw Catra outside and into Adora's tiny arms. Adora had not seen her in so long that she could have cried there and then, rushing across the tree line and where they are right now, refusing to let Catra even look back.

There is a bruise on Catra's cheek and she is a little bit thin inside Adora's knitted jacket. Adora doesn't know what to do for her yet,

she is still too young and she doesn't understand this kind of pain. But she can help ease the sting and she can love Catra. Loving Catra is the best thing Adora has ever known to do, maybe one day it will save them both.

“I missed you,” Adora whispers, bonking her forehead softly against Catra's temple. Catra sighs with a shutters, seeking for Adora's hand immediately and lacing their fingers together.

“I missed you too,” then, in an even softer voice, vulnerable and heartbroken, she says, “I miss my dad”

“I know”

They are eleven. Catra is a nightingale, Adora is still not sure yet what she is.

“I brought you something,” Adora scrambles with the insides of her old satchel, fishing out of it the paper creation she had carefully carried with her, presenting it to Catra with a grin. “It’s a lamp!”

“A lamp,” Catra repeats, her eyebrows twitching with confusion.

“Yes!” Adora places it over Catra's soft hands, brushing her hair off her neck. “My mom helped me make it. It's for your dad”

Catra stares at the small and round paper lamp, blinking slowly. It's pretty covered in paint and wax, and rough, obviously made by child's hands with a small place made of metal to hang a candle from it.

“I don't understand,” Catra says finally after a bit, raising her eyebrows and looking at Adora's pretty and young face. Adora's smile doesn't waver, instead twitching sweetly, cupping Catra's small hands around the lamp with tenderness.

“My mom said that when a lamp is lightened, you can send a message. And you can ask for something. A wish”

“To whom?”

“To your dad, silly”

Catra's eye skyrocket in her forehead, looking at the lamp with another kind of light in her pretty eyes. Adora hums, a sound like a flute, waiting patiently for Catra to find her voice again.

“Do you think he will answer?” Catra asks after a minute, her young voice hopeful. Adora shrugs next to her, thumbing Catra's freckles with the pads of her fingers.

“Who knows? But he will know that you're thinking of him and he will always look after you.”

Catra's smiles is the most precious things Adora will ever see in her life.

Adora leans down and lingers a kiss on the corner on Catra's mouth, fluttering, sweet and honest. She has seen her own parents kissing many times, she knows it is meant for the love of your life, something important, something between just you and them.

Catra did it first, shy and nervous and young on this very same spot, cold mouth against the corner of Adora's mouth. And from then on Adora kissed her every single day, on the corner of her lips where secret kisses live and in her cheeks, tender.

They are each other's first love and first kiss. They are still too young and their love is too quiet, just between them and the forest.

They hang the paper lamp on the metal of the stained window, Catra over Adora's shoulders, tethering dangerously to the side and barely managing to not fall to the moss. The candle burns orange and blue under the light of the forest.

Catra has become an orphan, in one way or another, but she is now alone. Catra does not say it out loud, afraid her wish might

not come true if she voices it, but she asks her father to help her and Adora be together forever.

They chase each other through the woods and the lamp burns.

## Halloween, Seven Years Ago

## The Golden Hour

*… I don't want to set the world on fire …*

Adora is hanging upside down.

The radio of her parents' car is still playing, the same song over and over again, repeating itself over and then back again. The music digs itself in Adora's brain, forever burnt to her memories.

*… I just want to start a flame in your heart* …

Adora blinks and looks around her, her face red with the effort and dripping sweat, all of her beautiful golden hair matted with blood. The seat belt buckle digs painfully over her ribs and waist, painting bruises there.

The window next to her is busted, completely shattered by the hit with the frame bent and twisted horribly when the roof of the car slammed against the pavement. The air smells a little bit like gas, nauseating and burning in Adora's young nose, dripping from the floor to the roof and only then Adora realizes it's not only her but the car hanging upside down completely.

In the seat between hers and her brother's there is a shattered piece of glass, huge and broken, killing like a spear and dug as far as it possibly could on the leather of the seat, ripping the fabric and stuffing inside.

For the first time in Adora's life, she is glad Catra was not allowed to come with them because this is her seat, curled around Adora's

side and sleeping over her shoulder. This ripped seat is Catra's and if she had come she would be dead.

Adora's father is quiet in front of her, hidden by the seat. He is slumped over the wheel and every once in a while a gushing sound comes out of him, nothing else. Her mother's seat is pressed tightly against the dashboard, the seals that kept it from moving busted, pressing her flat like some kind of torture device. All of her blonde hair is covering her face like a curtain, staining deeper in copper and red the longer the second go by.

Adora feels movement behind her, soft and pained too but she cannot move more than a few inches, her lungs straining inside her chest.

She looks to the side, blinking back tears. Adam is laying on his belly on the roof of the car, quiet. He wasn´t wearing his seatbelt, unlike Adora. His shoulder length hair is pooled on his shoulders, head bent in an unnatural angle. Adora cannot see his eyes either but he is so quiet.

"Adam?" Adora hears herself saying, mouth heavy, stuffed like cotton. She looks at the back of her father's seat, tears dripping clear and bloody off her eyes. She is bleeding from her shoulder and back. "Dad"

Nothing. Adora grows more scared, the shock and the ringing inside her ears finally lowering down, leaving her alone in this car with the same song playing from the broken stereo.

"Mom," Adora whispers, out of breath, crying now so hard that she can barely see. She is scared, she is just a kid, just fourteen. She still doesn't understand her life has changed forever and she needs her mother. "Mommy, please"

Quiet. And music.

Adora looks outside her busted window, past broken glass and towards the street they were calmly driving through towards the cabin where they were to spend the holidays. They are at an

intersection, on the path that leaves Etheria towards the Mountains, a venue they needed to cross now after the Thaymor Bridge was closed. Otherwise they wouldn't even be here to begin with.

Past the wreck of her parents car there are two more cars laying smoking over the grass. A completely destroyed car and another one, slim, engine destroyed and windows busted.

It is the car that had crashed against them, out of control at a hellish speed. It crashed fully against the other car and then against Adora's, sending them all flying and rolling yards away until it stopped smoking against a broken tree.

From the expensive slick black car the door bursts open and a man crawls out, coughing heavily. He slips out of the pilot's seat and towards the ground, catching himself on his palms and wrist. His expensive blue silk shirt is torn and covered in sweat and even here the stench of alcohol is clear, eyes bloodshot and blue hair matted to the side.

He is looking, staring, taking on the wreckage left by his own reckless decisions, at the lives taken, at the destruction. He is drunk and now he is a murderer.

Mayor Hordak looks up, staring at the Montenegro's destroyed car. He locks eyes with Adora's young ones, holding her stare for one second almost as if weighing if she is alive at all and then scrambles away, leaving them all there to die.

*… In my heart I have but one desire …*

Adora's chin wobbles and she cries, sobbing soft and heart wrenching on the remains of her family and her life.

She is bleeding, the seat belt hurts. The street is quiet after death.

The song is still playing on.

—

Adora is sitting in the middle of the police station, staring at some point of the wall. She is quiet, she is barely breathing.

Someone sits in the chair in front of her but she doesn't really recognize her. All she has ever known for years is her home, Catra's house and the forest. This place, the square, the town, they are foreign to her. Weird, filled with cold. She is cold. There is a blanket on her shoulders and she is covered in blood and she is cold.

Something has cracked inside of her, something already twisted and born different. It hasn't shattered completely just yet but it starts here.

"Adora? My name is Angella Bright," the woman sitting in front of her says, pink hair, lilac eyes. She is around the age of Adora's mother, but this woman will get to see her child grow older. Marlena is not here anymore. "I'm the Mayor's assistant. I was sent by him."

That calls Adora's attention. She knows the Mayor, she has seen him walk inside and out Catra's house once or thrice. Catra's father never liked him and never allowed him or the other brother to even breathe near Catra or Adora, but after his death, his presence was a constant. She knows it was part of the reason Marlena didn't allow her to sleep over Catra's home anymore. A reason why Marlena took Catra under her wing as much as possible, giving her a room in her house and house schooling her herself. Marlena loved Catra.

Adora knows who he is. She *saw* him.

"The Mayor asked me—"

"Is he going to deliver himself?"

Angella Bright's mouth closes with a click, her eyes wide. She looks at Adora's young face for a second and then frowns, shaking

her head.

“I don’t know what you mean, sweetie.” She is tense, she knows what Adora is talking about but she pretends she doesn’t. She is a good liar.

“He was driving the car,” Adora states, loudly. Detective Lashor and Huntara hear her, they look at each other and then away. “He killed them, is he going to deliver himself?”

Lashor leans down and whispers something to Angella’s ear. There are more testimonies being taken on the next office, so they lower their voices when they talk between them. Angella’s eyes are heavy on Adora’s, so lilac they look almost red.

She leans forward on the chair and laces her fingers, shaking her head. There is a First One symbol hanging from the chain in her neck.

“Adora, Mayor Hordak was in a meeting today.” She says, voice firm, clear, almost like saying the words very slowly to make Adora understand. To convince her of the truth. Of the lie. “A drunk driver killed them, Adora. But it was not him.”

“But—“

“Not him,” Angella leans back, ending the conversation with a heavy stare. She stands up, throwing her long and heavy hair behind her back. She is perfect, she is everything the forest is not. Adora is afraid. “We will call your cousin and go from there. You suffered a strong trauma and it will take you time to heal.”

Angella walks away, taking her briefcase in her hand. There is a wedding ring hanging from her neck too. She was married, she has lost someone, she should understand. She doesn’t.

“And please, do not spread rumors, Adora. I know all of this must be very new for you but we are a united town and you are part of it now. It will do you good to learn your place.”

Adora is alone. She wishes someone would turn the fucking radio off.

## Six Years Ago

## The Cabin

"She was my mother," Mara says, pointing with the tip of her finger at the photograph of the old newspaper resting over Adora´s knee.

It´s not cold today but there is a persistent fog that always surrounds the mountains, like a curtain, heavy and thick and frightening for anybody else. But Adora and Mara are hunters, they have roamed the forest this morning, the meat of their haunt cooks slowly on the fireplace. There is no reason for neither of them to be afraid here.

Adora runs her fingers over the picture of her aunt Serenia and her mother, long ago gone fragile by time. They are sitting cross legged over blankets and Adora´s phone rings every few minutes with messages from Catra.

Mara made lighthearted fun to Adora about them early on in their new living together situation. With time, Mara understood just how important their presence in Adora´s life was, how vital Catra´s life was in the strings of Adora´s heart. Mara knows a lot about pain and a lot about grudges and sadness, so she is glad Adora has someone to hold onto, someone that she wants to live for when she doesn´t want to do it for herself.

It´s fucked up, but it is honest and Mara is glad.

"You have her eyes," Adora murmurs, smiling softly.

Her mother spoke only highly things about Serenia, always. Adora was always sad that she never got to meet her and she was alway sad about how devastated Marlena always looked when she spoke

of her. There has always been sadness underneath Adora´s family, hidden in plain sight.

"Yeah, well, you´re a carbon copy of your mom. So you are one to tell," Mara nudges her softly on the side, giggling when Adora does.

It´s been three months since the accident and, little by little, Mara has come to know the person Adora is. At first, when Mara arrived at the small motel where Adora had been placed until her arrival, she was as quiet as a tomb and so still that she looked like another graveyard´s statue. And Mara had to admit that she, truly, didn´t know her at all.

Mara had left town after her grandmother had died and lived her life as far away from Etheria as she could. She knew about her aunt Marena and her husband and their children, but Mara never sought for them and Marlena never pressured her to. For a while, Mara managed to live her life not as a Montenegro but as Mara only, from town to town, from bartender to law school to business. For a while, Mara didn´t care about anything else and she was fine with it.

When the call came and with it the notice, Mara was tempted to refuse. She could, her friends told her, legal papers on the bar´s tables. Mara could just say no and be done with it. Etheria was a weird town with weird solutions and they would find a proper house for Adora to live in. She would survive and Mara would not have to return to the place where her mother was murdered.

At first, Mara wasn´t even go to bother to go. She could sign the papers declining and send them by package and be done with it. It wasn´t difficult. So when Mara stopped in front of the motel´s door, she was surprised with herself. And she continued to be surprised the entire trip from her car to the door to the police officers waiting for her in the small room plagued with people.

The first thing Mara saw was blue and hazel and the wild mane of dark curls standing between her and her niece. Ripped jeans and

bruised elbows and mud on cheekbones, a wild little thing sheltering Adora´s peace like a knight, her fists on her hips and her young face angry, regarding Mara heavily. And then there was Adora, sitting on the only chair of the room, her eyes glued to the wall but her arms tightly wrapped around the girl's waist, a sight so young and so honest that it crumbled Mara´s walls completely.

That was the first time Mara saw Catrina , and it was also the first time she ever saw Adora besides baby pictures and right there and then she understood how young they both were and how deep love ran. How alone would both of them be, even not knowing anything about them yet. They were children and Mara was a child herself once, left alone in the world too.

Now it´s been three months living in Randor´s cabin and Mara loves Adora with her entire heart. She is sweet, she is brave, she is still quiet. She is everything anyone could ever ask of a child but she is also more, so much more. There is a kind of darkness inside Adora´s chest, one existing there much before the accident.

A hunger, even. Like rescuing a wolf´s pup and watching it grow old, quiet inside what it is expected of them but just about to snap giving the right circumstances. Mara can appreciate that, can respect it. She feels the very same darkness inside of her sometimes.

She has beaten drunk idiots to a pulp before just to unwind a little from it. She holds back only by the violent desire to escape. She suspects Adora tampers it down by Catra´s sake alone. Again, respectable. Again, dangerous. Mara loves Adora.

“Did he really kill her?” Adora asks suddenly, voice young, voice heavy. She is staring at the, then, young man standing right behind Marlena. White and green and a murderer.

“Yes,” Mara says and there is no doubt inside her heart. She has never gotten justice no matter how hard she has tried, always pushed back by the people that have Priest Prime´s and Mayor

Hordak´s backs. But she knows he is guilty, she knows it inside her bones.

Adora doesn´t seem to doubt her, but her mind and heart are somewhere else, weighing something behind her smart eyes until she finally reaches a conclusion she likes. When she turns to look at Mara, the latter realizes she is considering if she can trust her back.

"He is Catra´s uncle," Adora says, unwavering, firm. Angry too. She is holding the newspaper so hard that her fingers ache.

Mara looks at her and doesn´t tear her eyes away, nodding softly.

"I see."

"He beats her," Adora adds, nose wrinkling, eyes flashing with memories of slaps in the middle of choir practice. There it is, the rage. What makes her an exceptional hunter, even so young. "Her mother beats her too. Everyone covers it."

"I´m not surprised," Mara says and she knows she should cringe about saying and answering this kind of stuff to a fourteen year old, but sometimes she feels like Adora is much older than her. "You love her."

"I do, more than anything." Adora drops the newspaper back into the box, pressing her knees against her chest. The first time Mara saw Adora finally sleeping after Marlena, Randor and Adam´s death, she was curled inside Catra´s noodle arms and breathing on her young neck. "What do I do?"

"Be smart, Adora," Mara says, looking at the fire too. She taps on the floor softly, humming under her breath. "And be with her, always."

Now that Mara has Adora, she has vowed to protect her. And that means she has also vowed to protect Catra. Mara doesn´t mind, she also loves that child, that rebellious and full of life child that

flies free no matter how much pain her own family causes her. She understands why Adora adores her.

And Mara has also vowed to protect them both from Him. Maybe not now, maybe not soon, but she will find a way to make him pay. Even if it is over her own bones, he will fall and he will pay and Mara will do everything possible so Adora doesn´t have to endure it herself, so Adora can leave this place like Mara did once and take her love with her and lose themselves in the woods they like to roam. Mara will find a way.

"I met someone at the market today," Light Hope says after a long moment, smiling to herself. "Her name is Light Hope."

She is still watching at the flames but even from this angle she catches the knowing grin out of Adora´s lips.

"I think I might like her," Mara adds before Adora says anything, shaking her shoulders when her cousin rolls her eyes and giggles.

"Well about time," Adora says, paying with the ends of her hair. She smells like sandalwood, her maroon sweater is short on her, belonging to someone else, cradled around her body to protect her from the cold here. "Are we moving with her?"

"Don´t over do it just yet, you menace," Mara ruffles Adora´s hair, snorting when Adora pushes her away. She is strong, that's good. She´ll need it. "Give it two months, then we can go crash to her house. I think you will like it there."

## Six Years Ago

## The First Ones Cathedral

Mara has been gone for seven months. It sucks.

Adora is almost sixteen now and she feels older than ever. She has felt so old since her parents and Adam died, and now she

feels completely worn down, left to drift on her own in this life.

And then there is Light Hope.

Light Hope has been taking Adora to the Cathedral almost every single day, dragging her here the day after Mara left. She makes her kneel on the floor in front of the candles of the altar and pray in silence. She makes her place red flowers over the altar and her eyes flash every time Adora wrinkles her nose at the smell. The newfound bones of the deity. They smell like formaldehyde and like death still, as if someone had just polished them clean. Adora hates them for some reason, can´t even bring herself to look up at them.

Then Light Hope drags her right back into the house chapel and hands her brambles but that's not something Adora likes to talk or think about. Her skin itches enough under her dress already, sticking to her skin, and she smells strongly like medicine under the tightly wrapped bandages.

*This is for your own good. Do you want to be like Mara? Do you want to forsake the people that love you?* Light Hope says always, standing between the altar and the door of a place that was supposed to be a new home. This isn´t home, this isn´t freedom. *Again, again. Until it hurts.*

*Do you want to see your stray? Again.*

*This is why the Deity placed you with me. Again.*

Adora clenches her teeth and kneels on the altar again. She clenches her teeth and feels the bramble slam against her back. She wants to scream but she has gagged herself, enduring by pride and by fear. Her head rings but she quiets it down. She is still too young, she misses hunting.

Somewhere inside her mind she wonders if this is what Mara would have wanted for her, if she knew what would happen to Adora when she walked out of the house that evening and never

came back. But then again, Mara left so Adora doesn't really know what Mara really thought or felt anymore.

Right now, Adora is kneeling in front of the candles, fingers laced beneath her chin, eyes narrowed. She is neither praying nor asking for some kind of forgiveness, even if she hasn't done anything to beg for it to begin with. She isn´t asking for help or for clearance or for understanding of pain that is not hers to take. She is way past that now.

She is just here, staring at the flames and feeling the bite of the fire on the skin of her cheeks and fingers. Her back hurts, she is tired.

Someone approaches her, steps light and voice humming. She smells like incense and wax, testimonies of hours of choir practice. She is neither an acolyte nor a First One but she is trapped here too, just like Adora.

Catra kneels next to her and presses their shoulders together, taking an ember from the pyre and letting her own candle, right in front of Adora's eyes. A small prayer, just for Adora's sake.

*Did she hurt you again?* Adora knows Catra wants to ask, wants to scream and kick and run, run far away from here. Yes, the answer is yes, always yes. Sometimes Adora wonders if Light Hope really got with Mara because of love or because she wanted to get near Adora.

*What did she ask from you this time?* Track team, new friends. The Academy awaits. Hang out with the Bright girl and Bow. Cheerleaders if no sports wants you. Better grades, better everything. Hair long, clean face. Golden and white. Perfect or you won't have a place where to come back anymore. Your parents would be disappointed.

Lies.

*Come with me.* Where? They are still too young. Too young and too worn out already. There is only the forest and even there they

will chase them. Light Hope, Weaver. Prime, his eyes follow Adora everywhere inside the Cathedral. He allows his sister to beat Catra inside the holy walls.

So, Catra doesn't say anything, taking one of Adora's hands and holding it between both of hers, resting her lips over their joint hold. She is praying now, to them both, to their love. Is all they both have.

It's nice, it feels like a promise. Like the reliquary on Adora´s neck, like the ring guarded in the loose wood of her bedroom. They are only sixteen and Adora breaths for her.

**Four Years Ago**

**Campus Music Hall**

**A week before the Quarry Crash**

Eighteen. Adora is eighteen and for some reason she is in the Music Hall today.

She used to be down here a lot, before the rupture, before the fight. She used to have lunch with Catra in the quiet classrooms filled with music instruments, sitting cross legged over the desks and hearing Catra play the piano or the guitar or sing.

Adora never found a liking to the school but she enjoyed being down here, near the theater and the mostly empty rooms during lunch, munching on sandwiches and smiling at Catra's pretty voice next to her. She liked coming to theater practice after classes and hearing her leave every other student in the ashes, cheering for her in the red seats and applauding even when she shouldn´t. She liked it, she loved it, just like Catra.

She hasn't been here in twelve months, three weeks and four days. She has counted them.

She doesn't even know why she is here to begin with. She should be in the library studying for the upcoming finals, this is her final year after all and she is valedictorian of her generation, followed closed behind by Catra alone. Or doing volleyball practice at the gym, track team and speaking about sports scholarships. She could be sitting on the cafeteria table, next to Bow and Glimmer and their friends, Adora's friend, eating bad fries and relishing on popularity with the rich kids.

She could be there but she is here instead.

Maybe it's because she had a bad night, or because she again couldn't sleep at all, plagued by bad memories and missing warmth at her side when she woke up.

Maybe it is because she saw Catra at the change of class, walking by the lean and pale hand of Double Trouble towards the barracks or the gym. Her dark hair straightened, her clothes red, her eyes tired.

Maybe it's because Adora has been observing Double Trouble, following them with her eyes for months now until she learnt exactly at what time they left for the theater club and when they skipped class to smoke behind the school walls. Because she knows right now they are in calculus class and she made sure they were there so Catra is on her own right now.

Maybe it's because the last time she spoke to Catra it escalated horribly and they fought even worse. Because Adora screamed and Catra screamed and then Glimmer butt in and Catra got physical until she was sent to the principal's office, staring at Adora with the most heartbroken stare ever before going away.

Maybe it's because Adora misses her, plain and simple. Like a limb, like a heartbeat, like blood.

So now Adora is wandering her way across the music halls, without thinking, without daring to hope. Before, Adora knew Catra's schedule like the back of her palm, sooner than she learnt

her own. Now Adora doesn't know what her classes are or where, she doesn't know anything. It freaks her out, it makes her mad with herself.

Now Adora stops in her tracks in the middle of the dark and silent corridor, her breath stuck in her lungs, staring at Catra in front of her.

Catra has walked out of a room, smelling like wax and old instruments, making her way back to the main halls of the school or even outside, to the gardens, when she tripped with Adora. She is alone and she is quiet, even her breath coming to a stop as her eyes widen at the sight of Adora down here, after so long.

Catra looks… surprised, to say the least. Her pupils blow up like new moons in her irises and then shrink, pin points as her shoulders shaken when the realization that Adora really is here washes on her. She was not expecting her but then again Adora was not expecting herself here either.

It's been twelve months, three weeks and four days.

They stare at each other in silence, feet away, so close yet so far away. The air is still warm between them but everything else is cold. Even their nervousness is cold. They have never hesitated around each other like this, they have never doubted the other's reaction like this. Never, until now.

Catra is looking at Adora as if she didn't know what to expect. As if she didn't know if Adora came here by some dumb accident after wandering off across the school, or if she had come here to fight. She is tense, opening and closing her hands at her sides, looking at Adora's face and then away.

Adora is frozen too but she cannot take her eyes away from her. Catra's hair is straightened, again, long across the middle of her back, held back with a red hair band. It hurts to see, Catra had always loved her curls, tending to them, washing them carefully, so it hurts to see.

Her makeup is dark, really dark, heavy mascara and sharp eyeliner, black eyeshadow mirroring the purple and lilac bags underneath her precious eyes. Cheeks sunken, new freckles over her nose, straight posture.

She looks thinner than Adora remembers her, ripped black leggings and the slim straps of her tank top matching each other. There is a turtle neck sweater in her hands that she was obviously about to slip into before tripping with Adora, but now she is just frozen in the middle of the corridor. The collar of the shirt is wide, sweetheart cut, showing her neck and collarbones. Adora cannot look away.

There are tiny bruises in her neck, purple and red, perfectly small, perfectly circular yet jarred on the edges. Two in the base of her throat, one right in the middle of the column  of her neck. Bruises but not the kind Weaver marks on her skin with drunk fury. Another kind, one that makes Adora sick for very different reasons.

Hickeys, marks of kisses. From a mouth that is not hers because why would it? Catra does not belong to Adora. Adora let Catra go in order to chase faux butterflies. Catra has the right to move on, to make her life, to fall in love.

Adora *knows* Catra has a partner; she knows Double Trouble kisses her and holds her now; she knows they place their red mouth on her neck and smiles against her skin. She doesn't know a lot of things, Catra will tell them to Adora much later, but for now Adora knows Catra is with them. Adora *knows.*

But fucking hell, how much it hurts.

Catra watches her in silence for a very long second, her shoulders curling in herself, almost as if bracing herself from what Adora might say now that she has seen them. As if she were to shame her or reproach her or fight her for them. As if Adora were to think less of her for them, even after everything. As if Adora didn't adore her fully, no matter what.

When Adora says nothing, unable to find her voice among the chaos inside her chest, Catra huffs. She shakes her head and tears her eyes away from her, making her way again across the corridor, careful not to touch a single inch of Adora's body when she walks past her.

She could very much return to the classrooms or just go the other way, through the other door, but this is Catra and Catra does not bend her head down for anybody. Not even for Adora. She does not regret the decisions she has made because at least she made them on her own, good or bad. It is more than Adora can say and Adora knows it.

Still, Adora cannot let her go like this. She has spent twelve months, three weeks and four days doing things others want from her. She is tired today, just for today.

"Wait," Adora wraps her hand around Catra's upper arm, holding her softly in place, stopping her from leaving. "Please, wait"

Catra snaps her eyes and head towards her, her eyebrows high on her forehead, her mouth fallen open with surprise, and then, with anger. She is so beautiful, Adora loves her.

She shakes herself off Adora's hold but doesn't leave, instead staring at Adora's conflicted face in front of her, waiting with her heart on her shoes and her breath on her sleeve for Adora's brain to work again.

"What?" Catra pressures her when Adora says nothing, growing more and more impatient the more the silence stretches between them.

She doesn't want to be here, standing in the dark corridor with Adora's eyes over her neck. She doesn't want Adora to see them, the proof of Catra being with someone else. She doesn't want Adora to see what Catra is doing to herself.

She doesn´t want for Adora to smell the cigarette on her clothes or the linger of parties in her hair; she doesn´t want her to know

Catra laid with Double Trouble, didn´t even want for her to know she was with them to begin with.

She doesn't want her to see Catra and realize all the good things that lived in her are slipping through her fingers and she doesn't want to see Adora's face and see that she is doing exactly the same to herself.

“Adora–”

“I just–” Adora tries, opening and closing her mouth. She is trying very hard not to look at Catra's neck and she is trying very hard not to tremble. “I– I just–”

She doesn't know how to say it, she doesn't know how to ask. This is Double Trouble´s doing but she still doesn't know how to ask. Catra seems to either take pity on her or want to dig the knife further, because she sighs and looks away from Adora's eyes, staring at the wall when she speaks.

“I slept with them”

*Oh*

Fuck. Fuck, *fuck.* Adora might actually scream.

And yet, she doesn't know how to say it, that she doesn't feel like she is crumbling into pieces for the sight of the hickeys or for this new knowledge but for the fear that they might have hurt Catra. She doesn't know how to say it so she just says it like that.

“Did they hurt you?” Adora whispers, voice breaking.

Catra exhales, surprised, curling her palm over the hickeys. She was not expecting for Adora to ask that, out of all things. It almost makes her laugh.

Adora is pale, they are tears hanging from the corners of her narrowed eyes and her mouth is pulled into the saddest of expressions. It almost makes Catra mad, how painfully honest

Adora is about this, about her worry for her. It makes Catra mad because she wanted to give her infinity to her yet they are stuck here, between this corridor and regret.

"No." Catra answers after a moment, her voice dropping. She is surprised by how softly honest she sounds. Her mouth is talking on her own and she doesn't feel like stopping it now. "I knew what I was doing. I was alright with it. It was not– it was not bad."

"Okay." Adora nods.

Adora wants to reassure her, reassure herself, but deep inside her she is mad. Because she doesn't understand, if she was trusted with Catra's body she would not bruise it no matter what. Much less knowing the reasons she already has patches of red sometimes. But then again, Adora has already bruised her in other ways.

Adora still looks devastated. Catra loves her so much that she wants to smack her.

"It was cold," Catra adds after a long moment and it is only when she voices it to Adora that she realizes how true it is.

It was quick and it was alright. Like a task. She only wanted to do it and get over the whole stupid first time stigma. But she felt alone through it, the beginning and the during and the after. She felt alone so it was cold.

Adora's face shatters, her chin wobbling violently. She knows Catra hates the cold. And maybe Catra is not the only one that wished for infinity, that wanted, *wanted.* But why would Adora ever leave her behind if she wanted her in the first place?

"I wish–" Adora starts, voice breaking and fading, looking away sharply. Angry with herself.

Maybe she was left with no choice. Maybe the bramble against her skin itched too much. So fucked up, because Catra loves her.

Catra exhales, wrinkling her nose, forcing herself to tear her palm off her own neck. She can hear Weaver´s voice inside her head, *You worthless cunt,* she says over and over again, so Catra stopped coming home until she could slip on the attic at dawn.

She can hear Double Trouble´s slick tongue on her ear, licking the shell, nipping at her throat. Passing the cigarette into her lips and blowing an alcohol smelling smile against her cheek. *I heard she is going to date the Bright girl,* they say, running nails down Catra ´s shoulders. *I heard she kisses the princesses.* And also, *Did you see her face? When she found us making out in the corridor? Do you think she looked mad? Isn´t that what you wanted, darling?*

Catra hates her life.

Adora´s hair is perfectly placed, all brushed out of her face, held by golden pins and gentle locks. It falls down her neck and shoulders, longer than Catra has ever seen it. It feels like a cage, all of its own, a golden cage or golden bars. Her shoes are white, her volleyball uniform red, her skin is sparkly with cream and perfume. Catra hates it, where is the mud? Where is the moss? Where is Adora? Where is herself?

"You look like your friends," Catra can´t help but to whisper, catching an errand lock of Adora´s golden hair, playing with it between her fingertips. Her voice is sweet, she is always sweet, but she sounds so tired.

She places it gently behind Adora´s ear, her hand brushing the side of Adora´s face in a caress that almost doesn´t exists at all. It makes Adora shiver from head to toe, the fine hair in her cheeks rising, her eyes damping with tears. Adora is tired too, she doesn´t want to fight anymore. She wants Catra but Catra is not hers anymore, not ever.

The only thing Adora has is this act, this faux pretension of control. Golden and white clothes and perfume. Lost infinity and lost regret.

“Perfect?” Adora asks because that's who the people she hangs out with under the approving stare of Light Hope are like. Perfect. There should be a certain kind of beauty in it, isn´t it? Something Catra might like from what Adora has done to herself.

But this is Catra.

“Sad.” Catra says instead, because she cannot say out loud that looking at Adora like this breaks her heart.

Catra drops her hand back to her sides and gives a step away, holding Adora´s eyes inside of hers for a second longer, waiting for words that doesn´t come. Catra sighs, turning her head away.

“Goodbye, Adora”

Her steps are light on the linoleum floor when she walks away, disappearing through the dark corridor. The heavy door of the Hall closes behind her and suddenly Adora is alone again. Catra is gone, gone, and Adora does not have the fucking guts to follow her back.

“Fuck,” Adora murmurs, turning around, looking at herself on the reflection of the glass doors. She really does look like her friends, like Light Hope. She doesn´t know who she is anymore and Catra has bruises in her neck. Adora also hates her life. “Fuck!”

Adora slams her foot over the closed doors and screams, leaving the silent hall like a hurricane, on a swirl. She cannot hear music singing anymore. The glass of the door shatters and breaks into the floor.

The next time they see each other is a week later and a car is destroyed and Adora pulls Catra out of the wreckage. She holds her inside her arms and breathes the smoke off her hair and swears following her behind from now on.

## Four Years Ago

## The Capellán House

## 36 hours after the Quarry Crash

“My car, Catrina. My fucking car, something so much useful than you, piece of worthless nothing!”

She was drunk, it always hurts more when she is drunk.

Catra is lying on her side over the mattress of her thin bed, eyes closed, forehead sweaty, drifting in and out of sleep several times. She doesn´t want to be awake because being awake aches, and she doesn´t want to move because moving is sound and who knows just how hard Weaver might hit her this time.

But there is movement, movement inside her tiny attic room, so Catra remains very still and drifts into some kind of unconsciousness that is neither passing out nor sleep. Cold, painful and tired. She lays there and hopes that Weaver ignores her, that she leaves, that she thinks Catra is dead so Catra can rest. Just that, that is only Catra asks.

“Catra,” A voice that is definitely not Weaver's calls for her, nudging her cheek gently with her knuckles. “Cat, open your eyes"

Adora complies because she will never be able to say no to Adora, never to her. Whatever Adora wants and wishes for, Catra will give it to her. The moon, the stars, the world. Opening her eyes. She can do that for her.

“Hey, Adora,” Catra greets, voice thick. She can see Adora through her damp eyelashes, matted with each other. by old tears and makeup. She didn't even showered after the police dropped her into her mother´s hands.

Adora´s eyes are red. That's wrong but Catra can´t understand why until she sees the bloodshot of her scleras and the raw skin of the underline of her precious eyes. She is pale, there are patches of red on her skin, her hands are warm but her nose is

deep red. She has been crying, Catra knows because she has known Adora her entire life, she knows her. So she knows Adora has been crying.

Wrong.

“Hi, pretty,” Adora greets her, still gently, still soft no matter how much her voice seems to be breaking. She is so ethereal in the middle of Catra´s tiny room that she looks like light. As id the sun rays had taken human form just for a second, just to kneel next to Catra´s cot.

“Are you in my dream?” Catra hears herself asks and she could beat herself for sounding so childish, but she craved Adora´s safety after so many months away. Catra has been dreaming with Adora coming for her for days and weeks and months, so now that it is happening Catra really needs to ask.

“No, baby,” Adora shakes her head, pushing Catra´s bangs out of her face. Catra must have drowsed off there because when Adora speaks again her voice is more urgent, on edge. Frantic. “Cat”

“Hmm?”

“Did she hit you?”

What a question. Nobody in their entire lives should have to answer something like that. Catra does not want to answer something like that but she owes it to Adora. Adora is the only one that knows and she is here, here. Adora came back so now Catra can breathe again.

“Yeah”

“Where?”

“Legs,” Catra points at her leggings and then up, trying not to touch her sore skin. “Waist”

Adora shifts next to her bed, gently rolling Catra further to her side. She is very gentle, never pressing her fingertips deeper than she should, never touching Catra more than necessary. Catra would let her wrap her completely inside her chest and swallow her hold, but that's a bit strange to say when you have just confessed your feelings a few days ago and your mothers had just beated the life out of you. So Catra conforms to hum and relax under Adora´s careful hands.

"Let me see," Adora whispers, waiting patiently for Catra´s confirmation nod before rolling her shirt up over her back. Adora holds her breath, Catra can hear it even there, shaken and heartbroken."Okay. Okay"

Catra doesn´t want to know but she imagines. Purple, long, steady across her back and waist. The belt is a Weaver favorite when she is in a particular nasty mood. Catra is surprised that she hasn´t sprained her spine with it yet; she has seen very similar marks on her arms and legs since she was eleven years old and for some reason her own mother blamed her for death.

Now Adora runs her fingertips over the marks and Catra hears her hold her breath, bite back a scream, gulp down the sob. It is sad, it is always sad hearing the person you love crying over seeing you in pain. A sad kind of comfort.

"That bad, uh?" Catra tries to joke but there are tears already rolling down her cheeks.

Catra wants to cry for Adora too because Catra knows Adora also bears marks in her own body. Also quiet, also unfair. Red and bleeding, jarred and acute with pain. Catra has seen them too before. Sometimes Catra wonders what exactly did they both do to end here.

"I´m going to help you change," Adora whispers, quickly brushing the tears from her eyes and helping Catra sit over the mattress.

Adora makes sure Catra is not going to fall down and seeks for silently permission before starting rolling the leggings all the way down, across Catra´s hips and thighs and past her legs, revealing the matching bruises from Weaver´s furious outburst over a fucking car. Adora does not say anything but Catra can feel her tears rolling down the skin of her ankles.

Then Adora takes the end of the shirt and slowly starts to pull it off too, tearing her gaze away from Catra´s lace bralette and covering her immediately in the old blue blanket over the bed. Covering her body and her bruises and her vulnerability from the cold.

"Wow," Catra murmurs, managing an edge of joking wonder in her voice. "We are going fast on this love affair of ours"

It hits her goal because Adora chuckles, shaking her head softly at Catra´s attempt to not freak them both. Adora is dressing her back again too, slipping the softest joggers and lacing them over her hips and then carefully running a soap smelling and also soft shirt over Catra´s head, careful not to strain her back on the way.

"These are your clothes" Catra points out, caressing the fabric between her fingers. Gray joggers, white long sleeved shirt, the red sneakers Adora laces on her feet. Not white and gold. Adora's.

"Yes." Adora leans behind Catra, running her fingers over the matted curls and pushing them all back into a tender braid. There is still blood on the strands. "Come on sweetheart, I'm taking you to the hospital"

Catra's owl eyes widen with alarm, her breath hitching inside her throat. She has never stepped away from telling the world exactly what Weaver is. But it feels different now, it feels like, if she does, Weaver might actually kill her. She was so mad last night.

"But–"

“Cat, you were in a car crash. I need you to let them check your head and your thorax and I need you to rest. I'm taking you.” Adora's voice is on edge, scared, and Catra does not need to remind herself the reason why.

Adora already lost everyone in a car once, if Catra is bleeding internally and fucking dies Adora won't make it a second time. It's that thought what makes Catra gather herself from enough guts to accept. She can't completely fight the fear in her body though.

“I can't leave,” Catra insists, frantic suddenly.

“You can.” Adora insists back just as stubbornly, running her arm below Catra's bruised waist and above her shoulders, gently guiding her up. “You are with me”

“She will beat me again”

“Well then she'll have to fucking beat me first,” Adora spats and it is only there that Catra realizes just how absolutely mad she is. Adora is angry, she is *furious,* barely contained in order to softly wrap Catra in her arms and guide her across the attic and past the door.

“How are you here?” Catra asks after a second, turning her head to look at Adora's handsome face. The crook of her nose, the twitch of her thick eyebrows, the frown of her lips. She is so beautiful, Catra missed her so much. “We– Weaver, did Weaver let you in?”

“I used the spare key and came through the kitchen,” Adora explains, shrugging. As if sneaking on the house was a daily task. It's kind of hot, to be honest, seeing Adora rebellious and angry, sneaking into the house and stealing Catra away. Or at least for Catra's beaten up head. She is still kind of dizzy and Adora is hot. “Come on. You are staying with me from now on”

“Okay,” Catra lets her head roll against Adora’s shoulder, breathing in her perfume.

Her waist and legs are killing her, she hadn't noticed it when she was laying down but now that the soft fabric brushes over the bruises, she can feel them completely.

Catra wrinkles her nose, aching. “They itch”

“I know, baby”

Adora helps her down the attic and the stairs towards the lower level, her arms firmly held around Catra's shivering shoulders, her other hand holding Catra's thin fingers in hers. Catra is cold, it has been raining and the attic is damp so Catra is cold.

They make it down slowly but sure, feet firmly over the floor. The door is right in front of them but they don't make it further than the kitchen, stopped by a voice rising next to them. In a way, it would have been a miracle they had managed to sneak out unnoticed.

“Adora, darling,” Weaver says, resting her hip against the frame of the kitchen. There is a full glass with wine in her fingers, as always, her garnet dress tight around her body. Her mouth twists into a smile but her green eyes speak of something very differently, running from Adora's face to Catra tucked next to her. “What are you doing here?”

Catra feels Adora tense next to her, her breath dropping inside her chest. She can feel every single muscle wrapped around her tightening next to her, tense as an archer's cord about to snap, her pulse speeding up immediately.

For a moment Catra wonders what is about to happen, for a moment she just wants to live in the space between Adora's neck and her hand where Adora keeps her guarded from Weaver's sharp sight.

“I´m taking Catra for a walk,” Adora answers after a beat, her back straight. It's a lie for Catra's sake and everyone in the room knows it but Adora says it so surely and firmly that it feels like a truth.

“A walk,” Weaver repeats, blinking very slowly. She stares directly at Catra's face when she speaks but Adora shelters her with her hair, keeping Weaver's eyes away. “Why?”

“Because she is my girlfriend”

Catra cannot see Adora's face looking at Weaver - harsh, stone cold, angry, regarding the woman as if she was about to throw herself over her and tear her throat into pieces - but she can feel her and she can feel the tenderness washing over her own cheeks, pushing everything dark and nasty aside.

It's not even about Adora defending her in front of her mother, or because of her bravery. It's about Adora calling Catra *girlfriend,* about referring to her as something that is hers, something shared, tender, sweet. It's the only thing Catra ever wanted and now she has it, even if she is bruised and her mother is staring at Catra from the kitchen.

“Your girlfriend,” Weaver repeats slowly, lowering the glass. Her face darkens completely.

Adora's hold on Catra grows tighter, her eyes stormy and so blue they look bright among the darkness of the corridor. “Yes”

“And, might I know, when this marvelous union happened?”

*Just a few days ago* , Catra thinks taking a breath, *Before you hurt me again, I was already loved. Just a few days ago.* But then again it feels like a whole time already, like a piece finally falling into place, something good in their lives that was only theirs to have.

Adora is not quiet. She is not quiet on her body or in her words or in her voice. She neither screams nor yells nor reproaches but she is loud. Like a firecracker, like a harpy, loud.

“Don´t worry, Miss Weaver. I´ll be sure to let you know properly next time” Adora says, voice sincere but firm, calculated. Her touch is soft around Catra but everything else in her is tight.

It throws Weaver off, who considers Adora beautiful and perfect, who sees her and doesn't see Marlena but Randor’s eyes and remembers the life she wanted for herself. Who cannot understand why she hangs from the arm of a child that she doesn't love.

“Next time?”

“Yes,” Adora nods, form as a mountain, “When I ask her to marry me”

*Oh.* Catra snaps her eyes from her mother's progressively angrier face to Adora, inhaling sharply. Adora does not turn to look back at her but she rubs tender circles with her thumb over Catra's knuckles, a quiet reassurance. Tender and sweet.

Weaver clicks her teeth together so sharply that she bites herself, blood filling her gums and making her choke on spit, wine and breath.

“Ah,” Weaver murmurs after a while, clenching her jaw. “I see”

Adora doesn't wait for her to say anything else. Instead of going through the kitchen door she approaches the main one, still holding Catra's hand but allowing her to make her way on her own as much as she can. She knows just how important it is for Catra to do this on her own, to face Weaver and walk on her own two feet away from her.

Catra straightens her back and walks with sure steps across her own home, guarding all the honor she has left and not sparing a single look back at her mother. She can feel her green eyes burning in the side of her face and can feel the threat on them, the promise of even worse once Catra is back, but she keeps walking, holding her breath and not looking back.

Adora does look back. They are one step closer to leaving, the door is open and the air of the day brushes on their face. They are so close but Adora feels Weaver´s stare too so she tilts her

head to the side and meets Weaver´s eyes with her, chewing the words inside her mouth.

“Miss Weaver?” She calls and her voice is sweet but Catra knows her, and she knows that voice. The same kind that she always wore around the forest, hunting and dangerously quiet.

Weaver´s entire face shifts, suddenly bright at Adora calling for her so sweetly. “Yes, darling?”

Catra knows Adora but Weaver doesn´t, not at all, nobody else knows this side of Adora. Weaver doesn´t even notice it is on purpose, she doesn´t notice it's a trap.

“She is mine”

Weaver blinks, confused by Adora´s words. “What?

“She is mine,” Adora repeats, holding Catra´s hand, looking at Weaver´s eyes. Adora is eighteen, her face is a mask and she is furious and for a second it makes Weaver afraid. “So don't put your hands on her ever again.”

—

“You need to be able to do something, anything at all”

Adora is sitting in the reduced expanse of a doctor's office, uncomfortable chair and chlorine smelling air and white walls. In a way it even looks like Light Hope's house.

Angella Bright and Detectives Huntara are on the other side of the desk. Angella sitting, Huntara standing and looking at the window. There is a camera in Huntara’s hands and she is very quiet, refusing to turn around and see Adora at all.

Adora is sick of that camera. The flash made her dizzy as she held Catra's hands in her while Huntara flashed picture after picture of her waist and legs, proof of purple bruises and aching bones. Proof that will be left on the limbo, as always, because this is the

Mayor's niece and Angella Bright cannot let this slip. She cannot allow for the people of the town to find out that the Mayor allows his own sister to beat her child, it's not good business and Angella is excellent about business.

"Maybe, maybe I don´t know, she could go somewhere else. She could come with me," Adora insists when nobody answers her, panting heavily. She is still trying to do this the right way, she is still trying to ask for help. But nobody comes to their aid.

"Adora, both of you are under the legal watch of your caretakers until you are twenty one, you know this," Angela says very slowly, as if Adora was stupid, folding her hands over the wood.

"Then you take her," Adora exhales, choking with her own breath. Angella is already shaking her pink head.

"She is not my daughter, why would I do that?" It sounds and it feels cold and it sucks.

Adora recoils at the words but Angella is unmoving and Huntara is still giving her back to her. Angella sighs after a beat, taking in Adora's expression. She leans over her forearms towards Adora and regards her with an apologetic stare, so well studied and place that makes Adora want to slap her across the face.

"I am sorry, but Weaver is her mother and sometimes mothers are harsh. She also crashed her car, Adora. She was drunk, underage and destroyed a pretty expensive car. Catrina is very lucky Weaver didn´t raise charges against her."

"But-"

"Whatever is happening there we cannot do anything for now." Angella raises her hand, shutting Adora down. She leans back on the chair and sighs, regarding Adora´s frantic stare with stone eyes. "Maybe you should just lay back a little bit. My daughter Glimmer, I know she is a friend of yours. She likes you. Spend some time with her. And Bow."

Angella stands up and Huntara moves too, pushed by the movement as if it was a silent signal. They are not even discrete with what they are doing; Huntara takes the card from the camera and hands it to Angella, who saves it inside her briefcase quickly. The Mayor elections are in a week.

"I´m sure things will resolve themselves with Catrina and her mother," Angella adds, palming Adora in the back before leaving the office completely.

Huntara frowns down at her, looking from Adora to the window of the office where the room Catra still is in awaits.

"Behave," Huntara warns, walking out too.

Adora exhales, looking at some errand point of the desk before looking to her sides, across the window too. She catches Catra´s eyes from across the half closed blinds, looking back at her with tired eyes. She holds Adora´s eyes on hers and very softly shakes her head, her shoulders flopping forward.

They are together again and they only have each other.

## Three Years Ago

## Spring, The Cabin

Adora is over Catra, Catra is resting over the duvet, their skins are a tender contrast with each other, bare and sweet. It´s a golden day of spring  outside and there are crickets singing on their windows. It´s kind of fun.

There is perspiration on their shoulders and neck and Adora's collarbones are of a deep shade of pink. They haven't even done anything yet but they are naked on each other's arms and their legs are braided together. Like this, the warm and tender skin of their cores kiss softly everytime one of them moves, Adora's against Catra's hips, Catra's against Adora's thigh.

Adora leans back from their kiss with a soft puff of air, resting her forehead against Catra´s so she can see her beautiful face. Catra ´s face is dusted with a tender shade of pink, her eyes shimmering when she looks back at Adora. Her lips are red and kiss bitten after an entire hour brushing together, the pads of her fingers running softly across Adora´s temples and the bare curve of her waist.

"Hey," Catra whispers, smiling softly. Her eyes are the most tender Adora has ever seen them before, voice sore by the kissing and the feeling of their bodies sliding together.

Adora smiles back at her, tucking one of the curls of her bangs behind her ear. "Hey"

It's their first time like this. For Catra, it's her first time doing it for love. It matters, so much more than anything before, it matters.

"Are you nervous?" Catra asks gently, nuzzling on the pillow below her head. The air is warm between their bodies and she feels soft everywhere. There is a little bit of a tremor on Adora´s arms that Catra tries to tamper with her lips over her skin, smiling around the soft gasp coming from Adora´s throat.

"A little bit" Adora admits, pressing Catra´s palm against her cheek, lacing their slightly clammy fingers together."You?"

"A lot," Catra says with an exhale, dissolving into a stupid giggle. Catra, giggling, how dumb, how wonderful.

Adora smiles and wiggles closer to her, pressing their noses together into a tender touch. They smell like each other, Like fruit and candy and the woods where they are right now, the only corner of the world left where they can feel safe, where they can do this for the first time and be together and guarded.

"Tell me what you like," Adora asks Catra, running her blunt nails over the curves and corners and Catra´s soft belly. It rips a sore gasp out of Catra´s mouth, her eyes darkening impossible more, like two new moons hung between the stars of her freckles.

“I don't know,” Catra says, ears red. She knows she did once but she learnt nothing from it and she took nothing from it either. She knows her body, but she doesn't know anything else. “This, Adora this feels like – um”

Adora catches Catra´s nervousness, the red of her cheeks and the pale of her forehead and her heart grows incredibly more fond of her with each second. Adora caresses Catra´s sweaty forehead with her thumb reassuring her  with her touch

“First time around here?”

Catra exhales, nodding. “I– Yeah”

Adora´s grin twitches, a spark of mirth in her eyes. She hums and leans the side of her own face against her closed fist, regarding Catra below her with a mischievous, joyful grin.

“Yeah, y´know? Me too. You're in luck I'm naturally gifted though,” she whispers, wiggling her eyebrows.

Catra snorts, a giggle escaping her lips as she presses her hand over the side of Adora´s face and pushes her softly away from her, laughing out loud when Adora tickles her on the ribs in return.

“You're so dumb,” Catra whispers, rolling her eyes. She drums her fingers over the ragged edges of Adora´s waist, tending to the fading and newest scars of the bramble brooms with sweetness. “I don't know, Adora, I guess we'll have to do trial and error”

Adora´s grin fails her a little, her mouth and eyebrows falling into a sad stare. She pouts, *pouts* out of all things, nose wrinkling adorably.

“I don't want to fail you with this”

Catra would laugh again if she wasn´t so breathless by realizing Adora is actually in her arms, naked and pouting after kissing her senseless.

“It's not failing, princess,” Catra reassures her and reassures herself because she also doesn´t want to fail her but she knows this will take them some time to learn. Each other in a way that they have never done before. “It's just - finding what we like and what we don't. We'll get there eventually.”

Adora considers it, tilting her head slightly to the side. She lingers her mouth over Catra's small breast and then very slowly moves her hips forward, thrusting her thigh against Catra's folds sweetly.

Catra presses her head against the pillow and her eyes roll back, the most honest of moans falling off her tongue between them, thick and sweet. Her cheeks bloom like roses and her pupils dilate so much they overtake inside her eyes, reflecting Adora's face on them.

“ *Ha* ”

Adora looks at her as if she was the sun and all the stars. Her own cheeks burn red and warm and her mouth falls open into a slit, an exhale full of wonder leaving her mouth when she allows her hand to lower down and caress her way between the petals of Catra's sex, damp against her fingers and warm.

Catra rolls her head to the side and moans again, her voice lowering into a soft whimper against Adora's lips when the latter leans towards her and presses their mouths together again, holding her across the tremors of her body relaxing against this newfound and beautiful pleasure.

Adora smiles, wrapping Catra’s waist inside her palm. “Was that okay?”

“Absolutely, yes” Catra sighs with a smile, her cheeks blooming with red. She wraps her arms around Adora's neck and brings her close until their breasts touch, sharing their warmth. “I like you being here, above me”

“I like it too” Adora dips her face against Catra's neck and she doesn't choke her, or bite her, or hurt her. She kisses her, painting

promises against her skin. “I can hug you”

Just as Catra said, it's a bit of a trial and try again; and just as Adora said, she seems to be naturally gifted with everything that has to do with pleasing Catra. With loving Catra.

The small cabin fills with the sounds of their love making and their laughter, showered in golden light and honest words of love. *I love you,* to each other time and time again.

Catra is not cold anymore. She is warm, she is the warmest she has ever been, so much that it makes her hum with a song. It makes her sleepy.

Adora kisses her neck and Catra is warm and happy. She will make it alive out of this.

**New Year's Eve, Almost a Year Ago**

**Five in the afternoon**

**The Street**

*… I don´t belong to you, Catra! …*

Adora parks in front of the house, sighing deeply.

She is right outside Catra's house, the winter air cold. The street is empty and quiet, almost unnervingly so, as if the neighborhood has hidden from the winter day.

The clock in the dashboard says it's five on the evening, on point

Adora leans back on the car seat looking at the dark paint of the quiet house and then away, towards the line of trees. She is here, at five on point as she promised, yet she cannot seem able to move, to walk out of the car and ring the door. Not just yet.

She needs to get out the expression in Light Hope's eyes out of her system first. She needs to shake herself off her absolute fury when Adora told her she would go for Catra and left the Bright Manor just about to start the dinner. She needs to pray the redness in her cheek where Light Hope slapped her slows down before Catra sees her because there is no world where Adora wants to see her sad. She had already failed her so much today.

*I'm coming for you right now* , Adora sends a message to Catra and the clock marks five o'one. Her phone dings inside her palms and she takes a look at it, hoping it is Catra answering back just for her face to pale when Light Hope's ID comes into view.

***LH || Come back here, right now***

***LH || You are making a mistake***

**5:02 pm**

For a long time when she was younger, Light Hope scared Adora and for a long time too she hoped Mara would come back one night and take both Adora and Catra away from her.

Light Hope always looks at Adora like a walking disappointment. Maybe it is because she shares her eyes with Mara, or because her love for Catra and her rebellion about loving her reminds Light Hope too much of what was lost the day Mara left.

Catra looks at Adora like she was something wonderful, always all the time. No matter what she does, no matter how, not even when Adora is breaking her heart, Catra always looks at her like she was the most precious thing for her, the dearest for her heart.

***LH || You know what this means***

***LH || Ten flogs for every minute you are late***

**5:04 pm**

Adora exhales, leaning her head against the wheel, taking a second, a minute, maybe two. Maybe five more, or just one. The clock of the car marks 5:05 pm, she is five minutes late. It only takes a second for your life to crumble into pieces.

“Ahhh!”

Adora snaps her head to the side, towards the house, frowning deeply. The neighborhood is quiet, the tops of the trees are moving violently with a new come breeze, threatening to rip their branches clean off their trunks and making the leaves fall over the street and the roof of the car in dry rain. Adora holds her breath, listening.

“AHHHH!”

It´s a yell. A scream.

Catra is screaming.

Adora is out of the car and running in a second, the door open and slamming against the car. She thinks she feels the eyes of the neighborhood on her, on the car, but she thinks she also feels the blinds close down again, tight. Adora does not pay attention to them.

She slams herself against the main door, tugging on the doorknob violently and without success. It's tightly closed and Adora cannot come in. She tries to look past the expensive fabric of the thick curtains but they are also closed, keeping her outside and unable to see more.

“Mom, please,” Adora hears Catra whisper at the other side and she knows she is crying, she can almost hear it. “Please”

Two shots go off.

Adora gasps, tears falling from her eyes, feeling the pain in her own body as if inflicted to her flesh. She cannot hear Catra

anymore and bile and fear pools on the back of Adora´s throat, choking her like an invisible hand around her heart.

She runs to the other side, jumping past the dry bushes of the garden and reaching the kitchen door. She jumps on her feet and catches the loose tile above the frame where Catra keeps a spare key for Adora to use, sliding it quickly on the lock and pushing the door open immediately. She throws herself inside, not even thinking or stopping to watch.

## The Kitchen

She slips on the kitchen floor, falling hard on her side, all the air leaving her lungs with a painful wheeze. Adora is dizzy for a second, looking around her, confused as to why she had slipped in the first place.

Her legs and her entire side feel somehow wet, soaking through her pristine white clothes. It´s strange, it doesn´t feel like water, it feels thicker and it smells like salt. Blindly, Adora lowers her fingers against the floor and gathers the wetness on her skin, bringing it to her face to look at it better.

It´s red, thick, growing every second. It´s blood. Adora´s palms and clothes are soaked in blood.

The body in front of her is laying on her side, struggling to breath, a wheeze and a gurgling cough every single time she tries to inhale. Her curls are soaked and matted on her own blood, chin and cheeks painted in red. And Adora can´t even see her neck but a horrid, pulsing mesh of flesh, right above her pulse point right above the place where Adora has rested her lips time and time again, drowsing off to the sound of her chest when she sleeps.

Catra´s eyes are bright and wide, looking at Adora fallen next to her and also looking at nothing at all, pain and shock clogging her consciousness. She opens and closes her mouth as if she wanted

to scream, her neck is open and she is bleeding to death. Catra is dying, dying and Adora´s clothes are soaked in her.

"Adora," Weaver´s voice comes, slow and thick, barely even words at all.

She is drunk. Adora knows this even before she turns to look at her, even before she gathers enough strength to look away from Catra´s bleeding body and towards her mother.

Weaver is standing a few feet away from the kitchen, fighting to keep her balance with the frame of the wall. She is sweating a little, washing the thick makeup on her cheeks and forehead, and her green eyes are wide and gone, gone, completely crazy as she looks at Adora with a grin in her lips and a laugh in her voice.

The wide mirror in the wall behind her is completely destroyed, broken, two small holes where the two gunshots crashed against the surface. Weaver´s face is bleeding a little, a single red drop falling from a scratch on her cheek made by the bullet, brushing so close to her head yet so far away. Catra is an excellent shooter but she has never been a killer.

"Adora, darling, what on earth are you doing on the floor?" Weaver asks, smiling widely. She is acting as if Catra wasn´t bleeding in the floor by her own hand, as if she didn´t even exist at all.

There is a gun on the floor, near Catra´s knee. And a shattered glass of wine rolled on the opposite side. Adora can see the pieces of sharp glass dug into Catra´s neck. She heard Catra sing this morning, she kissed her against blue sheets, they fought this morning, they should be on the mountains and Catra is bleeding to death.

It´s like a nightmare, it is so surreal for Adora that she hasn´t even said anything, eyes wide and breath gone. On the floor next to her Catra shakes from head to toe.

“Ah yes, her.” What a bitch Weaver is. She blinks down at Catra´s gurgling red body and sighs, shaking her head. As if her own daughter was nothing but an expensive piece of fine glass that has decided to tether into the floor and break. As if this wasn´t the love of Adora´s life. “Do not worry about her, Adora. In fact, you won´t have to worry about her anymore.”

Weaver giggles, running her fingers across the raven strands of her hair. Her hands are also soaked in red. She did it with her bare hands. Adora presses her palms over the floor, knees over blood soaked linoleum, the ponytail tugging on her forehead and temples painfully.

“I´ve spoken with Light Hope and with Prime, they have all such high hope for you. All of us do, Adora. And now? Now you don´t have to sacrifice your future for a girl that will do nothing but hold you down.” Weaver points at Catra´s agonizing body with a red finger. “I should know about it, I gave birth to her after all. Wasted years, wasted youth. But now we can all make the life we truly deserve!”

Adora stands up in wobbly feet, fighting with every single inch of her body so as to not fall down. Her fingers ache, wrapped around the hold of the gun, feeling with the tips the carved initials of Prime´s real name. She can feel Catra´s blood dripping down her legs and soaking her feet past the golden sandals, the smell of her life leaving her body choking Adora. Her entire body is shaking but her hand is not.

“My brother loves you, Adora, almost as much as he did to the whore of your mother,” Weaver says, spitting saliva in her excitement. “He wants you to be by his side, his successor in the First One´s eyes. Light Hope wants that too, all of your life has been guided towards that future, don´t you see? And what a bright future it will be, the entire town already adores you. The golden angel that survived death.”

*Murder, murder, murder,* Adora´s head screams, hammering in her temples and nose. Her parents, murdered. Her brother, murdered.

Her aunt, murdered. Her cousin, gone.

Catra, murdered. Murdered. Murder, murder, murder, murder …

“She is worthless, Adora!” Weaver is screaming now, frantic and furious against Adora´s heavy silence.

Adora gives a step forward, Weaver a step back, a kind of dance Adora learnt in the forest, chasing for a prey, about to shoot it down, about to twist its neck inside her palms. Adora has always been a murderer, she has only been holding back.

“A worthless, tragic piece of shit. I´m just helping her to die, don´t you see? Just leave her there, just let her go and leave–!”

Bang and oh, what a delight. Adora is an excellent shooter too, but unlike the other half of her soul, she does crave for blood.

Weaver falls on her side, gasping for air, convulsing on the expensive floor with pain. The bullet crosses clean across the side of her ribcage, ripping muscles and lung and making a home on her rib. It´s not a lethal shot but Adora didn´t wanted it to be. Adora has never failed a wound in her entire life, she is not about to start now.

Adora walks across the corridors of Catra´s childhood, the gun steady inside her hand, smoke rising white towards her face. She stares at Weaver´s face scrunched with pain and agony, looks at her dress soaking darker and darker with the blood sipping across the fabric and Weaver´s hands shaking as she tries to blindly control the blood loss, looking back at Adora with such a face that is almost foreign in her. She is scared, Weaver is scared. That´s good because Adora is going to murder her.

“Wait, Adora, wait,” Weaver gasps, raising her red hand. “I– I know you are confused, I´d be confused too. She has wrapped you on her fingers, I– I get it, she is so good at it. But I– I love you, Adora, alright? I love you like the daughter I never had.”

That's funny. The daughter she did have is an angel. Adora has always known this, Catra is an angel, sauntered out of heaven to sing. She stumbled with Adora in the ground and chose to love her, choose to save her, even knowing Adora would always be stained in blood in a way or another. It's funny because the only angel of this town is Catra and they have stoned her to death.

"Don´t hurt me, Adora, please. Don´t do it," Weaver is begging now, begging for her life.

Catra begged for her life too and now behind Adora she is choking on her own blood, scratching the floor with her nails and crying. She is scared, in the end, and she is suffering. Adora feels her blood boiling and her stomach into knots. She feels her soul strained and held by the only thread of holiness that is Catra´s breath and feels it growing thinner and thinner with every single second.

"She doesn´t love you, she will never learn how to love the real you," Weaver is frantic now, crawling to her knees, holding herself to the white pants and Adora´s forearms. She leaves red marks in the form of fingers and palms over her skin. "Just let me live, alright? Give me your mercy and we both will make it out of here. You´ll have everything anyone would ever want."

Bang. That´s nice. It´s a nice gun, expensive, Prime bought it for his sister in hope she would snap one day, he knows her very well after all. Adora doesn´t know this but she can feel it in the warm material of the gun.

The bullet crosses Weaver´s throat, right through the windpipe, from the middle of the neck to the other side, shattering cervicals and spine with it. Weaver´s body goes limp, from the shoulders to the toes, disconnected from the rest of her in a shot so clean it is almost frightening. Adora is glad because this means that she will never move again; it means that she will never raise her hands against Catra again and she will never be able to hurt her again.

Weaver is gurgling with her own blood now too, huffing, choking, tasting the bitter taste of death on her tongue too. It´s a mocking mirror of what she has done to Catra, of the way Catra is suffering right now and still, it is not enough.

It will never be enough. Adora wants to drink her blood. She wants to tear her skin and rip her limbs with her teeth and feast on the slow beating of her heart as she dies. She wants to dig her nails on her chest and pull apart her lungs and her teeth off her body slowly, one by one, She wants to hold her spine between her fingertips and knot it away like a broken tapestry because maybe this way the broken, rotten part inside Weaver that keeps her from knowing how to love Catra will fixed. And if it can´t be fixed then Adora will burn her bones and spit on her ashes and dance in her graveyard because how dare she. How dare she?

"Let–" Weaver is saying, trying to say, her green eyes overcome by darkness, scleras bloodshot by the pressure and the agony, looking at every side with frantic speed. Like a doll long ago broken, defective from fabric, finally being stomped over by the sole of a hurting child. "Let– l–let her die. Ler her die. Let her die! Let her die! LET HER DIE!"

Bang. Adora could write sonnets or death letters about this, about these seconds where blood sprays behind Weaver´s head and crashes on the floor, perfectly still, almost too perfectly, her face forever etched in a second of rabid hate and surprise, mouth open, perfectly placed hole of the bullet in the middle of her forehead. Another perfect shot.

But she is still breathing and she is still blinking at Adora, looking at Adora´s bright blue eyes and this is the last thing she will ever see. The red of blood reflected in Adora´s eyes, drowning them in red. The pull of her mouth into a snarl, the quiet wrath painted on her face and her voice, the golden of her hair stained in Catra´s blood.

This is the last thing Weaver will ever see and she doesn´t even deserve that, the end of her own gun, her own weapon brought

to life by rage, looking back at her and opening its fauces to eat her whole as Adora presses on the trigger and shoots her again and again and again and again and again in the face. One after the other, bang, shot, bullet, blood. Bang, shot, bullet, blood. Over and over again,

Bullet, bullet, shot, shot, shot, again, again, blood, blood. Blood. It´s not pretty, it´s not nice, it´s not perfect. It aches, it's gory and bloodbound and disgusting. It´s flesh against the floor and blood and saliva, tongue on the forehead and eyes on the mouth. Bones splintered and open, blood overflowing, brains on the carpet.

Adora goes on and on until she cannot do it anymore, until there is not a face anymore to shoot into, to feast into, to rip her way across. Until the gun clicks and stucks when the bullets go empty and even then Adora fills the need to kneel over the dead body and tear it apart until nobody else can´t make off her bones. But she cannot.

Catra wheezes behind her and Adora let´s go of blood thirst and the gun immediately, turning on her ankles and rushing at her side. Her soles leave footprints behind and she doesn´t spare a look back to Weaver anymore.

Adora falls heavily on her knees, carefully rolling Catra into her back, brushing her dark hair out of her face with now trembling fingers. There is only one thing that will ever make Adora shiver and that is Catra and Catra alone.

Her neck is a mess, a mesh of blood and flesh dripping and sipping into Adora´s fingers when she presses the pads over the deep wound, brushing her jaw with the heel of her palm. It feels wrong, *wrong,* to rest her hand of Catra´s most vulnerable part and feel it bleeding, soaking red, shivering and cold. It´s feels wrong to touch Catra and feel her fading away in her hands when her arms where supposed to keep her warm.

“Cat” Adora finally says after so long in silence, her throat screaming with pain. She hadn´t even realized she was screaming the entire time. Tears fall from her pale eyelashes and crash sweetly against Catra´s cheeks, washing red and pain away. “Catra, oh sweetheart.”

Adora gathers her inside her arms, cradling her away from the cold floor and against her chest. Catra is looking at her, her eyes wide, her pupils like pinpoints, pale as a ghost and red everywhere. She opens her mouth and tries to speak but she gurgle instead, a spray of blood staining Adora´s face, It´s horrid.

Adora pushes back the need to tear her own neck into pieces and fishes for her phone from her pocket, dialing the numbers quickly and throwing it back on the floor with the speaker on, supporting Catra´s body and pressing against the wound to try and slow the blood loss. Catra already feels so faint in her arms, a piece of light fading away.

*“911, what's your emergency?”*

“I need an ambulance now!” Adora yells, leaning her cheek against Catra´s forehead. She reassures her with a sweet voice, rocking her softly in her arms to try and subdue the panic rising inside Catra´s ragged chest.

Catra brings her trembling hand up, shaking so badly that her bones crack with each other, making even her teeth shiver. She digs her nails on the hair tie keeping all of Adora´s hair up and snaps it in half, letting the golden and copper strands fall softly around her face in waves. A curtain of gold keeping them away from the rest of the world.

Adora does not realize it but the only thing Catra wants to see when she dies is Adora´s face, not the blood on the floor or her mother or the poor old house but her and her alone. Catra wants to hear Adora´s heart beating against her ear like she does right now and look at her beautiful face and die.

*"Where are you?"*

"Fright Zone Street, number 66. Capellan´s House." Catra chokes on blood, rushing out of her nostrils and dripping on her chin. It´s horrible, dying, and Catra cannot help but shake in fear by it, trembling inside Adora´s arms. Adora sobs, cleaning Catra´s tears and blood with her thumb. "Oh baby, it´s okay."

*"Capellan´s House did you say?"* On the other side of the line the operator sighs, a tone so charged with condescendance and annoyance that it turns Adora´s blood into ice. *"Lady, as we have said countless times before, personal and family discussions are not a matter of concern for emergency services. If you have a problem please go to the Mayor´s family office for a formal complaint"*

"What are you talking about?! My– my girlfriend is bleeding out!" Adora turns around to scream at the phone and it´s a tremendous loss because Catra mourns her immediately, whimpering in her arms, her shaking fingers seeking back for Adora, brushing against her jaw and painting it in red.

*"Ah. Did she do it to herself then?"*

"No!"

*"Are you sure it´s an emergency and not a call for attention?"*

"I´m Adora Montenegro!" Adora screams, slamming her fist against the floor. It echoes in the otherwise deadly quiet house. Adora wonders if any other neighbor heard the commotion, Catra knows none of them care. "Get a fucking ambulance here, right now!"

*"Miss Montenegro!"* The operator says, surprised, her tone changing immediately into something much more professional. " *I didn´t recognize you. Yes of course, are you alright? Where are you hurt?"*

“NOW!” Adora slams her fists again, this time right against the screen, shattering it completely, the phone going dark and quiet again.

She doesn´t even bother to read Light Hope´s incoming and increasingly angrier messages. They are the ones that made Adora late. They did this, Weaver did this, and Light Hope and Hordak and Prime and Angella. And Adora. Adora did this.

“Adora,” Catra gasps around a mouthful of blood, resting her temple against Adora´s shoulder. Adora sobs, incapable of cleaning her own tears so they just fall against Catra´s freckles, tinted in red.

“I´m here,” Adora assures her, choking on her own words, on her own need to reassure her. “I got you. I got you, okay? I came, I came for you. You are going to be alright.”

Catra is crying and it's Adora´s worst nightmare. Blood, sweat, tears, and Catra´s breath is still sweet against Adora´s cheeks when the latter leans to kiss Catra´s forehead tenderly, her hand slipping with blood and her chest completely stained in red.

“I– I don´t want to die. I´m not– I´m not ready,” Catra´s voice is different, choked, pained. It's agony every single word, rolling off sliced vocal cords and into the space between them. Quiet voice, frightened voice. “I don´t want to go.”

“You are not going to die,” Adora snaps, curling into herself at the sharp sound of her own voice, ashamed to even raise it to Catra in the first place. But Catra does not curl or flinch again from her, instead she melts, taking her last solace in Adora´s words even if Catra knows they cannot be true. “You are going to be just fine and we will go to the cabin and camping and we are going to go to college. Together. Alright? We´ll go to Horde and we´ll graduate and have boring jobs. We are going to get married and have pets and a beautiful life.”

Catra sobs, looking up at Adora´s beautiful face with sad eyes. Adora looks so desperate, so heartbroken and pained that it makes Catra cry for her, cry for her tears and the way her heart is so clearly breaking against Catra´s sliced neck. Catra cried for Adora´s pale cheeks and the sad edge of her eyes and the way she is trembling so hard neither of them know where one starts and the other ends. They love each other so much, so honest. It ´s not fair.

"I´m sorry. For everything," Catra whispers because if she is going to go, if she is going to leave Adora here, she needs to say this to Adora first. She needs to make her understand that nothing of this is her fault. She needs Adora to stay, just a second longer. "You– you, *ngh,* you don´t belong to me but I just- I just wanted to have you a little longer."

It´s a stab on Adora´s heart and Adora is left breathless from it. Poor murderer, she said the words and pushed her love away on this day. Poor Adora, she will always think this is her fault. Poor thing, she thinks Adora does not love her enough to stay. Poor Catra, she thinks she is going to die. Poor brides, they are losing each other.

"No, no. No baby, you have me." Adora chokes, whimpering so sadly that it sounds like a heart ripping. "I´m yours, I´m here. I ´m right here holding you, I´m not going anywhere."

Catra´s eyelids are so heavy. Adora smells like home and Catra is tired but she holds herself from her like a lifeline still. "I'm scared"

"I know, baby. I know," Adora´s chin wobbles and tears keep falling down, washing them both in a kind of veil made of sorrow. "I´m here, I´m here. Oh god."

"Just, *ugh* , just stay with me today, okay? Just hold me today, *ngh* , just this time, for me," Catra coughs wet and blood soaked, whimpering with pain. She rests her temples against Adora´s cheek and cradles Adora´s jaw inside shivering fingertips, holding her as close as her body can. "Just while I fall asleep."

“No. Don't fall asleep, don't fall asleep,” Adora is frantic now, poisoned with terror. Her life is leaving, her soul and heart slipping off her fingers like sand. Adora pushes Catra´s bangs off her face, holding her beautiful eyes with hers, holding her blood and her heart. “You are not done yet. Did you hear me? You are not done yet.”

People tell you to be your own person, that you are already whole, but they don´t understand, they don´t understand Catra and Adora. They were woven together on the strings of the universe and have followed each other through countless times. And sometimes one or both or the other might be born dark and broken but they are still each other´s, they belong to each other. It´s not the same. They don´t understand, it is not the same. You cannot tear the earth from the rain or the sun from the sea or the moon from the stars. You cannot tear Catra and Adora apart.

“I– I love you” Catra gasps. A confession, as if she hadn't said it countless times before. As if her first *I love you* hadn't been Adora´s, as if she didn't carry Adora´s heart and humanity and soul inside her quivering nightingale chest. She is so tired, her eyelids can´t keep themselves open anymore. It´s a blessing, looking at Adora´s face and leave. “I love you. Stay with me”

“I love you too. I love you so much,” Adora whispers, pressing a sweet kiss against Catra´s bloodied mouth.

She can feel it too, the moment Catra goes limp inside her arms, the second unconscious reclaims her again, tearing her off Adora´s arms. As if the world was punishing Adora for existing alone, Adora can feel it. She leans away, looking with frantic eyes at Catra´s sleeping face, horror clogging her mouth.

“Catra.” Silence. “Cat? Baby?”

She has seen Catra fall asleep next to her countless times and yet so few. They were supposed to live their entire lives together and die old next to each other. Not like this. It´s not fair.

“Catrina.” Adora snaps calling Catra by her full name, searching for her in the dark and fighting death to let her go. “Catrina, wake up. Wake up,” Adora begs, pleads, holding the pulsing and broken vein with her fingertips, running her lips over Catra´s face, holding her chest against hers. She whispers now, it's instinct to do so, lowering her voice so she doesn´t startle Catra from her sleep, threatening her tenderly, kindly. “Wake up”

She is still breathing but is so slow that it is a feather against Adora´s neck. Her heart is still beating but soul is leaving, barely holding on to life by Adora´s sake alone. She is gone but not completely, she is dead but still breathing, she is in the Underworld and Adora holds onto her fingers and begs her to stay.

“No. No, no, no, no. Don't go, please don't go,” Adora´s voice is panic and horror and chaos and still she is quiet. She loves Catra so loudly how is it possible that her voice is still quiet. “Come back, come back”

Maybe she is not quiet, maybe she is just drowned. Maybe she just needs to hold Catra and take a breath. Maybe that´s the only thing they needed. To stay together, to leave. To scream.

“Catra, Catra. Catra!” There she is, Adora, who she is, breaking her own chains at the foot of her lover´s grave. “CATRA?!”

Adora screams.

She lets her mouth fall open, her lungs to expand, her heart to tear into pieces and she screams. She screams. She screams until the birds and the foxes, and the wolves and the mice and the eagles and the bears and the lambs and the vipers and the swans run away in terror. She screams until the hares turn their back and hide away. She screams until the nightingales get struck by arrows and saunter dead to the floor.

She slams the back of her head against the wall and screams, again and again, hit, scream, hit, scream until her nape is

bleeding. She holds Catra in her arms and cradles her against her neck and screams. She holds her own hair inside her fingers and screams. She smells Catra´s body and tastes her blood in her throat and screams. She feels the love of her life, half of her soul, heart and holiness, dying in her arms and screams. Adora screams.

“My love, my love. No, no!” When they were seventeen Adora left for thirteen months. When they were twenty, Adora let her go. At five in the evening, she was five minutes late. It just takes one. “No, please, Catra! Please stay. No, no. NO!”

Adora holds Catra´s warm body inside her cold and bare hands and feels her bleed out and she screams. She is not quiet anymore.

—

The paramedics make it there a whole half an hour later.

The house is a bloodbath, Weaver is already rotting in the carpet. All the neighbors heard the turmoil, the fight. They didn't know exactly what happened but they guessed. None of them called for aid.

Adora is unmoving, her back resting against the kitchen’s wall, Catra cradled in her arms, both soaked in red.

Adora's eyes are terrible, focused to some void point in the distant wall as she presses her palm fully and firm over the gashing wound on Catra's neck, her nails clipping the vein, her tears filling her bloodstream. It's the only thing keeping her alive, crimson soaking Adora's fingers, washing Catra´s freckles away.

Every once in a while Catra gurgles in her own blood and the sound is so horrid that it will haunt Adora's dreams forever

Catra’s breathing is so shallow. It's a miracle she is alive at all

There was always something different in Adora, something wrong. She knew it since she was a child, even younger than when she first met Catra. She knew it since she placed traps for mice and enjoyed sitting on the grass watching them tearing themselves apart. She knew it since she stared at the blood of her parents hunting for another reason than a hobby, like something calculating, like a sport, like a goal. Adam was not like this, maybe her mother was, she never knew. Maybe it was Serenia.

There has always been something kind of rotten, kind of twisted. She has always heard the whisper in her ears and has always felt the itch below her skin. For a long time she thought that would be it, and even before she learnt how to spell she knew she would be a sinner. And sinners do not get to have love or tenderness or light. She was alright with it.

Then there was Catra.

Something breaks inside Adora that day, something already frail, held together delicately and softly by Catra´s hands. It splinters and breaks, tethering inside her chest like the drops of Catra´s blood on her hands. It shatters fully, becoming sand, becoming tears. There is no turn away from this.

That day, Adora dies too.

## The Hospital

"Give it to her!" A cotton vase falls into the ground shattering. "GIVE IT TO HER!"

"Miss Montenegro, please"

"FUCK YOU!"

Castaspella walks inside the white room, wrinkling her nose and frowning deeply at the scene.

There is blood on the floor, that is quite obvious from the start, thick and red leaving a trail from side to side of the room, disappearing behind the heavy doors of the emergency room. There are also a lot of people here, which for a small town like Etheria is kind of rare. And all of them are screaming which, for Doctor Castaspella, Head Chief of Trauma Surgery, is a hard and absolute no.

"What's happening here?" Castaspella snaps, looking at one of the nurses that has resolved into tucking in the corner to avoid the wrath of the young woman ripping the room apart with her bare hands.

"It's the Montenegro heir," the nurse explains. She has a small bruise in her cheek, made by some flying instrumental that barely avoided hitting her in the eyes.

"Adora is here?" Castaspella´s eyebrows skyrocket, her mouth falling open. She was not in surgery or in consultation, if any emergency had happened they would have called her yet nobody had done so. "Why? Did she get hurt?"

"Um, no. It's about the Capellan girl," A doctor adds, wrinkling her nose, her lips curling over her gums in annoyance. From a nurse, disdain.

Castaspella knows Catra too, she has stitched hits on her shoulders, she has placed ointments on her bruises enough times, looking out of the corner of her eyes as Adora held her in her arms and whispered reassurance that neither of them could really fulfill for now. Castaspella *knows* about Catra, she has asked about her to her sister in law countless times, risking to break the confidentiality she held as a doctor just to be able to do something to get her out.

Castaspella knows Catra yet she can´t place yet that the blood in the floor is hers.

“There was a fight at her house. I talked with a neighbor, apparently the girl attacked her mother and poor Miss Weaver had to defend herself”

“Defend herself, how?” Castaspella presses, clenching her jaw.

“Opened her throat wide. Deity above, I can just imagine the desperation Miss Weaver must have felt to do that,” the nurse turns to look at the other doctor, shrugging. “We should run an alcohol test on that girl, I bet she was drunk again.”

“Excuse me, you said Catrina Capellan is lying in my emergency room with her throat open and you are standing here?” Castaspella holds herself from slapping them both with her entire strength, clenching her hands at her sides. The nurses stare at her as if she had grown a second head, eyes wide.

“She killed her mother. The whole town knows it by now, it spread like wildfire. The entire Cathedral is doing a mass for her loss right now, Priest Prime guiding it. My parents are there actually so if I could leave earlier and go–”

“And?!”

“Doctor Castaspella, there is just too much blood loss to do anything for her. That and she is in police custody by now.” The doctor frowns, clicking her teeth together. The room is still chaotic and there are screams everywhere. “She doesn´t have insurance either, since she was like eleven”

“So?” Castaspella asks again, her nerves shattering when the doctor says nothing.“So?! Aren´t you a fucking doctor?”

“Doctor Moon–”

“Get her ready right now! OR one for emergency surgery! I want the heads of neurology, cardiology and anesthesiology there!” When all of them hesitate she stomps on the floor, screaming at the top of her lungs. “Now! Right fucking now!”

The nurse and the doctor scramble away in fear of Castaspella, doing exactly as she ordered them to do not without grumbling in annoyance first. Castaspella is furious now but she cannot lose it, not right now, not if she wants to save Catrina´s life.

She does not know anything about her current status. She doesn´t know for how long she has been bleeding out since the first wound. She does not know the extent of the injury or what tore apart, jugular or carotid or more. She doesn´t know her blood pressure or that the paramedics had to bring her back twice with the defibrillator on the way to the hospital. She must be in shock by now, she can very well go into organ failure while everyone gossips around her. Castaspella is going to make sure all of them lose their license by the time the sun rises tomorrow.

Castaspella is a doctor, a very good surgeon and a decent person. The words of the doctor and nurse make a shiver run down her spine but right now she is the best shot she has for that girl to survive. She needs to deal with this first.

Castaspella pushes more doctors and nurses and security team out of her way, finally catching sight of the scene happening in front of her. Adora Montenegro is with her back towards the windows, facing the small army of police and doctors with her teeth bared like a rabid animal and her face terrible.

Terrible, all on and about her is terrible right now. Her hair is loose and wild, brushing her waist and spilling against her back in copper strands. Her clothes are red and it takes Castaspella a second to understand the original fabric was white, she is just soaked in blood. Her eyes are feral, just as everything else about her, wide and popping out of her pale face, beacons of unnerving blue among red.

She is bleeding, quite heavily too, and among so much blood it's kind of hard to place where but once Castaspella sees it she shivers. The long scratches on her forearms are a telling tale of desperation, nails dug inside her own skin when nobody else would do something for the girl she loves. She has bled herself,

there is so much blood inside this room that Castaspella won´t ever be able to forget it.

"Montenegro," Castaspella calls, stepping into Adora´s space. Adora looks at her but she is not actually looking, eyes wide as she lets her jaw fall and screams, one single guttural howl that makes Castaspella´s skin rise into goosebumps. "Montenegro!"

"Give it to her! If you have none then give my fucking blood to her!" Adora slams her bleeding forearms against Castaspella´s chest, staining her lilac scrubs in red. Castaspella catches her wrists inside her hands, harshly lowering them down.

"Adora, stop!"

"Castaspella I´m going to open my fucking throat here if you don´t give it her!"

"Listen. Listen!" Castaspella grabs Adora´s shoulders, shaking her twice and firmly, snapping her out of the mental and frantic fog that is overwhelming her completely, "I´ll operate on her myself, alright? I´m going in right now but I need you to let them stitch you up"

Adora is listening to her now but she shakes her head when Castaspella says the last thing, snapping her arms away and running her hands and arms across her head. "No, no."

"Adora," Castaspella barks, locking her in place with her stare alone. "I´ll save her life and you´ll get decent enough to receive her when she wakes up. What about it?"

"But–"

"If she wakes up and sees you bleeding, what do you think she is going to feel?"

It does the trick, shutting Adora´s panic completely off. Her chest is still rising and falling quickly, choking her and making her gasp, threatening to push her from the frail edge it is waltzing into, but

Castaspella´s words fall heavily over her, crossing the cloud of wrath and sorrow inside her head.

She looks at Castaspella with meaning, a new kind of expression that the latter had never seen before meeting her inside those stormy blue eyes. One that makes the world shake.

"Save her life, Castaspella. Do whatever you need but save her." Adora takes a shivering breath, dripping hers and Catra´s blood into the floor. "Or I´ll bring this fucking town to hell with me."

## Twelve hours after the incident

Adora leans her head against the pillow, watching Catra sleep.. She has been out of the operating room for eight hours, two since they brought her from intensive care to a private room where Adora has been sitting next to her without daring to stay away for a single second.

She is aware that Light Hope came to the hospital after the gossip of Weaver´s death and Catras  attack had spread like fire over hay across every single corner of the town. She is aware that, if Light Hope had seen her, she would have dragged her from the hair to the house of the chapel, but Adora was bound here for now. Either by the doctor quietly stitching her forearms back together or by her own stubbornness but if Light Hope wanted to take her away she would have to break the hospital brick by brick.

It didn´t matter anyway, Adora can always rip another part of herself. Whatever she needs to stay here.

The police is here too, and a few doctor and nurses, a lot of them actually, talking in loud voices at the foot of the bed and it is taking everything inside Adora to not take the spare catheters and dig them inside everyone's eyes just for standing here staring at her love sleep and talking about her in slick tongues.

Adora cannot grant herself that luxury right now, that pleasure. Maybe later but not right now, not with Catra sleeping finally safe in her arms, not with her neck tightly wrapped in bandages and stitches on her neck.

Someone brought Adora a clean pair of clothes and she scrubbed her face and hair clean on the bathroom sink, refusing to look at herself the entire time. Another nurse wrapped her arms in bandages and she hid them carefully beneath the white sleeves of her shirt, there, where they would be hidden as everything else. Where Catra could not see them or cry about them.

Catra stirs on the bed, sighing deeply as everytime she does when she is about to wake up. Her dark eyelids flutter and open, beautiful eyes in sunken sockets looking right back at Adora´s pale and thin face. Catra looks almost gray underneath the artificial lights of the room and the shut curtains, the skin beneath her eyes purple and red like sore patches of copper, her lips chipped. Adora washed her hair for her and braided it behind her back but the curls are tangled in places and flat in others, curling around the sides of her face.

"Hi, love," Adora greets her, biting back tears. "I´m here."

Adora´s voice alerts the doctors, detectives and police but she ignores them, curling her body over the bed so Catra is hidden by Adora´s broad back.

Catra looks back at Adora and, for a second, doesn´t move. Doesn´t speak or say anything, just looking at her face as if she had woken up to see the sun shining in the middle of her room and not as if she had just risen up after a real nightmare. A tiny smile makes its home on her dry lips and Adora´s heart flutters and sinks down immediately, watching as Catra opens her mouth to say something and nothing comes out.

Nothing at all, not a word, not a voice, nothing. She cannot speak and it hurts. Castaspella stitched her vocal cords back together but it will never be the same. Adora´s nightingale has been

defiled from her voice and off her safety and Adora vows to make everyone that hunted them down choke on their blood and their fears.

“A–” Catra tries but it's agony to even do so, a pained wheeze leaving her throat, threatening to make her bleed again. “A– A–”

Catra´s eyes widen, terror washing over her completely, choking her alongside the lingering taste of her own blood in her throat. She shots upwards on the bed, gasping for air, tugging from the tubes of her IV and EKG until the machines are beeping dangerously. Her heartbeat raises impossible and she goes incredibly pale, looking at everyone looking at her with weary and angry eyes inside the room as she brings her shivering hands over her neck.

She feels the thick edge of the gauzes and bandages with her fingertips and snaps her head towards Adora, realization drawing down on her too. She has realized too now, she is remembering, she knows. Weaver, her own mother, has finally managed to truly break her and Adora does not know how to shelter her from it.

Catra opens her mouth and lets out a strangled yell that sounds like a plea for air, biting on her own tongue and filling her gums with blood. Adora sees the panic attack at the same time the detectives and even some doctors pull out their phones and start snapping pictures of her, the white flashes illuminating the room.

Adora moves like lightning, climbing over the bed and wrapping her entire body around Catra´s, keeping her away from the flashes and the memories of cameras taking photographs of her childhood bruises. She tucks Catra´s head below her chin and wraps her arms around her shoulders, wishing more than anything to be able to absorb her into her chest forever.

“Cat, it's okay sweetheart, it's alright. I got you,” Adora says against her head, pressing kisses over her temples and nose, careful of not touching her neck. She tilts her head to the side, meeting the flashes and everyone else's eyes.“Get out”

The doctors and detective's mouths fall open, thrown aback by Adora's cold eyes and the sharpness of her voice. They all want a piece of the town's murderer but Adora stands between them, an actual murderer sheltering innocence.

“But– wait, you cannot throw us out!” A doctor is too brave to say, stomping his feet on the floor. Adora's eyes flash dangerously, her mouth and her entire face twisting into something furious.

“All of you, get out! NOW!” Adora screams, ringing loudly inside the room.

She doesn't know what they all see in her face but they scramble like cockroaches, tripping with their own shoes and even falling once out of the door until the heavy faux wood falls finally closed, the room drowning in silence.

Inside her arms Catra shivers, her tears falling heavy and cold as ice drops against Adora’s collarbones. She wraps her arms around Adora's waist, opening her mouth. She screams and no sound comes out.

“I got you, I´m here,” Adora whispers, over and over again, petting Catra's hair and face. Cradling her inside her arms, bandages and tubes and everything, kissing her temples and holding her shocked body against her heart. “I love you, it's alright. I love you, I love you, I´m so sorry.

Adora wants to shelter her but it is already too late. It has already happened.

“I'm sorry”

## Forty eight hours after the incident

Catra hears the door of the hospital room opening and closing again. The room smells like antiseptic and the walls are white, the

air too cold and the lights too dim. She misses her home, the old walls and the dry garden. She wants to go home.

A step walls further and her heart gives a tug inside her chest, cheeks blooming as she turns around. She feels like she is dying, every single day, every single second, but she wants to see Adora always. She wants to see Adora's sweet face, her sad eyes and tiny smile. Catra doesn't feel like she is here at all but Adora is her anchor, keeps her grounded.

She should have known, she would recognize Adora's steps everywhere.

Her uncle's eyes meet her in the middle of the room, bright green against the white walls and the white of his clothes. Prime looks back at her and smiles when her breath hitches inside her throat, delighted in the way her eyes go wide and terrified.

Catra opens and closes her mouth, out of Boise and out of words, agony spreading through her throat, tongue and even her guns and teeth when she forces herself. She doesn't even know what she wants to do, screaming at him to fucking go or scream for Adora to come back.

Prime meets her eyes and chuckles at her expression, shaking his pale head with amusement.

“Little sister, little beautiful nice. You've been behaving very badly lately haven't you?” Prime approaches her with slow steps, sighing heavily. He runs his sharp nails across the foot of the hospital bed, feeling the cheap sheets between his pads.

Catra can't help herself when she flinches, shrinking inside the bed. It fucking sucks being left so defenseless like this, hooked to needles and without a voice. It fucking sucks being haunted by your own family. It fucking sucks that she looks at her strained uncle and all she feels is fear.

“Oh, don't be afraid,” Prime chants, wrapping his palm around Catra's ankle from above the sheets, humming around her shiver.

“I've come to congratulate you, actually. You did it, you finally got yourself free from her”

Catra holds her breath, digging her nails on the soft duvet below her. She wants to scream for a very different reason now, she wants to scream that she didn't, that she tried but she couldn't because that was her mother in the end and she has always been softer than she wanted. That she was saved.

But she can't speak and even if she couldn't she wouldn't do it because that would mean cursing Adora and Catra would do and take the blame she needs to protect her.

“You and I know how my sister was. So– gut ridden, too guided by her emotions and her emotions were always a mess. But you, I knew something would come out of you. You are my blood after all, and you were beloved among my choir. Sad you will never return to it though.”

Prime walks closer to the side of her bed, staring at the heart monitor going off and smiling, slick and pleasant. He then snaps his eyes back to her, catching the way Catra's mouth is closed and her face is pale but her eyes burn with another kind of fire. Blue flames, copper eyes. Prime smiles at the sight.

“Are you thinking about the times I allowed her to beat you if you made mistakes during choir? That was only to make you stronger, so don't look at me like that. You and I know you are too much like her, you needed a steel hand”

Catra is nothing like Weaver. She was going through a very similar path, years ago, but she is not like her anymore. She is better, she was better. She was better than all of them, Weaver, Hordak, Prime. She was happy and she was loved. Now Catra doesn't know what she is anymore but she won't give this asshole the satisfaction of knowing that no matter how much he flatters himself of knowing her.

Catra snaps her eyes away from his, looking firmly at the closed door and hoping Adora will come through it any second now. She feels Prime right next to her head but she rebels against his presence, tightening her jaw and refusing to meet him. It makes him mad.

He shoots his hand forward and grabs Catra's chin between long, skeleton thin fingers, dragging her face and head back towards him with a violent shake. The pull makes the stitches in Catra's neck to strain and tears pool on her eyes, falling immediately against her cheeks.

"Don't you look away from me, Catrina," Prime barks on her face, his rancid breath crashing against her cheeks. "You should be grateful. The only reason you are alive at all is because the Deity allowed your dearest Adora to find you. You would be dead otherwise"

He looks up and down on her body, the hospital gown, the thick bandage, the red patches on her skin and the bruises on her face and arms, and he chuckles, shaking his white head.

"Perhaps you should have just died."

Catra bites into her own tongue until she bleeds, trying to shake herself away from his touch. Prime's grip just tightens even further, making her jaw protest with pain.

"Did you think that was it? That you'd got to kill Sharon and you would finally be able to leave? Take Adora with you? Catrina, none of us are going anywhere, you are staying in this town and you are dying in this town." He lifts Catra's chin, straining her until the bandage starts to spot with red. "And if you try to leave, if you try to take her away, I will look for both of you and I will find you and I will drag you and Adora by the hair back here if I need to."

He drops Catra's face, leaning back from the bed as Catra coughs wet and frantic, wheezing for air. Her heart monitor is going off

but Prime turns it off, ripping the wire from the wall with a violent tug.

“This is your real heirloom, Catrina. You have always been so soft, so tender for this world. You try to convince everyone and yourself that you have everything under control but you don't. That's why I was surprised. That's why I needed to see you myself.”

Prime looks at Catra´s face like a viper about to bite, like a demon about to take, like a sickness about to rip her apart. He studies her eyes and her way her freckles are so pale and the trembling of her body over the hospital mattress. Defiant and brave but not cold, never cold. Catra has never been cold in her entire life.

Prime´s eyes narrow, suspicion falling over him, a new kind of excitement tugging in the rotten fibers of his heart.

“Unless–”

The room´s door slams open against the door, making the windows and the furniture inside shake. Adora is standing on the frame, her eyes wide, her eyebrows knitted into a frown. She doesn´t look surprised or taken aback by Prime´s presence here. Instead, she looks furious and Prime knows immediately that she is aware who he is. For Catra, for the rest of the world.

“Priest Prime,” Adora mutters, running the name across her canines, spitting it inside the room. The temperature has gone frightfully cold.

“Ah, Adora,” Prime smiles, tilting his head to the side. “So good seeing you here”

Adora is not seeing him anymore, she is looking at Catra. Always and only at her. And Catra looks terrified. Prime looks between them, the way they share each other's eyes in a way or in another, the way Catra shakes her head and Adora clenches her teeth, the way in which he can almost see the torn wings over the bed and the blood dripping of peach skin, not dark.

Prime brushes a lock off Catra´s face, exhaling with a grin.

“I see now.” He murmurs, loud enough that both of them hear him, soft enough that it sounds like a shared secret. He meets Adora´s blue eyes and nods, something like pride and desire coiling inside of him. “And you are letting her carry with the guilt, yes, that's smart Adora.”

Adora´s mouth falls open, the air leaving her lungs with a painfully loud whimper. Catra is moving in the bed, snapping herself away from Prime and trying to reach Adora instead, crawling in her palms and searching for her. But they are both stuck and, for now, Prime holds the cards here and he knows it well.

“Thank you for clarifying it for me, little sister.” He says, a spring of his step. Yes, he was right. Adora is everything he thought she was, she is everything he ever hoped for her to be. He just needs to wait and she will come sooner or later to him. “I'll leave you too to be, for now. I bet you have a great deal of things to– *talk* about”

The mock does not come unnoticed but he is already across the room and in the door, giving a heartfelt blessing to both of them before walking away. He leaves the door open and Adora falls on her knees next to Catra´s bed.

## Fifty hours after the incident

“What? What are you talking about?”

Adora is back into the doctor's office and it all feels so similar and so surreal that she wants to scream. Angella is still sitting on the desk, Huntara is still looking through the window. They are slightly older, all of them, but it is all the same. The guilt and the injustice and the sacrifice of innocence.

“Hordak wants to send her to prison,” Angella repeats very slowly. She looks more worn down than the last time but her back is straight. She smells like incense and Adora knows Prime said nothing. He knows Adora did it, but still he said nothing.

Right now Adora is too busy screaming to think about that. She has been screaming for a long time now.

“Why?! Are you fucking crazy?!”

“Montenegro” Huntara snaps, scowling at her. At least that's something different, Huntara moving from the window to look at Adora, to put her full chest against her and sit her right back in the chair with a painful tug. Adora hadn´t even noticed she had stood up at all.

“Because she murdered her mother, Adora,” Angella explains, slow, as if Adora was stupid. As if she didn´t understand the full extend of the words. As if Adora hadn´t killed Weaver herself.

Angella is still on her chair, not moving, blinking slowly. Every once in a while, Adora thinks she sees her shiver but she hides it very well, cleaning her throat and palming Huntara softly on the back to signal her to stand back. Absently, Adora wonders if they are sleeping together, if that´s the reason both of them are fucking cowards and nobody is doing anything. Absently too, Adora finds inside of her that she doesn´t fucking care.

“He is her fucking uncle! He is her family!”Adora grunts, digging her nails on the desk, baring her teeth at Angella. Huntara moves, warning, but Angella stops her. Bastard. “Weaver tried to kill her. She opened her throat and you are trying to punish her?”

“Murder is murder, Adora. If Sharon Weaver had been alive she would have received the pertinent punishment for her actions. As it should have been.” She wouldn´t have and Angella knows this. As well as Huntara and as well as Adora knows it. Weaver wouldn´t have been punished at all because her brother is the Mayor, even if nobody else knows it. Angella catches Adora´s sour and

angry stare and exhales, leaning back on the creaking chair. “Listen, I don´t agree with it either but I can´t do anything. Mayor Hordak is the next and closest living member of her family, at least until she is twenty one.“

“You are going to cover this for him? Again?” Adora is out of breath, digging nails on her face. “I told you, I told you that time. I told you to take her and neither of you listened. And now you want to sacrifice her?”

“Listen Adora–”

“What if she didn´t do it?” Adora cuts her off, voice tangling. She wraps her hands in fists and lowers them down, straightening in the chair too. Both Angella and Huntara go tense, staring at Adora ´s sudden expressionless face with unease.

“What are you talking about, Montenegro?”

“If Catra didn´t kill that bitch? Would you do your fucking job and protect her?” Adora has always been ready to do whatever she needs to protect Catra, no matter what. “What if I–”

“Shut up,” Angella barks. She looks chaotic for a second, her own facade crumbling into pieces. She is panting and there are spots of red painted in her cheeks, staring at Adora so full of fury and unease that she recoils. “Be quiet. I don´t want to hear it, I don´t want you speaking about it or insinuating it. Just be quiet, Adora.”

“Why?” Adora presses, biting herself until she bleeds. Angella snaps her teeth together, clicking painfully.

“Because you are Adora Montenegro and I won´t have this town falling into chaos. So be quiet.”

Bastards, all of them, all of the town. Adora hates them, she has never hated so much before but now that the flood gates are open she cannot control it anymore.

Angella sighs, taking Adora´s silence as defeat and not as defiance, not as the start of planning. She pinches the bridge of her nose instead and leans back, blowing a breath to the air.

“Take her away,” Angella says, meeting Adora´s eyes. “Take her somewhere away from Etheria while everything cools down. Nurse her, help her heal. I´ll cool things down with the Mayor. I'm sure people will get over with time and they will forgive her”

“Forgive her?” Adora repeats slowly, feeling the words break something deeper inside of her, filling something dark, something void and without ending. “Forgive her.”

“I´ll pray for her, with Priest Prime. We will all pray for her for what *she* has done.” Angella extends her hands to the sides and for a second she is just one of the statues of the chapel. Cold and unmoving. “I really wish I could do more but my hands are tied”

Huntara opens the door of the office, hard, a cold signal for Adora to get the fuck out. Adora follows the movements, practiced, practical, standing from the chair and approaching the frame of the door without looking from the floor. She hesitates, though, right as she is about to leave, tilting her head to the side.

“Angella,” Adora calls and through the golden strands of her hair she meets Angella´s eyes, freezing her in place. “I´ll do it, I´ll take her away and I will shelter her. But you´ll take her in when we are back.”

Angella frowns, holding her breath. “I don´t know what you mean”

“You´ll take her to your house, you´ll give her a home, a room, food, clothes. You´ll shelter her until we are both free from here.” It's not a question or a petition, it almost sounds like an order. Adora´s voice is so cold and it makes an offense course through Angella´s entire body.

“Adora, you can't condition me–”

“I never said anything after my parents death.” It does the trick, Angella shuts up immediately. “If you don´t protect her I will go to Eternia and I will rise an investigation against you for election fraud and complicity in murder,” Adora´s eyes snap to Huntara, “And you.”

Angella´s eyes are wide, her mouth opening and closing with shock. They mirror Huntara´s expression. Adora doesn´t wait for them to get the words inside their head, she grabs the handle of the door and walks outside, slamming it violently behind her.

## January

“Done”

Adora leans back, patching the back of Catra´s hand with a bandage, kissing her fingertips before letting it rest back on her lap.

She disposes of the old catheter and the rest of the IV tubes quickly, cleaning their small night table with practiced ease. She was been doing this for the past month, managing Catra´s pain with the instructions Castaspella has written for her. Today Catra had finally had enough of burning chemicals in her bloodstream, begging Adora to take it off before she ripped it apart herself.

Catra is sitting in the middle of the soft bed, opening and closing her hand slowly, staring at it underneath the soft white light from the windows. There is thick snow outside, covering their landscape completely and sometimes Catra´s eyes wander into it, lost in thought. It breaks Adora´s heart.

“Does it ache?” Adora whispers, taking Catra´s hand again when she sits back in the bed. Catra shakes her head in negative, looking at the myriad of antiseptic stuff Adora is carrying inside her hands, already mentally curling into herself at the sight of them.

Adora feels her apprehension immediately so she leans towards her softly, pressing soft kisses over her cheeks until she feels the tension melt down. For the first few days, Adora did not know how to touch Catra, how to caress her, how to reassure her. She walked on her tippy toes and stumbled in fear to hurt her. Only after she caught the heartbroken stare in Catra´s face when Adora hesitated to kiss her was when Adora slapped herself back into track and threw her into her devotion for her with open arms.

Catra needs her, more than ever and more than everything, Catra needs her.

"Let me see," Adora begs, asking first always, going with Catra´s time only. Catra sighs, nodding her head very slowly and quiet, tilting her head to the side to present the bandage to Adora. Is much thinner than during her days at the hospital but it is still white and still sticky on her skin, pulling from it when Adora slips into gloves and carefully takes it off to inspect the wound living below. "Alright, It´s healing nicely"

It's going to scar. Ragged and red and in live flesh. She is going to carry with this forever.

Catra hisses as Adora manages her wound tenderly, digging her fingers over Adora´s thigh, holding herself to her. She tries not to move but her entire body is shaking as Adora dabs the antiseptic over the scarring and cleans it anew. And Adora is so gentle, so soft that her touch is a feather but it is still completely overwhelming, making Catra want to scream and run and throw herself off the window.

"I´m sorry." Adora whispers, biting back tears, hurrying up as much as she can. She dabs an especially tender spot because Catra gasps, widening her eyes and staring at Adora in alarm, her entire body shaking from head to toes. "I know, love, I´m sorry," Adora apologizes over and over again, trying a reassuring grin that almost makes them both cry. "I'm almost done"

Adora places the sterile patch over the scar and leans back, exhaling heavily and she lets Catra rest from it. Catra gasps, closing her eyes as she feels the edges of the patch with her fingertips, trying very hard not to break down. She leans back over the pillows, wrapping her arms around Adora´s shoulders and bringing her with her, gauzes and all, curling around her over the patchwork blanket with an exhale.

They are in the cabins near the Frozen Mountains, half an hour away from Etheria. It belonged to Adora´s father and then it belonged to her. She spent a year here with Mara and then it was an escape, a hiding spot, the only spot in the world she could think of, where she could keep Catra safe and help her heal.

The mountains are a barrier of natural formation around them, shaped as a halfmoon around the frozen lake and the meadow of the cabin. This patch of land is hers and the rest is protected so there is nobody else that could ever stumble on them, nor like they could pass the treacherous paths without knowing exactly where to go.

Bow brings them groceries every two weeks. He never comes into the rooms or further inside. He speaks softly with Adora in the entrance room and leaves right after. He knows Catra is not ready to see anybody else besides Adora and he respects it. Once or thrice he offered a phone to Adora but she refused it; she didn´t want to know anything about anybody for now.

She didn´t want to hear about the town or about the Mayor, about Angella or the detectives nagging Catra to answer interviews or about the rest of the people. She didn´t want to answer Glimmer´s curious questions or the rest of the group´s increasing wonder about what had exactly happened, as if they had some right to know at all. She didn´t want to hear about Light Hope and all the ways she would punish Adora once she were to come back, about how she had thrown away the Academy´s offer like nothing, about how sorry she would be in the end. Adora doens´t want to know.

Instead Adora only wants to live here, on these moments, on this small bed made for one that two share, over old blankets and creaking floors and winter flowers growing on the window frames. Adora wants to burn the whole world down but for now it's winter and Catra needs her.

“Do you want to try your words today?” Adora asks, caressing Catra´s face with her fingers.

She is still so thin, her cheeks sunken down and her eyes hollow, but there is more light in her eyes when Adora kisses her and her cheeks color in soft pink when Adora runs her hands over them, seeking for warmth like a moth to a sun. Her freckles are still pale and her hair has grown, soft and curly around Adora´s fingers.

Catra looks at Adora with her breath held, wrinkling her nose and nervous. Adora holds her immediately, holding the back on her head inside her palm and smiling.

“It can wait,” she assures her, nodding. She hasn´t heard Catra´s voice in so long. Since that moment where she was bleeding out inside Adora´s hands and she was getting ready to say goodbye. It´s a memory Adora will never be able to forget but this is not about her right now.

Catra huffs and wiggles out of Adora´s touch, scrambling into a more sitting position over the bed. Her legs crossed and her hand over her lap. Adora likes to see her like this, proud and stubborn about this. It´s a fragment of Catra, buried deep inside her grief.

“A–” Catra opens her mouth, forcing the letter out. Adora sits too, her legs cradling Catra´s hips; she holds her cheek inside her palms and brushes her cheekbone with her thumb, nodding softly as she coos Catra to keep going forward. Catra seems to take bravery off it because she shakes her shoulders, opening her mouth again. “A– a– dora”

“That´s it,” Adora tucks a curl behind her ear, biting back her tears. Catra´s voice is completely broken, raw in all places and

torn apart. High and low, wavering, scarred. But it is there, little by little it is there and Adora loves it all the same.

Catra doesn´t, she hates it, but she tries. "A– dora"

"I´m here"

"S– snow," Catra looks at the window, pointing at the white landscape with her chin. Adora smiles, nodding without looking back at it. She does not need to look at anything else but Catra´s sweet face.

"Yes. It is snowing," Adora rests her forehead against Catra´s nuzzling their noses together. "I even saw some wolves in the morning."

Catra musters the frail try of a smile, giggling breathless against Adora´s cheeks. They both like it here, they always have. This is their safe space but today it feels sad. It has felt sad since they arrived at the beginning of January, mourning, like a mausoleum for both of them and their love.

Today is Adora´s birthday and the air is sad.

"I–" Catra tries, gasping when the air fails her. Adora shakes her head and smiles, calming Catra´s increasing frustration with gentle fingers.

"Take your time"

Catra nods, taking several minutes to breathe deep, gathering herself again. She holds herself to Adora´s wrists and brushes her thumbs over the scars there, washing pain and desperation away too. She has no gift for Adora this time, she just has herself or what has been left of her so she gives it all to her.

"I—" Catra repeats, shaken, sweet. "I– lo–v–v– v" A gulp, an inhale, close your eyes and open them again. "I lov– e y–ou"

It's honestly such a gift, honest love over Adora´s heart. Adora´s eyes gather with tears, damping her eyes and falling down her cheeks freely. Catra´s eyes are sad but she smiles a little, catching them inside her fingers as she leans towards Adora´s face and kisses her cheeks and nose bridge, gentle strokes of adoration.

“I love you, too,” Adora gasps, choking with her love and her life. “I love you”

“St– t– ay?”

“Yes,” Adora cradles Catra back inside her arms, wrapping her arms around her slender shoulder and resting her nose over her temple. Breathing her in, sandalwood and antiseptic and pinetree, past blood washed away by tears. Sincere love coated in grief. “Always”

## February

Catra screams in dreams.

Adora has laid next to her every night for three months and Catra screams when she is sleeping. She trashes on bed like shock waves across her body and cries out loud, fighting invisible hands pressing down her body. She screams and it is not even a scream anymore but a gasp, a wheeze for air, a pained whimper, tearing her already fragile vocal cords and making her shake.

Adora wraps her entire body against Catra's and locks her wrists gently but firm over the sheets so Catra doesn't hurt herself, so she doesn't hit herself chasing shadows away. She holds her close so neither can breath without following the other's chest, subduing her fight instinct until the nightmares stop and exhaustion takes Catra's subconscious.

Adora doesn't sleep. She doesn't close her eyes and doesn't dream. She can't. She can't close her eyes and not look at Catra's

face, make sure she is breathing, that her heart is beating. That she is alright.

Sometimes Catra sleeps so profoundly that she looks dead. Adora doesn't sleep and it makes her go a little bit insane but who can blame her?

Other times, Catra speaks in dreams. Drowned, muffled, broken, her voice sore as it tries to repair itself, to stitch itself together to what it was once and unable to do so. So dear in Adora´s ears and heart, so heartbreaking.

"Adora," Catra calls inside her dreams, wrinkling the bedsheets inside her fingers and kicking blindly over the duvets, gasping her name. "Adora. Adora"

"Shh," Adora pets the curls around her face with gentle hands and presses her nose against her cheeks, lulling her inside her dreams, hoping she could know how to reach her inside the darkness and pull her heart out of its. "It´s okay, baby. I´m here."

"Adora," Catra whimpers, frowning, her mouth pulling into a sad grimace, fighting the garnet demon still chasing her inside her heart and her head. "Come. Please come for me."

"I´m here"

Some other times Catra wakes up from the dark dreams filled with blood and broken vocal cords and green chapels and she stares at Adora in silence among the dark. She hears Adora´s heart beating inside the shadows and makes herself a home there too, curling around her soul and meeting her blue eyes with exhaustion.

"School," Catra whispers once, tucking her face against Adora´s shoulder. The bandage in her neck is still thick, she hides her eyes but Adora can feel her tears against her night shirt. "The Academy was waiting for you"

Adora cries, shaking her head. She holds Catra so tightly against her chest that she feels like she cannot breathe anymore if Catra

is not there, resting over her heart and breathing against the curve of her neck. Adora shakes her head and she wishes she could rip her own tongue off her mouth for even having considered leaving Catra in the first place. For them.

"We can see each other on the weekends," Catra shakes, she is afraid. She is gathering herself of bravery for the sake of Adora´s heart, because that´s what she thinks Adora wants but she is afraid. "I can do that. I can do it"

"No, my love," Adora denies. She has never denied Catra anything and the only time she did she lost her, but she has to deny this because it is born from pain. It is born from hesitation and questioning sounds. It is born from the doubt of love so Adora says no. "No. No"

"I don't – I don't want to be selfish"

"You are not sweetheart," *You need me,* Adora wants to say. *You are hurt, you almost bleed on my hands. You need me.*

"Don´t ruin your life for me"

Adora twists her fingers on Catra´s sleep shirt, holding her over her chest, guarding her inside her palms, feather falling invisible and bloodied on their bed. Adora´s eyes are so blue among the gray darkness that they don´t even look human.

Catra is asleep again, whimpering against Adora´s neck. Adora rests her lips against the shell of Catra´s ear, brushing her tears with her lips.

"But *you* are my life"

Catra screams, Adora doesn't sleep.

## March

Adora likes to prepare baths for her, Catra has noticed. At first she made them thick with perfumes and stuff that felt like milk on Catra´s skin, heavy and tingling in Catra´s nose and she would have probably kept doing it like that if Catra hadn´t come out sneezing like crazy for a full half an hour for so many sweet smells.

Now baths are calmer, soft still but neutral. The smell of soap and the gentle vanilla candle on the corner is comforting and not overwhelming and Catra has found herself relaxing inside the warm water further and further as the weeks and months pass them by.

Adora still helps her wash her hair when the time comes or to braid it all over her hair when it is time to keep it dry. She still runs the soft sponge over Catra´s back and shoulders, across her waist where the bruises have faded almost completely, and down the length of her legs. Adora still keeps herself away, never stepping inside, never sinking inside the warmer alongside Catra. She takes freezing cold showers in the morning that last five minutes but spends twenty minutes preparing the bath and another forty helping Catra bathe. It´s sweet, protective, it makes Catra sad.

She is alone right now, inside the big tub with the warm water, staring at some point of the mosaics in the wall. Adora left to grab something or take something from the stove, she doesn´t remember, so she is alone inside this small space, with the sound of the drops of water falling against the surface and the silence.

There is silence in the room but her head is crowded. She hears her mother inside her head, inside her brain, eating her way like a worm on her skin, crawling herself like a shadow around her nerves and her bones.

Catra can hear her words of that day, the contempt of them, the hatred, the no longer held back disgust. She can hear her and taste the way Weaver, *her mother,* never loved her, never cared. Forsake her. She can taste the blood still in the back of her throat

and she can hear her own voice, gone and broken, back and wrong. The only beautiful thing she thinks she had, ripped apart and gone.

She can feel Weaver´s hands around her neck. Weaver´s and Double Trouble´s. Hordak´s and Prime´s, pushing her down the calm surface of the water, so calm that it´s almost a mirror under the candles. Catra feels them, Catra sees her, looming over her shoulder on the reflection, eyes green, face red, raven hair, staring back at her as she tugs her down and drowns her completely down the water.

Underwater, Catra is underwater now and it feels… peaceful, somehow. It feels good, lying here below the tension of the surface and against the strength of the water, keeping herself below them, just applying enough strength to not float above. Just here.

Down here is silent, down here she cannot hear Weaver whispering on her ears and poisoning her heart. Down here she cannot hear the town's indifference or the screams to burn her for daring to be alive after everything. Down here she cannot hear Prime threatening and Adora, threatening their love and their safety. Down here she cannot hear herself, choking with her own breath, having to learn how to speak again.

Down here she also cannot hear Adora, and that is probably the only reason why her lungs burn, screaming for air, begging her to stand up. That's probably the only reason why she starts moving but by the time she regains control of herself the room is no longer alone.

Strong hands wrap around her forearms and pull her away from the water immediately, ripping her from it´s faux merciful hands with a tug so desperate and frantic that it makes Catra gasp for air, drinking on the fresh freeze filling her ribcage and pressing against her heart. She crashes against a solid chest, strong in the collarbones and belly but soft everywhere else. And she would be able to see the way the water dripping from her body drenches

the soft white cotton if it wasn´t because Adora is holding her so tightly that she can barely move.

Adora is panting, Catra can hear it inside her eardrums, as if she had just ran a thousand miles in seconds. And her heart is hammering inside her chest, so hard it must be hurting her, so hard Catra can feel it on her cheek where she nuzzles her face against her sternum, seeking for her warmth immediately. The water was quiet and peaceful but Adora is a sun and Catra needs her to breathe. Needs to breathe for her.

"Cat," Adora gasps above the crown on Catra´s head, her voice breaking in the middle. "What are you doing?"

Oh. She is crying. Adora is crying, her voice gives her away. Only then realization starts to fall down inside Catra about what she was doing, clogging her throat down with surprise and shame.

She wants to speak, to talk and tll Adora to not worry, that she didn´t know what she was thinking. That she didn´t want to die, that she wanted to live, that she doesn´t know how to. That she loves her and misses her. That she should change her shirt because she is going to get sick. But her voice is stuck once against and she doesn´t know how to.

Adora moves them both, leaning away from Catra´s bare body so she can look at her face instead. Her forearms are soaked all the way to her elbows and her hair is in complete disarray, falling over her face and neck in golden strands, stuck to her nape with sweat that makes her face tint in red. Her lips are quivering violently, barely holding back tears as she searches for Catra´s eyes.

"What are you doing, baby?" Adora whispers, whimpers, pushing Catra´s bangs gently out of her face. Catra really hopes Adora can hold back her tears because if she cries then Catra will cry and Catra feels like if she starts she will never be able to stop.

"Did you get hurt? Let me see."

Adora runs her fingertips gently above every inch of Catra´s bare body inside the tub, from the back of her head to her shoulders and back and down to her waist and legs, avoiding her neck because Catra has asked her to do so, roaming her eyes still over the red scar and making sure there is no physical wound in her again.

She is so beautiful. Catra is tired.

"I want to sleep," Catra hears herself say, running her fingers across the waves that rise inside the tub. She feels the crevices of the tub´s material on her skin and the water and Adora´s hands and realizes she feels like floating, like sinking down, like falling and never reaching the ground.

"You can sleep in a moment," Adora reassures her, still frantic, still searching for visible pain, shaking so hard because she can feel the suffering she cannot see in the very palms of her hands where she holds Catra above the surface. "We'll sleep together"

Catra blinks at her, very slowly, counting the moles in Adora´s pale face and feeling the ghost of her mouth over her bare shoulders. She wants to kiss her, she wants to taste her in her tongue again. She wants to breathe in her love and when she looks inside of herself she finds out there is nothing there anymore. How can she love Adora like this?

"I can´t feel anything," Catra whispers, a confession, a nail to a coffin.

Adora freezes next to her, still kneeling over the floor of the lukewarm bathroom. Her hair is so long, Catra notices it, golden strands falling inside the water of the tub, tangling gently around Catra's damp fingers.

Catra looks at it and rubs it between her fingertips, gently, careful. Adora smells like the bath soaps and like rain, Catra does not dare to meet her stare, too ashamed to look into Adora's sad eyes. Too

afraid of seeing exhaustion and annoyance, the clear signs that Adora has finally given up on Catra.

Catra does not dare to look into them, who would ever want to live around someone like this, the ghost of someone, the shell of who she was before? Broken pieces of glass that cut if you get too close.

Adora cradles Catra's cheeks between her palms and doesn't force her to look back at her but she is looking at Catra, and when Catra looks finally back there is not disgust or anger or frustration but love, drowned in sadness and rage, but love after all.

“Then I feel it all for you,” Adora whispers and it feels like a promise. “Anything. Everything. Whatever, I will feel it for you.”

Catra meets her eyes this time, blue and silver against blue and hazel. River and forest.

“I´m quiet”

“Then I´ll be your voice,” Adora caresses her cheekbones and the shell of her ears, painting her freckles again with tenderness. She is crying now and her tears feel like being underwater too. “I´ll do it all for the both of us, okay? But I need you to stay with me, please”

Catra blinks at her, drinking in the sight of her. Her arms rise from the water of the tub, wrapping they across Adora´s neck and shoulders, cupping Adora´s sharp jaw and chin with her damp hands.

“Then tell me about the forest,” Catra asks, running her thumb over Adora´s shivering lips.

Adora exhales, leaning over the water towards her. “Yes”

Catra is pulling from her, wrapping her fingers around the fine straps of her shirt, cooing her inside like a wounded siren to an

enchanted sailor, her voice sore, her lips sweet against Adora´s cheeks.

“Tell me about the mountains”

Adora stands from the floor, following Catra´s call. Her hands wrap at the sides of the marble tub and hold her weight above the water, one of her legs slipping inside the lukewarm liquid, soles brushing Catra´s long legs.

“Always. Whatever you need as long as you want it.”

Catra presses her lips against Adora´s mouth, Adora´s tongue licks a line on the roof of her palate. The water around them splashes and falls off the tub, crashing on the floor. It reflects them both and only them both, Catra´s cheek pressed against Adora´s collarbones, Adora´s hands wrapping around her naked waist, seeking her underneath the water, finding her and pulling her against her soaked chest when she couldn't find the surface.

Adora climbs inside and sinks inside the water alongside Catra, wrapping their limbs together, keeping her head above the water. Making Catra breathe fresh air where Adora sinks her golden head underneath the waves and prays to the body of her love with her lips and her fingertips. Adora is here.

“Tell me about us”

## April

Adora stands in front of the mirror of the bathroom, looking at herself. She just took a shower, a second a third of the day, scrubbing herself raw trying to wash the invisible blood from her limbs.

No matter how much she tries, she cannot take away the vision of Catra´s blood soaking her arms.

The bathroom is quiet and dark, drowned in shadows where she refused to turn on the light to not wake Catra from her sleep. She also didn´t want to look at herself as she stripped from her night clothes and undid her low ponytail. She barely wants to look at herself now, but she endures it.

Her eyes meet her right back through the silver mirror, returning her blue stare without mercy. All her hair falls heavy and wet across her back and down her collarbones, spilling like golden ink over the crevices of her collarbones and the swell of her breasts.

The only light inside is the one that comes from the dim sun through the closed window, white and shaky, still faint as the night rips itself from earth. It washes Adora in a kind of glimmer that allows her to see herself, from her pale knuckles tightly wrapped around the bathroom sink to the fading scars in her body. Blasts like explosions from the car crash, lines like river paths down her waist from brambles, white scratching lines like thunder on her forearms from her own nails.

Adora is full of scars and yet none of them raise the same horror the scar in her lover´s neck does.

*What are you doing? Hiding here all on your own?* Adora can hear, her own voice speaking back to her across the mirror´s door. If she raises her blue eyes towards her shoulder, she might find her own blue eyes staring back at her, mouth dripping red

*Ah, you are hiding to not hurt her?* Her own head mocks her, giggling against her ears. Invisible golden hands that brush back her long hair and wrap around her neck. She is choking herself and her guilt looks like a shadow of herself.

*But you have already hurt her, haven't you?* If Adora blinks, she thinks she can see it, the demon that has been chasing her. Blond hair, peach skin, blue eyes, herself cradled in white clothes soaked with blood. It hovers over her back like a second weight, a second skin, bending her against the strength of the memories and the smell of blood.

The shadow, the weight, the ringing guilt and overwhelming rage opens her mouth from jaw to jaw and mouths the words again, spilling off bloodied tongue and dripping against the floor.

*You don´t get to decide what I want, Catra!* Remember? *Who the fuck do you think you are?*

Adora gasps, clenching her teeth, chipping the molars and grabbing at her bare chest, digging her blunt nails in pink lines across her sternum. Adora has been nurtured and trained to be a goddess and right she crumbles over water and mirrors by the lingering blood of her mortal lover.

The guilt twists again, like the mask of a theater play, forming features and spilling tears instead of blood, crashing over Adora´s skin in goosebumps in the middle of the quiet morning.

*I've loved you my entire life, Adora,* Catra´s voice, sweet and high, just about to sing, just about to take flight, just about to die. *And even after everything I only get to have a small fraction of your love.*

Adora slams her palm hard against the side of her head, so hard until her palm is her fist and she looks at the night stars beneath her eyelids. Still, it is not enough to quiet down the rush of noise suddenly slamming against her, throwing her from side to side inside her frail flesh and her scarred body.

*Do not let Catra distract you anymore, Adora.* Weaver, slick as a serpent, slithering her way across blood soaked floor and spilled wine, smiling at Adora like a desired daughter and not a prisoner. *It's not worth it*

*It hurts.* A lioness, Adora´s Catra, a panther, a natural predator that has chosen softness. So very brave against the poisonous arrows of her family and her home, holding herself to the strands of life by Adora´s love. *I´m afraid.*

*She is not worth it.* How is such a beautiful soul born from such a rotten heart? Maybe it was a mistake, at birth. Maybe she was

found and the spider never carried her inside her wound. That would explain why she always looked at her like a stray and not like a godly gift.

*Just stay with me while I fall asleep.* A lioness, no, a nightingale, fluttering her wings through the barriers of her cage, reaching for Adora´s shadows as if that was the sun, as if they could melt and test apart the bars and snatch her away and into the sky. *Stay*

*Maybe you'll stop whining about it, Catra!* There she is, Adora again, a coward running away from the hunt thinking that molding herself to the church would set them both free. Her decisions, her unbearable guilt about the open throat and the screams. She was five minutes late and it spilled blood on the floor, a miscalculated arrow flying right through her fingers and against the wings of her love. *I don't belong to you!*

If Adora closes her eyes, she sees Catra´s dead body in her sleep.

*I´m afraid.*

Adora slams her fist against the mirror, splintering the surface in sharp pieces. She hopes it will shatter the image reflecting on it but all it does is slicing it in dozens more, dozens of blue eyes looking back at her and smiling, echoing the words said by the love of her life on her last breathe.

*Just hold me. Just stay with me, just until I fall asleep*

Adora slams her palm and her fist and her arms over the mirror over and over again, again and again and again until she is bleeding, until the splinters are nothing but grains and the grains are nothing but sand. It makes the eyes go away but the voices remain, licking their way inside Adora´s eardrums and running their hands across her neck.

Adora looks at the splinters of the mirror dug so deep in her hands that rivulets of blood are flowing in her palms and chuckles, giggles, hums, taking the pieces of glass and digging them out of

her flesh. They fall against the marble sink with a tiny click, echoing loud inside the room but no louder than her own head.

*A fraction of your love, I'm just a fraction of your love*

*Love*

*My love, my love, my love …*

"Adora?"

The door of the bathroom is open, Adora didn´t hear it above the sound of everything else. She tilts her head to the side immediately, called towards the voice like a starving body, her mind, body and soul answering to the raspy breath of Catra´s voice, drowning everything else and extinguishing it into nothing.

Catra is lingering by the door frame, her feet bare over the cold floor, her hair falling over her slow breathing chest. She is wearing Adora´s shirt, white and gray and brushing the start of her freckled thighs, black boxers and nothing else. Under the light of the incoming dawn, Adora can make out the silhouette of her waist and the curve of her breasts beneath the fabric, soft and calling for worship.

Her cheeks are rose blooms and her neck is healed almost completely. She is better than before yet she is not the same. Neither of them are. They have both changed and right now Catra is looking at Adora with such a confused stare that it snaps all the strings of Adora´s heart and makes her return to the now with a small gasp.

"Oh." exhales, both in wonder and in shame. Her voice is soft, so tender, it almost doesn´t match the hurricane ripping inside her ribcage. "I´m sorry, did I wake you up, baby? I´m sorry," Adora lets her bleeding hand fall to her side, turning towards Catra´s figure with a gentle sigh. "Is your fever down?"

She has been sick the past few days, an errand cold that caught Catra unexpectedly. It made her forehead burn for two days

straight and a cough to linger in her already frail throat, making her toss and turn in the bed and whimper in her sleep. Adora has not slept in three days.

Today however the sickness has finally retreated its claw off Catra ´s body, allowing her to rest in their bed until she was awakened by the sound of shattering glass and drowned yells. Adora hasn´t even realized she was screaming among the laughter.

Catra tilts her head to the side, taking in Adora bare from the chest up, her soaked hair and panting chest. Taking in the bathroom still clogged with the damp warmth from the bath and the half closed window and then the mirror, broken in pieces over the marble. Taking in the blood dripping from Adora´s tightly closed hand, sipping through her fingers and crashing against the floor in red flowers.

Catra´s eyes widen, her hand leaving the door frame and gripping into the fabric of her shirt.

“What are you doing?” Catra asks, her voice quivering and breaking in all the wrong places. Panic falls over her, realization of what Adora was doing falling over her like another kind of curse. “No, what are you doing?

Adora opens her mouth to explain but she finds herself out of words. What was she doing, actually? Punishing herself? That´s mild, stupid in a way. Adora cannot look after Catra is she is hurting herself but then again maybe in a way she has been tearing herself apart since the beginning.

Maybe she was just seeking a way. To quiet the voices, to erase the images, to direct the wrath boiling inside of her. She doesn´t know exactly what she was doing but she knows it horrifies Catra near the door and that's enough for Adora to regret it.

Catra rushes next to Adora´s side, avoiding the broken glass by some miracle. She takes Adora´s bleeding hand inside hers and

brings it towards her face, exhaling at the sight of the deep and shallow cuts slashed over Adora´s peach skin.

“You're bleeding”

*Adora slips with Catra's blood on the floor, falling hard on her side. It soaks through on her white clothes and skin, salt and iron and Catra´s spilled life.*

“I don't even feel it,” Adora says, leaning to press a kiss against Catra´s temple.

Catra is looking at her in that kind of way that Adora never knows how to place, in that quiet way where Adora feels like her chest is going to explode with devotion and her skin raises with shivers. Catra is the only one that has ever known Adora enough to see through all her layers and Adora knows now that Catra is *seeing* her, past the mirror reflection and the voices and the memories. Adora doesn´t know how to hide it all from her so she doesn´t not this time.

Catra guides Adora out of the bathroom and back inside their small room, stopping near the small table by the window where they still keep the medical aid after months of using it every single day. Wordlessly, Catra grabs Adora´s hand and starts extracting one by one the tiny fragments of glass off Adora´s skin, gentle with the tweezers but quick, controlling the blood loss with a clean gauze and dab antiseptic over them right after.

Adora looks at her in silence, following her soft hands as they hold Adora firmly and her nose wrinkled with concentration as she places sticky medical tape over the wounds and joins them together. Gauzes with blood are gathering next to her but she doesn´t even seem to flinch at the sight of them, too focused in taking Adora´s pain away.

“I love you,” Adora says, echoing inside the silence like a falling bell.

Catra´s eyes snap at her, wide and taken aback. She stares at Adora with shock and little by little it melts into something that Adora cannot read, cannot understand. For the first time in their lives, Adora cannot understand Catra.

“I–” Catra starts but her mouth grows thick like cotton and her words die in her scarred throat, losing themselves among the silence. Her thick eyebrows fall into a frown, mouth pulling into a distressed grimace. “Why did you do this?”

“You think I only love you in fractions but I love you with my whole heart, Catra.” Adora keeps talking, following the thread they are both tangled into.

To Adora´s horror, Catra´s cheeks pale, her eyes dampening with tears that don´t get to fall. She lets go of Adora´s bandaged hand and looks away, crossing her arms over her chest, embracing herself. She looks at the cold morning, biting into her own mouth and fighting herself. Another kind of fight is going on inside Adora ´s chest, quieter and more violent as she starts to realize something.

“I– I shouldn't have said that,” Catra whispers, almost to herself. She pinches the bridge of her nose and doesn´t meet Adora´s eyes, “Listen Adora I, I know you feel guilty. And I know you are doing your best to make what happened better. So you don't have to say this for my sake or just to make me feel good I–”

“Catra, do you think I don't love you?” Adora´s question is a breath of sore air and it aches everywhere.

Adora´s heart is hammering violently inside her chest, her ears are ringing, her entire body aches, and in front of her Catra stills, her rich skin raising goosebumps and her throat closing. Adora looks at her precious face, so loved, so dear to her heart, and sees the answer written in the tears falling down her cheeks. It is worse than a knife to the heart, it's worse than dying.

“Oh goddess,” Adora whispers, so low that it sounds like a mourn, so sad that it is heartbreaking. “No. Oh god, no.” Adora chokes on her breath and her tears, shaking from head to toe. “My heart, my soul, you think I don't love you.”

Adora kneels in front of Catra, falling so hard against the wooden floor that her knees bruise immediately. Catra panics, trying to catch Adora inside her hands but Adora is already too far gone, wrapping her fingers pleading and frantic on the fabric of Catra´s shirt.

“Look at you. Look at you, my beautiful love.” Adora gasps, blue eyes silver with tears, pressing her palms over Catra´s belly and the side of her waist, feeling the pieces of Catra´s heart slip through her fingers like the mirror in the wall. “Look at what I have *done* to you”

“Adora, no–” Catra is panting, looking at Adora with huge owl eyes, her cheeks pale and her body shivering like a leaf. “No. No, Dora. It´s not–”

“I would have thrown myself off the fucking chapel´s tower if you had died,” Adora grunts, screams, tears herself apart. Catra chokes around the confession and the tears, holding herself to Adora´s hands. Adora is holding her completely now, pouring her plea and her devotion inside Catra´s warm palms. “I would have jumped, or stabbed myself in the heart, Catra. I would have ripped the damn thing off my chest with my bare hands and give you my life. I would have given you all my blood, ripped my soul in pieces and stitched yours with it.”

Catra whimpers, letting her tears run free. They slip off her cheeks and crash like kisses over Adora´s cheekbones, rolling towards her lips, salty like sea water and cold. Adora nuzzles her cheeks over Catra´s belly, runs her lips over her sternum and her forearm, across every single freckle in her wrists and knuckles and caresses the shivering skin of her thighs and knees. Breaths warm air inside her palms when Catra cups her face inside them and begs with her eyes for her to understand.

“I don't love you in fractions. I love you fully. I love you with everything. I love you with every breath. I love you with all the pieces of my fucking heart. I love you in every second of this universe's creation. You think there are things more important than you. You think I'm here because I feel guilty, that I´m going to leave when you have healed but that's not true. It's not true, Cat.” Adora digs her fingertips over catra´s waist and her spine and holds her when her knees buckle, catching her inside her arms and keeping her afloat. “My nightingale, my angel. Catra can't you see? You really can't see? Can't you see *you* are my soul?”

Catra is crying now, fully. It matches Adora´s tears too. She cries and holds herself to Adora´s face, to her neck and her broad shoulders and the nape of her golden hair. She is shaking so bad that she looks like she is going to crumble down, taken from the inside out by Adora´s devotion and the sincerity of her voice, the love, the adoration.

“But I'm – I'm broken,” Catra gasps, violently cleaning her tears away with the back of her hands, scratching the delicate skin below her eyes. Angry, angry with herself, with her voice, with her mother, with the world. Never with Adora, who is the only good thing left in her life. Angry with her fear of not being enough for her now that she has been defiled from her safety and her voice. “I'm wrong”

“No. No, you are everything that is good in this fucking world,” Adora reassures her, clenching her jaw and her teeth and shaking the entire house with the amount of her reverence and admiration for her. Catra hiccups, shaking her head.

“I can't sing anymore”

“Sing anyway,” Adora begs of her, meeting her eyes with all the love she has for her, overflowing from her eyes like fallen stars. “I'll hear you”

Catra bites into her lips, finally allowing her heart to splinter open and pour all the sadness guarded inside into the air between them.

“I'm in pain”

“I know, my love”

“I'm angry. I'm scared. All the time.”

Catra caresses Adora´s face, runs her fingers against her temples, tucking her golden hair behind her ears. Past the bridge of her nose and the dimple of her mouth, across slightly crooked teeth and damp lips. Catra´s tears keep dripping off her eyelashes and falling against Adora´s cheek, running down against her face. Holy oil over Adora´s bloodthirsty flesh.

Catra smiles sadly at her, underwater, beneath the earth, still laying on the cold linoleum of her blood soaked home, side by side with the moss and the earth and the errand spirits.

“My love,” Catra whispers, and her voice speaks nothing but about love and truth and loss. “I think I'm dead”

Adora has lost Catra. She bled out on her fingers, she lost her. She is lost, wandering among purgatory floors. Eurydice ripped out of Orpheus' hands when he looked away for a single second to chase an errand song. Adora is going to go to hell to reach her again and if she cannot then she is going to burn to ashes with her, just so they can mingle their ashes together, just so they can rest in the ground side by side.

“I love you, Adora,” Catra keeps saying when Adora is too drowned by the tears and the sadness, holding Catra against her chest and keeping her soul to slip between her fingers again. “I just– I just want to be here for you. I just want to be alive for you, I– I have nothing else.” Catra huffs at her own confession, shaking her head, disgusted by herself. “It´s so fucked up, I´m sorry. I love you so much, Adora, and I stained this”

“No, Cat,” Adora murmurs between her hands, voice hoarse. Her legs are numb but her arms are strong where she wraps Catra as she stands up from the floor, lifting her from the cold tiles and the memories of the yellow kitchen stained with blood. “I´ve got you, I´ve got you now. I´m not leaving again, I will never forsake you again.”

“They are going to come for me.” Catra says against her ears, tangling her fingers in strands that always remind her of honey, not gold, breathing on the musk of Adora´s skin- “They are going to reach me in the end. My uncles, my mother, I can still hear her, I can still see her. They suffocate me, they are going to kill me.”

“They won´t,” Adora grunts against the side of her head, her breath caressing the scar in her neck, her arms guarding her from the cold air of the morning. “I won´t let them touch you ever again.”

“And if I fall in the end?” Catra asks, because she has to, because she is still scared. Because she needs it.

Adora leans back and kisses her mouth, stealing the sadness of her tongue and twisting their chests into knots. Catra´s toes brush the floor, Adora´s knuckles bleed through the cotton ropes.

“Then I´ll go with you. Wherever you ask me to go, I´ll go.”

—

Unlike the morning, the dusk is louder. There are more animals awake and more bugs starting to sing now that the moon is close to visit again. A few birds have made their way back to their nests and some even are knocking softly on their window frame, eating the berries and seeds they have left for them.

Adora and Catra lay side by side over the bed, resting bodies over damp blankets. They are naked, perspiration in the air, sweat on their shoulders and pants on their chests. Adora is holding Catra´s hand inside of hers, drawing swirls over her palms. Catra is curling

on her side, shaking every other second with sweet aftershocks running down her legs and spine.

There is a kind of ache inside of her, one that she had not felt in months, the kind that is familiar yet so desired. Adora touches her, always, she adores her, devotes her, loves her, Catra knows this even if Adora trembles in fear thinking she doesn´t. But she had not taken Catra like this in such a long time, had not wrapped her arms around her waist and held her against her chest as Catra fell apart in pieces. She had not bed her, ravaged her, made her anew from the inside out in months, so now she needs to lay here for a second, catching her breath and her sensations again.

And still, still, she feels as if Adora was holding back something. Like a crave, an itch under her skin, crawling its way in the place where Adora presses her lips against her ribs and she falls quiet, underneath her nails and the back of her neck. Something Catra wants to see, something that she wants to feel on her skin.

Catra sighs, caressing Adora's forehead with shivering fingertips. She tucks the damp strands behind Adora's ears, brushing the back of her knuckles over her cheekbones.

"What are you thinking about?" Catra asks in a whisper, resting her thumb over her lips. Adora exhales too, kissing the past of her finger and wrapping her hand over her wrist, resting Catra's palm over her chest, right above the point where her heart beats the hardest.

"Sometimes I don't feel like myself," Adora murmurs, narrowing her eyes at the golden light of the sunset. "Sometimes I feel different. Like I was living but I wasn't inside myself anymore. Like there is something underneath my skin, like I want– like I want to rip the world apart. Like I'm– rotten.”

Adora closes her mouth and hums. The.weight of Catra's palm against her chest is a welcomed pressure, it eases the ache living inside Adora's chest. But the itch that crawls across her limbs and

waist makes her uncomfortable, wiggling in the bed without knowing where to scratch.

“Ever since the forest, since the hare” Adora adds, tilting her head to the side. She meets knowing Catra's eyes, already waiting for her. “You remember.”

“I do,” Catra nods, curling closer to Adora's side. Adora gravitates towards her immediately, cradling their bodies together like praying hands.

"It's better when I'm with you, like I can remember who I am if you are here," Adora lingers kisses over Catra's temples, but her hands are shaking for a very different reason than coming undone against Catra's skin. “I can´t ask you to love me like this, Cat, not after everything you've gone through.”

“Adora” Catra cuts her, drawing circles over Adora's collarbones and breasts. “You already are my entire soul, all that I am. I love you.” She licks her mouth, sticky lips like melted honey. “Do you love me?”

“Yes,” Adora buries her nose against her chin and Catra cannot hear her mother's voice inside her head anymore. “Like breathing. Like air. Like blood.”

“That's all I need, that's all I ever wanted. And I'll love everything about you no matter what it is.”

Adora's breath shakes, her shoulders shaking and falling. She wants to tell Catra everything, everything that she is feeling, the rage, the anger, the guilt, the fear. The need for blood, the crave for hunt. In a way she thinks Catra already knows.

“I don't know what I am yet.” Adora admits, wrapping her hands around Catra's waist. The wounds on her knuckles ache and bleed again but she lets them, she sighs on the pain. “I don't know what I want.”

Catra rests the bridge of her nose over Adora's temple, looking at her honey eyelashes. Her damp mouth brushes against the sun patched on her skin when she speaks. It's not an answer but it feels like it. After all, Catra knows her better than anyone else.

“I'm hungry, Adora”

## May

Adora is hunting.

Since the first morning when the spring sun started to melt the ice and the frozen lake, Adora has been hunting. She wasn´t hiding it, Catra knew what she did when she wandered into the forest before dawn, but for a while Adora refused to bring the image of it inside the home. She would lock herself into the small shed outside and clean fur and skin and slice the meat, washing her bloodied hands on the freezing cold waters and scrubbing the smell of death from her before stepping inside again.

For a while, Catra let her do it like this. She would sit on the window and look at the mountain still scattered with snow like powdered sugar and in the cold sunlight and wait for Adora´s return. Sometimes she would fall asleep waiting, waken up again either by the smell of cooking meat from the kitchen or by Adora ´s lips against her forehead, cooing her gently to eat.

For a while, for a long while, Catra did not eat. She ached, it ached to eat, to drink water, to pass food, the wound too fresh, the pain too violent. She almost did not eat during the first few months, wrinkling her nose at the soft blended vegetables and food and at the chicken, curling herself around the taste. And she knew it made Adora sad, she knew the way her eyes flashed when she ran her fingers across her back and felt the crevices of her spine through her skin, she knew it hurted her. But Catra could not eat.

Now it's different. This is meat, thick, rich, full of flavor, sinking in her fangs and ripping with heat over her tongue. Rabbit, duck, deer, hare. Adora is hunting, she is hunting *for* Catra, so Catra eats. She feasts, she hums, she tears the cooked meat apart with her teeth, meets Adora´s blue eyes over the grease and drinks on her smile. It satisfies them both.

It fills Catra's arms and her thighs and the curves on her waist and belly. Adora loves her in any way and form, but her eyes flash with another kind of light at the sight of her eating and feasting. Adora scrubs herself before walking inside but she still smells like blood. Catra kisses her until they are breathless every single time.

For a few days now, Adora has been cleaning her hunt inside. Catra convinced her, pleaded her to, *If you are to hunt for me then don´t hide outside, don´t hide this part of yourself where I can´t see. I love you anyway, I´ve loved you always.*

Adora refused at first because, how could she subject Catra to blood again? In the kitchen, inside their safe spot. After tasting her own blood inside her tongue, how could Adora make her look at her tearing the hunt apart and soaking her fingernails and elbows in blood?

But Catra insisted, *It´s not the same,* she insisted until Adora was unable to deny her any longer. *It´s you, Adora, I want to see.*

Adora is clean. Practical, practiced. She knows what she is doing and she does it well. It never splashes on her clothes and it never stains the table, flesh and guts on one side, bones in the other, already bloodied dry on the snow outside. She slices the pieces perfectly and places them over a clean plate, throwing the ears and tail of the rabbit alongside everything else.

Catra is sitting on the chair at the other side of the table, her legs over the chair, knees pressed against her chest. She looks at Adora work in silence, a flush cradled in her cheeks. She knows many people would cringe and shy away from this, the blood, the flesh, Adora´s red stained hands as she turns around to place the

dirty dishes and knives in the sink filled with disinfectant. She knows she should be triggered by the gore but she doesn´t. This is meat, it feeds them both, Catra knows Adora and she trusts her.

Her mind is buzzing though, flying inside her ears like flies, making her dizzy and too awake for this hour of the dawn. The kitchen is quiet and washed in pink colors and yet Catra´s mind is chaos, remembering another day in another kitchen and everything that came before that

She cannot shake away her mother´s words from her, she cannot forget them as much as she tries. She tried not to nurture it, but the seed of doubt that Weaver had planted inside her mind with her words and her killing hands had already taken root inside of her, making her head ring.

Catra looks as Adora takes another bloodied plate and licks her lips, feeling the words around her mouth and letting them fall on the silence between them before they choke her to death.

Catra knows what Adora wants. She knows what she wants too.

“She said you would always put your future above my legs”

Adora drops the plate. It bounces on the floor once and shatters loudly, scattering red marble all across the kitchen.

Adora is not breathing, not moving, staring at the sink filled with reddened water. A cold sweat falls down her spine and forehead, covering her in a kind of silver rage that she had not felt this fully, this raw, in months. It has always been there, inside her, rotted in her bones from the moment she held Catra´s dying body in her arms, but tamed. Now it returns with full strength, rushing hatred and adrenaline through her bloodstream and making her freeze in place. She wishes, oh how she wishes she could murder Weaver all over again. She would do it slowly.

Catra drops her legs from the chair, looking at Adora´s back where she has gone still in the middle of the floor and the

shattered pieces of the plate. The dawn is still quiet but they are not anymore.

“I knew she was saying it to break us. To break me,” she holds her breath, narrowing her eyes sadly. Adora´s nape is a special shade of peach, not pink and not pale either, Catra likes to linger her lips over it. There is the shadow of an errand stroke of blood over it. “I know it's not true because you are here and you love me. I know you love me, Adora. You hunt for me, you look after me, you shelter me, you take me. You love me. But I *hated* her for it. I hated them all.”

Adora holds herself to the sink so hard that she might just bend it in half with her fingers, leaving divots in the shape of her pads over the surface. There is so much noise in her head too, since that day and everything that happened before. She knew how to control it before but now it is set loose, feral, untamed. She is nor sure if she wants to lock it back again, she is not sure if she should.

Catra stands up and walks around the table, approaching her with soft steps. Her bare soles avoid the shattered marble and she shakes her head when Adora looks at her feet so close to the sharp ends, stepping around them to reach her instead.

“Adora?” Catra calls for her, resting her fingertips over Adora´s jawline. Adora´s eyes are so blue right now, the pupils so small, looking at Catra next to her and not looking at her at all at the same time. She is diving inside her mind, following treacherous paths, marking spots for the hunter. She is choking in rage just as Catra is choking in sadness. Catra knows this because she knows Adora.  “I know what you are, I have always known”

Catra slips her hands around Adora´s wrists and tears them gently from the sink, guiding her towards her. She places Adora´s bloodsoaked palms against her cheeks and the side of her collarbones, not even flinching when the fresh blood smears over her warm skin.

“You know what I am too. You know it's going to kill is both in the end.”

Adora´s breath hitches on her throat, her pupils shrinking at the sight of blood over Catra´s skin and then blowing up when she catches the spark lingering in Catra´s eyes. Purple and lilac inside her sea glass irises, copper and red with the light of the dawn. Her hair is thick falling down her waist and her skin dark. She smears herself with Adora´s rage and covers herself with her love, kissing the inside of her wrists and painting her lips in crimson blood. She looks like, if Adora was to place a beating heart against her lips to feed her, she would bite into it, no questions asked, humming and sinking white fangs into flesh.

She knows what Adora needs, she knows what she wants too. They are not so different, halves of one soul.

“Whatever is left of me it's yours.” Catra whispers, sore against Adora´s mouth when she leans to kiss her. Adora´s arms around her body are so tight and desperate, so devoted, that they leave her breathless, gasping for love and desire against her tongue. “Hunt. I trust you”

## June

“Stress cardiomyopathy,” Castaspella says with a sigh, leaving the test papers over the desk. “It is also called–

“Broken Heart Syndrome,” Adora fills in for her, clicking her tongue against her teeth.

She is in the hospital again, only pushed back here because Catra insisted to. Because she knew there was a kind of oppression pressing down Adora's chest, paining her to the bone, robbing her of her breath, making her gasp for air when. Adora thought Catra was not watching.

It wasn't an obstacle, it didn't make her hunting eye less sharp or her goal less twisted, but it was annoying. Unfair to carry with it.

“Indeed,” Castaspella nods, pressing her lips together. She stares at Adora's unmoving face, studying her expressions with sharp eyes.

Adora has changed, this much Castaspella can tell. Something has shifted inside of her, something already out of place since the day Castaspella stitched Catra's neck together. Something has changed yet now it looks almost into place, not back to what it was before but anew. A new kind of silence and a new kind of shyness. Calculated

“Listen, I know things have been bad, really bad. And I know that you are taking care of her. But you need to look after yourself too, Adora,” Castaspella says in the end, drumming her fingers on the table.

She wants to say more, wants to help her more but she doesn't know how. In a way, it feels useless, not needed, as if Adora had already taken a decision and Adora was just waiting for Castaspella to give her the needed nudge.

Sometimes it feels like she is privileged to know, to understand, to realize something is going to happen. Sometimes she wants to scream, ask her to forgive her and forget and run away. But Castaspella does none of it. She knows this town is rotten, she knows they are all at fault. She knows, she will allow it.

Adora tilts her head, looking at Castaspella curiously, rubbing her palm over her aching heart. She scratches herself every once in a while and she smells like blood.

“And how do I do that?”

“Find a way to bring you peace,” Castaspella says and it feels like jumping into the void, “To both of you”

## July

“Adora, *ha, HA* !”

Catra trips and spills over the sheets, shaking with the aftershocks of her orgasm, whimpering as it curses across her and makes her drip.

Adora parts away from her, taking a deep breath. Her mouth and chin are soaked, dripping on the duvet below their bodies. Her face is completely flushed, red from the cheeks to the nose and damp with sweat. Her mouth tastes like musk and forest fog and she loves it, worshiping Catra's body, she loves it.

She caresses Catra´s lips with her thumb and sighs, enamored by the sight of it. Catra´s entrance is puffy, pink and pulsing, cum still dripping off her with each after shock and Adora can´t help herself when she dives back again, pressing the flat of her tongue over her and licking her once, swift and as deep as possible, gathering it all inside her mouth and moaning at the taste.

Catra comes again immediately, shaking inside Adora's arms. She throws her head back, arches her delicious back and cums in Adora's lips, shaking from head to toe and falling heavily against the mattress when it is done.

Catra brings her hands towards her chest and jawline, pressing sweaty palms over her sternum and ribs, fighting to find her breath and panting against the humid air as she searches for Adora's eyes among the light of their room.

Adora is already looking back at her. She grabs Catra's ankle and brings her up, kissing her legs and skin reverently as she has been doing for the past minutes, hours. From the toes to the sole, from the ankle to the shin, from the back of her delicate knee to her thigh. Past the kiss bitten lips of her core and against her navel, lavishing her bellybutton like a treasure as she speaks against her slippery hands.

“it's okay,” Adora whispers, so hoarse and low that it drives Catra mad. “You can cum as many times as you need to, my love”

Something has shifted into place inside of Adora, this much Catra can tell now. Since the hunt, since the hospital, since the yellow kitchen. Since Catra voiced her permission and her devotion for Adora to be who she really is, to do what she wants to. It glued something into place.

Today Adora fucks her like a devotee delivering herself to a impossible angel, or like a goddess of death who has fallen in love like a mortal. Not like a hunter, never like a hunter, their bed is sacred. But like a starved woman after months of being torn apart from beauty. She touches her, grabs her, kisses her, licks, sucks and caresses. She is devouring her, from the inside out and everywhere.

Adora slips behind Catra's sweating body and wraps her arms around her, pressing her mouth against the side of her jawline and her hands across Catra's ribs. Never her neck, it is sacred for Adora to protect it and Catra needs it too.

Like this, Adora carries Catra's weight against her chest and she can run her palms and fingers down her body, worshiping the sweet of her teardrop breaths and the nipples already covered in kisses. Low and low and down below until it reaches Catra's clit and the slippery skin around it and she dives her fingers back inside that beloved heat, deliciously slow with her stretch.

“ *Ha* ” Catra moans, whimpering against Adora's cheeks when the latter dips down to kiss the freckles of her shoulders. “ *Ha* , Adora, Adora you are– you are caressing all of me. *Ngh* ”

If she keeps fingering her like this Catra is going to come again. So quick one after the other but she cannot stop it. Catra craves for it too, wants to feel the rush running down her bloodstream, filling her mouth with saliva and squirting out of her and into Adora's palm.

But she can also feel Adora behind her, below her, she can feel the curve of her strap bushing sweet and tempting against the curve of her butt cheeks, already damp after taking Catra twice with it before the need to feel her in her mouth was much stronger.

There is so much that Catra wants and she knows that Adora will give it to her if she wants. Fully.

“I love you,” Adora whispers, blooming a rose against Catra's chin. Catra trembles around her fingers, gasping for air.

“ *Oh* ”

“I love you,” Adora repeats again, over and over against Catra's skin, licking the shell of her ear and kissing the corner of her mouth. “I love you”

Catra is already dripping around her fingers, falling down in her palm and the sheets. Adora loves this too but just as Catra she aches to worship her from the inside too. Their time here, on this safe spot of the world, has come to an end and Adora wants to do the most of it before she delivers herself to the hunt.

“Every inch of you,” Adora gasps, “Every part, every scar”

Catra is beyond words now, chasing the touch of Adora's fingers and rolling her hips sweetly tempting against Adora's lap. Adora cannot hold it back anymore, taking her hand away and rolling back around Catra before she can begin to understand what is happening.

Adora nudges Catra's legs open with her knees and makes a home between them, cradling Catra's cheeks between her palms.

“Look at me, love,” Adora whispers, prays to her. She holds Catra's starry eyes inside hers, caressing her lips and cheekbones with her fingers as she brushes the head of the strap against her open folds, once, twice, until Catra is shaking below her, her pupils like moons looking back at Adora with wonder and Adora looking at her with adoration. “You are *mine”*

“Yes?” Catra gasps, hiccuping when she feels the line of the soft strap running across her folds and making a home inside of her, little by little, inch by inch, kissing her in another way, mirroring the way Adora kisses her mouth and licks inside her tongue gently.

“Yes,” Adora whispers, giving one swift, gentle thrust, cradling her until the very hilt, no space left between them to be apart.

Catra's eyes roll inside their sockets, her ankles slipping across Adora's sweaty waist and hips. They are both rocked by the strength of the thrusts, moving up and down the bed as Catra delivers everything to Adora and Adora worships her in return.

*“Ha, ah* !” Catra's mouth falls open, soft whimpers and moan leaving her throat. Low, quiet still, barely breaths against Adora's cheeks and Adora knows she is holding back. That won't do.

“Sing” Adora asks, pleads, commands and begs of her.

She rolls her hips and thrusts so hard and loving that Catra shivers from head to toe, overwhelmed by a sudden and back ripping orgasm. She can't even begin to process it because Adora does not stop, just slows down to help her ride it gently and then she is back thrusting inside of her until Catra cannot breath. Her tongue is heavy and her cheeks painted in deep red, wrapping her hands around Adora's neck and keeping her close, as close as possible to her.

“Adora, *ah,* my love”

“Sing,” Adora whispers again, smiling when Catra lets her mouth fall open and finally a long moan comes out of it, high and gentle, sweet and ringing like a hymn against Adora's tongue. “Sing, my heart. I'm hearing you”

—

Adora sits next to the bed and watches at Catra sleep peacefully on their bed, the night falling over them.thick and darkn.

Catra is on her side, her dark hair falling over her face and bare shoulders, cradled in dry and warm blankets and sleeping softly, soundly. It's a night like today where she does not have nightmares and Adora can see her drift into the gentlest of sleeps, allowing her to rest. It's a night like this where Adora does not sleep.

Adora sighs, brushing a lock off Catra's sleeping face and tucking it softly behind her ear. The scar living in her neck is pink now, completely closed, never healed completely. It still aches. It still weighs. It will always ache on Catra's body no matter what..

The door of the spare room next to them it's open, empty from everything except what Adora had been doing from the past few months, since Catra allowed Adora to set herself free. To set them both free.

The warm breeze of the summer in the Frozen Mountains makes the curtains shake,  moving the photographs stuck to the walls. Angella, Weaver, Hordak, Prime. Huntara, Double Trouble, Light Hope. Newspapers, lines of red. Marlena, Adam, Randor. Serenia. Mara.

Adora's plan, drenched in blood, coated in rage. Planned deaths, planned sorrow. The world has kept running around, they have gone on with their lives but Catra and Adora are still stuck there, in the yellow kitchen and the red walls.

She would have let them live, she could have taken Catra and leave and allow them to keep breathing. But they have killed her angel, so Adora is not allowing them the pleasure of that. She is not allowing them the gentleness of a life. She has been hunting them for years, months, weeks, days, and now that the warmth is coming to an end, Adora is going back for them.

They are all already dead, they just need to suffer first.

“They are going to pay.” Adora vows against Catra's temples, kissing her sleeping eyelids. “I´m going to make them all pay, I

swear to you.”

## Ends of July

## Start of the new school year

*Slash*

“Six months, Adora,” Light Hope barks, walking from side to side next to the colorful windows of the house´s chapel. “Six fucking months. The Academy has been calling non-stop to know what happened to you. And what was I supposed to tell them, that you had run away Deity knows where to have an stupid love affair?”

*Slash*

“You are so lucky that the Academy has you in such high hopes, Adora. because otherwise you would have thrown away all the sacrifices and hard work, all the plans that have been made for you.”

*Slash*

Adora grunts, holding herself to the wood of the precarious altar. Her nails leave halfmoon marks over the oak, matching past marks there. Every time she moves and holds her breath, every time the bramble slams against her waist, the candles shake, thumbling against the wood and spilling fire that extinguishes immediately after. Adora´s eyes are so bright against the flames that they look like beacons of light themselves.

*Slash*

“If it was on me I would never let you see that girl again. She is a murderer and she should have remained dead” Light Hope drops the bramble broom, throws it next to Adora´s knees where she leans against the hardwood. “But I will allow it for now, as long as it keeps you in check. As long as you obey from now on”

Light Hope kicks the bramble towards Adora, knitting her eyebrows, waiting with stone cold eyes for Adora to move. Wrap her hand around the handle, bring it towards her own skin.

“Well, what are you waiting for?”

**October 26th, early morning**

**Light Hope's House**

“She will ruin you.”

Light Hope snaps her head away and walks right past the door frame, steps heavy. Adora leans her head back and sighs, deep from within her chest. She narrows her eyes sadly to the ceiling before straightening again and walking out of the library too, her steps just as heavy as her heart.

There are things Catra cannot do anymore. She cannot sing, vocal cords butchered. She cannot laugh without wanting to cry. She cannot handle things around her throat unless it is the familiarity of soft fabric, and only soft fabric. She cannot sleep without waking up screaming

There are things Adora cannot do anymore. Adora cannot kiss her neck. Adora cannot make her laugh until her eyes wrinkle. She can't smile without her heart hurting. Adora cannot fight her nightmares for her, except that maybe she can

When they returned to Etheria from the mountains, a whole six months after the incident, a lot of things were different. Catra was different. Adora was different.

Catra was quiet. Adora was full of rage.

Adora follows Light Hope across the corridor of the house, steps quiet over the cold floor. She knows Light Hope must be tired after flogging Adora and herself at dawn. She knows she holds

her chin high and doesn´t look back, never, holding herself above everything else, too far inside herself thinking nothing will ever get to her.

She knows Light Hope hates Catra. That she has always hated her, that she cannot phantom a world where love can exist and where it can be pure and sincere. She knows that Light Hope will fulfill her promise, that she will hunt Catra too, that she will do everything in her power to hurt her and take her away. She has already planned it, making deals with the devil to rip Catra from Adora´s side. How dare she? Who the fuck does she think she is?

Light Hope is inside Adora´s room now, wrecking the otherwise pristine place, ripping sheets and pulling clothes apart, looking for every single trace of Catra inside the private space to purge it out of Adora´s life, clean and simple.

Adora knows and that's why she has kept the shed´s ax guarded inside her bedroom since the moment she came back from the forest. Adora was not planning on doing it this early, not like this, but Adora is fucking tired of her, she is fucking done and she doesn´t want to wait a single second more.

Her hunt for Light Hope has come to an end, this is as far as Light Hope´s tale comes.

Light Hope bends down towards the bed, undoing the duvet and the blankets. She is saying something, something about Adora and Catra, something about desecrating the sanctity of the chapel, something about laying together in the sheets. She is insulting them both, telling her to forget her, to leave her, to let her go or Light Hope will do it for her. She is saying a lot of stuff,

Adora wraps her fingers around the handle of the ax and pulls it off the messed up wardrobe, humming under her breath. The house is otherwise quiet above the sound of Light Hope´s unstopping whining and the rain outside is a nice song across the walls and the roof. It´s good, it´s nice, it reminds Adora of the woods.

“Light Hope?” Adora sings her name, tilting her head to the side. Light Hope snaps back her body towards her, her mouth halfway open around a nasty word.

Adora axes her in the head.

It´s pretty easy, actually. Adora has gotten pretty strong during these months, fighting her way in dark corners, training, preparing, cleaning the blood from her nose and staring at the pictures inside her head as she plans for what is to come. It´s easy to lift the ax and swing it down Light Hope´s head, past skin and skull and against the organs below. It´s easy, it feels good.

Light Hope stumbles back, her mouth falling open into an almost perfect ´o´. Blood drips off the wounds and against her face, falling like cascades across cheeks and nose, past her lips and chin, pooling on her clean clothes and over Adora´s room.

The crimson splashes against Adora´s face and dribbles down her own cheeks, staining her nose and lips. She stares as Light Hope stumbles back, tripping with the messed up sheets and falling heavily over the floor, staining the carpet and the very walls in red.

Adora tilts her head to the side and hums, squatting next to Light Hope´s bleeding body as she starts to convulse around the blood loss and the ax still dug so deep inside her head.

“You look surprised,” Adora says, almost with wonder, smiling when Light Hope´s eyes shrink at the sight of her. That's good, it means she is listening and Adora does want her to listen very intently. “You shouldn't. If you truly knew me, you shouldn´t be surprised”

Light Hope gasps, gurgling around blood from her mouth and her head. She stretches her hands towards the floor, grasping at the wood tiles and the carpet, crawling in her palms and her knees, and then crawling on her belly when she can´t keep herself up anymore, searching for the open door and corridor outside. Still

trying to get away, she is still trying to get away with this, even after everything she has done she still thinks she can come first.

“Where are you going?” Adora asks with a chuckle, running her hands over her hair, snapping the hair tie in two. “You have nowhere to go”

Light Hope says something, or at least that's what it seems to be. It sounds more like a drowned scream or a gurgling whimper of pain, dripping blood everywhere. It paints a trail of red behind her, from the room and all the way back to the office, little by little, inch by inch. It´s almost funny for Adora, looking at her trying to reach her office with so much desperation in her final moments. Wanting to reach for her oh so beloved chapel in hope ´s that it will save her somehow, or spare her from pain.

It´s funny because it´s not true, nobody is going to saunter off heaven and save Light Hope now. If something is coming for her now, it´s hell, Adora is going to make sure it drags her down.

“I didn´t want to kill you so early, Hope, but you´ve given me no choice” Adora runs the words through her gums, feeling them in the back of her throat. She leans down and calmly takes her shoes off, leaving them to the side. It´s easy to wash blood from flesh but from fabric it is always a pain. “You can flog me all you want, you can make me rip myself apart. Sell me, use me. But I ´m not letting you hurt Catra. I´m not letting you try and rip her away from me. I already did that for you once”

Adora stares at the blood in the ground, wrinkling her nose. The crimson is such a violent contrast against the white that is striking under the light.

“Look at you. You´ve soiled your castle, Light Hope,” Adora shakes her head, clicking her tongue against her teeth. “You made Mara leave us, leave me, and now you are trying to hurt my love? Gosh, you are so fucking full of yourself. I´m sick of you.”

Adora leans back, holding Light Hope's red shirt inside her palm. She wraps her fingers around it and lifts her easily from the ground, dragging her body easily across the remaining steps of the corridor and inside the office. She knows the wound is mortal, by this point Light Hope is more dead than alive,

Adora walks inside the small chapel and throws Light Hope´s body against the window, her head bouncing so hard the glass splinters. Light Hope wheezes but Adora is not paying attention to her anymore. Instead, she leans towards the altar and grabs the bramble brooms from beside the candles, turning towards Hope´s wheezing body.

"Before you go, though, I think you need to cleanse yourself from your sins. Don´t you think?"

## October 26th, Night

## The stairs

"I will make her watch, Catrina, I will make her watch while I kill you," her uncle says, dropping the facade only to torture her.

Catra gasps, out of breath. Her head is numb and heavy, making her dizzy, making her want to throw up. When she opens her eyes she sees artificial lights above her head and the cold floor behind her back and for a second she is back on the yellow kitchen bleeding to death.

But she is not there anymore, she is in a much different place. But she still aches. Her knee is screaming below her and her head pulses with suffering, a concussion eating its way on her brain. She feels something sticky clinging on her back, the phantom of Prime´s fingers drawing words on her bare skin.

She knew since this started that it would be painful. She knew it would be bad, sickening, wrong. Adora told her how it would, she

begged her to understand, to stay away and she was right. It turned out to be even worse.

But Catra knew, after all that's the hunt. She knew about the blood and the pain, she knew about the regret, the lost lives. She accepted it because it was Adora, because she also wanted to make it out of this alive. It still hurts though.

She rolls to her side and coughs, cringing when the pain of it makes sparks to lighten all over her bruised body. She can hear the sound of a heavy door falling closed and then swift steps coming from the stairs and her whole body tenses, ready to fight her way again, though she doesn´t know how much she can take anymore.

She expects another hit, a slap, a stab even, but all she feels is a thin hand wrapping around her shoulder and shackle her into sitting with surprising strength, uncaring of the bruises or the hits, searching for Catra´s face with anger.

Angella's eyes are rabid, full of fury and resentment. She looks at Catra like one would look at a wounded animal, one that you blame for daring to cross the oath made on its home so you accidentally ran it over with your car trying to escape the rain. Rabid, full of blame.

“Where is she?” Angella spats on Catra's pale face, shaking her hard. “Where is she, Catrina?”

“I- I don't –” Catra gasps, confused and in pain.

She tries to point towards the emergency door of the stairs, to tell her that they need to get out of here because Prime might just come back and kill her too. Catra does not want Angella to die, she knows Adora does but Catra cannot hate her even after everything, not after living with her for these months. She is a mother and Catra would never rip a daughter from.a mother that loves her, even if that daughter is Glimmer.

“The– the killer, we need to go,” Catra tries again, her mouth tasting like salt. She feels like she is going to faint but her eyes are focusing more now, looking back at Angella's eyes fully and hoping to see her understanding.

All she sees is anger.

Angella grips her chip tightly and forces her to hold her eyes, barking on her face at the same time she tugs off her bruised body to make her stand.

“Do not fucking lie to me, Catrina. I know it all, I know Adora is the one doing this. I know that she planned it.” Angella's hands are so hard around Catra's forearms that it's bruising her. “What is this? Some sick try for revenge? Did you both think this was going to undo what happened to you?”

“No. No, you don't understand. Prime–”

“That's enough of lies!”

“I'm not lying!” Catra screams now, pushing her away. She tries to shake herself away but Angella's grip is merciless and Catra is too tired. “Listen to me! You never listen! Prime killed Perfuma!”

“He didn't! He is a good man and you two are murderers!”

It's a tug and pull war now. Angella is yelling in Catra's face and Catra tries to snap herself away. Her legs are unsure and wobbly, trying not to fall again against the floor where her knee shakes like crazy and her whole body is shivering, trembling with the course of adrenaline and pain.

Angella is dragging her towards the stairs at the same time Catra tries to pull away. The elevator behind her dings and opens, cracking and shaking dangerously.

“You don't understand, please Angella,” Catra tangles her fingers over Angella's blouse, biting back a scream, unable to hold back tears. “It's not her fault. You need to listen to me”

“Murder is murder. I should have known since the very first moment I saw her but Priest Prime told me to trust, to pray for her, to hope she would be good in the end. I allowed you to be in my house, I allowed her to be near my daughter,” Angella grips Catra's wrists so hard that the delicate bones protest with pain, numbing Catra's already bruised body. “But that's over, I am going to make her pay. I am not holding back from doing what is right now”

“This is where you decide to grow a fucking back bone? Fuck you!” Catra bites into her mouth and rests her hand over Angella's shoulder, digging her nails over her skin. “Fuck you!”

“She is going to jail and I swear to the Deity I will make sure neither of you will ever be able to see each other again”

“No!”

Catra shoves Angella back, hard. She doesn't even notice the cloak Prime left behind and neither does Angella, not until her feet trip against it and she stumbles back, losing her balance. Neither of them notice how close they are to the stairs railing until it's too late.

It's an accident, really, it is an accident. Catra didn't mean to do it but, quite honestly, wouldn't you have done the same?

Angella trips against the railing and falls backwards, disappearing among the marble and the metal. She is there one second, her face raged and then surprised, shocked even, afraid when the ground disappears below her. And the other second she is gone, fallen, pushed out of heaven by an angel's trembling hands.

Catra stands still in the middle of the corridor, out of breath. Her arms are stretched in front of her and her breath is stuck on her throat, staring with wide eyes at the empty space in front of her.

If she stops the raging beating of her heart, she can hear the sound of Angella's head crashing against the ground.

She doesn't even notice when it happens, but she stumbles back down towards the elevator, falling heavily in her butt and back against the metal of the floor. It bites on her frail skin and makes her hiss, or whimper, she is not sure above the panting tangled in her chest, choking her down.

Angella is dead, dead. Catra killed her, she is a murderer now too. And the worst thing is that Catra doesn't not regret it at all. She would do it all over again just to protect Adora; she understands now.

The doors of the elevator start to close on her and her eyes catch the glimpse of movement to the side of the corridor. Prime, cradled in black and still with the godforsaken mask over his face, is looking at her, leaning back against the frame of the emergency door.

His green eyes dig inside Catra's and just as the doors fall closed he smiles.

**Dawn of October 28th**

**Montenegro's Mausoleum**

"Adora," Double Trouble gasps, choking on blood. "Adora, please"

Adora means back, her hand still dug inside their mouth. She tilts her head to the side, considering DT's destroyed face with curious eyes.

"Oh, you said something?" she asks with a little chiro in her voice. The dirt and rocks of her parents' defiled mausoleum digs into her knees, scratching past her dark clothes and making her bleed a little.

She is sitting over DT's body, locking them against the ground with her weight, eating her way across their face with her nails

and her knuckles, enjoying every single second where the flesh rips and blood falls against the thick leather of her gloves.

She kind of wants to take them off, to feel the flesh over her own skin, but working with teeth is a delicate matter and she needs them all in good condition for what she is planning for them.

Double Trouble on the other hand, well, there is not much they can give Adora now. Besides dying, of course.

“Please,” DT begs again, trying to wrap their hand around Adora's wrist and push her away. But they're too weak already, to bathered in wounds. The only reason they are not dead yet is because Adora wanted to make them feel it, regret it completely as she ripped them of everything precious for them.

“ *Please, please,* ” Adora mocks them, licking her lips. “Did you think Catra would have begged you when you sold her secrets to Prime? To Angella? Did you even care how much she would suffer?” Adora leans her face towards them, speaking against their bloodied nose. “Did you care about her when she was trusting you with her heart? With her body? When she was seventeen and scared in that destroyed car?”

Adora slaps them across the face, just because she can, just because has wanted to do it since she saw the hickeys marking Catra's neck and found her bleeding on the copilot seat of a wreckage.

“Did you remember what you told me the other day? When I found you roaming your way in Glimmer's gardens? You said I didn't know Catra, you said she kept things from me. You said you knew how pretty her legs looked,” Adora spits the words on DT’s face, digging her nails over their throat, choking them out of their breath. “You are so fucking stupid. Did you think I didn't know? She is the half of my soul. And she knows everything about me too, all of it, even the blood.”

Adora leans back, ripping her hands from their neck, taking a deep breath of old air inside the mausoleum. She hums, the ring of a song she has not been able to rip from her head since she was fourteen years old.

“You like putting on shows, right? That´s a pity.” Adora brushes her hair back, holding it all above her head. She doesn't want to smell like blood when she returns next to Catra in bed. “You know, I thought about it, about how to slice you and mangle you for the rest of the town to find you but in the end I realized I wasn´t going to give you that last wish.”

Adora drops.her weight back above their body and smiles, all white teeth and golden hair, overwhelming eyes like blue bells against the darkness. The last thing Double Trouble is going to see is her face smiling at them.

“I´m going to make sure they don't find a single trace of you until your bones fester the animals of the woods, I promise you.”

## October 29th

## The Cathedral

“You are so much like your mother.”

Adora's pupils shrink, leaning down to speak right next to Prime's ear. Somewhere in the chapel a window bursts open violently, pieces of glass and metal being pushed around heavily and a loud call, drowning every single sound inside and letting the cold breeze of the night slip inside through every corner and altar, blowing all the candles off.

Adora bares her teeth at him, soaked in blood from head to toe. She is not trembling anymore, she is not doubting. Her mouth tastes like Catra's skin and her hands are sticky with their hunt's and she is maiming the main beast, the faux demon, just another prey of her plan.

Even with all he has done, even with all the blood he has spilled, even with all the pain he has caused to whom Adora most tried to protect, he is still completely under Adora's control.

“I am not,” Adora growls, leaning back, searching for the symbol’s sharp frame. “I am your death. I am your god”

## Spring, Fourteen Years Ago

## The Graveyard

There is a golden hare in the woods of the chapel. Jumping and running its way away it now lays dead on the grass. Maybe it jumped too high and snapped its neck in half.

Maybe Adora held it too hard and broke it instead.

Catra looks at it, stunned, but Adora just seems annoyed, wrinkling her nose when the drops of blood fall over Catra´s tiny soles.

“It´s dead,” Adora points out, dropping it back against the moss, spotting the grass in red.

How inconvenient, truly. It's a beautiful day, warm after a morning of rain, the ground damp with dew and the trees filled with evergreen leaves and colorful flowers.

They have separated from their parents, too much maybe, chasing the little animal across the forest unt they found themselves here, playing hide and seek across the stones of the graveyards and humming at the echo of the cathedral's bell singing the eleventh hour of the morning.

In reality, only Catra had been chasing the hare, following its golden coat and its soft paws across mud and grass, giggling when it would escale her hands and grunting softly when it kicked her back and scratched her palm.

Adora, on the other hand, had been following Catra, walking and running next to her across meadows and fields of the forests and watching at her precious face laughing, pink and smiling. And then sad, so deeply sad, by the scratch and then by the blood. Adora didn't like that the hare scratched Catra's palm and now, when she turns around to meet her eyes, she sees red cheeks and pearl tears falling from her eyes.

“Don´t cry,” Adora chirps at her, searching for her pretty face. She cradles her tiny cheeks inside her also tiny hands, bumping their forehead together softly. “I can cook you something. I can make you a pretty something with its skin”

Catra opens her mouth but the tears win over her, clogging her throat. She doesn't mean to cry, she really doesn't, but she can't help the sob that echoes against Adora's cheeks, a shaking breath and a soft whimper.

Adora's small eyes widen, her young face nuzzling against Catra's cheeks, cooing her, calming her, trying to soften the sadness. Guilt falls over her like a heavy blanket, making her ashamed and sad.

“I'm sorry. You liked it,” Adora pouts, kissing her cheek. “I won't do it again”

“It’ine,” Catra says in a whisper, still looking at the hare.

“It's not, it made you cry,” Adora wraps her hands around Catra's, caressing her knuckles with her tiny thumbs.

Catra sighs at the touch, finally looking from the animal to Adora again. Adora's hands are warm, soft around her skin and kind, touching Adora with so much sweetness that it makes her heart flutter inside her chest.

They are both children still, seven and joyful. There is darkness inside Adora but it is tamed, quieted down and calm at the sight of Catra's smile and the sound of her laugh. There is also darkness inside of Catra but it is different, a kind that almost looks

like light, a kind that loves Adora above everything else, above life itself.

Adora takes Catra softly away from the hare, cleaning her soles and hands from red with the damp moss and smiling at her, all tooth gales in her grin and sweet glint in her eyes.

“I'll take care of all the hares and all the animals for you,” Adora promises, the first of many, bringing Catra's hands towards her chest and holding her there forever. She exclaims the words to the air, to the world, opening her arms to the side and grinding from ear to ear. “I´ll make you pretty bracelets with flowers and you can sing so they bloom. I'll help you swim in the river. I'll make you happy.”

Adora thinks it well, looking at the graveyard and the cathedral that she has prohibited ever visiting and then to the deep of the forest where they have grown up, where lover's ruins lay among fallen trees.

“I'll make you a castle in the woods,” Adora says and it's a vow, a whisper, a declaration of love untouched by anything wrong.

Catra chuckles, the smile returning to her cheeks, her heart blooming with love inside her chest. “Promise?

“Promise.”

Catra grins and wraps her arms around Adora bringing her into an embrace. She holds Adora so hard against her chest, tucking her face against her young neck and making her way inside her heart forever.

“I want to bury it,” Catra whispers in Adora's ears, still compassionate and kind above everything else.

“Okay!” Adora nods, because she would give Catra everything, anything she ever asked her for, Adora will give it to her. “Let´s pick some flowers”

Adora kisses Catra's cheek and tickles her in the ribs, laughing at each other as they hold the other's hands and run through the tombs, picking up tiny flowers and making with them a bow. Each other's brides. Nightingale and hunter.

From the chapel's window, the Priest stares at the scene and smiles.

♥

## October 31th, Evening

The emergency services, ambulances and detectives are going insane outside of the house. In a way it must be great, a really fucking work trip Adora think, because later on their lives, when all of these people grow old and have reached the end of their lives they will be able to say that they were there, on the house, on the murder scenes when the Etheria slashers murdered all those people all those years ago.

The forensic department is pulling gurneys with black bags on them, speaking in soft voices among themselves and shaking their heads when someone asks something about anyone left alive. Other people are taking pictures, scribbling things in papers and in data pads, taking off protective bags from their shoes so as to not contaminate anything else.

Adora even sees someone walk it with the ax inside a bag. That's alright, she guesses. She is good at what she does, she is good at cleaning traces and planting others, practical and quick on it. And she knows this is all a show after all, they are not going to dig deeper from what it has already in front of them. Not as they roll out the body of one of them in a dark bag and tag her as an accomplice of murder.

It's a nice day, warm after rain. She loves these kinds of days.

They are sitting on a bar corner of the curb, over a stone benche between the street of the house and the line of trees. From here, the noise of the cars and the people going in and around drowns the murmur of the Thaymor river, deeper inside the forest. Adora holds Catra's hand tightly between her palms, caressing her knuckles and playing with her fingertips, reassuring her and calming her when some paramedic comes to check on them and wraps them inside a shock blanket.

Catra is quiet but she nuzzles tenderly against Adora’s side, her eyes glued to the scene and her lips closed. There is something going on inside her mind, this much Adora can tell, running down her bloodstream and itching underneath her skin, but Adora allows her to work through on her own first. Adora is there, after all, holding her, she is never going to stop holding her no matter what.

The door of the big house suddenly flies open again, a bunch of paramedics rolling down a gurney rushing out of it and into the street. They are yelling orders to each other and to the people gathered around the street so they get out of the way, the white cover of the gurney staining progressively more and more in red.

“I have a pulse!” one of the paramedics yells, carrying the gurney alongside the others inside the ambulance. “Get me that IV, now!”

The hand of the person inside the gurney slips and hangs off the gurney, drilling a soft trail of blood all over the floor just as the doors of the ambulance slam closed again.

“Oh well.” Adora says with a small hum, kicking her feet in front of her. “That's unfortunate, I guess.”

She giggles under her breath, tilting her head to look towards Catra's direction. Catra’s pretty face, however, has changed completely. Her precious eyes are hooded and dark and her mouth is tense, still pressed against Adora's bare shoulder but cold.

“Cat? What are you thinking baby?” Adora asks softly, brushing Catra's bangs out of her face. Catra exhales against Adora's bruised upper arm, nuzzling her nose over her skin.

“We are going to die young, you know that right?”

Adora freezes, locking herself into a shiver. Her mouth falls open as she stares at Catra's freckles, her curls bouncing over her

forehead and the secret kiss still hidden in the corner of her mouth that she gives Adora with every embrace.

“What? No,” Adora says, and it comes shivering, frightened, completely broken in the edges. “I’ll do anything to make sure you have a happy life”

Catra looks at her now, her bright eyes holding Adora with so much tenderness and so much sadness that it steals them both off their breath. “I know”

A few yards in front of them, a couple of detectives are standing across from each other, all of them gathered in front of something one of them holds. The sudden movement makes Adora snap her eyes towards them, tearing her sight away from Catra and narrowing her eyes to understand what is going on.

The detectives turn to look at them and it's only then that Adora sees the data pad in her hands. White and golden and with the mayor's symbol on the back, Angella's data pad is held onto their hands and Adora knows exactly what they are looking at.

“Is it them?” One of the detectives asks, wrinkling their nose.

“Yes,” another whispers, brushing her palm over her gun. “Huntara sent it to the whole department”

The fucking video of the mall, the one that places Adora directly on Sea Hawk's murder, the one Angella saw that caused her death. The one Adora deleted from Huntara’s fucking phone but that never occurred to her that she make have done a safe copy off.

“Oh, Angella,” Adora mutters, clicking her teeth together. “Fuck”

Freezing cold runs down her body, making her gasp, making her want to scream and tear her hair from the root. It's not fair, she is done. The hunt is done, this is it, Adora is supposed to get Catra out of here now. Not this, not after everything. But Adora has

never been so lucky in her whole life and nobody has ever listened to her prayers.

Catra is moving. She wraps her palms around Adora's jaw and coos her gently towards her face. She presses their lips together, once, twice, a bittersweet kiss. Charged with cadness, charged with hope, with guilt and with freedom. They both taste like the blood of their friends and their captors. They taste like each other and like rain. Adora does not want to admit it yet but they are too far gone. Catra knows though.

Numbness falls over Adora´s whole being and she doesn't even notice when Catra slips off her arm until she is standing up and walking away from her, marching directly towards the line of trees without looking back.

"Cat?" Adora calls, suddenly frightened, sprinting out of the bench without caring if it calls the police's attention.

Catra does not listen to her, following a path only both of them know, across stones and patches of moss. Adora rushes behind her, tripping on the floor on her bare soles and reaching for her among branches and bushes thick with berries.

The forest is full of life after the rain, animals roaming the earth to eat, to feast after so long without being able to do so. Birds flying across the sky and from tree to tree and singing in the top of the trees where they make their homes, never looking down to watch what is happening below.

Adora walks and walks and walks, her heart on her throat and her soul away from her until the forest opens up for her, revealing the green and metal rotten and moss covered sight of the old Thaymor Bridge, old and beautiful and filled with sadness.

Catra is standing at the very edge, where the railing is destroyed and there is nothing between her and the turmoils of water below but a gasp of air. She is looking down at it, almost as if she was

looking for her reflection on the murky waters, almost as if she was waiting for Adora to reach her before giving a step forward.

Adora slips into the rotten rails and walks soft but quick towards her. She raises her arms in a calming motion, both to alert Catra of her presence and to be sure to catch her inside her arms if Catra tilts too close towards the water.

Catra already knows she is here, of course. She can feel Adora inside her bones.

“They know, don't they?” Catra asks and her voice is a whisper among the rush of the water.

Adora lowers her hands, her eyebrows knitting in sadness. “I think they do, my love.”

After everything, they know. Adora won't be able to walk out of this free but Catra still might. They both know this. Catra sighs, looking at the blue sky above her, narrowing her eyes at the birds and the trees. She is so close to the edge that it makes Adora want to scream but she doesn't move forward, instead turning around to search for her face.

“I've ruined you, Adora,” Catra says and her face is impossibly sad yet she looks the most beautiful Adora has ever seen her before.

“No, you haven't, love,” Adora steps right in front of Catra, “I did it all because I wanted to.”

Catra is holding a knife. Adora didn't even notice when or from where she took it but it is the same one Adora used against Huntara and later against Glimmer. In Catra's hands it looks foreign, a weapon of destruction that is not meant to be on such ge take hands, in hands what were supposed to live a soft life.

Catra points the knife towards Adora´s neck, head steady, eyes sad. All of her sadness was born from love. Sadness has reached her, eaten her alive and oh, maybe they are both dead after all.

Adora steps closer until she is right in front of Catra, the sharp end of the knife digging in the fragile skin of her neck, drawing a single drop of blood. Adora cradles Catra´s cheek inside her palm, looking at her tenderly. Catra is soft, she is always soft, bravery coated in gentleness.

They have killed for each other, Adora has hunted for her. They have bleed, for justice, for freedom, for pain. Prime, Weaver, Light Hope, Hordak, the people that hurt them and killed them are dead now too. But so are Perfuma and Starla and Sea Hawk and Scorpia. Adora was not lying when she said she didn´t want them to die, she also wasn´t lying when she said she didn´t regret it. Adora has always known she is a monster, she just fell in love in the middle.

“Do it if you want, it's alright,” Adora whispers, not even flinching, not even scared, leaning her forehead against Catra's bridge nose. “You are the only owner of my life Catra. If I´m going to die it´s going to be off your hand”

Catra looks at her, face hard and crying. She knows too, that the hunt has come to the end. She knows Adora has freed her and sacrificed herself instead.

“We are rotten”

“We are, my love,” Adora nods, kissing the corner of her eyes.

Catra turns the knife around and rests the sharp edge against her neck, opposite to the scar, threatening her own skin with its sharpness. Adora moves immediately this time, wrapping her palm and fingers over the blade, pulling the weapon back without taking it off Catra´s hold. Adora´s hand starts to bleed, cut open, dripping blood over Catra´s collarbones

“Cat”

“We are not okay,” Catra murmurs, almost so fond and sweet that it sounds like a lullaby. “We can´t go to college, we can´t have boring jobs. We cannot have that life anymore, we cannot be

Adora and Catra anymore.” Catra rests her free palm over her mother´s scar, like a phantom following to hell. “I can hear her still, I know you can hear them all too.”

Adora gasps, blinking around tears. Catra lets go of the handle, dropping the weapon between them. The knife tumbles against the rails between them and falls towards the river, losing itself forever among the rush of violent waters.

Adora sniffs, cupping Catra's face between her palms, brushing a stroke of red over her chin and jaw. She looks at Catra with all the love and devotion of the world nestled inside her irises, begging her to stay a little longer.

“But I freed you,” Adora whispers, her tears like pearls against her skin. “You are free. You are free, my love”

“I know, Adora. And I love you.” Catra kisses the corner of her mouth, lingering her sweetness on her skin. “Thank you.”

Catra closes her eyes for a second, sees the blood below her eyelids, her own blood, Adora's, the stare of the people on the street as they realize that the hunter is among them. They will never stop hunting Adora now, no matter what, no matter what happened to them, no matter the reasons why they did it.

They will always see the blood and not the beauty, they will always feast on the gore, not in the meat. They don't know Adora and Catrs like they know each other, and as long as they are here they will never truly be here. They haven't been free in such a long time.

“They will take you away from me, and I– I don´t want to be me anymore, Adora. I don't want to be the me that belongs to them anymore” Catra smiles, nuzzling her cheek inside Adora's palm. “We are dead and I want to start again.”

Adora holds her breath and nods, managing the sweetest of smiles. This is not what she was seeking, this is not what she

wanted, but she also doesn´t want to leave her side. The only thing she has ever wanted was to be able to be by her side.

She wraps Catra inside her arms, lowering her head to press a kiss over the jarring scar in her neck. In the thick woods behind them, the sounds of shouting and heavy steps coming towards them can be heard.

“What else?” Adora whispers against Catra's ear, drowning out the sounds. She cradles her head and tangles her fingers on her dark oak hair. “I´ll give you everything, Cat”

“I want you,” Catra confesses, kissing a line of tenderness across Adora's jawline. Adora smiles, nodding softly

“You have me, always.” The sounds are even closer now but they are not stronger than their voices and not stronger than the river below them. “What else, sweetheart?”

Catra smiles against her skin, humming at the murmurs of the forest. “I want a castle in the woods.”

Adora giggles, caressing circles against her skin. “Very well.”

Catra is right, they haven't been truly theirs, their own in such a long time, in forever, chased by shadows that clipped their wings as they barely managed to remain together. They have hunted, they did it, they brought justice to both of them and to their families. Now it´s time for peace and that peace is not here to be found.

Adora rests her mouth against Catra's cheekbone, breathing on her skin. Catra hums, looking at Adora through half opened eyes. She also can hear the sounds from the forest now. “If we fall we won't make a sound”

Adora cradles Catra's face and brings her into a searing kiss, her cut palms painting crimson marks over her cheeks and neck. Catra responds in kind, pouring all the sweetness of her heart in Adora's mouth.

This is who they are in this life. Sinners. Monsters. Justice lost in pain. Brides soaked in blood, imprisoned, setting each other free by blood. Catra is freeing Adora too, she has done it for a long time. This is the last thing they both have to give to these people, this town, this history, and then they will be each other´s.

The bushes part in the middle besides the bridge, revealing the figure of several detectives, gasping for air and red on the face as they chase their way behind them. Adora cradles Catra's head below her chin again, keeling her back against the scene, guarding her inside her arms as she promised to do since they were six.

"I´ll find you," Adora vows and Catra listens. She smiles.

"I know"

One of the detectives pulls out a gun towards them, raising it at the level of her eyes and screaming at the top of her lungs. "Stay right there!"

Adora doesn't even look at her. She closes her eyes and leans her temple against Catra's, enveloping them both into an embrace. They are covered in blood, other´s and their own.

"It´s alright sweetheart, I got you. You can go sleep now." Adora whispers, feeling Catra's smile against her skin. "I love you."

"I love you." She sounds drowsy, like when they make love. She is falling asleep in Adora´s arms.

Catra opens her mouth a slit and sighs, an exhale, a hum. A song. She is singing, singing again. It´s different than before, lower and quiet, tender and sour, bittersweet on the tongue and overwhelmingly loving. She is singing for Adora, for herself, for both of them. She is free and she is singing again and they are both leaving.

"Stop. Stop!"

Adora presses her mouth against Catra´s ear, damp and warm. Whispers something under her breath. Nobody will ever know what, it's only theirs to have.

Catra steps off the bridge and they fall down the river together.

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**October 22th, Sunset**

**The Chapel's Ruins**

“I have to go.” Adora says between kisses, holding Catra's wrists inside her palms but unable to lean away. “They need to see me at the party or they might figure things up.”

Catra parts from her mouth with a soft puff of air, exhaling against Adora's peach cheeks. There are beauty marks all over Adora's face, moles and sun freckles and tiny spots of past acne. Catra loves them all, she misses them so much every day when Adora has to put on the makeup Light Hope hands her to look porcelain and smooth.

Catra bites into her bottom lip, the edges of her piercings digging softly against the plumb skin of her kiss bitten mouth. She caresses the angle of Adora's sharp jaw with her fingers, shivering when Adora tilts her head and places a gentle kiss over her open palm.

There is so much devotion between them, it feels like something so light, so wonderful, so unstained still by pain and yet, they both know they are drowning in poison already, barely holding on by holding onto each other.

It makes Catra tired, and it makes her want to wrap Adora inside her arms and never let her go from this spot of the woods patch.

“Adora. Are you sure about this?” Catra asks because she needs to, because she has to. Before the horror starts, she needs to make sure Adora is not going to throw herself on the fire for nothing. Catra thinks of herself as nothing.

“I am,” Adora answers immediately, nodding, placing kisses over Catra's wrists. She is a little bit cold in the fingertips and her shirt covers the healing scars Light Hope left on her before leaving. “I'm not letting them get away with it, Catra.”

Catra exhales, blinking back tears. She was brave, so brave before. Now she feels she is going to break all the time. Adora holds her steady, and just the thought of Adora putting her own life in the line again, *for Catra,* makes Catra want to run to the bridge and throw herself from it. Makes her want to scream and kick and fight. Makes her want to laugh because she is wanted and she is loved and she cannot allow Adora to hurt herself because of her again. She loves her too much.

“You don't have to do this,” Catra wraps her fingers frantically around Adora's soft shirt, bringing her closer between her legs. The stone of the tomb digs on the back of her legs but she ignores it, holding Adora's precious eyes in hers. Sometimes silver, sometimes blue. Sometimes red. “You don't have to do anything at all, Adora. You've done enough already, you've sacrificed enough of yourself. Please. ”

Adora looks at her tenderly, so tenderly, caressing the corner of her eyes with her thumb. They could've had so much, such a tender life. Adora would have been happy with it. She wouldn't have needed the hunt or the fight or the blood.

She wishes deep inside her heart that neither of them were dead.

“Cat,” Adora whispers, kissing the bridge of Catra's nose, holding her eyes inside hers. “I'm a murderer.” She says it gently but firm, practice, facts. Still, she trembles where she holds Catra's face. Her only gentle spot is her. “I have always been one, you know this. You still choose to love me after all, and I will never deserve you for that. I will never deserve your love”

“Adora–”

“Let me free you,” Adora begs, curling her palms around Catra's cheeks. Adora's tears are warm when they fall against Catra's forearms and Catra knows Adora still sees her blood beneath her eyelids. “Let me free us both”

Catra has never been a crier but she undoes herself on the seams. She nods, exhaling something that sounds like an *Okay* but that goes lost between their cradled lips. They kiss dearly over the tomb of dead lover´s fingers against shoulders and jaws and lips over eyelids and tongues. Catra exhales and Adora inhales. Adora holds her breath and Catra gives her hers instead. It´s tender and bloodied, the way in which they love each other.

They say goodbyes between shared kisses and sighs, holding to each other still. Adora bends down and kisses Catra´s knuckles, the inside of her wrist, the crevices of her palm, lingering all of her love on her skin before looking up and back at her, her heart suddenly hammering inside her throat.

“Catra?” Adora whispers and it sounds shaken, out of breath. Devoted yet scared. “You might not love me when I'm done”

Catra´s eyes widen, her mouth opening just a slit, just to gasp. She has spent so many years thinking she is not worthy of Adora ´s love and yet here is Adora, hunter and sun in Catra´s life, shivering by the mere thought of Catra hating her for wanting to protect them both.

It should be scary, this plan of Adora´s, this agreement of theirs. It should be terrifying and disgusting and recoiling, it should make Catra want to run away, curse at her, cover her eyes and scream who Adora is, but she doesn´t. She loves Adora, including the blood. She has loved her since they were six years old, she will love her until the day they both die and rot for this. She loves her.

“I will always love you,” Catra whispers, reassures her, wraps her inside her adoration too. “I love you, so much Adora, you have no idea how much.”

“I do,” Adora´s eyes wrinkle in the corners, her smile small but caring, full of all the words Catra already knows, full of all the love Catra already holds inside her heart. “I love you. I adore you with all my heart”

Catra sits on the moss covered stone and looks at the sky, the blues and goldens above them, the swirls of the storm cloud above their heads, the tale of an incoming storm about to break above them. Adora braids flowers in the crown of her curls and places seeds that she knows Catra will plant on her childhood home inside her palms.

It is already drizzling by the time they finally manage to part from each other, sweet kisses and even sweeter words. Catra drinks every single one of them and guards them inside her heart. In a way it feels like the beginning of an end, the last words of their play, their names carved on the stone.

“I'll see you in the morning,” Adora whispers in her ears and kisses her against the window of the ruins, leaving her heart inside Catra´s palms when she leaves among the woods. She turns around to see her one last time, breathing Catra´s eyes inside her ribcage and lungs and heart.

The paper lamp is still hanging from the window, the candle long ago burnt out. A wish already made.

Adora has traveled through this underworld and trusted Catra will follow behind, unable to hold herself and not turn around. She loves her that much.

The most beautiful demon has fallen in love with a nightingale. They are both going to die.

## Fifteen Years Ago

## The Whispering Woods

Adora is six the first time she sees Catra, held from her father's hand in the forest where Randor and Marlena are taking them hunting.

Her skin is dark, her cheeks dusted in freckles. Her curls are in her face and her eyes are stars and Adora's heart no longer belongs to her.

“Adora,” the owner of the name says in a breath, in a exhale, the corner of her eyes twinkling with tears when she speaks. She doesn't understand them but they are born from devotion. “I’m Adora”

The little girl with stars in her eyes blinks at her and then smiles, broad across her face, full of relief, full of love, as if she recognized her even beyond her innocent comprehension.

“Hey, Adora,” she whispers. The way she rolls the *r’s* in her voice makes Adora think she is singing. She is walking towards her over the moss now. There are ruins of a chapel around them. “I’m Catra"

They are already each other's brides but they don't know it yet.

Adora stretches her young arm and catches a soft curl between her fingers, bouncing it softly against Catra's face. Under the golden light of the morning, her dark hair seems to shine copper and golden. Crowning her head, making her eyes look like the night skies.

“You have wings” Adora marvels, running small fingers across Catra's cheeks.

Catra giggles. She is in love too, as innocent and pure as their love could ever be. Untouched.

Adora is six the first and only time she sees an angel and from that moment on she is hers, completely. She loves nothing more, she knows nothing more. She adores her.

Another kind of devotion blooms in her heart. An old kind of love, guarded in the secrecy of the forest. The river washes away their laughter and they are together

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*End of Chapter VII*

*End of Part III*

Chapter End Notes

It´s funny because it went right under your noses

MAESTRO, PLAY "HAYLOFT II SPEED VERSION" aka THE Adora Song

Damn, I wish I could see the expression in your faces right now jsjs I honest to god didn´t think I would be able to fool you. Did you like the whole story of Prime´s murders? As Adora says, it was fun distracting you ;)

There was one person at the begining that commented that Adora could be a Despara version killing for Catra and, well, you were absolutely right. Except that this Adora knows absolutely what she is doing. It was all there, right from the begining it has all been there. The Hunter and the Nightingale

Hunter/Murderer Adora is absolutely one of my favorite Adora ´s I have ever done. I love the side of our usual Adora where she is not only a little shit but also a person with a lot of angry issues and I really wanted to explore what kind of person would she be if she chosed Catra above everything else and lost her anyway. Also, exploring a softer side of Catra where all the fire we know from her is already gone from the very start, which hurt like hell by the way. A lot of bad things happened to them and they just snapped in different ways. But at least, one way or another, they are free now.

Also, don´t be sad right now, we still have the epilogue to go! Please leave me your thoughts, screams, yells and comments below, I really want to see what you think ;) Thank you for reaching this point with me! (I´m really nervous right now). Love y´all.

# Epilogue

Chapter Notes

But guys, guys, listen to me ...
... wasn´t Adora at the party?

WARNINGS FOR THIS CHAPTER:
- Mentions of Blood
- Descriptions of death, gore and violence
- Descriptions of animal hunt (which I do not support)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

## Epilogue

## Choirs to Devotion

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*… La la la. La la la. La la …*

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"We didn´t find any bodies," the Detective says, running her palm across her hair. The little sounds of the hospital machines are almost too overwhelming against the silence of the room. "The Thaymor River is too strong, and if the current didn´t kill them the fall against the water did. That bridge is too high. I really don´t think they made it."

The only survivor of the slashers massacre sits on the hospital bed, resting from wounds and blood loss and hours of surgery. To be honest, the only reason why the Detectives waited so long to go and make questions and interviews was because Doctor Castaspella threatened them to stitch their mouths closed if they even got near the room. She probably wouldn´t have done it in the end, but the Doctor can be a really scary person when she wants.

“It´s strange,” another Detective adds, lingering by the half closed windows. The light that pours inside is orange but it is still drizzling outside. “Why all the bloodshed if they were to kill themselves in the end?”

“Oh, come on, really think about it. She must have been a bad seed from the very start too, always being hidden like that by her family. And then the accident? It destroyed her already messed up head,” the Detective shrugs, popping a bubble gum. She shouldn´t be doing that, this is a hospital and she is in front of a survivor. “What happened to the Capellan girl really just drove her over the edge. Sane people don´t just go murdering people out of the blue. And who knows what kind of crazy-jibby-gibby psycho-lovers-path they had after they killed everyone they planned to?”

The second Detective shrugs, scratching their head. “I don´t know, I guess that´s what revenge does to you. It turns you irrational in the end, so much that it can make you kill yourself.”

“I think it was very rational, actually,” Bow interrupts them from the bed, voice steady. The Detectives finally turn to look back at him, the IV´s, wires and clean patches clinging to his body meeting them in the middle. Bow sighs, leaning back on the soft pillow, looking at the ceiling above his head. “Adora would have done anything for Catra. Even dying. Just to be with her”

The two detectives share a look, shrugging after a second.

“Well, dying certainly was better than the alternative. The town would have ripped them to pieces. Especially after that whole Priest fiasco.” The first one ends, leaning away from the wall. “Anyway, no matter what we are closing the case. It´s been two weeks, there is nothing more for us to look into. Rest assured that you will be safe.”

Bow shifts under the sheets of the hospital, scratching the side of his arm. The IV cord pulls from the skin of his hands everytime he moves but he can barely feel it above everything else. He nods,

tilting his head to the side with his eyebrows knitted with curiosity.

“What about my friends?”

“Well, your friend Entrapta has left for the Space Program as planned by them, I really don´t think they´re considering coming back. Besides them, Mermista has finally been released out of the psych guard at the Hospital on Eternia. I believe nobody has told her about the killers but she´ll find out on time, we´ll see what happens with her head then. The two remaining Star Siblings are creating a foundation in their sister's honor but they have refused to speak more with us and they also don´t want to know anything else. There aren´t, um, there really aren´t more members of your group of friends alive, Bow”

Bow nods, still as calm as possible, drumming his fingers over the sheets. The bandages on his chest where he received the stab wound and the hit with the handle of the gun on his head don´t even throb anymore.

“And Glimmer?”

“Still in comma,” the Detective checks their notes on the data pad, wrinkling their nose with an apologetic stare. “They don´t know if she will make it. She lost a lot of blood.” They drop the pad right back, stretching their back with a frown on their face. “Pressing the wound with her hand like she did saved her life, I don´t even know where she learnt that”

“Maybe someone helped her,” Bow offers but when the Detectives look at him curiously he says nothing else, instead looking at the window. He wishes someone would turn down the music a little and open the window fully. He misses looking at the forest beyond the glass.

The Detective reaches the side of his bed, placing their hand over his shoulder gently, standing between his dark eyes and the woods.

“You are a good person, Bow.” They say, mustering a kind smile. It feels wrong, even for them. It is truthful but it feels wrong. Or maybe that's just what Bow can see with his mind and not his heart. “You managed to survive. It´s a miracle you are alive at all, Bow”

“It is, isn´t it?” Bow says, his voice wandering in the room, echoing softly. His eyes unfocus a little, staring at something none of the detectives can see, brushing softly at the bandage on his side. “Adora never failed a stab wound, after all.”

The Detective's mouth goes a little bit slack, something sticky and nasty growing on their chest. They look at the companion but they look just as lost as they feel.

Whatever. After this shit show it will be a miracle if the town gets to ever heal again. Corrupt police and mayor office, psychopath priests, cult fanatics flogging themselves, murderous teenagers, it's just too much. The town's reputation is done for and the remaining people won't take long to move out and leave this place as the ghost place it was meant to be years ago, when it all started.

“We called your brothers. They´ll be here soon to pick you up,” the second detective is playing with something on his hands, out of the evidence bag and disrespected. The delicate links of a necklace and the soft edge of a ring. “I know things got difficult after the accident. Your dads and the Montenegro´s– you all were very unfortunate to go on that trip together”

Bow blinks at them very slowly, scratching his way across his exposed arm. His breath smells like mint and the air is clogged with disinfectant. He has scars on his shoulder and the low of his back, long ago closed and never healed, mirror to Adora's.

“I know.”

The Detectives nod, shrugging, not even paying attention to what they say.

“Well, I guess we will take our leave. The whole department is going to be quite busy these days”

“What do you mean?”

“Oh, well, you know this town boy, it will never stop being what it is. The whole town needs the First Ones even after what happened so there will be a memorial inside the Cathedral in honor of the victims of the murders. Including Huntara and Prime. It´s going to be quite the event, everybody will be there.”

Bow blinks. “In honor of Adora and Catra too?”

“Uh, I don´t think so,” The detective scratches the back of their neck, grimacing. “I think we'll need to give the town a little bit more time with that one. Don´t you agree?

“Yes,” Bow says, voice calm. “Of course."

Both Detectives start walking towards the room's door, considering the conversation long ago finished. They don´t need anything else from Bow anyway, just more technical stuff and signatures and they will finally close this case for good. It's good because nobody really wants to talk more about this and everyone is sick of it.

“Detective?” Bow calls from his hospital bed, tilting his head to the side slightly. He looks from their eyes to the bundle inside their palm, pointing at it with his chin. “Can I keep them?”

The Detective gapes at him, surprise and confusion running through them. “Uh, the locket?”

“It´s a reliquary,” Bow corrects them firmly, humming under his breath. He looks so peaceful like this, hooked to medical stuff yet calm, his eyes smart and his face a mask. His eyebrows, however, they twitch on his forehead, the reflection of sadness shining on his irises. “Adora– she was my friend. Even with everything that happened, I would like to honor her memory in my own way.”

The Detective looks at her and then at their partner, searching for some kind of confirmation. The other one shrugs again, grimacing with an unserious look. They really couldn't care less anymore.

“Of course,” the Detective leans forwards, letting the golden chain fall softly inside Bow´s palm. There are still traces of blood and fine blonde hairs stuck to it. They didn´t even care to clean it after they took it out of the bag, playing with it like a morbid toy.

“And the ring,” Bow adds, rubbing his thumb over the golden surface of the reliquary, opening it with a little click.

This time the Detective does frown, scrunching their nose. “Why the ring? It was the Capellan´s girl, wasn´t it?”

Inside the reliquary there are two pictures, tiny and old, so much that the faces are a little bit blurred and the colors are washed out, yet Bow can still make out of the people living there. Marlena, Randor, Adam and Adora on the left side, cheeks pressed together, smiling, young and happy still. Catra and her father Francis on the right, his cheek nuzzling the top of Catra´s soft curls, also young, also happy.

Bow caresses the edges of the second picture with nostalgic fingers, his mouth pulling down with a mournful frown.

“Catra was my cousin.” Bow says inside the quiet air of the room, still looking at her young face across the tint of the picture. He hears both detectives take a sharp breath and looks at them through his eyelashes, grinning slightly at their stunned expressions. “The look in your faces… yeah, I know, nobody else knew either. Not even Glimmer.”

Bow sighs, rolling his head backwards over the pillow. He explains with a calm voice, slow, so slow it´s almost a secret between him and the quiet detectives.

“Her father was my dad, Lance´s, brother. He was my uncle. After his death at the Bridge, my dad mourned him a lot but he also went to a legal battle with Miss Weaver. I was too young then but

I know he was fighting her to be able to take Catra with us.” Bow exhales, wrinkling his nose. His arms itch and his neck burns, phantom pain crawling under his skin since he was fourteen years old. “Catra would have died too, I guess, if she had gone in that car. I was only in the Montenegro´s because she was sad that Catra was not allowed to come.”

The detectives are looking at him and then at each other, a silent conversation going on between them. There is some spark of intelligence going on inside their eyes but they ignore it, shaking their heads to each other and clicking their tongues against their teeth.

Whatever.

“Here you go,” the Detective drops the battered ring next to the golden chain, rubbing their hands clean over their pants right after. It is also bruised and broken in the edges but delicate still. It will take some time to fix but Bow has always been good at helping with things.

“Thank you”

“Call us if you need anything,” the detectives say with a little smile, nodding at Bow gently.

They like this boy, all the town likes this boy. He is good and kind, always standing on the side lines like them, always quiet. He is all smiles and all soft shoulders to cry into. Soft, gentle, clean. There is nothing unwanted on him that you may get to see. You won´t even notice the moss on his soles, not even if you get too close. Glimmer could tell you that, if she wasn´t stuck inside her own head.

Bow smiles at them, curling his fingers around the reliquary and the ring. If you look close to his wrists and palms, you might catch the fading bruises and the scratches Hordak left behind.

“I'm sure I will”

⏃

## Three months after the Thaymor Accident

## Capellan´s House

"Just let us take her," Lance grunts, cutting Weavers walk across the pretty living room. Weaver turns to look at him with a scowl painted on her red-wine lips, stomping in the ground with the heel of her high shoe.

"Why? She is my daughter, she is perfectly good here." She smells like alcohol, strongly, so much Lance has to recoil back a little, fighting a disgusted snarl only because he is a gentleman. George is a few steps behind him, quiet but ready to sprint into the conversation if needed.

"Is she?" Lance barks, frowning so deeply that his head hurts. Bow looks a lot like George. Catra, however, looks a little bit like Lance, the same eyes as a gift from her father and Lance´s brother. "Why are they bruises on her arms? Why does she look so thin?"

"Listen you little–"

"My brother would have hated you," it shuts Weaver right off.

The mention of Francis is still cut raw, sore, stinging like acid against a wound. In a way it feels as if it had been just yesterday that the rain had stopped and the body had been found. It had been just yesterday that Lance had just lowered his brother to the ground. The hunt gets us all in the end.

Lance sighs, pinching the bridge of his nose. George is right there immediately, caressing a soft circle on his back without losing sight of Weaver, still standing in front of them on precarious feet and flushed cheeks. She looks like she wants to beat them too but she is holding back. Her cruelty has basically just started, set free by her husband's death and the sudden sense that she can do anything now. Lance looks back at her stone face pleading,

narrowing his eyes. He would throw himself to his knees if he could, if that was enough to make her understand.

“Just, let us take Catra, please. You will be able to live your life, enjoy my brother´s money, everything. You won´t even have to see her again if you don´t want to. She will be safe with us. She will have someone her age, Bow, older brothers–”

“No.”

“You don't – you don't even act like you love her!” Lance exclaims, starting to lose it. George approaches him, placing his hand over his shoulder.

“No, I don't. What? Did you think I ever did?” Weaver chuckles, shaking her head. She is not letting go of the gold mine. As long as Catra is with her she gets the inheritance and the house. She is not letting go no matter what. “And still, that stray is staying here with me. So back off you sorry excuse of a family”

Lance kicks something, sending it tethering furiously across the ground.

“You miserable–!”

“Lance, Catrina can hear you,” George urges him, nudging him into something softer.

Bow climbs the stairs to the second floor, careful to not be noticed. He managed to slip through the kitchen door and across the main corridor without either of the three fighting adults seeing him so he is extra careful now, refusing to give himself away.

He doesn´t have to go really far though. Catra is sitting in the stair landing, her little knees against her chest, her hands wrapped around the metal railing, looking downstairs yet hidden in the shadows. Her hair is on her face and tangled, poorly taken care of since her dad´s death and her mother´s descent to madness. Just as Lance said, she is thin, and she wears clothes a

little bit too big for her, covering the bruises in the shape of fingers on her arms and her back.

She is just a kid and today as her uncles and her mother fight, she is quiet and hidden, like a little bird waiting for the storm to pass. And she is sad.

But she is also loved, over anything else, she is loved. By her father until his last breath. By her uncles who are fighting for her. By her cousin that searches for her in the shadows. By Adora that prays for her and still throws little flowers at night on her window, when Weaver cannot see. All of this is for her, the girl that was bright and then sadder, in all her forms.

This is a love letter for Catra.

"Hi, kitty cat," Bow greets her in a whisper, giving her a tiny but reassuring smile. Catra tears her eyes from the dim light of the room below them and turns to look at him, her young eyes hooded. She is too young to be this tired.

"Arrow Boy," she whispers back, resting her cheek over her knee.

Bow hums, reaching her on the landing. He snuggles next to her side, nuzzling her shoulder with his, his legs dangling off the stairs softly. They have always enjoyed sitting close to the edge of tall things, trees, bridges or stairs.

"I bought you something," Bow murmurs, searching on the bottm of his satchel.

He pulls out a small bag, still warm and butter smelling and places it right inside catra´s small palms. Cookies, toffee and salt, Catra ´s favorites. Bow has been teaching Catra how to bake lately, something private of both of them.

Catra´s tired eyes shimmer at the sight of the food, her stomach grumbling beyond her control at the smell. She starts undoing the little bow of the bag but stops in the middle, glancing at Bow weary, as if she was worried he was going to be mad for eating.

Bow frowns but nods reassuringly, smiling at her and that's the only little nudge she needs to gasp and dive right into the flavorful food, humming. Something sad pulls on the pits of Bow´s belly at the sight of her filling her cheeks with dough as if she hadn't eaten in weeks.

“And this. It's from Adora,” Bow pulls a second bundle from his bag, this time more careful. It´s a little bouquet, obviously made with child hands but still carefully done, yellow and blue from the wisteria tree that grows above their ruins. Little lavenders and evergreen long grass too, wrapped in a ribbon of red. “She told me to tell you that she misses you”

Catra smiles at the sight of it, unable to keep the blush from her face and the giggle off her mouth. She caresses the tender blooms over her lap and almost cannot hear the loud yelling below anymore.

Bow presses the back of his hand over her forehead, frowning when he feels the heat radiating from her skin.

“You are a little bit warm.”

“I´m sick,” Catra whispers, sniffing. She looks up again, at the darkness around them, looking at some point beyond Bow´s sight. “I was sick, that's why dad left work that day, to come see me,” she turns to look at her cousin's face, tears hanging from her eyelashes like rain over leaves. The things a mother can say just to hurt you can be terrible. “I killed him”

“No, kitcat,” Bow shakes his head sadly, wrapping his hand over hers, between warm cookies and flower knots. “You didn´t kill uncle Francis.”

He pulls from her as the tears start to fall down her cheeks, dripping between both of them, quiet among the shadows around. She hiccups around sadness and he shushes her gently, children wrapping their arms around each other, trying to comfort each other.

On the level below them a glass crashes against the floor and Catra flinches, already fearing what is to come of her when her uncles leave.

“I don´t want to be alone with her,” she confesses, nuzzling her young face against the angle of Bow´s jaw. He wiggles a little to cradle her more comfortably inside his arms, running his fingers across the tangled curls in a gentle attempt to brush the knots apart.

“Well then I'm staying with you,” he says, smiling when Catra leans back to look at him. He is all white teeth and a gentle smile, shrugging. “You are my favorite cousin after all”

Catra frowns, dabbing him in the ribs. “I'm your only cousin”

“Exactly, by now you are like my only sister,” Bow boops her in the nose, giggling at her annoyed squeal. It is true, all of his brothers are old enough to be either in high school or in college; Catra is his age, young, made out of soft things. “So I get to protect you with my life”

Below them their parents are still fighting in hushed and loud voices, walking in and around the rooms. From the yellow kitchen to the living room that is starting to be pulled down. Bow lingers his mouth next to her cheek, holding this part of his family safe next to him

“Adora also told me to tell you that she loves you.”

Downbelow, Lance runs his fingers above his dreadlocks, pushing his glasses up his nose. He and George are standing now next to the coaches of the living room where Weaver has let herself fall into, avoiding the shattered glass of her wine bottle, sipping on the liquid still stuck on her gums.

“Then at least let us take her alongside us with the Montenegros,” he begs, his eyes exhausted, his body worn.

It calls Weaver´s attention because she straightens up on the couch, nibbling on her lip. She has not seen Adora in such a long time, not since her husband´s death and when she did it was always hanging from her own daughter´s arm.

"Randor´s children?" She asks in a breath, trying to not show how the mention makes her heart speed up.

"Yes. And Marlena´s," George makes a clear point of establishing, softening his voice just for his children´s sake. "They adore Catrina. Adora is very close to her as you already know. If you are to keep her then at least let us take her with them some times."

"I see," Weaver wonders, considering. She might not have her husband anymore and she might have to endure raising the little stray for a while but at least she will have something that ties her to Randor. And her older brother might just be too pleased to hear the news. "Very well then. She is to take choir every single Sunday from now on and all the days I dictate otherwise. If you really want her, you might keep her the rest of the time."

She thinks about it, something crossing her mind, making her click her tongue against her teeth and scoff.

"If you take her to the forest like you like to do, just make sure she comes back clean. I won´t have a soiled animal roaming inside my door."

## Seven Years Ago

## Montenegro´s Car

Outside the busted window of the Montenegro car, past broken glass and towards the street they were calmly driving through towards the cabin there is an intersection, a venue they needed to

cross now after the Thaymor Bridge was closed. Otherwise they wouldn't even be here to begin with.

Past the wreck of the car there are two more cars laying smoking over the grass. Hordak´s expensive car and a completely destroyed one, a van, long and with purple details, carrying the now dead bodies of two men.

Third car, total lost. George and Lance were crushed to death by their own engine, folded like paper with the hit after Hordak crashed directly against them, sending them backwards and hitting the Montenegros and then flying towards the blue sky of the autumn day, crashing back down in a mess of metal and wires and dark smoke.

It was quick, they didn´t even notice they were gone, but it was painful. Bow should know, he saw it happen from the backseat of the Montenegro car, sitting right behind Adora. He can still hear her crying upside down and can see her blonde hair soaked in blood. She can feel him moving softly behind her, gasping for air too.

There is music playing non-stop on the radio and they are children still. So much for families that are more than friends. More than hunting partners.

“Bow?” Adora cries, sniffing, trembling from head to toe. There is blood on her, drilling from the back of her shoulders and neck and across her extended arms. Her voice breaks when Bow takes a little to answer, splintering like glass. “Bow?”

“Dora,” he answers, pushing his tongue through his teeth. He feels like something heavy has made a home inside his mouth, poisoning him from the inside out. “I'm – I'm here.”

He looks at the window, taking on the destroyed shape of his dad's car. He wants to scream, he wants to tear the seatbelt out and scream and run towards them but he is stuck here, upside down in a gas smelling car.

“My dads,” he cries, choking around a sob. “My dads”

Adora cries too, not silent, loud. They both cry inside this crushed car, held by a miraculous hand and in the middle of tragedy. From this angle Bow can see Adam's bent neck.

Their families die and neither of them are ever the same.

## August of the New Year

## The Quarry

Bow parks the car at the outskirts of the Quarry, sighing heavily. He knows he shouldn´t be doing this, not after vehemently promising to Adora not to tell anyone, especially Catra, above it all Catra. But there is just so much Bow can quiet down night after night.

The red clock of the car marks one in the morning and the town is quiet yet the Quarry is loud. It is not a strange knowledge that this place was once a small attraction for the youth to come camping yet after the flood of the rains it has become more like a hiding spot for people from outside the town to come and do hidden things you wouldn´t do in broad daylight.

The first time Adora asked Bow to drive her here, barely a few days after hers and Catra´s return to the town, he was mildly confused. After he stitched her shoulderblade on the back of the truck and drove her back to Light Hope´s at three in the morning, all confusion was replaced by shock. An a certain degree of awe.

Still, there is still so much he could tell and he loves Catra so much too. It´s a miracle he was able to keep it quiet this long.

The Quarry is boiling with movement and sound, bloodthirsty shouts and feral cheers, stomps in the ground and the

characteristic echo of bodies crashing against each other and breaking bones. Multiple people are here, all from dark places, all with darkness festering inside of them, some more than others, gathered around a circle in a mocking mirror of a Greek arena where two people like lions are tearing each other to pieces. If you were to narrow your eyes against the  precarious light of the car, you would catch the swift swing of golden hair against the night.

Catra is already unfastening her belt and throwing the copilot door open, rushing across the treacherous  terrain and trying not to fall. Bow is right behind her, trying to look after her and keeping her from falling. She is always naturally gracious but her feet stumble lately.

She has changed, she is different in a way. When she and Adora came back from the cabin where they have both nursed each other, she was not the same Catra he knew since birth. She was sadder, like a leaf loose on the wind and sent to die, like a spirit, long ago death and long ago forsaken wandering this earth for her lover only. She was quiet, so, so quiet, in her voice and in her soul and in her body. Quiet.

It was heartbreaking, it is soul crushing every time he looks at her. And in a way he understands why Adora is doing this right now.

Adora is in the middle of the chaos, right between the dirt below her feet and the myriad of people gathered around her and her opponent. A huge man that look more like a minotaurus than a human at all, a whole head taller than her and bulkier like fuck. He bares his teeth at her and cackles, not bothering to clean the stinky sweat clinging to his forehead and flexing his arms every time he can in an unashamed display of power.

He grins at Adora from ear to ear and cackles, sending her an invisible kiss and doubling in laughter when Adora narrows her eyes in return. He doesn´t know who she is, nobody of the people gathered here knows. Montenegro heir, tragedy survivor, town´s

princess. They don´t know and they don´t care and that´s exactly what Adora wants.

Adora is calculating. She is shorter than him but she is still taller than everyone else and for some reason Bow thinks sometimes that she has gotten even bigger. Her back is wider and stronger, her arms firmer, hands long and steady. Made to hold love tenderly and pushed to carry the world over her shoulders. All of her hair is held back into a messy ponytail, long ago undone and hanging low over her nape and she is covered in a fine perspiration from head to toe.

She cleans the errand drops of blood from her nose, born from an errand hit to the face that managed to make her bleed and chuckles, tilting her head to the side. This man might be the wet dream of any gym fanatic, but Adora is so much stronger and so much smarter. She moves around him in calm steps, circling him, studying him and his big brute hits. Hunting him.

She is in the middle of a hunt, plain for everyone else to see yet it seems nobody but the people who actually know her notice it.

The man grunts and puffs out his hest, seemingly tired of this little dance of theirs. He leans towards the grown as if he was a bull about to slam down his horns and god forgives actually growls, closing his hands into fists and speeding towards Adora´s form with all his strength.

Adora steps to the side with one swift movement, avoiding the crash and twisting her body in a way that makes it so damn easy for her to raise her arm and slam her elbow against the back of his neck, sending him tethering towards the side of the circle. The crowd cheers around them, laughing at the man´s stumble, making him grunt with unfiltered anger.

He turns around again and throws his arms towards Adora´s direction, who by some reason has not jumped away from her position to avoid a new hit. He manages to wrap his arm around her wrist and pulls her towards him, swinging his arm towards her

without a second thought. The man slams his fist against Adora´s ribs, ripping the air from her lungs with a gasp. Adora coughs but she doesn´t step back, chuckling around the pain. Her hair is soaked with sweat and her nose is bleeding.

Street fighter, seeking blood.

Catra holds her breath next to Bow but she doesn´t move, frozen to her spot between barking people like feral animals and the dirt clustered with saliva and sweat. Bow leans his head to the side and just as he starts to wonder why the hell did Adora allow him to get so close to her, he sees it coming.

Adora uses the proximity and the brute attack to distract her attacker. She wraps her full hand on the back of his head and janks him completely backwards by the hair, easily ripping him of her before he even has time to react or understand what the hell is going on. The man throws a blind punch but Adora already has the high ground here, raising her arm and slamming her closed fist against his face with all her might. It comes with no resistance after that.

It is not clean and not fair, it is dirty fight, painful and grotesque. Adora slams her fist against his face and when he stumbles back to search for his breath she kicks him directly in the middle of the chest, crashing him flat back against the soiled floor. Adora throws herself over his among the enraged cheer of the crowd, straddling her once big body between her thighs and knees, holding him still against the floor and punching him on the face and throat until blood sprays on the earth and moss.

It is not the first time Bow has seen her do this. Hell, he has seen her go even worse and by the state of several other men lingering defeated and bruised on the ground at the limits of the Quarry, he knows this is not her first time tonight. She has become good and she has become insatiable and on any other night Bow would have stepped back and allowed her to unwind herself. Maybe even cheer a little if he gets rubbed with enough shared adrenaline.

But Catra is trembling badly behind him and when he turns to look at her he sees her owl eyes wide. Not plagued with disgust and recoil as any other sane person would be at the sight of such a scene, but devastatingly sad, wrinkling her nose when the man kicks Adora in the side trying to push her away and she just laughs.

Bow rushes across the crowd without another word, pushing several rage intoxicated people back and slipping inside the arena with practiced ability. After all, he is the one that taught about these fights to Adora in the first place. His name is well known here.

“Adora, stop,” Bow wraps his arms around Adora´s shoulders and janks her back from the man, holding most of her struggling and tall body on his and giving an unsure step behind when Adora tries to shake him off in return, craving to come back to her hunt. Below them the man´s face is covered in blood and he has clearly passed out, mouth open and a few teeth on the ground. “Stop it, he is out of it, come on”

“What?” Adora yells at the man's face, ignoring Bow and chuckling. “Weren´t you going to kick my pretty pussy, you fucking asshole?”

“Come on,” Bow insists, finally ripping her away. Adora is still yelling as he pulls her onto her feet, spitting a gush of saliva and blood towards the man's face, her teeth red.

“Fucker”

She snaps her face away from the defeated man and faces the crowd, laughing out loud when they cheer her so loudly and feral that it sounds like the chant of hyenas. It doesn´t even matter that Bow has interrupted the fight, they already got what they were seeking for, the smell of blood and the show of violence. It doesn´t matter if Adora steps back now.

“Don´t be boring, Bow”

“Let´s go, you really want to let go right now.”

Adora allows Bow to drag her away, rolling her head backwards over his shoulder and chuckling around a wheeze of pain when her ribs scream at her in return. She only raises her head when Bow comes to a stop near the tree line of the Quarry, her boiling body freezing immediately at the sight of Catra standing still and quiet, staring back at her with heavy eyes.

She doesn´t belong here, in this place, among dirt and cars and people full of sweat and cackles seeking for blood. She belongs somewhere softer, with her sneakers and her black overalls and Adora´s sweater over her shoulders. Not in the middle of something raw but somewhere more tender.

“Cat,” Adora exhales, her cheeks paling. She snaps her eyes towards Bow, grunting between clenched teeth, her voice and eyes accusatory. “Bow, I told you–”

“I know,“ Bow cuts her, shaking his head. “But I needed to tell her, Dora. She has the right to know”

Adora leans away from him, focusing all of her attention back to Catra. They hold each other´s eyes heavily, quiet, a thousand words and none crossing between them in the frail inches that keeps them apart. Bow shifts on his feet, looking around until he finds some very interesting looking rocks to distract himself into and slip away from the whole ordeal.

“I´ll just, I´ll just sit here,” he mutters, quickly moving away. He would be in the mood for a good fight if it wasn´t because his most beloved family member and his best friend were looking at each other as if the world were to explode any second now.

Once Bow is fairly gone, Catra clicks her teeth together, her shoulders shivering when she turns around and walks several yards inside the tree line. Adora follows her immediately, wordlessly and with her heart on her throat, following her trail like the space follows a falling comet.

Catra stops suddenly, without a warning, opening and closing her hands at her sides. Adora wrinkles her nose and nibbles on her bottom lip, the pain of the fights merely a ghost or a second thought on her body right now.

"I know you are angry," Adora whispers, giving a single step towards her. Catra snaps her face towards her but there is no anger in there, just sadness and quiet resignation, and that somehow hurts Adora even more.

"Why are you doing this to yourself?" Catra asks, walking softly through the space that separates them. She thumbs at the drops of blood staining Adora´s sleeveless shirt. Under the light of the cars and the full moon, she can see Adora´s scars like a second skin over her. "Why are you allowing them to hurt you?"

Adora´s eyebrows skyrocket, her mouth falling open. Out of all things, as always, this is the last thing she expected Catra to ask. Why the Quarry, maybe? Why street fighting? Why beat anger-drunk people in the middle of the night? Not why is Adora letting them hurt her, again.

Bow asked her too, why did she really want to join the quiet and red club, and she answered sincerely. But now that Catra knows and it's standing right here in front of her, watching with her own eyes the carnage, Adora doesn´t know what to say.

"I– because I–" Adora tries but finds herself out of words.

"Did you think it would scare me away? Is that why you kept it from me?" Catra whispers and it hurts more than all the punches and bruises to Adora´s bones. Catra looks at her from under her big eyelashes, thumbing her bruised nose with her fingertips. "Did you think I would not want you if I saw you hunting?"

Adora gasps, out of breath. There is fire swirling inside Catra´s eyes, red and blue and golden and in one burning second Adora realizes that Catra is not disgusted or angry. She *wants.* Vulnerability through desire.

“I'm your sword,” Adora whispers sore against Catra´s palm, kissing the inside of her wrist. Catra frowns, confusion falling over her like rain.

“What?”

“I'm your sword. Your executor,” Adora confesses, rotten sweet. She wraps her long fingers around Catra´s wrist, kissing her way across her forearm and the inside of her elbow. The adrenaline of the fight is being chased off by another kind of craving. “I´m getting ready”

“For what?”

“To defend your honor.” Adora establishes, lingering a kiss over Catra´s collarbone above the window of her turtleneck. Catra smells good, clean like the products the Bright Manor use and like sandalwood, forever itched to her skin. Adora smells like metal and like blood, sweat and mud crawling on her skin. Catra presses her nose against it and breathes it in.

“My honor,” Catra chuckles, looking at the clouded sky and shaking her head. “Adora, I have no honor left. It was ripped from me”

“Then to bring justice to it.” Adora grunts, reaching Catra´s jaw and cheeks, feeling how the fight and the sadness starts leaving her body, replaced by something melting sweet and boiling to the touch. “You told me to hunt so I will. I´ll strip from my honor and wrap it around you.” Adora licks a line over the shell of her ear and kisses the corner of her eye sweetly. “Let me feed you, let me save you”

“Save me,” Catra repeats but there is no exasperation on it. Just breathless infatuation. “Adora, I´m already–”

“Dead?” Adora finishes for her, pressing their foreheads together, caressing Catra´s cheekbone with her raw and bleeding knuckles. “Then I´ll be holding your hand at the edge of the bridge. But with my other hand I will make them pay.”

Catra exhales, melting in Adora´s hands. She cannot say no, she cannot look away and she cannot not hold her, blood and all. She will not, she has no desire to do so. She knew from the moment Bow sat her down and explained to her what Adora was doing and she thinks Bow knew too. Adora is not stopping but she still needs the people she loves by her side to do so.

"Then, if you still want us to, we can die together," Adora vows, wrapping her body, bent for the fight and the blood, around Catra ´s scarred and soft one. "Maybe just not in winter"

Catra laughs without a breath, shaking her head. She hates the cold.

"No, not winter," she bumps into Adora´s bruised cheek with her nose, sighing against her ear. "Let's die in autumn," a kiss, lingering in Adora´s mouth. "On a warm day, right after rain"

Bow stares at them from his spot on the Quarry kicking his feet in front of him and smiling. He sees them and hums, blinking at the sight of the broken tree next to where they are standing, the last trace of the Double Trouble´s car crash. It feels like walking in a circle, like following the tracks of a hunt, like holding the arch in his steady hands and crossing an arrow across a prey´s heart.

Adora is an excellent planner, Bow is an excellent shot.

He looks back at the arena and doesn´t bite back a smile, popping his knuckles with expectation. He is in for a fight after all.

## September of the New Year

## The Cabin

The wall of pictures is a jarring contrast against the otherwise bright colors of the cabin. It's night and Now and Adora are sitting

on the chairs in front of the wall, staring at it quietly.

They drove here after class and dinner time. Bow dropped Glimmer on her house and Light Hope is out of town again. Nobody else bothered to check where Catra was. She slept on the couch of the old fashioned living room, curled inside older blankets and not dreaming for once. It allows her to rest.

Adora and Bow have not slept in an entire day. They pass a glass with whiskey back and forth, silently gathering their thoughts.

“I want them dead,” Adora says, taking a long puff of her cigarette, wrinkling her nose at the taste. You will never catch her drinking in front of Catra but she cannot help taking a smoke when she is like this, nicotine numbing her brain. Her eyes are bright and alive right now though. “I want them all dead, Bow. Hordak, Light Hope, Double Trouble, Angella, Lashor, Huntara. Prime. I want them to suffer."

Bow sighs, lowering down the glass filled with copper and sour liquid. He stares at the photographs, the eyes of all these people looking back at him. People he knows, people he hates. He looks at Angella too and his mouth goes numb, filling with acid. Not exactly unwelcome.

He loves Glimmer, so much. He loves her freely and loves her tenderly, but, just this once, something comes before.

Blood, thicker than water. Covenant and womb.

There is something dark inside of him too, just like Adora; something that also feast and craves on arrows against throats and the tear of flesh from the muscles. Something that hates, something that has been raging underneath the softness of his smile this whole time. Something that also waits for the hunt.

“Alright,” he says, firm but still in a low voice, not waking Catra up. “Tell me what to do”

Adora turns her blue eyes towards him, her eyebrows arching on her forehead with surprise.

“Are you going to help me murder people?”

“Those aren´t people,” Bow clicks his red tongue against his teeth, leaning back on the chair. He looks at the pictures and doesn´t see humans at all. “They aren´t even animals. Why would I feel bad for skin them to death?”

Adora´s irises blow up but she narrows her eyes, tilting her head to the side with wonder. “You don't think I'm insane?”

“Adora, Catra is my cousin. She is my blood, my family. And you are my best friend.” Bow leans on the chair towards her, giving her a sideways grin. Under the dim light of the oil lamps, two twin fires dance on his dark eyes. “I just have one request”

Adora´s eyes are narrowed but the shadow of a smile twitches in the corners of her mouth.“Tell me”

“I want Hordak for myself”

## October 22th, a quarter to midnight

Hordak crawls on the floor of his apartment, wheezing for air. His mouth tastes like salt, blood spilling on the back of his throat where he bit himself earlier. There is a gushing wound on the side of his thigh and a deeper one on his ankle, breaking the Achilles tendon, gaping like the sick mockery of a puppet’s mouth. There isn't a way Hordak is getting out of this by running and he knows that. He knows it as well as the person that walks calmly behind him knows it.

“Did you know?” Bow says, sighing deeply. His shoes are soaked in blood, leaving unrecognizable footprints behind him. The air

smells like a sea, heavy, darkened, mirroring the violent rain outside. Next to them, the record player Bow had just turned on plays a song over and over again. Forever stuck in Adora´s mind. Forever stuck in Bow´s. “If I had gone in the car with my fathers instead of Adora´s, I would have died too,” Bow licks his bottom lip, looking at Hordak´s convulsing body below his foot. “Did you know that?”

“I– I didn´t know!” Hordak gasps, wheezes, overwhelmed by pain and by fear. This is the first time in his whole like that he feels truly and well afraid, that he feels that he hasn´t have a way to get out. This is the first time in seven years that Bow doesn´t feel afraid. “I didn't know. I didn't know, alright?”

It feels good, hunting Hordak like this. It feels good to chase him across the floor of his home like a miserable little coward, just like he crawled out of his car after killing Bow´s family. It feels good to swing the hunting knife Bow had inherited from his fathers, even if he had always much preferred the control of the arrows. Still, Adora was right. The intimacy of digging the blade against the flesh face to face is quite exhilarating.

Hordak doesn't even see the flash of the knife until it is already moving, digging past the skin of his palm, across tendons and ligaments and barely avoiding the delicate bones until it comes sprouting on the back, splitting it open like a flower on the church's altar. Hordak screams, a howlering that goes unnoticed by the rich neighborhood around him, drowned by the storm lashing against the earth. All the lights are off.

Bow grabs him by the shoulder and yanks him back, quick and easy. He has also gotten so much stronger from the street fight, from wrestling with Adora and training with her in the cabin and in the woods. From hatred alone. In and out goes the knife, into lungs and ribcage and away. Yes, it is nice.

“You can´t– You can't kill me.” Hordak gasps, spitting towards Bow´s face, staining his skin with his blood.

He has known Bow since he was barely a toddler, a brat, running around his fathers legs when Hordak wandered to his sister´s house. A political nephew he never wanted but had to tolerate because the Capellan´s were loaded and Lance and Frances were twins. A scared face he saw dangling behind Adora´s young body in the back of a destroyed car, even through the haze of the alcohol. This face he knows well, a torment chasing him and finally reaching him.

"You need me, just think what I can give you. Money, connections, an easy way out, a new life. I can give all of that to you!"

Bow stops for a second, considering, weighing the true meaning of Hordak´s words for a second so long that Hordak thinks he might just make it, coughing around his own blood still but still prideful, the bloom of hope spreading on his wounded chest. There is rain outside, Adora is at the party.

*Squelch.* In, out, in, out.

Squelch, squelch, *squelch.*

Through ribbons of flesh and the bones of ribs and the guts of the belly. In, ou, in, in, *squelch.*

The privacy of a knife to a chest, a lung, a liver, kidneys, guts and bladders and muscles, sharp against bones and slicing across muscles. It´s a bloodshed, a bloodbath, a fun hunt.

Hordak murdered Bow´s dads, he murdered Adora´s parents and brother. He hit Catra when she was a child and when he could not do it anymore, he ruined her future.. He hid Francis' death, Prime sins, Weaver´s violence. He allowed Weaver to destroy Bow´s cousin, Bow´s only sister; he allowed Light Hope to sell Bow´s best friend, to break her. Two people that love each other.

Bow is Mercutio, he is Tybalt in this play, impetus and rebellious underneath soft smiles, full of rage and courage, igniting a tragic chain.  Hordak did not stand a chance, ever.

Bow rests his cold mouth against the side of Hordak´s butchered ear and Hordak can't see him, eyes fogged and blind by pain and suffering, but he knows there is a smile on Bow´s mouth. It smells like incense from Hordak´s skin, it smells like blood from Bow´s lungs.

"You can die now" it's the last thing Hordak hears, gurgling blood and boiling hot skin. "Uncle"

Adora would never kill by the throat but Bow it´s different. He even leaves a smiling face on the glass door.

## October 26th, The Mall

Adora rips off the Halloween mask, dropping it and the cape on the trash as she walks out of the building. She gasps for air, ruffling her golden hair behind her, careful not to misstep. She is so annoyed by the way the mask makes her feel like she is choking that she doesn´t even notice the single camera following her behind.

The air is chill when she steps outside, the call for a drizzle and rain quickly hovering in dark clouds above the square. She is careful here, avoiding patches of light and skipping over the stones of the streets until she reaches Bow´s car, huffing. She got rid of the main clothes but she still stinks to death and, honestly, just how much screaming could Mermista really do? Adora´s ears are still ringing.

Bow smiles when he catches sight of her, sitting on the roof of his car and looking at the incoming rain. His pleased smile melts into a wrinkled nose of disgust at the sight of a chunk of flesh still stuck to Adora´s shoe.

"Uh, you have something there, Dora," he says when she approaches him, pointing at her shoes with his chin. Adora scowls

when she sees it too, bending down and cleaning it with her palm.

“Well, that´s annoying,” she grunts, huffing.

“How did it go?” Bow asks, slipping off the roof and back on the ground. He is chewing mint gum, running the strong flavor through his teeth. It has always worked for him, even as a child hunting alongside Adora in the woods. It helps overpower the stench of blood.

“I had to kill Sea Hawk. He got in the way,” Adora says, shrugging softly. Bow looks at her with wide eyes and then he also shrugs, grabbing a bag with new clothes for Adora from the back.

“That´s a pity, I liked him.”

“Didn´t you have a torrid affair with him before dating Glimmer?” Adora asks with a mischievous glint, slipping off her clothes and into the new ones. Bow points at her with an accusatory frown, shaking his shoulders.

“It was one night and he lured me with a song. A very bad one, by the way.”

“Sure, sure,” Adora chuckles, brushing her hair into something more manageable. She is starting to get sick of the long strands. “Sorry for killing your ex.”

“Eh, it´s alright I guess. He wasn´t very good anyway, and he had a very bad hero complex.” Bow jumps into the pilot door, closing the door behind him as Adora slips next to him too. “Mermista is a bitch, she shouldn´t have spoken of Catra like that. She is lucky everyone else was there.”

“I know,” Adora buckles her seat belt, scratching her arms. She is a little bit dizzy from the run and by the smell of blood. “Besides lifelong trauma I also left her a smiling face. You were right, it is funny.”

“I told you so!”

## October 28th, The Motel

Adora slips back inside the motel through the little corridor of the garden that Bow had shown her. It goes completely out of sight from the police stationed outside and, honestly, it is kind of funny.

She needs a shower but more than all she needs to eat. She is starving after being in the Mausoleum for so long. The delicious smells coming from the motel´s kitchen are not helping either.

Bow rises his head when he sees her come, a smile spreading on his face. “Hey”

“Hey,” Adora huffs, letting herself fall over a chair in front of the bar. Bow looks at her fondly, giggling under his breath at Adora´s both bright and exhausted expression. She really does stretch herself too much sometimes, but at least her cheeks are rosier than before.

Bow was right, she really did need to do this.

“How did it go?” Bow hums, looking back at the club sandwich he is carefully serving over the plastic plates of the motel. Adora digs her hand inside her pocket and grabs a bundle out of it, leaving it on the counter right next to the smoking potatoes. Double Trouble ´s teeth are still dripping with blood. “Well, that's nice”

“Fucker,” Adora grunts at the teeth and the now well deceased owner of them, stretching over the table to grab at the already opened beer there. She hates beer and Bow only uses it to cook but she really needs a fast drink right now. There is still so much adrenaline pumping inside her veins. “Cheers.”

“Cheers to you,” Bow answers in kind, returning his attention back to the food. He has come to learn that, right after a hunt there always comes unbearable hunger. Especially from Adora.

“How´s Catra?” Adora asks after a beat, resting her chin and cheek over her folded arms.

“Still sleeping, I went to peek at her like five minutes ago.”

“Hmm,” Adora is thinking about something, her eyebrows knitting together and her mouth closing into a tense line. “Glimmer kissed me.”

Bow doesn´t stop from his work, barely throwing a sideways stare towards Adora with a heavy sigh. “Yeah, I know. I saw from the mall”

Adora sighs sadly, clear remorse and slight anger towards Glimmer coating her face. “I´m sorry.”

“Don´t be. It´s not your fault,” Bow reassures her with a small shake of the head but Adora still looks pale and conflicted, chewing on the inside of her mouth.

“Aren't you angry?”

“Not with you,” Bow places the plate full of food in front of Adora, ruffling her bangs with his palm. “I´ve always known she still has feelings for you, I guess I just hoped she wouldn't actually act on them. Or disrespect me and Catra.”

After Adam´s death, Bow has been the closest thing Adora has to a brother and she will always be grateful for him. “What do you want to do?”

“We´ll see. We need her now that Angella is dead.” He serves himself a plate too, leaning back on the counter top. There are a lot of feelings swirling inside of her but above all things there is silent intelligence, piecing parts of their plan together and

planning others. He is a hunter too, after all. “I love her of course, but she is still her mother´s daughter, Dora. I´m not surprised”

Adora hums, still looking way too sad for Bow´s liking. He smiles at her and gives her a small bump on the shoulder with his fist, nudging her into something happier.

“So, when are you asking my only cousin to marry you?” He asks, wiggling his eyebrows. It has the desired effect because Adora goes red like a beet and her eyes twinkle with love and excitement, trying very hard to bury it all below calmness.

“Don´t be a little shit, Bow. I don´t even have–” She bites her own tongue from how hard and fast she closes it, looking with wide eyes as Bow takes out of his pocket the little ring Adora had asked him to keep safe when all of this started. Adora chuckles, looking at Bow with incredulous eyes. “My god. You motherfucker”

Bow giggles too, saving the tender ring inside his palm, lifting his sandwich and taking a huge bite out of it.

“You haven´t asked me for her hand, though. That's not very gentlemanly of you, I might not want to give you my blessing after all,” he says with his mouth full of breath. Adora´s silver eyes narrow, her face morphing into something dangerous mixed with mirth.

“I´ll kill you,” she threatens around a laugh, stretching over the counter. Bow shakes his head, lifting the ring above his head, still eating.

“I´ll kill you first, Dora."

“Give that,” Adora grunts, trying and failing to recover the ring when Bow jumps back, still dangling it in front of her face like bait. The little shit. “Bow!”

“Nu-uh. Eat your sandwich first. I´ve been working the entire night on that,” Bow gives Adora´s frustrated face a full teeth

smile, almost mirroring the ripped teeth still next to the spilled food. “If you ask nicely I might think about it after all.”

“Hey!”

**October 31th, Halloween**

Huntara is on the ground, wheezing for air. Bow cleans the knife on his pants, wrinkling his nose at the blood still squirting out of Huntara´s chest every time she takes a breath.

Catra is hovering over Adora, checking the hit on her temple where Huntara managed to throw Adora a hit. It is bleeding, again, falling on Catra´s shoes and Adora grunts at the sight of it, already making her way out of her own sneakers to bend down and lace them in Catra´s feet.

“Why did you kill the officer downstairs?” Bow asks Adora, rubbing the inside of his ear where Huntara´s screams and the bang of her failed attempt to shoot them all made him lose his hearing for a second. Adora huffs, gently taking Catra´s ankle inside her palm.

“Huntara told her to arrest me. She hadn´t even noticed I had already taken the gun off her belt,” Adora rolls her eyes, annoyed, raising to her feet and kissing Catra´s cheek gently. “You okay?”

“Yeah,” Catra turns her eyes towards Bow, nodding at him. “Thanks for that”

“Sure. I wasn´t going to let her point a gun towards you,” Bow, ruffles Catra´s bangs with his hand, palming Adora´s biceps with the other. His expression falls into something more serious, sighing heavily at the scene around him. “Glimmer is here, she is probably going to bring more officers. We need to do something quick.”

“What are you thinking?” Adora asks, rubbing a gentle circle around Catra´s waist.

Bow looks at Light Hope´s rotting body and then at Huntara, tilting his head to the side with a new idea.

“Stab me”

Adora and Catra´s eyes go wide inside their faces, sputtering with shock as Bow´s words start to sink in. Catra shakes her head, grabbing Bow´s wrist softly between her fingers.

“No. Are you crazy?” she asks in a breath, her eyes huge and scared. Bow shakes his head too, palming her knuckles gently.

“Listen to me. We need to make it believable that Huntara attacked us. I cannot go unscarred a second time, it is starting to look weird,” he looks at Adora´s serious eyes, shrugging. “Stab me, I´ll pass out enough until help comes. We´ll blame it on Huntara and say we had no choice again.”

“It's madness.” Catra whispers, shaking from head to toe. “Bow, I don´t– I don´t want this, I´m not asking you this.”

“This is about all of us, kitcat,” Bow wraps his hands around her temples, smiling down at her softly. She has uncle Francis´s eyes and it is sweet, a nice thing. She is a good thing between all of them. “I will be alright”

Bow reassures her with a soft hug, rocking her from side to side and petting the curls falling down her back. She has grown so much since they were just children sitting on the stairs, they both have.

“They won´t suspect anything if we are hurt, it would be in bad taste. And I will be fine if Adora does it. She is an excellent shot” he looks at Adora from above Catra´s shoulders, smiling gently at her. “You know I´m right.”

“Yes, I know,” Adora sighs, bending down to pick up the fallen knife. “What do you want me to do with Glimmer?”

Bow considers it for a second, lingering a soft smooch over Catra´s cheekbone before leaning back, trusting her into Adora´s hands. “That depends on her. Do whatever you need.”

“Alright”

They walk back inside Light Hope´s office, away from the carnage of the chapel and in front of the glass. Here it's quiet and Adora can see better. Catra follows too, ready to catch Bow´s body in her arms when he tumbles down.

“You are my favorite cousin, you know?” Catra says, wrinkling her nose. Bow smiles at her, closing his eyes.

“I'm your only cousin”

Bow stands right in front of Adora, looking at her eyes, his arms relaxed on his side. He smiles at her when she looks unsure, not of her ability but of doing this to her best friend. After everything they have gone through, she finds herself hesitating for the first time.

“It´s still going to hurt,” she warns him, holding the knife steady on her hand. Bow nods, chuckling under his breath.

“Yeah, I figured,” He gets himself ready but there is still worry in Adora´s eyes, jumping from his face to the knife and back again. Bow rolls his eyes, nudging her softly with his shoulder. “Come on. Don't go soft on me now, Montenegro. You are the best hunter between both of us.”

“We both are,” Adora mutters but her back straightens, confidence slipping and wrapping inside her bones again. “Hold your breath”

She holds Bow´s shoulder steady on her hand and rests the cold end of the blade below the ends of his crop top, right in the place where she will slice flesh but won´t hurt organs or arteries. She is

good at what she is doing and Bow trusts her. He trusts her with this and he trusts her with Catra´s life.

"I´ll see you both on the other side," he whispers, feeling Catra´s gentle arms wrapping around his shoulders, holding him softly. "Take care of each other"

Adora digs the knife swiftly and easily inside his body and all goes black.

## Two weeks after the murders

## The Hospital

Bow sings the last paper of his hospital release and sighs, rubbing his eyes with steady fingers. Out of the corner of his dark eyes he sees Doctor Castaspella walking out of a room, pink and lilac and white, exhausted as always but just as smart. She has always been smart, she knows these children.

Their eyes meet when Castaspella looks up, her face going from mild confusion to understanding at the sight of Bow on civilian clothes. He is still patched over and bruised but he looks healthy, back straight, face calm. The knife really didn´t hurt him at all but the trip and the free hospital food was fun.

"Bow," Castaspella sighs, scratching her eyebrow. "Where are you going to go from here?"

It´s a good question, gentle and easy. Calculated. Bow smiles, so hard the corner of his eyes wrinkle. He knew she would get it in the end. Adora told him she would and he was not disappointed by her.

"Around," he says, sighing deeply. "What about you?"

“My shift is over so I guess I´ll have to go to that godforsaken mass at the Cathedral,” Castaspella says, dragging the words, eyeing Bow sideways when she signs her leaving on the reception counter. Bow hums tilting his head to the side and smiling.

Castaspella starts walking away, no doubt towards the locker rooms where she can change into more comfortable clothes and slip into the mask they all were in this town. Quiet and coward. It´s a bit tiresome by now, these mask things. Bow is tired of them.

“Castaspella?” he calls, tilting his head to the side, grinning sweet and sticky when she turns to look at his handsome face with wandering eyes. “I think you should stay to look after Glimmer,” he says, shrugging. “Who knows? She could wake up any minute now.”

Castaspella freezes on her tracks, staring at Bow with wide eyes. Bow doesn´t really remember Micah but he knows they looked a lot alike. They have all lost someone in this place.

“I see,” Castaspella whispers, nodding. “Yes, I think I should.”

Bow hums, leaning away from the counter and walking towards the door. One of his older brothers is set to pick him up later tonight. For now, Bow just needs to walk.

## Fourteen years ago

## A Patch of Moss in the Woods

*… Lala lala …*

Adora jumps up and down on the moss, falling on her ankles. She doesn´t go further than a few inches yet she feels like flying, the

sky taking her inside her arms and twirling her around on her warm breeze before letting her back down with a soft push.

Adora´s small hands are slightly clammy, held tightly around other small hands as Catra, Bow and she dance on a circle in the middle of the forest, over patches of grass and dew and fallen leaves underneath their bare soles. Under the dim light of the sun crossing the moon shaped fruits hanging from the branches and the sounds of the river rushing hard and alive like guitar strings.

They are young. Six, seven, eleven, fourteen, twenty one. They are young.

Randor and Marlena, Adam, Francis, Lance and George, are somewhere in the woods, roaming the earth and chasing the leaves, Hunting. They are good at it. Lance and Francis have been Randor´s best friends since they were the same age as their children and their whole lives until Randor and Marlena ran away, chased by Prime´s fury. They are all so glad to be together again.

All of them share a look when they see Catra and Adora, wrapping their young hands on each other and never letting go again. They are familiar with this, everlasting love, old as the root of the tree that lives in the ruins.

Adam sleeps most of the time in the car, too soft for the life of the forest but the other children are different, they are born different. They are friends and family. Adora and Catra are halves of the same soul. They skip on the moss and make hats of wheat and crowns out of flowers. Their clothes are patchworks of each other, scattered in soft moss and mud.

Bow is excellent with the arrow, he always shots to the neck and to the ribcage, he never misses. Adora is a smart hunter, she always uses the knife on the lungs and the arteries. Catra sings, she is a beating heart.

They dance in circles around each other, mirrors, children, following steps only they know, following secret paths and hidden

spots on the forest that sees them grow. They know these barks of trees and these bushes, these mountains.

These rivers.

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The forest is damp and Bow finds his way across it like a second skin covering him. There are many sounds around, birds on the trees, deers eating on the grass, rabbits and mice  and foxes and lambs. Sounds of harpy eagles tearing flesh and wolves nibbling on bones. Bow does not hear voices or songs but instead this, the forest. Like a part of them. Another kind of animal among the stone stress and across the damp trees.

The forest welcomes him, knows him, feels him, bending down to him like a second part of this place. He steps barefoot on the ground coated in fallen yellow and blue flowers from the wisteria tree, refusing to disrespect the sanctity of this place.

He will move on, he will go on with his life. He will grow old and live a good life, that was the plan and Bow is honoring it, but for now he is right here, between the murmurs of the river and the chirping of the woods all around him, sun washing golden through the clustered leaves.

The ruins of the old cathedral meet him in the middle of the meadow, quiet as always and yet loud, so loud. The stone of the dead lovers is still carved in swirls and still untouched, moss crawling over it, showered in drying flowers and the last errand drops of rain, still refusing to let go completely. The glass window is still there, painted glass by young hands, purple and red light, blue and silver and copper and death.

There is a paper glass hanging over the metal, swinging softly by the air. It has long ago grown cold. Its light and the wish that consumed it long ago were fulfilled.

Bow places both the reliquary and the ring over the crumbling tomb, stepping back. A blessing, a return, a burial. Graveyards for lovers. Like this they look so small yet so significant, beautiful like a part of the forest. Doomed like the tomb.

Behind Bow´s back, yards and yards away, there is red light. Red and blue and green. Heat. All consuming. Fire.

It respects the limits of the Whispering Forest but it consumes everything else. It eats, it devours, like teeth sunken on flesh, like red tongues drinking on blood.

It rips apart new wood and faux metal, bends down the golden and the silver and the white, breaks ropes and lets the bells fall down. It covers windows wrapped in thorns of black and blocks the already chained doors where hands slam from the other side, unable to crumble them down. It clogs darkness and shadows and smoke on noses and throats, it boils eyes and arms, it bites on torsos and feet and hair. It curls around the tower and pulls it down. So fragile, all of it, so doomed too. So false.

If Bow listens intently, just a little, just enough, above the song of the birds and the blue sky on the celestial vault, he might be able to make off the sound of the screams. It is kind of nice, the entire town gathered to sing together one last time. It wasn´t part of the path but it is kind of nice, the hunt.

If Bow brings his hands to his mouth, he might still smell the lingering stench of metal and locks. Of fire and gas. What a small Cathedral that was, one entrance, one exit. Red like glass.

Among the branches of the peaceful woods, Bow thinks he catches the song of a nightingale and a glimpse of golden strands. A hare, no, a harpy maybe. Maybe none at all.

An animal roams the trees, red coated, curled protectively around a stray wisp of wings finally flying free. Hand in hand.

It´s a warm day after cold rain, a sad day. A perfect day.

There is a castle in the woods.

Bow smiles.

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*And the door below, it splinters, and the creature creeps inside*

*And we fall into each other, the scratching grows so loud*

*Because that unwanted animal wants nothing more than to get out*

Chapter End Notes

I never said Adora was the Unwanted Animal, did I?

Heart - Catra (The Nightingale)
Lungs - Adora (The Hunter)
Ribcage - Bow (The Unwanted Animal)

Also someone please play Crimson Rivers for Bow! I knew some of you were sad for him but well, I could not give it awayn! Didn't you think weird that Adora killed Sea Hawks then she was with Bow? Or that Bow and Catra always seemed familiar to even have nicknames? Or that Adora was at the party when Hordak died? Hehehe, definetly something to think about.

When I first started writing Unwanted Animal, I wanted something you could not fix, and even if you could, you would have not wanted to fix it at all. I wanted love beyond comprehension and raw anger and untamed instincts. I wanted blood, guts and angel cake (like Teen Idle!) .

This is definitely so much different to what I usually write, even if in those writings there is also justice and blood sometimes. It was such a trip to plan and to write and it has been amazing to share with all of you. Thank you from the bottom of my heart for being here during this journey and

support me so far and my weird little fables. I will always be grateful with you.

One last time, I read you below. I'll answers your comments during this week. And also, I have a Discord Channel now for my stories! Join to have a nice time, receive news from new stories and new chapters of ongoing ones, art, theories and more.

DISCORD

After a trip of cults, revenge, blood and love, this story has come to an end. Thank you so much for the trust.

Be good
Or don't

End Notes

Thank you so much for your support! Bookmarks, comments and kudos are deeply appreciate it! See you in a few days!

Be good!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!